Before Midnight

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Before Midnight

by DriftingGlass

Summary

Izuku Midoriya takes the same train to and from school Monday through Friday, morning and night. His only company during these lonesome hours comes in the form of another boy his age—a teen with scarred hands and blood gem eyes, a stranger with ash-blond hair who walks in a shroud of danger and mystery.

"Would you stop with that fucking muttering, idiot?"

And before Izuku can find his footing, his life becomes a full-blown collision course thanks to walking cannonball Katsuki Bakugou.

(And along the way he may have found the missing fuel to his fire).

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Discharge

Monday. 10:05 PM.

The leather cushions reek of cigarette smoke and desperation.

Izuku pulls up the zipper to his sweater, bracing himself as cold winds break through the rising windshields of the train.

He steps onto the locomotive, releases a long, heavy breath, and sinks his hands into his pockets, clutching one stress-relieving ball in his left hand.

He mutters apologies and smiles too brightly for this kind of an evening to strangers: fellow workers and hard-pressed citizens who thrived off of copious amounts of coffee and whispered half-conscious promises into the bitter winter air once they were out of earshot. Izuku brings himself to smile when he can, especially to the mothers and children he comes across, earning either baffled expressions in return or a sheepish wave or two.

His back tight, he gradually takes his seat exactly six rows in the back, where not a single soul waits.

Night seeps through the frosted glass, stars glistening like trapped fireflies in an otherwise black-as-soot sky.

Izuku sets aside his backpack and removes a thick wad of old newspaper clippings, some outlined with the *Daily Inkling*'s traditional emblem. Pictures of a slender, tall man with wooden skin and elongated, intertwining limbs studded in leaves are slapped onto each article, accompanied only occasionally by a curvaceous woman who stood at a miraculous fifty feet in height.

The announcement of yet another heroic intervention from only two of many retired professional heroes sparks something longing and yet, awe-inspired within Izuku; it had been years since it was considered for Quirks to be used domestically and without the confines of heroic agencies, and to be able to glance over these photographs and timely articles as if they happened yesterday was enthralling.

They boasted strength that he would never know or experience outside of his dreams, but even so, he can't suppress the elated smile that stretches out his lips when he can finally read these new issues and enjoy them on his lonesome after work and school.

They're old articles, smothered in cobwebs and stashed in the back of old boxes on the sidewalk that he bothers rifling through when he has the chance. He still has commemorative posters of his favorite childhood heroes strung up in his room, some more recognizable than others, and he was one of few people he knew who refused to sell his old merchandise online after the incredibly quick decline of Quirks being used in professions.

It took only a few years for the government to instill those beliefs in the general public. Heroes were quickly subdued to remaining with their Quirks in casual professions in the office, stowed away from the public and committed to ideas that were more trivial and stress-inducing than what was commonly believed. Izuku struggled believing in this concept or even finding reason with the government's decision to enact those practices, and the retirement of All-Might, in particular, had forced him to reconsider his dreams.

They're still amazing, he thinks, grinning even wider as he pieces together certain clippings, *even if we only have a few hidden reminders once in a while.*

He hums, glancing over the papers.

"Maybe I should put these together for the school paper… Iida would be fine with that, wouldn't he? He likes the superhero column. I could turn it into a more appreciative section… maybe that would work better? But then again I've already written a lot of articles about Quirks and stuff. Oh, I could put more photos in that one section that we haven't paid attention to in a while. But then again Uraraka might not like it and she has the final say… but maybe Momo could help me out and it could be fine after that…?"

He grumbles under his breath, and brightens with an idea.

He pulls out his notebook and signature pen—one speckled with too many tooth marks on its red, wooden surface and bitten to just a few inches above the eraser—and scribbles into the pages with reckless abandon. He taps his chin and draws a faint outline of the hero in the paper with the wooden skin—*Kamui Woods*, he remembers fondly, from years ago in middle school when he could happily announce his total admiration for local heroes and their impact on society.

At sixteen years old, he wonders just how many times he's been told he dreams too much.

He rubs his eyes, groaning at the weight seeped into his eyelids. He pulls out his phone, unlocks the touchscreen and sends a brief text message to his mother, letting her know he'll be home around eleven o'clock, which was usually the hour he returned to their tiny apartment just two districts away.

He knows he looks and smells awful—working after-hours with reports and the school paper was already draining enough, and waking up extremely early and going to bed even later was starting to take an entirely new toll on his system.

But he *loved it.*

Loved it for the distraction, for the chance to be excited about something that drove his passions to new heights, that encouraged his nonsensical mutterings and allowed him to be

more like himself in the presence of his few but genuine friends.

Uraraka's radiant sunniness was enough reason to go into the late printing room and go over local photographs with her, and even though she had an excellent Quirk that made cleaning the office space so much easier, she seemed to understand his frustrations at being Quirkless more than anyone else he knew. Even having Iida there from time to time frantically reminding them which article needed to be approved before printing.

The train stops, rails screeching into a sharp halt. Izuku blinks at this; he's never usually joined on this particular hour. Sometimes a grouchy late-night engineer or plumber or even a babysitter would hop on the train for the closest fast food joint around the block, but normally Izuku happened to be alone in this strange hour to board the train from his high school to his district.

The doors slide open. A tall, languid figure slumps through with hands burrowed into loose-hanging pockets, and Izuku is unable, for some reason, to look away from this entirely new stranger.

I've never seen him before...

The boy looks around his age, probably sixteen, and Izuku's skin already feels warm.

He's not aware of how long he's staring at the currently distracted teenager, who quickly takes a seat across from the width of the train, one leg bopped up on the other.

Izuku's pen twitches in his hands, nervous tremors running through his body—part of him wants to smother his face into his sketchbook and notebook and pretend that he's still the only one on the train like he normally is, but another part of his mind screams for him to just *keep staring.*

This newcomer's face is carved in all angular lines, a sharp scowl etched onto his lips and his skin a fair, almost ghostly complexion. He pulls back his hood and cards one hand through a wild mop of ash-blond hair, spiky and unruly as if he'd just rolled out of bed. His brow is creased as he pulls out his phone, one hand contained in a fingerless glove while the other boasts thick white lines—*scars,* Izuku notes—his enormous headphones booming electric, heavy music through a protective encasing around his ears. His sneakers are torn and ragged, but his eyes are what grab Izuku's attention the most.

While focused and oozing contempt and a lack of normalcy, they brim like twin scarlet oceans, brooding and powerful.

Izuku wonders, faintly, if they're contact lenses of some sort, but he can't bring himself to actually wander over to this stranger and ask him such an absurd question. On top of looking as if the world decided to throw wool over him and destroy his day in every way possible, Izuku can think of at least a dozen or so reasons why he shouldn't interact with this person.

I wonder what high school he goes to. I would've seen him at Yuuei, I'm pretty sure. At least I think so. He doesn't look like he wouldn't *go to school, at least. He's not a delinquent, I think. Well, I guess that part doesn't matter much. Wait, what am I even thinking?*

Izuku rolls his eyes.

The train shifts to a final halt in the station where Izuku normally gets off. To his surprise, the stranger removes himself from his seat as well, even bothering to put his headphones in his large backpack without a single acknowledgement of his surroundings.

Izuku's feet remain planted on the ground, sweat gathering in his palms as he watches the stranger exit the door before he's able to collect his thoughts and do the same.

The night breeze boggles his senses for a few seconds, and the train drifts by him in an oddly silent hum. Beneath the starry sky, he watches the stranger leave without even turning around once or even giving any indication that he noticed Izuku was there.

Izuku doesn't know why it feels oddly disappointing to find that the other boy is heading in the opposite direction of his apartment.

"Izuku? Hey, earth to Izuku!"

Izuku snaps out of his trance and leans back in his chair. He sheepishly laughs as his friend of three years, Uraraka Ochako, stares at him as if he'd sprouted another head. She tilts her head to the side, large, soft brown eyes twinkling like molten chocolate. She places her hands on her hips and looks over his notes.

"Are you sure you're okay? Iida and I can take over from here so you don't have to tonight. I know that you get home around midnight, so…" she trails off, but Izuku sighs and holds back a sputtering mess of apologies for being so distracted.

The lights flicker above them, casting a faint ray over the numerous scattered notes, clippings and photographs tacked onto bulletin boards and splayed out along wooden tables. Past issues from over the last few months are gathered in neat piles, drawn together in binding string and appearing even more prominent each time someone from the newspaper club walks into the printing office with a broad smile and new idea.

"Sorry, Uraraka," mutters Izuku, "I've just been distracted lately. Hah, I guess that's not out of the norm, though." He grins awkwardly, rubbing the back of his neck.

Uraraka frowns. "Izuku, you don't have to stay here, you know." She smiles, attempting to appease him, but Izuku would rather take over all of their duties at once than allow Uraraka to sacrifice her time.

"I can handle it!" He grins broadly and gives her a thumbs-up. "We've all been working hard. It's not like I'm pulling my weight more than other people."

Uraraka groans at this and rubs her forehead. "But you *are* pulling more weight."

Izuku turns back to his miniature project, groaning a the headache seeping into his temples.

He wants to rub these painful sensations away and take his mind off of the stranger he saw on the train the previous night.

Grimacing, Izuku just now realizes how awful he looks, even for late-night-journalist standards. His collared uniform shirt sleeves are rolled up to his elbows, calloused fingers—nails stress-bitten to the cuticle—going back and forth between typing and scribbling notes into the rough draft of the next article he needs to put out with Uraraka for *The Yuuei Herald* before next week.

He wants to cover the importance of superheroes and their symbolic impact on society, despite the governmental shift in having them resort to remaining outside of the spotlight.

“You know, Kaminari and Kirishima mentioned something about going to the movies this weekend with some of the others in our class. I was wondering if you wanted to come? We could finish his work early and—maybe go together?” Uraraka’s sudden question pops up and the last few words pull Izuku out of his jumbled thoughts.

“Huh?” He blinks. “Where are we going?”

She bites her lip.

“The movies. I think you need a break, Izuku. You don’t look like you’ve slept at all.”

She leans against the table and scrunches her nose like a rabbit. As endearing as it is, it contrasts with the stranger's sharp scowl from the other night.

“… Izuku?”

“Huh—wha?” Izuku blushes hotly as Uraraka giggles.

“Okay, I’m just going to take that as a yet. Gosh, Izuku, you’ve been so out of it today. Even Aizawa seemed a little weirded out with how you were acting.”

Izuku snorts at this. “Don’t think Mr. Aizawa cares all that much.” He checks his watch, and immediately he bolts out of his chair and snatches his backpack. “I have to go, Uraraka! I didn’t even realize it was this close to ten!” He turns to his friend, wildly glancing between the school paper drafts and his friend’s shocked expression. “I’ll make it up to you, okay?”

She only manages to weakly wave her hand before he’s out the door.

Tuesday. 10:30 PM.

This time, Izuku waits in silence.

He wonders if he'll be joined by the other boy again, even while he pours over his notes and occasionally sends a text to Uraraka to stop her from being his mother hen for a few minutes. Sometimes she worried over him like an extra parent, and with the amount of coddling and affection his mother granted, this wasn't entirely necessary.

He couldn't begin to explain the strained way he felt throughout the day, the odd moments when he became too mesmerized by the window and the illustrations in his textbooks.

The doors to the train open.

Izuku's eyes widen as the same stranger strolls onboard, his hands, once again, shoved deep into his cargo trousers.

He tosses his backpack to the other end of the seat line, and without the extra sweatshirt layer Izuku takes in just how slender and *built* this teenager is.

The stark white polo is snug to his chest, bare arms rippling with cords of muscle. Both of his hands are gloveless, revealing longer traces of those intricately patterned scars, how they twist from his knuckles to around his wrists and stretching towards his elbows. Without even glancing up, the stranger takes out his headphones and places them over his ears. In that moment, he leans back with one leg crossed over the other, his brow furrowing as he closes his eyes and tilts his chin towards the ceiling.

Even in this relaxed position he seems so stiff and tense, like a cat ready to strike on first touch.

Izuku's head tilts to the side.

I wonder if he has a Quirk.

And if this teen *did* have a Quirk, what would it be? What kind of identity would he have as a superhero without the government turning against them? What was this person even like in casual conversation? Did he ever stop frowning as if the world was placed on his shoulders and every acidic word he wanted to scream at the top of his lungs were permanently stored in his chest?

"I have too many questions," Izuku mutters.

He raises an eyebrow at the teen and wonders just how someone could be able to sleep through such loud music; he can almost hear exact lyrics just by sitting across from him on the train. The distinct rumble of the locomotive sliding on railings is not enough to distract him from the current setup.

It's only thirty minutes, but it blasts by as if no longer than sixty seconds, and Izuku is hardly able to suppress the coil of disappointment in his chest as not being able to smile at all or grab the stranger's attention.

The blond ducks out of the train with smooth calculation, exuding an essence of swagger and intimidation that Izuku has not seen attached to anyone else before.

He's embarrassed at how easily he stresses over the matter while restlessly tossing and turning in his bed.

Wednesday. 9:55 PM.

"Izuku, are you sure you're okay? You almost set the printer on fire from staring outside the window for too long…"

"Y-Yeah, sorry about that. Just didn't want to miss the train. Have you been sleeping okay? I know that this has been a really late-night week for all of us. Oh, and sorry about just throwing all of those papers on your desk. I wasn't trying to just edit them all at once…" Izuku groans and buries his face into his hands.

He's already placed himself in a terrible position with the fact that his homework *and* school paper projects are splayed out next to him on the train seats with little organizational quality. He wants to tear out his hair for being so stupid and putting off his work and using some strange excuse as "daydreaming too much" to his teachers earlier that day. It's almost shameful, really. But he can't help being distracted all the time when that's truthfully all that's been wrong with him.

"I've been fine, Izuku. Iida and I are just worried about you. He said he texted you and you didn't answer and… look, I know that we're all stressed out and that college fair is coming up soon and I know you're dying to be prepared for that, but this school paper thing is supposed to be fun! You're—you're still having fun with it, right, Izuku?"

Izuku smiles and nods, as if Uraraka was sitting beside him.

"Of course, Uraraka! I love working on the paper with you!" He hears a pause on the other line, and a slight, faint giggle, but some of it seems to be a trick of the mind since it's firmly reduced to a mere clearing of the throat when he hears the muffling noises retract. "Are you still there? Did I say something weird—"

"N-No, Izuku! It's totally fine. I'm just glad you're okay. We were worried about you."

Izuku frowns. "Worried?" He ponders. "I'm sorry…"

He doesn't know what else to say.

He'd been so engrossed in his own projects he had no idea that he was affecting anyone else. He never gave any thought to how Uraraka would be acting to him being suddenly so distracted.

“Oh—Izuku, you don’t have to be sorry! Sheesh! You’re acting like this is so serious. It’s really not. I just wanted to check on you! See how you were doing. And it’s been a while since we’ve all hung out so you better be coming to the movies with the rest of us on Saturday!”

Izuku grins, his heart jumping in relief. He was incredibly blessed to have her friendship, even when she was unaware of the impact she’d made on his life on his first day of transferring into their high school with a speech impediment issue and misplaced ambitions.

She’d smiled, offered her hand to guide him through the school, and on that very first day he simply knew.

“Thanks, Uraraka,” he says, grinning softly.

“Yeah, yeah, thank me after *you get some sleep, you crazy workaholic. Honestly Izuku, sometimes I think your ability to live on fumes is your secret Quirk!”* Izuku laughs, and can almost feel Uraraka’s wink on the other side of the phone line.

He opens his mouth to respond when the train stops, and the doors open to allow the same person he’d come to expect show up around the same time walk through the entrance and take his usual spot across from him.

This time, the stranger snaps his head towards Izuku, and *glares*.

Izuku’s tongue turns dry. “I-I’ll call you back, Uraraka.”

“Huh? Izuku are you—”

"Yep! Totally fine!”

He hangs up, and immediately pulls out his book to conceal his furiously blushing face.

He didn’t know why he was acting his way, especially towards a person he’d never been bothered talking to, but the fact that the other boy actually acknowledged his presence with that sharp, piercing red stare sent strange shivers up and down his spine. He wasn’t sure how to process it.

“Would you *stop* with that fucking muttering, idiot?”

Izuku blinks owlishly and lowers his notebook. He turns to his left, then to his right, and then finally, lets his confused gaze rest on the stranger, who was now standing and grappling the iron support beam next to his usual spot. His backpack was set down, and today he was wearing an unzipped sweatshirt, his hair slick with sweat from what Izuku could only assume to be the local gym from a few blocks down, and wearing a black muscle tank that clung to the faint outline of chiseled abdominal muscles that clearly dwarfed Izuku’s own.

But the glare that this stranger is sending him and the crooked sneer marring his features is the indicator that Izuku was, apparently, the target of his irritation.

“Um.” Izuku closes his mouth.

Should he apologize? He's used to muttering on his own and being called out on the action, but the fact that this stranger was bothering to take his frustrations out on him—someone who'd never even engaged in conversation with, *ever*—and even daring to call him an "idiot" of all things, cancels out out the need for an apology.

"God, what the fuck is wrong with you? Do you have an off-switch, *midget*? How hard is it to just sit tight and shut the fuck up? You're not the only one on this fucking train. Jesus."

Izuku's cheeks burn.

The other teen raises an eyebrow, his teeth visible beneath his curled upper lip. For a moment, he reminds Izuku of an angry wolf.

Still, his own slight annoyance builds in his chest, and he decides that the best he can do is ignore it. Maybe this person is having an incredibly terrible day (maybe even more so than the others since he's always scowling, at least on this particular train)

"Well I was going to apologize until you decided to insult me." Izuku shrugs. "Guess we're both in a bad place."

He grins slightly to try and dispel the tension, but the other teenager simply scoffs, rolls his eyes, and glares to the opposite side of the train. His shoe thumps against the floor, his visible left fist clenching and unclenching. Izuku thinks to the stress exercise ball he has in his pocket, and briefly wonders if this teen has the same problem.

"Stress issues?"

"Don't fucking talk to me," growls the other teen.

Izuku hates how he actually *likes* listening to how his voice sounds. It's lilted in some accent he's not entirely familiar with, but it matches his appearance. It's almost foreign-sounding. Russian, maybe? He doesn't look like he's American, then again, given Izuku's half-Japanese parentage and only knowing two languages fluently, he can detect a myriad of possible bilingual nature in just listening to how the other speaks.

"I'm, um, Izuku."

"Fuck off."

Izuku closes his notebook and suppresses the urge to roll his eyes.

Ah, okay. Not a talking type.

Despite this, however...

There was something very intriguing about this teenager that struck him the moment he saw him. Other than his striking face and the slightly powerful way he walked, an air of mystery hugged his strong aura with open arms.

He wonders just how many secrets lie within those scars, or even where this stranger comes from and where he's heading to each and every night.

"You don't have your headphones today," Izuku blurts out.

This, apparently, actually grabs the other teen's attention. Snarling like an angry coyote, the stranger sharply turns his head and stares unblinkingly towards Izuku.

There's a slight tilt to his expression. A chill dashes through Izuku's bones and sets his heart into overdrive, whether out of anxiety or plain nervousness, he's not sure.

"You a fucking stalker, you scrawny little shit-faced *nerd*?"

Izuku remains completely still while the other teenager takes a few menacing steps forward. Izuku holds back an embarrassing squeak when the other boy snatches the collar of his shirt and pulls him close.

His notebook is tightly clenched in his left hand, and in this instant he can see so many ferocious details in this teen's dark eyes. They glisten with anger, with tumultuous, brittle fervency, as if he has a million targets and is frustrated that he can only take out his emotions on one of them.

"N-No! I've just—you've been on this train the last couple of days and I've never seen you before!"

The boy huffs and drops him, stepping back and refusing to break his glare. The scowl remains, but now his teeth are hidden in his mouth once more, and a little relief settles in Izuku at avoiding being punched.

"Whatever. Fuck. I have better things to do."

But, to Izuku's slight surprise, the teen remains by his side, and even has the audacity to lean and grasp the support beam next to Izuku's seat.

He's hovering over him, a stable and intimidating force.

"Stop fucking looking at me."

"I wasn't—"

"I'm going to wreck your face if you keep talking."

"Okay, seriously, I have a stress ball in my pocket if you need one."

Izuku holds up his hands in a slight surrender, incredibly tempted to frantically wave them back and forth to ward off the animalistic person invading his personal space. However, despite his helpful suggestion, the aggressive blond's eyebrows shoot to his hairline and his lips curl back in the most menacing sneer Izuku has ever seen.

Well that was the wrong thing to say.

“You saying I have fucking issues? You don’t fucking know me, you piece of shit. Keep your fucking weird-ass *stress toys* to your fucking self you greasy-haired asshole.”

Izuku’s jaw drops.

Before he can think of a response, he realizes the stranger seems disinterested in whatever he has to say, since he finally rears his head back and moves from the support beam, stomping huffily to the other side of the train without another word.

Izuku turns to gather his homework and paper drafts into his backpack and move to another part of the train, when he spots something on the other person’s back.

The more the blond moves, the more Izuku realizes there’s a definite, menacing swollen bruise marring arm, just briefly noticeable when he lurched forward and snatched his collar. Once the image passes through his mind, he can’t help but stand up and ignore the panicked alarms sounding off in his mind.

“I-I have bandages. In my bag. If… if you need one.”

The boy pauses in grabbing his backpack.

There’s a definite twitch to his body, as if he’s operating on static movement. Slowly, he turns on his heel, yet his glare has definitely simmered. His nostrils are flaring, his fists balling and becoming undone in a stuttered few seconds. A vein pops on his forehead, and Izuku would have found the image incredibly amusing if not for the fact that he could very well be twisted into a pretzel in the next few seconds.

“I mean,” begins Izuku, groaning at his own insistence on stepping into this stranger’s personal matters, “in case you needed help—”

“Don’t. Fucking talk to me. I don’t need your fucking *help*.”

Then, he grabs his nose and huffs, his eyes closed as he breathes slowly.

In. Out.

Izuku wonders, for a brief, consolable moment, if this teenager is actually taking the time to count off sheep in his head to calm himself down. Apparently, Izuku’s assumptions were correct, given the much clearer stare the blond sends him a mere second later.

Izuku realizes that they’re both standing from their seats, half-moving towards the door as the train moves to a stop.

“Um… we both get off this stop…”

The blond snorts. “Why’s that my problem?”

A few hesitant seconds pass, the breeze slipping in from outside and whipping past Izuku’s nose.

He swallows, knowing the tense predicament he's found himself in. He watches as the blond slowly begins to grin rather crookedly—maniacally, even—a sudden aura of mischief shrouding him. Izuku blanches at the implication and tries to rush to the door before the other can, but the blond straddles the door and pushes Izuku back several paces. He stares towards the bond with clenched fists, holding his tongue to stop from spouting off because he knows that, despite his own strength, this blond could probably break him in half if he wanted to.

"Yeah you can fucking get off the next stop, asshole," says the blond, laughing at Izuku's distraught expression.

But the blond is caught off-guard when Izuku launches forward and rams into him, knocking them both off the train and onto the hard, solid sidewalk. The train bustles by and rolls in humming unison, and Izuku holds back a squeak of surprise in realizing what he's just done, and the strange, tangled position he's found himself in with the stranger. The blond is groaning in pain beneath him, his head having hit the pavement from Izuku's tackle.

"Oh—Oh God, oh no—I'm so sorry!"

Izuku squeaks and tries to sit up, but the other boy snatches his collar and pulls him down, his glare absolutely *murderous*, but his smirk catches Izuku off-guard.

"Fuck, you're feistier than you look."

And then he slumps back, unconscious.

Izuku desperately ignores the heated flush rising to his cheeks, pulls out his phone, and dials the ambulance.

"Y-Yes, please, there's an unconscious man on the sidewalk and he needs help! I'm at the train station…" He groans in misery and would face-plant into some solid surface if he weren't outside in the freezing cold with a man he'd accidentally assaulted.

Way to go, Izuku, he mutters, his skin still hot with underlying fire long before the ambulance arrives.

Equable

Chapter Summary

Katsuki slowly trails his eyes back to the other teen’s relatively plain features, from the dopey shape of his mouth to the wild green-tinted ebony curls. He can already picture this idiot smiling bigger than a child posing in a 1950s propaganda photograph, armed with a pink balloon and an ice cream cone bigger than his torso.

This kid fucking for real?

Chapter Notes

Wow. WOW. I'm so floored, honored, flattered, so many adjectives that describe just how incredibly blessed and happy I am to have had such a wonderful response to this story. THANK YOU, each and every one of you, for your kind words, kudos, bookmarks, and everything in-between! I'm so glad that you seem to be enjoying this so far. Words can't describe how disgustingly happy I feel about this, haha.

Also, I wanted to address something. This story will feature darker elements, including mentions of child abuse, possible scenes depicting those moments, derogatory bullying, possessive mannerisms and behavior, intense violence at points, and minor (VERY MINOR) sexual harassment in choice scenes. This world has its squeaky clean corners but there are dark, menacing ones as well, and both will be prevalent in this story, given the context.

Despite those notes on sexual harassment in a few select moments in this story, both in mentioned conversation and brief confrontations between characters, THERE WILL BE ABSOLUTELY NO RAPE. None whatsoever. I don't want to offend anyone with this story, so please read at your own will with this in mind. Again, violence, language, and those other trigger warnings I mentioned before will take place, but absolutely no rape whatsoever.

With that all covered, thank you again for reading this story, and please enjoy!

Izuku’s teeth grind to the gum.

The pastel, blank walls of the hospital close in around him in looming, ghostly forms. He counts the tiles beneath his bright red sneakers, pressing his exaggeratedly clenched fists to his nose as he breathes and clutches the stress ball tightly between his palms. He mumbles

and switches back and forth between glancing up to assess his surroundings and peering through his notebook to scribble out his thoughts, tempted to constantly find another sidetrack so that he doesn't have to live in the current situation.

Especially given that the current situation is unbelievably ridiculous.

"Why me…" He groans, one knee bobbing up and down in broken rhythm.

He'd been able to check the blond stranger into the hospital with fair ease, despite his panicked state and frantically waving his hands to grab the attention of nearly every nurse and doctor in the vicinity. With the minutes that passed and the terrible way the blond stranger had been nearly tossed around like a sack of potatoes before being transported past the white painted doors, Izuku had admitted to, silently, sweating like a roasting pig.

He groans and smothers his face with his hands at the thought, perspiration staining his forehead and his foot incessantly tapping the tiled floors out of his anxiety alone. He leans back against the wall, releasing a heavy sigh as he listens to the distant hum of shoes hitting the waxed floors and the occasional rolling of wheels. Patients pass by him in a gentle flurry; it's quiet in the hospital tonight, only floundered with the occasional clicking of keys and the turning of a stranger's coat around the corner.

The sudden intrusion of high heels clanking on the tiles snaps Izuku out of his stupor. He instinctively straightens, perfectly aware of how tousled his hair has become from the exhausting night, how his shirt, jacket and jeans are rumpled and he, himself looks like he's been tossed into a garbage dump and pulled back out minutes later. He self-consciously runs his fingers through his air, mumbling under his breath as the approaching stranger alerts him; they're heading in his direction, towards the hospital room where the blond teenager was being kept.

What will happen when he wakes up? Izuku dreads to think of how angry and livid the other male will be when he finally opens his eyes. Concussion or not, he'll be outraged, and Izuku already feels guilty enough for the pain he'd caused on a complete stranger, despite the fact that the other had provoked him first.

"I don't care whether that batshit little fucker is awake or not! Where the hell is the person who called him in? Who *checked him in*?"

Izuku nearly jumps out of his seat as the wearer of said high heels comes into his line of vision. Almost instantly, he realizes that this must be the blond's mother: tall, athletically built, a frazzled crown of stylish ashen blonde hair, all angled cheekbones and striking mahogany eyes. She's wearing a pencil skirt and a deep gray blazer over a light blue button-up shirt, her eyelashes lengthy and flecked in black, lips painted red, and Izuku suddenly can't tell if she's been interrupted from an incredibly late shift at work or a date.

The sneer overtaking her lips and screwing up her pretty face is undoubtedly very much like the blond whom Izuku pushed off the train. She is glaring hotly towards one of the nurses, who sputters and attempts to lead the huffing, strong woman down the hallway without apparently ending up unconscious with a stiletto sticking out of her throat.

“This young man, right here, Mrs. Bakugou, called in your son. He should be awake soon, and—and we’ve made sure to take great care of him.”

Mrs. Bakugou blinks slightly at this and finally turns to Izuku. Instantly, her angry sneer melts away, and Izuku realizes with a slight jolt that her eyes have been reddened even further with swollen marks, tearstains marring her beautifully lined cheekbones. Up close, she’s absolutely stunning, and somewhat familiar, though Izuku can’t quite place why.

“I’m sorry, Ma’am, it was my fault,” he stutters out, mentally kicking himself in the presence of this strong, beautiful woman. He wants to admit to the entire scenario, but something about her naturally angry demeanor promises him an outcome that would probably only be worse if he informed her of the entire truth. “We—I didn’t mean to upset your son, but, we both ended up off the train and he hit his head. I made sure to call the ambulance right away and get him here as fast as possible, and… I’m so, so sorry.”

He ducks his head, shutting his eyes tight, hands poised over his knees as he trembles from head to toe. He can already feel his heart leaping and writhing beneath his skin as if attempting to burst out and run its own marathon. Tremors roll through his veins and simmer in his blood like ants crawling under his flesh.

“Well damn, aren’t you just the cutest gentleman. Fuck, those freckles are just sinful.”

Izuku blanches and looks up, his jaw dropping. The blonde woman’s head is tilted to the side, a small, amused smirk playing on her lips, her hand poised on her waist as she studied him from head to toe. As if satisfied with a brief once-over, she nods her head a second time, and her eyes turn gentler, softer.

“I—um, what?” He manages to squeak out, grimacing at the growth of amusement and slight, hidden mirth in the woman’s subtly glowing demeanor.

“So what the hell did my son do to get him in there, huh? Stupid brat, never listens to common sense. Heard he hit his head, right? So, you witnessed the whole thing.” She smirks, and a mischievous glint shines in her eyes. To Izuku’s surprise, she steps forward and pinches one of his cheeks. Heat boils under his skin and he struggles to find his footing in any type of conversation, especially in this moment with this woman. “You seem awfully familiar.”

Izuku frowns. “Um…” He shakes his head, clearing his throat. “I’m sorry, Ma’am. My name is Izuku. I—I met your son on the train heading to my apartment from school. Things got out of hand and… I may have accidentally pushed him off the train. I didn’t want to cause him any harm, but—”

“Oh that sly son of a bitch!”

Mrs. Bakugou snarls, though her anger is not directed towards Izuku at all. He can tell simply with the way she steps back and glares harshly towards the door where her apparent son is waiting with a large bump on the back of his head and his attacker currently sniveling beneath her like an intimidated rabbit.

“He…” Izuku bites his lip.

Truly, this woman's son *had* antagonized him on the train, and even threatened to keep him locked behind the automatic doors and force him to get off the next step, which was a long journey from their chosen block at the time. He remembers reacting instinctively, motivated by the sharp fear stabbing his gut at the thought of being left behind on the train when his routine was not interfered with once, but his reasoning for attacking the blond at all was entirely unreasonable, despite the other's foul tongue and harsh way of addressing him.

"Eh, sure he'll give me a load of excuses. The little brat's been away from home for a couple days and he's already stirring a lot of trouble. Anyway, you're a sweet kid for checking him in like this. He didn't try to fight you out of the blue, did he?"

Izuku blinks. Slowly. "Um, no. He… it was my fault, really. He didn't do anything."

Mrs. Bakugou snorts. "Don't defend him. He does that enough on his own." She brushes her hair behind her ear. "So, Izuku, was it?" She smirks down at him, brushing aside the topic of her son being hospitalized with far too much ease for Izuku's liking. "Tell me about yourself."

Izuku opens his mouth, and instantly his voice is shut off as the door to the hospital room suddenly crunches together, bursts, and flies to the opposite wall. Brutal, scratching noises of metal on metal scorches Izuku's eardrums as he loses his footing, falling back and tumbling to the ground over his own shoelaces. He turns around instinctively to search for Mrs. Bakugou, though one of his ears are ringing, a faint humming reverberating in his chest.

Surrounding doctors and nurses quickly rush to the scene. White, pastel debris are scattered in the hallway, the aftermath of an explosion that came to sudden life in the closed-off room. Terror grips Izuku's chest, instantly picturing the body of the teen he'd encountered on the train reduced to blown, charred pieces due to some wild chemical mishap.

"Oh fucking lord, he's such a drama queen."

Izuku gawks at Mrs. Bakugou, who angrily struts forward and unceremoniously plops a wad of green paper bills in one startled nurse's trembling hands. "Keep it for your troubles. I'll deal with the bastard."

If I were smart, I'd leave, thinks Izuku, yet the twitching in his fingers and the annoying pinch of curiosity slithering into his mind beckons him to the battered doorway and peer inside. If he's processing what Mrs. Bakugou is saying correctly, with her total lack of concern and the sheer force and power of that explosion, it must be related to the teen's possible Quirk. A Quirk that Izuku, despite his initial skepticism, would be more than happy to ask more questions about.

His fingernails chip with the force of immediate fire surging out of his palms each time he allows his Quirk to overtake his emotions. With a dreadfully long and monotonous lecture from his overbearing mother, Katsuki Bakugou can already believe that his night has turned so incredibly awry, given the strange encounter on the train with a freckled oddball he'd most definitely seen wandering the train station on more than one occasion.

He'd chosen to ignore him, this insignificant speck attempting to invade his radar, but clearly that brief attempt to show the other boy he shouldn't mess with him only ended up with his back hitting the sidewalk and the idiotic nerd tangling up in his legs with a hot blush flushing his cheeks. Before he'd drifted to unconsciousness, he'd grabbed the little punk's collar, annoyed at his slight admission at being both impressed and royally outraged at what the other teen had tried to pull.

His fists ball harshly into the fireproof blanket lain over his knees. Grinding his teeth, Katsuki lifts his gaze, watching the slender form of his mother she, once again, negotiates terms for spending money to cover the damages he'd caused. He hadn't expected to panic when he regained consciousness with a solid bump in the back of his head (thanks to one fucking green-haired asshole on the damn train), and inadvertently allow his Quirk to nearly explode the entire fourth floor of the hospital.

Fucking bastard, pushing me off the train, he groans, pressing an icepack to the back of his head. He leans back in the chair, grimacing at the distinctive stench of molten plastic and what he can only identify as boredom, coming from numerous patients sitting next to each other with open magazines in their laps and the occasional toddler running unattended.

An anxious tremor bolts through his muscles and simmers in his blood, along with the consistent trickle of fire that slinks into his dreams and commands his movements in jarring motions. He inhales shakily, exhales, and counts to twenty and then reverses. The simple motion repeats until he recognizes the familiar fleeting of his knee-jerk panic subsiding. The throbbing in his skull remains fresh and irritating, pulsing and careening from the back of his head to the temples.

"Hey, um… Mr. Bakugou?"

Katsuki's eyes snap open. He winces at the quick reaction, groaning at the limited reaction time he has with his body, despite the minor concussion he's retracted and the inevitable luck that follows the fact that he hasn't been diagnosed with anything too serious. A sharp, deep growl rumbles in his throat like a starved animal.

Plastering on a menacing sneer, Katsuki lifts his glare from the table full of gossip and architecture magazines in front of him, and into a pair of abnormally large green eyes he'd caught watching him from time to time on the train.

"What the ever-loving flying fuck do *you* want, shitrag?" Then, he snorts in processing how he's been addressed, caught halfway between screaming and cursing out this foolish half-pint and sulking in another corner of the building. "I'm not a *Mr. Bakugou,* you fucker. That's what people call my fucking old man."

To his annoyance, the green-eyed teen seems completely unfazed at his insults. Instead, the curly-haired former stranger rubs the back of his neck and takes his sweet, unbearable time glancing over Katsuki's frame, including the large ice pack pressed into the back of his skull.

Katsuki growls at the attentive stare, and suddenly finds himself distracted.

His eyes follow the significant patterns of this teen's long-sleeved, button-up uniform shirt, from the bobbing of his Adam's apple down his slender arms beneath upturned sleeves, both rolled to his elbows. His trousers are too long for him, easily bunched at his knees with a bright red pair of sneakers. He's scrawny, shorter than Katsuki by a good few inches, but there's an undeniable length and tone to this other teen's features, showing some form of athleticism that squeak along the lines of a swimmer or cross-country runner.

Katsuki slowly trails his eyes back to the other teen's relatively plain features, from the dopey shape of his mouth to the wild green-tinted ebony curls. He can already picture this idiot smiling bigger than a child posing in a 1950s propaganda photograph, armed with a pink balloon and an ice cream cone bigger than his torso.

This kid fucking for real?

He snorts, and focuses back on the other boy's rambling mouth, realizing with a brief jolt that this strange other teen had been mumbling under his breath for a solid few minutes. The strange echoes pulsing in and out of his mind mirror the ticking of the clock above their heads. He wants to stand up, tell everyone to fuck off, and leave.

"… But then again, I mean, you *did* kind of provoke me and everything, but I'm not really sure if I should just try to make it up to you or we can go our separate ways and pretend that none of this happened, or, or we could even just look away and I can go out that door. Oh, but, then there's the matter of the hospital and your mom seems really nice and I like her a lot, actually, and she seems kind of familiar but I can't place why? I'm not sure if—"

Katsuki—with as much restraint as he can muster with a temper boiling and rising near the surface—stands up from his chair, slaps a hand over the teen's mouth, and glowers.

"Shut. The fuck. *Up*." He narrows his eyes, and Curly Top's brow furrows for the briefest moment, even after Katsuki pulls his hand back. The blond snorts and sits back down on his chair, grimacing as the pounding in his head continues. "It's your fucking fault I have a concussion, dipshit. Just leave me the fuck alone."

At this, Curly Top's jaw tightens, and he stifles a sigh of his own. "I understand that. And, and I'm really, truly sorry for putting you in this position—"

"God, stop talking. You're making my fucking head hurt." Katsuki's patience was slipping away far too quickly for this other teen's safety. He wasn't sure if he would be able to control his Quirk with how quickly and rapidly his temper built and receded like a broken thermostat. "You really want to fucking make it up to me? Get your sorry ass out of here and stay out of my way on that fucking train if you, so help me, *must take it* all the goddamn time!"

Curly Top shuts his mouth at this. Katsuki glares at the ground, subconsciously patting himself on the back for not setting off an explosion in this brat's face; he was already going to be ridiculed and lectured for his lack of controlling his Quirk by his parents for a long while after this. Having this weird, scraggly newcomer come into his path was more than just annoying—it was fucking inconvenient, and it was already cracking a new layer of frustration open like a raw egg.

Katsuki blinks and jolts back out of instinct when the teenager decides to sit on the table in front of him, just thirteen inches or so away from his position on the chair. Releasing a heavy, warning growl, Katsuki keeps his head held high and refuses to look anywhere close to the insufferable bastard's wandering eyes.

"I want to start over, at least."

Katsuki groans. Why is this kid even still here? Why is he even bothering to talk to him? They met on the train, went through a skirmish, and fuck, Katsuki was even willing to let this scrawny mouse-brain off with a warning at most, even after deliberately attacking him on the fucking train. So why was he being so persistent?

"The fuck do you want, shithead?" Katsuki growls lowly. He winces as another low hum rolls through his temple. "Fuck…"

Curly Top sighs, running a hand through his locks. "So, um, we don't go to the same high school, do we? I think your mom mentioned something about that—"

"So what?" Katsuki snarls. "A lot of idiots go to fucking school. Even with this fucked up education system and piss-poor economy, it's kind of fucking hard not to get a proper education, dipshit." He snorts with a sharp roll of his eyes. "You're not the first fucker who pegged me as some homeless delinquent. Two-faced motherfucker…" he growls out the last few words, muttering his remaining curses in slick, calculated Russian.

Izuku's jaw goes slack. A spark of something akin to admiration or some other disgustingly bright emotion twitches the corners of his mouth and enlivens his green—too green—eyes.

"So, you *are* Russian! I had this feeling when I saw you on the train that you were, and… your Quirk is so powerful! You were half-conscious when you blew up that room and those sparks and that firepower… it was incredible. I've never seen anything like that, not since pro heroes were forced into retirement a few years ago."

Katsuki's eye twitches. He guarantees that the growing, deafening pain in his skull is only growing worse with the continuous chatter that this irritating, doe-eyed idiot is spouting between his lips in indecipherable murmurs.

He's close—dangerously, inevitably close—to clocking this brat across the face with a spark or two rimming his knuckles. He knows it's illegal to activate his Quirk outside of a training facility or even outside of a professional internship, but, fuck, he knows he's more privileged than the average male. He considers his options, between sending this mumbling idiot flying across the hospital wing and letting the bastard check himself in for his own fucking concussions, and setting his clothes on fire.

Sure, his own mother would be ashamed of him taking down someone who honestly resembles a windup plushie living on fairy dust fumes, but he doesn't give a fuck about what she thinks. He'll gladly pop off doll heads and laugh at little girls crying if that's what it takes to get what he wants, and this strange goody-two-shoes nerdy idiot, *who doesn't know how to mind his own fucking business*, still has the audacity to encroach on territory that shouldn't be ever touched.

"Well, I don't want us to be… enemies, I guess. I have enough of those already at school, actually. Heh," says Curly Top with a bashful scratching of his cheek.

Katsuki raises an eyebrow at this, finding it quite believable that this mush-for-brains is the target of probably much taller, stronger students in his grade or even beyond.

"Anyway, I really am sorry for knocking you off the train like that, even though you *were* provoking me first." He extends his hand, and a ridiculous smile stretches across his face that leaves visible dimples in his cheeks, pressing in like extra freckles.

Katsuki blinks.

"I'm Izuku. And, you are?"

The blond sinks back in his chair and glares at Izuku's extended hand as if it's covered in spiders. "The fuck? Do you—shit, you even know the fucking old hag's name, shithead, and you still want to fuck around with me? Do you even know who the fuck I am?"

At this, Curly Top retracts his hand and awkwardly rubs it on his side. He's already acting like a strange mix between a meek, curious little rabbit and an observant owl of sorts, a hybrid of two personalities into one that Katsuki, frankly, does not know how to compute.

"I mean, it did sound familiar, but, I still don't know who *you* are. Your mom seems like a very nice and… strong, lady, but she isn't the one I pushed off the train."

Katsuki's eyebrows shoot to his hairline. For a moment, just one moment, he forgets about the numbing pain in his skull and the tempting sparks sizzling in his palms. He studies this shorter teen stupidly placing himself in his path even after finding crucial information that should immediately direct him to the door, because that's what every other fucker did the moment they realized who Katsuki Bakugou was.

He's not serious. He suppresses a bemused snort; this kid didn't seem intellectually stupid, and was clearly too analytical for his own good with his constant ramblings and twitchy fingers. He wouldn't be surprised if this asshole had a full list of behavioral issues that probably either exceeded his own résumé, mumbling issues and anxiety and everything else combined.

"Listen, Zuku, Iduzuku… Deku, whatever the fuck your name is, if you had even one fucking active brain cell, you'd get the fuck out of my face and hightail it out of here before I explode your tacky sneakers off your legs." His grinding teeth and imperceptible scowl was usually enough, but this teen, in the middle of his own rant, stares at him with an irritating blankness that sends a bolt of anger up his spine and directly into his growing headache.

“Um, it’s Izuku, and, why are you always threatening me? I know that you can’t activate your Quirk lawfully to blow my shoes off.”

Izuku’s brow furrows, scrunching up his features and staring with his chin in his hand, as if pondering the workings of the universe. Katsuki can only stare, dumbfounded, as the kid doesn’t even bother leaving at the first signs of being threatened by *him*, of all people.

“I’ll call you whatever the fuck I want to call you, *Deku*,” he snarls out, finding it quite fitting that this reduction of the other’s name rolls off in a quick, snippy dance on his tongue.

Curly Top—Deku—actually manages to look irritated at this, trying to conceal it with a firm biting of his own bottom lip. Katsuki watches this action with only a mild flicker of interest, and it disappears as quickly as it comes, pestering his subconscious like buzzing termites.

“Alright, you brat, let’s get out of here before you blow something else up and cost your parents thousands of dollars in damages.”

Both Katsuki and Deku blink and turn to the source of the voice; his mother, of course, with her hands calmly poised on her hips and only a mildly annoyed scowl gracing her mouth. She returns his icy glare tenfold, the silent communicator more than enough to reveal just how angry he is and how he’s barely holding onto what’s left of his patience with the sniveling idiot sitting close to him.

“Ah, right, I’m sorry Mrs. Bakugou, for keeping him from you! I just wanted to apologize in person and make sure that he was alright.” Deku’s bashful smile and flushed cheeks are deceptively perfect for his rabbit-like demeanor, and Katsuki only snorts at the two sides of the coin he’s been able to pick apart so far with this oddball.

His mother, to his own surprise, blinks and smiles genuinely at the curly-haired teen.

“Oh, you don’t have to apologize, Izuku. My bratty son sometimes thinks he has control over everyone he meets, just prancing around like he owns the place. And thank you for checking him in to the hospital. He’ll never admit it, but even past his atrocious personality he has a knack for forgetting to thank people.” She grins rather broadly at the enraged look her son is sending her, and she laughs to brush this off.

Izuku laughs awkwardly and avoids looking either of them in the eye, nervousness visibly tingling his body in interestingly long waves. Katsuki studies this with careful stealth, noting the minute trembling of the other’s shoulders, the quick clenching and unclenching of his fists—

“Okay, seriously, I have a stress ball in my pocket if you need one.”

He sneers at the memory, blocking out the conversation this goody two-shoes nitwit and his old hag bitch mother are having. *What a little fucker.* He glares hotly towards the other sniveling teen, grinding his teeth at the thought of this asshole trying to make or break his image by offering help to him. At first, he thought the weird kid was staring him down on the train simply because he wanted something, constantly writing in his stupid notebooks and sketching out drawings that he was—unfortunately—quite curious about.

“And dearie, this little punk’s name is Katsuki.”

Katsuki glares daggers at his mother, who laughs off his expression and winks, as if nothing abnormal had transpired at all over the last several hours. Normally he would engage in an impressive screaming match with her that could easily be heard from blocks away in the large, bustling city streets, but he couldn’t bring himself to care. He was exhausted, and frustrated, and cranky, and all he wanted to do was sleep, and the fact that this shit-faced nerd was making it impossible for him to leave at the moment made it even more frustrating that he couldn’t use his Quirk in public.

Or to blast someone off their feet and watch them shrivel into smithereens. That was, unfortunately, forbidden by the law as well.

“I, um, was hoping to make it up to him, or both of you, at least. I’m sorry about this turn of events. We—it was an accident, and I don’t want to cause any more trouble for your family, Mrs. Bakugou.” Deku’s voice is annoying in its strained politeness, but the genuine way he smiles and clasps his hands together in a respectful gesture in front of his mother earns a glimmer of adoration in her eyes as she places one hand over her heart.

“Well, goodness, you’re just the cutest thing! I would be over the moon if my kid had manners like yours. Katsuki, you little shithead, you need to bring friends like him over to our place! You see, Izuku, he’s not the most social type—”

“Old hag, fuck off! Why are we even still here?” Katsuki snarls and snaps his teeth. His mother returns the glare with her arms crossed. “And we’re not *friends*.” He growls, the last words tasting bitter and borderline acidic on his tongue. He sends a brief glare towards the teen now standing between him and his mother, the other clearly petrified and unsure of what to do.

“I have an idea,” says Katsuki’s mother, and his stomach lurches because whenever she says this it’s never a “good idea” unless it involves her own wishes in total disregard of Katsuki’s. At least, that was how he envisioned each situation. “How about we treat you to dinner, Izuku? Tomorrow night, I would love to have you and your parents over as a proper thank you for checking in my idiot son to the hospital.”

Deku’s jaw drops at this, and before Katsuki can even process what his mother is saying, the teen is frantically waving his arms and shaking his head. It looks quite comical, even from this angle, given how childish and admittedly soft this other teen’s features are.

“I—that’s very kind of you, Mrs. Bakugou, but I don’t know if I should. My mom, I’m not sure what she’ll think, and, I mean, it’s my fault he’s in the hospital in the first place—”

“Nonsense!” Mrs. Bakugou huffs. “Young man, we would be more than honored to have you over. I will personally see to it that you are properly thanked for stepping out of your way and helping out my asshole son.” Her crooked smile and glistening eyes are sparkling with nothing but total mirth and mischief, and Katsuki loathes every bit of her when she’s like this.

Deku stutters out incoherent babblings as Katsuki’s mother grabs his phone and starts typing away on the keys. The bastard’s skin is close to the shade of a true summer tomato, bristling

from head to toe and struggling with choosing whether to try and take his phone back, politely ask for it back, or just stand there dumbly with his mouth hanging open.

Fucking kill me now. Katsuki groans and readjust his ice pack with the other hand. His other arm had already gone numb from holding it in place for so long.

“There. Now, you have my information, so please, dearie, do not be afraid to call me tomorrow. I’ll have to make sure that your mom gets this message, alright? Come prepared for a spectacular dinner with the Bakugous, young man.”

Deku’s eyes are unblinking and stretched wide to the size of dinner saucers.

It takes every ounce of self-control Katsuki has to not punch this fucker in the face. Twelve times.

Izuku’s hands fumble on his keys, calmly injecting the metal object into the keyhole and twisting in the darkness. He squints, carefully pushing the door open. Moonlight spills through the shadows enveloping the doorframe, his shoes scuffing the tiled squares leading to the combined space of the dining room, the living room, and the tiny corner in the complex that resembles a kitchen. Glowing green digits resembling blurred numbers pop on the microwave and stove: *1:15*.

Mom is going to kill me, he thinks.

Guilt swells up in his chest at the thought of her being too distracted with her own work and typing away at her keys to realize how late he’s coming home this time; normally she wouldn’t worry, perfectly aware of his safest strategy of leaving his late nights at the high school by taking the train, but the events that led him to arrive home this late would make her lose her hair.

His mother didn’t deserve the stress withering her soul into a stem of the blooming rose it once was. Her rosy cheeks had gone paler and paler by the day, her fingers trembling around the paper envelopes concealing bills and announcements with bold, enriched letters foretelling a darker future. He’d managed to work hard on the school paper and petition his articles to local publishers for extra cash and an update to his résumé, leading to visions of landing a spot in a university that would appreciate his analytical mind, writing talents, and his desire to attend a school that wouldn’t cost his mother a dime.

With the gentle shift between the clamor of the outside world and the dappling of rain coasting the stairwells leading to his apartment complex’s front doors, Izuku knows that he’s lucky to be able to arrive here every night with the skin on his back still intact.

Izuku releases a shaky breath and slowly closes the door behind him, removing his keys in the process and slipping off his backpack into the chair closes to him. He runs his hands through his hair, mumbling under his breath and counting off the ridiculous scenario of the night and what had happened; none of it seems real to him, but it is, and he's been simultaneously invited to dinner with a mysterious Russian-bred family who spoke in colorful expletives and carried themselves with the same ferocity as the fire that burst from one Katsuki Bakugou's palms.

An explosion Quirk. Izuku was shamelessly curious about the fundamental usage of such a powerful Quirk. If the circumstances were different, Katsuki would be heralded as a prodigious talent, dangerously so, with power so easily commanded at his fingertips. With just a knee-jerk reaction to waking up in a hospital bed he'd managed to accidentally blow a door off its hinges with just a half-activated Quirk.

Suddenly riding on the adrenaline and exhaustion that plagued him the moment Katsuki had screamed nonsensical curses at his mother upon leaving the hospital, Izuku situates himself at the dining room table. He pulls out his notebooks and a reading light, turning on the tiny switch and directing the miniscule bulb towards him and away from the hallway, steering any invasive light from his mother's bedroom. He pulls out his carefully organized tins of sketching pencils and ballpoint pens, meticulously arranging measured boxes and lines on his current notebook's paper with a new entry on the top of the page.

Katsuki Bakugou

He bites onto the end of his trusted red pencil. *I'm so weird*, he concurs with a small smile. With the temper the other teen had, he knew that he would be tossed off the closest balcony if he ever found out why Izuku was so intent on learning about his impressive Quirk and even more interesting personality.

"Explosion Quirk…" Izuku mumbles, sketching a faint outline of a fireball on the page below Katsuki's name. He opens the silver tin full of sketching pencils, each point sharpened to a pristine edge that he always pined over in order to create the perfectly straight lines he preferred in his collection of tools.

Drawing out images for profiles and feature articles often helped him with his propositions in the prep room, so this seemed no different. It vaguely reminded him of being in elementary school and drafting bullet points with sloppy handwriting on his fellow students' Quirks, comparing them, analyzing them, dissecting them to the point where he was ridiculed and mocked for his invasive interests.

Izuku brings his new pencil to the paper, next to the bullet points and below Katsuki's name on the top, and begins to sketch out the shock of hair he'd pegged as a distinctive shade of ashen blond. He starts drawing out the tufts, the distinctive slope of Katsuki's strong jaw, and he knew he would have to ask him permission to actually hold still for a perfect capture of his eyes.

Smoldering. Powerful. Mysterious.

"Sure has a mouth on him, though," mutters Izuku.

He stares at his temporary project, wondering in the back of his mind if any of this is worth the trouble. He's always been competitive to the bone, despite his obvious disadvantage in most sports and even as one of the more proficient and talented journalists in Yuuei High School's history. Still, he found a strand of determination inside him upon meeting Katsuki, and actually learning his name only ballooned his curiosity to newfound heights.

He'll have to talk to his mother in the morning about the surprise dinner that they've both been (ironically) invited to, even though he'd given said invitee's own son a concussion, as mild as it was.

He takes out his phone, rubbing sleep from his eyes, and starts typing on the bluish screen.

[*To: Ochako Uraraka*]

- *I have something really crazy to tell you tomorrow. I also kind of need help and I may have given the most terrifying person I've ever met a concussion. Also, his mom invited me over for dinner. Am I crazy for even wanting to go? Okay, actually, don't answer that. See you tomorrow, hope you're resting!*

Uraraka would most definitely make fun of him for his pristine texting grammar, but that would have to take a side-seat to the confusing excitement he feels twisting up his chest into knots.

Provocation

Chapter Summary

> “Why the fuck did you invite that fucker over?” Katsuki asks.
>
> Mitsuki tosses various lettuce leaves, tomatoes and shredded carrots in another bowl. Her blouse sleeves are rolled to her elbows, white-blonde hair swept back in a bun. She looks whimsical, almost fairy-like with how she prances around the kitchen with a rare, all-consuming aura that exudes a sensation that is not at all familiar within the Bakugou household. Frankly, he’s half-convinced she’s possessed.
>
> “Well, I have a thought, and your mother is hardly ever wrong, you know.”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

> “Izuku, you can’t just throw something like that out of nowhere and expect me not to freak out! I swear, one of these days you’re going to become way too ‘one with the paper,’ and the cover story will just be you! Dead! With no one knowing about it because even when you die it’ll be last second and no one will know what happened—”
>
> “U-Uraraka, I already apologized so many times!”
>
> Izuku laughs, waving his hands in front of his friend. She glowers dangerously at him, standing taller with her hand poised on her hip beside the table. Numerous scratch papers are spread out in front of them, some input with yellow and blue tacks and attached with color-coded Post-It notes, courtesy of Iida Tenya, another reporter and member of the *Yuuei Herald*. Normally the glasses-donning genius would be taking Izuku’s side in this scenario, but considering he’s lingering in the background with a suspicious glint on his glasses while checking his own drafts, Izuku knows he’s subjected to Uraraka’s ferocious overprotectiveness with only himself as defense.
>
> And against a concerned and flustered Ochako Uraraka, that form of so-called “defense” was practically useless.
>
> “It’s just… dinner,” he finishes lamely, a scorching red flush already beginning to snake up his neck. He crookedly grins at Uraraka.
>
> She slams her hand down, her bangles jangling in noisy rhythm as his pen leaps out of his hands.
>
> He can never focus when she’s like this; as soon as he’d sent her that text the previous night, he knew he’d made a horrible mistake.

“With some psychopath’s weird Russian family? What if they kidnap you?” Uraraka steps back, her large doe eyes focusing on the opposing wall, as if piecing together a mystery begin spun out in front of her in a web. “That would make sense. They have the leverage, the means to do so… Izuku, you could be in serious danger!”

“Uraraka, you watch way too many crime dramas,” Izuku says with a light sigh. Still, his fond smile lingers. “I’ll just be going tonight with my mom. We’ve already talked about it, and she said she was going to look into it further before I come home earlier tonight. I let you know ahead of time because I wanted to be sure that my work is covered.”

Uraraka’s features soften, her gaze roaming over him in one sweeping motion.

“You already work too much, anyway. School and the head of the newspaper committee and writing articles for other publications… honestly, you’re your own one-man show. No one else would do that, you know.” She scrunches her brow in further pondering, kicking back and sitting on top of the desk. A few inches remain between them, her polished fingernails rapping on the mahogany wood. “Makes me wonder, though.”

Izuku shrugs. He doesn’t want to relay too much information to Uraraka without her wanting to become a fully invested detective on some intense investigation.

There would be too much to explain in such a short amount of time, but the fact that he’s going to the strange address that Mrs. Bakugou provided him would be enough to rile up anyone besides his mother. He would have to relay more of those important details to her, when she was in a better state of mind after harping on him for coming home so late and how she worried he was dead and carted off the side of the road; she’d even gone on to say that he could have been sold on the black market for his organs.

Though, him mentioning that no one would pay for Quirkless organs seemed to stop her ramblings.

“Hm, well, first thing’s first, you know.” Uraraka smirks. “This guy… tell me about him. What made him so scary? Other than the apparently *scarily smooth Russian accent*,” she finishes off with a poor imitation of Izuku’s voice.

Izuku rolls his eyes. “He has an explosion Quirk. I’ve never seen anything like it, not since heroes were forced into retirement.” He ponders this, resting his chin on the upturned palm of his hand. “He was half-conscious when he blew off the door to one of the hospital rooms.” He chuckles nervously at the memory, tugging at his shirt collar. “Heh, I was standing really close to that door too when his mom showed up…”

Uraraka tilts her head. “An explosion Quirk? Like, fireworks?”

“Yeah,” says Izuku, “something like that. It was amazing, though! I’ve never seen such intense power generated so quickly and so easily. And the thing is, he blew off that door, and his mom paid it off like it was nothing. He wasn’t questioned by any police or anything about using his Quirk outside of what the law permits. There was a giant *hole* in the *wall* and he pretty much got away with it…” His brow furrows at this, staring deep into the table. “But then again, maybe there’s something else going on? Hm, I didn’t think about that before.

Maybe Uraraka is onto something. Wait, would they invite me over like that if they wanted to murder me? I don't think his mom would want to murder me. Probably just him. But I'm Quirkless so I wouldn't be of value to anyone, but I'm also out of the loop with what's popular nowadays—"

"Okay, Izuku, you're doing it again," says Uraraka. She grins fondly at him, kicks up her legs and hops off the desk. Izuku scrambles to grab his flying papers and rolling pencils, momentarily glaring at Uraraka despite the playful twitch to his smile. She shrugs haughtily. "Mutter about your doomed fate all you want, but I still think you should go digging around about this Bakugou family. I've never even heard of them, and honestly I thought everyone in Isabori District attended Yuuei."

Izuku frowns, pondering. "I don't think they're from Isabori. I've seen him on the train and everything, but that same tram winds through Redmond, Illenova, Sommartyn, and Isabori…" He trails off, counting off the names of every intertwining district that forms the city limits. "And none of them cross over each other for obvious reasons. I wouldn't take that train if I knew I would accidentally cross a border outside the tracks."

Uraraka sighs, her left hand clenching. "You worry me, Izuku. That's…" She studies him carefully. The brightness in her gentle brown eyes has faded to nothing but a wary, concerned glimmer. Izuku's chest twists in guilt; he should have kept those minor details to himself, especially about his suspicions on the Bakugou family. "That's such a dangerous route to take. And you take it every day. What if, what if the tram broke and you were stranded in a district that isn't marked for visitors?"

Izuku stands up and tenderly places his hands on Uraraka's shoulders. His friend blinks at him, but accepts the gesture, composing herself almost instantly. He dips his head when he knows he's grabbed her attention, letting his hands fall back to his sides as he leans against the desk.

"Uraraka, I know how to get out of danger. Just think about all those times when we had to go snooping for interviews in the other districts!" He grins widely, even as Uraraka pouts and pinches one of his cheeks. He grimaces and bats her hand away. "You know it's true."

"Yeah but we have special permission from our teachers. It's not like we can just waltz right in and talk about how we're not permitted in most of those places. There's a toll for a reason, you know." She shrugs. "Anyway, just, don't send me cryptic texts like that. You basically shaved off ten years of my life, pretty sure." She groans and crosses her arms behind her head. "What does your mom think about this?"

Izuku sighs at the question. "I… haven't really gone in-depth about it yet." He shrugs. "She's been… not really like herself, lately," he says, and then pauses at the startled look in Uraraka's eyes. He quickly turns to the table and gathers his papers in one hand, shoving them into his backpack with a broad smile flashing to the concerned girl beside him. "A-Anyway, I should probably head out soon. I'll text you later, alright?"

He's gone before she can protest, her words dying on her tongue.

Thursday. 3:50 PM.

Taking the train in the early afternoon for the first time since he'd moved into Isabori District with his mother four years ago is strange and, as far as Izuku is concerned, much less comfortable than taking it during the evening. His backpack remains pressed to his body, tapping his shoe on the hollow metal floors beneath him.

Strangers are packed into clusters around him, their sweat and mingled breaths—reeking of mint gum, tea and harshly roasted coffee—disperse and slither into his nose. He inhales shakily, sweat pricking at the back of his neck. As soon as the tram stops, Izuku bolts to the door, accidentally stepping on at least six people's toes on the way out. He stumbles, and runs as fast as his legs allow him down the sidewalk and towards the apartment complex where he and his mother have lived quietly for the last few years.

He has ten minutes before *they* start patrolling the premises.

Ten minutes before he's potentially beaten for avoiding paying a toll—

Focus. Focus. Focus. Just keep running. Don't stop until you get there.

He swallows the numbing pain growing in his stomach, the cautious numbing in his skull that warns him of many assemblies he'd attended at school and in the public alike, listening to the new laws being addressed to split territories. To keep those with Quirks and those without Quirks under monitored surveillance, though it extended far beyond that.

He arrives at his apartment, fumbles with his keys, and bolts into the front. Gasping, he slams his back to the door, heaving, panting, before dropping his backpack and turning to his watch.

3:58.

"Two minutes to spare…" Izuku sighs and smiles to himself, relief swelling up inside him like a rising geyser.

"Izuku?"

Izuku blinks. "Oh—Mom! You're home early."

"Speak for yourself." Inko Midoriya—all smiles and gentle warmth combined into a genuinely beautiful and humble human being—struggles carrying a tower of foldable boxes. "Oh, well, um, since you're here—Izuku, can you please—," she squeaks and nearly stumbles over her toes. Izuku almost mimics the sound before he snaps into reality.

"R-Right! Sorry!" He rushes to her side and balances it out, helping her carry it over to the table. He runs his eyes over the labels attached to the sides and lids, ranging from pristine

yellows to stained pinks, and then turns to his mother with a broad smile. “Are you clearing out your study, Mom?” Inko hesitates and tucks a strand of hair behind her ear.

She looks flushed, tired, her eyes swollen red around the rim. Her exhausted, desperate smile stabs icicles into Izuku’s heart, though he suppresses the rising fear and protectiveness with a sharp clench of his fists.

“Just… doing some spring cleaning,” she says with a small grin.

Izuku frowns. “But, it’s fall.”

“Well, the earlier the better!” Inko giggles and then, her eyes brighten as she looks over her son. “Why are you back so early from school? You’re always staying there so late, working so hard on that brilliant paper you have going on for you. Making your mama proud every day.”

Izuku’s cheeks color. He laughs faintly, rocking back and forth on his shoes. “Well, tonight we have… dinner, with that family I was telling you about. After I pretty much, accidentally, but, still, you know, injured their son. He’s okay now, though. Just, yeah, we need to go to that. I mean, I guess you don’t have to if you don’t want to—”

“Izuku,” Inko says, softly, “you’re rambling again, sweetie. Of course I’m coming. But you haven’t even told me who these people are, yet.” She gestures with a flick of her head to their tiny kitchen crawlspace, where three individual plastic bags filled with groceries are sitting untouched. “I just got back from the store before the… patrol, would start coming around. You can tell me while you help me put them away.”

Izuku nods. “Of course, Mom.” He tenderly grasps her arm and flashes a smile. She returns the gesture, and the both of them maneuver to the tiny crawlspace they consider a kitchen with little complaint following them.

Izuku knows that what little food they have is purely out of how his mother slaves away at working as a bookkeeper just down the street. He knows from the broad smiles she presents to passersby and the genuine warmth she exudes from crossing the street and in her occasional neurotic behavior, that she is well-respected and loved in the small, peaceful square of the community in which they live; a speck of light swallowed up in cemented darkness.

He pauses in putting away packaged turkey and a bag of sweet potatoes and cucumbers. “It won’t be like this forever, Mom.” He bites his lip.

She pauses in stashing away a bag of coffee beans in the cupboard above the stove.

“You don’t have to worry about anything, Izuku. You take your love of words and hard work after me, but…” she trails off and shakes her head, suddenly grabbing a carrot and pointing it at her son. Izuku blinks, his eyes crossing as she places the pointed vegetable beneath his nose. “Now you listen to me, young man! Don’t you *ever* concern yourself with what’s going on with money. You’re too young to stress over these things, and your mom is taking care of it. Understand?”

Izuku rolls his eyes and lowers the carrot. “Alright, if you say so.”

He knows that she doesn’t believe him. It’s a fight she can never win.

She stares for a few moments longer. “Izuku…” She shakes her head. “What in the world am I going to do with you?” Despite the grimness in her choice of words, she’s turned softer, gentler, and her smile is rosy and laced in a graceful hue. Izuku becomes mesmerized by it and remembers why he’s loved and admired his strong mother over all these years.

His father didn’t deserve her. No one did, in his opinion.

“Anyway,” Inko started, her voice slightly choked. She rubs at her nose and places her hands on her hips, assessing their kitchen space with narrowed, focused eyes. “Hm, I need to sweep up a little before we leave so that we don’t come back to a mess.” She turns to Izuku. “Who is this family, then, Izuku? I keep forgetting to hold you accountable to telling me! Goodness, and you were supposed to let me know after giving me a heart attack for not answering your calls yesterday.”

“Uh, right…” Izuku shrugs sheepishly. “Sorry about that.”

“So…” Inko’s lips twitch, a sparkle in her eyes. Izuku shrugs.

“Um, well, the lady who invited us over is named Mrs. Bakugou. She was really nice and classy, and strangely enough didn’t seem too bothered about what I did to her only son, so that was weird, but—” he stops, blinking. Dread swells in his chest. “Mom, are you okay?”

Inko’s eyes had gone so wide he feared they would pop out of her head. At first, she looks sickly pale, her hands shaking at her sides. She opens her mouth to reply, closes it, and then quickly shakes her head while carding one hand through her ponytailed hair.

Izuku reaches out to her, but then, she looks at him with an elated smile. Her trembling turns into excited tremors and a bright, sunny flush darkens her cheeks.

Izuku blinks, taking a step back.

“Mom…?” His frown deepens. His stomach somersaults and he tastes bile in the back of his throat, suddenly being reminded of this expression from years ago, from even before his father stepped out the front door—

“Oh, no, Izuku, that’s—goodness. It’s been so long.”

Izuku blinks. “Wait, what?”

Inko claps her hands together and nearly hops up and down in excitement. “Alright, change of plans! We’re going to make you look so handsome tonight! I can make some cookies, her favorite—wait, would they still be her favorite? Oh, it’s been too long, how could I have lost touch with her so easily after all these years…?”

Izuku’s jaw drops. “Wait—you, you *know* Mrs. Bakugou? I mean, that’s probably a common name…”

“She was Russian, right?” Inko asks. Izuku ponders, then nods. “Very few Russian immigrants in these districts, Izuku. I’ve known Mitsuki for years. We were practically inseparable at university before I met your father.” She frowns at this, a distant glimmer in her eyes, and then she smiles even wider at her son. Izuku’s confusion subsides for happiness, elated at the sight of his mother being so genuinely happy. “Alright, I’m sure one of your father’s old suits is around here somewhere… oh, she must be married, then, since she has a son. What’s her son like?”

Izuku scratches his cheek. “Um.”

Loud? Arrogant? Insanely strong? Probably incredibly dangerous? Wants to twist me into a pretzel and leave me on the side of the train tracks? Curses like a banshee? Kind of resembles an angry chicken who can time himself to explode when his temper snaps?

He blinks. That was more than he expected to come up with on the spot, and the way his mother watches him makes him realize he’s been daydreaming for a solid thirty seconds.

“Uh—he’s, um, a lot like his mom.” He grins sheepishly.

“Ah, of course,” Inko says, grinning fondly, “what are the odds? Mitsuki Bakugou, having met my son off the train? Oh, don’t worry about what happened, dear. You apologized and he’s alright, and if Mitsuki isn’t bothered by it then you should be fine.”

Izuku doesn’t know what else to say. He’s still processing this somewhat incredible information and tries to picture Inko and Mitsuki younger, in their early twenties, laughing while exchanging textbooks and giggling girlishly over steaming mugs of coffee.

It boggles his mind. Still, joy for his mother and how she’s flying around the kitchen with a towel to scrub away residue makes him smile a little lighter. A little clearer.

“This will be so wonderful, Izuku!”

Izuku grins. “Yeah, Mom. It will.”

I’m just glad you’re happy.

“This is going to fucking suck.”

“Hey you little ass-brat! Keep that heat coming! And it’s going to be fucking wonderful so shut the hell up!”

Katsuki snarls and whips around to face the stove, gradually flipping over cooked rice in expert, cleanly timed motions in a nonstick pan. His other hand hovers beneath the pan and ignites, tiny trickles of flame bursting around the sides of the pan and receding in the exact

right moments. He twitches one knuckle at a time to even out the fire spreading beneath the pan.

A vein pops in his forehead and his teeth grind in annoyance as a small clump of rice hops off the pan and splatters on the floor.

With a barely mustered groan behind clenched teeth and a strain in his throat, he continues staring into the pan and watches as the spices mingle together. He rotates his hand again.

Stupid Deku. Stupid Deku's mom. Stupid dinner. Fuck it all. Fuck everything.

"Fucking rice," he growls.

"Ignore it, Katsuki." Mitsuki hums a small tune to herself, balancing one hand on the end of a two foot-long cutting board, slicing through numerous carrots, peppers, and zucchini. She quarters the appropriate pieces and sprinkles them into a ceramic bowl. "Going to bring this over to you to mix with the rice, so don't burn it, my little asshole chef!"

He snorts, but doesn't protest. He needs to pay attention to the rotating heat and the pan he's carefully flipping and turning.

Even at this point, the rice browns further and smells richly of fresh spices and cooking oils.

"Fuck off, old hag."

She just laughs, full of mirth and robust delight that Katsuki never understands.

"Aw, music to my ears!" She smirks. "You used to love it when I called you that. Well, without the *asshole* bit. Guess that comes with becoming a teenager. All those hormones and anger issues. You remind me so much of myself sometimes."

Her smile is a string of pearls for teeth, and it irritates Katsuki to the bone.

So he refrains looking at her, and is almost grateful that he's been tasked with combining the bowl of vegetables she hands him into the frying rice.

Katsuki, for just a second, pauses. He holds back a sigh, knowing that if he makes any noise that his mother would reciprocate with far too much happiness for his liking. Despite this constant irritation, he was invested enough in the task of cooking dinner with his mother to actually pick out his favorite apron: a simple black design sewn through with explosive patterns.

With matching mittens, because his obsessive-compulsive need to have appliances and physical attributes of the kitchen presented in stylish pairs keeps him awake at night sometimes.

"Why the fuck did you invite him over?" Katsuki asks.

Mitsuki tosses various lettuce leaves, tomatoes and shredded carrots in another bowl. Her blouse sleeves are rolled to her elbows, white-blonde hair swept back in a bun. She looks

whimsical, almost fairy-like with how she prances around the kitchen with a rare, all-consuming aura that exudes a sensation that is not at all familiar within the Bakugou household. Frankly, he's half-convinced she's possessed.

"Well, I have a thought, and your mother is hardly ever wrong, you know."

Katsuki cleanly swerves around the pan and snaps his fingers to readjust the heat blasting from his palm. The vegetables and rice toss and roll, the smell wafting through his nostrils, and he's halfway tempted to add an extra dose of cracked pepper and chili for a kick that he craves almost constantly, but he'd probably end up with a second concussion if he considered messing with this dinner his mother has set up.

"And, I have a great feeling about this particular boy!"

Mitsuki grins, and this time, Katsuki glances over his shoulder to briefly make out the crooked twitch to her lips. The snarky, simpering smile that stabs simultaneous fear and expectation into the hearts of her targets and friends alike. If he weren't her son, it would most likely chill her to the bone, but now he just feels competitive and wanting to exceed how her smirk affects people in their own home.

"The fuck does that mean?" He rolls his eyes and turns back to the pan. The rice steams and rolls with heavy flavor. He carefully removes the pan from the stove and waits for his palm to brush away the rising flames.

"I think that adorable young man is the son of one of my best—no, *the* best friend. The only one. From college. We lost touch, but, she's made quite an impact on my life, even before I met your father."

Katsuki blinks and raises an eyebrow. "The fuck? You invited him over him possibly being the son of your weird past friendship… person, thing?"

He groans at his own boggled choice of words. Mitsuki stares blankly at him.

"Shut up!"

Mitsuki clicks her tongue. "Honestly, I don't understand why your father thinks your horrible mouth is worse than your manners. I think they just go hand in hand." She chuckles. "Anyway, I already recognized the kid's name. Izuku. It sounds too similar to his mother's name, and I remember her distinctly telling me back in school that if she had a son, she would give him that exact name." She pauses, and groans. "I wish your father wasn't away on a business trip right now. Would be great for him to meet Inko again after so long."

She smiles fondly, and frankly, it makes bile rise in Katsuki's throat.

With a sharp huff, Katsuki meticulously pours the finished rice into a larger bowl, his mittens useless given the abilities of his Quirk, so Mitsuki inwardly squeals at the fact that her son apparently just likes wearing them.

"Fuck off, old hag," he snarls.

She smirks crookedly. Knowingly. He can sense her whimsical stare burning into his back, hotter and more palpable than the fires he brought to life beneath the cooking pan.

“Oh, Katsuki, if Inko’s son is just as charming as she is, even you will fall for his charms.”

She laughs at the blank, twitching look he sends her. His palms burst into flames and set his mittens on fire, and he growls and throws the ruined things into the sink. Angry, he removes his apron, folds it perfectly into a reasonable square, and shoves it beneath the cupboard on the island in the middle of their extremely well-decorated and flourishing kitchen.

“I’m not you,” he growls out.

He moves over to the sink and turns on the water, furiously scrubbing his hands underneath and ignoring the pointed look she gives him. Mitsuki leans against the counter, her manicured nails tapping the smooth granite counter. He bristles beneath her stare, but he would rather not give her the satisfaction in asking her whatever the fuck was wrong with how she was acting tonight, and why she couldn’t stop staring at him.

“Those cuts fresh?” she whispers.

Katsuki—for a second that passes as quickly a mouse’s heartbeat—stiffens. He’s not sure whether or not it’s because his mother noticed, but the lines burrowed into his palms are thick enough to be gashes, painted and ripped through his skin in vicious, aggressive lines. He swallows quietly and times out his response carefully enough to try to convince her.

“No, they’re fucking not.”

Mitsuki’s arms fold over her chest. She watches him, quietly this time. The thick blanket of silence that envelops the two of them lasts too long for Katsuki’s liking. He bristles beneath the proximity between them and removes his hands from beneath the sink, drying off his hands in a clean white towel. Singe marks brush onto the fluffy cotton fabric. He curses under his breath and folds the towel over to snuff out the new marks.

“You’re not meant to do what I did, you know.” She tilts her head. “We moved here to get away from that lifestyle, Katsuki. There’s change here—”

“Old hag, we’re not talking about this. Plus, you’re a fucking hypocrite.”

He doesn’t even glance at her, pointedly glancing over the cookware still splayed out beside the stove. With a click of his tongue, he moves to put spatulas, wooden spoons and other similar items into the sink. He repeats the action to avoid glancing at his mother, who still watches him like a determined blonde hawk.

“I’m your mother. I’m involved too deeply in this. You are not.”

Katsuki raises an eyebrow at her. “Fuck off, *Mom*. You’re worse at lying than the old man.”

Mitsuki opens her mouth to reply when a significantly long spattering of knocks echoes through their four-story house. Instantly, her expression brightens, and she quickly takes out her ponytail to allow her hair to fall to her shoulders. Katsuki watches her, somewhat

surprised, as she removes her apron and beckons for him to follow her with a stern look gracing her lips.

He bites his tongue, furious.

The fucking food isn't even done cooking yet!

Izuku shifts in his shoes—his father's old loafers—as he cranes his neck and glances up, and up, and even further across the massive house displayed in front of him. He gulps, half-listening to his mother's excited chattering as she holds a glass casserole dish filled with cookie brownies that were apparently Mitsuki's old favorite flavor, but she hadn't stopped talking since they paid a fee to enter this part of the district this late at night. They were lucky they managed to arrive here without any trouble, but now, Izuku isn't entirely convinced that they're exactly out of trouble yet, either.

He nearly jumps out of his skin when the door to the practical mansion opens, and Mrs. Bakugou stands there with an elated, expectant smile on her face. Izuku's jaw drops at noticing that, yes, there was no possible way that this woman didn't expect for his mother to be here, if in fact Inko was expecting to meet the exact same person.

"Inko! Damn, girl, you're just as cute as a button like always!"

"M-Mitsuki, it's so wonderful to see you! Izuku dropped the bomb on me this afternoon and my goodness, I'm so excited to see that it's actually *you*!" Inko then fumbles around the casserole dish, and presents it a little awkwardly in front of her. Izuku softens at his mother's sheepishness and the nervous blush dressing her cheeks.

Mitsuki places a hand over her heart. The genuine twinkle in her eyes startles Izuku, as it's nothing like the aggressive and polite manners she'd shown to him the other night, and most certainly nothing like her crazy son.

"You made me those cookie brownies we made in college? How did you even know?" Mitsuki smiles and politely takes the dish. "This is so wonderful, Inko. I just had a hunch as soon as I saw your son. Those freckles are just too adorable."

Izuku blushes. Inko giggles and smiles, and the warmth radiating from her would be powerful enough to brush away the pain in aching muscles.

"Oh you must be freezing. Come inside! Oh, just wait, Inko, I'm so excited to show you around the place! I made my asshole son clean it from top to bottom before you came! And don't worry, he'll be on his best behavior for tonight." She winks at Izuku, who scratches the

back of his head. He's not sure what to say to that, and even more unsure as they walk through the front doors and an immaculate household presents itself.

The entire bottom floor clearly connects to at least three or four different rooms with variously colored wallpaper. From them stepping through the front doors, Izuku can glimpse the expanse of a long dining room table, complete with four prepared silver China dishes and matching silverware. Wine glasses. A centerpiece sculpture the size of his forearm modeled after a sparrow. Smooth mahogany chairs.

He can barely comprehend the size of an enormous glass chandelier that dangles out of his sight above the table, beautiful and glinting like cut diamonds.

And that's just one room…

His jaw drops.

Mitsuki smirks. "Close that mouth before a fly buzzes in, Izuku. You'll want to open it up again to dig in! Katsuki and I have been at it for hours, now."

Izuku gulps. He's not entirely unconvinced that Mitsuki's son will come sprinting through the combined rooms with a kitchen knife, making some dramatic violent declaration before possibly stabbing him in the chest. After setting the knife on fire, because his Quirk was simultaneously fascinating and extremely deadly.

He tugs at the collar of his shirt. He's already sweating.

It's for Mom. It's for Mom. She hasn't looked this happy in forever.

He watches as the two women talk as if no time has passed, exchanging various laughs and broad smiles that stretch their mouths wide and glistening. Izuku grins at the sight, wiping his clammy palms on his slacks. Then, he trains his eyes to the door, where Mitsuki Bakugou's son nearly phantoms out of one of the connected rooms. He stands there, silent as stone, and once those smoldering crimson eyes shift to Izuku, Izuku's chest ties into a vicious, warped knot.

"Uh…" he says dumbly.

He blinks to gather himself, shaking his head, and nearly squeaks when he sees the other teen boldly taking a few steps forward, just using an extra stride or two to clear the distance between them. The atmosphere grows thick with tension, but Izuku isn't just drawn to this.

He looks… His jaw pops open for the second time in five minutes because, Katsuki Bakugou is unfairly stunning.

The blond's spiky hair remains untamed and just as dimly fair as it appeared the first night Izuku saw him on the train. His button-up, black collared shirt is ruffled and undone near the top, exposing the teasing glance of an underlying white top and a clear shock of fair, sun-tinted skin. His dark jeans hug his muscular form just as well, his sleeves rolled to his elbows and a thick musky scent wafting from his clothes. His angular features are tight and wound

shut, clearly hiding the rising anger at seeing him, which Izuku blatantly ignores in favor of drawing his eyes up and down the other's appearance.

"You done eye-fucking me, *Deku*?"

Katsuki's voice is dancing on needles, barely composed, and if one were to pay attention, the twitching of his fingers and the popping vein in his forehead betrayed any sense of indifference. It sounds bored, irritated, clearly only approaching him for the sake of false politeness.

"Not yet," Izuku says, distractedly—and not one second passes until he realizes what he's let slip out.

His cheeks turn a bright scarlet.

Katsuki's twitching fingers and vein disappear, his eyebrows shooting to his hairline.

"U-Um, t-that's… not…" Izuku doesn't know what to do with his hands. He doesn't know why he said that, why he even thought that, and now, it's escaped his mouth, and he can't take it back, and that thought alone shocks him.

Before Katsuki can even process what's just been communicated between them in a span of twenty seconds of seeing each other, Mitsuki's laugh shatters their awkward silence. She glances between the two of them with a knowing, crooked smirk.

"Well, damn, Inko, your son's got some flirty spunk! I've never seen my asshole son so speechless!" She only continues to laugh, and Inko seems just as confused as the two teenagers in front of her, switching between Izuku and Katsuki.

Izuku feels as if he's combusted into flames.

Well this was a *brilliant* start.

Chapter End Notes

THANK YOU to everyone who commented/left kudos/bookmarked last chapter and even before that! It honestly means the world and I am so flattered and honored. I hope you enjoyed this chapter! The next one will be a teensy bit longer and cover more questions you probably have, considering what's being presented here.

Feel free to go to my Tumblr to ask questions, talk, or just whatever. :)

Until next time!

Recrimination

Chapter Summary

Izuku stiffens. His mother's spike in anxiety drifts and wafts through the air, tumbling over his own body in vicious waves. He instantly wants to lead her to another secluded area in the house and listen to her speak her mind. He glimpses briefly across the table at Mitsuki's crossed features and Katsuki's mask of indifference, though both have grown considerably tense after the chosen words that left Mitsuki's wine-red lips.

"What did you guys do in college?" Izuku asks. Mitsuki turns to him, smirk as crooked as her son's though containing far less cynicism and sharp teeth.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The fuck?

Katsuki blinks. Twice. He doesn't listen to his mother's laughter and mocking tone; he's sure it's directed at him in some way.

He's too preoccupied, perplexed with a rummaging train of thought that crash-coursed the moment he heard those unexpected words that slipped between the pink, lightly bruised lips of a boy he'd rather banish from their household and forget.

"Not yet."

What. A. Crazy. Fucker.

He stares at the freckled idiot in front of him, standing a few inches shorter and blushing bashfully as if he hadn't just blatantly swallowed him up with his eyes. Eyes that were far too big, far too expressive, and too sickly green, like sprouting summer leaves. His outfit is too large on him, his body composed of gangly shoulders and appearing awkwardly out of place in the dark burgundy button-up shirt and dusted slacks. His loafers even seem too big for his feet; he constantly shifts back and forth beneath his stare, though the idiot wouldn't notice even if Katsuki directed him to look through a magnifying glass to prove his point.

"Katsuki, go make sure the food's ready! We'll be at the table in just a moment."

Katsuki glares at his mother and, before he can snap out a reply worthy of any other mother brutally kicking him out onto the sidewalk, he absorbs Inko Midoriya's wide-eyed face, and grimaces.

She resembles her son in nearly every way, short in height but generously overweight. She's a bundle of similarities and stark images that are easily comparable to her flustered, sputtering fuckwad of a son, yet he knows that he will gravely suffer if he curses again in front of his mother's apparent best friend.

It's strange, watching how she and his mother are exchanging words and teenager-like giggles as if they'd spoken just yesterday.

"Fine," he growls out, his fists clenching harshly at his sides. He watches his mother smirk in silent approval, as if praising him for refraining from his gratuitous swearing.

He dismisses this with a roll of his eyes, turns on his heel, and stalks back to the kitchen with his hands firmly shoved into his pockets. He levels his breathing, counting as best he can to calm himself down—

"Izuku, precious son of my college best friend, why don't you go help him? He can be so careless sometimes when setting up the table for guests. He's got such a reckless temper." Katsuki bristles like an angry cat, practically feeling the whimsical adoration for his misery in his mother's ed eyes.

She mirrored him in multiple ways, but for her to use his forced politeness to her advantage was cruel.

"Um, I—of course, Mrs. Bakugou."

Katsuki bites back a groan. He's not looking forward to this. Even hearing the stumbled scuffling of the other teen trailing behind him takes back his previous inkling of patience and catapults it into a brick wall. He doesn't even turn to acknowledge the other as he makes his way into the broad kitchen, rubbing his palms together as he sweeps his gaze over the array of pristinely cut slices of side vegetables, fried rice, traditional potato salad loaded with chopped onions and cut celery—

"*This* is your kitchen?"

Katsuki pinches the bridge of his nose, and turns to glare frigidly at the other teen.

The boy who he's been referring to as Deku is spinning in a slow, entranced circle, green eyes spread so wide any foolish stranger would easily fall prey to them.

"What does it fucking look like?" he snorts.

Izuku stops, spreading out his arms beside him. He's not paying attention to Katsuki. Rather, his eyes are shifting over the granite countertops, then quickly sliding over the firm, polished rosewood cabinets and spacious corners wedged between the stove and cupboards. Katsuki twitches, holding back a vicious sneer, impatiently steering his attention to the food and very calmly counting back from one hundred.

"The hell are you doing?" he snaps.

Izuku's fingers pause on the cupboards, his mouth slightly open in awe. He turns, and those freckles pop with a new blush, one far sweeter and just a light dusting of pink along his nose and cheeks. His smile is irritatingly wide, his teeth far too white. Far too clean.

"This is *amazing*. Our kitchen is… it's not even half this size. You could fit maybe five of our kitchens into just one of these!" Izuku then turns and balks at the amount of food neatly arranged into bowls and balanced on plates. "Did you and your mom make *all* of this?" He takes his time moving back and forth between the different dishes, his hands fumbling on the cloth of his shirt as if he's unsure of where to put them. He's sparkling and muttering inconsistent phrases under his breath. "Are these all traditional Russian dishes? Wow, these all look so interesting! I've never seen a potato salad presented like that. Oh, I don't think this one looks traditionally Russian, but I'm not that educated in it. N-Not that I think I'm dumb or anything, or that I don't think your food wouldn't be good—"

Katsuki abruptly steps forward and slaps a hand over the other's mouth. Izuku jumps beneath the contact, his back pressing against the square sink, in-between two clusters of neatly arranged platters. Katsuki's teeth grit, his remaining hand steaming, one too many veins pulsing in his head.

"I'm going to move my hand," growls Katsuki, barely above a whisper, a crooked smirk taking over his lips, "and you're going to stop talking." His eye twitches and his mouth shakes in a struggle to maintain what's left of his composure, and it's only been ten minutes since his mother's guests stepped through the front doors to their home.

Izuku hesitantly nods beneath his hand, and Katsuki, with a far too-wide smile, releases him and roughly pats his shoulder.

"Good. 'Cause, if you peep another word—yeah, just *one more fucking word*—I'm going to burn your lips right off. Understand, *Deku*?"

Izuku pauses for a moment, as if lost in his own sea of meandering thoughts. Then, he grins genuinely, and nods, miming the action of drawing a zipper shut across his mouth.

Katsuki steps back, nose scrunched in suspicion. He's not entirely convinced with this sudden obedience, especially given the odd glimmer in Izuku's expression.

"Alright, fuckwad. Quit staring at me and move the potato salad."

He turns his back to Izuku and grabs a plastic cutting board, scraping off the chopped vegetable stems and loose leaves into the trash bin below the sink. He glances briefly over to see if the little twerp is actually moving the platters over to the table in the other room. He's pleasantly surprised to see that the teen is humming annoyingly low to himself and doing just that, smiling incessantly wide and neatly tripping over his own loafers.

"Hey! Don't fucking trip! I spent forty fucking minutes cooking that rice to fucking perfection!"

Izuku stares at him, gives a slight roll of his eyes, and continues on his way. Katsuki groans and turns back to the sink, placing the remaining utensils beneath running water.

He dries off his hands when he's done and moves to the entryway that separates the kitchen from the dining room. He stops abruptly in front of Izuku, who's now watching him with a normalized, slightly nervous smile.

"The fuck do you want?" Katsuki snarls. "Let's just get this fucking over with—"

"Wait," Izuku says.

Katsuki glares blankly because, didn't he *just* warn this idiot that he was going to burn his fucking lips off if he started talking again?

Biting his lip, Izuku hesitates, fidgeting awkwardly like a windup toy, until he finally reaches Katsuki's glare and swallows the lump in his throat.

"Let's try to get along, at least, for our moms. I don't care if you hate me. I would probably be bitter too if someone pushed me off the train and gave me a minor concussion." He shrugs, but the new flicker of determination has not faded. "But, this isn't about us getting along. My mom hasn't been this excited in years. When I told her that we were meeting a Mrs. Bakugou, she just turned…" he trails off, lips curling into a quite noticeable pout as he struggles finding the correct descriptor. "Radiant? Happy?" He clicks his tongue and nods, smiling, though his eyes are soft and no longer looking at Katsuki. "Yeah. So, I don't want to ruin this for her, and I don't want to fight with you."

He sighs, trembling like a branch caught in a winter storm, though Katsuki has managed to hold his tongue and let the little brat speak.

"So, truce?" Izuku reaches out, his hand open. Inviting. Kind.

It's instantly infuriating, but given the daring risks this fool has already taken into speaking even though Katsuki Bakugou warned him not to, he supposes he warrants him at least thirty —no, fifteen seconds of leeway.

Then, his brow furrows, staring down at the outstretched hand.

Silence envelops the gap between them, only occasionally pestered by the hushed laughter from the dining room, where their mothers have already situated themselves.

"I do hate you. Quite a fucking lot."

Izuku lets out a small yelp as Katsuki grabs the collar of his shirt, lifts him off the ground, and abruptly shoves him to the side next to the counter. Izuku stumbles, but doesn't say a word as Katsuki keeps his head held high in the air.

"Whatever. I don't need your fucking permission to act polite to your mom. She hasn't done shit to me."

He's the first to enter the dining room, where he spots Mitsuki and Inko not sitting in their respective seats, but walking around the spacious area as his mother points to elaborate paintings depicting his relatives. His grandfathers and grandmothers, some brandished in powerful suits of armor, some scowling in their embellished uniforms and barely mustering

the ability to smile at all towards the painter. He supposes that the trademark scowl is expected in the family line, along with the red-tinted eyes and pale blond hair, though he's never questioned it until finally glancing over the awe and wonder on Inko's face as Mitsuki explains who each person is.

"Remember him, Inko? That's Grandpa Aleksandr. He passed away a couple years after we graduated, but he always loved having you over for tea. And believe me, that grouchy old bastard hated just about everyone." Mitsuki's eyes are practically twinkling.

"I definitely do. He was so kind, and so knowledgeable. Your family has always amazed me, Mitsuki."

Katsuki groans and coughs into his fist. Both women turn to look at him.

"Ah, right, Inko! We may have gone a little overboard, but I wanted to show you and Izuku the joys of Russian dishes as well as some of your old favorites. It's a bit unorganized, and my idiot son was getting a nervous tic just mixing some of these ingredients together, but trust me, your pallet will thank you." Mitsuki grins and leads Inko to her seat.

"Your house is so beautiful," Inko says, awestruck. Mitsuki nods affirmatively, gesturing for Inko to take a seat across from her.

"You're too kind as always, Inko. I made Katsuki clean the entire place with me from top to bottom, just to be sure that it was perfect for you and your son."

Of fucking course. Katsuki snorts and begrudgingly moves to the other side of the table, pulling out his chair and plopping down next to his mother. Inko settles herself on the other side, her widened eyes curious and glistening as she observes their dining room. Katsuki raises an eyebrow, but next to him he can feel his mother practically radiating with satisfaction.

"It's so huge…"

"We saved a lot over the years," Mitsuki says. Katsuki resists a snort at this, pointedly glaring into the fine tablecloth settling above his knees.

Once Izuku enters, Katsuki refuses to even look in his direction. He meticulously passes the first bowl—this one steaming with copious amounts of his carefully cooked rice—around the small square of people, ignoring the way that Izuku is clearly watching him even after he takes a seat next to his mother. The other teen whispers and gently smiles towards Inko as if she's the most angelic person he's ever encountered in his life.

His dimples pop on his cheeks like extra freckles.

Annoying. Katsuki grinds his teeth.

"So, Izuku," Mitsuki says, propping her chin on the upturned palms of her hands.

She's watching Izuku as if he's one of the wonders of the universe, though the skepticism underlying her expression tells Katsuki that she's dissecting him just as minutely as she

normally would with any new companion.

“Tell me about yourself. Inko was just telling me that you run the school paper? You must be quite the wordsmith.”

Izuku blushes, carefully setting down his glass of water.

Katsuki's frown deepens. He doesn’t understand why, but this curly-haired boy is acting as if everything he touches is going to dissolve into ash, as if the Bakugou household is somehow breakable to that capacity. It angers him for reasons he can’t grasp, but the flinching and unsureness clouding Izuku in luminescent make Katsuki’s skin crawl.

“Yeah. Thank you. Um, I work as the chief editor and writer at Yuuei High School’s newspaper department. *The Yuuei Herald*, actually. I write feature articles, profiles and I also photograph for some special issues once in a while.” Izuku keeps his replies short and sweet, his youthful face glowing. “I mean, I’m not a great writer or anything, but I love doing it. Reporting and gathering information and putting it all together. That part is always the best, even though it takes the longest. I don’t usually come home from working late until after ten.”

Katsuki raises an eyebrow at this.

“You take the train every day?” Mitsuki blinks. “What district are you both from?”

Katsuki watches Inko quickly reach under the table and grab something. He assumes it’s Izuku’s knee, judging by the way he turns to her with a clearly confused look on his face.

“We can talk about that another time,” Inko says.

Mitsuki frowns. “… Alright, then.” She leans back in her chair. “Go ahead. Dive in! My asshole chef son would love to know what you think of the rice, especially. He practically *begged* me to let him do it!”

Katsuki snorts. “Shut up, old hag.”

“Ah, so much love!” Mitsuki chirps.

Then, her eyes glisten with mirth as she spots one side of Izuku’s plate already clean. The boy blushes at the attention, his fork still hidden in his mouth. Katsuki follows his mother’s stare, blinking at realizing how quickly he’d eaten one side of his dish already.

“I…” Izuku chuckles and sets down his fork. “The rice is really good.”

Wrong. It’s fucking perfect.

Katsuki glares.

“What’s fu—what’s wrong with it?”

Izuku stares at him. Only Katsuki seems to notice the treble of determined stubbornness and the slightest flicker of annoyance dancing in those vibrant green eyes. He wants to strangle this other teen and watch him admit to some sort of dark secret that he's apparently hiding at his own dinner table. He doesn't care if his mother ends up frustrated with him once their guests leave; this pathetic fuckface bothered trying his food, and his opinion should have been honest.

"Nothing." Izuku's smile is crooked. Forced. "I like it."

Inko glances between Katsuki and Izuku. Mitsuki does the same, though the slightest smirk graces her lips in contrast to Inko's concerned frown.

"Really." Katsuki's grip tightens around his knife. "Just *good*."

"Yep."

"S-So, what do you do?" Inko implores, gradually interrupting the silent match between her son and the teenager he'd accidentally assaulted.

Katsuki's grip lessens slightly on his silverware. Just enough to loosen the tension in his back and the encroaching tremors in his muscles. He needs to hit something, but he'll have to suppress these urges until later, when he can slip through the front doors or windows and sprint into the night.

Or something equally as dramatic and irritating to his mother.

He rolls around his tongue to practice stiff politeness, addressing Izuku's mother with a bob of his head.

"I work for my old man and the old hag keeps me busy with homeschooling. In Kindergarten I was requested to skip three years because of my academic progress."

I skipped three whole fucking years because I'm brilliant, mother of that freckled fuckface.

Inko's eyes widen at this. She turns to Mitsuki, an interested glimmer crossing her features. Katsuki finds it intriguing how her lips twist into a hesitant, as well as considerate and genuine, smile.

She's a bundle of contradictions, mirroring the actions of her teenage son with ease. Determined to distract himself from the bubbling warmth in his chest, Katsuki reaches for his glass of water and brings it to his lips. His throat had already run dry.

"Goodness, Mitsuki, I had no idea that you homeschooled your boy." She smiles warmly at Katsuki.

He blinks at the attention, resisting the instinctive scowl that threatens to break out on his features; he would keep his promise to himself that he wouldn't step out of the usual boundaries with this far too kind woman, even if she was Izuku Midoriya's mother.

"What's your name again?" she asks gently.

Katsuki swallows too quickly, and starts coughing at the table.

“Kats—shit—ack, Katschuki—an. No, um. Ah, great.” He glares into his glass and ignores the surprised look his mother sends him. “Fuck. Sorry.” The curse word slips out before he can stop it. He bristles beneath his mother’s sideways glare and rolls his eyes, feigning calmness with a stiff rolling of his shoulders and with a quick clearing of his throat.

Izuku blinks at this. “Kat… Kacchan? I thought your name was Katsuki.”

His eyes are wide and almost doe-like, but Katsuki sees directly through that infuriating façade—nothing but mischief shines in those deep green eyes. His blood simmers, his glare matching the other’s feigned expression with equal intensity.

Shut the fuck up.

“It’s Katsuki.”

Motherfucker.

“Hm, it sounded like you said *Kacchan*.”

Izuku’s lips twitch into a small, crooked smile. He turns innocently to his food and grabs his own glass of water, gradually taking a few sips of it as both of their mothers exchange awkward, curious glances.

“Inko, his name is Katsuki. I don’t know why he suddenly lost twenty IQ points and forgot his own name.”

Mitsuki laughs it off and harshly elbows Katsuki in the ribs. Katsuki snarls and glares darkly into his plate, tempted to stab his fork into the roasted chicken in front of him.

He imagines it to be Izuku’s broadly satisfied face, using his multitude of freckles as ideal targets.

“Oh that’s completely fine,” Inko says. “That’s very impressive that you have such an advanced education, Katsuki. It must be hard for you to balance that while working with your father.” She smiles warmly, and once again it makes Katsuki incredibly uncomfortable and unsure of what to do with his facial expressions. “I’ve known your mother and Masaru for many years. I don’t know if I would even be in the wonderful spot I am today without their help.” She giggles slightly and plays with the utensils next to her plate, seemingly becoming lost in her own thoughts. “It’s been so many years, now, hasn’t it?”

Mitsuki folds her hands over her lap, tilting her head to the side as she addresses Izuku with a brief wish of her long, butterflied eyelashes. “Izuku, sweetie, your mom probably hasn’t told you this, but she used to work with my husband and I back in the golden days.”

Izuku visibly brightens at this. “Really?”

Katsuki snorts. Inko, however, pales slightly, and lets out a shaky laugh.

“Ah, well, that was a long time ago. Things are different, now. It looks like you and Masaru have made quite the foundation for yourself.” Inko reaches for the potato salad bowl and scoops another helping onto her plate, trembling like a wind-whipped branch. “These recipes are so well-done and beautiful, Katsuki. Tastes amazing.” She finishes her statement by quickly diving back into her food.

Katsuki’s eyebrow raises at this. “Thanks.”

Izuku stiffens. His mother’s spike in anxiety drifts and wafts through the air, tumbling over his own body in vicious waves.

He instantly wants to lead her to another secluded area in the house and listen to her speak her mind. He glimpses briefly across the table at Mitsuki’s crossed features and Katsuki’s mask of indifference, though both have grown considerably tense after Mitsuki spoke.

“What did you guys do in college?” Izuku asks. Mitsuki turns to him, smirk as crooked as her son’s though containing far less cynicism and sharp teeth.

“Many things. We’ll have to enlighten you with some great stories at some point. Your mother was a real trooper in that department, weren’t you, Inko? It’s a shame that we never really were able to finish some of the jobs we were given. Think of it, Izuku, as a temporary form of service, so to speak. There are more than a few ways to handle jobs given over and under the counter.”

Inko avoids looking at Izuku’s prying eyes. He holds back a sigh, turning back to his plate and toying with one of the loose vegetables around the rim. He can feel Katsuki’s burning stare, and instantly wants to return it with a smile as lopsided and brutal as the other can give. However, there’s nothing that he can do to change the other’s mind, or at least convince him to try to move past their current opinions of each other and hopefully reach a new level of understanding.

“That was a long time ago,” Inko says, her voice having spiked a few octaves higher.

Katsuki’s eyebrows both raise in unison at this, as if scoping something out about Izuku’s mother that he himself hadn’t noticed until now. He watches how Mitsuki’s son expertly tracks both of their movements, decoding their mannerisms and absorbing them with immense interest.

Those deep scarlet eyes brim with knowledge and perception, two vindictive qualities Izuku had always wished to have himself, especially considering his ambitions at the *Yuuei Herald* and his desire to reverse the impending laws on keeping superheroes in hiding.

Izuku swallows a mouthful of rice and smiles, hoping to relieve the attention from his mother. “Your house is beautiful, too, and it reminds me of traditional Russian architecture. Kind of like that one superhero’s house. Um, Noborikov? Iron Hammer?” Izuku brightens once Mitsuki’s eyebrows raise at this, and a pleased smirk dresses her lips.

“You’re a smart little bastard, huh.” She tilts her head. “You’re a lot like your mom. Inko, you should be proud to have raised such an educated and well-spoken son.”

Katsuki’s scowl deepens next to her, though his stare is firmly burrowed into Izuku’s chest.

He almost starts sweating at the intensity behind such a ferocious glare, but he chooses to ignore it and suffer the embarrassing way Mitsuki acknowledges him instead. It’s better than suffering the other way, he supposes.

Besides, he legitimately likes Mitsuki Bakugou, despite her intimidating nature.

“What district are you living in, by the way, Inko?” Mitsuki asks. “I’m surprised you’re not somewhere closer to Sommartyn. We invited you here but I would’ve sent someone to go get you rather than make you take the train here.”

Inko hesitates, her hand paused over her plate.

Izuku swallows. “Isabori, Mrs. Bakugou.”

To his surprise, both Bakugous stiffen at this. Katsuki’s shock is less evident, but the way his lips twist up and the way his shoulders turn as solid as a rock strikes Izuku as more concerning than the way his mother stares at Inko as if she’s grown another head.

“Inko, you live—you live in *Isabori*? What are you doing there? That place is…” she trails off, struggling to find the correct words and maintain her politeness at the same time. Izuku can read it all over her expression; the way she dances around her struggle to maintain her composure and still be overjoyed at seeing his mother are combating in the same playing field.

Katsuki, however, is unreadable. Izuku’s eyes stray to Katsuki’s right hand, which is gripping his fork with far too much intensity. He wonders if the utensil will break under his grip—given the strength of his Quirk and the explosive potential, he knows that there are plenty of methods for him to express his anger. Watching him attempt to conceal it within his skin and refuse to expel the flames from his fingertips is an interesting, absorbing sight all on its own, despite the clear animosity being directed towards him.

Izuku accepts it fully. He would rather Katsuki Bakugou inflict some form of anger on him rather than direct it towards his mother.

“We manage,” Inko finally says, though she keeps from looking directly at Mitsuki. “I moved there with Izuku and his father a few years after graduation. We just had to relocate, given the circumstances. I’m sure you can understand that, Mitsuki. Sometimes it’s too hard to maintain a life in the same place.”

The blonde woman across the table is gripping the tablecloth with one hand while the other positions her chin in feigned confident position. She oozes worry and concern like a dispatched waterfall, and Izuku can read a multitude of signals that contrast and amplify between both her and her son; it's startling.

"Children," Mitsuki suddenly says, grabbing both Izuku and Katsuki's stares. "How about you both go and… I don't know—Katsuki, show Izuku around the house and give him a tour. I want to talk to Inko about something."

Inko doesn't protest.

She nods, and Izuku watches her, his mouth dry.

"Mom?"

"It's fine, Izuku! We're just going to be talking like old friends. Nothing for you to worry about." She smiles at Katsuki, almost apologetically, and he returns the sentiment with a brief nod.

Izuku is mildly impressed that he is able to restrain himself, despite the clear disgust at the proposition his mother is presenting him. However, Izuku allows himself to move from the table, casting one sideways glance at his mother before Katsuki quickly presses his hand to his back and brutally shoves him into the other room. Izuku stumbles over his shoes and grasps the edge of the island countertop in the kitchen, turning to glare at Katsuki as the other rolls up his sleeves and stomps towards him, a dark snarl curling back his lips.

"What are you—"

"Shut the fuck up and *move*."

Izuku holds back a startled yelp as Katsuki snatches his elbow—fingers delving rough and harshly into the fabric of his sleeve—yanking him behind him as if he was dragging a dead fish. Izuku bites his tongue, struggling not to turn his head and admire their surroundings, drink in the startling portraits of the Bakugou ancestors strung up along the walls. Vivid wallpaper separating the rooms where they pass through, cleanly printed in fine patterns and muted colors. The carpet changes beneath him as they continue, even as Katsuki yanks him behind him up the stairwell into yet another floor of the rather large and confusingly mapped household.

Izuku openly gapes at the broad assortment of rooms diagonal to each other, their doors closed off and recently waxed and polished. At least five or six slabs of mahogany wood accented with pristine silver doorknobs, contrasting with the typical deep wooden arch stairwell and even the kitchen on the first floor.

Katsuki yanks Izuku forward and, without warning, flings him to the other side of the wall. Izuku braces his back against the door, and is barely able to look up before the taller teenager is invading his personal space, snatching the collar of his shirt and shaking him. His mind spins and lethargy quickly pools in his stomach.

Something deeply uncomfortable coils in his muscles like a tight spring, directing his eyes to face the infuriated, narrowed red slits that form Katsuki Bakugou's intimidating glare.

His palms instantly burst into sweat. He gulps, but he keeps staring straight into the other's unreadable stare. All he can see are flickering embers of anger and suspicion, melding into each other in equally insurmountable strides.

"What the fuck are you playing at, huh? *Fucking Isabori*? Are you a fucking *spy*, Deku?" Katsuki snarls, snapping out the last part of Izuku's forced nickname.

Then, the words sink in, like pebbles disappearing into quicksand.

Izuku blinks owlishly and admonishes Katsuki with a harsh stare of his own. Struggling, he pries Katsuki's fingers off his collar and pushes him off, unsure of the sudden fire stirring in his chest, but all too familiar with the lingering frustration that spread through his muscles. He's handled himself before in situations like this, desperately escaping skirmishes in the alleyways and outside of old, decrepit buildings around his apartment in Isabori when he couldn't afford to pay the toll for that week. He'd learned his lesson on several occasions, though he wouldn't allow anyone to accuse him of something so ridiculous.

"What are you talking about, *Kacchan*?" Izuku demands, the brutally wrenched-out nickname he'd forcefully inflicted on Katsuki sliding off his tongue as easily as water. Katsuki's left eye twitches at this, his fists clenching at his sides. Steam quickly boils in his clenched fists and slip between his knuckles.

"Fuck you! The old hag is too enamored with your mom to even notice! The fuck do you think you are? Are you tracking my fucking family? Tracking the *Bakugous*? Are you some messed up motherfucker from Isabori?"

He growls out the last few words, raking his eyes up and down Izuku's form. He blushes beneath the harsh scrutiny, knowing how the other's tremendously powerful stare can easily burn through the fabric of his clothes as if his Quirk allowed him to do so. Izuku stares, unsure of what to say, not when his own words remain lodged in his throat and, at best, become invisible glue on his tongue. He needs to say something, anything, to convince this walking time bomb anything outside of the conclusions he's spouting out of his angry mouth.

"Come on, you shitty little nerd, show me what the fuck your Quirk is! We'll have a real fucking fight. No one from Isabori would be stupid enough to send a spy who can't fight a *Bakugou*."

His pupils dare dilated and swimming in the deep crimson depths of his eyes. Izuku swallows and slowly shakes his head, attempting to raise his hands, but the other bares his teeth, as if to warn him to stop. "Don't fucking raise your hands! I don't know what the fuck you're planning, Deku, but you better stop this shit right now and I'll throw you out the fucking window before you can see anything you shouldn't see!"

"Bakug—Kacchan," Izuku begins, dreading himself for becoming so quickly attached to the name, "I'm not a spy! I don't even have a Quirk! You have to believe me—"

“Stop fucking lying!” Katsuki screams. Izuku pales, wondering if either of their mothers are listening to their one-sided conversation. “Tell me the truth and fucking fight me!”

What?

Panic swells in Izuku’s chest. He feels caught between dashing down the stairs and dragging his mother out of their home by her dress, or continuously insisting that he isn’t even capable of fighting Katsuki Bakugou in any way, shape, or form.

If he doesn’t say anything soon, he knows that Katsuki’s flame-embroiled fist will come crashing into his cheekbone.

He will do more than break bones—if he’s capable of exploding hospital rooms only half-conscious, he can easily kill Izuku with one punch.

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathes, sweat dripping from his chin. Heat suffocates the second floor, swallowing the teenager’s powerful, bristling form in front of him. “I’m not a spy. I’m from Isabori, yes. I have to deal with those hustlers as much as anyone else in my neighborhood. I’m Quirkless. Why would I even bother coming here at all if I was part of that regime?”

He’s not sure if Katsuki is listening to a single word he’s saying, not with how the other trembles with barely concealed energy. Flames lick around his fists, steam and smoke curling through his nostrils and emblazing his eyes with newfound reckless abandon.

“You’re weak,” Katsuki snaps, “obviously they would send a weakling to spy for them. And fuck, Deku, eighty-five percent of the population has Quirks. Why the fuck should I believe a single word you say?”

He has to a spy. He has to be a spy. There’s no fucking way around it.

Burning white and gold heat slithers into his subconscious and breaks out of his pores, liquefying his anger and turning it into solid, combustive power in his fists.

He’s barely holding back his strength, barely holding onto the threads of consciousness he has left, where the other side of his temperament stands as a brick wall between what little coherency he has in his thoughts and the current target pressed into the wall in front of him.

He searches Izuku’s freckled face, glaring harshly past the distorted green irises, the sweat beading his skin, the bobbing of his Adam’s apple as he splutters and waves his arms around him like a flustered rabbit.

Izuku, however, does not crack.

He doesn't admit to being a spy. He doesn't splutter out any pathetic secret and grovel and beg to kiss Katsuki's feet for his mercy.

Instead, Katsuki sees nothing but determination swim through his terrified features, pulsing with one too many secrets he's kept hidden somewhere in his mind's eye, far from where he can reach.

He'd assumed at the dinner table that he saw a darkness in those eyes, a lingering doubt that convinced him of another fool attempting to breach the Bakugou household and threaten his mother. Threaten *him*.

"Hit me, then," Izuku whispers. "Hit me, if it proves to you that I don't have a Quirk. I don't. I came here, unarmed, and I know that if you hit me you'll kill me. I would never put my mom in danger like that, if—um, if what you're saying would theoretically be true. I don't even know what's so apparently special about the B-Bakugous. I don't know—I swear I don't. I don't know what's wrong with me to even be curious about who you people are, or why my mom is so attached to yours. But, something's there, and if I was a spy, none of those connections would make sense. You have to believe me."

Despite the way he trembles—his fists roughly clenched at his sides, a noticeable gulp slipping down his throat—he delivers this statement with electric stability. Katsuki stifles his own hands, willing the fires to remain still and maintaining a slight level of control, a sneer twisting the corner of his mouth.

He watches as Izuku dips his head, inhales shakily, and lifts his gaze once more to stare straight into his eyes.

And it infuriates him in how annoyingly stubborn this curly-haired nerd is. How blatantly stupid he's acting, provoking a Bakugou with no knowledge of the possible repercussions.

Then, Katsuki concedes. He wills his Quirk to submission, glaring pointedly towards the shaking, smaller teen with a furrowed brow. Izuku is staring into the carpet, his lips drawn into a thin line. He doesn't say another word, allowing his glare to stare deep into Izuku's shaking body.

He slowly steps forward, grapples one of the other teen's shoulders and presses him further into the wall. He leans down, a slow, pleased smirk stretching the corners of his mouth.

From this angle, he can count the amount of freckles dappling Izuku's face, note the faint white scar lining the left side of his jaw as he instinctively turns his head. His vein pulses beneath him, and suddenly Katsuki resists straightening his shoulders and standing tall and proud, convincing the other that he is certainly weaker. That he has been bested.

His fingernails roughly dive into Izuku's shoulder.

The curly-haired boy grits his teeth, resisting a harsh groan from leaving him. Katsuki's eyes grow wide, wild, even, with uncertainty and, dare he think it, curiosity. He levels the other, smaller teen with narrowed eyes, his tongue clicking in observation. He leans closer, reveling

in the way the teen remains stiff and somehow standing despite the enormous pressure and pain he's delivering straight into his soon-to-be-aching shoulder muscles.

"I fucking guess that a dumbass *Isabori spy* wouldn't fuck me with his eyes, now would he?"

Katsuki mentally kicks himself—what the fuck is he doing? Why is he saying these things?

Though, Izuku says nothing in return, his blush returning to his features and darkening his dusted cheeks a few shades darker. The redness striping his cheekbones and neck ripple with fire that Katsuki has not yet experienced from a person he's confronted, not even those equally flustered idiots he'd confronted in Isabori.

"I'm *not* a spy," Izuku whispers.

He keeps his head turned away, though he swallows. He's nervous, Katsuki can see, judging squarely by his fidgeting and the slick choke in his words. He's desperately holding on, yet with Katsuki this close and this easily positioned to rip the kid's shoulder out of its socket, he knows he has the advantage. Yet, the other boy is resisting.

Katsuki snorts and releases him. Izuku stumbles and grips his pained ligament, a clear strain in his frown as he admonishes Katsuki with irritation and hesitation written on his features. Katsuki's lazy smirk remains as he takes a few steps backward, baring his teeth and holding back a satisfied laugh at how ridiculously cornered the other teen looks.

"Fucking prove it, then. Tomorrow. Before midnight. You're coming with me to those fucking Isabori highwaymen fuckers and proving that you're not a threat to the Bakugous." Katsuki's eyes glisten, as if he's playing a game, and he revels in the uncertainty painting Izuku's startled face. "If you don't show up, I'll fucking find you. Understand, shitty *Deku*?"

Izuku opens his mouth to reply, though Katsuki has already decided he doesn't want to hear the other speak anymore. He growls and brings his fist up to the other's face, watching as Izuku's eyes cross to focus on the embers flicking around Katsuki's raised fist.

"I'll be there, Kacchan."

Izuku's voice has returned to its statuesque state. Katsuki blinks and retracts his fist, tilting his head in slight wonder as he observes the scrawny teen in front of him. He's not used to this behavior, not at all. But, for some reason, he can't resist the amusement quirking his lips and allowing one eyebrow to raise.

Izuku shifts uncomfortably beneath his stare.

Good. He then sharpens his features into a glare. "Before midnight, Deku. Don't be fucking late."

Izuku seems to ponder this, nibbling on his bottom lip, before he nods. His eyes are bright and smoldering and *alive*. Katsuki has never seen anything like it, and he's not sure how to process the way this other teen can so easily stare straight into him, as if uncovering his skeleton and inspecting each individual bone.

“I won’t,” says Izuku.

For some reason he can’t explain, Katsuki believes him.

Chapter End Notes

First off, THANK YOU SO MUCH to everyone who read/commented/left kudos, etc. Every kind word just meant the absolute world. I'm updating this fic two days earlier because I can and because it's BakuDeku week and I'm going to be mainly focusing on this story, so I won't have time to write other entries. So, technically, this is kind of cheating, but whatever. I don't really care since it's still BakuDeku and it's a lot of work writing these chapters. :P

Feel free to leave a comment below and, once again, THANK YOU. To each and every one of you! I'm so glad that people are enjoying this so far. I'm just floored at every comment and it just warms the soul, really.

Oblivion

Chapter Summary

> “Have you considered asking for help?”
>
> Izuku turns to Todoroki, eyes slightly widened. “From?”
>
> Todoroki pauses. “From… outside sources.”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Friday. 7:05 AM.

Izuku rubs sleep from his eyes, stifling a yawn as he leans onto the railings. His left arm hangs weakly from grasping onto the supportive strands overhead, fingers loose and dangling like emptied gloves. His phone buzzes in his pocket, though he refrains from checking anything just yet.

He’d been awake all night, slaving over paper drafts and attempting to forcefully scrub away his worries from his encounter with Katsuki Bakugou.

Around him, smoke travels in steady waves, directly puffed from the homeless man slinking in the corner and fixing a sharp glare on him every few minutes. A woman with leather shoes and a chain-strap purse blows a bubblegum wad and pops it between her teeth. Two children, a boy and a girl, playfully nudge one another and laugh with their touchscreen devices. An older couple sit in the very back of the cart, one man sipping on his takeout coffee and flipping through a newspaper.

Izuku squints and spots one of the older headlines on an issue of the *Daily Inkling*; it wasn’t long ago when he had his own article featured on the fourth page.

His right hand dives further into his pocket, seeking the exercise ball he’d forgotten at his apartment before leaving with his mother to have dinner with the Bakugous. He squeezes the device, releasing a shaky breath. He’d hardly been able to sleep from the impending promise he’d sworn out into the open, beneath the murderous, hypnotic glare of the teenager with the explosion Quirk.

The train moves to a subtle stop, railings screeching in the quiet morning. Izuku yawns once more, a smile drifting across his lips. He glances towards the opposite windows across the length of the train.

Sunlight shifts and bleeds through the glass, warm and inviting. Clouds swirl and hang like cloth in the distance, dusted orange and pink across the tops of buildings and townhouses.

The doors slide open and shut in seconds.

Before long, the train is moving again. Izuku sinks into the quiet, humming in bliss.

“Good morning, Midoriya.”

Izuku releases a rather unmanly help and reflexively releases the ceiling strap. He loses his balance, grasping the iron bar and huffing. He turns, and immediately lets his eyes widen in pleasant surprise at recognizing the newcomer.

“T-Todoroki! I didn’t know you took the train.”

Shouto Todoroki smiles, soft and barely there, though Izuku detects it with ease.

The fellow teenager is a few inches taller than Izuku, composed and strong and always striding through Yuuei High School’s hallways with an air of silent power and confidence that few dared to oppose. He’s handsome down to the monochromatic eyes, tinted like reflective glass from the sunlight, and the red and white colors splitting his hair down the middle.

“I don’t, usually. Thought I sometimes mix up my routine for a change.”

Izuku tilts his head. “Huh. You don’t strike me as the type.”

He grins crookedly at the slightest glimmer of amusement passing through Todoroki’s eyes, though it vanishes.

The other teen balances his backpack on one shoulder, gesturing with a flick of his head towards the seats a few yards away.

“Are you going to sit?”

Izuku shrugs. “I mean, I usually don’t, in case other passengers need it. Usually the train doesn’t take too long to get to the school. I mean, it’s not like I think I’m a martyr or anything, but…” he trails off, skin flushing at the blank, knowing look Todoroki is sending him. Izuku hesitates and scratches his cheek, gulping. “Sorry. I know I do that too much. You’ve probably heard of that—I mean, not that I think a lot of people talk about me. Just, you’re so popular and I know that you probably hear about the paper and… I’m going to stop talking now.”

Todoroki spares him with a nod. His mouth curls in one corner.

“You’re thoughtful.”

Izuku blinks. “Huh?”

“You’re thoughtful. Though, I suppose *kind* would be a better descriptor.” Todoroki shrugs. “You’re considering the passengers before they even step on the train, in trade for your own comfort. I would find that something worth discussing, or acknowledging, at least over your mumbling habit.”

He reaches into his pocket and pulls out his cell phone, sleek and black and expensive.

Izuku opens his mouth, then closes it, unsure of how to respond to the other’s kind words, but the embarrassment lingers and hums beneath his skin.

“Um, thank you."

That was good enough, right?

“No need. I’m just stating facts.” Todoroki brushes this off with a small wave. “But really, it takes the train thirty minutes to get to the high school from here. Let’s sit.”

Izuku considers fighting against this, but nods anyway. He lets go of the iron support beam and follows Todoroki to the cushioned seats. He inspects the chair with a dusting of his fingers before sitting down, setting his backpack down between his legs.

He glimpses over Todoroki’s profile, the other teen’s back flat against the windows, eyes squarely focused on his phone as he browses through dozens of messages popping up on the screen.

“So, what made you want to take the train?” Izuku asks.

Todoroki shuts off his phone and slides it back into his pocket.

“Curiosity.”

Izuku grins slightly at this. “Yeah. I can understand that. I like looking out the windows and seeing the sun rise in the mornings. Early jogs right sunrise are nice, too. You know, if you’re able to catch the train and grab a good spot before someone else does. Plus, it’s always quiet in the mornings since not a lot of people ride the train.”

Todoroki turns, scrutinizing him.

Izuku stares ahead at the doors to the cart, leaning over and placing his elbows on his knees, chin in his hands. His brow furrows in deep thought, a soft smile overtaking his lips.

“It’s nice, having almost an hour of total quiet before school. It’s like the world is on pause. Just for a little while.”

Todoroki softens beside him. The teen searches, glaring into their surroundings and picking up on details that Izuku surely wouldn’t have noticed even after taking this train every single morning and night for at least two years. He calmly lopes one leg over the other, interweaving his fingers.

“What district are you from, Midoriya?”

Izuku blinks and leans up, raising an eyebrow to Todoroki. He sighs. “Isabori.”

Todoroki’s frown does not go unnoticed.

“Isabori?” He echoes.

Izuku hesitantly nods. “Yes. And, I know, it’s not the ideal place to live, but it’s all I have access to. My mom is trying her best to support us and I am too. We just can’t afford it right now, but I’m planning on continuing to save up so that she doesn’t have to pay for college. I want to get a great job and support her for the rest of her life so that she can stop worrying about it.”

Todoroki’s brow furrows. “That’s… noble, of you. But, that district is dangerous.”

“I’ve handled it so far,” Izuku mutters. “It just takes some practice.”

“That is impressive, that you’ve been able to handle living there. I’m from Sommartyn, myself.” Todoroki tilts his head, rubbing his chin with his other hand. “It’s rare for... kids, from Isabori to be able to afford to attend Yuuei, let alone any educational facility in general.” He pauses, as if considering other possible answers, though Izuku finds it surprising that the other teen is so intent on asking these questions. “Have you considered asking for help?”

Izuku turns to Todoroki, eyes slightly widened. “From?”

Todoroki pauses. “From… outside sources.”

Izuku swallows. He knows what the other is referring to.

The fact that the pristine honor roll student is even talking to him about this rattles his mind, but rather than question the validity behind Todoroki’s statement, Izuku feels a familiar sense of unwelcome hostility boil in his chest. He suppresses the reaction and lets out a sigh.

“I’m not interested in putting my mom in more danger than she already is.”

“Of course not,” says Todoroki, quickly. “I’m simply making a suggestion. I'm impressed that you’re able to handle the both of you so well in Isabori, given certain restrictions.” He pauses, as if considering his words and the blank look Izuku is sending him. “You seem affronted.”

Izuku rolls his eyes. “You know, just because I’m Quirkless doesn’t mean I’m helpless.”

Todoroki stiffens. “Midoriya, that’s… that’s not what I meant. I apologize for insinuating that.” He hesitates, and Izuku blinks at how flustered the other teen suddenly appears.

It was almost mythical. Being able to witness Shouto Todoroki stumble over his own words is strange to witness.

Izuku tilts his head. He grins. “You’re fine, Todoroki. No harm done.”

Todoroki turns to him, suddenly pausing in his abrupt apologies. His shoulders are slumped, eyes searching.

“Say, Todoroki,” says Izuku, rummaging through his pockets to pull out his phone. “Have you heard of the Bakugous?”

A poignant silence settles after his question. Blinking at noticing this, Izuku turns and fixates a confused stare onto Todoroki, who’s gone quite still and is eyeing him as if he’s grown an extra limb.

Suddenly flustered, Izuku pockets his phone once more, eyes darting back and forth between the doors to the train and Todoroki’s wary expression.

“What’s wrong?” he whispers, as if exchanging a secret.

Todoroki’s brow furrows. “Midoriya, how do you know them?”

Izuku stiffens at the change in tone.

Something dark and hesitant flashes in Todoroki’s eyes, forming a sharp crinkle in his brow.

Izuku has never seen the normally calm and collected student react like this, not as if he’s been cornered and asked a particularly probing question.

“I just… do.” Izuku swallows.

He’s not sure what would happen if Katsuki were to find out he’d told someone else he knew who they were. He already thought it was completely ridiculous that the temperamental teen thought he was a spy of any kind, especially for the hustlers stationed in Isabori, tracking the clock until the hours were perfectly timed, stopping pedestrians with batons and guns. They were not afraid to smirk at their own outrageous behavior and demand an extra twenty dollars or more if they were friskier than usual, though Izuku’s dealing with them had earned him some sort of radar in Isabori.

He and his mother were already targeted, and it never wavered once he left the front door of his apartment to sprint to the train.

“Midoriya.”

Izuku blinks, rubbing his chin. He flushes at the inquisitive glare Todoroki is wearing on his face like a contorted mask. He looks pensive, as if a hundred jumbled thoughts are slowly coming together in an organized chorus line.

Perhaps he shouldn’t have said anything—the least he would want to do is make Todoroki suspicious. What if he started to assume that he was a spy, working for the Bakugous, maybe?

“You haven’t heard of them before?” Todoroki asks, with underlying caution.

Izuku shakes his head. “No. I… I hadn’t. One night on the train I met Katsuki Bakugou, but one thing led to another and it turns out my mom is actually good friends with his mom. From, I mean, years ago, since they were both in college and everything, but I’m not sure what that has to do with anything…” he trails off, and instantly his skin flushes. “Oh, um, you weren’t supposed to hear any of that.”

He dips his head and buries his face into his hands, groaning in misery.

Todoroki’s lips twitch. He straightens his posture and rests one hand on Izuku’s shoulder.

On reflex, the teen stiffens, peeking out between his fingers.

“I won’t tell anyone. And, you seem to have good judgment.”

He withdraws his hand.

Izuku studies him quietly, wondering, in the back of his mind, if he should still consider asking Todoroki about an interview for the school paper. Maybe another time, another place, when they’re both not lodged in the middle of this awkward, accidental topic.

Still, Izuku’s fingers twitch in the urge to whip out his notebooks and scribble down memorable phrases and details of Todoroki’s Quirk and features to add to potential profile articles later.

You’re so weird, Izuku, he thinks, rubbing his temples.

“Do you know who they are, Todoroki?” Izuku asks.

Todoroki refrains from turning to even acknowledge the curious look Izuku is giving him.

“I do.” He shrugs. “Many people from Sommartyn do. We, um," he clears his throat, "live in the same neighborhood.”

“Ah, right, that would make sense.” Izuku nods. “I mean, I was over at their place last night having dinner with them, since my mom is, like I said, really good friends with Mrs. Bakugou—”

“*What*?”

Izuku pauses and blinks at the wide-eyed student beside him.

“What’s wrong, Todoroki? You look kind of sick.”

Izuku’s brow furrows. He hesitates, yet tenderly reaches over and presses the back of his hand to the other teen’s forehead. As if blinking out of a trance, Todoroki quickly takes Izuku’s hand and pushes it away, his Adam’s apple bobbing in a conflicted series of motions.

“You were at their *house*? Midoriya, that’s—do you even know who they are, technically?”

Izuku sighs, exasperated. “I would know if someone told me. I mean, I was accused of being a spy at one point. Ah, not by Mrs. Bakugou, though. I think she’s already pretty attached to me. Her son, though, hates me. I can’t say I’m too fond of him either, but he immediately accused me of being a spy.” He shrugs, and then, clearing his throat, he speaks in his best impression of what Katsuki Bakugou: “Deku, you better be telling me the bleeping truth! Or else, I’ll bleep you sideways! Then who’ll go look for your body? No one, ‘cause no one bleeping gives a bleep. Oh, usually followed by explosions because that’s his Quirk, I guess, which is pretty amazing, but yeah. Expletives and explosions. That’s the best way to describe him.”

Todoroki stares at Izuku with utter bafflement coloring his tan features. His lips are drawn into a thin line.

“You’re talking about Katsuki Bakugou, then.”

Izuku straightens at this and nods, smiling. “Yeah! Him. I didn’t know you two knew each other.”

Todoroki rolls his eyes. “He’s a horrid human being.” He pauses, and reaches into his pocket to pull out his cell phone. “Do you have my number?”

Izuku frowns. “Eh? I don’t—”

“Here.”

Todoroki takes Izuku’s hand and places his phone in the other’s palm. Izuku blushes slightly at the close contact, unsure of how he feels about the other’s soft skin tracing beneath his palm and containing his own hand in the other as if this type of contact was never permitted until now.

Izuku hardly allows himself to invade anyone’s personal space so easily, and with a person as privileged and respected as Todoroki suddenly becoming so open with a simple, kind gesture, Izuku’s words die in his throat.

“Put your number in. We should talk more.”

Izuku blinks, dumbfounded. “Um.”

Todoroki looks away from him. Izuku almost swears he notices a string of fresh pink dash across Todoroki’s cheeks, though he isn’t able to question it as he directs his attention to the phone in his palm. Without another word, he opens the device and calmly inputs his contact information.

“We should meet outside of school. About this.”

Izuku scratches the back of his head. He smiles brightly and places the phone back in Todoroki’s hand, a slight chuckle leaving his lips.

“Sure! I don’t have a lot of time, but I’m always working in the office on the paper after school and sometimes even before school. We could talk in there, if you want.” Izuku then

hums in thought, tapping his chin. “Then again, we could always talk on the train. This is the first time I’ve even met someone else from our school while taking it."

Todoroki considers this. “I will, then.” He sighs. “Midoriya, you shouldn’t associate yourself with the Bakugous. If they reach out to you again, you should turn them down. It would be in your best interest to not be involved with them.”

Izuku’s lips tighten at this. *A bit late for that.*

He decides that it wouldn’t be the greatest argument to admit that he’d given Katsuki Bakugou a minor concussion from their brief, unpleasant encounter on this very train.

“Thanks for being concerned, Todoroki.” Izuku smiles, catching the other’s glance and smiling in return.

Todoroki, to lack of Izuku’s knowledge, flusters discretely beneath the attentive stare.

“It means a lot. I wouldn’t mind being better friends.”

Needless to say, once they step off the tram, Izuku continues elaborating his ideas for his future articles for the paper while Todoroki patiently listens, unaware of just how close the other teen is to spontaneously combusting.

“Izuku! Hey, Izuku!”

Izuku grumbles, his glare burrowing into the several crossed-out phrases he’s already tested on the notebook spread out in front of him.

His textbooks remain stacked in a neat pile next to his pencils, the borders facing the windows and half-shut blinds. The suppressed noise of chalk running on blackboard screeches in the front of the classroom, drawing several curious stares towards Izuku’s mumbling voice as it opposes Mr. Aizawa’s droning, exasperated lecture.

“Izuku!”

Izuku’s pencil tip snaps under the growing pressure. He flexes his hand, wincing at the strain in his palm.

He turns, twisting around in his seat and scanning the rows of students behind him. Several of them blink at his attention, yet one in particular—Denki Kaminari, an athletic puppyish teen with jagged blond hair and striking eyes— eagerly waves towards him, gesturing with his other hand to the boy in front of him. Flashing a sharp-toothed, albeit friendly, smile, Eijirou Kirishima delivers a humble wave from his own desk.

Izuku sheepishly returns the gesture, unsure of the sudden growth in attention. He watches as Kaminari and Kirishima exchange hushed words under their breath, yet Izuku is too far away to distinguish what they're actually saying. Izuku turns back in his seat and turns to his notes, grimacing at the distracted doodles lining the margins and the lack of focus and structure shown on his work. Normally his notes were pristine, some with helpful color-coded margins if need be, but in this moment, they may as well have been pulled apart and rehashed with Crayola marker and glue.

Once the bell rings, Izuku quickly jogs up to Kirishima and Kaminari, both students standing taller than him with their hands calmly resting in their pockets. His hands break out into sweat just from reflex—associating with anyone outside of his fellow newspaper writers makes him nervous and tug at his collar. He wishes he could pull out his stress ball without drawing too much attention to his habits.

"Hi, Kaminari! Kirishima," he says with a broad smile.

"Hey! Midoriya!" Kirishima grins, almost blindingly. "We were just checking on something with you, bro. Uraraka mentioned that we're heading to the movies tomorrow, right? You still coming?"

Izuku blinks. *That's what all of that was about?*

"Um. Yeah. I think so."

He tugs at his sleeve.

He'd completely forgotten about that, and he would rather pretend that he remembered all along rather than admit to Uraraka that this little detail slipped from his mind.

He'd been incredibly focused on what was going to occur tonight, minutes after he would step off the train and rendezvous with an ash-blond teen in the dark of the night in quite possibly the most dangerous district in their city limits.

"Cool!" Kirishima suddenly sounds strained, as if he's forcing the words past his teeth. Izuku's brow furrows at this. The red-haired student's eyes are darting back and forth, sweeping through the hallways and then slowly turning back to land on Izuku. "So, Todoroki mentioned something about you wanting to join us at the gym later? We usually head to the one in Sommartyn after school, since it's so close."

Izuku blinks. "Huh?"

His mind races back to his conversation with Todoroki on the train, glimpsing through their exchanged sentences as if pulling out flash cards from his brain. He pouts, nibbling on his bottom lip as he rocks back and forth in the same place.

"I don't… think so? We never talked about it. And—and I mean, it's not like we talk a lot! I talked to him this morning on the train. Oh, I guess you really don't care about that. Um, never mind, then. I didn't say anything. Other than that... I don't remember mentioning that. Not like I wouldn't want to!"

Kaminari grins and leans forward, his eyes sparkling with mischief. “Don’t worry, Midoriya. We get what the problem is. We’ll just show you around afterwards and stuff. Plus, it’s a great place to train. You know, self-defense classes."

Izuku resists the urge to snort.

Whatever Todoroki was planning, he wasn’t sure if he could quite agree with the other’s perception of him.

“I’m not weak, you guys.” Izuku chuckles, shaking his head with a somber smile. “I mean, I lift sometimes. I run a lot. I’m in good shape. I… guess there’s no harm with extra training, but I don’t really have time with the paper and taking the train every day. I don’t even get back to my apartment until after ten.”

Kirishima’s eyes widen, his lips pressed together in a quick whistle. “Damn, Midoriya! That’s so manly! Working hard, like, all the time! That’s crazy, bro.”

Izuku flushes. “Ah. Um. I guess? Thanks, Kirishima.” He laughs awkwardly and begins to turn on his heel. “I… think I should be going, now—”

His phone buzzes in his pocket. Blinking, Izuku reaches into his uniform and pulls out the device, squinting at the new bubble popping up on the touchscreen glass. Instantly, his chest stills with unsureness, like icicles trudging through oil and sludge.

[*From:* ***K. Bakugou***]

- *We need to talk, fucker! You better have your damn phone! 5 fuckin minutes!*

Of course.

Izuku grumbles and drags one hand down his face. He turns and bows apologetically to both Kirishima and Kaminari, begrudgingly making his way down the hallway and bypassing the confused glances burrowing into his back from his classmates.

He strides on autopilot, one hand swinging with his phone while the other grips tighter on his backpack strap. He turns the corner, opening the door to the restroom and quickly making his way across the tiles to the opposite side of the room. He briefly scopes beneath the stalls and sighs in relief at the lack of company.

Swallowing, Izuku raises his phone, stares at the screen, and waits.

The few minutes that tick by remind Izuku just how ridiculous this entire situation is.

He can’t believe he even agreed to go through with this, to even abide by his mother’s wishes and reunite with a mysterious half-Russian woman who clearly had a subdued violent streak and a strangely incognito line of work. His mother hadn’t even said a word to him about

Mitsuki once they stepped back into their apartment, though he didn't even bother asking her questions.

He was too perplexed by Katsuki's incessant screaming and demanding that Izuku give him his phone number.

"It's for fucking safety reasons, fuckface. Don't get any weird ideas."

Izuku rolls his eyes at the memory. He's truly never encountered someone just as insane and volatile as Mitsuki Bakugou's son.

He nearly drops his phone when the screen lights up, an alarm signal ringtone blasting through the restroom.

Biting his tongue, Izuku unlocks the screen and calmly brings the device up to his ear.

"Hello—"

"About fucking time, shitty Deku!"

Izuku rolls his eyes. "Good afternoon, Kacchan."

Also, you're the one calling me.

"Let's just fucking tal—wait, what the fuck? Why are you still calling me that?"

Izuku snorts and turns, pressing his back to the restroom wall. The cool tiles running behind his uniform are chilling and uncomfortable through the material, but it's a slightly welcome distraction given who he's talking to on the other side of the line.

"Well, you call me *fuckface* and *Deku* every five seconds. *Kacchan* is a compliment by comparison." Izuku bites his cheek to hold back a laugh as he hears a stream of loud curses break out. He brings the phone back to his ear, a small, barely noticeable smile tracing his lips. "I have class soon. Did you hit your head again?"

He guesses he deserves the extreme flurry of colorful insults hurled towards him through the speaker. He holds the phone away from him, mildly chuckling at the energy that the other teen carries so easily.

"Okay, I deserved that." Izuku purses his lips. "But, really, I can't miss class. Is there a reason you're calling me? Pretty sure you made it clear to never contact you—"

"Yeah I fucking know, idiot! Shut the fuck up! And where are you, anyway, huh?"

Izuku blinks. "… School?" *Did he not just hear me?*

"Fucking moron. Jesus. Obviously you're at school, Deku! I'm waiting fucking outside this stupid-ass, ugly shit building. This fucking Yuuei? Christ, it's a fucking dump."

Izuku pales. He nearly drops his phone for the second time in less than ten minutes, sweat slicking his palms in nervous clamors.

Bristling, Izuku desperately fumbles over his words, running one hand through his messy curls.

“W-What? You’re *here*? Why? I thought we were meeting tonight—”

“Yeah I changed my fucking mind. You wouldn’t last two fucking seconds off that train before getting your tongue ripped out, numbskull. Isabori hustlers don’t fuck around! Plus you’re scrawny as hell and I don’t need blood being drawn back to my name.”

Izuku struggles to follow the conversation.

Katsuki is speaking with surprising eloquence, despite how ridiculous he sounds with this brand new claims, as if this was common knowledge between the two of them. Izuku had assumed he would be riding the train late after his project with the newspaper team, like his schedule would normally allow, and he would simply rendezvous to whatever location Katsuki would provide him through text message.

“Wait…” Izuku refrains from losing himself in a stream of muttering possibilities, hoping that his voice remains quiet enough that no one walking by the bathroom doors outside would be able to hear him struggle to not panic. “Are you—you’re here. You’re actually here. Right now. Kacchan, I can’t come and see you! I have class, and—”

“What, too chicken to ditch class? You’re a fucking nerd. Sure you have strategies to make that up, asshole. You wanted to prove this to me, didn’t ya?”

Izuku growls, his hand balling into a sharp, clenched fist. He can practically envision the snarky, devilish grin crossing that mean-spirited teen’s handsome face. It’s even more irritating at just how fitting the expression looks with sharpened teeth and fiery brimstone eyes.

“What’s the point of coming early?”

“The fuck? So your ass doesn’t wind up fucking dead, asshole!”

Izuku pauses at this. He reels back, wondering just how many questions Katsuki’s mother (or father, for that matter) would have had to force onto their son before he would give them an answer that they would agree to. Perhaps Mitsuki talked to Katsuki about this? Did his parents even know about the questionable predicament and wager Katsuki forced into Izuku’s hands?

“Wait, but they only patrol at night, anyway. I don’t—”

“We’re not going to just any fucking random alley, stupid Deku. I have connections. And if you’re a fucking spy you’re a fucking terrible actor. I’ll find out the truth soon enough. Now come the fuck out of this ugly ass building! You can’t miss me. Unless you’re blind. Stupid.”

And with that, Katsuki hangs up.

Izuku stares at his phone, speechless.

Katsuki pockets his phone, a deep, annoyed snarl slipping through clenched teeth.

He's leaning against the stairwell leading up to the unimpressive brick building before him. The tinted windows are lined with vines, spreading through cracked, weathered stone and slithering through the grass in messy tendrils.

He inhales, grumbling at the strange, bitter tinge of cigarette smoke and paste wafting through his nostrils.

His hip slightly pops as he reels back and squints towards the sun. The breeze ruffles the collar of his shirt, the top two buttons undone and the material itself a pale blue. His sneakers and jeans are a bit uncomfortable compared to what he usually wears, though his fresh appearance is mostly owed to his decision to exercise in the morning, shower, finish his homework, and bolt out the door and catch the bus to this place before his mother bats an eyelash.

His fingers pierce the cloth of his pants and dive into the fabric. Stubbed nails brush and struggle to grip onto anything, bitten down to the cuticle from one too many nights fussing over his habits. Over his life. Over his inability to make a decision regarding the strange, freckled teenager who pushed him off the train and gave him a barely harmful concussion.

The other kid was meek, trembling under his grip the previous night like a startled mouse, but the determination that equaled his cowardice in immeasurable waves awoke something within Katsuki.

He wasn’t sure what to name it, not with the sick satisfaction of being regarded as the superior in that confrontation, as if proving to his demure acquaintance that he belonged in the higher position. The stronger point in a confrontation that would inevitably lead to the other’s demise.

He hates how easy he’s already making this him.

Quirkless.

He holds back a snort, remembering just how easily the freckled idiot had muttered these words, as if it physically pained him to admit it but he would do so in a heartbeat if it led to his mother’s protection.

It was clear to Katsuki the moment he drew his flaming fist back that Izuku Midoriya was willing to sacrifice every piece of him if it meant that his mother would leave the situation

unscathed.

Katsuki went to bed with the slightest—and largest—amount of guilt he'd felt in years.

He was forced to ponder over the subtle, sprouting sensation in his stomach, glaring hotly into his cereal bowl while his mother danced and frolicked around the kitchen in glee that her college friend was just as wonderful as she remembered.

Or something like that.

Katsuki wasn't exactly paying attention.

"Kacchan!"

Katsuki freezes.

He turns, and instinctively narrows his eyes at the familiar, doe-eyed teenager sprinting towards him, his backpack nearly falling off his tiny shoulders. Katsuki's brow furrows in quick observation, noting the other teen's form without his jacket on. His shirt is long-sleeved and collared, and his red tie is horribly done—so misshapen that Katsuki fights the urge to straighten it himself.

Izuku pants as he makes his way up to him, straightening his shoulders with an exaggerated stretch.

Katsuki holds back an impatient growl as the other boy stares at him with disbelief and annoyance brimming in those dark green depths. He's still significantly shorter than Katsuki, though it's interesting seeing him without any extra layer over his shoulders. He's clearly toned, like a seasoned cross-country runner, though he's naturally small and thin.

His curls have this irritating, distracting way of reflecting the sun's rays. The gentle light dances across Izuku's lightly flushed cheeks, freckles popping.

Katsuki breaks out of his concentration at realizing the other boy's opening his annoying mouth and talking to him. Ah, right, he had screamed at him over the phone to meet him outside his school.

"—acchan? Kacchan? Are you listening? What is this all about? Why are you here? Is this even worth me missing class? Have you ever even heard of a *pop exam*? They have those—"

Katsuki slaps a hand over Izuku's mouth. His temper is already nearing its limit.

Something wet slaps his palm, and Katsuki reels back his hand with a gaping, disgusted expression.

Izuku's smile is far too smug.

"If you want me to pay attention, just tell me. I'll lick your hand if you keep doing that."

Katsuki snarls. "Listen here, you little fucker! You took forever to get here."

"*What*? I was just sprinting away from my confused teachers and pretending that I was contracting some horrible disease! Now they all think I'm bursting into flames, and they already know it would have nothing to do with Quirk side effects." Izuku releases a defeated sigh, turning to address the front doors to the school building. "And it's not a dump."

Katsuki blinks. "What?"

"You called it a dump. You know. My school." Izuku shrugs, unimpressed. "It's not. There are plenty of worse buildings."

The blond twitches and quickly dismisses the reaction of setting this bastard's clothes on fire and laughing at the expression he would make afterwards.

No, no, he needs to keep his control in check, and think back to how he's supposed to handle more serious situations like this. If he's going to prove any point, he needs to stay focused on the task at hand.

"That's not even close to being the fucking point." Katsuki snorts. "We're fucking leaving. Come on."

He starts walking down the sidewalk, nose held high and hands in his pockets.

Izuku scurries after him, his strides just a slight step behind. Katsuki inwardly grins at the height difference and slightly taller length to his legs in comparison to the other male.

Heh. I fucking win.

Izuku watches him at the corner of his eye, even as he steps beside him in silence.

The streets are bustling with traffic, sleek, older and newer brands of cars trudging and dashing across asphalt in streams of smoke and gasoline. Streetlights blink on and off, signaling for pedestrians as they laugh and gossip, absorbed in their own conversations. Their own little worlds.

Izuku drinks in his surroundings with careful patience, his fingers shifting around his backpack as he subconsciously counts and associates one image with one number at a time.

Katsuki picks up on these mannerisms with little trouble. He's not directly observing Izuku, but it would be impossible for him not to notice how quick and tempted the smaller teen is to constantly muttering.

His hands twitch every so often, as if itching for a pencil and some solid surface to write on. His eyes are distant and vastly intelligent at the same time, though Katsuki would never believe that this other teen could possibly match him in that category.

He knows the little fucker is smart, but not smart enough to research into his family name.

Izuku Midoriya is, as far as Katsuki is concerned, intriguing enough to satiate his boredom.

For now.

“Where are we going, exactly?” Izuku asks.

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Just follow me and don’t talk.”

Izuku puffs his cheeks out. The blond snorts at this, refraining from daring to glance over the clearly annoying expressions the other teen is displaying. His pouting lips and shining, frustrated eyes are not affecting him in the slightest. The strange bubbling in his chest and the reddening on his neck are only aiding in his frustrations, he’s sure.

“Are we going back to the train?”

Katsuki growls. “Why the fuck do you never shut up?”

“Um, because I have questions, and you’re not the boss of me?”

Katsuki blinks at this. He almost stops to an abrupt halt, wondering just how obvious it is how stiff his shoulders and back have become at this snappy declaration. He turns slightly, one eyebrow risen as he studies the perturbed, scrunched-up expression donned on Izuku’s face.

“I don’t want to be your enemy, Kacchan.” Izuku’s frown deepens at this, his gaze sharply grazing into the sidewalk beneath their mismatched sneakers. “Your mom is my mom’s best friend. We’ll be seeing a lot of each other. And, I want you to trust me, because for some weird reason I already trust you.” He sighs. “I don’t know if it’s because of your mom or not, but that must be part of it. If this is still about the train—”

“Shut up, Deku,” growls Katsuki.

He hesitates, struggling to find the correct words. He’s not sure what to say to that, what to mention in response to a teen he can’t decide between constantly loathing and finding an inkling of some strange form of respect.

“I fucking have a feeling you’ll both be at our place more. The old hag wouldn’t shut up about it. I don’t want a fucking spy under my goddamn roof if it’s gonna put the old hag or the old man in danger. I don’t know who the fuck you are, but if you’re working for someone, this is the only way to find out.”

Izuku considers his words for only a few moments. “Do you *really* think I’m a spy, Kacchan?”

Katsuki glares harshly into Izuku’s bewildered eyes. “At this point, I don’t think you’d hold a goddamn *candle* to those Isabori fuckers.” He snorts. “I have my own reasons for pushing this back from midnight, stupid Deku. You’ll just have to fucking trust me.”

Izuku processes this with a quiet, demure nod. He steadies his pace alongside Katsuki, though the foot-long distance between them is necessary to not set off Katsuki’s own temper. He’s not sure if his changed plans are going to work, not with Izuku already asking too many questions, but his own promises to his mother and the Bakugou name are already riding high and mighty on his shoulders—

“Fuck, don’t tell me! That fucking *Bakugou*?”

Katsuki’s eyes bolt wide. On instinct, he turns, and nearly smacks Izuku’s backpack in the teen’s face from how quickly he adjusts his position.

The knife strapped to his ankle feels heavier under his jeans, barely seen by its hilt through the dark gray fabric.

He glares, frigidly, towards the four newcomer teenagers casually addressing both he and Izuku from a considerable distance. On first glance, they hardly seem different from any high school student, with their almost uniform-like appearance, though Katsuki has known these same young men since he’d moved into Sommartyn with his mother years ago.

Izuku stiffens beside him, and his eyes are wide. Searching. Understanding.

He knows them?

Katsuki doesn’t have to demand any answers from Izuku to know that he's recognized at least one of the teens in the group sizing them up on this corner of the sidewalk.

It’s already made apparent to pedestrians eyeing them from across the street that a scuffle may take place, though the hours would not call for any patrolmen to act out.

“Fuck off, bastards. It’s not even close to a patrolling hour.”

The teen who’d spoken earlier steps forward. He’s roughly the same height as Katsuki, black shirt tight and constricted to his chest and printed with an image of a white bird on the hem. His sneer is stretched wide across his mouth, eyes intelligent and brown and curious. His hair is roughly spiked, tinged dark brown and struck through with rough blond streaks. The jacket he wears bears the same cut and style as the other teens beside him, the leather material simple and pliant, all the way to the cuffs and the obvious trademark ribbons and bracelets clamped around their wrists.

“Ah, Bakugou, you’re not supposed to be out and about this early, either. Me and my boys, we’re just scouting around. Checking out the competition. Not like that high school down the street ever offers anything interesting.” The teen smirks and shrugs. “Don’t worry, we’re not looking for a thrashing. But that voicemail you left me last night was a bit too interesting to pass up.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, barely suppressing the growing irritation in his gut. He can feel Izuku’s confused stare burrowing into his shoulder. He simply shrugs, mirroring the teen a few yards away from them, and sharply tilting his head to the side. He’s about to open his mouth when Izuku steps forward, his brow furrowed and that same bold look crossing his features and illuminating his green eyes.

It makes Katsuki sick to his stomach.

Anger boils, yet before he can chastise his reluctant companion, Izuku is already talking.

“You’re Nero Edmure, right? I've seen your picture before in the *Inkling.* You lead Illenova’s squadron.”

Katsuki blinks and stares at him.

The leading member of this apparent squadron snaps his head away from Katsuki and looks at Izuku, an amused smile crossing his lips.

He switches his gaze from Katsuki to Izuku, curiosity glimmering dark and heavy in his wavering eyes.

“Who’s this, Bakugou? He apparently knows his shit.”

Katsuki snorts. Well, this already answers his previous demands of Izuku being a spy.

He wouldn’t be surprised if this strange nerd knew far too much about situations he couldn’t control, yet the look Izuku is sending towards Nero is one that he hasn’t seen yet.

“I’ve had to pay the toll here when leaving the school too late a couple times. I have a lot of late nights.”

Izuku’s smile is surprisingly sheepish, given the situation. Katsuki finds it mind-boggling that he’s speaking to this Nero character as if he’s been acquainted with him before.

“But, we don’t have to have trouble here, right? I think we’re heading to Isabori—”

“Oi, fucker! Don’t just spew out what we’re doing, fuckmunch!”

Izuku sighs. “But, I mean, these aren’t Isabori people.”

“I fucking—,” Katsuki snarls, harshly grabbing at his own face and dragging his fingers down. He sends an exaggerated glare towards Izuku and impatiently stomps up to where Nero stands with a smug smirk on his face. Katsuki huffs, and roughly shoves the other teen back, sparks sizzling in his palms. “Stay the fuck away, you poser. I don’t have business with you.”

Nero, however, is not paying attention to Katsuki.

He peers over the blond’s shoulder.

Katsuki steps back, bristling from head to toe. “Hey, fucker! Fucking look at me when I’m talking—”

“Say, Freckles, what’s your name?”

Katsuki growls. “He’s a scrawny little shitnerd. He’s not a part of this, motherfucker!”

And that is enough for him to hear Izuku’s sigh from behind him.

Nero gradually steps aside Katsuki, while he fumes with clenched fists and snarls at his back.

These are not permitted hours to use Quirks, and they would all be reprimanded by higher forces if he struck anyone with flaming fists, but the danger he's suddenly placed this idiot Midoriya character in strikes Katsuki like a gong and he knows, for a brief second, that he's made a stupid decision.

Nero strides up to Izuku, who blinks at the sudden close proximity and instinctively steps back. Katsuki ignores the snickering from the other goons and comes over to their side, glaring harshly into Nero's profile.

"It's rude to ignore a squad leader's request, don't you think, *Freckles*?" Nero almost purrs out the name, though it goes unnoticed to Izuku.

Katsuki's eyes widen. *What the fuck?*

Izuku at least has the audacity to seem a bit embarrassed at the sudden attention. "Um. Midoriya, Sir. Nero? Edmure? Mr. Edmure?" He ponders, groaning. "Eh. I'm not sure what to call you. I've heard of you before. From the other districts as well when I had the pay the tolls there too…"

Katsuki twitches. *How many fucking tolls has this kid paid?*

Nero's grin is crooked. His eyes are lit with curiosity and amusement, relishing in Katsuki's fuming offense and turning back to Izuku with something akin to acknowledgement and humor.

He reaches out with one hand, and tips Izuku's chin upwards to lock eyes with him.

"Well, you won't have to pay the toll here anymore, Freckles. Just say I gave them the word." Izuku flushes and steps back, staring with a slightly slack jaw.

"Um. Thanks? I think? I don't, really understand what's happening…"

Nero barks out into a laugh, flashing Katsuki a wide, beaming grin. "Heh, Bakugou, where the fuck did you find this kid? He's fucking cute as shit. I may just have to steal him away from you."

Katsuki holds back a roar and stomps into his space. "Back the fuck off! You're not getting this kid roped up in your shit! You fucking man-whore!"

Izuku, without warning, suddenly grabs Katsuki's shirt and proceeds to start dragging them away, muttering apologies to the squadron as they burst into guffaws of mocking laughter. Katsuki fumes and snarls, ripping himself out of Izuku's grip and staring frigidly into the other's surprised, yet clearly embarrassed, features.

The kid is red as a fucking tomato.

"Yeah, you better be fucking ashamed. That was godawful."

"How is any of this *my* fault?" Izuku sighs. "It doesn't matter. Just—where are we going, Kacchan? Are we heading anywhere at all? Or is this some weird form of kidnapping?"

Katsuki stops, blinking at his own overreaction from a few minutes prior. Nero Edmure was a nuisance, but never a true threat, at least when it came to the Bakugous. They had reached a mutual understanding ages ago, with hardly any conflict.

“That fucker is a trickster,” Katsuki growls, low and serious—and, as expected, not answering Izuku’s question. He jabs Izuku in the chest with one finger. “If he talks to you again, hightail it the fuck away from him. He probably eats kittens for breakfast and watches creepy child pageants or some shit.” He shakes his head, groaning at his own distracted nature. “And you’ll fucking see! Just follow me and shut the hell up.”

Izuku’s amused, quiet chuckles do not go unnoticed, though it takes every muscle in Katsuki’s body to stop himself from smacking him.

Chapter End Notes

Well, holy shit, this was way longer than it was supposed to be. 8,000 words, buckos! Hope you enjoyed. I've written so much this past week. Holy crap. I don't even believe it.

Well, it's here! Two days early and... yeah. Early. 'Cause, I finished work early and just wanted to see how far I'd go. Fun fact: most of the time I write these chapters in one or two days. This... I wrote all of this today. Don't know how, but, yeah.

Hope you enjoyed! Can't stop writing, yo. Working and writing and... sleep is important too? Maybe? Nah.

Thank you for the comments/kudos to the last chapter! Was absolutely wonderful. Thanks so much! :)

Until next time!

Galvanize

Chapter Summary

His muscles twitch and spring to life. A sudden fire soars through his chest, igniting his hesitations and casting them aside.

He braces himself, stands once more to his feet, and sprints.

He can buy Katsuki enough time. He can stop this from getting worse.

Chapter Notes

First off, thank you, each and every one of you, for commenting, leaving kudos, bookmarks, all of it. I read every single one, and while I won't have the time to reply to all of them unless a specific question is asked, I do appreciate and take to heart all of these. Thank you so, so much.

Alright! So, I'm going to establish some things before this chapter takes place. Questions will be answered in this chapter, but I would be lying if I said that there weren't going to be more questions that come up. Sorry. :P

NOW, let's talk about the districts.

There are four of them: Sommartyn, Isabori, Redmond and Illenova; they all comprise the fictional (HUGE) city of Augustana. The tolling system will be explained a little in this chapter, along with the purpose of the squadrons. I am withholding answering too many questions for the sake of the story's setting.

Please enjoy. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Friday. 1:15 PM.

“Fuck. Place stinks of leftover shitnerd.”

Izuku fiddles with his backpack straps, setting it down beside him and glaring at Katsuki, who stands on the opposite side of the tram with his hands firmly placed in his pockets.

Izuku's noticed various habits that the other teen performs, whether the other male is aware of it or not.

Katsuki is often either grabbing onto something with iron force or hiding his clenched fists in his pockets, lips always twisted into one of many scowls. Izuku has wondered, over the last few minutes, if those scowls could ever turn into the opposite with something positive as the cause and effect, rather than marveling at his own accomplishments or the gratuitous pleasures around him.

"The fuck are you staring at?" Katsuki growls.

Izuku blinks, his palms breaking out into sweat. He brushes them down on his pants, finding it odd that he's already been on the train twice. Todoroki's unexpected presence on the tram earlier that morning had startled him enough, though the mysterious aura the other teen exuded was far different from the toxicity that emits from Katsuki like a shower of embers.

"Hey, shitnerd! Pay fucking attention!"

Izuku lets out a dry huff, acknowledging Katsuki with a sheepish, yet strained, smile. "Sorry. Wasn't trying to stare at you."

He ponders, brow furrowing as he reaches into his pocket and removes a long, stamped strip of laminated paper, colored copper to mark the familiarity of his constant presence in Isabori.

Katsuki raises an eyebrow, eyes flicking to the ticket in Izuku's hand.

"Toll stamps?" he asks, more or less a statement than an actual question.

Izuku nods. "Yeah." He turns the ticket over in his hand. "It wasn't always this bad. Just… ever since heroes retired, it's been so crazy in Isabori."

He remembers helping his mother move furniture into the apartment complex, staring into her tired, worn eyes from hours of hulking chairs and tables up several flights of stairs. She'd insisted that things would be different, that living in the largest, yet most unstable district would be fine as long as they stayed behind closed doors during toll hours and took the tram as early as possible.

"How the fuck can you even afford all those fucking tolls...?"

Izuku purses his lips, pondering. He turns away from Katsuki's withering glare, fidgeting underneath the weight of a stare so powerful and intense that he has difficulty even accepting that the other person is even there.

He doesn't want to recall the memories of being shoved into brick walls, listening to his bones break for refusing to pay more than what was expected of a typical toll. Money being filtered from his pockets, harsh tugs on his hair, curses spit in his face. On his clothes. Warning him to stay loyal to the tolling hours.

The squadrons, at times, were ruthless. He'd come to know that Isabori's were most likely the worst.

The lengths he would go to in order to record the best story for his articles, the risks he would take and shove under his belt to prevent placing Uraraka or anyone else he loved in danger was what drove him to venture into the other neighboring districts in the most inopportune times.

“I… work a lot.” He bites his lip, swallowing.

Suddenly, he’s bearing the weight of reality on his shoulders, listening to his mother’s desperate pleas for him to stop placing himself in danger.

Her voice and his concerns ride in heavy waves and punch him in the gut.

Katsuki doesn’t even respond to him, turning his head as if pretending he hadn’t even heard Izuku’s response.

Izuku leans back to the windows, listening to the gentle hum of the train.

It’s strange, with this considerable distance between him and Katsuki Bakugou, knowing how the other teen is, at most, a year or two older than him, and carries himself with an air of responsibility that is far superior to his juvenile temper. The more Izuku observes the way the other moves, the way he talks, the more he questions the validity of what transpired between his mother and Mitsuki Bakugou.

He knows many secrets are dancing on this blond delinquent's sharp, insufferable tongue.

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki suddenly turns to him, nose scrunched up, though for once, he doesn’t immediately open his mouth to curse or complain. He regards Izuku with a barely noticeable flick of his chin, probing him from a distance.

Izuku hesitates, struggling to find the correct words. His fingers twitch and tremble on his uniform pants, seeking the comfort of a pencil or the spiral ridge of his notebook.

“Who… why is everyone so scared of you? The Bakugous.”

He tugs at his collar.

He’s hesitant to look over and see the expression Katsuki is probably wearing at this point, especially in reaction to such an accusatory question. Perhaps he should’ve chosen better words to use.

Still, he persists.

“I’m not sure how else to phrase it. But, everyone seems to unsure about you. When your last name comes up, it’s like it’s a threat... a *warning* of some kind.”

He waits for a few seconds, unsure if he should meet Katsuki's glare when he has too many questions tumbling in the corridors of his mind and begging for release.

"I just think I have a right to know, given how we're… both kind of stuck with each other, because of our mothers…"

To him, his reasoning sounds more idiotic than what he intended. Before he can take anything back, however, a loud, mocking laugh splits the quiet air.

Izuku blinks and watches as Katsuki's lips stretch out into a crooked, dangerous smirk, those sharp teeth poking from underneath his lips. Competitive fire lights his irises, like blood sizzling on hot coals.

"The fuck do you think, Deku?" Katsuki then leans forward, one elbow propped on his knee, his chin resting in the upturned palm of his hand. His smirk is still there, lingering like fog, matching the whimsical satisfaction dancing in his almost predatory gaze.

Katsuki Bakugou thrives off of adrenaline, off of the challenge, and Izuku knows that this teen enjoys toying with him.

It angers Izuku, but he knows he won't get any answers if he lets his personal emotions become the forefront of his reasoning.

"You have influence. Power." Izuku's taps his chin in thought. "You thought I was a spy. So, you have secrets to hide. A lot of people know who you are. But…" he trails off, and he doesn't want to bring up his speculations. He doesn't want to ask if the Bakugous are a criminal family, if they're involved in something far darker and deeper than he or his mother would ever think possible. It stills the blood rushing to his heart, and then, without warning, Izuku's eyes direct to the scars lining Katsuki's hands.

Katsuki notices.

Within moments, he is in front of Izuku, his stance so tall and glowering that Izuku instinctively presses his back further against the wall.

Izuku flushes, embarrassment and unsureness prickling up his spine and spreading through his bones. He glances up into the teen's cocky smirk and flashing eyes, one hand positioned on the glass window above Izuku's head while his other is in his pocket. If he leans down any closer—

"What's the matter, *Deku*?" Katsuki growls, breathy and quiet and electric.

Izuku stammers. "W-Why are you so—"

"Come on, Deku. Don't be a fucking coward. Tell me who you think the Bakugous are. If you guess correctly, maybe I'll tell you more." His taunting smirk remains.

Izuku glances away, but his presence is impossible to ignore.

“You’ve seen my Quirk. I could easily fuck you up if I wanted to. You’re lucky to not be on my bad side.”

Izuku releases a shaky sigh. He doesn’t want to let Katsuki know how intimidated he can be of him. He knows what the other is capable of, though he also knows this is a clue—the police were easily paid off when Katsuki had illegally used his Quirk in the hospital.

Mitsuki only slapped a few flashy bills in their hands and walked away with her volatile son, not once glancing back to assess the damages.

“You have influence.” Izuku sighs. “I don’t… have enough information to deduce anything.”

Katsuki pauses, his smirk vanishing as he searches Izuku’s face.

Then, he clicks his tongue.

“Figures.” He snorts and stands straight, leaning against the support beam beside Izuku’s bench.

He’s still close to him, Izuku notes, despite feigning disgust and growling through his teeth every ten seconds or so. It reminds him vaguely of a dog, or even an angry wolf. And yet, somehow less threatening, especially given the amusing image that pops into Izuku’s mind at the comparison.

“Yeah, we have fucking influence.” Katsuki shrugs. “Think about it, Deku. Isabori is the largest, most crime-ridden district in Augustana. Sommartyn is rich and clean, for fucking prissy assholes worse than my family. Illenova and Redmond are that weird middle-ground. The most populated for obvious reasons. I doubt a lot of your classmates are in the same district as you.”

He pauses, glancing at Izuku as if communicating: *you keeping up, idiot?*

With a roll of his eyes, Izuku nods, tempted to reach into his back and take notes on what’s being discussed, but by doing so he knows he’s placing his notebook in a shorter lifespan.

Katsuki turns away from the other teen, glaring harshly into the windows on the opposite side of the train cart.

“Anyway, heroes were forced into retirement… what, twelve years ago? And when did that fucking jump in crime rate happen? Less than a year after. Those tolls picked up, those other fucking weird limitations were placed for transportation. Hell, this fucking train is the reason why people can still work.” He snorts. “My family relocated us from Russia to Augustana—to Sommartyn District—the same day those fucked up laws were passed.”

Izuku’s lips purse, pondering over this new information. “Twelve years ago?”

“Yes, fucker. That’s what I just said.” Katsuki growls. “Augustana’s a huge, shitty city, but having it split up like this is fucked up. Makes it more difficult to track the squadrons in each district and see what happens when the public are too busy looking the other way.”

Izuku's throat turns dry. Some of his suspicions click in his mind, wondering, after all this time, if he was actually correct.

"Are you… you're not…" he hesitates. "You're not—"

"Fuck, you're so annoying." Katsuki cards his hand through his hair. "No, we're not the fucking mafia, if that's what you're thinking, Deku." He smirks. "Good to know you think we're a bunch of killers."

Izuku's brow furrows. "What do you do, then? Why did you relocate?"

Katsuki's smirk returns, secretive. Dangerous.

"These fucked up squadrons putting up fake bullshit ideas of protecting the population are all greedy and corrupted, Deku. No heroes around, so who's going to stop these new law enforcers from turning around and using their Quirks to shakedown stupid weaklings like you for cash?" He turns and lets out a harsh, biting laugh. "My family's here to put them in their place. Bakugous lead by fucking example. Every district knows my name because you don't fucking mess with me."

Me. The Bakugous. Me. Me. Me.

Izuku feels the color draining from his face. He wants to ask another question, but he wonders just how much of Katsuki's patience he's tested.

It's as if the world has tipped over to its side, testing his boundaries, his imagination, making him wonder what the correct thing to say at this point would be.

This is Katsuki's way of gloating, of openly telling Izuku that his given role as a secret vigilante, as the link in a chain of laws reserved for the Bakugous.

"You're the city's protectors. Vigilantes. But… your own organization, of some kind."

Katsuki's lips twitch. His eyebrows raise to his hairline, as if inspecting and observing Izuku for the first time since they met on this very train.

"Fuck, well, that's one way to put it." Katsuki snorts. "But not wrong. For once. Don't let it get to your head, fuckface."

Izuku scratches his cheek, the insult sliding off him like water on duck feathers.

"I want to become a journalist. To publish articles about heroes and bring them back."

He clamps his mouth shut, nervous sweat building on the nape of his neck.

He hasn't told anyone about this aspect of his dream, specifically. Uraraka had known that he wanted to pursue a journalism degree and increase his level of influence in Augustana to allow him the ability to reach outwards and attend universities of his choice. Yet, voicing these concerns to Katsuki seems almost fruitless, manipulative, as if there is no actual point to saying them out loud other than to have someone listen.

He expects cruel taunts and insults, and even a mocking laugh in return for his confession. However, upon turning his head to discretely observe Katsuki's profile, he glimpses nothing but a furrowed brow, a cautious frown dressing the other's lips, and something he hasn't seen before shining in those dark crimson depths.

"That's a fucking huge goal, shitnerd."

Izuku blinks. He brushes the tips of his thumbs together, rubbing. Counting.

"Yeah. I know it is."

His chest swells with uncertainty. It's strange, conversing with Katsuki and not being abruptly cut off with a brutal snarl or insult every five seconds. He knows he will pay dire consequences for vacating school grounds without warning; his mother will be notified, he's sure, and that alone makes his stomach flip over and twist into knots. Disappointing his mother… that was inexcusable, even if he believes he can somehow use the situational relationship they've formed with the Bakugous as an advantage to some kind of endgame.

"So what the fuck have you done about it? Written shitty articles for your school paper? Fuck, shitnerd, you won't get any readers doing just that typical shit! You need a fucking audience to get your message across. Dumbass."

Katsuki's smirk is wide and crooked and cruel, though Izuku watches him, studying him, knowing that there's something else lingering.

Maybe.

"I write for other places, too," says Izuku. He gulps and scratches the back of his head, as if Katsuki's clear judgment is oozing through his skin. "I've come a long way. So has the paper. Heroes will—I believe that it will help! Maybe not soon, or ever, but I'm going to try! Even though I'm Quirkless and barely making enough money to pay off tolls in Isabori alone, I know that I can support my mom for now and then move on to bigger things. More people need to know about heroes, how they helped us. How they *still* help us."

He stutters, struggling to find the correct words. It's as if his emotions are pouring out and he can't decide which one he wants to cling to the most to communicate the grandiose vision in his head.

"That's all I wanted, when I was little. To be a hero. When I found out I was Quirkless, I knew I had to think of another dream. Had to think of another way to contribute like a hero would. I know that what I plan to do isn't nearly enough, and even what I've done so far isn't even scraping the surface. I know it'll be different, though. I'll make a difference, Quirk or no Quirk."

He bites his lip and turns to look at Katsuki, who, even though he's not facing him, has returned to frowning pensively towards the floor.

There's a smoldering glint in his eyes and a crinkle indenting his brow.

“We both want to do similar things, I think. What you’re doing is really, really cool, Kacchan —”

What you’re doing is really, really cool, Kacchan…

Katsuki reacts before Izuku can finish his sentiment.

He whirls from his position on the support beam, and jabs his finger into the shorter male’s chest. He’s bent on an awkward angle, mouth twisted in a sneer as he glares and snarls in Izuku’s startled, reddening face.

“We’re not in the same fucking game, *Deku*. Don’t get weird ideas about this *shit*.”

Izuku blinks, his gaze flicking between the finger jammed into his chest and the twisted expression marring Katsuki’s features. The blond releases a low, guttural growl as he steps back once more and turns to the tram doors. They should be arriving soon, though by the look Izuku has been giving him over the last few minutes, his assumptions were probably already confirmed without—for once—voicing them aloud.

Sparks pop and dance in Katsuki’s palms. He resists the urge to slam his fist into the wall and watch the fires burst and lick from his fingertips, preferably close enough to Izuku Midoriya’s stupid freckled face to startle him and make him jump out of his skin.

He’s not sure why his hands are sweating so profusely, considering he’d been carefully locking onto each word that pertains some form of interest to his family name whenever Izuku speaks.

“You’re helping people with heroes being absent, right?”

Katsuki bristles at the question. He sends a dark glare towards Izuku, studying the hesitant, curious expression crinkling the other’s nose and causing his lips to curl into a pout. He blinks and looks away before the other teen can notice, growling at the incessant frustration sprouting the back of his mind from observing the teen’s annoying mannerisms.

Helping people. Absent heroes.

He cards one hand through his hair.

He’s grown accustomed to battling the occasional stirrings in his stomach and the anxious thrumming in his heart whenever he scouts the streets of Augustana alone, hopping off buses and drifting between districts like a phantom on this very train.

He’s cracked his knuckles and released explosions in darkened alleys, laughed and grinned in the smug faces of his enemies who dare to encroach on his territory. His name reeks with

reputation and displeasure, soaking the wary public with assumptions on the type of person he is.

He doesn't give two flying fucks about what people think about him.

Yet, for some reason, hearing Izuku Midoriya deliver such whimsical claims about Katsuki—about his *intentions*—causes his insides to backflip like tumbleweeds in a desert.

"It's more complicated than that, fuckmunch." He snorts, burying his hands into his pockets, annoyed at the possible singing he's going to find later in the cloth lining.

Izuku shifts in his seat.

The train hums as it slows to a stop.

"If you say so, Kacchan."

Katsuki clicks his tongue and moves to the doors, experimentally glancing out and allowing the late afternoon breeze waft over his clothes. He briefly glances to be sure that Izuku is following him, given the slight chance that the shorter teen could break into a sprint and escape, though he would have been surprised if he'd bothered trying something so reckless.

They step onto the sidewalk.

Izuku comes over to his side, a strange glint flashing in his green irises. Katsuki quickly averts from letting his gaze linger for too long, annoyed at the consistent curiosity that pokes and prods his brain whenever the annoying curly-haired boy is in the vicinity.

"So, why are we in Isabori?" Izuku asks.

Katsuki snorts. He wonders just how easily this teen fools others with his stable smiles and determined, close-lipped frowns. B

ut even with Izuku staring off into the distance and swallowing the appearance of cramped department stores and apartment complexes brimming with cobwebs and cracked walls, Katsuki can read the apprehension.

"Fuck, quit shaking like I'm putting a fucking gun to your head, shitnerd! We're in Isabori because we're scouting the area. Or, I'm scouting the fucking area and keeping an eye on you so don't do anything funny." He glares sharply towards Izuku, who blinks and adjusts the straps of his backpack and tilts his head just a few inches.

"… Why did you need me to come with you, Kacchan?"

Katsuki groans.

He knew he wouldn't be able to keep his intentions completely secret for long, though the fact that he's kept enough secrets hidden away from his parents makes him believe he has the right to expose one he'd begrudgingly sworn to his mother.

Their one-sided shouting match, ringing over thrown ceramic bowls filled with leftover food and his throat stretched to a point so cut and exhausted he swore he was bleeding.

"That boy is not a spy, Katsuki Bakugou!"

His teeth grit at the memory.

"You're going to erase this planned rendezvous you have with him immediately! No scouting those streets at night! Ever! Inko has enough to deal with and her son is more involved in all of this than she probably knows…"

He'd seen his mother cry on the rarest occasions, usually out of frustration and bottled emotions rather than pure, genuine sadness. Though the concern that flickered in her eyes, the way her hands clenched as if the bones in her fingers would break—no, it had been years since he'd seen her as vulnerable as the previous night. He'd been willed to silence himself, suppressing every urge to lash out with his Quirk in his own home while his mother screams and throws objects in every direction but towards him.

He stood. Glared. Held onto every word.

"If you're going to take Izuku anywhere, do it before the toll hours are finished. You're not stupid, Katsuki. I expect more caution from you. Fix what you've done and talk to him!"

His mother expected him to apologize like any other teenager who'd realized he'd been acting wrongfully.

Though, Katsuki Bakugou was not like any other teenager, so to speak, and he regarded his mother with a dipped head, a scowl and a cloud of silence that drifted between them in some form of communication that no one other than they could understand.

His mother's eyes were bloodshot with tears, desperate and angry and terrified, and he never could decipher how she could possibly care about someone outside of their family that much.

Inko Midoriya—her, and her son—were deemed in his mother's eyes as worthy of their protection. She would never say so herself, with fears of her past crawling behind her in distant, gaping shadows, though Katsuki understood the bloodlust that ran in his mother's veins and what guided her to do what she did when she and her husband agreed to move to Augustana.

Katsuki is not convinced of Izuku Midoriya's innocence.

Even now, with him doubting more and more that this bright-eyed boy next to him could hold any semblance to an Isabori gang member.

"Kacchan?"

Katsuki blinks, suddenly becoming aware of where he is.

He stares around him, briefly acknowledging the decrepit, morbid buildings and the strange flashes of unwanted fretting in Izuku's eyes. He turns away and growls, heat crawling

through his muscles and causing licks of present sparks to burst in his palms.

He wipes his clammy hands on his jeans and glares frigidly at Izuku, who's bright features are contorted in a mask of what Katsuki can only assume to be genuine concern.

"Just fucking follow me."

He starts walking, keeping his gaze focused and glaring straight and narrow.

He doesn't want to pay attention to the person sticking close to his side like a parasite, but he'd sworn to his mother (unbeknownst to her, of course) that he would force the freckled teen to earn his trust through scouting Isabori and confronting one member at a time to confirm his suspicions. He'd scoured these streets before, devilish smirk on his lips, loudly proclaiming that he was untouchable and that Isabori wasn't worth his time or the Bakugous' protection.

Yet, his mother seemed to be reconsidering that notion, given the fact that her close friend from years past was apparently living there.

"Wait. Kacchan."

Katsuki rolls his eyes, turns on his heel and growls at the other boy. Izuku's brow is furrowed, as if contemplating something that hadn't occurred to him before.

"The fuck are you waiting for, Deku?! Just shut up and follow me—"

"I'm not…" Izuku hesitates, keeping his distance between himself and Katsuki. The blond frowns, suddenly straightening his shoulders and observing the other male's fidgeting reactions. "I'm not allowed to be close to my apartment, Kacchan, not during school hours. It's one of the deals I made with the Isabori highwaymen."

Katsuki raises an eyebrow. "What the fuck? What kind of bullshit rule is that?"

The streets are eerily quiet. Only the occasional hum of crickets and birds flying between rooftops create rifts in the blanket of silence.

Izuku hesitates. Color drains from his face.

The fuck is wrong with him?

Katsuki's frown deepens. "Talk, shitnerd. No one's fucking here right now. Isabori has the same regulations as any other fucking district, so why the fuck are *you* paying extra tolls?"

It's a matter that's far more than mildly suspicious.

Given his bloodline, he'd encountered many liars in the past, instilled horrifying thoughts into them for even thinking of crossing his path or attempting to segue him from the big picture. He's experienced enough to claim that he can tell when another person is lying from a few key changes in facial features and mannerisms.

Izuku is a horrible liar.

And right now, nothing but truth spills from his lips.

“It’s—they,” Izuku grunts, frustrated, “Kacchan, they threatened my *mom*. I had to agree to the extra toll. She—she works as a bookkeeper just a few blocks from here, right next to our apartment.” He looks away from Katsuki’s inquisitive stare. “She has to travel back and forth a lot between her work and our place, so... so instead of her paying the extra toll and getting… hurt… I volunteered to take it on myself. It’s not like I skip school and come back here during the day anyway. But, it gives my mom freedom to go back and forth.”

The wheels in Katsuki’s mind begin to turn.

There were normally only a select few tolling hour blocks in each district in Augustana. Travel was permitted freely and without pay before nine o’clock, long after parents would be gone for work and students would be attending school, leaving the streets free of any possible detection of crime.

However, from what Mitsuki had learned from Inko Midoriya, Katsuki knew that Isabori was not just broken up into two tolling hour blocks, but four.

From nine o’clock to twelve, tolling would commence. Then, tolling would be on hold from one to four, a three-hour break to allow students and working adults freedom to return to their houses without paying the necessary amount. Tolling was then required from four to seven, leaving the last break between eight and eleven. Afterwards, midnight was the capstone for tolling—anyone left wandering the streets after midnight were subjected to the highest forms of punishment outside of a courtroom.

Katsuki had half-expected his mother to break the coffee mug in her hands when the stuttered explanation fell from Inko’s lips.

“Fuck.” Katsuki shakes his head. “Deku, who charges you for tolls?”

Izuku blinks at the sudden question.

“I don’t know his name.”

Katsuki growls. “Fucking useless…”

He watches Izuku, considering the possible steps they can take from here. He may have been wrong about his previous assumptions about Izuku, though he could benefit from learning more about what’s happening in Isabori while the Bakugous receive the blunt end of one-way slander.

“Come on.”

Izuku, this time, doesn’t protest.

Izuku holds his breath long before he follows Katsuki into a small department store on the corner of the block.

Anxious tremors spread through his gut and drift through his fingers. He wants—*needs*—to latch onto something to quell the stuttering pattern squirming beneath his skin.

What in the world am I doing?

It's almost as if a bucket of ice cold water has been spilled onto his heart, his soul, his mind.

He doesn't understand the knee-jerk reaction to run back to the train and return to Yuuei High School without anyone noticing that he's there without permission. He's breaking the rules he'd established to Isabori patrolmen, and his heart jumps into his throat at the thought that he or Katsuki could be caught in a similar situation.

The familiar jingle of the door opening to washed-out, painfully white walls and energy drinks poking out from glass-doored refrigerator shelves draw Izuku's eye.

He pauses every now and then, focusing on the tense patterns in Katsuki's back, wondering just how composed and focused Katsuki can be, given the risky situation they've placed themselves in.

"Keep an eye out, Deku."

Izuku blinks and hesitantly nods. He's not sure what Katsuki is planning, and he's more confused now than he was before with the sudden changes and the fact that Katsuki constantly screams at him to get out of his life but, in return, always seems to pull him back.

Katsuki comes over to the cooling area, scanning energy drinks with disinterest.

Izuku fumbles with his backpack, sighing.

"Kacchan, what are we doing here?"

Katsuki strokes his chin, zeroing in on one particular drink. "You said your mom works close to here, just around the corner of the block."

He turns Izuku with a grin, just slightly cracking open the glass door and pulling out a bottle of strawberry milk.

Izuku watches him steadily as the blond tosses the bottle in his hand, fumbling with the plastic container as if unsure what to do with his thoughts.

"So, we wait."

Izuku's brow furrows.

“I don’t even see anyone behind the counter…” Izuku frowns. *So why is the store even open? People aren’t permitted to walk the streets during this time. So no one could sell anything, right?*

Somehow, he knows his questions will not be answered with Katsuki being the only one he can ask in this period of time. He doubts the young Bakugou has any idea as to why the store is open in the first place either.

The door to the department store opens.

Izuku instantly blanches, his breath escaping him as a familiar, heavy wafting of cigar smoke drifts through the cracked open glass and swallows him up in a cloud. He turns on his heel, sweat building on the nape of his neck.

He recognizes the slender figure by the door, long gray hair scraggily and loose past his shoulders. His jacket resembles similar patterns to the patrolling uniform that donned Illenova’s squadron.

Katsuki doesn’t react at first.

He shifts, calmly tilting his chin up and scowling towards the gray-haired, older man sauntering to the countertop. The cashier isn’t present, but the clear expectations glinting in the stranger’s cold amber eyes are enough to chill anyone to the bone, though Katsuki, of course, is not frightened of anything.

What is he doing here? If he’s not buying anything?

Izuku swallows. He bears bruises from his encounters with Isabori squadron members, lingering like phantom marks on his flesh.

He recoils at the realization that it was usually in his desperate attempts to convince them to not lay a finger on his mother, who wasn’t aware that he secretly paid their respective tolls to keep her safe. To keep her unaware.

“That him, Deku?” Katsuki whispers.

Izuku blinks at hearing the other speak in such a hushed, steady tone. It sends a strange, bewildering shiver down his spine, yet before he can question the validity of reacting in such a way, Katsuki is already moving.

The last expression he expects to see on the blond’s face is a wicked smirk.

“Hey, fucker!”

The taller, lanky stranger wearing the Isabori jacket turns, and those frigid eyes light up in surprise.

His eyebrows raise for a moment, set in a narrow face and slanted jaw, though when he grins, his yellowed teeth reek with cigar-smoking tints.

He'll get hurt, Izuku thinks. His heart slams to an abrupt halt, noticing just how dangerous of a situation this is.

Why is Katsuki openly instigating a confrontation with a lone Isabori gang member? Why is he even bothering like this?

"Who the hell are you, hotshot?" the man mutters, cocking an eyebrow. He's a few inches taller than Katsuki, looming over the arrogant teen as if he's waiting to step on a cockroach. "You're not from Isabori. You're too dressed up like other prissy motherfuckers. You gotta pay the toll like everyone else."

Katsuki snarls, twitching. "The fuck? You don't even know who the fuck I am?" He growls, opening his palms and quickly stepping into the other's personal space.

The squad member blinks, then raises his hand and roughly shoves the blond back a few paces. Katsuki's eyebrows shoot to his hairline, staring with utter shock and confusion.

"Doesn't matter who the fuck you are, you cocky bastard. Fork over the cash. You know the rules."

He doesn't even seem remotely fazed, casually checking his watch under his sleeve as if waiting for the tolling hours to come to a stop.

Anger boils in Izuku's chest.

Before he can allow Katsuki to take a step forward and try set off an explosion in the other's unimpressed face, Izuku drops his backpack and dashes to them.

He quickly grabs Katsuki's forearm and tugs him backward, putting himself between Katsuki and the Isabori gang member with seconds to spare.

Katsuki is screaming, but Izuku doesn't listen. He braces himself, knowing just how many bruises this older man had inflicted on him just weeks before under the curtain of nightfall.

"I'm so sorry, Mr. Zeke, sir! My friend, um, he's new to Augustana and doesn't understand the rules and regulations here. I—I'll pay for him, Sir."

Zeke blinks, amusement flickering in his eyes.

"Ah, Greenhorn Midoriya! The hell are you doing outside of school, eh? You know the rules…" he smirks. "Hm, worried we were going to go back on our word about your mother? No need to be concerned if you have the money on hand."

Izuku swallows the growing lump in his throat, wondering if he really has any money to cover both his and Katsuki's rule-breaking. Though a distant, shadowed part of his conscience is screaming for him to do something else. To do something that isn't painting him as the victim in a situation he wishes he could avoid.

"The fuck he's paying for *shit*, you greasy-haired yellow-toothed bastard *motherfucker*!"

Izuku groans, stiffening. “Don’t listen to him. He’s just upset. I’ll pay for—”

“Don’t fucking insult me, Deku!”

Izuku yelps at the brutal snatching of his collar.

In seconds, he finds himself being flung backwards, his back skidding onto the tiled floors. Candy bars and deodorant sticks fall off the shelves, whisking by his shoulders and falling into his lap. He groans and rubs the back of his head, blinking to adjust to the sudden image of Katsuki’s hands bursting into explosions, and both males are wrangling and thrashing in the middle of the department store.

Izuku blanches.

No. No. No. No. No—

Zeke, exactly as he expected, activates his Quirk, and Katsuki is not ready for it.

Suddenly, the other man slams his hand onto Katsuki’s face, fingers delving into his cheekbones while explosions burst out of his hands. For a moment, just one fleeting second, Izuku watches as those menacing crimson eyes bolt wide in surprise, allowing the situation to sink in and a strange purple color to swarm through his skin and drift around his eyelids.

He screams, throat straining. Veins bulging. Muscles taut, constricting. *Panicked.*

Katsuki’s pupils vanish.

His angry yells rapidly turn into frustrated screams, explosions bursting out of his palms and casting fiery marks onto the walls and catching plastic products in the vicinity.

Zeke remains quiet and controlled, his fist powerful as his grip pushes further and he uses his body weight to pin Katsuki to the ground.

“Kids like you shouldn’t get way over your head like this,” he mutters with a sharp click of his tongue. “My Quirk takes away five senses through touch, you cocky shit. The longer I hold on, the more senses you lose. Greenhorn could tell you all those wonderful side effects, but he’ll go through the same when I’m done with you.”

Izuku’s body is frozen.

He considers his options, wonders if any other squadron members could be nearby, but the fearful expectations of what could occur as soon as he moves tackle him as well. He thinks of his mother, wonders if she’s safe where she is right now, hopefully pouring over her desk and typing up reports behind the safekeeping walls of a building.

Do something.

Katsuki is writhing. Screaming. Momentarily blind.

He’ll be deaf soon, and the longer Zeke holds on, the worse the effects will be.

Do something.

His muscles twitch and spring to life. A sudden fire soars through his chest, igniting his hesitations and casting them aside.

He braces himself, stands once more to his feet, and *sprints*.

He can buy Katsuki enough time. He can stop this from getting worse.

Before he can decipher what's happening, he slams his body into Zeke's side.

The other's surprised stare turns to him, his hand, just for a moment, lifting from Katsuki's bruised jaw. The purple shadow begins to fade almost instantly, cut short from the lack of contact. The blond adjusts to the startling vision of Izuku launching onto the other's back and yanking him off, the older Isabori scout caught off-guard from the sudden attack.

Izuku's back slams into the tiles. His breath caves in and streams out in a rough wind. His vision blurs, grimacing as Zeke grabs the collar of his shirt and slams him repeatedly into the ground, yelling and tossing insults into the air like confetti. Izuku's mind flashes back to Katsuki's washed-out eyes, the fears of him losing his sense of hearing, of touch and even having the ability to feel anything at all launching into his mind's eye and compelling him to move.

Fire from Katsuki's explosions swirl and engulf the inner workings of the department store. Izuku grimaces as a clenched fist slams into his jaw. He spits, watching as saliva frothed in reddish pink bubbles spray onto the tiles. He's not sure where is, how much time has actually passed, or why he's being pinned down and viciously beaten for acting on pure instinct.

Numbing pain surges through his brain and straining his bones and muscles. He hears the cracking of his teeth and the snapping against his cheekbone as the balled fist keeps driving into him, one after the other.

He barely musters a cough as a moment of hesitation passes. A loud, deafening scream—brimming with outrage, with liquid volcanic heat—bursts through Izuku's battered eardrums. He barely recognizes the shock of Katsuki's crown of faded blond hair in the corner of his jumbled vision, wondering if those red, smoldering eyes are able to see.

Why are you still here?

One last punch reverberates through Izuku's crunching bone. Swirls of red and black swarm his vision entirely, his breath escaping him one last time as the weight on his chest increases.

It's only seconds before he completely loses himself to darkness.

Chapter End Notes

So, if some of you are still lost...

The Bakugous have never scouted Isabori personally. Clearly, Isabori is more corrupted than the other districts, and now Katsuki is seeing firsthand what it's like for Izuku to live here. I touched on the reasons why Katsuki changed his idea from meeting Izuku before midnight to moving it to the earlier afternoon instead, simply because his mother pretty much demanded it and called him out on his bullshit.

I swear, more questions will be answered in due time, wonderful readers! Hopefully this chapter helped clear some questions!

Armistice

Chapter Summary

He can have this moment of freedom from the districts. From the realization that he's injured and it's partially his fault for allowing this to happen to Katsuki as well. He can have these few minutes before his mother returns, most likely worried and angry beyond recognition. He can think of these spare moments where he can enjoy the space of his bedroom and the surprising whimsical appeal that comes in the form of an angry, violent, complicated, intriguing Katsuki.

Chapter Notes

THANK YOU SO MUCH TO EACH AND EVERY ONE OF YOU. Oh my word. I love reading all of the comments, every notification with every kudos, bookmark, etc. Seriously everyone, THANK YOU. This fic is one of my babies and I love writing for it. Also, this chapter is definitely fluffier than the others and a bit shorter, but I think we need this little pause before things really start rolling.

Thank you, everyone. So much. :) I really hope you enjoy this next chapter!

The acrid taste of gunpowder and steel swim through his mouth.

It rolls over his tongue and slithers to the back of his throat, saliva and blood bubbling like the core of a cauldron.

Green, cautious eyes snap open to shadows enveloping a desk in the corner, notebooks stacked in haphazard patterns and a large bulletin board studded with thumbtacks and colored strings held by clothespins.

Wood creaks and shifts beneath his weight, his hands feeling so much smaller, so much weaker than they had before as he presses his thumbs into the carpet. Something wet and dark stains the patterns, flashing a painful tremor in his temples.

It's too dark for him to see anything else.

He doesn't know where he is.

"You can't keep ignoring the problem here, Inko!"

He recognizes this voice. The words slam through him like bullets, knocking out an unfamiliar weight he didn't know he was holding until now. The awkward gaps in silence turn dreadful the longer the voice lingers, sometimes in hums, sometimes in loud, rushed screeches that are met in return with calm, calculated pleas.

He glances down at his hands, at his tiny, wobbly legs. Are they…

Broken?

Panic clouds in his chest. He needs to discover what's happening. Where was he when he was outside of this room? How did he get here? Who is screaming his mother's name on the other side of the door?

"It's not his fault that he can't… you know it's not his fault that he's…"

"I don't care, Inko. He's going to get himself killed out there in the real world. You—you're just too blinded to see it. We're in Augustana now, and you… you swore to me that this wouldn't come up again. You promised that you'd left that life behind."

"No, no, don't go to his room—you leave him be—Hisashi, if you don't step away from that door—"

The door opens.

Izuku bolts up, sweat clamming his skin.

A dream.

Just a dream.

Thump. Thump. *Thump*.

Breathe.

He shakes, a tremor running from his head to his toes. *Calm down, Izuku.*

His body feels incredibly hot, as if a torch was set aflame in his stomach, spreading through his muscles.

A subtle, cold shiver violently ricochets down his spine and tempers the edge of his fingers. A throbbing, dull pain reverberates through his skull, through the swelling of his left eye and another ripple along his collarbone, chin, and cheekbone.

"About fucking time..."

Izuku groans, recognizing the snappy, irritated voice even in his half-delirious state of mind.

His vision is blotchy, but he recognizes the gentle whirring of the fan above his head, the familiar crinkle of sheets under his hands. Heat rises to his cheeks, unrelated to his possible fever—this isn't the right time to be embarrassed, but bearing these wounds and slung in a bed like a victim of some awful mugging makes him feel almost ashamed.

"What…" he coughs. "Ugh. What happened?"

Are you okay?

He turns his head only slightly, pupils dilating and drinking in the sight of the other boy, hunched over on a chair and rubbing his hands together as if wiping any gymnast's chalk.

He's been stripped of his blue button-up shirt, instead now donned in a loose white T-shirt and sweatpants. A harsh, gnarly black bruise swells up his jaw and peppers along his right eyebrow.

His wine-red eyes glare ferociously into Izuku, though the emotions broiling in those depths are far different to what Izuku has come to know in only a few days of knowing him.

"Quit fucking looking at me like I've come back from the dead, Deku." He runs one hand through his hair, jaw tightly wound. "What the *fuck* were you *thinking*?"

His voice is stern, riddled with anger, but containing something unfamiliar for the both of them.

His own words seem to surprise him, since Katsuki quickly avoids looking into Izuku's eyes.

Frustration bubbles in Izuku's chest. They're both injured, yet the only explanation for them both being relatively fine considering the circumstances would be that Katsuki had somehow rescued him back when they were instigating the Isabori scout in the convenience store.

He bites his tongue, annoyed at being useless in a situation where he could have been better help to Katsuki—to this incredibly powerful vigilante gifted with an equally powerful Quirk.

He was a liability to Katsuki, and he loathes thinking of how easily the blond could have handled the situation if he hadn't intervened.

If Zeke's Quirk had taken full effect, Katsuki would have been rendered completely senseless, a victim to unspeakable pain if Izuku hadn't stopped him.

I let him go in the store, Izuku thinks, *I let him get hurt. It's my fault. What have I done? He's hurt, and we're both hurt, and oh my God my mom is going to kill me—no, both of our moms are going to kill us—*

"Jesus, Deku. You seriously never shut up, even when half-conscious. What the ever-loving fuck."

Katsuki snorts, breathing through his nose and raking his hands through his wild, matted hair. Now that Izuku observes him more closely, he looks like he hasn't slept at all.

"It's my fucking fault. I shouldn't have brought you there, alright? Fucking happy? Now quit blaming yourself for something that was my fucking problem."

What? Izuku almost gapes.

He turns away and stares at the window beside him, blinking in realizing that this is definitely his bedroom, and if Katsuki is in his room, then he's seen…

If he could lift his mangled arms and hide his furiously blushing face, he would gladly do so.

All of his All-Might merchandise was displayed quite proudly in his room, usually reserved for his eyes and his eyes alone. And occasionally, his mother. Though, to even picture someone with the caliber and vicious personality like Katsuki Bakugou being in his room and scoping out the action figures lining his shelves and the myriad of posters slung up along the walls—it was almost too difficult for him to process without spontaneously combusting.

But, the wheels in Izuku's mind begin to turn in another direction. He blinks blankly towards Katsuki, who glares harshly in return and holds back a sneer.

"Where's my mom? This is… they both know, right?"

His mother must be furious.

Katsuki blanks for a second before rolling his eyes and groaning in misery.

"Obv-fucking-iously."

Izuku snorts.

Katsuki's glare increases, pinning him down.

"What the fuck are *you* smirking about, shitnerd?"

Izuku huffs and stares back at the ceiling.

He's not sure how long he's forced to stay in the same room with Katsuki, though, he's not entirely against the idea of the young Bakugou remaining at his bedside, despite how annoyed and bored he looks. He entertains the thought of their mothers storming through the doors and demanding an explanation from both of them, but from what he can tell from reading Katsuki's body language, he knows that the other teen has already suffered through the brunt of it.

He reels back onto Katsuki's venomous question.

"Well, you do that a lot. You add that curse word to pretty much everything you say. Sometimes it works, but sometimes it just sounds kind of ridiculous? I mean, that word means 'sex,' figuratively, so it's strange when you switch it up with other words to try to

make a point. I mean, even just now, what you just said would be *ob-sex-iously*, or something like that. So, so it's just funny…"

He trails off, only slightly mortified at his rambling and the fact that he'd actually said every word aloud, and also highly amused at the blank, twitching look on Katsuki's face.

His lips are pursed into a thin line, his unblemished eyebrow shaking as if set on a ticking time bomb.

"W-What the fuck? Do you even… how does your brain even work like that?" Katsuki snorts. "You making fun of me, you piece of shit?"

Izuku blinks as Katsuki gradually comes closer to him, the other's hand bunching up the cloth of Izuku's shirt and lifting him off the bed.

Katsuki is far less intimidating with the giant bruise on his jaw and the growing tic in his eyebrow.

Izuku holds back another laugh. "O-Of course not, Kacchan."

"Fuck you!" Katsuki snarls and releases him.

"Ow! Hey, I'm injured, here!" Izuku sighs. "And why aren't you resting? I mean, you're hurt too—"

"Shut the fuck up! It's my fucking responsibility to make sure you get healed! Fuck, it's my fault, alright?" Katsuki groans, huffs, and glares at the wall. His ears are tinted pink.

Izuku frowns. "Kacchan, you… you saved me, though."

Katsuki snorts at this, rolling his eyes. "Whatever. You were unconscious—"

"If you weren't there, I would be in... gosh, I don't even want to know what shape I would be in. Trust me, I've dealt with worse."

Izuku winces at his own words, especially at the wide-eyed, furious stare Katsuki sends him. His hands are curling into fists, fingernails scraping skin.

He almost looks tempted to punch holes in his own bedroom walls, though Izuku hopes that his lack of wealth will convince Katsuki to not damage his home.

"Don't insult me, Deku."

Izuku's brow furrows at this.

"I'm not…" He pauses. "I'm not trying to insult you, Kacchan. I mean, you told me yourself that you, that your family protects the districts, right? That the Bakugous are… vigilantes of sorts." He doesn't wait for Katsuki to respond, his own thoughts tumbling out of his mouth before he can stop them. "And—and I've honestly dealt with worse. Isabori highwaymen are pretty gnarly, and I've dealt with them enough to take some bruises here and there if it'll keep

my mom safe. And, I didn't want you to get hurt, and that was my fault too for not telling you about how dangerous they are and how well they actually know me—"

Izuku squeaks as something cold and icy is slapped to his cheek. He winces, and frowns at recognizing the plastic, bulbous blue object being forced against his face.

He struggles to peer over the edge of the wet icepack to admonish Katsuki's outraged, yet focused, expression.

The way Katsuki's forehead is wrinkled almost seems… concerned.

No.

No, of course he's reading that incorrectly. None of that would be possible.

Katsuki is abrasive and difficult and explosive, figuratively and literally. His Quirk exudes the power of cannons on constant rewind, enabled only to blast off when he commands it with the snide curling of his tongue and the flash of competitive fire and anger brimming in his eyes.

Even now, Izuku recalls watching Katsuki step onto the tram for the first time, his ears concealed within enormous headphones, his gaze forlorn and distant and shadowed with exhaustion—

Katsuki lowers the icepack, snorting at the dazed look in Izuku's eyes.

Despite his rough treatment with the other's battered form, there's a clear definitive way Katsuki forcefully presses the icepack to Izuku's face, usually as a means to stop his rambling when permitted.

Izuku can easily imagine his mother ordering Katsuki to monitor him—is she out at the moment? Is she safe, being away from their apartment, acting purely off of her instincts to protect him and her genuine love that he doesn't deserve?

"Quit spouting that bullshit! She's your fucking mom!"

Izuku squeaks. "D-Didn't mean to say that out loud…"

"Whatever. I don't care." Katsuki takes the icepack back, scrutinizing Izuku's wounds with narrowed eyes. "Fuck. That fucker…" He grits his teeth.

Izuku frowns, tilting his head. There's an extra layer of potency that dresses Katsuki's features, smoothing out the harsh angles to his jaw and cheekbones.

From how close he is, Izuku is completely aware of the new proximity between them. It's vastly different from how Katsuki hovered over him and grinned maniacally only days before, claiming that he was some kind of spy sent from Isabori… the thought alone would be amusing if not for the context of the situation, and how they've both barely managed to escape unscathed.

A vigilante…

Izuku itches for the opportunity to expand on this. He wants to ask Katsuki numerous questions, ranging from what he could fill in his notebook on his Quirk to what he believes the other person would prefer on a busy morning for breakfast.

These random occurrences in his mind, drifting back and forth in a distorted current, drag his attention from his wounds to the physical features of the other teenager that, now, he finally has the opportunity to observe up close.

On the train, before instigating any form of conversation with the volatile, threatening teenager, Izuku had known that he looked like a wild force of nature.

Katsuki was reckless and dangerous, and yet, extremely intelligent and calculating, and sliced cucumbers and tossed rice in a frying pan with the obsessive-compulsive precision of a seasoned chef. While he was primarily vicious when discussing his mother or father, he remained protective of their family name and had iterated in passing moments of silence on the train that he had gladly confronted strangers who denied their validity.

“Oi. Shitnerd.”

Izuku snaps his head up. Katsuki’s scowling, unreadable expression is only inches from his own.

He holds his breath, confused at the sudden racing in his heart and the definitive cords of muscle he can glimpse along the strong column of Katsuki’s neck.

He instinctively leans back, though Katsuki's stare hardens.

“The fuck is wrong with you? I’m checking your fucked up eye, shitnerd!”

Izuku sighs. “Sorry.”

Then, Katsuki sits back, grumbling. “Fucking annoying…”

Izuku frowns. What he had done this time?

Still, he is able to notice the slightest dusting of pink blooming along Katsuki’s fair skin.

Whether he himself is contracting a fever, or embarrassed, Izuku isn’t sure, but he finds it oddly intriguing to glimpse such a look on the normally tough and constantly screaming teenager.

“How did you fight off Zeke?”

The question is blurted out as if he’d just confessed his darkest secret. Perplexed, Katsuki splutters and glares with an abnormal amount of patience before pinching his nose and inhaling and releasing deep, frustrated breaths. Izuku smiles, apologetic.

“I just…”

I really want to know. How were you able to do that so quickly? After him using his Quirk?

Katsuki snorts and steps back, stretching his arms above his head and rolling out the kinks in his noticeably broad shoulders.

Izuku glimpses the flash of chiseled abdominal muscles as Katsuki's shirt barely rides up, only for the blond to adjust his clothes and flick his head off to the side, a scowl dressing his lips.

"I fucking took him out easily after you decided to be a fucking martyr and charge at him like some brainless cat set on fire."

He raises his hands in front of him, allowing sparks to pop up and dance on his open palms.

Izuku's jaw slacks in awe as he watches Katsuki maneuver and change the flame's size and ratio, his glare focused and unwavering.

Embers swirl around his pupils, illuminating the dark reds and browns.

Izuku gulps.

Focus. Focus. Gosh.

"When that Isabori fucker had you pinned down, all I had to do was deduce from my angle what the best move would be. Obviously, he was punching the shit out of you, and my senses were still returning. His Quirk was strong, and it took some time to wear off." Katsuki pauses, licking his lips. "My Quirk nearly set the entire store on fire since I couldn't see. I tackled him with using mostly my hearing to compensate, and popped off a smaller explosion in his shoulder blade. Didn't take long to disrupt the flow. He had the advantage for only a few seconds before I knocked him on his ass."

Izuku imagines it vividly.

Katsuki, regaining his senses, tense and coiled and ready to spring back into action after being dismantled from his glorified, powerful stance.

Heat spreads through his cheeks as he thinks of how he must have looked on the cold, tiled floors—beaten, bruised, unconscious and bloodied with a shattered nose and other broken bones…

"—Then, the fucker was trying to get smart with me. Heh, as if *that's* even possible." Katsuki grins, acting out smaller motions with his clenched hands, as if visualizing holding the Isabori scout's throat in his grasp. "I knocked him the fuck out with some explosive—hey, shitnerd, are you even listening? What the fuck!"

Izuku squeaks and laughs at the infuriated, reddened look the Bakugou is sending him.

The sight of Katsuki standing there, half-paused in his erratic movements with a smug—albeit a bit maniacal—twitch to his lips and glint in his eyes are washed blank.

Something warm settles in Izuku's stomach, different from the growing fever in his body, as he takes in the irritated frown, the furrowed brows, the clenched fists at the blond's sides, and the obvious red blush swallowing up Katsuki's handsome face.

Katsuki was proud and a bit vile, but he was demonstrating his "incredible badassery" to Izuku as if he's the only audience who currently deserves it.

The smile that overtakes Izuku's lips almost disrupts the giggle in his throat, even as Katsuki quickly grows angrier by the second with his lack of response.

It's oddly endearing, seeing Katsuki so flustered.

Izuku almost chokes on his own thoughts, completely mortified.

He blinks to adjust his stare, immediately becoming suspicious of the sudden wide-eyed look Katsuki is wearing.

Then, Katsuki's smirk, this one much wider, much more devious, the blush rapidly disappearing.

"Heh. I fucking knew it." He rubs his jaw, nodding his head, as if having come across some great discovery. "'Course, you're a pathetic pervert."

Izuku blinks, completely taken aback. "Wha—*what*?"

Katsuki straightens out his T-shirt, smug.

"You're doing that thing with your fucking eyes again. I get it. I'm fucking awesome. But you don't even try to hide it. At least have some fucking shame, shitnerd." Then, his eyes glimmer with something dangerous and unknown to Izuku, and the other can hardly suppress the surprised shiver spreading through his bones and muscles.

What did he just say?

Izuku splutters as the blond suddenly comes over to him, glaring down with sickening satisfaction that causes Izuku's stomach to backflip.

"I don't…" *Know what you're trying to say.*

What is Katsuki saying?

What is he *doing*?

Katsuki searches him, tilting his head ever so slightly.

"You're fucking obvious, Deku. Whatever. I don't care." Katsuki rolls his eyes and leans back, hands on his hips. "Let me guess, with all this cheesy All-Might shit in your goddamn room, you probably get off to that stuff, right? Is that what this is? You don't get out enough so you gotta resort to jerking off?" He scoffs. "Weirdo. Everyone fucking knows that the

fucking All-Might poster on your ceiling is the rip-off version. No one cares about season two's bullshit, so-called *updates*."

Izuku doesn't have enough energy to be embarrassed. Instead, he hinges onto one detail that left Katsuki's mouth before the other could stop it.

He's not sure if it's intentional, but the immediate glee and surprising mirth that floods Izuku from top to bottom awakens him from his stupor. He blinks up at Katsuki, his smile wide and blindingly bright, eyes sparkling.

Katsuki watches him, and *chokes*.

"Why the fuck are you looking at me like that?"

"You watched the All-Might cartoon! The—the one that aired even after superheroes were in retirement!"

He smiles in remembering those comfortable Saturday mornings, wrapped in soft, woolen blankets and devouring his mother's homemade pancakes while All-Might's cheesy grin flooded his television screen and motivated him to become a hero.

A Quirkless, yet dream-ready, hero of *some kind*.

Katsuki's jaw slacks. His face bursts into a pretty rose-pink.

"T-The fuck I—no! Fuck you! I didn't fucking…" he trails off, frustrated. Teeth clacking and grinding. "I mean, it was fucking everywhere! Nothing else was on fucking TV! I didn't watch that bullshit!"

Well, okay, that's a major contradiction, for one.

"Admit it, Kacchan!" Izuku smiles.

It's a painful gesture with his battered bones and bruises, yet he cannot deny the glee that warms his heart and the delight at seeing Katsuki so flustered once again.

"You watched the show! It's an amazing cartoon—"

"*Fuck off*!"

Katsuki screams, desperately closing his palms to prevent any further explosions.

Izuku is silently thankful for his restraint, yet the relentless desire to tease him until he loses his control over his preservation and admits to what he wants greatly satisfies him. He wants to see this happen more than anything else, and the butterflies that ascend through his body and mind are easily welcomed and enjoyed. He never would have expected this alien sensation to appear in the presence of a Bakugou, especially this one in particular, but he's glad for it all the same.

"Stop fucking laughing, shitty Deku! You don't know what the fuck you're talking about—"

“You know, Kacchan, it’s okay to like fun things.”

Izuku can barely hold back his laughter now as Katsuki screams, yelling profanities and threatening to break every action figure and rip up every poster in his room. He knows with the look of hesitation on the other’s angry face that he would never do such a thing.

“I-I think it’s awesome! A lot of people don’t know about that cartoon and I often get made fun of for it at school if it’s brought up, but All-Might’s cartoon self was my hero even before I saw the real one in action—”

“I didn’t fucking ask to hear about your sob story, Deku!” Katsuki’s spluttering, muttering and snapping his jaws in the air as if an irritated shark.

Izuku continues to chuckle and giggle, knowing that he’s close to hiccuping at this point, and it’s easy even now to ignore the pain rubbing beneath his skin.

He can have this moment of freedom from the districts. From the realization that he’s injured and it’s partially his fault for allowing this to happen to Katsuki as well. He can have these few minutes before his mother returns, most likely worried and angry beyond recognition. He can think of these spare moments where he can enjoy the space of his bedroom and the surprising whimsical appeal that comes in the form of an angry, violent, complicated, *intriguing* Katsuki.

“Well, it ran for six seasons,” Izuku begins, trying desperately to steady his breaths.

I’m going to have a heart attack if I laugh any harder.

“But, I think season one and four were the best. I mean, it was cool for him to have a sidekick, but, I think that it would have been better if he just went through solo. He learned a lot from his first sidekick, though, I think, and that Kamui Woods cameo was so cool—”

“*What*? Fuck you, Deku! Everyone knows that All-Might’s sidekick arc was a fucking stupid idea!”

Izuku smiles in victory.

This time, the blush that floods Katsuki’s cheeks are enough to solidify Izuku’s opinion on the open-mouthed, furious expression, and the gentle red that blooms across sun-touched skin.

Adorable.

“Y-You little *shit*! Fuck!” Katsuki snarls and pulls on his hair. “Whatever! That show was damn good and I don’t even fucking care anymore. But, hell, I don’t have freaky fanboy shit splayed up all around my fucking room like *you do*!”

Izuku huffs. “Hey! That’s not fair! I put in a lot of work into making this room look as close to those display stands at conventions that I saw when I was little!”

Katsuki snorts with a cocked eyebrow, rolling his eyes. “This room is already a fucking convention, shitty Deku. I bet you even have fucking All-Might underwear.”

Izuku blinks because, he does, in fact, have a limited edition pair of All-Might-themed boxers. In four different colors.

The blond snorts. “Pervert.”

“Why are you thinking about my underwear, Kacchan?”

… Wait, that was definitely not the right thing to say.

Silence spurs between them.

The realization of Izuku’s impulsive statement almost signs his death certificate for him. He glimpses the absolute rage, impatience, and clear *embarrassment* that warps Katsuki’s confident mask into something else entirely. He points fingers and curses and kicks around balled up blankets and clothes lain around the floor, unable to vent his frustrations on anything else with the proper energy that Izuku knows Katsuki wears on his sleeves.

“Shut the fuck up! Don’t turn this around on me!”

“You’re the one asking me about my underwear—”

“I wasn’t fucking—*fuck you*! You’re so full of yourself! Take a look in the goddamn mirror you piece of shit!”

“But you were the one asking, Kacchan!”

“I was fucking not! Shut up!”

The incoherent stutters that leave both of their mouths are enough to put them at a stalemate.

Katsuki is fuming, struggling halfway between possibly putting Izuku into a second state of unconsciousness and storming out of the apartment with barely any dignity left intact.

Then, Katsuki tosses the icepack onto Izuku’s stomach. Izuku winces at the impact, turning and staring in surprise as the blond yanks his bedroom door open and begins stomping outside. As soon as he does so, he props his foot at the bottom of the door, turns, and points angrily towards Izuku as he lies beneath his bedcovers.

“We’re going to fucking make you strong enough to deal with those fuckers! You understand me, shitty Deku? And don’t even try to fucking get out of it! We’re going over the fucking details by tomorrow and you better fucking rest and eat healthy shit and get the fuck better because I’m not waiting around for your scrawny ass to train you the fuck up!”

And with that, he’s gone, like the most violent blond whirlwind that could ever transpire.

Izuku blinks. Gawking.

Training? Make me stronger? What?

He can hardly yell any of his questions at the angry, huffing blond now gone from his line of vision, before the door opens and his mother's greeting and Katsuki's surprised screams mingle together in an awkward explosion of its own kind.

Izuku groans, slamming his head back on the pillow.

Great, he mumbles, *here comes the yelling*...

Headway

Chapter Summary

> “A-Ah, Uraraka, maybe we should go? Or, better yet, we could stay, or I could stay, and you could go! That way, we can work on this another time and meet tomorrow or—”
>
> Uraraka blinks. “Izuku, what’s gotten into you? Are you okay?”
>
> “Y-Yes! Perfectly fine!”
>
> “Hey! Fucking idiot shitnerd Deku!”
>
> Izuku buries his face into his hands.
>
> Unbelievable.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to everyone who read, commented, left kudos, bookmarked, etc. So happy that you're still enjoying this story so far. Things happen this chapter. Some clues. Some new developments.
>
> Oh, and protective/in denial about it Katsuki is best Katsuki. ;D
>
> EDIT: I had to delete and reupload this chapter because it wasn't showing up in the filtered tags. Thank, Ripedolphins, for pointing that out! I noticed it was continuous. Hopefully it works better this time.

“I swear, Izuku, you’re going to kill me someday.”

Izuku has enough shame to brace a small smile. Still, Uraraka raises an eyebrow and pops another teacake into her mouth, chewing contentedly on the lemon bar. Powdered sugar dusts her lips. She calmly wipes her mouth with a napkin and props her elbows on the table.

Izuku glances down at his plate, unsure if he’s ever going to touch the oatmeal cookie his friend had forced in front of him with little to no argument.

“Sorry, about that.” He scratches his ear, glancing out the tall glass window next to their table. Outside, sunlight spills onto clean sidewalk curbs. Cars move along in a gentle, rolling

pace. The singular tram that winds through the districts seems to lull like a caterpillar on a giant, iron-and-wheel leaf.

Sommartyn was the only district that he and Uraraka often feel comfortable with when collaborating on projects on weekend hours.

Various coffee shops studded this particular district, polished and pristine. The buildings were vibrant and colorful, quite a contrast to the streets that wound through Isabori.

He stares into his cup of green tea, running one hand through his hair.

“I’m okay with you bailing on going to the movies with us on Saturday, but I didn’t expect you to show up to our weekly Sunday lunch with *that* on your face! Are you going to talk about it at all?”

Uraraka’s hands are tightly grasped around her cup, hot chocolate threatening to spill over the lip. She’s ticking with very few allowable minutes of patience, and Izuku knows that, since the first day he became her friend and partner on the *Yuuei Herald*, that she would remain overprotective and overly concerned.

It was his own fault to not warn her beforehand about the bruises marking his skin and making it difficult for him to see clearly.

His black eye is considerably better, yet still viciously swollen and recovering purple, like the flesh of an eggplant. His bruised knuckles and jawline are still faring better in comparison to what Katsuki had claimed before the Bakugou heir was promptly kicked out of their apartment.

“Yeah, you look like a fucking mess, shitty Deku. What’d you expect me to say?”

He rolls his eyes at the memory, yet the tiniest smile dresses his lips at remembering the way Katsuki turned various shades of red. Nervousness was a surprisingly charming emotion on a Bakugou. He wouldn’t have expected that in any other case.

“Izuku?” Uraraka frowns. “You’re so out of it. Are you sure you even want to meet today? We could always… go over this later, you know. We don’t have to talk about the paper—”

“Oh, no! Of course we can, Uraraka! I’m sorry.” He bites his tongue. “Really, it’s… my fault. Sorry. Just been distracted lately. I owe you a lot with the paper and I have some ideas I want to run by you, too.”

Izuku leans back and suppresses the guilty tremors surging through his stomach. It was difficult enough, sputtering out an explanation to his mother, who was absolutely livid at the bruised and blackened states of both her and Mitsuki’s sons. The only reason he was allowed to grab coffee with Uraraka was that his mother was aware of his organized schedule with her, and she happened to still trust him enough to not wander off and become embroiled in another confrontation with any district scouts.

To worry Uraraka even more than necessary would be terrible.

“What ideas were you thinking?” Uraraka smiles slightly. “We have enough for the next issue, but, if you have some more ideas, that would be good! Maybe another superhero column?”

Izuku nods, pondering. “I was thinking of doing another piece like that, but…” He pauses, considering.

The underlying system that governs the city of Augustana, where he and Uraraka and countless others rest each night with hidden anger towards the corruption around them, is functional almost solely because of individuals whom no one seems to notify as good people.

Katsuki Bakugou had described his family as a group of vigilantes, or something similar to that extent. Requested to move from their Russian location to implant their roots in Augustana and create some form of organization in a place that clearly teetered on the edge.

Izuku hadn’t expected those developments to occur with Katsuki. But, the more Katsuki spoke of himself and his family, the more Izuku wanted to know.

The retirement of superheroes publicly exposed intense depression and anger across the country, especially cities similar in size and scope to Augustana. To think that there were underlying secrets to their system that very few knew about, that they were traveling under their noses like scurrying rats in sewer pipes, was mind-boggling in its own right.

Izuku’s hands twitch. He reaches into his backpack and pulls out one of several spiral notebooks, his lips fluttering as thoughts continue to spew into the open and litter his surroundings like invisible glitter. Uraraka glances at him blankly from across the table, gradually leaning closer and tilting her head to listen to what he’s saying, though the freckled boy is intently pouring into his new scratched notes with diligence and speed.

He then snaps upward and nearly hits Uraraka in the nose.

She yelps and leans back, her hands raised in a mock-surrender. She glances over his sheepish smile and blushing cheeks, skepticism lining her frown.

“What are you muttering about?” she asks.

Izuku sighs. “Well, I think I have an idea for a profile piece.”

He’s not sure if Katsuki would ever agree to something so ludicrous, or potentially damaging to his name, but he would gladly sacrifice his future dreams of being a revolutionary journalist if it meant that he could keep the Bakugous’ name safe.

They were connected to his family. Mitsuki was one of his mother’s only and best friends. Katsuki had stepped over boundaries that Izuku had never dreamed possible, and although they weren’t on particularly friendly terms, he respected them enough to keep the overall idea private.

But, the thought of somehow convincing the individual Katsuki himself to answer a question or two for an influential school newspaper made Izuku’s blood run in high, energetic rivers.

He can picture Katsuki's smug expression as he tosses out answers to each question, puffing out his chest like a proud peacock.

He would either welcome it or let off an explosion in his face. There would be no in-between, but he was not the type of person to let a situation go by without assessing every factor that could potentially come into play.

"What kind of idea?" Uraraka tilts her head. "You seem pretty invested!" She then smiles and leans forward, as if she's about to listen to some startling secret. "Come on, Izuku! Spill the beans! I want to know what you're thinking! You always have the best ideas, but don't think you can run them by without letting me know as chief editor."

Izuku laughs, rubbing the back of his neck.

"It's… a bit out there," he admits. "Um, just hear me out though, alright?"

His friend blinks at this, yet shrugs.

"Sure! I'm open to almost anything. Remember, we've gotten some pretty weird requests in the paper before. Remember when Tsuyu wanted us to do a photo journal piece on local frogs? I swear, that girl and her weird obsession with reptiles…" she wrinkles her nose. "Or, amphibians? Right, amphibians. Or something. Either way, they're gross." She giggles. "The point being: yes, go for it."

Izuku holds back an enormous smile at this.

He enjoys the thrill that claims him the moment he sparks with an idea, something he can scrawl onto paper before bringing to life in a printed piece that various eyes would scan over and read with different levels of depth.

"I want to do a profile piece on Katsuki Bakugou."

In an instant, Uraraka's sunny smile shatters.

She stares at him for a solid few seconds, unmoving, unblinking. Izuku wonders for a moment if he'd accidentally caused her brain to short-circuit.

He shifts in his seat, sighing at the realization that this was probably not the right way to bring up the topic, or even consider it in the first place, but the impact it could have on their school, on the Bakugous' reputation…

"Um, I'm open to anything but *that,"* she finally says.

"Eh? But, Uraraka—"

"Izuku, what are you even *thinking*? You want to get a profile piece on *Katsuki Bakugou*? You've heard of that guy, right? I mean, Todoroki's said some crazy things, but I didn't really want to believe it because it just sounds so… wrong." She taps her fingers on the table, her brow furrowed. "Where'd this come from?"

Izuku frowns. “I, um, was just curious. I don’t know... *exactly* how intensive the piece would be. I know that he lives in Sommartyn.”

Uraraka's eyes widen.

“Look, I know this sounds kind of suspicious, but, I think a lot of people have the wrong idea about them!” Then, Uraraka's statement sinks in, and he fixates a bewildered stare on her. “Wait, *Todoroki* mentioned something about that?”

She purses her lips. “Yeah. He came into the office while you were being a crazy madman and fleeing the school property and stuff.” She sighs. “He was just asking about one of these other pieces that his dad apparently requested to have printed. Honestly he didn’t even look like he wanted to be there.” She grins. “Anyway, he said he bumped into you on the train and asked us if we had all met a Bakugou at some point for an interview. I told him we didn’t, but… if you guys talked about it…”

Izuku shakes his head. “No, we—he barely came up.”

He warned me to stay away. He said they were dangerous.

Izuku frowns slightly at the memory. Todoroki had been so insistent to continue talking to him about the matter outside of school, as if it was a situational topic that he couldn’t instigate with watching eyes. It felt odd, thinking about how the pristine, polished student could possibly become uncomfortable or uncertain around another teenager who didn’t even attend the same high school.

“He would give you a black eye way worse than the one you already have! Which you still haven’t told me about, by the way…” Uraraka’s frown deepens. “You seriously worry me sometimes, Izuku. You just disappeared from school and ran off, and we were all worried something happened to your mom, or—”

“No, no, nothing like that.” Izuku’s tempted to bang his head into the floor.

How selfish could one person be? Worrying his friends like this and ignoring their concerns?

Uraraka was his first friend when he first showed up on Yuuei’s front doorstep, and she had remained patient with him in worse moments than this. Still, keeping any kind of secret from her, from someone he so heavily admired and cared about, felt wrong.

Uraraka studies him for a few moments. He can feel her doe-brown eyes searching him, picking apart his defenses, until finally her face brightens and darkens simultaneously. Her eyelashes flutter the faster she blinks, and Izuku knows that there are too many possible scenarios she’s concluded in just a handful of seconds.

“Wait, that Russian family you and your mom met a few days ago…” She pales. “Izuku, were they—the *Bakugous*? Was that *them*? You’ve been in their *house*?”

Ah. Of course.

Izuku weakly grins. “Um. Maybe?”

Uraraka groans. “Izuku, what are you even *doing*?”

“Uraraka,” says Izuku, quietly, “I kind of… know what I’m doing, to an extent. Like I said to you before, my mom has known Mrs. Bakugou for a very long time. They’re actually good friends, and even just from what I saw I know that they would never do anything to put my mom in danger.”

For Izuku, that was all that mattered.

He would rather place himself in harm’s way to shield his mother from danger, and part of him wonders of Katsuki took advantage of those instincts. Whether or not he was aware of it was a question that still lingered like fog in the young journalist’s mind, but he was willing to allow Katsuki leeway through their complicated interactions in just one week alone.

Uraraka opens her mouth to reply when a distinct ringtone sounds off in the café. Izuku blinks, reaching into his pocket and pulling out the vibrating cell phone with the familiar All-Might television show theme song careening in the air in static whispers. He stares at the name flashing on the top of his screen, and hopes that he’s angled in a way that will make it too difficult for Uraraka to see.

TEXT MESSAGE FROM : Kacchan Bakugou

I can’t talk right now, he thinks, *ugh. He always does this in the worst times.*

Izuku holds back a smirk before pocketing his phone again and smiling apologetically at Uraraka.

She raises an eyebrow, squinting.

“You have plans going on later today?”

“Huh? Um, no. Not really.”

Yes.

“… You sure?”

Izuku laughs awkwardly. “Yep! Of course! This is our Sunday meeting! So, we can still talk about the paper. I’ll just let the profile idea slide—”

“Well there has to be a reason you wanted to do it,” says Uraraka. “I mean, I’m not saying I’ll consider it, since I think it’s too risky, but what did you have in mind with this?”

As he opens his mouth to answer, Izuku’s cellphone goes from silent to buzzing emphatically in just a few seconds. He stutters, flushes red and shoves the phone into his backpack, the sleek black device becoming irrationally loud with each incoming text message.

It takes at least twenty minutes for him to convince Uraraka to stop worrying. Soon, both of them have their notebooks, computers and notes splayed out the tabletop, silverware and

empty dishes free of their previous snacks. Izuku orders another green tea and waits for the files to upload on his computer, tearing his teeth into a protein bar as he clicks away.

With their lack of school uniforms, he wonders if anyone would even consider the rare fact that two Yuuei students—one from Isabori, the other from Illenova—would bother spending their Sunday negotiating article ideas for their local paper.

Uraraka has always struck Izuku as the eventual celebrity journalist, her short, cropped brunette hair almost always swept back in a frazzled bun and her eyes stained with tiredness and constant worry. Her work ethic was unbeatable, though she would often argue that his was far superior to hers. Still, she's adorable and presentable in both matters with her pink cardigan, yellow blouse and matching pencil skirt.

Izuku wonders if he often appears like the typical starving artist by comparison.

With his calloused, pen-trodden fingers and incessant rambling, how he dresses outside of school never seems to pop like stars on television like it would for Ochako Uraraka. He considers the bright blue sweatshirt that was easily three sizes too big and faded jeans and trademark red sneakers would never convince someone else he was worthy of any form of attention, especially from news broadcasters who he would hope would consider hiring him.

The new, fresh bruises destroying his profile are easily the newest reasons why no one would take an aspiring journalist from Isabori seriously.

Izuku pushes his meandering thoughts away, clicking through his saved documents on his computer screen. He browses bullet points and notes taken from their last issue, scrolling through images of Kamui Woods and old screenshots of All-Might, both heroes standing tall and proud in the aftermath of wreckage in their glory days.

Observing them in these poses, those proud stances and glistening smiles, makes something inside Izuku's chest swell and flutter.

The doors to the café open. Izuku glances up at reflex, and pauses halfway between biting into his protein bar as a familiar crown of wild blond hair and auburn eyes break his concentration.

Oh. My God.

Katsuki is here.

Why is he here? Oh, no.

Uraraka is oblivious to Izuku's rather dramatic pause from reality.

She continues tapping her pencil on her notebook and drawls out a few choice lines potentially needed for her next column, though Izuku hardly finds any words to convey as the angry, volatile teen scans the vicinity. Once that heated glare lands on Izuku, he stiffens, and bursts into sweat.

"Izuku?"

He almost chokes on his cake.

Katsuki's lips curl into a furious sneer, and before Izuku can say another word to Uraraka, the other teen is stomping over towards them with long strides and swinging arms. He can almost imagine steam bursting out of his eardrums to match the twitching eyebrow and grinding teeth.

"A-Ah, Uraraka, maybe we should go? Or, better yet, we could stay, or I could stay, and you could go! That way, we can work on this another time and meet tomorrow or—"

Uraraka blinks. "Izuku, what's gotten into you? Are you okay?"

"Y-Yes! Perfectly fine!"

"Hey! Fucking idiot shitnerd Deku!"

Izuku buries his face into his hands.

Unbelievable.

Uraraka instantly turns, though she doesn't have to, as Katsuki quickly stomps over to their table and looms over Izuku's chair with the presence of an infuriated jaguar.

He's bristling from head to toe, his bruises far less impressive and prominent than Izuku's.

"Oh my God, *Kacchan*, could you have picked a *better time*—"

"Why don't you answer your fucking phone, shitty Deku? I called you like fifty fucking times! Don't tell me you were trying to ignore me, you piece of shit!"

Izuku can barely address the shocked expression on Uraraka's face.

He drops his hands, sighs, and glares straight up into Katsuki's furious expression. Despite the wounds the blond still carries on him like powder, he appears ready for an extensive training session with his outfit.

Izuku's throat dries, annoyed at his own inability to focus—and slight envy—over the fact that Katsuki, even with his current getup, is attractive in a way that he can never describe accurately.

Katuki's black, sleeveless top is loose enough to be comfortable for an intensive workout yet tight enough to show clear teases of chiseled abdominal muscles. His shoulders are round, exposed, and strong, his arms just as defined and nearly bulging with every muscle and vein he's desperately attempting to control with his devolving temper. A gym bag is slung over his shoulder and flapping against gray sweatpants.

Izuku rapidly shakes his head to clear his thoughts and glares.

"Are you *serious*? Is that *actually* what this is about? I told you I work on the paper with my friend Uraraka on Sundays, and—wait, how did you even know I was here?"

Katsuki slaps Izuku in the back of the head.

"Ow!" He stares at him in shock, even as Katsuki shamelessly snorts and glares at his disorganized pile of writing supplies.

“Fucking lucky guess, *nerd*. Come on. I reserved a spot for us in the gym in Illenova and you’re fucking coming with me.”

Izuku rolls his eyes. “I’m busy. I told you I was busy.”

“Wha—that doesn’t fucking matter! Come on!”

“I run the school paper, Kacchan. I can’t just go with you wherever you want, whenever you want it.” Izuku shrugs and takes a sip of his tea, gesturing with a widespread arm over his computer, folders, notebooks, and color-coded assortment of pencils and pens. “We have editing, conceptualizing, proofreading, and headlines to come up with! I can’t just leave—”

“Does it look like I give a flying fuck, shitnerd? Get the fuck off your ass and come on!”

“You’re unbelievable! I’m busy with Uraraka—”

“I don’t care if you’re having fucking lunch and afternoon fucking tea with All-Might, you shitrag! Just quit arguing with me and come on—”

“Um, I love that you’re both having your little fight and talking about me like I’m not here, but I would appreciate it if you would stop making a scene, at least.”

Izuku stares, mortified at the realization that several customers have already started staring at them, some unimpressed and others both annoyed and amused. He surveys Uraraka’s risen eyebrow and stern frown, knowing that he will owe her a heavy explanation later. He glances up at the corner of his eye, and is somewhat surprised to find Katsuki raising an eyebrow and narrowing his eyes at the girl sitting across from him, his expression unreadable for once.

“The fuck? When’d you get here, Round Face?”

Izuku’s jaw drops, and bangs his forehead on the table.

Why me?

Uraraka flushes, slamming her notebook shut and about to stand up and yell into Katsuki’s face.

Before Katsuki can react, Izuku stands up, pressing one hand to his chest and pushing him back while using his other hand to keep Uraraka’s shoulder in place.

It’s strange, standing a few inches shorter than Katsuki and an inch or two taller than Uraraka, with Katsuki growling like an angry dog and Uraraka glaring with the ferocity of a mother tiger.

“Guys, um, not here, alright?” He dips his head at Uraraka. “I’m so, *so* sorry about this, Uraraka. I—I promise I’ll make it up to you! Whatever you want, just let me know, okay? Oh, and for Kacchan being an ass.”

Katsuki snaps his head to glare down at him. “What the hell? You wanna run that by me again, you fucker—”

Izuku ignores him.

“*Anyway*, Uraraka, I’m so, so sorry, but—”

“Fuck you, bitch! Deku doesn’t owe you a fucking explanation!”

Izuku is hardly able to fathom the next few seconds as Katsuki grabs his wrist and yanks him off in the opposite direction, almost dashing out the café’s front glass doors with a trail of smoke behind them.

He yelps and stumbles over his own shoes, unable to keep level with his sweatshirt sleeve as Katsuki continues pulling, muttering angry phrases under his breath and huffing.

“W-Wait! Kacchan! My stuff!”

Uraraka stands there, fidgeting awkwardly and watching the practical kidnapping of her friend take place with little more than a startled series of blinks.

Sunday. 11:05 AM.

“I can’t believe you! You’re such a drama queen!”

“You call me that again and I’m blowing up your mouth!”

The train is relatively crowded this late morning.

After wrestling with Izuku for approximately ten minutes to get the curly-haired teen to follow him onto the tram, it seems almost relieving to finally have the stubborn idiot kept in one spacious vicinity with others crowding around them as foreseeable witnesses.

He inhales the distinctive stench of cigarette smoke and rust, his nose wrinkling with each breath as Izuku shifts beside him, his knee bobbing up and down in broken motions and his fingers poking and prodding at his callouses. Izuku is looking away from him, muttering under his breath and refusing to even glance towards Katsuki after they step onto the locomotive.

Katsuki snorts and removes two water bottles from his gym bag.

He shoves the plastic object into a startled Izuku's face, who stares cross-eyed at the offering.

Katsuki's grip tightens around the bottle. He glares into the overweight homeless man across the length of the cart, his overextended arm strong enough to hold this position for a good while.

"What is this—"

"It's a fucking bottle of water. Electrolytes and shit. Fucking take it or don't. I don't give two fucks in a handbasket."

Izuku purses his lips, yet he does eventually take the bottle from him.

Their fingertips brush, and Katsuki grits his teeth at the electricity that sparks under his skin at the contact.

He leans back and crosses one leg over the other, sneering at the freckled idiot beside him as he watches him with studious, narrowed green eyes.

"The fuck are you looking at me for?"

Izuku tilts his head. "You packed me a bottle of water. Ahead of time. Without even asking."

"So the fuck what?"

"I dunno. Just think it's interesting." Izuku shrugs and opens the cap. He tilts his head back and tastes the first gulp, his throat bobbing at the motion.

Katsuki watches this with bated interest, and quickly turns away when the other teen scowls at him. It's an expression that reminds him of his mother, and that alone is a terrifying thought.

"You could have been nicer to Uraraka, you know. She's my best friend."

"I don't care who your friends are, Deku." Katsuki snorts. Then, with a quick side-eyed look towards Izuku, he adds: "What, she your girlfriend or something?"

He's not sure where the question even came from.

He expects Izuku to laugh it off or brush away the matter, or even regard him with a typical backfire insult that he hardly finds worth his time. He expects Izuku to ignore him or babble about his superhero icons from when he was a sniveling, stupid child.

He expects *several* different reactions.

He doesn't expect, however, for Izuku to turn bright red and stare down at his fidgeting hands, now clasped tightly around the plastic bottle.

Katsuki's eyebrows raise to his hairline.

He can't explain the slight tremor of anger boiling in his chest, unlike the usual reactions he's accustomed to or the sensations he'd equate to his snapping temper or even his tolerance level reaching a breaking point.

"She had a crush on me, once." Izuku shrugs. "We talked about it. Didn't go over well. S-So, of course she's not my girlfriend! She's a really good friend, though. And, I don't appreciate it when people insult her. She's amazing. And, you shouldn't have called her a bitch, because she isn't one and never has been." He focuses on Katsuki once more, his lips tight and eyes shining. "She's tough and she can handle your insults, but I care about her. I don't tolerate people insulting her."

I don't tolerate people insulting her.

Earlier this week, Katsuki would have considered the phrase laughable coming from this smaller male, but he knows that Izuku's honesty and inability to keep his mouth or opinions shut propels him in another state that leaves him questioning. Hesitant.

Katsuki blinks and mirrors Izuku's tilted head.

He studies the other's determined face, counts the childish freckles adorning his nose and cheeks.

Katsuki had pretended to not notice the brown-haired girl sitting across from the teenager when he'd stalked by one of dozens of coffee shops in Sommartyn. They were talking animatedly, arms waving, concerned expressions shared, laughs and disgustingly loud giggles practically threatening to crack the glass windows…

It was also the first time Katsuki had seen Izuku outside of a tacky oversized suit and equally tacky (and still oversized) uniform. He couldn't explain the pause in his angry screeching when marching into the shop, intent on making the idiot explain why he'd been ignoring his texts and phone calls—this was Sommartyn, but what if another incident happened?

The freckled bastard was barely strong enough to handle himself, let alone an area full of people.

Still, the bright blue sweatshirt is two sizes too big on Izuku, yet somehow not terrible or awful-looking on someone who could easily pass off as a twelve-year-old if given the chance. He's freshly washed, curls wild and bouncy and bright green and tinted black on his layers, cheeks a healthy shade of color despite the bruises marring his skin.

Green and blue go well together, apparently.

Katsuki nearly chokes on his water, glaring into the bottle.

At the time, Katsuki couldn't pinpoint exactly why the anger that boiled in his stomach made him immediately take in Izuku's simple outfit, or made him purposefully ignore the brown-eyed girl and drag Izuku's attention away from whatever nonsense they were talking about.

“Whatever,” he finally says, addressing Izuku’s irritated, yet patient, frown. “Just don’t ignore my calls next time. I know these districts better than any fucker, and if you were targeted in a café of all fucking places, there would’ve been no way for you to know what’s coming.”

Izuku blinks at this. “Wait. You—you were *worried*—”

“Don’t finish that fucking sentence!” Katsuki snarls and jams his finger into Izuku’s chest.

Izuku reels back, eyes wide, brows shooting upwards in surprise, yet his secretive smile makes an annoying humming sensation stir in Katsuki’s gut.

He knows that they’re closer than they probably have ever been on the train, and if he wanted to, he could easily pinch Izuku’s cheeks together and make him listen.

“Is that why you were so upset?” Izuku grins. “Does that mean we’re friends now, Kacchan? Aw, all you had to do was say something!” He reaches out, and tentatively pats the top of Katsuki’s wild blond hair. The other teen backs off as if he’s been stung, twitching and growling like an irritated feline. “Who knew you were actually just shy—”

Katsuki then leans back forward, his scowl viciously crooked and nothing less than evil as he jabs another finger into Izuku’s chest, allowing his fingertip to sizzle with sparks.

“Don’t. *Ever*. Fucking do that again. You understand me?”

Izuku shrugs, biting the inside of his cheek.

His eyes, however, are shining.

Fucking disgusting.

No one should look at him like that.

Like we're friends or some shit.

Katsuki snorts and turns away, desperately shoving down the heat crawling up his neck.

“Quit spouting off bullshit. It’s my fault you got fucking hurt in Isabori, so we’re going to train you to handle it. Otherwise I’ll have to be there to pick up the fucking pieces because you walk around like a stick-figure punching bag.” He snorts at the gaping look Izuku gives him, yet he smirks and shrugs.

“I’m not *that* small—”

“You’re fucking scrawny, Deku.”

Izuku rolls his eyes. “Sure, Kacchan. Sure.”

Katsuki’s smirk grows wider. He shifts in his seat, surveying the people around them with caution. To him, they appear like formless shapes with nothing of interest, yet once particular

head of hair catches him off-guard. He instinctively tenses and coils like a spring, his hands tightening around the plastic bottle in his hands.

“Kacchan?”

“*Quiet*.”

He suppresses a growl in his throat as a familiar, older teenager spots them with ease, a smirk dressing his lips as he saunters over to them. Even now, his patrolling band glistens copper on his wrist, marked with Illenova’s crossed symbol of overlapping diamonds, his buzz-cut glinting beneath the terribly broken lights on the train.

“Well if it isn’t Bakugou.”

“Fuck off, Nero,” growls Katsuki.

Izuku stiffens beside him and looks away. He’s tense, though Katsuki doesn’t blame him for this reaction. He unconsciously shifts closer to Izuku and leans back, his arms coiled and fists prepared to clench and spark if need be.

Nero watches them closely, before his eyes land on Izuku, drawing back towards Katsuki with a widened, amused smile and mischievous eyes.

The fucker even bothers coming over to their bench, his hands in his pockets yet the bracelet still visible like an enormous watch. The fluorescent green numbers tick by in patterns, like the clocks on microwaves and stoves.

Katsuki keeps his head high and snarl present on his lips, the silent communication hopefully enough to cause this Illenova squadron leader to leave them alone.

Izuku avoids looking at Nero, despite the patrolman's attention latching onto him.

Katsuki twitches at this, especially since Izuku is either ignoring it or taking no notice of it at all.

“Damn, you’re just dragging this little puppy everywhere you go, eh, Bakugou?” Nero's grin is an antagonistic sickle slashing across his strong, angled features.

“I said, *fuck. Off*.”

“Oh, believe me, Bakugou, I would much rather talk to Freckles, here.”

Nero leans against the railing bar supporting their seats, his stance open—*too open*—and head tilted as he surveys Izuku.

Katsuki’s eyes widen, a snarl building in his throat.

He needs to control whatever instincts these are, these insatiable sudden urges boiling in his gut that are telling him to stand up and wedge himself between Nero and the stupid nerd like a barrier.

“Do you ever visit Illenova on your own, Freckles?” Nero asks, picking at his cuticles.

“I don’t travel around much. Not outside of Isaboir, at least,” says Izuku, quick and final.

It’s a lie, but a good one.

Tell him to fuck off before I blow him to fucking pieces!

They’re in a public place.

Nero is allowing every advantage possible to irritate Katsuki for his own sick amusement, even if that means dragging a civilian into the situation who honestly should have never become involved in the first place.

“That’s too bad. I said the toll was free for you, you know. I would’ve thought you would come for a visit, maybe even be a little more generous. I would definitely like seeing you around sometime, preferably without this blond guard dog hogging you all to himself.”

Katsuki’s breathing through his nose, inches away from setting off an explosion, before Izuku finally looks up to meet Nero’s eyes, his fists clenched and a sudden fire brimming in those bright green eyes.

“He’s *not* a dog! Kacchan has worked hard to protect what he can! The Bakugous aren’t evil people, and the districts are better places because of what *they* do, not what *you do*! You have no idea what you’re saying.”

Katsuki blinks, too absorbed in his confusion to notice the wide, amused smile on Nero’s face.

“Oh, Freckles, he’s got you *bad*, huh?” He shakes his head. “Too bad. Like I said, though, Illenova’s free of charge for you from now on."

"I heard you the first time." Izuku shrugs. "My answer isn't changing. I have no reason to visit Illenova."

"Most people like free things, sweetheart."

Katsuki straightens, an arrow of caution striking him.

Izuku does not even bat an eyelash.

"I don't need it."

Nero holds back a laugh seconds away from slapping his own knee. He watches Izuku, leaning far too close to the other’s determined face.

"I'm sure you'd think differently if you knew what I was offering, here. Illenova's bigger than Isabori. Better, too. Pretty damn generous of me, a squadron *leader*, to extend something so useful to an urchin like you."

Izuku backs away instinctively, and turns eerily still as Nero places one hand on top of his head, fingers brushing through his curls—

Katsuki is operating on bated time.

Blood roars in his ears.

He doesn't care why at the moment, his eyes completely dilated and focused on the scene transpiring before him like some taunting, dangling film. Nero shoots him a sideways glance, his expression impish, *taunting*, as he takes the same hand and lowers it, trailing one finger and pulling down Izuku's sweatshirt collar.

What the *fuck* is he doing?

Izuku is frozen, shocked pale.

Fuck off, fuck off, fuck off, fuck off, fuck off, fuck off—

Nero releases a low, breathy purr. "Though, I wouldn't be opposed to…*other* methods of payment—"

In a flash, Katsuki's hand is around Nero's neck, lifting him off the ground and slamming the entire teen's body into the wall.

His muscles bulge and coil, veins rushing with newfound angry energy. He's panting, his mouth open, his temper building on an entirely new threshold as he clenches his other fist and reels it back.

"Wait, Kacchan! Don't!"

Katsuki freezes, nostrils flaring.

Lightning rips down his spine.

"Fuck off, Deku."

He doesn't even recognize his own voice.

When did it become so low, so dark, so tempered with barely threaded patience?

He knows people are watching, staring with muffled gasps and shocked murmurs as their pleading stares burrow into his back.

They would recognize him if he continued moving. If he dared use his Quirk in public.

Judging by Nero's wince and satisfied smirk, he's played directly into his game.

"Good to know that he's a short fuse for you, Bakugou."

Nero's grin is more infuriating than anything Izuku has bothered saying to him over the last few days.

Katsuki's grip tightens around Nero's throat, his glare deadly. Simmering.

"You come near him again and I won't hesitate to rip off your dick and *feed it to you*."

He's a Bakugou. Bakugous pay their debts to civilians. His reaction is necessary and would be reserved for any local boy put under his type of tension and danger.

Right?

Nero's eyes flash. "You could certainly try. But you and I both know, Bakugou, that I'm not even close to being the worst danger to that kid. You keep him tagging along with you and we both know what kind of shit'll happen."

Katsuki snarls, a slight, bemused smirk overtaking his mouth. "And we both fucking know that your intentions for Izuku aren't allowed between a squadron leader and a civilian, you listless motherfucker." He leans close, close enough for his message to be heard and absorbed in the frayed wall behind Nero's head. "I'm not one of you fuckers. I wouldn't trade favors for protection. Bastards like you make me *sick*."

Nero rolls his eyes. "Pretend all you want. If you had the balls, you'd use your authority to have him wrap those pretty lips around your dick—"

This time, Katsuki's doesn't hold back.

He restrains himself, just slightly, as his knuckles slam into the other's cheekbone and a satisfying series of cracks echoes through the train.

The people around them are desperately quiet, afraid of him, most likely, but he doesn't care.

His grin turns wide and merciless, drawing back his fist and releasing the furious squadron leader, who rolls around his broken jaw and eyes him with a fuzzy, bewildered glare.

Blood drips from his nose, staining the rotting steel floor.

Nero is left fumbling for his broken teeth, whining incessantly into his fist as tears leak out of his eyes.

Katsuki laughs, cackling like a hyena as Izuku stumbles behind him off the train, notably silent for the first few steps as they take long strides in Illenova.

"Um, Kacchan?"

Katsuki snorts, his hands in his pockets and gym bag still loped over his shoulders. He doesn't want to look at Izuku's concerned, annoying expression right now, not when he can keep picturing Nero brushing his fingers through the youth's curls like he was some sort of *prize*.

Why the fuck am I so pissed off?

He rolls his eyes and snarls, the edge loose and controlled in his voice.

“Don’t lag behind, shitty Deku. The gym’s down this way.”

Izuku considers this, as if he’s about to argue, but he keeps his complaints hidden behind silence as he comes to Katsuki’s side.

“You... you didn’t have to do that—”

“Save it, shitty Deku. It’s not like you’re fucking special or some shit. I just need to get out a good sweat.”

Katsuki tilts his head and flashes a wicked smile towards Izuku, who sheepishly grins in return. He seems flattered, maybe even impressed.

Katsuki quickly looks away.

“I’m gonna fucking whip your ass into shape so you can beat the fuck out of fuckers like that. Never as good as me, though, so don’t get any fucking ideas!”

Izuku blinks, splutters and *laughs*.

It requires Katsuki to viciously bite into his own tongue to prevent the annoying stutter in his heart from distracting him.

“If you say so, Kacchan,” says Izuku. Soft and genuine and warm.

Annoying, Katsuki thinks.

Still, he supposes he wouldn’t mind being the reason behind Izuku’s laugh once in a while.

The clicking of a printer sounds off in the dark corners of the room. The blare of a computer screen lights up, illuminating withered, bony fingers as they glide and type along an ancient keyboard.

Cobwebs and empty soda cans sit emptied and crushed in scattered patterns along a typical wooden table. Up above, a string of clothespins hold onto glistening, laminated photographs beneath layers of tentative, faded red and black.

“Hm. No good, no good at all.”

His voice is young, yet strained, as if constantly teetering on the edge of a violent tantrum.

He pulls himself away from his computer, reaching up and examining the photographs still recovering from their soak in the tub beside his stained sheets.

His thumbs glide over the laughing face of a youth he's seen numerous times, now. The requests seeking further information on this plain, freckled face crowned in whimsical curls, seem odd to the man as he seethes and groans through his collection of photographs. He comes across several of the same teenager, most of them consisting of the green-eyed boy conducting interviews on school grounds, being tossed around with bloodied fists by district squadrons, and occasionally in the open company of a blond teenager that no one in their right mind would try to form a companionship with.

He releases a low, satisfied grin as he takes off the photograph and runs one thumb over a photograph he'd taken of the two teens. It depicts the blond yanking the boy away by the sleeve of his sweatshirt, clearly heading towards the tram that winds through the districts like one long, sand-treading snake.

The blond kid has a scowl and angry red eyes to scare off only the uninformed.

The curly-topped boy is foolish. Ignorant. Perhaps his bright eyes and naivety are what drew the blond to his company. No one can seem to figure out any other reason for the blond being so incessantly hovering over the smaller teenager, especially since they couldn't have possibly met on high school grounds.

A growl resonates in the dark of the room as long, wiry arms hang up the photograph.

There's still work to do.

Dubiety

Chapter Summary

Katsuki's forearm is pressed to the lockers above Izuku's head, his other hand calmly in one pocket as he leans down, his frown still firm, still threatening.

Still teeming with the silent flames of Bakugou blood.

"You don't scare me, Kacchan."

Chapter Notes

THANK YOU SO MUCH everyone for your supportive comments, kudos, bookmarks, etc. as usual. It honestly means so much to me that people are still enjoying this story. And yes, this is truly the slow-burn trek, but we get more development! And fluff! And good conversation! Because those things are important!

More questions. More answers(?), and all the good stuff! Hope you enjoy this next chapter. :)

ALSO, I love it when you guys message me on Tumblr. It just, brings so much joy to my world. I love answering questions, talking to new people, getting to know some of you... ah, it's such a blessing. Thank you so much for being the most patient and gracious readers. It means the world.

Alright, I hope you all enjoy!

The moment Nero materialized out of seemingly nowhere, Izuku knew that the potential outcome of both him and Katsuki leaving the tram unscathed had fallen to a bare minimum.

However, he was unable to comprehend how close Nero had decided to be, inching into his personal space and allowing his fingers to roam through his curls.

He'd bristled, apprehensive beneath the unexpected gesture, watching an unknown sensation flicker in those darkened eyes.

Nero had said very little, though Izuku was sweating profusely, desperately trying to focus on a way to get out of the incoming scuffle between Nero and Katsuki, though before he could

firmly request Nero to stop touching him, Katsuki was already moving and pinning Nero against the tram wall.

Passengers on the train gasped in surprise, though Izuku's thoughts were fleeting and *panicked*.

He needed to think of a way to get Katsuki to stop, to somehow grab his attention. Being polite had clearly gotten him nowhere, and the more he realized just how strangely poised and focused the blond vigilante happened to be, the more Izuku came to terms with how nothing he could say would be able to stop his violent companion from doing exactly what he wanted.

He couldn't hear what they were saying, but it was enough for Katsuki to nearly cave the Illenova scout's nose into his skull with a raging, sparking fist.

Now, Izuku can hardly assess just how strange that entire encounter was. His stomach is still flipping and tying itself into knots over the odd shadow that was cast over the three of them in the public presence, widely displayed for just about anyone to see. The moment Nero's fingers dared to tug down on his sweatshirt and inch closer to his face, Izuku knew something was different. Even so, he never knew that Katsuki was willing to defend him like that.

It had to be out of guilt. It was, apparently, Katsuki's reasoning for bothering to take him to a gym and encourage him to train at all.

I need to call Uraraka…

He wants to bury his face into his hands and then apologize for centuries.

Was she still watching over his belongings? Was she just as shocked and surprised as he expected for her to be once she discovered that he was acquaintances with Katsuki Bakugou?

Maybe even friends with him?

She didn't deserve any of this.

With a sigh, Izuku tugs at his hoodie's drawstrings, biting his tongue.

A chill sweeps through him, turning his blood to ice.

He wants to return to the tram and reconsider the steps he's taking, even though a part of him has definitely lent itself to trust Katsuki Bakugou. The longer he stares at the other teen's angular profile and sharp eyes, the more Izuku suppresses the instinctive twitch in his fingers and the uncomfortable desire to see what Katsuki's wild hair feels like.

"Hey, shitnerd."

Izuku squeaks and comes to an abrupt stop. Katsuki is glaring at him with a risen eyebrow, for once looking a little relaxed.

"You're muttering again. It's annoying." Katsuki snorts. "So shut the fuck up. We're here."

Izuku follows Katsuki's gesture to the massive glass-walled building in front of them. The windows form the entire expanse of the exterior, the doors themselves so extravagant and wide that Izuku wonders how many people can walk through the front without blocking the entrance.

"It's *huge*," Izuku says, his jaw dropped in awe.

"Well, duh. What, you think a Bakugou would get his sweat going at some cheap-ass imitation of the real deal?" He smirks and places his hands on his hips, his smug expression impossible to miss.

Izuku snickers behind his hand.

"Come on. You're so fucking slow."

Izuku sighs, but decides to humor the other teenager. He keeps several paces behind Katsuki, even after they enter the facility and he's able to scope his surroundings with wide, observant eyes. The walls are brimming with white tile, exercise equipment stretching from one end to the other. Treadmills, elliptical machines, numerous mechanical contraptions loaded with weight blocks, and more are placed in haphazard, almost nauseating patterns.

The stench of sweat and strange cleaning spray flood Izuku's nose.

Anxiety stirs in his chest, spurring beneath his skin in an uncomfortable hum.

Katsuki shoves a pile of clothes into Izuku's hands.

He stares down at the lump, raising an eyebrow as Katsuki rolls his eyes and shoves him.

"Go change. Meet me over there," he says, pointing to a small square corner of the gym where a string of punching bags dangle from an iron bar. "You've got five minutes. The longer you take to put on a shirt and a pair of fucking shorts, the longer we'll be here. So get to it."

He says nothing more as he jogs off.

"But, Kacchan!" Izuku groans. "I don't know where the locker room is."

He bites his lip and looks to the all-white metal desk where he expects the receptionist to be. Yet, he sees no one.

"I should be able to figure it out. Can't be too hard," he mutters.

It does, unfortunately, take him far too long to find the locker rooms. It also (and again, quite unfortunately) takes him an inordinate amount of time to figure out how to use the automatic buttons on the locker. The strange looks the gym employees give him when he's not sure whether or not to take their towels are enough to send him scurrying off and hoping for the best, after he's slipped on the casual white workout shirt and basketball shorts.

He groans at the slight draping effect to his slender figure in comparison to Katsuki's more muscular form. He rolls his eyes, perturbed, but decides against mulling over comparing how they look as he motions back onto the main floor, assessing his surroundings with a furrowed brow and a concentrated purse to his lips.

"Shitnerd! Over here!"

Izuku holds back a snort.

Okay, well, at least he's literally impossible to miss.

Katsuki is standing rigid next to one of the punching bags, having already dropped his gym bag a few yards away. A towel is thrown across his shoulders, his pose rolling with authority and a sense of territory control that makes Izuku want to laugh.

Katsuki snorts. "Why the fuck are you standing so far away? Come here."

Izuku blinks. "Um…" He glances at the punching bag, and then back towards Katsuki with widened eyes. "Are you *serious* Kacchan? I've never even used a punching bag before!"

"That's why you're going to start, shitnerd! Quit your whining!" Katsuki growls. "I have some protective gloves, you idiot. You're not going to break any fingers. So come on over."

Despite his harsh words, Katsuki's voice is quieter. Sterner, even. It's almost as if he's leveling his voice to create some form of normalcy between them in a way that could confuse this interaction for a balanced conversation.

A nervous tremor races up Izuku's spine. He cautiously nods his head, and slowly approaches Katsuki and the punching bag, the blue mat squishy and supportive under his sneakers.

Katsuki removes two gloves from his gym bag and slaps them in Izuku's hands, pointedly glaring as if instructing him to put them on.

"You know," says Izuku as he slips one glove at a time over his hands, "you really shouldn't have caused a scene on the train." He frowns. "What if someone saw? I mean, they would piece together that it was you, and, we could both be on a newspaper later or something, or Nero could come after you and that's not really worth all the trouble."

He squeaks, grimacing as finds his back flat on the ground, the wind temporarily knocked out of him. He stares up at Katsuki, who's teeth are gnashing together and eyes wild with fury.

"What was that for, Kacchan?" Izuku groans and sits up on his elbows.

Katsuki huffs, and crawls off of him.

"Don't worry about that Nero fucker. Also, I'd fucking prefer it if you didn't even say his name. If you do, I'll blow up your face. Under-fucking-stand?"

Izuku tilts his head, blinking dumbly.

However, rather than fight Katsuki on the subject, he silently complies and readjusts his position, finishing placing on the gloves and flashing a broad smile at his temporary teacher.

“Would that please you, oh great *Master Kacchan*?”

His smile dissipates as Katsuki grabs the collar of his shirt and reels back his fist, a threatening, dangerous growl rumbling in the other’s throat.

Izuku holds up his hands, chuckling.

“Okay, okay, I’ll stop.”

“Good,” says Katsuki. He scrutinizes the black and white-striped boxing gloves now engulfing Izuku’s hands. “And wait to put on your gloves. You still need to stretch and warm up. I have a specific regimen planned for your body type, and we’re going to follow it to a damn T. Get it, Deku?”

Izuku rubs the back of his neck. “Alright. I guess…”

He supposes that’s fair.

It’s odd, however, feeling the burn of Katsuki’s stare into his body as he creates space between them.

He begins stretching, extending his arms above his head and leaning this way and that, almost groaning at the relieving aches departing from his strained muscles.

Then again, it’s odd that he’s even willing to comply to Katsukk's schemes at all. He’d never considered finding himself in any sort of position to even be allowed in the same vicinity as someone like the Bakugou heir, yet it’s strange to believe that he’s present in a massive, pristine facility with polished walls and state-of-the-art exercise equipment, stretching out his hamstrings and calves under the watchful eye of a teen who many people avoided.

Katsuki joins him on ground level, squatting low and drawing up and down Izuku’s straightened legs and arms. Izuku blinks from the scrutinizing glare and turns away, ignoring the urge to brush away his curls and forcefully push down the blush in his neck and cheeks.

Being under this amount of attention, no matter what the circumstance, is already affecting him.

Still, he thinks, biting his lip, *I deserve to have some questions answered.*

“Um, Kacchan?”

Katsuki doesn’t even turn away, rubbing his chin as he continues focusing. He grunts as a reply, lingering on Izuku’s shoes as he leans forward to graze the ends of his sneakers with his fingertips.

“Why exactly are we doing this?”

Katsuki snaps out of his concentration and raises an eyebrow.

“Why the fuck do you think, Deku?” He pushes on his knees and stands up, rolling his arms in a windmill motion to pop the remaining stationary bones under his shoulders.

Even from his angle on the ground, Izuku can scope out each definitive line and curve that make up his companion’s impressive physique.

Izuku mentally kicks himself.

Really? Is this really *the time for that?*

He stands up and pushes the gloves back on over his hands.

“That doesn’t really answer my question, Kacchan.”

Instead of answering him, Katsuki assesses the size and scope of the punching bag, placing his hands on his hips from a considerable distance as if analyzing a mathematical graph.

His eyebrows are scrunched together, hand rubbing his chin and his expression oddly contemplative.

The sight alone makes Izuku tilt his head to the side in slight bewilderment.

Even when he’s quiet, he’s so intense. Would he always be like that, though? I don’t think I’ve ever seen him this quiet. And, he just beat up someone on a train and people are going to wonder about that, and what if Nero finds us here? He’s part of Illenova’s squadron… is that going to place Kacchan in danger? He shouldn’t have broken his teeth…. Wait, is Kacchan hurt? He hasn’t shown me anything and we’re both still recovering—

“Quit your muttering,” growls Katsuki, still turned away from him. “And quit worrying.” He flicks his head to the punching bag. “Hit it. And don’t hold back.”

Izuku blinks at him. “Eh?”

“… Just, fucking. Jesus Christ.” Katsuki growls through gritted teeth, dragging one hand down his face. "What the fuck do you *think I mean*, dumbass?"

Izuku nods, and inches closer to the punching bag. His fingers flex in preparation. Nervousness builds in his stomach and erupts into butterflies, and whether it’s from the actual act of demonstrating his athletic ability—or that it’s in front of Katsuki—Izuku isn’t sure.

He punches it once, tentatively.

The bag barely moves as a result, heavy and leather and firm.

Katsuki barks out a harsh, grating laugh. Izuku sputters.

He wishes he could look anywhere else except for the blue mat beneath his shoes.

“What kind of pussy punch was that? *Holy* fuck, you’re such a nerd!” Katsuki rolls his eyes and steps forward, taking Izuku’s wrist and shoving it closer to his face. “Make sure your fist is completely balled up. One at a time. And you don’t just swing your arm like a fucking wet noodle. Just, pivot your foot and direct your body weight into each strike.”

Izuku considers this, hesitating. “But, why boxing? Why a punching bag?” He frowns at this thought, his thumping foot and anxiously twitching hands missing the presence of his many notebooks. “Wouldn’t it be more practical for… I dunno, sparring? Or, or something like that? I mean—”

He’s abruptly cut off when he realizes Katsuki has moved, and is now standing behind him instead. They’re close enough for Izuku to smell the distinct whiff of sweat and a mixed scent of cucumber and pine, barely traceable through his clothes and wild light hair.

Izuku stiffens, every piece of him constricting like a coiled spring.

Don't have an aneurysm. Or a heart attack. Oh my god. He's so close. Wait, this shouldn't matter. Why am I even thinking about this—

His eyes widen to the size of dinner saucers, watching with slightly bated breath as he feels one hand set on the left side of his waist. Those fingers are scarred, calloused, carrying the weight of many confrontations in dark alleys. Those knuckles have inflicted pain and protected others, have been stained with the blood of many enemies.

Izuku swallows.

Katsuki's skin brushes the cotton fabric of his shirt, warmth lingering through the ghosting touch.

Izuku’s mouth dries up, even as he barely snaps into reality at the presence of another hand grasping his right wrist on the opposite side and lifting it.

“Hold your arm after I move it,” says Katsuki, firm and concentrated.

Izuku's brain short-circuits.

He's almost positive that his heart is inching close towards cardiac arrest.

What is wrong *with me?*

“U-Um. Right. Uh-huh.” He inwardly rolls his eyes and does what Katsuki asks.

Katsuki releases his wrist, and he keeps his right arm stationary. Then, he feels Katsuki’s right hand drift to his waist and firmly grip the area, mirroring the placement of his left.

“You need to turn your waist and push your body weight into one side.”

Izuku nods, concentrating on the punching bag, even as he feels Katsuki pull his left side back a bit.

He knows that Katsuki is moving with him, like a detached shadow, just a few inches taller and clearly reveling in the obvious difference in strength and height.

He blinks away the thoughts of what Katsuki looks like now, his voice unreasonably close and each instruction sending his spine tingling with sparks.

Stop. Stop. Stop. Stop. Stop.

"What's the matter, *Deku*?"

Izuku holds back a squeak at this.

Katsuki's voice is deeper now, huskier.

It's a tone he hasn't become familiar with yet, still edging on the void of danger and leaping into another realm that Izuku wishes to step into.

His curiosity lends his mind to want to replay this same tone over and over again, like a broken record.

"Don't tell me you're *distracted*?"

Izuku can *feel* the smirk.

"U-Um, no?"

He shudders even after Katsuki releases him, as if two burning hot coals have been set free.

He releases a clandestine breath, fluttering his eyes and struggling to adjust to the suddenly blurred shape of the punching bag.

What the hell is going on?

Katsuki then pats Izuku on the back, strangely condescending in its heaviness.

Izuku glares towards Katsuki's profile, yet his breath hitches once more at scoping the clear, snarky smirk stretching Katsuki's lips.

It's smug and reeking with Bakugou confidence, his teeth glinting beneath the pastel white ceiling lights.

"Good. You'd be fucking dead by now if shitrags like Buzzcut Fuckface came running at you."

Izuku blinks. "Buzzcut… wha—"

"Try again, stupid Deku."

Izuku sighs, exasperated. "Fine."

He loathes how stuttered this one simple word comes out between his lips. He almost hates it as much as the sensations he wishes to feel again from having Katsuki's presence so close behind him. Those sturdy, roughened fingers and palms pressing through the cloth of his shirt and firmly grazing his waist, just a few inches shy of his hips—

He shakes his head.

He refrains from looking at Katsuki, drawing in a shuddering breath and forcing each thought —each question he wishes to ask—kept locked away inside.

"What the fuck are you waiting for? Again!" Katsuki snaps.

Izuku bristles. "Sorry, Kacchan!" He groans. "Okay, okay. This can't be too hard. Just, pivot, and, full-weight forward, and strike." He nods to himself. "That should do it."

He ignores the eye-roll from Katsuki, keeping the bulleted list in his mind as a consistent reminder.

Katsuki's instructions help, at first.

He notices a significant increase in the punching bag shifting off to the side, back and forth. His heart slams into his ribcage, sweat staining his shirt and dripping from his chin in minutes. He brushes at his skin, taking off his gloves after a solid twenty minutes and running his fingers through his hair. There's a definite numbing sensation in his knuckles. He turns them over to look over the purple and blue bruises.

After each break, he's pulled back into reality for just a few moments.

Kacchan hasn't said anything this whole time.

With a nervous flush heating the back of his neck, Izuku slightly turns his head.

Katsuki is sitting cross-legged on the ground, his elbow propped on his knee and his chin resting in the palm of his hand, his wine-red eyes narrowed, focused, and content.

They seem zeroed in on particular targets, a grim line keeping his lips pursed together.

"Um."

His eyes flicker around the gymnasium, suddenly feeling as if dozens of strangers are watching him, their gazes burrowing into his back and analyzing his movements.

Could they see the flaws in each punch? In each faltered pivot in his foot? Would they be able to calculate how much sweat he should actually be releasing when training this early? Was twenty minutes a normal time for a boxer to take a break?

"Hey! Fuckers! Keep your fucking eyes to yourself! Private lesson!"

Izuku blinks out of his stupor and looks to where Katsuki was.

Instead of still being seated on the ground, Katsuki is now standing and marching to one end of the mat towards one man and one woman, both sweaty and clearly overworked themselves —a couple, most likely—close enough to brush by Izuku's shoulders as he does so.

What in the world is Katsuki doing?

As far as Izuku was concerned, no one was trying to interfere with their "private lesson," as Katsuki has apparently proclaimed, in any way, shape, or form. He was acting ridiculous, though Izuku would not let this happen if he was able to stop it.

"Wait, Kacchan!" Izuku instinctively reaches out and grabs his wrist.

Instantly, tension wrings his companion to silence.

Katsuki digs his heels into the mat and glares over his shoulder, barely hanging onto what's left of his patience.

Izuku quickly releases his arm and waves his hands, desperately shoving down the anxiety churning in his gut.

The targeted gym members stare blankly for a moment before quickly scurrying off, zipping up their jackets and tugging along clanking water bottles. Izuku breathes a sigh of relief, even as Katsuki glares vicious holes into him.

It's almost surreal, being able to feel someone's glare like this.

"You sure threaten people a lot for no reason," Izuku mutters. "They weren't doing anything wrong." He shrugs. "Why do you do that? You've been acting so… paranoid. Beating up Nero Edmure on the train, threatening random people in the gym, dragging me along to find people in Isabori for no rhyme or reason, and now you're trying to *train me*? For *what*?"

He hadn't expected to say all of this aloud.

However, as Katsuki straightens his shoulders, Izuku can read far more than just a flicker of surprise flash across the other's features.

A sneer curls Katsuki's lips. He glares intently at the ground.

"You don't need to fucking worry about it."

Izuku's hands ball into fists.

Fine. Don't tell me anything.

He turns on his heel, picks up his gloves, and slips them back on without acknowledging Katsuki.

He can still feel Katsuki's glare, as incredibly sharp and fiery as it usually is, though at the moment he can't bring himself to care. He wants to inflict whatever damage he can on this giant leather punching bag.

However, just as he's about to move, he stops, and blinks at the presence of a rather familiar figurine setting down a pair of weights.

He's almost unrecognizable outside of his uniform, with the white shirt and track pants, though the half-white, half-crimson hair says quite enough for Izuku's jumbled mind.

Todoroki? He frowns. *What's he doing here?*

The last time he'd been able to talk to Shouto Todoroki was on the train drifting from Isabori to Redmond, the conversation light and almost wistful. He remembers Todoroki being open and willing to help him, showing concern about his apparent relationship with the Bakugous, or lack thereof. He had said too much, potentially placing both Katsuki and his parents in danger, but Todoroki had been more than cordial enough to understand.

Or was that a ruse, as well?

"Oi. Deku."

Izuku turns away from Todoroki as Katsuki comes into his line of vision. The other teen is rolling back his shoulders and cracking his knuckles, a determined frown set on his lips.

He steps next to Izuku and flicks his head to the other punching bag beside him.

"Watch me."

It takes a few seconds for Izuku to calm his rapidly beating heart.

Todoroki is a mere hundred steps or so away.

Maybe if we're lucky, he won't notice.

He crosses his arms behind his back.

"R-Right. Sure, Kacchan." He nods his head.

He's not sure of the exact motives behind Katsuki dragging him into this training regime with hardly any explanation, though the fact that Katsuki is not only assessing his moves and critiquing them, but bothering to give a demonstration, warms Izuku in a way that ignites something unfamiliar beneath his skin.

After several minutes, his own sweat feels cold on his back. He grabs a towel on the mat next to Katsuki's bag, loping it over his shoulders and allowing the cool fabric to brush the nape of his neck. He wishes, with his tightly wound fingers and quivering insides, that he would remember the stress ball that relieved his overriding emotions.

He pops open his water bottle, also filled to the brim with ice-cold water—could Katsuki have filled both of their bottles?—and glances up slightly through his lashes to observe Katsuki's form.

However, just as Katsuki is about to throw a punch, he stops, turning like clockwork to glare with a gobsmacked, livid expression to something—or some*one*—behind Izuku.

“Midoriya?”

Izuku stiffens, and squeaks.

“Todoroki! Hello!”

He almost trips over Katsuki’s bag as he whips around, towel nearly flying off his shoulders.

Todoroki has dared to even step onto the blue mat where Izuku and Katsuki are training, his own clothes slick with sweat.

However, Todoroki’s heterochromatic glare is not directed towards Izuku, despite how closely he stands.

Izuku swallows.

To his flagrant surprise, Todoroki delivers a firm, cold nod towards the other teen in question. Katsuki is frozen as if he’s seen the most anger-inducing ghost in his life, caught between a frigid grip on some haywire thread that none of them can see.

“Bakugou.”

Katsuki breathes through his nostrils.

Izuku looks between them, the tension thick enough to slice through with a knife.

Whatever has transpired between these two, and whatever has caused the both of them to react this way in public, Izuku knows that it can’t possibly be good if they’re addressing each other in this way.

“The fuck are *you* doing here, *Half N’ Half*?”

The venom that coils through each syllable, and poisonous smirk that Katsuki wears should be enough to warn Todoroki away from the premises. His fists are clenched so tightly that his veins nearly bulge through his strong, bare arms.

“I was unaware that you were acquainted with Midoriya.”

Izuku frowns at this. “What? I—I had told you that I met Kacchan, Todoroki.”

He blinks at his own usage of Katsuki’s nickname—he shouldn’t have said that, not to someone who’s apparently shared some form of history with Katsuki.

“Hm. I don’t remember asking for your fucking opinion, you candy cane prima donna," says Katsuki.

Katsuki growls and stomps over towards them.

He shoves Izuku aside with a firm bump to his shoulders, momentarily sending Izuku a sideways glare before instantly focusing back onto Todoroki.

Izuku's chest feels encased in ice and steel.

Should he do something? What could he say? What was going to happen with completely innocent bystanders if these two managed to exceed the limits of their own self-control?

Izuku had never seen Todoroki's stare so blank and frigidly before, mirroring the darkest elements of a student whom everyone admired in Yuuei High School.

Yet, Katsuki's head is tilting ever so slightly to the side, his glare inquisitive. Demoralizing.

Izuku had been subjected to this exact glare once, in the Bakugou household under accusation of being an Isabori spy.

"What are you two doing here, then?" Todoroki stares at the punching bags. "Training? For less traditional scouting? What kind of danger are you willing to put Midoriya through? For that matter, I was able to notice from quite a distance that he is injured as well. Is that also your doing?"

His brow furrows, taking one step forward and easily mirroring the loud aggression in Katsuki's posture.

Izuku blinks. "Wait, what?"

He thinks Katsuki…?

Why would Todoroki immediately assume that Katsuki was the one responsible for Izuku's injuries?

Katsuki's snarl is slow and grating. "Mind your own fucking business. Deku has his own brain. He *chooses* to tag along. Whatever happens is up the fuck to him." He smirks. "Heh, fucking coward. You want to get in a real fight, let's have a real fight. I'll kick your fucking ass, like every other time."

"Funny. I don't remember losing to the likes of a frustrated dandelion like yourself. You are too sensitive to handle your role in Augustana, Bakugou." Todoroki calmly steps backward, turning towards Izuku with a risen eyebrow. "We should talk—"

"*Fuck off*, Half N' Half!"

Katsuki snaps his jaws and places himself between them. His chest is puffed up, head held high.

A defensive, angry shield.

Izuku nearly falls back, blinking owlishly to confirm the surreal vision that's happening in front of him.

Every word he wants to say dying easily on his tongue like wisps of smoke.

“You little *fucker*," growls Katsuki, fuming, "you were *watching* us!”

“You have no basis for your accusations, Bakugou. I doubt that you'd know how to properly handle Midoriya’s company—”

"Oh yeah? And how the fuck is that *your business*?" Katsuki's fists open and close. "You wanna go? Oh, because *we will*. You walk in on my territory, you're asking for it. I'll wipe the fucking *floor* with you."

Izuku balks at him. "*Eh*? No, wait, guys—"

"I think we both know how that would turn out." Todoroki's mouth presses into a line, face smooth with boredom.

"Say that again, Icy Hot, I *dare you*—"

“*Todoroki*.”

Both teens stiffen at this.

Izuku calmly steps between them, pushing them aside with his hands on their chests. This position, while oddly familiar, seems more subdued. It’s alien to feel his fingers press against the two people on opposing sides, yet their glares do not waver from one another.

Katsuki recoils, tightly wound, and Todoroki remains calm and complacent.

Izuku then releases them, and nods towards Todoroki, dipping his head just enough to clasp his hands together in an apologetic gesture.

“I really do appreciate your concern. Honestly.” He pauses. “That being said, I trust Kacch—Katsuki, enough, for him to try to show me to how to defend myself. You and I both know that Isabori is a tense district, and our mothers happen to know each other through mutual means, and over a years-long friendship. I trust their judgment, and so far Katsuki hasn’t led me into serious trouble that we couldn't handle. These injuries are my fault because I rushed headfirst into danger to try and help him in a situation that wouldn’t have turned out okay if I waited.”

Katsuki’s first name rolling off his tongue is unfamiliar, though he quickly pushes this thought aside before he distracts himself.

“S-So,” he gulps slightly, “just, try to trust my word for it. Thank you, again, for being concerned. And, we can talk some other time, when I’m done training here. Katsuki even, um, just helped me out on the train. I was being…” What was the right word for it? “Harassed, erm, or something like that? I’m not really sure. B-But anyway, he was there, and helped me out when no one else on the tram would’ve been able to do anything. He did it on his own accord. So, I trust him.”

When he finishes, the slight, strange moment of silence that envelops all three of them is awkward enough to be palpable.

Izuku moves away from his position between Todoroki and Katsuki, yet this time both of their gazes are following him. Perplexed. Bewildered.

The smug, dare he say *elated*, smirk Katsuki is wearing is enough to tell Izuku that he's made the correct decision to say something.

"I would also appreciate it if you didn't talk about me like I wasn't here."

His heart thumps at remembering Uraraka's request for the same thing when Katsuki bothered dragging him out of the coffee shop with barely a word of explanation left behind.

Without another word, Izuku reaches down, grabs his belongings, and heads into the locker rooms with a burning face and rapidly sweating hands.

Whatever they have left to say, they can sort it out themselves.

Izuku has always hated locker rooms.

The strange, close proximity he was often forced into while being squished into tight spaces with other boys his age, most of them almost always stronger and taller than him, had never boded well in elementary and middle school.

His mother was never insistent on him waiting until after school hours to come home and change and shower in his own apartment, letting the water run in gentle currents through his curls and wash away his instilled anxieties and moments of unsureness. Yet, over their dinner table, with his hand fumbling over the fork as he was unable to grasp onto any form of appetite, he had never been able to look his mother in the eye and tell her the truth.

I need to get over these things.

Izuku sighs and pulls his shirt over his head, grimacing at the feeling of cotton slipping off his skin, slimy with dried sweat. He ruffles his hair, hesitating as he glimpses around the corner to see if anyone's in the vicinity. With a sigh, he purses his lips at the meticulously arranged security latch on his locker.

"… What number was it again?" He mumbles, tapping his chin. "Oh! Right." He grins and presses the assorted keys. The door clicks and swings open automatically. He blinks in awe. "Wow, that's so cool…" He grins widely and places his bottle and towel inside the compartment. "Okay, just a quick shower, then maybe Kacchan will be ready to leave—"

"You really are fucking useless if you can't even figure out an automatic security lock."

Izuku squeaks, a red blush blooming over his cheeks. His arms flail beside him, the action far too instinctive for him to stop automatically.

“Kacchan! You, why would you do that? You scared me!”

“Pussy.” Katsuki clicks his tongue, and as he does so, Izuku notices something rather peculiar about the way Katsuki is standing.

Since he’s met Katsuki, Izuku has taken considerable notes on how the other acts, how he speaks, how he moves with his Quirk, without his Quirk, and so forth. His entry in his journals were littered with question marks and empty bullet points that begged to be filled soon. With that in mind, it was second nature for Izuku to take time to observe how the other walks.

Katsuki Bakugou is a person who walks in long, lazy strides, hands often in his pockets, a slouch to his shoulders that show confidence and smugness despite the standoffish image. He’s an image carved in sharp angles, in both physical features and human motions. His Quirk is just as energetic and temperamental as he is, matching the level of his screams, expletives, and the integral spikiness to his ashen hair.

Though, at this very moment, Katsuki is leaning against the entrance to the locker room, his gym bag now unceremoniously dropped onto the tiled, wet floors. His hands are shoved into his pockets, one leg crossed over the other. His head is tilted just a few inches to the side, his eyes no longer hardened with boiling, competitive rage, but something Izuku hasn’t seen before.

There’s an overwhelming aura of subtlety now swallowing up the blond’s features, turning his stern frown into a shadow of something... neutral. *Content*.

Izuku flushes upon realizing that the other male is, rather slowly, drawing his eyes up Izuku’s form, momentarily resting on his stomach, his chest, and then his shoulders. Studying him. Analyzing him. A stare that Izuku has never seen, nonetheless *felt*, yet it sends delighted pinpricks flaring under his skin.

Katsuki folds his arms over his broad chest, and then finds Izuku’s eyes.

“Only gonna ask this once, so pay fucking attention.”

Izuku holds his breath.

“Um—”

“Why’d you take my side?”

Izuku pauses at this. He closes his mouth, pondering.

He has several potential answers to that particular question, yet as he cycles through them, none of these conclusions make enough sense for him to say them out loud.

Would any of these possible answers he could give put him in another dark place against Katsuki? Against the Bakugous in general? Was there still a strange, dangerous line he could cross without knowing the consequences?

“Think carefully about your answer, Deku.”

A bolt of electricity shoots up Izuku’s spine. He braces himself, recognizing the slow, intimidating way Katsuki motions over to him. He’s stronger, taller, broader—he could easily hurt him if he wanted to, even when recovering from his own injuries, boldly removing bandages that still technically needed to dress his days-old wounds.

Katsuki is close, now. Hovering.

Dangerous.

He leans down to Izuku, prompting the freckled teen to flop onto the bench in front of the lockers, staring up with a clenched jaw and tight throat into that intimidating glare. A look meant to instill fear into its targets as easily as flipping a switch.

Katsuki’s forearm is pressed to the lockers above Izuku’s head, his other hand calmly in one pocket as he leans down, his frown still firm, still threatening.

Still teeming with the silent flames of Bakugou blood.

“You don’t scare me, Kacchan.”

Izuku’s hands grip into the wooden bench beside him.

“I meant what I said. My mom and I… we’re involved in your family now. I believe what you said about you wanting to help Augustana be a better place. You haven’t lied to me yet.” He pauses, considering. “I feel like you trust me, too.”

Katsuki’s unreadable frown finally breaks. The left side of his mouth curls up, baring just the slightest flash of canines.

“You don’t think I’d turn on you? You don’t think I’d leave you behind if you even tried yapping your mouth and letting out our secrets?”

Izuku stares directly into Katsuki’s eyes.

“No. I don’t think you would.”

Katsuki squints, his smirk vanishing.

“And I wouldn’t turn on you, anyway.” Izuku bites his lip. “I mean, you’ve never struck me as a bad person, Kacchan. I doubt I could ever even consider betraying you like that.”

Katsuki ponders this, pupils flickering across Izuku’s features as if assessing each individual freckle.

Then, he snorts, leaning back and promptly taking a seat beside Izuku on the bench. He closes his eyes, leaning his head against the lockers and resting his intertwined fingers in his lap.

Izuku holds back a grin.

“I’m guessing that’s an acceptable answer?”

“Fuck off.” His lips twitch despite himself. “You’re fucking full of yourself, you little shit.”

Izuku barks out a laugh. “If anything, Kacchan, I think you’re the one who’s full of yourself.”

“Wrong again, shitnerd. You’re deluded to be full of yourself. I’m fucking awesome so obviously my point of view is validated.”

Katsuki leans forward, and Izuku is instantly drawn to the firm line in Katsuki’s back, so clearly visible through the tight fabric of his black workout top.

“And you suck at throwing punches. Jesus. It was painful to watch that shit-fest. But, it’s not a lost cause, I guess.” He snorts, rolling his eyes.

"Oh, come on." Izuku grins, leaning his head back against the wall. "I wasn't that bad."

"It was disgraceful." Katsuki shrugs. "Whatever. Progress, I guess."

Izuku desperately tries to ignore the flutter in his stomach.

"Wow. Um." He stares at the back of Katsuki's head, considering. "That's... that's probably the closest to a compliment I'll ever get, huh."

Katsuki doesn't even twitch when he says: "Don't push it."

Izuku barks out a laugh, the tension in his shoulders receding. Just slightly.

A comfortable silence drifts between them.

Izuku bites his lip, rubbing the back of his neck.

“I... I do have a question, though.”

Katsuki says nothing, which Izuku takes as an invitation to continue.

“What did Nero say to you to get you to freak out like that?”

Instantly, Katsuki’s relaxed form tenses up.

He jerks up from the bench and refuses to glance at him as he roughly pulls his top over his head—an action that immediately sends Izuku into near-cardiac arrest—and grabs his gym bag.

“Fucking motherfucker Buzzcut Fuckface said things he shouldn’t have said," says Katsuki, holding back from clearly entering another plane of anger that Izuku would rather not touch at this moment.

Still, the hostility radiating from Katsuki is more than what the freckled teen expects.

“Um. Alright.” He frowns. “I mean, you just seem really tense—”

“I’m not fucking tense! Why would I be fucking *tense*?”

“I, uh," Izuku hesitates, "well. I mean, Kacchan—”

“Fuck you! I’m *not tense*.”

“Okay, you’re not tense—”

“That’s right I’m not you fucking piece of shit!”

Katsuki fumes and looms over Izuku, jabbing his finger into his chest, and both stare directly into each other’s eyes with far too much ferocity for Izuku to handle without his stomach doing solid backflips in his chest.

Katsuki is shirtless, close, and breathing hotly through gritted teeth.

Izuku can see every rippling muscle, every taut vein, every twitch and barely constrained burst of energy that Katsuki is struggling to contain within himself as he encloses on Izuku’s personal space.

Even the finger viciously jabbed into his bare chest causes a thunderous shiver to coil and spread through his muscles, his blood, his *bones*.

“Answer me fucking honestly, *nerd*,” growls Katsuki.

Izuku gulps.

“Has that *fucker* ever done that shit before?”

Izuku frowns at the question, and rolls his eyes. "You're going to be have to be more specific."

"You fucking know what I mean!" Katsuki groans.

"Are you talking about Nero?" Izuku raises an eyebrow.

"No. The *other* squadron leader who was eye-fucking you on the train," Katsuki deadpans, looking far past his limit.

Izuku blinks. Slowly.

“I—what are you talking about, Kacchan? He wasn't...” He trails off, considering.

“*Deku*." Katsuki groans in misery. "You can’t fucking tell me you *don’t know*.”

Izuku purses his lips.

The context of the two of them discussing all of this in the middle of the locker rooms at a pristine gym center in Sommartyn District fails to dawn on Izuku, even as he cycles through his encounters with Nero Edmure.

“I mean, I never really wandered into Illenova that much. I met him officially for the first time with you, a few days ago.” He tilts his head. “He was only… *weird*, like, that, on the train.”

Katsuki snarls and glances away. “I. Fuck. I fucking knew that—just, how the fuck can you be so stupid? And quit looking at me like that, fuckface!" He runs his hands through his spikes.

Izuku bites his tongue to keep himself from smiling; he knows that will only anger Katsuki more.

“Fucking forget it! We didn’t have this conversation! And why the fuck are you just sitting on that bench like a loser? Get in the fucking shower so we can get out of here!”

Izuku blanches. “W-Wait, what? Kacchan!” He shakes his head. “I’m not—not, not with you here!”

He can hardly even picture the two of them in the same vicinity. He can barely even handle Katsuki on his lonesome with only his shirt off.

“Not like *that* you fucking pervert.” Katsuki rolls his eyes. “I’ll wait outside. Just, get clean or something, dammit! And keep your mind out of the fucking gutter! It’s not like I’ve thought about you naked before or anything!”

Izuku’s jaw drops.

A few seconds pass.

They as well have been eons.

Katsuki freezes, realization clicking like firelight along his features. He tenses, his entire body turning redder than the ripest summer tomato Izuku could imagine.

“… You’ve—”

In that second, Izuku finds his back pinned to the wall, the blond’s hand ferociously grappling his throat and holding him there. It’s not enough pressure for the gesture to be lethal, but the warning is clear as the most brittle winter night, instilling some odd mixture of confusion and bashfulness within Izuku.

“You say another word and I will *end* you.”

Izuku slowly nods.

When Katsuki releases him, he storms off with his gym bag and towel, still completely shirtless, and rather blatantly flipping the bird to employees and strangers alike walking into the showers.

Izuku blinks, recounting the previous events that transpired. Aside from wondering if Todoroki was still in the vicinity at all, there are far too many questions buzzing in the back of his mind.

"… What just happened?"

The lights are still on the moment Izuku walks back through the front doors. He holds his breath, silently turning the lock to the entrance and quietly assessing the faded amber and orange glow from the kitchen table. His mother's bookkeeping documents are still spread out, several foldable moving boxes stacked beside the chairs.

Izuku softly smiles, sending a quick text off through his phone before setting it on the table.

[*To: Kacchan Bakugou*]

- *I know you hate it when I text you back even though you send me a million messages at a time, but thanks for dropping off my stuff. And for getting me a ticket back to Isabori. I know it was you. Don't even try to pretend.*

He rolls his eyes.

He'll be receiving an angry series of voice messages before he even wakes up, yet the thought alone makes him wonder if it's worth documenting in his journals.

Calmly, Izuku walks over to the table and gathers his mother's bookkeeping folders, pens, stacks of assorted papers, folders, and several other objects that should be placed away in drawers. He sets them back in their organized clusters that he normally comes home to if his mother is still working out of the office.

Then, he lifts the lid to one of the boxes set aside the table—

His heart jumps to his throat. Even under the faded light flickering overhead, casting muted rustic light onto the wooden tabletop, Izuku can spot this object as easily as anything else in the clearest spring morning.

Slowly—*trembling*—he reaches into the box, through layers and layers of paper and plastic, and pulls out an object that glints with a dark, metallic silver barrel.

He swallows the lump in his throat, and turns his head to the darkened hallway where he can see his mother's lights are turned off in her own bedroom.

He looks back to the object in his hands. It's heavier than he had expected, but his thoughts are racing at such a pace that he can hardly piece everything together at once.

Why would Mom…

His entire body trembles as he sets it on the table, closing his eyes to shut out the paranoid voices trickling into his mind.

His question is voiced aloud, a ghostly whisper only he can hear through these thin walls.

"Why would she have a gun…?"

Thunderstruck

Chapter Summary

Katsuki raises an eyebrow, holding a massive bucket of popcorn under his arm. He pops a piece in his mouth and chews, refusing to glance at Izuku as they both make their way through the shadowed hall. It’s not crowded in this theater, with the definitive leather cushion seats reeking with mildew musk.

Izuku tugs at his collar.

He hadn’t expected his afternoon to turn out like this at all.

Chapter Notes

Longest chapter yet, folks! And probably my favorite so far. Lots of fluff in this one, with more questions, and stuff happens, and all that jazz. Hopefully it's not utter shit.

Thank you everyone for being so supportive in all of these chapters! Honestly, it means so much more than you know! It warms my heart to see all of these beautiful comments, and seeing how much these chapters impact some of you... it blows my mind. Thank you. From the bottom of my heart.

Hope you enjoy!

The porridge bobs in lifeless clumps.

The longer Izuku stares into the bowl, the more tempted he is to continuously tilt the container side by side and test whether or not his breakfast is actually edible.

The wet grains stare back at him through layers of frozen blueberries, a dollop of cinnamon and a teaspoon of sugar, meticulously placed by his mother’s own hand.

Izuku’s hand trembles around his spoon as he takes a tentative bite of his food. Beside him, Inko stirs through her eggs and sausage in absentminded circles, her free hand flipping through cut-out newspaper clippings. Several books are splayed out across the table, sample paragraphs underlined in blue marker and labeled with heart-shaped Post-It notes.

Izuku swallows another mouthful of porridge, grimacing at the bland, forcefully sweet taste. He watches his mother quietly as she works and eats, noting the tremble in her hands and the

distinctive femininity and frailness he's recognized in her movements since he was young.

His throat dries as his mind harkens back to the feeling of the gun in his hands, the metallic surface brushing smoothly under his caressing thumb.

Should I ask her?

"Is something wrong, Izuku?" Inko's smile is warm and beaming.

Her soft green eyes glisten with life that Izuku had not seen before they'd reconnected with the Bakugous. For reasons unknown to him, the lurching in his chest and the newfound sparkle in his mother's smiles remind him why he wakes up each day and continues pursuing his dreams.

"N-No," he says, grinning weakly. He turns back to his bowl and prods through the soaked grains with little interest. He's lost his appetite. "Was just thinking. About something. Nothing important. I—oh, Uraraka and I are still discussing what we want to do about the next paper issue."

Inko nods at this. "She's a sweet girl. Very talented writer, from what I've seen." She sets down her fork and eyes Izuku's bowl. "Izuku, honey, when you said you wanted to try my homemade oatmeal, I would think you would tell me if you hated it."

Izuku frantically waves his arm. "N-No! It's not like that at all, Mom! I like it a lot! Just, not hungry. At the moment. Sorry."

He swallows the lump in his throat and curiously digs through his porridge, scooping up a lukewarm lump and popping it in his mouth. His mother blinks, yet says nothing as he continues to chew and stare out the parted blinds into the outside world. He wonders, if he keeps shoveling porridge—or oatmeal, whatever his mother insists it should be called—into his mouth, he can silence both his muttering and the jumbled questions rolling around in his mind.

"So."

Izuku freezes, halfway between another bite. He pauses and lowers the utensil. His skin prickles and his fingers twitch, itching for something to write with. He stares at his mother, watching as she picks up her monogrammed napkin and folds it in one hand, occupying her other hand with turning the pages in her paper-clipped documents.

"You've been spending quite a lot of time with Katsuki."

Izuku blinks.

"Um."

Yes?

"Uh. Yeah. He just… he's been showing me around. And stuff."

Inko bites the inside of her cheek.

“I see.”

Izuku stares at her blankly.

“Mom. What are you getting at?”

Despite the drop in his stomach expecting otherwise, the crinkling around his mother’s mouth betrays a secretive smile.

She sips at her glass of water and turns back to her books, shaking her head. Even now, Izuku can hardly understand how a woman with this much natural grace and poise—albeit coupled with inherent awkwardness and stuttering—could possibly be able to own or even wield a gun.

Yet, her statement lingers, heavy in the air.

He wipes his hands down his pajama pants, twirling the fork in his other hand in absentminded circles.

“You shouldn’t be out all the time, seeking trouble like that. I worry that you’ll come home and wind up even worse than you did before…” Inko closes her book, tucking a strand of hair behind her ear. “Sometimes, it seems like you’re not aware of how much danger you’re actually in.” Her shoulders shake as she props her chin in her hands. “Isabori isn’t a safe place for that…”

Izuku’s stomach backflips. He holds back the reassuring gestures, the gentle words he wants to soothe his mother with in order to reset her to the smiling, bubbly person he’d known her to be.

To know that he’s the current reason for the bags under her eyes and the tired stretch to her frowns makes his knees buckle in his own chair.

Izuku licks his lips, pondering.

“I—we don’t… voluntarily look for it. I’m really sorry, about that day. About what happened. It was just a fluke and it all kind of got out of control and I know that it wasn’t the best way to handle things, but,” he pauses, considering, “I think he’s trying to help? I mean, you said something similar about you and his mom, right?”

Inko hums at this. For once, Izuku finds his mother to be unreadable, from the firm crinkle on the bridge of her nose to the subdued twitching in her lips. She’s caught between two bridges of thought that he wishes to connect on his own accord, but lacking the materials to put the actual wooden planks and glue together.

“Mitsuki and I have a very strong history together, yes.” She stands up from her chair, grabbing her plate and Izuku’s bowl. “But from how much time you’re spending with him, it makes a mother wonder.” She winks, discrete and entirely unexpected, and it causes Izuku’s skin to spontaneously redden with hidden flames.

He squeaks. “I—wait, Mom, no, *no,* ah, it’s nothing like that—”

“Oh, Izuku.” Inko giggles from her place in the kitchen, dumping leftover food in the trash bin before setting the dishes in the sink. “It’s normal to have a crush on someone like Katsuki. The Bakugous… have this way about them. I understand the pull.”

Izuku’s eyes widen, and she seems to notice this enough for her own smile to grow. Wide and teasing and merciless.

Ugh.

“The only reason you’re not *both* grounded is because Katsuki was willing to stay here for an entire day while you were resting. He refused to leave until you woke up, and even helped me clean the apartment and do the laundry. I almost thought he was guilty. After that… incident.” She shakes her head. “But you should know better. I won’t tolerate anything like that in the future.”

Izuku tilts his head. “Mom…”

“I’m serious, Izuku.” Inko sighs. “Even if you and Katsuki—just, oh goodness, I can hardly think of that as a mother. But, if you’re dating… sweetheart, you can’t be doing those things. You *can’t* be going against the district rules.”

She’s trembling now, one hand fisting the cloth of her apron and the other resting on the sink nozzle.

Izuku ignores the dreaded heart attack he can feel breaching his concentration from the word *dating*, despite how desperately his skin bursts into sweat from the implications.

The memory of him and Katsuki in the locker rooms three weeks back, staring up into that angry glare and scowl, tracing each curve of every muscle—

He flushes and turns back around in his chair.

He paws back his bangs and exhales.

What else is there to even say to his mother other than another desperate apology? And now, if she even considers the possibility of him and Katsuki somehow forming *that* kind of relationship… it was simply ludicrous.

“We’re not *dating.*"

Oh, nice Izuku. Maybe next time you can try not to squeak. Dear God.

Inko places her hand on her hip, one eyebrow risen.

“I swear, we’re not!” He sighs. “Mom, I’m sorry, really, for everything. And for worrying you. I never stay out late enough for any hustlers to find me or charge me extra tolls, or anything like that. I don’t usually have trouble around it. Most of the time Uraraka and I have

permission from the education board to interview people outside of tolling hours, and that's the only time I've done it." He scratches his cheek. "Kacchan and I are…"

He blinks, pondering.

Were they friends? Acquaintances? He's never been able to pinpoint exactly what they were.

Yet, Katsuki's threats have quickly grown from terrifying to somewhat empty, especially in light of him no longer suspecting him of being a spy.

"Kacchan?" Inko blinks.

Izuku blushes. "I—um. It's a… nickname."

"Oh, right! I remember you calling him something like that during our first dinner." She muffles a giggle behind her hand. "How cute!"

Izuku groans. "*Mom*."

He's surprised that he's still able to get away with as much as he has, given how volatile and dangerous Katsuki claims himself to be, on top of his surprising awkwardness and secret adoration for All-Might.

Inko shakes her head, a fond smile on her lips. "Can't be too angry for long, I guess." She shrugs her shoulders. "There's no shame in liking him, Izuku, sweetie. He's a very handsome young man." Her smile grows wider at Izuku's stuttering. "But you stay safe, now—"

"*Oh my god*, Mom!" Izuku squeaks, standing up from his chair. "It's not like that! A-at all!"

"Alright. If you say so, sweetie."

"Mom, that's not…"

This isn't what I need to talk to you about.

The gun.

When could he confront her? Now? When she's somber but uplifted? Or later, after she's surely more stressed and cornered against her own backdrop of emotions? Would he able to converse with her at all later about anything resembling violence of any kind? Was the gun even supposed to be in the apartment? Was it somehow a mistake, and he'd assumed incorrectly? Perhaps the gun wasn't hers at all?

Not now.

He sighs, caught between his mortified embarrassment and his confusion from discovering the gun the night before. He'd barely been able to look his mother in the eye at all since bidding each other good morning, less than an hour ago. The sleep still stings under his eyes and he hasn't brushed his teeth, but he feels as if he's walked through a tidal wave in just his clothes and blind sense of direction for multiple days on end.

“Oh, I almost forgot.” Inko wags her finger in the air. “Your friend, Uraraka, actually called and asked where you've been the last few weekends, since you didn’t have your phone with you. She mentioned that you left all of your stuff behind in that café you like to go to at one point?” She tilts her head. "Did you ever get your stuff back?"

Izuku rubs his neck. “Yeah…”

I really need to talk to Uraraka.

“I’ll call her back. In a few minutes. I’m sorry you had to deal with that.” He pauses. "Wait, no, Kacchan grabbed my stuff for me and dropped them off here the night I had to leave our session early. I've been, um, kind of preoccupied with other things. Schedule's been busy on Sundays. So she didn't have to worry about that..."

Inko's green eyes sparkle. "Oh, is that so?"

Izuku's cheeks puff up. His skin prickles.

He could never win against her in something like this.

"He just. I dunno. Maybe he felt bad?"

Except that was extremely unlikely, on almost every account.

"Hm. Perhaps. Or, he wanted to do you a favor. Or impress you. Since, you could be dating, and just too embarrassed to tell me."

Even more unlikely.

"We are *not dating*, Mom!" Izuku squeaks.

Inko hums at this, and with a definitive smack of her lips, she nods at him. "Maybe you should hang out with your other friends more. Keep some space between you and Katsuki for a bit. It almost seems like you boys have been inseparable these past few weeks. With... whatever you've been doing.”

Izuku flushes, but there’s hardly any room for denial on the tip of his tongue. Sighing, he motions towards his bedroom and nods at his mother.

“I’ll call her, really quick.”

He turns the corner before his mother can say anything else, the image of the gun flashing in his mind’s eye long after he closes the door to his room.

"Wow. I almost started thinking you died. How tragic would that be."

"Uraraka, I'm so, so sorry."

He flops back down on his bed, staring contemplatively up towards his ceiling, where numerous posters stretched across show All-Might's beaming smile.

He rolls his eyes, wondering just how many collectibles he has strung about his room, before tuning back in to what his friend is saying on the other side of the phone.

"Yeah, you owe me. Again. Honestly, Izuku, what are you doing with people like that? You just kind of left me high and dry and—okay, forget about just how… weird that was to begin with. But, why didn't you tell him off? You just left with him like you're actual friends or something. And you haven't really talked to me all that much at all since then!"

Izuku hesitates. His grip tightens on his phone.

He replays Uraraka's words in his mind, tempering past the slight barrier of rumbling static.

"We, um, kind of are." He pauses. "But, it's not—he's not as bad as you think. He's actually helped me a lot these last few weeks, and, I *do* owe him for helping me out of a couple rough spots."

"You don't owe him anything, Izuku. He just sounds like trouble to me, but, I can't control who you hang out with or anything. I just worry about you."

He nods. "I know, Uraraka. You're one of my best friends." He sighs. "I'm sorry I haven't been there the last few weeks. It's been crazy." He considers his mother's words, wondering if the small voices pressing in the back of his mind are actually going to make him do this. "I was wondering. Um. Are you… are you or Iida, or anyone else, doing anything today?"

He hears muffled rustling on the other line. Glass and porcelain being shoved out of what Izuku assumes to be cupboards.

"Is this a bad time?"

"Um, nope! Just putting things away."

Izuku's brow furrows. "Are you off from school today too?"

"Ah—my dad hasn't been feeling that great, so I'm taking care of him today. Yuuei understands. Are you still off because of your injuries?"

Izuku groans. The amount of arguing he'd gone through with his mother to let him go back to school almost led to him being grounded. He'd always considered it so backwards with how insistent his mother wanted him to stay behind while he'd always begged to be released to go to school, despite the bullying and pestering from students he'd rather never see again.

“Yeah. Just for today, though. Had to negotiate with my mom about it. You know how she can be.” He grins slightly as Uraraka giggles on the other line. “So, after school hours, then? Do you want to go do something later?”

Uraraka hums, feigning indecision.

He rolls his eyes, yet resists the slight, fond smirk dressing his lips.

He knows how important this is to her, and even to him, to have this conversation in light of all that occurred in the span of a few weeks.

He needed to make this up to her, somehow.

“Well, I was going to go to the mall with Tsuyu after she was done with classes. Pretty sure we could all go in a bigger group if you want? It’s been a long time since we’ve hung out with the others in our class. With the newspaper and you being gone and everything.”

Izuku chuckles bashfully at this. “Right. Again, sorry about that.”

“You can make it up to me by showing up! I’m sure everyone else will be happy to see you too.”

Izuku muffles a laugh behind his hand. “Yeah. Okay. That’s fair.”

“So. Now, I have a question.”

Izuku purses his lips. He stretches his arms and folds one behind his head while propping the phone in the other. It feels somewhat alien, to have this stretch of relaxation and silence specifically allowed for himself, after a hectic week spent with plenty of one-on-one time with Katsuki.

He almost rolls his eyes at his own thoughts.

No wonder my mom is suspicious…

“So, is Bakugou… is he, um…” Izuku blinks at the long, strenuous pause between them. He hears a frustrated huff on the other side, and can picture Uraraka’s cheeks puffed out in anger as she rifles through the questions she wishes to ask him. *“Izuku, are you guys dating? Is that what this is all about?”*

Izuku gapes. “No! Why—oh my God. No. My mom just thought the same thing. *No*.” He drags his hand down his face. “No way. We—he’s my friend. That’s all. He’s…”

There are far too many images of Katsuki that replay in his mind, ranging from how strangely compliant he was next to him in the locker rooms after accepting something akin to defeat in their one-sided conversation. He remembers how the blond looked at the rumbling ground beneath him on the tram when handing him one of two water bottles. He remembers each visit in the gym, each encounter becoming coordinated and established, learning one move after the earth. He was getting stronger, learning more about combat and defense, and...

He'd put extra thought into having Izuku at his side during this span of time, whether he wanted to believe it or not.

Izuku's chest tightens.

He gulps, wondering if the sweat slicking into his shirt and the nervous thrumming of his heart is only attached to his nerves, or if it's also latched onto the admittedly handsome teenager he's spent all of his time with.

"You're pretty flustered for denying it—"

"Uraraka! We're. Not. *Dating*." Izuku sighs, albeit shakily. "He's… he's just a friend. I don't even think he has any other friends." He blinks at his own words.

Wow, that might actually be true.

Katsuki certainly hadn't mentioned anyone else as a constant in his life, and with his homeschooled background and attachment to his family's purpose in Augustana, perhaps he didn't even have time or even the desire to socialize outside of his normal boundaries.

"Say. Uraraka."

"... No."

Izuku pouts.

"Please? I swear, he's not that bad! I honestly think the guy just needs to see you and others in our class more often to trust them and who I hang out with. Not that—I mean, not that it matters all that much, but he's probably actually just insecure and needs some reassurance in that way? I don't, really know what I'm saying, but… um." He groans. "Just once? And if he's an ass then he can leave. But, I think this would be good for him. He has a… difficult home life."

For some reason, the thought of actually interacting with Katsuki in a group of people he could all consider to be genuine, casual friends, makes something inside him burst into life and erupt like a storm of butterflies.

"... I can't believe I'm saying this... fine. He can come! But, I can't promise that we have a backup plan if he acts out."

Izuku's smile is far too broad for him to contain.

"I promise, it'll go smoothly."

Another pause.

"Well, you did say you wanted to do a profile piece on him."

Izuku's jaw drops. He'd almost forgotten about that.

He can hardly contain his elation at the thought of having a successful, thorough interview with Katsuki and actually obtaining information that would be useful to his family, to Katsuki's family, to the community, to the entire city of Augustana—

The joy bubbling in his chest almost levels the idea of spending the afternoon with his friends, with a new companion borne from an entirely different world.

"Are you fucking *joking*?"

Izuku's impending excitement at Katsuki's agreeing to meet with him at the same café bistro where he'd abruptly crashed his newspaper meeting with Uraraka fizzles to nothingness.

He stares, exasperatingly, towards Katsuki as he shoves his hands into his pockets—*jean pockets*, Izuku notes with risen eyebrows and a glimmer of appreciation—and takes a seat in the booth across from him.

Izuku taps his fingers on the table, humming a tune under his breath with one half-finished milkshake propped off to the side. He assesses Katsuki's glare, allowing the silence to shift into a new topic as he thinks of a response that won't cause his friend to leave.

"Are you really that against hanging out with other people?"

"I don't *hang out*, shitty Deku. Is that what you think we've been doing?" He grunts. "You're supposed to text and call for emergencies only, shitnerd. I thought you were getting fucking squashed by a truck or kidnapped by squadron members!"

Izuku blinks. "You have… some imagination, Kacchan." He frowns. "How did you go from getting hit—no, *squashed*—by a truck to getting kidnapped by—"

"Does it fucking matter?" His glare is icy enough for Izuku to bite his tongue.

Katsuki snorts, leaning back in the booth and glaring off to the side, focusing on the ring in the middle of the café.

The heart of the bistro was serving milkshakes today, each elaborate drink topped with whipped cream and drizzled in rainbows of colorful sweet syrups. Light jazz music rumbles in the small, comfortable space, with the sound of light chatter from happy strangers nullifying Izuku's anxious thoughts.

After a poignant pause, Katsuki huffs and turns back to Izuku, at just enough of an angle for the sunlight to catch his locks of hair and turn the crown white-gold.

Izuku's breath hitches—just for a moment—before he scratches his cheek and hides his blush behind another slurp of his milkshake.

He can feel Katsuki's eyes burrowing into him, that calculated glare watching each movement he makes as he reluctantly grips the bottle-like cup between two hands. The coolness of his treat slipping through and numbing his palms and fingers should bother him, but it's a better way of cooling off than running to the bathroom and splashing his face with water.

"Spit it out, Deku. Why would your… *friends*, want to *hang out* with a Bakugou, hm?" Katsuki rolls his eyes. "I fucking know the kind of reputation we have, as inaccurate as it is."

"They're really nice people, and Uraraka's even willing to give you a chance to come with us at all. I vouched for you and everything." Izuku shrugs. "I mean, in her defense, you completely insulted her, in that table over there, and kidnapped me to force me into the gym in Illenova. Don't you think that warrants just a little bit of suspicion?"

Katsuki snorts. "Dunno, fucker. You tell me. Since you *know everything*." He cocks an eyebrow and leans forward, his elbow resting on the table and his chin propped on his hand. "I don't give a fuck for your reasons why, Deku. You make no fucking sense so this isn't a surprise."

Izuku tilts his head. "Well, you're my friend, Kacchan." He grins slightly, hoping that his blush isn't all the more obvious in the fluctuating lighting in the bistro. "Don't Bakugous even relax once in a while? Your parents do, don't they? I mean, that dinner we all had together. You, my mom, your mom, and me. That was… technically relaxing, right?"

Katsuki's glare only intensifies.

How is that even possible?

Izuku sighs. "You don't have to come, but, I mean, I would like it if you were there."

Perhaps it's the wrong thing to say, despite how truthful it is, and even he doesn't exactly understand the strange leaping in his chest at hearing the words play off his tongue.

Yet, the way Katsuki instantly tenses, his eyes widening just a fraction, and the way he slumps back and barks off a flurry of insults with a reddened face makes Izuku feel as if he's somehow won an unspoken argument.

"Don't give a fuck what you want, Deku."

"Uh-huh. Sure, Kacchan."

"Oh, *fuck off*."

Izuku shifts in his seat, holding back the smallest grin. The nerves still flutter under his skin, calling his attention and retreating just as quickly.

Despite the fact that he's engaged in conversation with Katsuki on several occasions—most of which leading to him being gratingly insulted—he'd fretted for a solid thirty minutes before coming to this very bistro about what he was going to wear.

And now, just with glancing over what Katsuki has bothered to put on, he knows he wasn't the only one.

There was no reason to be nervous at all, he'd reasoned, yet he'd still splayed out his twelve shirts that he considered to be halfway decent enough to wear in public that didn't have a superhero's face imprinted on the front. He'd opted for a simple yellow T-shirt, jeans, and his red sneakers, combing just once through his curls and hoping that he could show up on a nice warm day in a bistro without an extra layer and not feel self-conscious about it.

Yet, he's never seen Katsuki exactly like this either. The black, somewhat loose lank is imprinted with a massive smirking skull on the front, and the light brown leather jacket is easily shrugged off his powerful shoulders and looking rather fitting slumped over the booth's top. His low-hanging jeans and roughed sneakers add a dangerous image to a look that Izuku finds rather pleasing and fitting for his friend.

I need to stop.

His mother's words echo back to him.

"You done staring at me, yet? Fucking weirdo…"

"H-Hah?" Izuku squeaks.

He catches his milkshake glass once it stumbles in his startled hands.

"I—I wasn't staring!" He shakes his head. "Nope. Not at all! Just. Thinking. I was daydreaming and you happened to be in my path."

... I'm sweating so much.

Katsuki's smirk is purely mocking as he leans forward again, scooting his elbow to the middle of the table and tilting his chin high. From this close, Izuku spots the sliver of his shining white teeth—unfairly clean, in all honesty—and the shimmer of slight… *playfulness*, in the dark maroon depths of his eyes.

"You sure about that, Deku?"

Izuku presses his back to his own booth. Stiff as a plank of wood.

What in the world is he doing? What am I *doing? Oh my God, does this look like a date? Did I accidentally ask him on a date? No, no, that's not possible, there's no way—calm down Izuku. So he's attractive. You already knew that. Get a grip. This is crazy. What are you even thinking? You need to breathe and—wow he smells really good, I wonder what kind of cologne that is—*

Suddenly, Katsuki moves, standing up from the booth and abruptly cocking his head towards the bistro ring where the displays of coffee and tea drinks are colorfully printed on chalkboards.

Izuku is barely able to conjure up a complete sentence as Katsuki raises an eyebrow.

“I’m grabbing a fucking milkshake, then we’re getting this over with. Don't give a fuck.”

Izuku splutters and nearly chokes on his straw.

“U-Um…”

Say something!

Katsuki barks out a laugh.

“Useless, fucking nerd! Jesus Christ.”

He shakes his head as he saunters off, hands once again hanging out the loops of his belt, and Izuku can’t help but follow where he leaves, despite the strange tremors crawling through his arms, chest, and around his stomach.

He’s reduced to robotic nodding and squeaking when Katsuki returns, a strawberry milkshake safely contained in a Styrofoam cup. Katsuki says nothing, irritation shining clear on his sharp features after Izuku stammers like a buffoon and follows him out the door.

Even as Katsuki rambles about how incredibly pathetic this entire arrangement is, Izuku is unable to quell the realization that, if Katsuki truly wanted to leave, he would have done so by now.

... Did I just have a stroke?

Katsuki had, initially, been more than a little surprised at Izuku’s casual request in having a “get-together” with his so-called “friends from Yuuei High School.”

As far as Katsuki was concerned, he’d barely tolerated Izuku’s presence long enough to even step outside his own home—or away from his patrols and hidden work—to even scrape hours out of his schedule to help the useless nerd.

Despite this, the definite spike of sick enjoyment that sped through him at Izuku's blushing, stuttering face made him reconsider the possible torture he could put the freckled boy through while agreeing to something he would never otherwise consider doing.

It was also frankly irritating at how Izuku's appearance—as plain and uninteresting as the freckled boy was when compared to him, of all people—made Katsuki's chest constrict and his teeth grind a little harder than necessary.

He had already come close to crushing the cup in his hands and screaming profanities in the middle of the street when Izuku, for the life of him, could not stop talking to random pedestrians if they happened to have the "world's most adorable puppy" pawing at his jeans like they were marking him or something.

He'd yelled at two innocent puppies, and Izuku gave him the silent treatment for a solid ten minutes, until he remembered that Katsuki was subjected to the same cartoon as he was growing up, and decided to enter a tirade about that particular subject.

Katsuki's twitching brow and aggravated insults have apparently no effect on a determined and superhero-riled-up Izuku Midoriya, since the green-eyed boy's motor-mouth has no end in sight.

His eyes are glistening, shining, almost beneath not just the glare of the sun but the happiness accompanied with his conversation. His exaggerated hand-motions in describing details of scenes he's known since he was a child, and the analytical summaries he pulls out of seemingly nowhere when regarding classic villains and heroes strike Katsuki was both annoying and, oddly enough, quite interesting.

He's never doubted Izuku's intelligence, but the many subjects he can cover in one sitting with extreme, pinpointed detail, would be an incredibly useful skill in any line of work. Even in one similar to the likes of a Bakugou's daily concerns.

"… And, I also think, that maybe if Mount Lady was given more opportunities in the later seasons, we could see more of her character! I think her Quirk is amazing but still ultimately lacking in potential, you know? And that weird episode where she turned evil because of Doctor Plasmas. Hm. I don't know. That never really made sense to me—"

Katsuki shoves Izuku's face away, causing the shorter boy to stumble on the sidewalk. He laughs, crushing the emptied milkshake cup in his hands and tossing it to a public trashcan. Izuku groans, but refrains from lashing out as he comes back over to his side.

"So, what assholes are we meeting with, shitnerd?"

Izuku's temporary frown immediately washes away, and his grin is so broad and beaming that Katsuki swears he'll turn blind. Quickly, he glances away and grunts under his breath.

"Well, Uraraka will be there. Oh! And her friend, Tsuyu! She has a pretty strong obsession with frogs, and a passion for… amphibians and reptiles in general, but she's awesome, and one of the best competitors on Yuuei's swim team. Mina Ashido will be there, and she's nice,

and… wow I just realized there are a lot of girls, so, um, sorry about that. But, I know that Kirishima will be there too, and he's really friendly—"

Katsuki blinks. "The fuck did you just say?"

Izuku's brow furrows. "Um, well, Tsuyu has a strange liking to frogs—"

"Not fucking *that*, idiot! You said," Katsuki starts, groaning, "Kirishima? Like, fucking *Eijirou* Kirishima?"

Izuku blinks. "You… you know him?"

Shit.

Katsuki clears his throat and reels his head back, turning back to the sidewalk and increasing the casual length in his strides. He carefully avoids the inquisitive expression Izuku is giving him, and hopes that his irritated frown masks the frustration in his gut. Eijirou Kirishima had helped him in the past when accessing information regarding both Izuku and Shouto Todoroki, yet the thought that Eijirou would be a fool and possibly spill those secrets—

Would Izuku lose his trust in him?

Fuck that bullshit.

"We've met." He snorts. "Coincidence. Didn't know he went to Yuuei." *I*

didn't fucking trust you and he happens to go to the same fucking school as Half N' Half.

"Don't worry about that shit. My stuff to deal with. Not yours."

"Oh. Okay." Izuku nods his head. "If you say so, Kacchan."

Katsuki watches him, nose wrinkling in suspicion. "The fuck's wrong with you?"

Izuku looks at him. His ears are burning pink.

Huh.

"I don't know what you're talking about, Kacchan," says Izuku, slightly more rigid than before.

He shrugs and forces out a strained smile that would never convince anyone if they'd spent more than one day understanding how Izuku's scrambled mind works.

"This'll be good for all of us, then! I really like Kirishima. I'm just surprised that you knew even more people from Yuuei than I thought."

Katsuki rolls his eyes. "I'm not a fucking hermit, shitrag."

"Really?"

Katsuki snarls. “The fuck’s that supposed to mean, you snarky shit!” He grabs Izuku’s collar and roughly shoves him to the side. Izuku laughs and shrugs, intertwining his hands behind his back and gradually taking a few steps ahead of him. “Hey, you! Fucker! Anyone who insults a fucking Bakugou gets fucked up right back! Get back here!”

“Don’t kill me yet, Kacchan! I still have to show you around—”

“I’d rather explode myself than use you as a damn tour guide!”

Katsuki growls and comes over to Izuku’s side, resisting the temptation and set off a small explosion as a warning in the obnoxious teen’s face. However, Izuku’s smile, once again, distracts him long enough for him to halt and snap a few curses under his breath instead.

“Izuku! Over here!”

Izuku’s laughter comes to an abrupt halt as he turns on his heel and returns the wave towards a group of high school students in front of the gargantuan entrance to Sommartyn Central Mall.

“Uraraka! Tsuyu! Kirishima! Ashido!” Izuku grins and gestures for Katsuki to follow him. Reluctantly, the blond keeps his nose high and shoulders straight as he follows him, his glower following the disgruntled, curious expressions of Izuku’s apparent *friends*, though he’s not sure why the thought of his companion forming relationships outside of their dynamic bothers him.

Fuck no. Nothing bothers me.

He snorts, and glances up at the mall’s entrance.

The massive structure is made entirely of wide glass windows, colorful banners and numerous tiny shopping branches and food courts extended inside. Numerous people flood through the opening and closing doors, children and adults alike, some grasping ice cream cones and some tossing popcorn into each other’s mouths—probably taken straight from inside the infused theater that this particular mall was famous for.

Katsuki has only been here a handful of times, usually with his father or mother on important errands or meetings, but to be here on his own accord, with a group of people he hasn’t interacted with in casual, conversational means, makes his skin prickle like the back of a porcupine.

“It’s good to see you, Midoriya.”

A girl with large, round black eyes—Katsuki doesn’t exactly care to remember her name—glances from Izuku to him with a blank, unreadable expression. Her hair is long and tied back in a ponytail, wearing casual jeans and a loose pink blouse. She is standing rather close to the girl he remembers encountering at the café bistro just yesterday—*Round Face*, he recalls with a smirk—who is fixing him with a forced smile and a threatening glare.

He returns it tenfold, sneering.

“Bakugou.”

“Round Face.”

Uraraka’s eye twitches, yet before she muster a reply, another voice interrupts.

“Hey! Blasty McSplode!”

Kill me now.

Katsuki fixes a sharp stare onto Eijirou Kirishima, the annoying fool bothering to hobble over and lope one arm around him. He grins broadly and gestures towards the small group in front of them.

“It’s just us against the girls, man. You, me, and Midoriya! It’ll be all grand and full of manly adventure, in the treacherous forces of the mall—”

“Get the fuck off me.”

Don’t ask me about anything, Shitty Hair.

Katsuki slips out from under his grasp and gravitates towards Izuku, who is rubbing his neck and smiling bashfully in the presence of a pink-haired, pink-skinned girl with antennae and large, expressive greenish black eyes.

“We finally get to hang out after, what, forever, Midoriya? What’s up with that?” She pouts and pops her hip, an action that immediately strikes Katsuki as odd, especially with Izuku’s nervous laughter that follows. “Seriously, what the heck? You basically disappeared! You go to class, work on the paper, then just, *poof*! You’re gone.”

Izuku holds ups his hands defensively.

“Y-Yeah. Sorry, about that. And everything.” He grins. “So, what are we all doing first?”

Uraraka claps her hands together.

“Well, Mina and Tsuyu and I are going to go shopping first. We need some new dresses for the college fair coming up. You guys can do whatever you want, but we *do* want to check out a movie in the cinema if you all want to come.”

Katsuki grits his teeth.

He doesn’t enjoy the idea of being around these people at all, and frankly even having Izuku at his lonesome can be incredibly grating, but he’d rather take this as a challenge than completely evade it.

Izuku shrugs. “Okay. We can just explore. It’s been a long time since I’ve last been here.” He then brightens, popping a closed fist in the palm of his hand. “I got it! Kacchan, we can go to the comic book store! I’m sure there’s a new All-Might issue out!”

He’s practically bouncing on the balls of his feet, and the stirring in Katsuki’s stomach, on top of his already-building irritation should be enough to tell him to go fuck himself.

Instead, he flinches, grunts, and says: “Whatever.”

Uraraka’s shocked smile and the pink girl’s annoying giggles are exactly opposing to Eijirou’s arrogant, knowing smirk and the delighted look that bathes Izuku in a new light.

Too fucking bright.

Katsuki scratches his neck.

Maybe it will turn out fine.

Katsuki had, once again, completely underestimated Izuku’s ability to obsessively mumble about nearly *everything* they come across.

The comic book store, as grand and enormous as it truly is—brimming with hundreds upon hundreds of shelves with plastic covers of fantastic superheroes engaging in frivolous, time-frozen combat—is nothing but a maze for Izuku.

The green-haired teen is insistent and direct, maneuvering through each and every aisle with precision, ease, and familiarity that strikes him as unsettling.

“So, you and Midoriya?”

Katsuki glares at Eijirou, particularly his smug grin as he leans against the wall. Katsuki scans the shelves with lack of interest, only occasionally glancing backwards to see if Izuku was done with his determined search.

“Fuck off.”

Eijirou shrugs, his abnormally sharp teeth making his smile all the more aggravating. He turns away from Katsuki, humming under his breath as he follows Izuku’s form in the store.

“Todoroki thinks you’re trying to brainwash him or something.”

Katsuki freezes, hand poised on one particular comic issue that looked vaguely interesting.

He turns his head, fixing an unwavering glare onto the teen beside him. He cautiously twists his body and mirrors the other's posture, breathing through his nostrils.

"You spying for him?" He snarls.

"Nah. I don't have time for that. Plus, I think you're cool! In all honesty." Eijirou's grin lessens. "And, well, Midoriya doesn't trust just anyone. Not too surprised that he melted all that ice around your heart and stuff."

Katsuki pinches the bridge of his nose.

Murder is bad. Public murder is bad. There's cameras everywhere so you wouldn't fucking get away with it anyway. Fuck my life.

"He's just a fucking nerd. I don't give a rat's ass."

Despite this, his stomach flips at remembering Nero Edmure's fingers brushing through Izuku's curls, the lewd smile crossing his mouth and the disgusting words he'd muttered under his breath as if Izuku was somehow under his claim—

And now, he wants to punch something. Preferably Eijirou, since he's already broken Nero's face enough to leave him cursing his name for months. Or, years, maybe.

Eijirou hums at this, crossing his arms behind his head. "You know, I told you at the time that there was no way he could be a spy. Todoroki knows I wouldn't lie to him, either, ya know? From one bro to another, man, I wouldn't worry about it." He winks. "I was okay with, you know, getting info for both of you and stuff, but neither of you have to worry, I think. Todoroki's all like: *yo, make sure Bakugou isn't hurting Midoriya*. And I was like: *bro, Bakugou's a bro*! *Bros don't hurt other bros*."

Katsuki's face blanks. Then, he slowly lifts his palm, revealed to be sizzling with sparks.

Eijirou grins. "Your Quirk doesn't really work well on me. Also, it's illegal to use it in public, man. Not even you can get away with that."

"Get the fuck out of my face and don't bring this up to Deku." Katsuki snorts. "Or I'll rip you apart myself. Understand?"

"Sure, sure, Blasty. Whatever you say." Eijirou chuckles. "You know, Midoriya's pretty cute. The freckles. Green eyes. I can see why you'd go for him."

Katsuki's jaw drops, his mind running on such a furious speed that he's unable to properly process what Eijirou has just said to him. Instead, he feels the other pat him on the back and promptly make his way over to where Izuku is standing with dozens of comic books under his arms, frantically trying to decide which one he'd rather buy.

Katsuki twitches, hands balling into fists.

Fucker doesn't know jack!

He whirls on his feet, and stomps over to where Eijirou is helping Izuku rifle through the selected comic books. The close proximity doesn't seem to be bothering Izuku, as the freckled boy is stroking his chin and concentrating firmly on each comic book issue that he raises for consideration, lost in his own mental ramblings.

A low growl rumbles in Katsuki's throat at spotting Eijirou extend a hand to help Izuku with his books, despite how *clearly capable* Izuku is of taking care of it himself.

The redheaded bastard even has the audacity to gently ruffle through Izuku's hair, completely harmless and coincidental, yet it sends Katsuki's blood *boiling*.

Huffing with flared nostrils, Katsuki stomps over, roughly kicks Eijirou off to the side, grabs Izuku's stack of comic books, and flips them both off as he makes his way over to the cash register.

Izuku stands there, gawking with a rapidly blushing—albeit confused—look on his face, rubbing his neck and soon trailing after him.

"Um, Kacchan—"

"Fucking shut the hell up, Deku! If we stay in this fucking store any longer than I'm going to blow you up, then your fucking comics, then this whole fucking store and then the fucking world and no one would be able to find your fucking remains!"

Izuku remains completely gobsmacked as Katsuki purchases twenty comic book issues—some of which Izuku hadn't even gone through yet—and leaves the store with a bulging plastic bag heaved over his shoulder and a stuttering, blushing Izuku following his footsteps.

He places extra effort in the opportunity to step between Izuku and Eijirou as they make their way between stores, even with Izuku consistently apologizing for picking out so many comic books and not understanding why Katsuki would bother spending his money on him.

Katsuki never answers his questions.

"So, are you going to buy him the entire video game store too?"

"Shut the fuck up, Hair-For-Brains!"

Still, Katsuki resists the immediate temptation to bang his head against the wall when Izuku, for the life of him, cannot decide between two brand new games in a series he likes that are, honestly, just colored differently and are, essentially, the *exact same game*.

He hasn't played enough video games to understand the desperation behind owning every single copy, but he doubts he would ever force anyone to sit through a situation like this.

"Deku, just fucking pick a game already."

Izuku grumbles, staring at him with pleading eyes, as if he was trying to decide between the fate of his own world or the fate of the universe.

Katsuki twitches.

“But they’re both so important, Kacchan!”

“How could they both be important if they're both the exact same fucking game?"

"Because they're collectively different!" Izuku huffs, defensively crossing his arms with the cartridges still held between his fingers. "You don't understand, Kacchan! In one of these, only certain options are available and exclusive to the color. And the other one is the same thing, but with alternate routes depending on the choices you make!"

Katsuki slaps a hand on his forehead.

"Okay, fuck it. Whatever. I'm not dealing with this bullshit."

He reaches over and swipes one of the cases from Izuku’s hands.

Izuku glares as Katsuki confidently stalks his way over to the register.

“Wait, no! Kacchan, you’re not buying anything else for me—”

“I can fucking do what I want, shitty Deku! Quit fucking worrying about it!”

“Oh my God, Kacchan, you really shouldn’t! I have my own money that I brought with me —”

“Oh well, would ya look at that, I don’t give two flying fucks in a handbasket!”

“You’re *unbelievable,* Kacchan!”

“And you move with the pace of a fucking drunk snail!”

“I—*huh*?”

“You’re a fucking drunk snail and you need to get the fuck out of this store because I’m buying this shit and nothing you say can convince me otherwise!”

Eijirou lets out a low whistle from his position at the doorway to the store. Beside him, Uraraka blinks, watching the two boys bicker and nearly tackle each other while swiping at one another’s games.

“How long have they…?”

“Oh, at least fifteen minutes, now. Bakugou’s been buying everything for Midoriya up to this point.” Eijirou’s grin is infectious as he turns to Uraraka. “Cinema soon?”

Uraraka slowly tilts her head to the side, looking absolutely baffled as she observes her best friend and rather odd, presumably dangerous blond acquaintance nearly wrestles and clobber each other to death over who was buying what. It seems so out of place, so strangely unorthodox and not at all belonging in their world.

“Um. Yeah. We did our shopping, so, we were thinking an action movie or something.”

Eijirou nods. “Cool. We’ve been doing some great bro bonding, here.”

“I… can see that.”

“Yep.”

It’s not a surprise to anyone when both Izuku and Katsuki are promptly—and politely—asked to leave the store and never come back.

The entire top level of the mall contains the wide space of mahogany doors with classic golden knobs, movie posters strung up along the papered walls and a confection stand with overpriced food and drinks that are unique only to Sommartyn’s shopping district.

Despite the impressive display in front of them and the amount of time it takes for each teenager to buy their own ticket to the next showing of a film Mina Ashido had apparently labeled as “the greatest thriller of the decade,” Izuku cannot find it in his nature to remain still.

His entire body has been shaking uncontrollably since Katsuki roughly grabbed the comic book issues from his arms and bought them without even questioning the amount. He wonders, rather guiltily, just how much of a dent he’s placed in Katsuki’s wallet due to his inability to make a decision on what he wanted to purchase.

“Hey, you two! We’ll see you inside!” Mina calls with waving arms as she and Tsuyu disappear beyond the first corridor.

Izuku sighs, flashing an apologetic smile to Uraraka, who winks in return and departs with a smug-looking Eijirou, who bothers to waggle his eyebrows towards Izuku and Katsuki as if they were, undoubtedly, on a *date* of some kind.

The thought only makes Izuku all the more uncomfortable, and he can feel that Katsuki has been glaring towards him and growling like an agitated wolf for minutes on end.

“Um. So. I could, sit with Uraraka or switch a ticket stub with someone else—”

“Fuck that. It doesn’t matter if we sit next to each other or not.”

Katsuki raises an eyebrow, holding a massive bucket of popcorn under his arm. He pops a piece in his mouth and chews, refusing to glance at Izuku as they both make their way

through the shadowed hall. It's not crowded in this theater, with the definitive leather cushion seats reeking with mildew musk.

Izuku tugs at his collar.

He hadn't expected his afternoon to turn out like this at all.

He was glad, exponentially, even, that Katsuki was able to somewhat tolerate the presence of his other friends from Yuuei. Yet, he'd been especially stingy around Eijirou with no prior explanation, and remained tense after the comic book store. His insistence on purchasing everything had riddled Izuku with anxiety and guilt, and more than anything he wished he could return what was bought and fill Katsuki's wallet back up with money he shouldn't have spent.

And now, with the silver screen stretched to its lengths in front of dozens of emptied rows of seats, Izuku realizes with a slight jolt that he will be sitting next to Katsuki Bakugou, just one row ahead of his friends, *alone together*.

His heart rams into his ribcage. He swallows the lump in his throat and wipes his sweaty palms on his jeans.

It's okay. It's not a big deal. We're friends.

Slowly, he makes his way through the chairs to where Katsuki has already taken a seat, shifting back and forth to adjust. Izuku clears his throat, sliding into the chair next to him and pointedly ignoring the way the light from the screen casts a fine halo onto Katsuki's angled, pale features.

Just my luck. Izuku grumbles under his breath.

"They're so *cute*!"

Izuku groans and buries his face into his hands.

He can hear Mina gossiping with the others behind them.

He would rather they all leave the mall unscathed, instead of any one of his companions interrupting and being obliterated by Katsuki's own hand.

"The fuck's wrong with you?"

Izuku blinks, and finds Katsuki staring at him with a risen eyebrow, a carefully balanced bucket of popcorn, and one cheek puffed out from mid-chewing on said snack. Izuku holds back a delighted snort at the adorable image, and smiles back at the screen while shaking his head.

"Nothing. Sorry."

The film plays through a traditional, more formulaic script that Izuku has seen several times before, usually on his mother's television while she cleaned the apartment. He recognizes the

actor, all clean-shaven and brass knuckles, and the numerous explosions that occur throughout the film—usually including ramming giant cars and chase sequences with abnormally large guns—don't strike Izuku as particularly interesting.

Yet, when he turns to survey Katsuki, his thought process rams into a wall.

Katsuki is completely glued to the screen, eyes wide and focused as he pauses between bites of popcorn. His features are relaxed and brow furrowed with each action sequence that takes place, his eyes following the movements of each actor. Occasionally, he smirks at an explosion and chuckles.

He slumps back in his chair, shoulders loose and stare locked onto the film rolling in front of them.

Then, something catches Izuku's eye.

Instinctively, he reaches up, and ghosts his hand along Katsuki's hair, reaching for the loose popcorn kernel that escaped his more enthusiastic snacking.

Katsuki tenses, and turns to face him.

Izuku's breath lodges in his throat, his hand paused, fingers barely skimming the fine crown of ash-blond hair he remembers admiring so heavily on the first night on the train when he'd seen Katsuki Bakugou for the first time—

He doesn't move. His heart is racing, emphatic.

"Y-You have…" Izuku slowly pulls his hand back, shaking. "Had. Um. Something… in your hair."

Though, instead of cursing him out or even huffing and ignoring him, Katsuki's eyes narrow, his jaw clenching.

But, they're not in a stare-down in the gym locker rooms. No, they are inches apart, and he was close to *caressing* Katsuki's hair to fish out a piece of popcorn, and the action would undoubtedly land him in a difficult predicament, yet…

Katsuki's eyes are searching him. Curious.

Izuku can't move. Can't breathe.

Suddenly, he doesn't understand, at all, where and how they've come to his place, this sacred exchange that never should have transpired.

He wishes Katsuki would look away and brush him off like he normally would, but that glare is too curious, that brow too furrowed, those lips too pursed.

Izuku blinks dumbly when he catches Katsuki's eyes lowering to his lips.

It lasts less than a second, but Izuku feels his skin tingle at the attention, at the *predatory* glint in the other's stare.

Katsuki's weight shifts in his chair, his gaze never leaving him.

Izuku's too frozen, too mesmerized, as Katsuki leans forward—

The theater screen shuts off.

A deafening, loud noise tears through the vicinity and crackles the peaceful air.

People raise from their seats, screaming, running, the lightbulbs overhead bursting in showers of glass shards.

His back hits the floor, Katsuki above him, hissing, teeth gnashing and his command ringing out; telling him to *stay quiet, don't move, stay beneath me, don't say a word—*

The noises continue. The pattern turns more static, more disruptive, echoing and smashing through Izuku's eardrums as a horrible realization spills into his gut and grasps his heart and soul in vicious, ice-cold claws.

Gunshots.

Milestone

Chapter Summary

The numbing pain that explodes through his skull at the impact is all the more satisfying at recognizing an exact reflection on Nero's startled, twisted features.

Izuku pants, eyes wild. Angry. Fiery.

"Don't touch me," he says, breathless.

Chapter Notes

Alright, guys.

First off. Wow. This story has received so much dedication, so much appreciation, love support, and I'm just so humbled every time to be present for readers and commenters like all of you. Thank you, once again, for giving this story a chance. For bothering to enter this crazy journey in the first place.

Now... I'm going to warn you.

This chapter, is easily, the most violent and uncomfortable chapter in the story.

WARNING: Foul language, manhandling, non-consensual molestation (to an extent, nothing too graphic), blood, gore, and other violence. Also contains a brief moment of torture in an interrogation sequence.

Our boys go through a lot this chapter. Also, this chapter is even longer than the other. Capped off at 9,100 words. Holy shit.

Again, if this bothers you... this chapter is a big tonal shift. Read at your own risk.

Thank you again, for your support. It means the world.

Pain explodes through his mouth, snapping him out of his dark reverie.

"Wake up, Freckles."

With his mind half-seeped in a dreamlike consciousness and the other barely stepping into reality, Izuku is barely able to roll around his own jaw.

His teeth clack together like iron pellets.

A string of haphazard lights flickers overhead. Footsteps echo on concrete. Faint murmurs disrupt the tremors of silence that tumble in broken rhythm in Izuku's mind.

His vision blurs to the spattering of grays and whites in this room.

He shifts, his muscles aching—so *tight*, so *strained*—his body leaning forward slightly as he watches the first drops of his own blood fall onto his shoelaces.

"Damn. Must've knocked him out worse than I thought."

"The blond bastard's awake, at least… careful, Edmure. He doesn't look too happy with you smacking around his boyfriend."

What?

Izuku reels back, squinting up at the lights. He struggles, and panic shoots down his spine and quakes through his entire body. His wrists are bound behind him—tightly strung up in thick, grating ropes—his ankles strapped to the legs of his chair extra cords.

He spits out blood, a dozen questions formulating in the back of his mind.

The mall… the theater… gunshots.

Slowly, the memories rush back.

Deafening screams, angry yelling from Katsuki, hovering over him like his he was balancing both of their lives on a thread. He'd never seen Katsuki so enraged as he was pulled off of him, his head snapped off to the side, forced into unconsciousness with the blunt end of a handgun.

He remembers the confusion, the way his limbs froze as if paralyzed, his heart racing at an unfathomable pace, the bile that slicked and rose up in his throat. He remembered noting that only he and Katsuki were contained while the rest in the theater were safely escorted out, only seconds before strong arms around his throat shoved him into a dark, *dark* world.

They had been tracked. Followed.

Kacchan…

"Kacchan?" Izuku croaks. His throat is dry as chalk, his tongue numb.

Slowly, he registers the sight of his companion beside him, and instantly his stomach drops to his toes.

He wants to scream out and force the recognizable squadron leaders away from his friend, who is glaring through handcuffs binding his wrists and a strange gel-like substance swallowing up his clenched fists.

Katsuki is bristling from head to toe, eyes wild and teeming with fire. His bare arms are rippling with pent-up energy, veins bulging in his neck and forehead, skin flushed. His teeth are gnawing desperately around the gag wrapped around his mouth. His chest is heaving in heavy, quick motions, as if preparing for the final sprint of his life.

Katsuki stiffens, just slightly, at hearing the name fall from Izuku's lips.

"Good. They're both awake."

Izuku blinks, forcibly tearing his gaze away from Katsuki to focus on the scene ahead of them.

He holds his breath, eyebrows shooting to his hairline.

Many jackets imprinted with the squadron symbols are hung up on the far wall. Nero Edmure and Zeke are the only ones present, the glowing bands and clockwork watches around their forearms and wrists echoing their stature as leaders. There's a desk resting in the middle of the room where they position themselves.

One man stands out in the middle, scrutinizing Katsuki and Izuku as if they'll attempt to escape in any moment.

He's tall and slender, shifting on the edge of his desk with a perturbed, yet bored, air to his posture. His long, bony fingers are attached to multiple pairs of hands, some engulfing his face entirely while others linger like spiders crawling over his own flesh. His skin is paler than weathered paint, eyes crinkled around the edges and scouring through the cracks in the cement floors. With each tilt of his head and wisp of greased silver-blue hair that swipes across his hidden features, he resembles more of a cloaked exoskeleton than a human being.

Of all the Quirks Izuku has seen throughout his childhood, he's never seen one affect someone so viciously as this.

His skin bursts into goosebumps, the dreading fear threatening to take over his conscience quickly shoving his meandering thoughts behind him in a torrential wave.

Katsuki growls and snarls and bites in his own chair, his voice muffled yet somehow still gratingly loud, the threats pouring through the layers of cloth stuffed into and around his mouth.

"You caused far too much of a scene in Sommartyn Mall, you idiots," says the hand-faced man. Izuku straightens his back, wincing at the painful bruises marring his spine. The lanky man shoves his normal hands into his pockets and flicks his head to Zeke, who shuffles his shoes.

"Yeah. Sorry about that, Shigaraki." Zeke's golden eyes glint brightly as he stares at Izuku, shifting between him and Katsuki with clear bloodlust in his gaze. "Can't wait to beat the shit out of these two brats. That Bakugou kid caused me a whole lot of trouble in Isabori."

Shigaraki chuckles and slowly strides towards them.

“Well now people will be wondering where the hell the Bakugou brat’s gone. No one cares about this… what, Green Bean over here?” The hand-faced man—Shigaraki, Izuku notes—seems all the more disinterested with each second that passes. “They’re foolish children, trying to play *hero*… like all those others before ‘em. To think, even with All Might in retirement they’ve got some hopeful little brats littering the streets.”

All Might?

Izuku blinks, unbelieving. Why would any of these people have any connections to heroes before their called retirement? Back when Augustana wasn’t nearly this disjointed? This corrupted?

“Who knows, Boss,” Zeke mutters, chuckling. “Whatever. I won’t even bother using my Quirk on you two brats. Not at this point, with how fucked up you’re gonna be by the end.” He tilts his head, long gray hair spilling like a curtain over his shoulders. “And you, you blond bastard—you caused me a whole lot of *shit*, burning down that store and costing the *Isabori* squadron all that fucking cash.”

Katsuki struggles, yet his curses are discernible behind the cloth.

Sweat drips from Izuku’s chin.

There has to be a way out of this—

“Get on with it, Zeke.” Shigaraki shrugs. “I’m bored.”

Izuku’s eyes widen at this detail. He couldn’t have misheard that, could he?

Was this clear, downtrodden criminal of some kind, from the shadowed depths of Augustana, truly doing all of this because he was *bored?*

No. That wouldn’t make any sense. There has to be another motive, here.

This Shigaraki character was clearly aware of who Katsuki was.

He’d remarked him openly as if he was acquainted with him before, yet with the discrete glances Izuku gives Katsuki every few seconds, he doesn’t spot anything resembling recognition in those dark red eyes. He would assume Katsuki would brace himself for something to come, or make a more desperate attempt to vocalize his acknowledgement of Shigaraki’s presence.

“How,” Izuku chokes, grimacing, “did you… even go through with it?”

Zeke barks out a laugh. “Oh, kid, you underestimate our influence. Shigaraki, here, our boss, he controls all the channels. Sommartyn Mall belongs to *us*, not you greedy resident fuckers who refuse to pay your tolls and try to beat your way out of it instead.” His smirk falters. “You were already on thin ice, kid, before you got roped into the Bakugou brat's shit.”

“Hey, hey, Zeke, light up on Freckles.” Nero comes over to Zeke’s side, hands in his pockets and bruised eyes widening as he drinks in the sight of both Katsuki and Izuku strapped,

defenseless, to their chairs. “At least he’s a cute little fucker. Too bad he’s become Bakugou's *bitch*.”

Izuku swallows, tempering his breathing. He can read the hidden maliciousness and anger spiking through Nero’s stare, past the gnarly bandages covering the wounds Katsuki inflicted on him on the train.

Izuku wonders how many wounds Katsuki will suffer at the hands of Nero alone, and can’t bear to think of anything happening to his friend.

He knows, that for his pride alone, Katsuki will keep his mouth shut and endure whatever is thrown at him. He won’t crack or shatter beneath any threat, any warning tossed in his direction. And now, Nero Edmure is standing in front of him with the bruises and wounds Katsuki had inflicted on his own accord, and now both would suffer the consequences, with or without proper rhyme or reason.

“Don’t touch him,” says Izuku.

He instantly detests how weak his voice is, in comparison to how much his insides wriggle with strength and his eyes blaze with vigor.

He struggles in his bonds, ignoring the glare Katsuki shoots towards him, and the wave of anger and frustration he feels rippling alongside it.

I don’t care about your pride, Kacchan. We won’t be able to escape if we’re both messed up.

“Oh…” Shigaraki’s voice clips through the momentary silence like scissor blades.

Izuku reels back as the tall, slender skeleton of a man saunters over towards him, his movements carefully precise and wobbling with each silent breath he draws.

“I see, now.”

Katsuki instantly stills.

Izuku watches him questioningly, unsure, even as Zeke comes over to his chair and quickly yanks his head back by his curls.

Katsuki screams behind his gag and struggles in his chair, almost lifting off the ground with the force of his aggression.

Nero shoves his chair back down and punches him across the face. Katsuki jerks to the side, only for a second, before he snarls and strains his neck. He writhes in his bonds like a collared wolf. Blood spurts from his flushed nose and reddening forehead.

Shigaraki’s eyes flash.

“No need to demonstrate my Quirk yet…” He gestures with a flick of his head towards Zeke, who calmly slips his hand behind Izuku’s chair to grab at his fingers. “Just one, for now, Zeke.”

What—

Izuku's earsplitting scream flies through the room as his finger is brutally wrenched out of place.

Katsuki pants, watching in blind fury as he is restrained in his own chair, his voice held back in near-impossible restraints through chewed up cloth.

"Take off the gag."

Izuku pants, teeth grinding at the pressure boiling under his skin. He flexes his other fingers, wincing at the immediate residual pain drifting through his bones and pulsing through his veins. His vision turns spotty, peppering the image of the people surrounding him.

He blinks away tears, chewing on his bottom lip. He can't let himself show weakness, not now.

"Leave..." he chokes, chest heaving. Heart racing. "Leave Kacchan *alone*—"

Zeke's elbow smacks him across the jaw.

Hard, scathing pain jolts through him like lightning.

It adds to the blood welling in a coppery pool below his tongue and around his teeth.

"*Fuck you*! *I'll fucking rip out your throat with my fucking teeth*!"

Katsuki roars, and it's almost as loud as the ringing in Izuku's own ears.

He needs to stay focused despite the unbearable pain in his hand, the desperate jostling in his fingers.

Think of something. Think of something.

"Hm. If you answer my questions, your friend won't suffer. Much."

Shigaraki crouches low to the ground, balancing his elbows on his knees. He hums, a jittery noise, while glancing between the panting Izuku and the distressed, outraged Katsuki.

The strange glimmer in his eyes never fade, dancing on the edge of murky shadows.

"So. Son of Mitsuki and Masaru Bakugou." The cryptic man's voice lowers, a frosty shiver in a disjointed world. "We know you're trying to undermine the affairs of the squadrons here in Augustana. See, you fool, we have plenty of resources here, keeping peace and order in the city with connections going as far as the eye can see." He stands up, kicking one heel after the other. "Perhaps I should have made that clearer, with the tolls being raised past their previous limit. Even more time restrictions on residents. On the train that winds through Augustana like a snake full of stupid, *dirty hero-worshipers."*

Tension coils through the blanket of silence sweeping across the room.

Izuku holds his breath, *trembling* with each need to somehow communicate to Katsuki to not listen to these people.

He assumes, almost, that bearing a few injuries will be enough for his friend to accept the consequences.

Katsuki wouldn't sacrifice anything as crucial as his family secrets, and even then, these stirring questions probing his mind make him want to ask Katsuki himself when, or if, they manage to get out of this alive.

His heart slams into his ribs.

No. When, not if. You have to…

He sighs shakily.

Focus. Focus. Focus. Kacchan is hysterical. They're going to question him. And he only has you here to help.

He's Quirkless. He's powerless.

He wishes he could scream and vent his frustrations without sacrificing the momentary seconds they've bought to process what's happening to them both.

"Don't, Kacchan," whispers Izuku.

He stares up towards Zeke, who raises an eyebrow. Nero, beside him, smirks slightly and lowers his eyelids, though turns back to Katsuki with feigned disinterest.

Izuku shifts in his chair. The ropes grind and burn around his wrists.

Katsuki's teeth are gritting, fists balling in his bonds. The gel seems to tighten with each struggle.

He snarls up towards the three men standing in front of them, a look of utter defiance combed across his handsome face. His scowl returns over his lips, though the aggressive sneer remains, combating the worries building in Izuku's stomach.

"I've been watching you, Katsuki Bakugou."

Shigaraki's left eye twitches, focused entirely on Katsuki as he looms over him. Katsuki growls through his teeth, though he seems tempted between killing the man as well as Zeke, who is also pressed under the scrutiny of his glare.

"You have such intense bloodlust. A shame, that it would be wasted on self-proclaimed, disgusting *vigilantes* such as you and your pitiful family. You should remain in the dark with your parents and stop what you're doing. Now, tell me, Bakugou."

Shigaraki places his hands on his knees, releasing a low chuckle before turning around and walking back towards his desk.

With his back turned to the two captured teens, Shigaraki lifts his head towards the ceiling and squints at the lightbulbs.

“Tell me… when were you planning to tell this innocent friend of yours about your connection to the crime workings here? Before or after you stopped using him as your pawn? As your bait?”

His chuckle is low and dangerous, poisoning the air.

“You don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about!” Katsuki snaps.

Izuku glances questioningly towards Katsuki, yet keeps the look reserved.

If he keeps placing attention on Katsuki, Zeke and Nero, especially, will assume that they have a stronger bond than necessary. Since Zeke hasn’t lain a single hand on Katsuki yet and has only inflicted damage on Izuku, he knows that they believe them to be closer than they actually are.

But…

Izuku swallows.

I can’t… I shouldn’t be a distraction for Kacchan. Maybe, maybe we can use this to our advantage.

He breathes shallowly, directing his attention towards Shigaraki, who calmly leans back against his desk and wipes his hands down his turtleneck.

“Hm. Perhaps. Unless you don’t know yourself?” Shigaraki shakes his head. “A shame. But, that just makes it even less fun. And I don’t tolerate liars. Whether or not you’re aware of it, you’ve been scouting these districts and causing disruption in my games far longer than you should be. So unless you talk, your friend…” he shrugs dismissively. “Will suffer the consequences.”

Katsuki inhales, and the growl that reverberates through the room is deep enough to tremble glass.

“You fucking touch him and I’ll—”

“You’ll *what*, Bakugou?” Nero’s lips curl back, his crooked smile all the more infuriating the longer it lingers on Katsuki’s outraged, stifled growl. “You’ll kill us? Hurt us? *Blow us up*? We already have your explosive Quirk held in restraints that not even you can break out of. That gel is from a Quirk that stabilizes firepower." He lifts his hands, the gel substance crawling from his forearm and extending past his fingers, shimmering in a glass-like blob. "… Lucky for you, this is a *private* session. Doesn't matter when or where I use my Quirk, old friend."

Katsuki’s wordless, vicious snarl is enough to shake Izuku’s own bones.

He wishes he could revel in this strange sense of attachment he notices from his companion, through the very glare that Katsuki sends towards their enemies with total lack of restraint.

Zeke snorts and rolls back his shoulders. “Enough with this. Talk, you piece of shit.”

Izuku turns to Katsuki. “Kacchan, *don’t*—”

He’s cut off with another echoing *smack* to his jaw.

He coughs, spitting out a spray of blood onto the floors. The chair moves off-balance from the impact of this punch. A fresh bruise melds into the opposite side of his jaw, his tongue caught between his teeth and tearing skin.

Water builds in the corners of his eyes, though his mind drifts instantly to the look of absolute *rage* that morphs and colors Katsuki’s features.

Katsuki *howls*. He strains in his bonds, the chair shaking beneath his pressure as he desperately tries to wring his hands out of the cuffs. He thrashes and screams, veins bulging in his neck.

“You’re fucking *dead* you bat-shit piece of fuckwad *motherfucker*!”

Shigaraki taps his chin. “Heh, what fun!” He claps his hands together. “Oh, do go on, Zeke. He’ll crack soon. Maybe this will be a good cure for this rather bland week.”

Izuku coughs, spitting a broken tooth onto the ground.

“Shut *up*! He doesn’t owe you anything!”

He shakes his head, ridding the strange blurring sensations pooling in the back of his head.

He can’t fall unconscious. Not now, not when Katsuki needs him at his side.

Zeke motions over towards Izuku, his fist clenched and ready, yet both Izuku and Katsuki stiffen once Nero reaches over and sets a hand on his companion’s shoulder. Zeke raises an eyebrow at his friend, yet Nero’s large, vengeful eyes are focused entirely on Katsuki.

“I know how to get this guy to talk.” He smirks and steps in front of Zeke. “I’ll take it from here, Zeke. Besides,” he hums, "this is my chance to get to know Freckles a little better."

Izuku’s brow furrows, the implications whispering dangerously, threateningly, in the back of his mind while he avoids looking in Katsuki’s direction.

It pains him to see his friend so outraged and unable to do anything about it, yet the strange silence that follows Nero’s declaration causes him to turn his neck.

Katsuki is completely frozen, yet his body is trembling with barely controlled emotion, riding on the waves of destructive heat that cannot be released through the Quirk-enhanced cuffs.

His pupils have blacked out the wine reds of his eyes, his pants leaving in rumbling growls that shake the room in a thunderous grasp.

Izuku's blood chills to ice.

“*Nero*,” Katsuki breathes, “*you lay **one finger** on him—*”

“Hm. I don’t remember being the one interrogating you, Bakugou.”

Nero smirks as he comes down to Izuku’s level, tilting his head to the side.

His smile is so broad it crinkles the edge of his mouth, the expression of a man Izuku had regarded as little more as a passing shadow in Illenova District.

And now, the strange fear slithering under his skin returns tenfold, and he watches as Nero’s gold eyes flicker across his face, and then lower and crawl along his body.

He feels exposed. *Naked.*

His breath hitches in his throat, and the fear multiples. His stomach swells, bile rising up his throat.

Izuku’s heart races so fast he fears he'll vomit.

He stills, petrified, as Nero draws one calloused thumb along his lips.

“Answer the questions, Bakugou,” says Nero, his grin insatiable, “or I’ll fuck him right now and make you *watch*.”

What?

A fresh layer of sweat builds on Izuku’s skin.

Focus. Focus. No. He’s trying to intimidate you. Ignore him. Focus.

“…You’re one messed up fucker, Nero,” says Zeke, shaking his head. He turns to Katsuki with a sardonic smile. “But it seems to be working. Answer the Boss’s questions, Bakugou. You know what’ll happen if you don’t.”

Izuku snaps out of his daze and pulls his head away from Nero’s touch.

“No, Kacchan—*Katsuki*, don’t—”

Nero grabs his face and turns him back to face him, his fingers digging painfully into his bruised, battered cheeks.

“Eyes on *me*, Freckles,” Nero purrs. “You’re such a *slut,* a natural, obedient little puppy. I bet Bakugou has you go down real hard on him…”

Without looking away from Izuku, his hand trails beneath Izuku’s shirt, ghosting along his bare stomach.

He grimaces and wriggles back against his chair at the pressure, refusing to look Katsuki in the eye in fear of distracting him, but the fear building in his chest at the lengths Nero will go alarms him.

Panic seizes his chest as the hand trails lower and slips over his crotch—

"***Get the fuck off him***—"

Katsuki's deafening scream is halted by Zeke, who yanks a fresh gagging cloth over Katsuki's writhing mouth and yanks his head back, holding him forcibly against his chair. Katsuki tugs, pulls, *snarls*, desperate and building on his growing energy and palpable hatred that slips and winds through the room.

Shigaraki remains silent, fixated on the scene with presumably bated interest.

"Interesting…" He shrugs. "A bit more exciting, I suppose. Stupid fools, choosing to mess up my games!" He shakes his head. "Come on, Bakugou, you're willing to let this go on? Surely a valiant Bakugou vigilante would risk *everything* to save a civilian."

Izuku struggles and grinds out his own frustrated breaths, angry over his restraints, livid about the fact that he's being *used* in this way.

The hand stroking along his legs, thighs, crotch and even moving behind him to trail up his back—it sickens him. It enrages him.

He needs to focus on an escape plan, and none of it entails these wicked actions forcing him to remain exposed and crumbled in the presence of these villains.

Then, Nero grabs a fistful of Izuku's hair, and plunges his mouth onto his.

He keeps his teeth gnashed together, but is forced to open with the vicious tongue that swarms over his and invades his mouth.

He holds back the angry whimper, the tears threatening to break on the corners of his eyes as the other hand reaches back down to the one spot between his legs he would never want anyone to touch against his will, and then—

No.

He's had *enough*.

Izuku snaps his teeth down, as hard as he can.

He musters each moment of coherent thought outside of fear into this one spare second, relishing in the gasp and wail of pain that follows and Nero releasing him—leaving him *free*.

Then, before his assailant can properly gather his thoughts over his bleeding, punctured tongue, Izuku smashes his forehead onto Nero's.

The numbing pain that explodes through his skull at the impact is all the more satisfying at recognizing an exact reflection on Nero's startled, twisted features.

Izuku pants, eyes wild. Angry. *Fiery.*

"*Don't touch me*," he says, breathless.

His clothes are in disarray and the awful remaining tingle of Nero's touch remains imprinted on his flesh and in his mouth like invisible handprints.

He musters the smallest, weakest smile, though he doesn't want to see Katsuki's expression, not when his companion has gone suspiciously silent.

Kacchan needs my help.

"Y-ya l-lithwle *fwucker*…" Nero whimpers, clutching his mouth. "I-It… fuck…"

"Holy shit, did he almost bite off half your fucking *tongue*?" Zeke's eyes widen.

Nero says nothing in response, grumbling and concealing his loud, agonized moans behind his hands.

Izuku's body tightens.

Serves you right!

He bit down as hard as he could for a reason.

"Hah! You idiot!" Shigaraki hollers. "Incredible! What a shame, that a Bakugou bitch like him is only chained down to the son of Mitsuki and Masaru. How unfortunate that such fire is wasted on pathetic hero-worshipers who have nothing better to do than ruin my games."

His chuckle is loud and boisterous, though deceiving in where its mirth lies.

"Alright then, Bakugou. You have something else to say to us? If not, I'd rather just kill you now—"

"You—you were wrong!" Izuku shouts.

He inhales.

Here goes nothing.

"He's—Bakugou isn't a spy. I am."

Do something you fucking weakling—

Katsuki's thoughts run in a torrential, cathartic rhythm.

The patterns spill through is conscience and flood his clenched fists, enlivening his knuckles through the strange Quirk-laden bonds that prevent him from activating his explosions.

Each word he wishes to say, each insult he needs to exclaim, each mark of devastation that flows through him at Izuku's torture makes his heart twist and catapult through a series of emotions he's never felt before.

When Nero's eyes flash towards Izuku, and that definitive statement threads through the air like the lash of an electric whip, Katsuki knows his thoughts are almost completely *gone*.

All he wants to imagine is twisting Nero's head off his shoulders and burning his corpse in one sitting. He wants to drive his nails through Nero's chest and pull out his heart and make him choke on his own cock.

Being restrained, being kept shackled down against his will and watching Deku—no, Izuku Midoriya—a person he'd never expected to grow close to in such a short amount of time, being subjected to invasive, perverse touch against his will causes his blood to boil with the heat of a volcano.

He gnashes his teeth and screams and writhes in his constraints, hoping in the deepest, darkest pit of his heart that there is another source of strength he can access that will lead to Nero's head being swept off his shoulders and Izuku's being free from his touch.

When Nero smashes his lips onto Izuku's, the previous concerns over the barriers protecting the Bakugou family secrets are instantly shoved aside.

No, no, fuck, Deku, fight back, get him off, Nero you fucking bastard I'll fucking kill you—

He watches Izuku struggle, fighting, *desperate*, still silently begging Katsuki to keep his secrets safe, while watching him suffer like this beneath Nero's groping hands.

When they escape—*they will, no matter the cost*, Katsuki silently swears—Nero will die first.

"*Don't touch me*."

It's a soft whisper, yet it pulls Katsuki back out of his deep pool of irrational thinking.

He squares his jaw, flickering his gaze onto the sight before him: Izuku panting, trembling with his broken finger in his balled fists behind his back, hair tousled, his jeans almost yanked off his waist.

The blood dripping down the defiant green-eyed boy's chin… is not his own.

Nero is doubled over in pain, howling, screaming, his forehead stained in blood and the same red substance spilling between his fingers from his own mouth. He's trembling, rolling,

moaning and reacting like the pathetic, greasy weasel Katsuki has always known him to be.

A strange, ethereal sense of pride engulfs him.

He almost laughs, wants to scream to the heavens that Izuku, *his fucking Deku*, retaliated and nearly ripped off half of a squadron leader's tongue with his own teeth.

Good, Deku.

Katsuki's laugh is hysterical behind the cloth around his mouth.

Good fucking start. You got the first hit before I burn that disgusting, twisted fucker alive.

"He's—Bakugou's not a spy. I am."

Katsuki's head jerks up.

He watches Izuku gulp down his own lie, watching the three other men surrounding them in a strange flurry. Izuku stifles a sigh as a chorus of laughter breaks from Zeke and Shigaraki, with Nero still curling in on himself next to the wall and bracing his body from collapsing.

"*You*? Come on, you pipsqueak. You really think we'll buy that?"

Izuku sighs, leaning back into his chair with a slight shrug.

Katsuki blinks.

Holy fuck.

Is the nerd actually going to go through with this?

"You wouldn't know about it. Why else would I bother to befriend someone like Katsuki Bakugou?"

Izuku hums a little in mock thought, his brow furrowing as if cycling through a dozen conversations at once.

Katsuki bites back his own smirk, watching as a slight cloud of disbelief swallows up these three bastard fools who would dare try and kidnap them.

"I've been writing extensive articles and interviewing retired pro heroes since their retirement a few years ago." Izuku nods his head. "As an experienced journalist, with the literal focus being keeping track of documented information and becoming an expert in research, you would think I would already have the information I'd want from the Bakugous."

Zeke opens his mouth, yet Shigaraki steps forward to cut him off.

"Plenty of journalists who are not threats to the squadrons or the government have interviewed pro heroes. It's part of running newspapers. And you're… fifteen? Sixteen?"

Izuku shrugs. “Makes it all the more unbelievable that I would have that access, right? But I’ve been in the Bakugou residence. I’ve gained access to them through my own connections. Both Zeke and Nero have seen me gain permitted entry to certain districts for the sake of interviews with payment from either my high school or out of my own pocket.” He ponders. “Now, why would I bother to go through all that trouble unless I wanted experience? Or, even an agenda?”

Katsuki reads the considering expressions on the other three men’s faces. Zeke’s lips are pursed, concentrated, his gaze flicking back towards Shigaraki. The willowy, bony man taps his chin in thought, tilting his head to the side as he surveys Izuku’s position while strapped to the chair.

Katsuki wriggles in his constraints, noticing the slight drop of sweat falling from Izuku’s chin.

He’s shaking, heavily so, and placing all of his concentration into his carefully woven lies.

The tension rolling from his body is enough to alert Katsuki of the truth, but not enough to remind their kidnappers of their situation.

His fingers, for the first time since he was woken from his unconsciousness, *twitch*.

He holds back a victorious grin as the heat builds in his palms and circulate through the gunk imprisoning his hands.

“Oh yeah? And, pray tell, who is this *third party* sending you on these little sprees?” Shigaraki chuckles. “You need to be more thorough than that! You may have been messing up the routine in my games, in my little stories in Augustana, but you’re no mastermind, foolish boy. You would need powerful influences in the city to give you that sort of privilege. And you’re looking at the most influential figure in Augustana right now.”

Izuku blinks rapidly.

“Really? Hm. I don’t think my boss would like to hear that. He hasn’t said the kindest things about you or your gang members, you know.” He sends a startling, icy glare towards Nero, who blinks at the shift in tone. “He wouldn’t like to know that your squadron members go around molesting and threatening to rape passersby. I know that civilians and squadrons aren’t allowed to have those relations. Part of the contracted law, isn’t that correct? Soon passed after Kamui Woods was directly asked to retire his hero career?”

Fucking brilliant, Deku.

The heat spreads from Katsuki’s palms through the fading gunk keeping his cuffs in place.

Apparently this shit is on a time limit. Keep lying, you damn nerd. You’re fucking smart as all hell. Shit.

The absolute gleeful image of popping out of these bonds and burning each one of these people alive is enough to send his thoughts running on repeat, and the more Izuku lies, the

more time he's granting them.

"You're starting to annoy me, Green Bean." Shigaraki clicks his tongue. "I haven't even demonstrated the true power of my Quirk, yet. If you keep harping off these lies, I'm sure we'll find better use for your bones and muscles after your brain crumbles right before your eyes." He lifts his scarred, damaged hands, flexing his fingers.

Izuku clears his throat. "Well, I doubt you'd want to take a risk like that against a Midoriya."

Katsuki knows, more than anyone, that this is a risky statement. A possible checkmate or instant loss in a game of chess, balanced on the edge of one board to the next among a sea of black and white squares. He's noted the diagonal patterns and possibilities since he'd been snapped out of his black dreams, but now—

Now, Izuku is willingly changing the game.

Instantly, Shigaraki freezes.

Katsuki's eyebrows raise to his hairline.

Keep talking, Deku, you damn nerd.

He continues focusing his pent up sweat and riddled anger towards his hands, feeling the gunk simmer away through his touch.

This will take several more minutes, yet the way Shigaraki has tensed in regards to Izuku's last name turns Katsuki's insides to nervous mush.

"*Midoriya*?" Shigaraki whips his head towards Nero. "You idiot! You didn't tell me this brat was a Midoriya! Are you insane? You brought the son of *Hisashi Midoriya* into this hideout?"

Izuku's eyes widen at the declaration.

Katsuki follows suit, glaring headily towards their kidnappers and hoping, with every fiber of his being, that Izuku feels his stare.

Instantly, the curly-haired boy turns his head, just enough for his bruised eyelids to flutter slightly and a small smile to overtake his lips.

Katsuki's chest swells with a sudden warmth, a direct flourish that calms the impending threats winding unceremoniously through his exhausted mind. He needs to claw his way out of this mess and allow them both to escape, yet the questions lingering in his thoughts will serve as a distraction far after they leave the premises.

He could hardly imagine any different turnout taking place with their current circumstances, even with Izuku apparently shining with wordplay prowess that betrays his usual stuttering nature.

“Hisashi Midoriya is, indeed, my father,” says Izuku, riding the wavelength of subtle charisma that Katsuki can't help but admire.

He shakes his head.

Fucking keep your shit together!

He wiggles around his wrists, grinning even broader as the gunk continues to drip softly on the ground behind his chair.

He watches Zeke and Shigaraki motion towards Izuku.

A growl rumbles in his throat, threatening and sharp.

You fuckers stay the hell away from Deku.

“So, Hisashi Midoriya sent you as a third party?” Shigaraki snorts. “I don’t believe it! You’re like all those other hero-worshipers, missing people like All Might… he’s *nothing* like what you imagined him to be, hm? I doubt he’s the epitome of what you admired as a child. So, what does Hisashi want then, if not for the old heroes to return? Money? A stake in running these districts? A good word in for the Bakugous?”

Izuku, once again, only shrugs.

“That’s for me to know. I probably would have relayed some of that information if you allowed me to speak my mind. Now, I think the Midoriyas have made some prominent enemies.”

“You’re a lying little fuck,” Zeke whispers. “You’ve been fucking scraping by and working two jobs at your own high school to keep you and your little momma out of hot water. It’s because of me, you piece of shit, that you’re not tracked down by other squadrons and wrecked beyond belief.” He snorts. “Then, you and Bakugou attacked me and refused to pay a toll. In this situation, *Curly*, you’re the one who’s fucked up. The law’s our word. Not yours.”

Izuku stiffens at this, going far too tight and too soon.

Fuck. Katsuki bristles. *He’s faltering.*

Even this surprising brilliance brought out of his back pocket will not be enough for Izuku to completely turn around their situation. Not on his own, at least.

Shigaraki leans forward, skeptical.

“Well, then,” he says lowly, his fingers outstretched, “we’ll just have to see—”

Fucking bastard, keep your hands off of him—

Katsuki rips out of his bonds, releasing a loud, maniacal laugh as a vicious pair of explosions rocket out of his palms.

The jet-like flames that burst from his skin propel him forwards, tossing his chair and former constraints to the opposite wall as he slams his body into Shigaraki.

“Not today motherfuckers!” He laughs, turning around on his feet and smashing his fist into Zeke’s cheek. Instantly, the other man staggers backward, dazed even before he buckles to the ground.

Katsuki whirls around towards Izuku, who, even through his bruised, bleeding features and light tearstains, is absolutely *glowing.*

Katsuki shoves aside the strange back-flipping in his chest as he runs over behind Izuku’s chair and quickly blasts through the ropes.

Izuku yanks his hands free, staggering to his feet and whipping his head around him at the scene.

“Kacchan, how did you—”

“No fucking time. There.” Katsuki points towards Zeke’s stunned form. “Grab that gun. That Shigaraki bastard is out cold for now. I have *business* to take care of.”

Izuku frowns. “Kacchan, you don’t—”

“Oh, believe me.” Katsuki snarls lowly, pivoting on his heel with clenched, fire-encrusted fists, “nothing you say, Deku, will convince me not to kill that disgusting waste of space.”

His grin is absolutely livid and dancing on the embers of his own inner turmoil and need for *vengeance*, blazing scarlet eyes entirely focused on Nero Edmure.

The sniveling Illenova squadron leader is scrambling across the floors, dashing to one of the doors to the warehouse with flailing limbs.

"You fucking coward! Come here and fight me!"

Izuku hesitates, yet dashes to grab the gun beside Zeke’s head and frantically absorbs the disjointed scenery around him.

The flickering lightbulbs and vicious cracks in the walls encasing them in seem all the more daunting, yet Katsuki is far too focused with his shoe slamming into Nero’s back and pinning him to the floor.

“Oh, what’s that, you running away, you little *fucker*?” Katsuki laughs, readying his blazing palms and directing his attention towards the back of Nero’s head. “I told you I would fucking kill you. What was that you said about *Deku*? That you’d *fuck him and make me watch*? You really like to live to piss me off, you vile piece of *shit*—”

“Kacchan! If you kill him now, more squad members will point it all back to you! The law isn’t on our side right now!” Izuku calls from one of the open doorways, his frantic pulse noticeable from miles away.

Katsuki, reluctantly, through even his vale of anger and blind hate, reacts to Izuku's reasonable plea.

"I don't fucking care, Deku."

"N-No! Wait!"

Katsuki snarls, leaning down and grabbing Nero's collar, flipping his body over and pressing his heel into his chest.

"*I shouldn't even let you get fucking last words*. I was *nice* before, fucker. And now, you get to *die*." He grins toothily, eyes wild. Dangerous. "I would make you apologize to Deku for treating him like he's some common whore, but I'll do the honors since he's too fucking nice."

Nero gasps, choking on his own blood, what's left of his tongue flopping between his lips.

"*Kacchan*!"

Katsuki freezes. "*Deku*, you're starting to piss me the fuck off—"

"We have maybe ten minutes to get out of here, and the longer you take to kill him, the longer it will take to get a lead. We need to go before they call in reinforcements and we're outnumbered."

Katsuki, glaring frigidly towards his companion, who is holding open the door with the gun trembling in his clenched hands.

Ten yards away, Zeke begins to stir.

Katsuki watches Izuku, notes the tension in the other's shoulders. He sees the reluctant need for satisfaction in the green-eyed boy's expression as well, from the furrowing in his brow and the frown splitting apart his normally vibrant lips.

His entire body is flushed red, marked with fresh and old bruises alike, dried blood crusting his temples and staining his jaw.

Yet, Izuku has never looked more determined. More *alive*.

It lights something inside Katsuki. It burns deep in his gut, rising like a desert storm.

He blinks out of his stupor, growls and viciously tosses Nero's barely-conscious body to the opposite wall.

He smirks, wiping his hands together at hearing the sickening crunch of bones and more gasps of pain.

"Fine, Deku." Katsuki jogs over to Izuku's position, face smoothing into a determined scowl. "Let's get the fuck out of here."

Izuku's heart is close to bursting out of his chest.

His palms are sweaty, clamped around the handgun—so foreign and steely in his touch, cold and warm at the same time from being in both his and Zeke's calloused hands.

He keeps his pace alongside Katsuki, the other teen effortlessly pumping his arms in fluid motions in the whereabouts of the small, wooden and stone-barred warehouse.

The windows are blocked off with stacked bricks, the corners of each turn they take outlined in cobwebs.

"Deku," breathes Katsuki, gesturing to one door they haven't tried yet. It's framed in iron hinges, the doorknob seemingly impossible to open with the extravagant locks clipping it closed. "I'll blow off the locks. Something tells me that that's going to take us outside. Come on."

Izuku only nods, barely able to speak, to process the scene that just transpired.

The events run in a vicious somersault through his mind, tearing through his senses with reckless abandon.

He follows Katsuki through the darkened, damp hallways, ignoring the squeaking of their shoes splashing in puddles and the strange echoing footsteps behind them.

He knows they're awake by now, searching for them, struggling to regain their concentration in what's just happened in their own kidnapping ploy.

Keep running. Keep moving.

He will think about what Shigaraki said—about what he claimed as truth about his own *father*—when they're alone. When they're safe. When they can contact Izuku's friends, or anyone, and let them know that they're alive. That they're breathing. That they still currently have all of their limbs.

Izuku feels suddenly quite lucky that he's managing to escape with, most likely, only a partially fractured jaw and a broken finger.

Katsuki brakes in front of the door.

"Die, fucking lock!" He screeches, clenching his burning fists and setting off a sharp, precise explosion on the metal.

Instantly, the doorknob and its respective chained locks fall off in unison, clattering to the floor in a series of *clanks*.

The sound echoes in the corridor.

“We have to find them!”

No. No, no, no, no, no—

Izuku halts.

Panic seizes his every muscle, running his bones and thoughts taut.

He pivots on his heel, unable to think, unable to focus, as his working hand grasps onto the trigger—*shaking, close to collapse, desperate, fumbling*—and pulls.

A bullet ricochets through the blanketing silence and, right as Zeke’s head turns the corner, clips the edge of his knee.

He screams, grasping his leg as he buckles to the ground. Fresh blood stains the concrete floors, drenching the stone and alerting each and every signal in Izuku’s brain.

Izuku feels as if the air has been knocked out of him.

“Deku! Fucking come *on*!”

Izuku is unable to process Katsuki’s hand wrapped around his, desperately pulling him from one side of the door into the outside world.

Katsuki slams the metal entryway behind them, and shoves Izuku through the fresh patch of withered flowers, grass and wet soil that clumps the staircase leading to their escape route.

Izuku stumbles through his own thoughts, breathing sharply, far too quickly for his own good, desperate and heaving and stumbling up stone steps and wondering how h*e was able to the pull the trigger on a gun he’s never even seen before in his life—*

“Deku! Hey, fucking Deku! Snap out of it!”

Kacchan…

His voice is stern and tight, riddled with conflicting emotions that border on something raw, something previously unreachable.

Izuku stiffens against Katsuki’s hold, relishing the sudden sensation of the other’s powerful hands on his shoulders, keeping him stable against the brick wall of a building—no, no, not just any building; this couldn’t be the warehouse, could it?

No. No. We were… we were running.

“Deku! Shit… fuck. Fuck, can you hear me? Deku, come on, say *something*—”

“I—I *shot* someone,” Izuku whispers.

In an instant, his entire body trembles, shaking with each breath, water leaking out of the corners of his eyes and forming fat trails down his cheeks.

He watches Katsuki’s stunned, open-mouthed expression, noting just how oddly ethereal Katsuki appears beneath the light of the streetlamp propped on the corner of the sidewalk, just off the cusp of the alley where they’re hidden.

His angular jaw, the narrowed shape to his widened eyes, his pale skin and ashen hair—

Beautiful.

“Deku, I don’t know what shit you pulled,” breathes Katsuki, his voice far too close, so close that Izuku hears and *feels* every breath that travels over his throat and ghosts over his shoulders, “but that, was fucking *badass*. Where the fuck have you been hiding that?”

And then, Katsuki is laughing.

It’s a startled, ruptured sound, one so foreign, so incredibly alien that it causes Izuku’s skin to warm up beneath the pressure, beneath the touch of something else that doesn’t make his insides quiver in acidic disgust like they had under Nero’s touch—

His stomach lurches.

Those hands, crawling over his skin, pressing against him, prodding, pulling, invasive, *unwanted—*

Calm down. Don’t panic. Kacchan doesn’t deserve that.

It’s cold out, he notes, and the first spotting of rain dapples the sanded brick walls of the alley.

“Kacchan, we…” Izuku wipes at his eyes, slowly regaining control of his vision around him, “our moms. Our—my friends, we… I need to be sure they’re okay. I don’t—I don’t even know where we are. Do you know where we are?”

The sky is dark blue, a fresh splash of stars coloring the canvas above their heads. The moon is bright, a beacon of promise, of reminding him of their successful escape from a dangerous group of people who are responsible for pulling the vey strings of Augustana.

Shigaraki.

He will research that name.

He will discover more. He needs to.

“Somewhere in Isabori, I’d think.” Katsuki’s nose wrinkles as he drinks in their surroundings. Rainwater quickly assaults the two of them, soaking their parallel frames. “This looks like an

unoccupied district. Warehouses like this aren't just anywhere, especially in Sommartyn, or even Illenova."

Izuku's skin quivers.

Isabori?

Was his mother in danger?

"Hey, calm down, Deku. We'll get this shit rolling and tell people." Katsuki searches him, jaw tight and still bruised and covered in blood. "Come on. We can't stay. We ran far but not far enough for them to not track us. Who knows what they'll pull the next time." He snarls under his breath. "Should've fucking ripped that fucker's head off…"

Izuku runs his fingers through his curls. An uncomfortable wetness seeps through his cloth shirt and jeans.

He wonders, just how many times he will need to scrub on his skin to wipe away Nero's touch.

Will it ever be removed?

Stop. It's not... it's not going to help anything. Focus.

"We should call them, Kacchan. Our moms."

Katsuki's brow furrows at this.

The exhaustion that's surely sped through both of their systems has clearly overridden their adrenaline, sinking into their muscles.

Izuku reads the tiredness on his companion's features, wondering if anything that had occurred less than an hour before was directly responsible.

"We'll need to find a payphone," Izuku adds, smiling slightly.

Katsuki groans. "Oh, fuck."

"… Do you have change?"

"Does it *look* like I have fucking change, Deku?"

The nearest payphone is a twenty-minute walk from the warehouse sector in the stranded section of what Katsuki presumes to be Isabori.

Izuku's hands are buried in his pockets, his head tilting back.

The crisp, cool night air is simultaneously chilling and comforting, coupled with the slightest dappling of rain on the sidewalk and flickering streetlights. A humble array of stores and houses are positioned on the opposite end of the asphalt streets, painted rainbows of colors even in the darkened presence of early morning, still bathed in nightfall's shadows.

The payphone juts out awkwardly from a convenience store that oddly resembles the encounter he and Katsuki had with Zeke several weeks prior.

The memory gripes at him, clawing at his mind with no restraint. He shakes his head, holding back his need to allow his breathing and rapidly increasing heartrate to double and spill over.

Breathe.

He gulps.

The sound of Katsuki pressing the number keys on the payphone draws Izuku's attention. He waits, shifting in his shoes as he observes Katsuki, still drenched in his black tank from earlier that same day—when they were just perusing the mall, enjoying the company of friends, buying comic books and games, for *fuck's sake*—and scowling at the payphone as if it had a personal vendetta against him.

"Stupid cheap-ass fucking payphones…" Katsuki snorts, dropping several selected coins he'd shamelessly pilfered from Izuku's pockets. "Shit. They're gonna lose it."

"Think they have a right to…" Izuku sighs. He rubs his forehead. It still throbs from his instinctive move to head-butt Nero.

"Not picking up," Katsuki murmurs, placing the phone back on the stand. "Let's just walk. We'll figure it out."

Izuku scratches his cheek. "But. My friends. What if they're… what if they're *hurt*?"

"They're not." Katsuki groans. "They were after us. They made that clear. What I saw when..." he trails off, rubbing the back of his neck. "I mean, when I was... guarding you, I guess, I saw them being shoved out of the theater by other squadron patrolmen. We were the ones they were after. Not them." He wipes at his nose, mumbling under his breath.

Izuku's ears burn pink at the memory.

Katsuki had leaped to protect him, warned him to stay to the ground on first instinct.

He's exhausted, and wishes he could curl up under a sheet of blankets, but the memory softens his heart. Weakens the heavy weight of what they both had just experienced.

He locks onto Katsuki's back, the other teen glaring ferociously at the payphone.

"Thanks..."

Katsuki blinks, and looks over at him. "What?"

Izuku flushes, and clears his throat, though does not break the stare.

"Thank you. For protecting me." Katsuki's expression is unreadable, but the lack of anger or exasperation on his bloodied, wounded face sets Izuku's spirits alight. "Back there. I... it meant a lot. It still does. Those... those kinds of reactions. Um." He grins, a weak movement that cracks his chapped lips. "That's why Augustana deserves people like you to protect them. Not those vile people."

Katsuki splutters and looks away. His Adam's apple bobs, fingers curling into his palms and a series of curses staying lodged behind his teeth.

Izuku nods his head and casually bumps his shoulder against the other boy's.

"Really. I mean it." He shrugs one shoulder, a bashful blush spreading throughout his entire body. His heart slows into a gentle rhythm. "That was really heroic."

"Jesus fucking Christ." Katsuki swallows and lightly taps him, rolling his eyes. "Don't be all fucking sappy with me, Deku," he murmurs, strangely quiet in the dark. "Just... a heat of the moment. Type of thing."

"Alright." Izuku nods, and decides not to pester him further.

They move away from the payphone and continue walking in the dark. A comfortable silence develops between them.

Katsuki is the first to break it.

"Those bastards broke our phones, sure, but we can still find another way to get back to your place, at least. This has to be Isabori. Just keep an eye out for the street names."

"Fine." Izuku sighs.

He takes a few more steps, intending to direct what's left of his tired mind on the sidewalk to read the street names, when Katsuki's hand snatches his elbow.

He blinks, and turns to find Katsuki's eyes intensely scrutinizing him.

"Hey. Um."

Izuku blinks.

"… Kacchan?"

"Are you—" Katsuki splutters, angrily drawing one hand down his face. "Fuck, are you—are you fucking okay or whatever, Deku? That shit back there—that was fucked up. I wanted to kill that motherfucker. Tear him apart. I should've killed him on the train, then he wouldn't

have even been able to touch you." He bites his lip, considering. "And you're, what, *thanking* me for failing to protect anyone in that goddamn theater? And while that was happening to you I couldn't do anything, and, shit, *fuck*—"

"Kacchan."

Izuku's other hand reaches over and pats Katsuki's, who's fingers tighten instinctively around his elbow.

The gesture is warm and comforting, allowing a strong surge of delight to spread through Izuku's chest.

"I'm fine. Thanks for asking."

Though, when Katsuki attempts to brush it off, Izuku doesn't let go of his stare.

Izuku recalls the gentle light of the theater washing across Katsuki's smirking features. His dangerous chuckle vibrating in his throat, low and predatory. His eyes, dark and always searching for answers, always probing for questions.

Izuku knows so much about Katsuki, and yet, still so little.

"Back… um." Izuku flushes, scratching the back of his neck and calmly stepping away from Katsuki's hold.

He can feel him staring at his back, reading him.

"In the theater. Were you…? Ah. No. This isn't the right time to ask." He strokes his jaw, and winces at touching a rather tender bruise. "I have to stop muttering when I keep getting hit like that… oh, great. Now I'm babbling. Um. Just ignore this, Kacchan. We can talk about it later, and stuff—"

"Spill it, Deku."

Izuku's brain short-circuits.

He turns and admonishes the curious furrowing in Katsuki's brow, the calm placing of his arms slack at his sides, hands concealed in his own jean pockets.

His frown is unreadable, yet there's something teeming behind his expression. Something glowing that he finds familiar, that he once considered unreachable and unthinkable.

Yet, it's here, now, and he wants, more than anything else in this world, to feel the reassurance Katsuki Bakugou is willing to give him.

Izuku motions closer to the other teen. He reaches up, hesitating at first, before allowing his roughed, calloused hands to brush by Katsuki's cheekbones, to feel the pressure of the bruises of sleep deprivation marking his lower eyelids. He skims his thumb along Katsuki's jaw. His heart leaps into his throat, even as Katsuki's only response is a slow widening of his eyes and the slightest dip of his head.

Katsuki's eyes then shut tight. His nostrils flare, jaw clenched and his arms visibly rigid.

Izuku blinks, bewildered.

Oh, no. I ruined it. I ruined whatever this was—

Then, Izuku jolts out of his thoughts at Katsuki's own hands lifting to caress his face, tenderly framing the bruises marring his jawline.

Katsuki's eyes are open. *Alive.*

And Izuku feels it.

Here, now, and *real.*

"You're fucking *impossible*."

Izuku's eyes flutter shut the moment Katsuki's lips press against his.

Sequester

Chapter Summary

> All that Izuku wants, before he needs to talk to both of their mothers about what happened to them the next morning, is to have his mind shift to something else. A safe haven with open arms and a dangerous aura of protectiveness and pure, raw strength that makes Izuku's chest flare up with competitiveness and his knees buckle with desire.

Chapter Notes

> I'm speechless. Ah. Thank you, so much everyone. And this last capter received over FIFTY COMMENTS! That's absolutely insane! I'm at a loss for words each and every time and I'm so honored! Thank you, so much! For each comment, kudos, bookmark, etc. It all means the absolute world!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki Bakugou's lips are soft, supple and tender even as harsh teeth nip, pull, and tug at Izuku's mouth in a wrestle for dominance.

It's so much and still not enough.

Calloused hands running behind his back and head and pulling his smaller form close to a rain-soaked black shirt—his cologne from hours before still cloud his senses, like spearmint and cucumber and lemon—and Katsuki's tongue pushes through his lips and caresses his own as a definitive test: a daring risk for permission upon the bruises still fresh and swollen on the green-eyed youth's mouth.

Izuku complies.

Katsuki tilts his head and pulls Izuku in *deeper*, a heavy, rumbling growl rising in his throat and spilling between them in a mess of hot breaths and muttered whispers that neither can decipher as they pull more and more in towards each other.

Izuku breaks off the kiss, blinking lazily to adjust to the sight of his companion—friend, ally, (*possible significant other*, he quietly notes)—frazzled and flushed and mouth partially opened with impatient growls. Katsuki's brow is furrowed in uncertainty, studying the sudden pause in Izuku's expression.

Calmly, Izuku cracks a small smile, squirming beneath the intensity in the other, taller teen's stare.

Katsuki's jaw shuts tight, his arms rigid around Izuku yet refusing to let him go.

"Did I hurt you?" he asks.

Izuku startles at the strange, solid tenderness and equal strength in those choice words.

Katsuki remains the same in his posture and how he carries himself, his bare arms riddled with raindrops, muscles taut and powerful as they encase around him.

Izuku shuffles back and forth in a reflex, to fight for his own stance as equal ground in their standoff.

Somehow, allowing Katsuki to kiss him first after all that transpired seemed to open a gateway to a new kind of experience that Katsuki was not willing to lose.

"No." Izuku blinks, his voice dry and cracked. "I, um. Maybe, we should go somewhere else? And…" He trails off.

The fire smoldering in his chest from their escape, their mutual leaps in adrenaline and the strange battle of exhaustion and tiredness over these sensations are still riding high in their minds.

He wonders how close they are to both running a marathon and collapsing in awkward intervals, wishing to simultaneously conquer the world and fall unconscious in their homes.

Katsuki's blank stare evaporates in favor of a crooked grin that crinkles the corners of his eyes. The perfect jagged cut in a face made of all hard angles and snarky arrogance.

He's not prepared for Katsuki to release him, his chuckle low and dark, irritating for the way it causes the hair on Izuku's arms to rise.

"You're always fucking overthinking about everything. Tell your brain to shut up for once."

He rolls his eyes, yet the gesture seems oddly fond rather than patronizing.

Izuku shifts in his shoes, his skin burning and tingling from the feel of Katsuki's mouth on his.

He watches Katsuki's red eyes enlarge, pupils flickering like a hungry lion's as it latches once more onto the green-haired boy's lips.

"We should… get out of here, first." Izuku avoids Katsuki's sharpened glare. "Trust me, Kacchan, obviously I would much rather make out with you in the rain like all those dumb sappy romance movies Uraraka used to make me watch with her. But, we have to get out of here first. Someone could find us while we're all wrapped up in each other and—"

Katsuki grabs his collar and shoves him into another kiss, this one long and stable and commanding. Izuku blinks owlishly as the other boy releases him, one eyebrow risen and his teeth only faintly showing, though Izuku wipes his mouth and glares regardless of how smug and cocky his companion can be.

“Good to know that fucking works with your stupid muttering, Deku.” Katsuki snorts. “Fine, then. Come on. You live in Isabori so we should be able to find your place, or at least somewhere where we can find tickets for the train.”

And with that, Katsuki puts his hands into his pockets and starts moving forward, hair still defying gravity even with the rain spattering the sidewalk and glistening on the windowed buildings surrounding them.

Izuku sighs and trots after him, self-consciously reaching over to one elbow and rubbing his fingertips over the cut, scabbing flesh.

“Kacchan, the train won’t let us board outside tolling hours.”

“I didn’t say we’d fucking buy any tickets, now did I?” Katsuki snarls. “I hate these scumbags and we don’t owe them shit. We’ll just fucking break in or something and empty their entire stash if that’s what it fucking takes.”

Izuku balks. “Kacchan, we can’t just steal from Isabori like that—”

“Oh, look, I don’t give a fuck. As per damn *usual*, shitty Deku!” Katsuki snorts. “If you’re going to just bitch and moan, shut up about it and we’ll find some other, far more *difficult* way of getting the fuck out of here and avoiding any more squadron members!”

Izuku folds his arms behind his head as he matches strides with Katsuki. The blond keeps his attention forward, brows creased in the center and his scowl unmistakable. Izuku smirks to himself, quickly reaches up, pecks Katsuki on the cheek and bolts ahead of him.

“Then let’s get there faster, Kacchan!”

He laughs at hearing Katsuki’s seething snarl and spluttering noises, knowing for a fact that his companion will be bolting after him and demanding he pay his respects. The flutter in his chest is all the more distracting, even with his fresh wounds and the dire situation hanging over him and Katsuki’s heads like a looming cloud.

He hopes that he can have these few spare minutes to revel in what little happiness he can obtain before he asks his mother—and Katsuki’s, for that matter—some pivotal questions.

Katsuki easily catches up to him, shoving him off to the side and hollering mirthfully as Izuku awkwardly stumbles and trips over his own sneakers. Huffing, Izuku glares, yet his playful smile is more than reciprocated as he moves back to the other’s side and bumps shoulders with him.

Katsuki’s ears turn pink, yet he snorts and glares forward yet again, suppressing a mumble.

Izuku bites his lip.

Cute.

“The fuck you smiling about?” Katsuki growls.

Izuku laughs, shrugging sheepishly. “Oh, nothing.”

The rain slows to a stop, yet their footsteps are just momentary splits in the silence that falls between them. Izuku remains close to Katsuki’s side while the other’s strides remain heavy and relaxed. Even so, the tension through their muscles and the paranoid way Katsuki turns his head every few minutes to look over their shoulders is enough to remind Izuku that they, at any point, could find themselves in bad company.

Then, Katsuki halts, rigid as a board.

Two blinding headlights flash towards them on the road—a rare sight in the dark when tolling hours were not permitted for vehicles to hit the streets. They clunky vehicle is brandished with a strange, barely noticeable symbol in the darkness—a rented car careening through the shadows like a jagged lightning bolt.

“Deku.”

Izuku stops. “We should—”

“Run.”

However, once the car screeches to a halt at the side of the street, and a familiar pair of silhouettes jump out of the vehicle, stumbling with pale blond and dark raven hair becoming apparent beneath the flashing streetlights—

“*Katsuki*!”

Mitsuki Bakugou hurls herself onto her son, her arms flinging and encasing him and immediately pulling him impossibly close to her chest.

Izuku has only two seconds to fully digest the scene before him as he, too, finds his face plunged into warmth and his mother’s familiar perfume—*roses and chamomile*—enveloping him in a tidal wave.

He winces as his bones pop and his bruises freshly react to the new pressure and body heat, but the wetness sliding onto his skin from above reminds him that his face is buried in his mother’s shoulder, her jacket so thin beneath the cold and yet, he finds shelter with her in a way he never could in any other moment.

Mom?

“Oh, m-my baby, Izuku—honey, I-I’m so glad you’re okay. We…” Inko sobs further into him, clutching tighter to a point where Izuku isn’t sure he can breathe.

Then, something inside him, whether it’s been coiled and waiting all this time and not having an opportunity to come forward or not, snaps.

His knees buckle he trembles and embraces his mother in return, burying his nose into her hair. He whispers soothing words to her, delighted, overjoyed, *unbearably happy* to feel his mother's arms around him and know that both she and Mitsuki had arrived here safely.

How did you find us…? How did you know? How did you rent a car this late? Who came with you?

His own tears leak out over his cheeks, running down and dripping off his chin. He sighs shakily, hoping that he won't cry for too long and make them all stay outside in the frigid cold. He turns, and sees Katsuki standing stiff and his face oddly open and *warm* as his mother screams, curses and refuses to release him from her undeniably powerful hold.

"Mitsuki. Inko. We should be leaving soon, I'm sorry to say."

Izuku blinks and, instinctively, breaks out of his mother's hold and pushes her behind him. She blinks at this action and steadies herself, sniffing and wiping at her nose.

Izuku's eyes widen.

Two men stand next to the parked car, both draped in long brown overcoats, middle-aged and quite different in their facial structures. It takes Izuku several long seconds to draw his eyes up and around these two, polished and ruffled silhouettes. One man resembles an everyday gentleman from any street in any scenario during the day, with cropped black hair and kindly black eyes. The other is scraggly and taller in height with a narrow jaw, wisps of golden hair tumbling past his chin with ice-blue eyes staring into Izuku's very being with a slight merciless edge.

Strangely enough, something about them both seems…

Why do they look so familiar?

"Who the fuck are you?!" Katsuki snaps, also standing protectively in front of his mother even as she continues to hiss and gripe at him. He growls and steps forward, swinging his arms and his brow twitching. "You're not holding our moms hostage, are you, *motherfuckers*?!"

"Katsuki!" Mitsuki smacks him in the back of the head, earning a stifled growl in return. "They're friends of ours!"

Ours?

Both Mitsuki and Inko?

Izuku's brow furrows, even as he studies the two men. Despite their powerful presence, both seem slightly sheepish under the attention. Clearing his throat, the golden-haired man steps forward and nods his head towards both Katsuki and Izuku, as if preemptively knowing to present himself in some manner of respect.

"My name is Yagi Toshinori. This is my… partner, you could say, Detective Tsukauchi Naomasa. We have known both Mitsuki and Inko for many years. Though, that's not the

important thing at the moment." He flicks his head towards the car parked on the side of the road. "We will be heading to Sommartyn immediately for the Bakugou residence. Security is tightly wound there thanks to Tsukauchi's doing."

"You flatter me, Yagi." Detective Tsukauchi tips his hat. "Pleased to meet you both. Izuku. Katsuki." Both teens blink in his presence, unsure how to digest the situation before them. "I think it would be best if we left before we're forced to establish more serious matters in order to be walking around after dark."

Izuku keeps his mouth shut and his questions ablaze in his mind even as he and Katsuki are directed to the car.

Katsuki growls and snaps at the two adults and steps harshly between the nudging detective and Izuku, glaring up at the man with a firm scowl.

"Don't touch him."

Izuku flushes red, scratches his cheek and ducks into the car.

He situates himself on the other side, blinking at the clean, fresh-smelling interior. His mother and Mitsuki are seen outside the windows, talking animatedly with one another while occasionally glancing through the rolled-up windows of the vehicle, fresh tears speckling both of their faces.

Katsuki slides next to Izuku, hunching forward and running his hands through his hair. Izuku leans forward as well, and slowly, carefully, reaches over and squeezes Katsuki's knee. On reflex, Katsuki blinks and glares into the floor, yet accepts the gesture. Izuku's breath hitches, considering the warmth seeping into his fingers and the hard cords of muscle that make up Katsuki's bruised, hurt leg.

To think, Katsuki had been the first to initiate an intimate touch, a mind-boggling kiss in the rain with hopeful movement towards something more when Izuku stopped him.

Yet, the memory of Nero's mouth on his and his hands roaming every inch of his body still zaps in his mind's eye like lightning.

He reels back. Sweat bursts out onto his skin. He balls his hands into fists and balances them on his knees, his breath leaving in calculated, heavy pants.

"... Deku?"

He can feel Katsuki's unsureness and frustration at watching him struggle to even keep his mind focused in the present.

He shakes as if the world is thrust onto his shoulders, his heart beating rapidly against his chest and his eyes rolling into the back of his head.

"*Shit, shit, fuck—hey! He's fucking—what the fuck is wrong with him?!*"

It’s almost as if an eternity passes, but Izuku isn’t sure what the reality is as he blinks open his eyes and finds himself clutching to Katsuki’s arm as a lifeline. He flushes beneath the contact, and moves to remove his hands, only for the blond to grab his wrists and keep him there, his glare ferocious and burning in their scarlet depths.

He blinks, the warm scent of tea and fresh scones wafting through what he recognizes to be the Bakugous’ grand living room.

The traditional Russian décor from their last visit bounce off the walls and flourish through Izuku’s vision. He holds his breath, counting back from one hundred even as he leans back towards the couch and ignores the heavy layer of sweat caking his body and soaking through his clothes.

“Hey, shitnerd.”

Izuku groans shakily.

“Sorry, Kacchan—”

“You finish that sentence and I’m throwing you out the goddamn window.” Katsuki rolls his eyes and lightly presses the back of his hand to his forehead. "You're not burning up or anything..." he frowns.

"Uh." Izuku blushes. "I'm fine, Kacchan. Really."

Katsuki scoffs.

"Really!" He sighs, still shaking. Barely holding onto the present. "I'm fine. I... I swear."

He adjusts his clothes, scanning the vicinity with a slightly more honed awareness.

“What’s happening?” he asks.

"You, lying like a little bitch."

"Eh?" Izuku huffs. "Kacchan, that's not fair at all."

Katsuki only rolls his eyes, shifting away from him but allowing his leg to brush against his.

“Oh, good, he’s calmed down.”

Izuku bolts up and squeaks, only to relax at Mitsuki Bakugou's presence.

She enters the room with surprising grace and stability, considering her freshly swollen eyes and tear-strewn features. She looks as if she hasn’t slept in days and has screamed herself hoarse, and for a moment, Izuku remembers how strained and ferociously angry her own son had looked back in the warehouse—

No. You’ll freak out again. Stop.

“You had a panic attack.” Mitsuki tilts her head. “How are you feeling now?”

Izuku cards one hand through his curls. Beside him, Katsuki stiffens, his presence still dangerous, still tumultuous, like an ever-ticking bomb ready to fly off its hinges.

He’s not sure why the other teen is still so tense now that they’re back in his own home, yet the possibility of him missing out on a key conversation while he was lost in a frayed world in the car seems likely.

“I’m… okay?” Izuku pauses. “Yeah.”

Mitsuki tucks one strand of hair behind her ear. She's carrying a finely decorated china plate in her nimble hands. Slowly, she lowers it to the coffee table, hot scones studded with berries and chocolate flooding Izuku’s nostrils and sending an alarming stirring sensation to his stomach. He lurches forward, aware of the way his mouth fills with water at such a sight, and almost sighs in relief as Katsuki grabs the plate, roughly pops one into Izuku’s mouth, and keeps the rest to himself.

“Mmph—”

“Shut up and *eat food* before you pass out again, stupid Deku!” Katsuki snaps.

With a roll of his eyes, Izuku complies. He bites off the scone and chews, relishing the gentle, warm bready dessert.

Mitsuki sighs. “Your mother, Izuku. She went out to talk with Mr. Toshinori about something private. Today was…”

She shakes her head, gritting her teeth behind her closed lips.

“We immediately contacted them when hearing about how Isabori and Illenova’s own squadron members secured Sommartyn Mall to arrest two people who, apparently, according to the broadcast, had broken tolling regulations and were required to be taken into custody.”

She pauses.

“We made sure to dial in with your classmates, Izuku. They’re all okay.”

Izuku’s eyes widen at this. He sets down his scone.

“And Uraraka? You called her family too? I know that, her dad’s been sick—”

Mitsuki blinked, smiling slightly. “Yes. Of course. They were all escorted out of the theater and she called your mom first to see if she knew what was happening. Inko then called me, of course, and, we knew something was wrong. The fact that I hadn’t heard from my son at all to begin with was reason enough to be concerned.”

She stifles another frown, tilting her head to the side as she addresses the both of them and their current state.

“Boys. When Inko returns, you need to tell us what happened, who did what, and who these people were. *Specifically*.”

Katsuki’s glare sharpens.

“Why the fuck does it matter, old hag? You already know what a lot of them do. It’s not like it will change anything. Hell, we fucked up their warehouse and I blew the shit off of some security cameras before we left—”

“Oh? So that makes you think that you’ve completely wrecked their system apart from the inside-out? Goddammit, Katsuki, that is not how this works!” Mitsuki breathes harshly through her nose.

She paces along the carpet, arms trembling as her long, manicured fingers perch on her hips. Despite her constant air of elegance, she always seems exhausted beyond belief, and tonight Izuku has never seen a powerful woman like Mitsuki so close to crumbling.

“The only reason we were able to find you at all was through interrogation and other sources brought to us by Mr. Toshinori and Detective Tsukauchi.” Mitsuki turns to the closed door of their home, a sigh leaving her lips. “Izuku, I’ve already spoken with your mother about this, and I think it’ll be indefinite by the time we go through… everything, we need to talk about, tonight, but, I will say this. One thing is clear, and that is that you and Inko will be living with us for the time being.”

Izuku’s eyes nearly bulge out of their sockets, his flustered, bruised, battered cheeks so livid with newfound emotion that it nearly burns Katsuki just to look at him.

But no matter what, he can’t look away, not when he’s aware of the other boy’s presence, the other teen’s touch and the feel of his lips under his own, how his skin trembles beneath his hands and how their knees both buckle with stubborn resistance—

Fucking weak. Why the fuck are you thinking about this right now? Asshole.

He pinches the bridge of his nose, struggling to count back from the patterns of numbers imprinted in his mind’s eye. He can’t explain the sudden need to remain close to Izuku’s side, especially on the couch while the other boy frantically waves his arms and splutters in the presence of his own mother—whom Katsuki knows adores Izuku almost as much as Inko—while altogether turning fiercely red.

“We—huh? No, no, we, we couldn’t do that—”

Katsuki restrains himself from smacking Izuku in the back of the head.

It takes one look to reassess the other's wounds, still visible over his layers of clothing and the distant shimmer of shock and appreciation in those forest-green eyes.

"Shut the fuck up, Deku," whispers Katsuki.

Mitsuki has the audacity to roll her eyes, but remain firm while she folds her arms over her chest. Even now, with her emotions whipped out of her and slashing faded tears across her cheeks, she still exudes the strength of a true Russian Bakugou.

Katsuki wonders just how well Izuku's own mother paralleled Mitsuki years ago, when they were supposedly inseparable friends in university.

Still, despite his harsh whisper, Izuku is determined to run his mouth with a ridiculous air of courage and insistence that, frankly, Katsuki knows is partial to why he was drawn to kiss him.

"My mother… she needs a place to stay, for sure. But, I don't want to even add an extra hindrance to your space. I couldn't! And, won't that make you worse targets than you already are? I don't want to impose and I know that my mom would need the help more than anything. You've all done so much for us already and—"

"Izuku." Mitsuki shakes her head. "This isn't an option. It's a solution. And, I've already talked about it with your mother. She basically protested the same way but said you should stay here and that I leave her out to rot like some horrible friend who can't stand people with kind hearts. The both of you are far, far too nice for your own good." She chuckles, a twitch in the corner of her lips. "My husband will be here soon to go over some of the house rules and regulations, and hopefully he can join us for the more… important matters."

Katsuki snorts.

Damn right he's fucking staying here.

The thought of somehow being apart from Izuku, after watching him become subjected to unspeakable things in front of him while he could do *nothing*—makes Katsuki's blood curdle. He can't even imagine the scenario of both Izuku and Inko leaving the front doors to their house tonight and somehow making their way back to Isabori, the most dangerous district in Augustana, in the same vicinity as the warehouse where they escaped…

Not gonna fucking happen.

Before Izuku can protest to Mitsuki's words, the door opens, and the slim figures of Yagi Toshinori and Detective Tsukauchi slips inside.

Their coats are wet with rainwater, their faces flushed from the growing cold in the outdoors. Inko follows suit, peeling back the hood of her own jacket and appearing far paler than she had before.

"Mom!" Izuku stands up, and Katsuki does as well when his companion winces and struggles to even budge from his spot on the couch. He clenches his teeth and palms at his knee, brow

furrowing in confusion. “What the…?”

“Did you pull something?” Katsuki reaches. “Let me see.”

“No, Kacchan, it’s okay.” Izuku sighs.

“Like hell it is!”

“Really. It’s fine.” Izuku stares at him, pleading silently with his eyes.

Please don’t. I don’t want them to know.

Katsuki blinks.

He wants to tell him that he’s absolutely insane for wanting to keep anything secret, that it’s completely useless against someone like Mitsuki Bakugou who could read him like an open-faced textbook. He wants to tell him that it’s absurd to think that any of this is worth shoving aside for no other reason than for Izuku to somehow keep his problems concealed in shadows.

Fuck that bullshit!

“You’re fucking crazy,” Katsuki growls, low and deliberate.

Izuku stares back defiantly, refusing to break eye contact with him, and it’s at this point Katsuki knows how far he’s crawled into Izuku’s space, leaning forward to increase the aggression in his stance and causing Izuku to subconsciously mirror him and lean backwards in return.

Both faces focused and angrily mocked up, eyes flaring and noses scrunched.

Immediately, Katsuki clears his throat and shuffles back to the other end of the couch.

His face burns, and he feels his mother and Inko eyeing the two of them with risen eyebrows and a certain air of speculation about them.

“Young Izuku. Young Katsuki.”

Katsuki snaps his head over to where Yagi Toshinori comes over to them, coughing into his fist. He wipes his hand on his coat and switches between the two of them. Katsuki growls and bristles, following the way Yagi’s eyes fall onto Izuku in particular, as if considering something he wishes to say and deciding in the last second that he doesn’t want to.

“It’s… been a long day, I’m sure, for the both of you. Detective Tsukauchi and I will remain close, and will be stopping by tomorrow for an intensive interview. I’m sure you have many questions, but tonight, we all should regroup and get some of the basic details out.” He scratches at his narrow chin, his movements oddly waif-like despite the air of strength hanging about him like a disgruntled cloud.

“We can take it from here, Toshinori. Detective. Thank you for helping us find our boys.”

Katsuki lifts his head, blinking at the sight of Inko removing gloves from her hands, still shaking like a leaf under a storm but bearing her own weight against the throttle of her emotions. She reminds him so incredibly much of Izuku that it's alarming. Even then, she turns, smiles brightly towards the two visitors, and dips her head.

"Inko?" Mitsuki frowns. "Let's wait until Masaru gets here."

Inko pauses. "Should we really wait that long?"

They stare at one another, a silent battle for dominance that simmers beneath the surface with palpable awareness. Katsuki stiffens, skin enlivened with goose bumps. He discretely watches Detective Tsukauchi make small observations of his own and whisper to the golden-haired gentleman under his breath. The looks they share are brief, but not quick enough to avoid Katsuki's watchful eye.

Katsuki turns to Izuku, and smirks at noticing Izuku watching them as well.

"Anyway." Mitsuki clears her throat, though Katsuki doesn't miss the way Mitsuki stares between him and Izuku with a risen eyebrow. "Izuku. Katsuki. Why don't the two of you go wash up? And Izuku, honey, we have a guest room for you that my bratty son can prepare for you. We can talk afterwards."

Inko blinks. "Oh! That's fine, Mitsuki. The boys can just share a room."

Instantly, Katsuki's heart leaps into overdrive.

The thought of being locked in a bedroom with Izuku in any capacity is enough to make him almost collapse into cardiac arrest.

He doubts that *sleeping* will be the only thing that transpires if he's anywhere near the other boy in a close, tight-knit vicinity where his personal belongings and bedsheets and old collections are displayed for only the freckled boy to see…

Mitsuki bursts into a hollow, bemused laugh.

Inko frowns. "Um—"

"Oh boy. No, no, Inko." She smirks at Katsuki, and he knows that she can read just about every urge rippling beneath his skin. "It'll be fine. I think it'd be better if they didn't sleep in the same room. That might even mean they'd sleep in the same bed. And, we can't have that."

Her eyes are sparkling with mischief and *knowing* and Katsuki's already flaring red with embarrassment.

He snarls and resists every urge to stand up and bellow at the top of his lungs and toss the coffee table at the sniveling blonde wench.

"Right. Well." Yagi coughs into his fist once more, this time harsher than the last. He pounds his fist to his chest, sighing. "We will stop by tomorrow and check in on things. Thank you,

the both of you, for helping us further in our investigation. It was good to see you again."

Inko and Mitsuki nod with their goodbyes, and with that, both the detective and the mysterious golden-haired man are gone.

The quiet that follows would be more awkward if not for the tension thickening the air.

Katsuki growls and stands up, brushing down his pants.

"You stink and you need to clean those wounds. Help Izuku with that, will you?" Mitsuki nods her head. "Understand?"

"Don't need to fucking tell me twice, old hag." Katsuki snaps his jaws. "I'll fucking do it. Come on, Deku."

He doesn't wait for the freckled teen to protest as he snatches his wrist and drags them both up the stairs, though he is not ignorant enough to not notice the abrupt, fiery conversation volleying back and forth between both of their mothers.

"Um…"

"What the fuck are you looking at?"

Izuku turns away from him, the sudden air of bashfulness striking Katsuki as both oddly endearing and incredibly frustrating.

He'd rather it be the two of them alone again, yet the possible chance of being able to kiss him won't be possible with their quite literal mother hens arguing downstairs.

"So. Clothes." Izuku scratches his cheek. "I don't exactly—"

"You can borrow some of mine. Even though they'll all be huge on your bony ass," Katsuki says with a firm click of his tongue. He passes the door to his bedroom and to the closet at the end of the hallway, opening the doorknob and peering inside. "Blankets and shit are in here. Just pick what you want and take it with you to the guest room at the end of the hallway."

Izuku huffs with a firm roll of his eyes, muttering.

"I'm not *that* scrawny."

Katsuki hides his smirk with his back turned to the other boy, rubbing his chin in thought as he scans the blankets and stored pillows. Plastic bins and other older woven blankets from the early years of his parents' marriage are wedged in organized layers. Colorful pillows are shoved in the back as well, just out of reach.

He calmly turns his head, feigning indifference as he slowly draws his eyes up Izuku's form, lingering when he notices Izuku flushing beneath the attention and shifting in his own socks.

"Hm. Maybe not *that* scrawny." His lips curl dangerously in the corner, and he barks out a laugh as Izuku splutters and starts to move down the hallway, furiously rubbing at his neck.

Oh, no you don't.

Katsuki reaches out and hooks his chin over Izuku's shoulder, effectively keeping the other boy locked in place and stiff as a board.

Katsuki resists the urge to firmly plant his mouth on Izuku's clavicle, and smirks with his hands in his pockets and his figure looming just a bit taller, just a bit broader behind this insufferable—yet, infuriatingly tough and dare he admit, *adorable*—nerd shielded under his grasp.

"Kacchan...?"

Katsuki's snarky grin grows wider.

"You trying to run away?"

Izuku stops, and cranes his neck to somehow meet some of Katsuki's meandering glare with his own skeptical green eyes.

"Are you trying to catch me?"

Katsuki's pupils dilate at this.

The idea of chasing after Izuku and reveling in the thrill of such a challenge sends his heart hammering and mouth salivating with interest.

He remembers Izuku's determined fire and brilliant thinking in the middle of their conflict with the squadron members and the disgusting fuckers who even tried messing with the both of them, and instantly his previously discovered respect becomes intermingled with the knowledge that he'd been the second, not first, person to kiss Izuku Midoriya.

Perhaps he will have to be rid of Nero himself.

Fuck.

But now, he has Izuku in his vicinity, the two of them up the stairs in a distance that's broad enough to keep some privacy between them.

He hides his erratic, villainous smirk at such a thought, and instead sidles up his body to brush against Izuku's back. He keeps his hands bunched in his pockets, yet his palms are dangerously close to sparking with his Quirk if he lets himself too close too soon.

"We didn't finish where we left off." Katsuki growls lowly and teasing, inhaling the fresh musk of *sweat and exertion and smoke* leftover on their clothes.

Through the heavy musk of their escape and the warehouse on their clothes, there's still an undeniable touch of *Deku* through each interweaving layer.

"We—um. Right." Izuku stammers and struggles to maintain his composure. "But, Kacchan, we're both—we should wash up, and—"

He lets out a squeak when Katsuki nips at his neck, growling over his heated, flushed skin.

"Kacchan," Izuku hisses, "what if our moms—"

"They won't," says Katsuki, taking his hands out of his pockets and resting them on Izuku's hips. "It's weird how soft your skin is," he mutters.

Izuku blinks. "Um. Thank you?"

The other boy stiffens and straightens his posture, as if to somehow take back some form of resistance in their current position.

Katsuki smirks at the action and grazes his lips over Izuku's collarbone, just below the stained fabric of his shirt.

Then, Izuku ducks out beneath Katsuki's chin, causing him to stumble over his shoes and nearly land face-first on the carpet.

He blinks and glares harshly up towards Izuku, who watches him with a sudden twinkle in his eye and a vindictive grin on his lips.

"We both smell like old cars and asphalt." Izuku sticks out his tongue, an action that causes Katsuki's brow to twitch and his chest to tighten up. "Maybe after I shower, then we can see —*oomph*!"

Izuku squeaks as his back is pressed to the wall, Katsuki's hands pressed on both sides of his head and his mouth slammed onto his. He lingers there, his tongue tracing and exploring the caverns of Izuku's mouth. He smirks into the embrace and slides apart Izuku's knees with his leg, grinning at the close proximity and eagerly kicking aside the pillows and blankets Izuku had dropped in the middle of his ambush.

Katsuki parts the kiss, a growl rumbling thick and fierce in his chest.

The last time they were this close, he'd threatened to burn him alive and throw him out the window.

Izuku blinks rapidly, his lips swollen red and somehow still so pink and *ready for Katsuki* among the bruises and scuff marks.

“You really like to rile me up, shitty Deku.” Katsuki inches closer, tilting his head to the side and searching Izuku’s determined, scarlet features. “Maybe I don’t want to wait.”

Izuku clears his throat, pausing momentarily to collect his jumbled thoughts.

Katsuki almost purrs at the overwhelming sense of pride and territorial joy that crawls up his senses at knowing only he can render Izuku this breathless; that only he can cause his annoying mumbling to slam into a brick wall.

Stupid fucking nerd.

He’s kissed him twice and he’s already feeling the desperation to kiss him until he holds his heart in the palm of his hands. He wants to see Izuku unravel completely, but…

Tonight is not the night for that.

It’s a miracle that Izuku is willing to be touched in any way at all, considering the disgusting hands that wandered over his body only hours before—

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki snaps out of his reverie, his pensive frown drawing up as he reads the concern on Izuku’s face.

A slight playfulness dances in those green irises, adding an extra layer of childish innocence to the freckles dusting his nose and cheekbones.

“Are you—”

“Don’t even fucking ask, shitnerd.” Katsuki snorts and reluctantly pulls back, running one shaking hand through his hair. “Gonna shower first.”

Izuku balks. “Wha—Kacchan!”

“Hey, quit your fucking whining! I take short showers!”

“You just made a huge deal about—”

“Yeah I know what I fucking said!” Katsuki pinches the bridge of his nose, growling lowly and refusing to even look Izuku in the eye until he gathers his bearings. “Just. Fucking bear with me, alright?” He watches as a certain flash of understanding crosses Izuku’s lips.

The other boy’s eyebrows raise to his hairline, and he nods, as if guilty.

“Okay.”

No. Wait. Why the fuck do you look guilty, you stupid asshole?!

Izuku grins sheepishly.

“You know, Kacchan.” He pauses, considering. “I wouldn’t have let you touch me at all if I didn’t want it.”

Katsuki’s frown deepens, and he turns away.

“You’re just—”

“Trying to make you feel better?” Izuku tilts his head to the side, a curious expression that reminds Katsuki more of a puzzled puppy than anything. “I wouldn’t just assume or disrespect you like that. That’s not… how your brain works.” He shrugs. “Um. Yeah. So—um, you never have to worry about that, or anything.”

He giggles slightly, and all that Katsuki can do in that moment is… stare.

Blood rushes to Katsuki’s cheeks. He turns away and rubs his neck.

Stupid, fucking, annoying, insistent, dumb, smart-ass nerd.

“Oh, hello boys.”

Instantly, Katsuki straightens and bristles and Izuku flushes twice as red as before.

They both look to their left, at Mitsuki standing with her arms crossed and a knowing smirk overtaking her lips. She giggles behind her hand and flicks her head to the bathroom just a few yards away on the same level.

“Izuku, honey, you can shower *first*.” She emphasizes the last word with a click of her tongue. “I’m going to have a little talk with my son.”

Katsuki twitches.

Izuku smiles apologetically at him and bolts to the bathroom.

Fucking traitor.

Katsuki rolls his eyes and turns to his mother, grumbling under his breath.

A few beats of silence pass, and Mitsuki apparently deems it safe enough to talk when they both hear the shower water running beyond the closed, locked door.

Katsuki already wants to explode the knowing smile off his mother’s face.

“So.”

“Don’t start, hag!” he snaps.

“How long?” Mitsuki raises an eyebrow.

"None of your business!" He crosses his arms. "We met, what, not even a month ago? So why the fuck does it matter?"

"Well I mean," Mitsuki starts, tapping her chin, "you clearly had a crush on him that first night."

"Hah?" Katsuki *fumes*. "If anything it was that stupid nerd who had a thing for me first!"

"Hm." Mitsuki chuckles, shaking her head. "How a son of mine can be so ignorant of his own affections really puzzles me."

"Shut the fuck up!" Katsuki glares into another wall. "It doesn't... it doesn't matter, alright? So buzz off!"

His mother's eyes soften, but she persists. “Inko and I were suspecting something was going on, what with you two hanging out together all the time…” she trails off. “But I’m not stupid, Katsuki. I know that you’ve been dragging Izuku through some intense situations that shouldn’t even be on your radar.”

Katsuki’s hands ball into fists. “He’s… more capable than he fucking looks. And—I’m working on it. Getting him stronger, I mean.” He groans at the infuriating blush coloring his skin. “I put together a regime for him and everything. He was stupid, wanting to protect both him and his mom with, what, noodle arms and the power of fucking *words*?” He snorts at the thought.

Mitsuki is silent, studying him.

He growls under her stare, glancing around him as if just to avoid her scrutinizing gaze.

“*What*?”

His mother’s grin widens.

“Oh, nothing. We can talk more in the morning. But, if you two, you know, hang out, keep the door cracked open just a smidge—”

“Oh my fucking God we are *not* having this conversation you crazy old bat!”

Izuku hesitates in pulling the old shirt over his head, his eyes raking over the bruises and welding scars that have formed a tense place on his flesh.

He bites his lip, annoyed at the swollen rings around his eyes, the black patches marking his shoulders and especially around his jaw and left cheekbone, and he wonders, for the life of him, why *Katsuki Bakugou* would ever feel the incentive to kiss him at all when he currently looks like garbage.

His skin still tingles with the muted scents of unwanted touch.

The memories of Nero's hands roughly grabbing him, caressing him, palming between his legs while viciously pulling at the strands of his hair… even with the shower water bulleting against his back in rough, but soothing patterns, he could not forget or wash away the sensations.

Gritting his teeth, Izuku finishes pulling the shirt over his head and brushes his hands down the old, worn fabric. He blinks, and cracks a small smile at noting the faded letters of a Russian translation of All Might's name, embroidered over the image of the heroic icon himself pumping his fist into the air.

The shirt is, unfortunately, a little big on him, and when he slips on a pair of sweatpants he holds back an annoyed grunt at the thickness. The drawstrings allow the material to somewhat hang on his hips. He rolls his eyes and, with a final fluffing of his wild, still-drying green curls, he opens the steaming bathroom's door to nearly ram directly into Katsuki.

"Watch where you're going!" Katsuki snaps.

"Sorry Kacchan!"

Izuku steadies himself by the doorway. His heart races in his chest as he looks up and down Katsuki's frame, realizing that the blond has already showered himself—maybe he used his mother's or father's, Izuku thinks—and he's walking around with a long-sleeved, red cotton shirt and a pair of his own sweatpants, black in contrast to Izuku's gray.

Katsuki is bruised and physically damaged as well, but the undeniable ferocity and handsome aura that drew Izuku to him in the first place on the train still radiates from him like cologne.

"Fucking sneaking up on me like Houdini or some shit," growls Katsuki, but there's hardly any bite to his words.

"Well, *you're* the one who just walked randomly up to the bathroom door," says Izuku, shrugging. "You can't blame me for *every* flawed moment of yours, Kacchan."

He expects another yell or even a screaming match from his companion, but the blond is far too busy scoping him up and down and drawing in each and every detail and—

Oh. Right.

I'm wearing Kacchan's old clothes.

"Who gave you that?" Katsuki asks, his eyes glazed and distracted as he lingers on certain details of Izuku's outfit.

“Uh—your mom. She left it folded up in the bathroom…” Izuku scratches his neck. "Um, I can... maybe I can switch into something else. Or something."

"No."

Izuku blinks, glancing over Katsuki's features. He seems unfocused, still latching onto random places on his upper body and face.

"I like it."

Oh.

His heart stutters under his ribcage. His stomach erupts in butterflies.

Katsuki leans against the doorframe, hands in his pockets. He's watching him, as if expecting him to talk.

Izuku blinks dumbly and grins. “Uh. Um... h-how’d you shower, anyway? You tried picking a fight with me about it earlier.”

“Didn’t want to use my old hag’s if I didn’t have to.” Katsuki clicks his tongue, and the smirk that follows suit causes Izuku’s skin to flush red and tingle.

It’s a rather unfair advantage that he should add to the *Katsuki Bakugou* list in his notebook.

Though, Katsuki had already staked a firm foothold earlier in this strange, unfamiliar game they’re playing.

All that Izuku wants, before he needs to talk to both of their mothers about what happened to them the next morning, is to have his mind shift to something else. A safe haven with open arms and a dangerous aura of protectiveness and pure, raw strength that makes Izuku’s chest flare up with competitiveness and his knees buckle with *want.*

Before Katsuki can say anything, Izuku takes a firm step forward, grabs the other by the collar of his shirt, and *pulls*.

Katsuki nearly stumbles over his feet at being yanked into another kiss.

It takes only seconds for the tentative experiment to explode into a rough mess of clashing teeth and wandering tongues and desperate mouths. It's overpowering, but enough to let Izuku breathe in-between exploring Katsuki's mouth with his tongue, thankful and safe.

Izuku moans and wraps his arms around Katsuki’s neck, holding him in place. Katsuki's hands drift down to the small of his back, carefully, hesitantly, pulling him closer to him. His body heat washes over Izuku in a wave, and he can feel the steady thumping of Katsuki's heart under his chest, through the thin layer of fabric separating them.

Then, Katsuki breaks the kiss, and stares into Izuku’s eyes. He growls so deeply that he *shivers*.

“My room,” whispers Katsuki.

Izuku only nods, and that’s enough for the teen to grab his wrist and pull him down the hallway, past the cracked open door and to be suddenly pushed onto a soft, clean bed—fragrant with fresh lavender detergent and reeking of Katsuki’s cologne—his back ramming into it with a soft thump.

He blinks, excitement and anticipation sizzling in his veins as he turns and watches Katsuki, all while his gaze remaining glued to Izuku, close the door to his room.

Izuku sits up, frazzled and curious and ready.

Katsuki reads this instantly, and within those seconds he stomps towards him and pushes him back down, straddling his thighs with his own powerful legs, leaning down and pressing his mouth onto his. The kiss is softer than the other and wet with intensity, and instinct drives Izuku to run his hands along Katsuki’s chest, feel the soft fabric bunch beneath his touch and revel in the heavy growls and curses that come out of Katsuki’s mouth.

There's strength in the muscles rippling under the cloth, in the protective bones caging his heart. The heart of someone who protected him, who tried to save him as quickly as he could when they were both in imminent danger.

Izuku's right hand lifts and grabs the back of Katsuki's head, tracing through the tuft of wild blond hair. It's soft under his fingers, like he'd always expected.

“*Fuck, Deku*,” Katsuki moans, and even his looming presence hovering over Izuku alone is enough to send his heart and stomach fluttering.

He trails his mouth from Izuku’s lips to his throat, and Izuku’s mind blanks as he places one possessive hand next to his head and *sucks* directly on the juncture between his neck and shoulder blade. He hesitates, for only a moment, before his teeth sink in.

“K-Kacchan,” Izuku rasps.

Warmth pools in his stomach and drops to his hips, liquid fire traveling low and lower still.

He groans and allows his hands to roam Katsuki’s back, joyful in the dips and arcs of what make up the contours of his body.

He’s powerful through and through, stable like a mountain and aggressive like a prowling tiger, and it delights Izuku in ways he can hardly describe.

He runs his hands beneath Katsuki’s shirt, trailing his fingers over defined, strong abdominals.

His toes curl at the feeling of smooth pectorals under his touch, and he grins toothily as Katsuki’s breath hitches and he responds with another rough kiss on his neck. He drifts across his neck, and bites into his bared shoulder. Izuku squeaks however, when Katsuki’s teeth find a path and sink into his collarbone.

Katsuki smirks as he pulls up with a small *pop*.

“Y’ asked for it, damn nerd…” he growls and nudges the collar of Izuku’s borrowed shirt with his nose. “This. Can I…?”

Warmth swells inside Izuku.

Katsuki is asking him permission, being careful with his wishes. With what he wants.

He hesitantly nods.

“Um, there’s not much to see, um.”

He blinks as Katsuki’s calloused palm coasts beneath his shirt and trails over his own stomach, sheltering and curious.

His dark red eyes find his, smirk insatiable and hungry.

“Kacchan?”

“I’ve seen you shirtless before, Deku,” he growls. “Trust me. I want to be the only fucking person seeing that.”

Izuku blinks, unsure of how to process this as he’s shimmied out of his shirt.

He blushes beneath the weight of the other’s stare and how… strangely mesmerized, Katsuki seems as he raises up and hovers over him, a pillar of strength and raw aggression.

“You, too.”

Katsuki stares at him, eyebrow risen.

Izuku flushes. “Um—I want to see you, too.”

Katsuki’s smirk broadens. He leans forward and whispers into Izuku’s ear.

“Take it off me then, *Deku*.”

A sudden fire roars in Izuku’s stomach.

He nods his head, and eagerly grabs the bottom of Katsuki’s shirt. He leans up and pulls it over his head.

The two of them stop and stare at one another, both sitting up and parallel to each other’s bodies, their sweats low on their hips and dangerously close to more—

Though Izuku is too distracted with the image already presented to him.

Katsuki Bakugou is unfairly gorgeous.

A young, growing man, built of power and explosive anger, made of endless hard angles and sharp grins. A heart that beats wildly to protect and fight, so believable and real under Izuku's hand.

Katsuki growls, low and teasing, his mouth quirked into a grin, though he doesn't say anything as his eyes search over Izuku's form with tantalizing slowness.

Suddenly, Izuku chuckles, a strange fluttering rising in his chest beneath the other teen's attention.

"You done eye-fucking me, Kacchan?" Izuku asks, hardly breathing through his constrained chuckles and giggles.

Katsuki's eyes shoot up, and his answer is altogether predatory and strong as he leans in.

"*Not yet*."

Chapter End Notes

Sorry, no smut this chapter... I mean, Izuku DID almost get raped. Katsuki's aware of their limits.

It's... coming, though... *Nervous*

Thank you so much for reading everyone and I hope you liked this chapter!

Next udpate will feature... a lot more development. But I think these two boys deserved this moment together, don'tcha think?

Rejoinder

Chapter Summary

He’s not sure what to name this fleeting feeling, this uncomfortable prodding in the back of his mind that connects easily to the image of his parents and Inko talking to one another. Every now and then, he catches Inko watching his movements, her emotional and intelligent gaze latching onto his fading cuts, bruises and marks, the curiosity glowing on her features.

He looks away each time, unsure of where to look without Izuku sitting beside him and muttering nonsensically.

Chapter Notes

Posting a little early because it's KATSUDEKU WEEK EVERYBODY.

So excited.

Not sure if I'll be posting anything outside of the three WIPs I have going on with KatsuDeku, but I suppose we'll have to see, hm? Anyway. Thank you all so much for reading the last chapter as normal. That was one was a lot of fun to write. This one... will have SOME ANSWERS. YES. ACTUAL ANSWERS. THINGS YOU HAVE BEEN WAITING FOR.

And some fluff. Because, there will be a lot more fluff and then... badass stuff. It's a mess.

Thank you all so much, again, for reading, commenting, leaving kudos, bookmarks, etc. It means the world and more.

“Inko, you can’t keep protecting him like this. He’s going to be useless if he doesn’t learn the truth about me, about you, even! You promised you’d leave this behind—”

“Stop touching my son—get away from him right now, Hisashi—”

“Know your place, Inko! He needs to be strong for what’s to come! Our son won’t—”

“You consider this making him stronger? Mitsuki was right; I should’ve stayed—”

“Get out of my house!”

“Stay away from my baby boy Hisashi! Before I do something I regret—”

"You're not capable of something like that, Inko. You know that more than anyone."

"Hisashi. Step away from that door..."

Izuku wakes to the smell of lavender and sweet cream.

He gathers his breath, ignoring the steady racing of his own heart beneath his chest, and tries to be rid of the horrid, acrid taste of gunpowder and metal on his tongue.

The feeling of a gun in his hands, the weight of another, meatier fist beating into his back and slamming him into the ground—

It all felt…

Real.

Blinking, his hands bunch into the bedsheets, and he surveys the lack of decoration in this particular bedroom.

White walls, a single vase filled with lavender stalks, freshly washed and folded blankets stacked off to the corner, moving boxes splayed out in front of the closet… it’s certainly not Katsuki’s bedroom.

Heat floods his cheeks as memories of the previous night, before he’d fallen into an exhausted dream, slips into his conscious.

He bites his lip, remembering as he’d crawled out of Katsuki’s arms once they’d kissed and felt each other up—*a beautiful, discombobulated mess of wrestling tongues and calloused hands and hot breaths and Katsuki’s growls and moans*—and snuck out of his bedroom before either of their mothers could have caught them in the same bed.

His skin tingles with the memory of Katsuki’s lips on his neck, teeth puncturing his skin, hands gripping his back, his stomach, his shoulders, his sides, reaching around his thighs and cupping his rear as he moaned and responded with equal fervency—

Oh my God.

Izuku slaps a hand over his mouth, struggling to balance his flurry of emotions.

He was caught between the shock and strange euphoria he wanted to delight in with knowing that he'd been able to kiss and hold someone like Katsuki Bakugou and have those actions reciprocated.

Yet, his dream, the strange panic he felt leap in his chest, and the unsettling memories of phantom hands grabbing and pulling and yanking in the worst, most private areas of his body tempt him to remain in this room, and stay secluded.

He exhales a shaky breath.

"Calm down," he whispers. "It's the morning. Take a walk, or, run, or something. Maybe the others aren't even awake yet."

He rolls his eyes, blinking down at his naked chest and holding back another groan at realizing he'd most likely left his shirt in Katsuki's bedroom.

"Great…"

Izuku rolls off the blankets, cards one hand through his wild curls, and makes his way over to the dresser. Blinking, he spots a folded old sweatshirt on top, clearly another piece of clothing that belonged to Katsuki. Grinning, Izuku examines the material and slowly pulls it over his form, adjusting its size to slimly fall over his frame. The bright, sunburst orange color is hard to imagine on someone like Katsuki, and it smells strangely fresh, like the interior of a newly purchased car.

He flushes red.

I wasn't always this embarrassed around him. When did things change?

The idea of actually staying with the Bakugous seems unreal to him. How could any of this be possible?

Even now, the memory of finding a gun in his mother's safekeeping boxes, the strange sensations of blood and steel flooding his mind and body in his dream… it all rolls together in jumbled unison, slithering into his muscles and harshly dragging his mind from the warmth of Katsuki's lips on his to the cold loneliness in being trapped in a void he doesn't understand.

With a shrug to himself and a firm brushing over his neck, he adjusts his sweatpants and cautiously opens the door to the guest bedroom.

He peeks his head outside into the hallway, and slowly makes his way across the clean white carpet to coast down the stairwell.

His nose wrinkles as a peculiar, yet familiar, scent wafts through his nostrils and coasts through his mind. He blinks at recognizing the tang of what he believes to be wheat, or a flour of some kind—

Oh.

He arrives at the bottom of the stairwell, the steps cleanly winding into the combined kitchen and casual dining space that was, expectantly, separate from the fancier room where he'd first shared dinner with Mitsuki, his mother and her son.

The tile is cool beneath his socks, and when he glances around the brightened space—glistening white tiles, marbled countertops, light wooden cupboards and open windows spilling through with morning sunlight—his eyes lock onto an unfamiliar gentleman sitting casually at the island.

He's tall and well-muscled beneath the scruffy wool sweater. A pair of glasses is perched on his nose. He's skimming through a newspaper issue, a gleam in his eye as he lifts the ceramic mug from the counter and takes one brief sip before setting it back down.

Instantly, Izuku's skin flares.

This must be Kacchan's father.

As if suddenly sensing his presence, the docile-looking man turns and blinks. His surprise fades into gentle understanding and a slight air of curiosity, nose scrunched in the middle and his aura far too calm and steady to have anything related to the Bakugou family.

But the warmth that rumbles off of him seems strangely familiar as well, and it's almost as if Izuku has met this person before.

"Ah. Good morning. You must be Inko's boy." The man gestures with a flick of his head to the kitchen, just barely cut off even through the technical shared space and the awkward empty doorway. "I know it's hard to see them, but if you were smelling something good, my son is in there whipping breakfast together."

Izuku nods, and smiles bashfully.

"Izuku Midoriya, Sir. Um, it's nice to meet you, Mr. Bakugou." He extends his hand. "My mom always talks about how wonderful your family is and that you all knew each other in college. She hasn't really told me any stories or anything though."

He quickly clamps his mouth shut to prevent any further muttering, though the man laughs jovially and takes his offered hand.

"Please, call me Masaru." He chuckles. "You're certainly as polite and gentlemanly as Mitsuki said. I would expect nothing less from Inko's son." He clears his throat. "I've been gone for quite a bit on a business trip, and got back a little late last night. I heard about some of those gnarly details and that you'll be speaking with the detectives later today." He sighs. "I'll be around here if you boys need anything. Don't be afraid to reach out. Though, Katsuki's already a little riled up already. Wonder why."

Izuku frowns at this, digesting each word carefully.

Right, he'd almost forgotten that they were supposed to speak with the mysterious two men from the night before. He wonders, quite fervently, just how intensive that discussion will be

and what questions will be asked.

Too many things to ask already…

Izuku's smile wobbles, though he strains it just enough to convince this kindly man in front of him.

"I'll go… talk to him. See how he's doing, and—yeah. I'll go do that."

Izuku laughs nervously as he quickly skids across the room and pokes around another corner, momentarily gaping in awe, once again, at just how large and impressively beautiful the Bakugou establishment is.

He scans the vicinity to the stove and extra island and stretch of counters where he remembers fumbling over his own words, wearing his father's old suit, and being angrily ordered to carry potato salad into the dining room.

He holds back a chuckle at the thought.

The sound of metal clanking on marble grabs his attention.

His breath hitches, his stomach growling with hunger as he scopes out the sizzling pancakes on the griddle, handpicked ingredients set aside on the opposite counter. A bowl of freshly cut strawberries and a bag of sugar are sitting untouched, next to utensils that have yet to be used.

Katsuki coasts his hand beneath the pan, his scowl set in a firm line as the flames in his palm burst and engulf the pan in patterns. He sets down the object, grabs a spatula, and tosses one cake after the other with practiced precision and movement.

Izuku looks up and down Katsuki appreciatively, a small smile tugging at the corner of his lips.

Katsuki already looks pristine and ready for the day in a loose white T-shirt and stonewashed jeans. The clothing on his upper body drapes flatteringly over a teasing dip and curve of his well-developed muscles and smooth, flawless skin.

Izuku subconsciously gulps, stares down at his own outfit, and then looks back to the handsome teenager flipping pancakes in the middle of his own kitchen and mimicking the presence of some high-earning fashion model.

It's both a blush-inducing blessing and a frustration.

He may or may not be a little spiteful.

"Um," Izuku starts, groaning at his own mumbling voice. "Do you need help?"

Katsuki blinks, pausing briefly in switching one of the new sets of pancakes on the griddle.

"Deku?"

He then screeches and rushes back to the pan, tossing out curses and holding back from completely obliterating his own stove.

Izuku tilts his head to the side, focused on one particular detail.

“Kacchan,” he says, “you have a working stove. Why do you need to use your Quirk to cook?”

Katsuki snarls as he sets down the pan and flicks away smoke from the burnt, ruined pancake.

“Fucking mind your own shit, Deku!” Katsuki snarls and drags one hand down his face. He raises an eyebrow at Izuku, clicks his tongue, and gestures to the bowl of mix set on the counter behind him. “Make yourself useful. Not in the mood for dumb questions right now.”

Izuku chuckles. He’ll be sure to ask again in a few minutes when Katsuki isn’t upset over a destroyed pancake, though he definitely doesn’t mind the idea of helping cook breakfast in a beautiful house, with the soft morning glow from outside dipping in and casting rays of light along the marble counters.

He gradually makes his way over to Katsuki’s side with the bowl, watching with bated breath and eyes wide in fascination.

The more Katsuki shifted and moved back and forth with the griddle, and the more he allowed his Quirk to be used cautiously and in a controlled manner, the more questions Izuku wanted to ask.

His fingers twitch. He hisses through clenched teeth at the bruised, broken finger, swelling and purple.

Groaning, he moves his hand to his pocket and balances the bowl on his left forearm.

Katsuki’s scowl is still firmly set on the pan as he flips another cake onto the plate next to the stove.

“You didn’t wrap it.”

Ah. So he noticed.

Of course.

Izuku dips his head.

“… No…”

Katsuki growls, furiously moving the pan back and forth. The sparks bursting in his palm roar to life once more, though these flames are undoubtedly stronger.

“And why the fuck *not*, Deku? I left you fucking clear instructions in the bathroom,” he hisses lowly, toning down his voice to avoid his father hearing from around the corner.

Though, despite these efforts, Izuku suspects that the kindly middle-aged man is far more aware and perceptive than he allows others to believe.

Izuku frowns. “It… slipped my mind?”

Katsuki sets down the pan and flips the last pancake onto the plate.

“Whatever. Walk around with a limp noodle finger and advertise to every fucking person in the world that we were kidnapped and tortured. As if our moms aren’t nosy enough.” He snorts. “I’ve fucking broken my fingers before and it hurts like a bitch unless you follow those instructions I left for you in that damn bathroom. But *no*, apparently a certain stupid *Deku* thinks he's totally susceptible to leaving it alone!”

He huffs, and flips another pancake. It lands perfectly on the waiting plate.

Warmth builds in Izuku's chest and spreads to his cheeks, a flattery he hadn’t expected upon knowing that Katsuki was willing to demonstrate a gesture so thoughtful, kind and small specifically for him.

The concern hidden in Katsuki’s growls and yells are spotted with ease, masked to anyone else who wouldn’t be able to experience that same delight that Izuku now recognizes to be alive and well.

For now, at least, he thinks, gulping down the lingering doubts.

“Thanks for worrying, Kacchan,” Izuku says with a brief snicker, “but I’ll take care of it afterwards. I was too distracted, I guess, yesterday.”

He hums under his breath and takes immediate delight in the rosiness that blossoms on Katsuki’s cheeks. He momentarily pauses and clenches his jaw as if the same images are, indeed, careening through his skull.

Izuku bites his lip and casually bumps his hip to Katsuki’s, who grunts.

“I didn’t say I was fucking worried. You’re so full of yourself, shitty Deku,” mutters Katsuki.

Izuku rolls his eyes. “Sure, Kacchan. Sure.” He beams at the sizable portion of cleanly arranged, golden pancakes on a large plate. “They look amazing, Kacchan!”

“’Course they do.” Katsuki’s smirk is a jagged line along his features, one eyebrow quirked as he tosses the spatula back and forth in one hand. “I made them. So they’re fucking griddle masterpieces.”

Izuku snorts and quickly clamps one hand over his mouth.

He leans across the counter space to his far right, gathering the extra plates and balancing them below the dish topped with Katsuki’s “griddle masterpieces.”

Izuku blinks as the weight lifts from his arms. He watches, his breath holding at the clear invasion of Katsuki’s fingers splayed out beneath his own hands supporting the plates, the

grip simple yet stable and undoubtedly protective.

“You’re gonna drop them, dumbass,” growls Katsuki, lifting off two of the six plates in Izuku’s arms. “Plus your finger’s broken so just give it all to me.”

Izuku finds his voice through his stuttering after a good thirty seconds.

“I can—”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, takes half of the plates from Izuku’s arms, and saunters forward into the other room with a steady sway to his strides and his other, strong arm loosely hanging off his jeans.

Izuku swallows back the lump in his throat, heat bristling beneath his skin from just the slightest contact. He wonders if it will be too distracting to be close to Katsuki at all if one touch or one look is all it will take to make him remember the previous night.

His eyes stray from Katsuki’s narrowed glare to the white fabric of his shirt, breezy and soft to the touch and concealing the fine pectorals he’d kissed and stroked with eagerness—

Okay, Izuku. Calm down. We’re not even alone.

He doesn’t say another word and simply follows Katsuki to the more casual dining room.

“Where’s the old hag?” Katsuki says with a risen eyebrow.

His father blinks up from his paper. “Ah. She’s out with Inko, helping her move things from Isabori to here for storage.”

Both Izuku and Katsuki nod at this, and resume their task of setting up the table with folded napkins, silverware and the plate topped with hot pancakes in the center. Izuku blinks in awe and brushes his fingers over the table centerpiece: a glass swan, perfectly fitting the palms of his hands if he bothered to pick it up.

The door opens.

All three heads turn to the presence of Mitsuki and Inko slipping through the doors, both carrying stacked boxes with impressive effort. Inko’s face is flushed pink as she sets her own boxes down, sighing at her friend, who drops each container with a firm brush of her hands and a smug smile on her face.

“Mitsuki, you really shouldn’t have—”

“Hush, Inko! What kind of friend would I be if I made you go take all of this here, hm? Oh, hello darling!” Mitsuki nearly skips over to where her husband smiles softly from his place at the island counter, her lips pressing to his temple in a gentle kiss. “Welcome back.”

Izuku blinks to adjust to the fact that this image, in itself, looks incredibly familiar.

Witnessing his mother, father and Inko Midoriya talk amongst each other like reunited high school friends is more than unnerving.

Katsuki conceals his skepticism behind a firm swallow of his food, chewing around the fluffy texture of his own masterfully created pancakes and switching his gaze between all three adults on the other end of the table.

He carefully tunes out Izuku's impendent muttering, and doesn't even glance his way when the curly-haired boy excuses himself from the table and dashes up the stairwell, mumbling something about "needing to change clothes."

He's not sure what to name this fleeting feeling, this uncomfortable prodding in the back of his mind that connects easily to the image of his parents and Inko talking to one another. Every now and then, he catches Inko watching his movements, her emotional and intelligent gaze latching onto his fading cuts, bruises and marks, the curiosity glowing on her features.

He looks away each time, unsure of where to look without Izuku sitting beside him and muttering nonsensically.

The tension that develops as soon as they excuse themselves and inform Katsuki to start washing the dishes remains high in the air. Katsuki suppresses his irritated growls and glares, gathering each plate and huffing with each stomp to the kitchen. He scowls into the sink, turns on the water and pours blue lathering liquid onto each dish.

"Hey, Kacchan, let me help you with those!"

Katsuki snarls and lifts his head to yell at his companion—*fucker, why did you just abandon me at the fucking table with those old assholes*—and stops.

"What the fuck are you wearing?"

Izuku blinks, lips pursed and brow creased in obvious confusion as he examines his outfit.

"… My clothes? Since, my mom brought them…?" He tilts his head to the side. "I know they're not, you know, *badass* or anything, but they're comfy."

Katsuki's teeth sink into his tongue to keep himself from snapping back out of pure instinct, since he's not actually listening to Izuku's explanation at all.

Izuku is wearing a loose, dark green cotton sweater, draping over a battered pair of jeans with paint splatters and mismatched socks. The neckline is low enough to reveal his collarbones, freckles trailing from his nose and cheeks and disappearing beneath the material.

The material looks easy to rip off is Katsuki would be so daring. He glares, as he can hardly see evidence of where he'd placed his mouth the night before.

Katsuki inhales at the smell that suddenly wisps by his nostrils when Izuku rolls his eyes and insists on shifting closer to him, peering into the sink and lowering his head just enough for Katsuki to glimpse the pale nape of his neck.

"You smell like... mint," he murmurs, only half-paying attention.

His hand is paused in the sink, one hand lingering on the sponge as it scrubs away residue and the other balancing the plate, the water running on a mindless pace. He doesn't even notice when Izuku backs away and stares at him with a mild flush to his cheeks and an awkward smile.

He's searching Katsuki's features for any sign of a change, concentrated yet hesitant to extend a hand towards him.

Katsuki snorts.

He knows that if he dares to even lift that loose sweater just a few inches above the hips, he can scope out hand-shaped marks and purple stains from his own touch and teeth. Marks from him, and him alone.

He wants to pull Izuku close to him, maybe whisper a few dark words in his ear...

Damn.

Their parents are in the other room in complete earshot, and his father especially would be able to tell if they took the risk and fooled around in the kitchen.

He groans and stubbornly turns back to his sink, his scrubbing becoming far more energetic and fervent.

"… You doing alright, Kacchan?"

"Fucking peachy."

He finishes the first plate and hands it to the slightly shorter boy, not even bothering to glance his way this time. "Dry these off, Deku."

Izuku beams at the gesture and gradually takes it, rolling up his sleeves.

Katsuki spots Izuku's bandaged finger as he does so, humming and spewing random thoughts under his breath with a bounce to the balls of his feet. The more he talks, the more animated he becomes, and Katsuki is only able to listen to some relatively random nonsense while keeping his eyes glued to the framed doorway where he knows their parents are still talking on the other side.

"Kacchan."

Katsuki shakes his head, somewhat disturbed by the quiet, rough change in Izuku's voice. His eyes flick to Izuku, noting the deep turn in his formerly bright smile and the shadowed look that passes through his bright green irises.

Seeing Izuku like this immediately makes Katsuki want to punch something.

"I…" Izuku pauses, taking another plate and drying it off. He neatly stacks it on top of the other completed ones before he finally opens his mouth again. "Kacchan, I think, our parents are hiding something. I mean, do you remember what Shigaraki said back in the warehouse?"

Katsuki frowns.

He had been wondering when Izuku was going to feel inclined to talk about what happened, though the thought of pestering him or forcing him into that conversation too early had driven him into a frustrated silence.

The fact that Izuku is opening up the gates first allows some anticipation to wriggle to life.

"Something about your old geezer," says Katsuki, pausing as an afterthought.

Izuku nods.

"Yeah. He knew my father's name. He knew… he knew his first name without me mentioning it first, and for some reason the name *Midoriya* has significance here. At least, that's what it sounded like."

He rubs his chin in thought, nose scrunched up. He's muttering before Katsuki can stop him, though he allows him to do so while attempting to pick out the more important details.

"And our moms have known each other for a while. We both don't know how they met, or how your parents would even know my dad on top of it. So, the missing link here… what could it be? After all this we barely have any clues from our own resources outside of what the villains have told us. Think about it, Kacchan; our moms have known each other for forever, but whenever they talk about themselves or their past, they never talk about what they actually did *together*."

Katsuki leans his back to the counter and wipes his hands in a towel.

"You think they…?" He snorts. "Don't be an idiot, Deku. There's no way that my parents would get people like *your pansy-ass parents* involved."

Izuku whips towards him and the instant fire in his eyes sparks against Katsuki's own surprised expression and causes his stomach to lurch.

He's never seen Izuku this angry.

"My *mom* is the farthest thing from a *pansy*, Kacchan. I can't say the same thing for my dad, considering he left us a long time ago…"

He trails off, though the rage in his irises simmer to a faint summery residue. Katsuki watches the expression shift and bites back an impressed smirk.

“Oh.”

Izuku blinks, his momentary flash of anger apparently pushed aside in favor of something else that causes his eyes to glow.

“Did I tell you that I found a gun in her storage boxes?”

Silence falls between them.

Once the words click, however, the screech that flies out of Katsuki’s lips is deafening.

“What the *fuck*—”

Izuku frantically waves his arms and slaps a hand over Katsuki’s mouth. Katsuki glares warningly and yanks the appendage off, holding tightly onto his wrist. He peers around the corner towards the other room, and then back to the freckled teen just a few inches shy of his height with newfound confusion.

“Not so loud, Kacchan!” Izuku sighs. “I was going to tell you earlier when I… processed it, more. But, yeah. I found a gun in her stuff, in our apartment after we went to the gym that one day.”

He scratches his cheek with his free hand and steps away to allow some distance between them.

Katsuki growls at this, yet straightens and holds his head high in some ascertain way to assert some form of dominance in his own home, even around this admittedly less-scrawny-than-he-expected asshole he conveniently likes to wrestle tongues with.

“You should’ve told me sooner,” says Katsuki.

I could’ve done something.

“I know, I know.”

Izuku frowns. At least he has the decency to look slightly ashamed, if his downcast expression is enough for Katsuki to observe in that regard.

“I didn’t know what to think, though! It was obvious that I wasn’t supposed to find it or even know about it. Even with how it was stashed inside. It was the only box open out of half a dozen, and the lid was half-off.”

He ponders through his recollection, mimicking the expression of a customer trying to choose between one greeting card over the other for an event.

“Just, why would she have it, unless she was involved in something dangerous? I know that we live in Isabori, and that it’s a dangerous area, but she’s always been a pacifist and adamant

about not having weapons in the house."

Katsuki folds his arms over his chest, stroking his chin.

Izuku's rather vocal train of thought are decidedly quite useful, given this context and the fact that his analytical wiring is perfect for exactly what they're trying to decode. Katsuki had ventured through the districts on his own accord and attempted to root out secrets and information on his family from people he knew were conspiring against them.

Though, none of his suspicions had traced him back to the possibility that Inko Midoriya, his own mother's best friend of many years, could have created a presence of her own.

It's almost impossible to picture Inko in any dangerous situation or even being aware of the Bakugou lifestyle. If she's truly as pacifist as Izuku claims, the idea of her even touching a gun, let alone keeping it safely stashed away in her own belongings, borders on the line of inconceivable.

Unless…

"Maybe it's not hers."

The statement grows thick in the air.

Izuku opens his mouth, then closes it, as if to consider this option. His large eyes are glossy with curiosity and wonderment as he rifles through a new set of possibilities. Katsuki snorts at the childlike mannerisms and turns back forward, slipping his hands loosely into his jean pockets.

"Could be your old man's." He sneers. "Let me guess, you haven't asked your mom about it."

"How could I?"

Izuku glares at him and, while it's hilariously out of place on a face that's so youthful and docile, Katsuki would be foolish to dismiss the genuine frustrations and panic hidden in that expression.

There's potential fire lingering in this stare, one that could instill fear into the hearts of its targets in the future. If Izuku followed his regime and allowed him to guide him through the rigorous process Katsuki wanted for him, the possibilities were endless.

"I heard the old hag talking about those two detectives from yesterday. Those geezers are suspicious. I don't care if they have background with the fucking military; we can't just trust them yet." Katsuki locks eyes with Izuku, who reads him just as carefully. "There's something going on here. Those fuckers who kidnapped us know more than we do. Somehow, this all traces back, Deku, and *you* have to fucking grow a pair and ask about the gun."

Izuku's shoulders sag. He bites his lip and brushes both hands through his wild curls.

"You're right, Kacchan," he mutters.

He turns away from Katsuki and quickly wipes at his nose, sniffing.

Katsuki goes rigid and watches, awkwardly, as the boy he'd furiously kissed and felt up the other night struggles hiding his impending tears.

Oh, fuck.

"Uh. Yeah. Just, go fucking talk to her, or whatever. She's your—mom and shit."

He grumbles something inaudible, unsure of how to pass these next few seconds. He takes a half-step forward, reconsiders the gesture and returns to his position in front of the sink. His back hits the countertop, his fists clenching tighter and tighter in and out of his jeans.

Izuku abruptly snorts and bursts into a laugh that causes Katsuki's insides to plummet to his toes.

"Oh, my God, you're *awful* at this comforting thing—"

"Shut the fuck up, stupid Deku!" Katsuki barks, his anger amplifying each second as his blood rushes through his neck and into his cheeks.

Fucking hell!

"I wasn't comforting your crybaby ass! Just, go do it already. And, stop fucking making that dumbass face! It's annoying."

Izuku splutters and his laughter only grows. For a moment, Katsuki wonders if the idiot will even remember to hold back and breathe, as if he's in immediate danger of keeling over at any moment.

After a solid minute of Izuku laughing until his voice drones down to a squeaking, silent gasp of air, Katsuki realizes that he's been watching this freckled son of a bitch make ugly noises and cry for sixty full seconds.

His back and arms turn still when Izuku finally straightens once more, his smile weak and flustered and eyes bright.

he sun spills through the windows and casts a gentle halo around the little bastard's green-hued curls, his fragile smile and strong heart and glass-like eyes shining altogether in a vision that renders Katsuki speechless.

... Fucking Deku...

He wants to vomit at his own thoughts.

"What are you staring at, Kacchan?"

... And he's a fucking idiot, as per usual.

Katsuki whips his head away and rubs at his neck.

“Wasn’t staring. Your face is weird. Or something.”

Izuku chuckles and snorts, his eye-roll completely noticeable from even Katsuki’s straining neck and exaggerated limit of sight between the two of them. He can feel Izuku’s body heat as he leans back to the countertop next to him, mimicking his posture and allowing his hands to hang on the loops of his jeans.

“I’m going to talk to her.” Izuku nods, and, before Katsuki can say anything in response, leans forward and kisses him directly on the cheek.

Katsuki’s palms explode with flames.

Izuku jumps back with a squeak, staring with deer-like eyes as Katsuki splutters, flushes, and desperately runs to the sink.

“Fuck you, shitty Deku! Why the fuck would you—”

“I’m sorry, Kacchan! I didn’t think that it would activate your Quirk—”

“Oh, well *would you look at that* you inconsiderate fuckwad! I could’ve fucking blown up these counters, or even the stove, or even your face—”

“*Oh*.”

Izuku and Katsuki abruptly halt in their rather one-sided argument.

Slowly, Katsuki glances up from the sink where his palms are currently sizzling to calm down the dancing sparks, and his gaze lands on the surprisedform of Inko Midoriya rounding the corner.

Her head is tilted to the side, her eyes soft and kind with a certain glow that he assumes to be genetic in the Midoriya bloodline.

Instantly, the sight of Izuku’s muscles tightening his back through his sweater and his hands nervously flexing and un-flexing at his sides prompt Katsuki to move away from the sink and stand closer to him. He sets his jaw tight, and reads the distress and instinctive unsureness rippling from Izuku’s body as if drinking water from a glass.

Inko approaches them. Izuku bites his lip, for once appearing far tenser than he should around his mother.

Katsuki watches them steadily, growlingin reaction to the urges that call him to drag Izuku away from the object that’s currently causing him distress.

Quit fucking protecting him. He can handle his own shit.

“Izuku, honey.” Inko’s smile wobbles, teetering on the edge. “We should talk. Privately.”

The breath that leaves Izuku is strong enough to topple a cliff.

It takes every ounce of self-control Katsuki has to refrain from reaching out and grasping Izuku's hand and force him to remain glued to his side. His hands fasten around the edge of the sink, burrowing into the tiles and turning his knuckles white.

"Yeah, I think we should talk too, Mom," whispers Izuku.

His mother nods knowingly, the air to her suddenly quite different. She glances between Izuku and Katsuki, though says nothing more as she tenderly pats his shoulder and makes her way over to the other room, presumably towards the front door to the house.

Katsuki grits his teeth.

Izuku finds his hardened glare, and his smile is crushing in its weight.

"I'll be back soon, Kacchan."

Even when the curly-haired teen leaves, Katsuki struggles with the panicked thought of the freckled idiot somehow never returning.

Fucking hell…

Izuku cradles the cup of coffee in his hands, thumbs skimming over the edge of the sleeve.

Inko smiles across the table from him, though the expression is weak, lacking in its normal glimmer that he wishes to see each and every day. He's suddenly reminded of the harsh words grating his skull in his dream, his mother's younger, angry voice yelling in a disembodied echo towards one that was far more masculine, more threatening, more authoritative…

"I know that you have a gun," he blurts out.

Inko pauses, one hand rifling in her purse and her entire body going still as concrete. Slowly, the pregnant silence develops into a cloud.

The spell is only broken with Izuku's frantic, labored breathing, and his mother finally turning her head to address him with enlarged, shocked eyes.

Then, she exhales. It's a sigh that travels on the weight of many years, on the backs of countless truths and stories Izuku has never seen or dared to listen to. He wonders how many times his mother could wear such an expression and look at him with so much pity and guilt that it causes his blood to boil up and bubble over with the force of a smoking cauldron.

“I do.”

She tucks one strand behind her ear. The skin beneath her eyes are bruised, stretched and swollen red and purple.

He fights desperately against the urge to ask her if she’s slept, knowing full-well she hasn’t and already riding on the growing impatience with knowing that his suspicions were confirmed. The absolute fury and raw, impassioned disappointment and sadness inside him rushes to the surface, and it takes every fiber of his being to prevent a yell from escaping his enclosed lips in his demand for answers that he knows he deserves.

“Why?” He bites his tongue.

Inko hesitates. “It’s—Izuku, you weren’t supposed to find that—”

“But I did.” Izuku sighs shakily. “Mom. Why do you have a gun? Why were you hiding it from me? Why would you even want to? You said we couldn’t have any weapons in the apartment, and that it would just attract danger to us.”

“Izuku.” Inko’s shoulders are shaking, conflict shining bright and clear in her eyes. “It’s—”

“Is it Dad’s?” Izuku bites his lip.

Inko immediately blanks.

“Wha—your *father’s*? No, no. He—hah, he would never…” she shakes her head. “Izuku, you’re jumping to the wrong conclusions. Your father isn’t even important to our lives anymore. Not now, after all these years. What… what brought this on?”

Izuku’s hands tighten around his coffee cup.

Customers pass by their booth and disregard their presence. They blur by in mannequins of color and white noise.

“Kacchan and I…” he hesitates.

He knows that Katsuki will be furious with him if he openly talks about their kidnapping and what transpired in those events, but they need answers, and the more they put off the inevitable, the larger the wound will grow. And, as he stares into his mother’s eyes and reads her crumbling defenses, he knows that there are more answers lying in front of him than he’d thought possible.

I’m sorry, Kacchan.

“We were… tortured. Interrogated. The people who kidnapped us. They, um, they wanted to know about the Bakugous’ secrets. I don’t know what’s going on, Mom, but neither does Katsuki, and the man who talked to us. Shigaraki. He… he mentioned my dad’s name. He talked about him like he was a threat, or, or that he knew him personally.”

He glances up, and finds his mother trembling like a leaf. She straightens, holding back an aggressive series of hiccups as tears spill from her eyes and drop into her own tea.

“You were *tortured*.”

It’s not a question, Izuku notes, and immediately he knows that he underestimated his mother’s ability to process this in one sitting.

He swallows his guilt and attempts to push his desire and curiosity to know the secrets being dangled in front of him on a plethora of strings.

“Mom.” Izuku bites his tongue. “I know, that you don’t want to hear that. And, Kacchan and I want to figure it out and put things together with your help. You’ve known the Bakugous for so long and apparently Dad was roped into all of this, and I just have a lot of questions about it. Those squadron leaders and Shigaraki himself all knew our name.”

Inko’s fingers blanche white.

“Izuku, there are—oh goodness, there are so many things I need to tell you. And, no, this was not how you were supposed to find out… the gun, did you… did you touch it?"

She’s suddenly frantic, like a rabbit fleeing from the jaws of a hungry coyote. Izuku frowns at this, his shoulders sagging under an entirely new weight as his mother’s panicked face locks onto him.

“Did you touch the gun, Izuku?” She’s firmer now, more insistent.

Stronger.

He hesitates. “Mom, why—”

“Izuku. Did you touch the gun that you found in our apartment?”

His eyebrows furrow at this. “Yes. But, why does it matter?”

Inko bites her lip. “It does.” She pauses. “Have you… experienced, anything unusual at all? Aside from finding the gun?”

“Mom.” Izuku shakes his head. “Please. Just, one thing at a time. I want to understand what page we’re on. What was Dad up to? Why is Augustana pretty much after the Bakugous and slandering them? Why is everyone so intent on going against them and my dad?”

Inko leans back in her booth, pensive and silent. Tension grows within Izuku with each second that passes by, unleashing coils of building emotion into his senses that he would rather forget. He doesn’t want to think of his recent nightmares, of the ethereal pain that explodes in his consciousness every time he wakes. He remembers the metal under his hands and the brunt force blown across his temples and harsh weight slamming into his knees—

He remembers his first nightmare, after he and Katsuki narrowly escaped from their first encounter with Zeke in Isabori.

The recollection of broken bones in his legs, of hearing his parents arguing on the other side of the door spring back and forth in his mind and pound and pound and *pound* like a sledgehammer.

“Izuku.” Inko sniffs, wiping at her nose. Tears gather in her eyes. “I want you to… listen very carefully, to what I’m about to tell you. Can you do that for me? For all this that I’ve kept, I know that, that I was going to tell you when you were older. I never wanted this to happen to my baby. The decisions I made when you were young, and the choices I made even after your father left…” she shakes her head. “I never wanted you to be trapped in something you could avoid.”

Izuku’s heart leaps to his ribcage and struggles between the bones. He can feel it launching to his throat and bouncing between the caverns of his thoughts and physical being in a confused, broken rhythm. The desire to both learn and digest what his mother is willing to tell him now is almost enough to excuse her of the secrets she’s undoubtedly hidden.

He nods. In that second, Inko draws in one long breath, stares into her tea, and shuts her eyes tight. When she opens them again, she stares straight into him. It’s a look that pierces his gut, his heart, his very soul like crystal shards.

“Mitsuki, Masaru, Hisashi—your father—and I had all met around the same time. Mitsuki and Masaru were already involved in a powerful vigilante corporation based in Russia, but were attending university in this country, as you would expect. Hisashi was a transfer student from here, Augustana, and through joint classes I met him by chance.”

Her thumbs run along the edge of her cup. Steam rolls in a cloud above the rim.

“The gun was mine, Izuku.” Inko wipes at her nose. “I was… an agent, and ally, to the Bakugous during and after university. I regulated contracts for them, worked with technical support, and completed missions with them. When Hisashi came into my life, I fell for him hard and fast. I promised him that I would leave that life behind to raise a family with him back in Augustana.”

Izuku breathes through his nose, shaking.

She… was a vigilante too?

“And we had you.” She smiles softly at the memory, yet it vanishes as quickly as it comes. “I… was ignorant to the influence Hisashi had already formed here. He wanted pro heroes to retire. He wanted their influence to wane and for us to establish a presence like the Bakugous. I had no idea that Mitsuki and Masaru relocated to Sommartyn while Hisashi and I were in Isabori. It was part of why I was so shocked when you told me that you met Mitsuki and her son.”

Izuku subconsciously shakes his head.

“How were you…”

Inko dips her head. “I know it must be hard for you to believe. But your father—he wanted to counter the Bakugous’ way of doing things. He wanted to mark his own influence in Augustana and make a point against the pro heroes. The squadrons and patrolmen and tolling system... all of that was still around at the time, but far less severe. It was hardly needed with professional heroes still active and running about. And you were just a boy when they were publicly forced to retire.”

Her smile turns raw and damaged, heartbreaking on first glance.

Izuku stares, puzzled. Breathless.

“Your father left after,” Inko begins, pausing to steady herself. “I told him to leave. To pack his things and get out of our lives after… after he tried *grooming* you to become like him. He wanted his connections in Augustana, in the underground, to expand and develop with you as his successor. The squadrons were already having trouble with freedom-fighters seeking justice and retired heroes voicing their opinions, identities open and everything.”

She shakes her head.

“Your father lost his mind, Izuku. I couldn’t let him stay in our lives after he became who he was. Mitsuki was adamant when she first met him, years before we were even married, that he was close enough to the sun for his own wings to burn off.”

Somehow, someway, Izuku knows the true answer to why his father left them. To why he would have been disappointed with a son to the point where he would go mad.

“It was because I was Quirkless,” he whispers.

Inko studies him quietly, shame and guilt clouding her irises. Yet, she refuses to let her tears fall.

Izuku swallows down the thick lump in his throat, grinding his teeth hard enough to taste blood. He levels her with his stare, softening beneath the weight of the conversation filling the silence. He breathes and counts in patterns, calming the racing of his heart and pounding of his lungs.

Then, Inko nods.

Izuku smiles wryly.

“It’s okay, Mom.”

Inko shakes her head.

“No. No, it was never okay, Izuku. He’d turned into a monster and I couldn’t let him around my baby anymore.” She frantically tugs at her ponytail, nervous energy springing off her body in invisible sparks. “I’m not surprised that his influence affected the squadrons around here. Maybe it’s why you and I are always charged with extra tolls.” She shakes her head. “He’s not a danger now, though. He can’t be.”

Izuku bites his tongue. “Mom. We…” He hesitates. “We need to tell someone about this. Someone with influence outside of the Bakugous. They can only do so much and more than half of Augustana is already against them.”

“And that will be inevitable, Izuku.” Inko’s gaze hardens. “Your father wanted you to become wrapped up in this violent, dark world, and I refused to let that happen. I couldn’t protect you when you needed it most. My baby was kidnapped and *tortured*, and Katsuki…”

Izuku’s stomach drops at hearing the blond teenager’s name.

“Mom, none of that was your fault. Kacchan and I want to help and save Augustana—”

“It’s impossible, Izuku!” Inko shakes her head furiously. “There’s only so much a handful of people can do, even people with influence and power. Heroes have retired. Those squadrons are more or less becoming gangs now. Tolls will grow larger. Your father’s name still hangs in this city like a terrible fog.” Her lips curl back in vague disgust, though her expressions never go unnoticed under Izuku’s watchful eye. “I don’t want you going out and hunting down people and try to protect this city like some delusional vigilante—don’t be like *me*, Izuku. You have a bright future ahead of you, and you’re doing so well with the paper—”

“*Mom*.”

Izuku struggles between both raising his voice and pulling his mother into a hug. He wants to reassure her of her fears, even with this new thread of knowledge threading through his stomach and adding nausea to his jumbled thoughts. He wants to breathe in her concerns and wash them away with what little he can give.

He’s so powerless. Still *Quirkless.*

And yet, the only source of power they have are right beneath their fingers, stemming through the influence of people who have been misconstrued in Augustana to be terrible, awful, even bloodthirsty criminals. Murderers. Members of the *mafia*.

Though, as far as Izuku knows now, from the way Katsuki was willing to kill someone the previous night just to avenge his virtue, from the kindness Mitsuki showed his mother after all these years of being apart, from both he and Inko being allowed to stay in their home in Sommartyn…

With each question he has, he’s found one answer at a time to point directly to the Bakugous. The patterns in their relationships have grown dimmer already.

And Kacchan and I... He blinks. *Whatever we are, what will that do?*

His heart thumps.

He will talk to Katsuki later, when they have more time to discuss things privately. When all this chaos has subsided and he can sort through the strangled panic and unsureness riding on icy currents.

Izuku reaches out and takes his mother’s hand, tenderly intertwining their fingers.

He stares straight into her eyes and holds onto her cold, tiny palm with as much subdued strength as he can muster. She can only smile.

And the detectives…

They will surely ask more questions. He and Katsuki will have to talk about their kidnapping to authoritative figures who were most likely concealing themselves from the squadrons as well. This entire underground environment of secrecy and shadows had evaded Izuku's life in Isabori will also remaining completely entwined with who he was to begin with.

The revelation strikes him like lightning and holds him under water.

He wonders just how far he'd need to step over the edge to fall and drown.

Astonish

Chapter Summary

> “Augustana has been an unsafe place for years, now, with certain rules being broken by local and expanded squadrons, and we believe that it stems all the way back to the roots of how it all began. Even before heroes were forced into retirement.”
>
> Yagi’s eyes darken, his lips pressing into a thin line, though it vanishes almost as quickly as it appears.
>
> Izuku’s mouth turns dry.

Chapter Notes

> HOLY.
>
> This story is just... wow.
>
> Thank you, everyone, so much, for commenting, bookmarking, leaving kudos, clicking on this story AT ALL. It's just incredible to me that you all exist and that you're willing to read it. Thank you so, so much. I'm still recovering from being sick but since I was able to muscle this chapter out, I guess it's finally fading haha. Thank you for all of your patience! I like how this chapter turned out at the end. I hope you enjoy!
>
> Some more answers here, with some more questions, and of course, some fluff. :)
>
> Hope you all enjoy! Thank you again!
>
> Also this story crossed 18,000 hits?! That's INSANE. I just... can't believe it. You are all the best. Thank you.

His heart bursts through his ribcage and slams into the confines of his chest, consistent and deafening like hummingbird wings.

He stills his jaw, groans into the cold, bitter winds, and slows his jogging pace to a stop beneath the warming sun.

Katsuki pulls his hood over his head, panting heavily and looking down at his stopwatch.

The time flashes back at him in dark, black numbers. He snorts and pockets the device, shimmying out of his jacket as he enters the front door of the Bakugou household, the material sliding easily off his shoulders and over his arms. Sweat glistens on his neck and disappears beneath his white workout shirt.

He rolls his eyes as he hears his mother's frantic steps clacking in the kitchen, her voice carrying as if attached to a bullhorn.

"Katsuki Bakugou, you better not be getting back from a run after all that shit that happened —"

"Shut up, old hag! I took a safe route!" Katsuki snaps back. "I can handle any of those squadron motherfuckers if they show their pansy ass faces again!" He rolls his neck and yanks off his running shoes, perspiration still damp on his collarbones and slick through his hair. He turns, and scowls at the closed door and assesses the vicinity.

Mitsuki appears from around the corner, donned in a loose wool sweater and jeans. She eyes him warily, drawing from top to bottom as if inspecting him for wounds.

He growls under her stare, yet allows her to do so, quite used to the routine after years of growing accustomed to the district rules in Augustana.

"Deku's not back yet?"

He glares at the amused smile on his mother's face.

The tips of his ears turn pink, though his chest swells with uncertainty. The thought of something else happening while Izuku was out to coffee with his mother was more than enough reason for him to let his stress loose in his second run of the day.

"They're fine, Katsuki." Mitsuki rolls her eyes. "Inko and Izuku just went to that same bistro he goes to for… what, paper things? He mentioned that newspaper gig he has going at his school. Pretty impressive for someone to have so much hope like that in a time so dark."

Katsuki rolls up his windbreaker. "The fuck does that mean?"

His mother quirks an eyebrow. "What, brat? You don't think he's a hopeful person?"

Katsuki clamps his mouth shut, lips set in a firm line.

He'd known Izuku was a hopeful person, definitely, stemming back to the awkward confrontation they'd had on the train less than two weeks prior. In such a little span of time he'd grown to know far too much about the freckled nerd, ranging from his voracious interests in writing and art to what kind of toothpaste All-Might most likely used in his glory days.

Goosebumps raise on his shoulders.

"Whatever." The room feels heavy, sweltering. "He's stupid to be so optimistic."

Izuku placed too much of his dreams in his ability to write, interview, and construct powerful stories. He'd placed his future in a solid direction, from what Katsuki gathered in the brief moments he latched onto little details from Izuku's ramblings. Yet, it was impossible for him to see Izuku succeed when his naivety seemed alarming in some respects.

His manipulative wordplay in the middle of their kidnapping, and how he'd stalled long enough for Katsuki to break out of his bonds in the warehouse, glimmered like gems in Katsuki's memory.

He wanted to turn those sparks into something sustainable, something that Izuku could propel to unfathomable lengths if he continued trusting him and understanding that he needed to be stronger to protect himself.

"I think he has more awareness than you think," says Mitsuki, as if reading his thoughts. He scoffs, shaking his head. "Heh. You can keep looking at me like that and denying it, but that boy has some fine intuition. Just because he's the opposite of you doesn't mean he's any weaker." She smirks. "After all, look at your father and I."

Katsuki's stare hardens. "I don't want to hear about your weird adventures with the old man."

Deku isn't the same as him, or you, for that matter.

He cracks his knuckles and motions over to the stairs.

"Gonna shower."

Mitsuki scoffs. "Oh, no you don't! You've been getting out of doing laundry for ages! You're getting those chores done before you and Izuku have to meet with the detectives, brat."

The detectives...?

He addresses her quickly, one hand paused on the staircase railing.

"What the fuck? Why do we have to talk to *them*?"

"Why do you think, you ungrateful punk? Yagi Toshinori is very invested in this whole case, with the districts, squadrons, and even our family background. If there's anyone with power and status to talk to, it's him. Both Inko and I talked extensively about this before we agreed to have him talk to you and Izuku." She leans back against the living room couch, arms folding. "Might want to crank down that attitude and actually act like a decent fucking human being for once."

"Whatever, hag—"

Then, Katsuki blinks as an unfamiliar, casual ringtone cuts off what his mother is about to say.

"Oh, and you still have to thank your father will buying you that new phone." She rolls her eyes. "Spoiled little brat..."

Katsuki ignores her, confusion knitting his brow together at the continuous patterns popping up on the touchscreen.

He thumbs through the notifications and the limited messages sent to his inbox. The red phone number blares near the top of the screen, an alarming color that distracts him the more his mother complains in the background. Her words fade into white noise.

The fuck is this shit?

He’s never seen this number in his life.

He’d shared contact information with other squadron members in the past, when the connection between the Bakugous and the residents in Sommartyn were far less strained. He was hardly ever surprised when they left messages in his inbox, either to taunt him or request something ridiculous or otherworldly from his parents.

"Katsuki, you getting your ass moving or what?" Mitsuki watches him, a frown curling her lips.

"I'll do it later," he says absently, before racing up the stairs.

"Katsuki, you get back down here—"

He closes the door to his bedroom, wringing his bottom lip under his teeth.

He can't talk about this, or anyone, in front of his parents. They shouldn't have to worry about something he can handle on his own.

Cautiously, he unlocks the screen, scrolls to the red phone number, and presses it.

It begins to ring.

He props the phone on his shoulder, breathing through his nose.

“I don’t give a fuck who you are, whoever this is. You have exactly five seconds to tell me how and *why* you have my number—”

“Ah. Charming. Should’ve known you’d answer your phone like this. Then again I’m surprised you picked it up at all.”

Katsuki's mouth dries up.

“Half N’ Half.”

He seethes through clenched teeth, his grip tightening around his phone. His chest heaves, up and down. Up and down.

Just hearing this bastard's voice made every hair on his body stand on end.

“You sound like you’re running a marathon, Bakugou. Is this a bad time?”

“Fuck off, you piece of shit.” Katsuki snarls. “How the hell do you have my number?”

“You always seem to forget that our parents know each other fairly well. My father was setting up a meeting with your parents, I believe, to talk about what happened in Sommartyn Mall. As you can expect, everyone’s a little rattled. My school is no different.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Sure. Whatever. Doesn’t mean you can just fucking call me like some clingy girlfriend.”

“Your insults are dated beyond belief, Bakugou.”

“The fuck did you just say to me—”

“But, I’m not here to discuss meeting over tea with you. I’m calling you to ask about Midoriya.”

Katsuki snarls, dangerous and low, like bullets penetrating steel.

“Watch it, *Halfie*,” he says. “Be fucking careful about what you’re gonna say.”

He smirks to himself, the curl to his lips nothing short of menacing.

He knows that Todoroki can feel the essence of his warning in the middle of their call, and hopes that it renders him angry or irritated enough to hold back any accusations. He would be foolish to continue to slander the Bakugou name with all that’s transpired, and presumably knowing that Katsuki himself was kidnapped alongside Izuku Midoriya.

“I can ask you however I please. I’m not scared of you, Bakugou. You would be foolish to cross me, on top of that.”

A pause on the other end. Katsuki narrows his eyes, imagining where the pretentious bastard could be in this very moment.

He fumes at the mere thought that Todoroki could be seeking out Izuku’s location, attempting to steer the other boy *away from him—*

“Mind your own damn business.” He clicks his tongue. “What, you have nothing better to do than to just stalk me and Deku? He’s under *my* protection. Not *yours*.” He growls, each word dripping from his tongue like venom. He straightens his spine, posturing for a target he's picturing in the otherwise unoccupied room. “Your old man has been spreading lies about my fucking parents since we arrived here, and it pisses me the hell off. You can take your opinions and shove them up your ass.”

He hears Todoroki pause and exhale.

Katsuki’s knuckles blanche white from the pressure, a thousand insults hanging off his tongue.

“Should’ve known this is all that would happen calling you…” Todoroki clears his throat, a sound left audible to the both of them. *“I'll keep it simple then. This is about Midoriya. Is he*

alright?"

Katsuki pauses, holding back the stream of curses he wants to unleash just to rile up the other teen. He reads the threaded patience, the careful sincerity in regarding Izuku.

His stomach churns, his thoughts running back to images of Izuku and Todoroki in the same vicinity, bumping shoulders and exchanging pleasantries long before he and Izuku encountered each other rather explosively on the train.

Katsuki knew it was his fault that Izuku was thrust into these insane circumstances in the first place. He'd dragged Izuku into patrols with him in the districts, leading to Zeke nearly fatally wounding the both of them through means of a dangerous Quirk. He'd attempted to right his wrongs by forcing Izuku through the beginnings of a training regime he had planned for him.

He'd thought of every moment he could have rejected Izuku's presence and saved him of the encounter, only for the other boy to flash a genuine smile and face the next day with a burst of optimism that should have been illegal.

It was because of Katsuki's willingness to remain glued to Izuku's side, whether due to his paranoia or suspicions of the other being placed in danger, that led to them both being kidnapped.

The scent of the strange gunk capturing his hands and subduing his Quirk, the rage that coursed through his veins in rivers of ice and fire, and the sight of Izuku being constrained and *violated—*

Katsuki's jaw tightens.

"He's fine."

Fucking liar.

Izuku would say he was fine.

He would insist he didn't harbor any injuries, that he was completely free of need for medical attention. It was a gratingly similar trait that Katsuki also shared, to an extent that rendered the both of them unable to allow the other person to go through another minute without having their bruises, cuts, or egos checked.

"Is there any reason he hasn't come back to Yuuei? The panic that spread—as you've probably not seen since you're too busy shoving your thick head into business that's not your own—has been mainly stemming from him being absent. It was insane, almost, for me to consider that he would somehow be staying with you."

Katsuki scoffs. "Oh, like I give two fucks about your opinion on what Deku chooses to do."

"I find it hard to believe that Midoriya would choose to stay with a rash, violent hothead like yourself unless he was forced to make that choice."

Katsuki bristles, his fury barely contained behind his storming eyes and fire-laden tongue.

“You better not to be accusing me of fucking kidnapping him, Half N’ Half.” He smirks cruelly. “You’re asking for a beat-down. Fucking *watch* your back.”

“Midoriya is rational, but too forgiving. Since my father is in a similar position to your parents, my concerns for Midoriya are similar to yours. I don’t want him to be placed in any danger. The moment he told me that he met you, I knew of the risk. You’re not worthy of trusting, Bakugou.”

“Shut up!” Katsuki snaps. “You don’t know fucking shit!”

“I will talk to him myself, and get the truth. If you’re hurting him—”

“Shut the fuck up! I’ll fucking kill you!" He growls and proceeds to shout through the speaker. "You aren't even friends with him! So why the hell do you even care so much?"

"You're right." Todoroki's voice rumbles in static. *"If you've forgotten, it's also my job to protect what I can in Augustana. Midoriya's become involved in too many things, too quickly. It makes me suspect that your family is up to something that involves him. He's a student at our school, and leaving him to be around you will only make him a more blatant target."*

Katsuki licks his lips. He moves to sit on the edge of his bed, knees wound tight. Knotted into ropes.

"I'm protecting him, you fucker," he mutters, each word punctuated with iron and heat. "Don't threaten me. He's got *me* to look after him. If he wanted you, he would've *picked* you."

He wouldn't have let that happen, but these details remain hidden, locked tightly in his rummaging mind.

“Very mature.” Todoroki pauses, each moment of silence rumbling in Katsuki’s stomach like a growing storm. *“If you’ve hurt Midoriya, I will deal with it myself. Your family has done more than enough to cause havoc in these districts—”*

Katsuki roars and slams the phone on the ground, lifting one foot and stomping on the technological device until it’s nothing but splinters of metal and wire beneath his feet. Pain runs through his sock, blisters and callouses turning red at the pressure.

His jaw is open, teeth bared. Arms shaking. Nostrils flaring.

Fuck. I need a shower.

Shouto Todoroki never fails to make him want to punch his hand through a wall.

Slowly coming back into the world of his bedroom, he stares down at the destroyed piece of technology.

He'd only had this new phone for two days.

"... Oh, fuck me."

“Kacchan, you’re going to break your mug.”

Katsuki stiffens, tearing his hands away from their position around the brown-and-white-striped coffee mug set in front of him. He grimaces, avoiding Izuku’s pensive, curious stare and the concerned tilt to his head.

“And… you probably shouldn’t drink anymore coffee, if you don’t want a heart attack.” Izuku’s grin is amused and kind, a combination that Katsuki despises. “I mean, not like you have regular coffee anyway, with all the cream and sugar you put in it.”

“It’s hot bean water, shitty Deku,” growls Katsuki. “The only thing it’s good for is fuel for inflicting death and destruction.”

He slams one balled fist on the table, lips twisted into a scowl.

“You don’t even like sugar, though, Kacchan.”

“Sacrifices need to be made for the greater good, Deku. Don’t know why that’s a fucking hard concept to grasp.” Katsuki mumbles into his cup.

Izuku muffles a chuckle behind his hand.

“Whatever you say, Kacchan.”

He shakes his head, and turns to the window, puffing hot breath onto the frosted glass.

Green and copper leaves brush by the glass and sweep along the streets. Pedestrians bundled up in woolen scarves and jackets pass by and enter the bistro, each new customer leading to the definitive ringing of a bell attached to the front door.

Katsuki struggles focusing his attention on his beverage, with his thoughts continuing to veer backwards to the conversation he’d unwillingly had with Shouto Todoroki less than an hour before.

The moment Izuku and Inko returned from their coffee date, Katsuki had barely maintained his composure, insisting that they leave to the same bistro earlier before the detectives would arrive.

Izuku was gracious enough to keep his concerns abated until they were out of earshot from their parents. Yet, despite Katsuki’s incessant wriggling and constant peering over his

shoulder, he could feel the spiked unsureness from Izuku as well. Whatever transpired in their separate experiences had affected them both in ways that were less than comfortable.

Katsuki bristles, teeth clenching.

Fucking detectives should've been here by now.

With a snort, Katsuki ruffles his jean jacket and removes it, bunching it up in the spot next to him on the booth. Izuku's own warmth reaches out to him, tender and comforting, somehow stable amidst the dangerous thoughts brewing in Katsuki's mind.

The two of them somewhat match, with the both of them wearing long-sleeved sweaters with zip-up collars.

Izuku's is bright red and smells freshly laundered, probably delivered straight from his kindly mother's own hands.

"You trying to copy me, Deku?"

Izuku chuckles beside him, though the sound is weak. Failing.

Katsuki tilts his head and balances his chin in the upturned palm of his hand, watching Izuku stir a wooden stick in his cup of Earl Grey tea.

"I mean, sweaters in cold weather is a pretty common thing," he replies.

He smiles bashfully towards Katsuki, his teeth unfairly pristine and lining along his smile like a string of pearls. His wild, dark curls are even more unkempt, ears and cheeks tinted pink from his brief walk in the cold at Katsuki's side, their hands fidgeting in awkward unsureness, as if neither of them could decide whether it was appropriate to calmly reach over and intertwine their fingers—

Katsuki blinks and stares ahead once more. He drums his fingers on the tabletop.

"Whatever, stupid Deku," he mutters. "And where the fuck are those detectives? They're late. Stupid posh posers. Wouldn't expect anything less from stick assholes who somehow know both of our fucking moms…"

"Erm, well, you *did* want to come here thirty minutes earlier than we were supposed to—"

"Shut up Deku! They should've suspected that or something!" Katsuki snaps.

"What would make them suspect that?" Izuku chuckles. "Kacchan, that's ridiculous. And because you destroyed your phone for some reason, we can't contact them."

"I don't even have their phone numbers, you moron." Katsuki leans back in the booth, stretching his arms wide. His left hand grazes Izuku's shoulder.

He glares at passing customers, who raise their eyebrows at the pair of them and the empty spot in their shared booth.

He growls through gritted teeth and flips the bird to each and every one of them.

"Fuck off! Mind your own business!"

Izuku pinches the bridge of his nose. “Kacchan, that’s... really not necessary.”

“Don’t tell me what the hell is necessary, Deku!” Katsuki says, angling his head back against the booth.

He splays himself out comfortably, grunting at the growing anxious tremors in his legs. He wants, or *needs*, preferably, to punch something.

Anything, that doesn’t resemble the freckled boy at his side whom he would much rather quiet through aggressive kissing than with his actual fists.

He adjusts his seat, fingers just a hairsbreadth shy of Izuku’s left ear. The other boy seems to sense this, his neck and cheeks blossoming pink.

Katsuki's lips twitch, a snicker bubbling up in his throat. He daringly sliding himself closer and lowers his mouth to his comrade’s neck, tongue flicking out between his lips and flicking Izuku’s earlobe.

“*Kacchan*!” Izuku squeaks and pushes him away. “We’re in a *public place*! What’s— honestly, what’s really going on with you?” He watches him, those big green eyes baffled and just a tad mortified. “You’ve been acting so strange since we left your house. Did something happen?” He pauses. "I mean, other than destroying your phone for... apparently no reason?"

Katsuki twitches and glances away. He takes one dramatic sip of his coffee before slamming the mug back on the table.

“Not fucking important. Just shit I have to deal with. It’s not your problem.”

Izuku rolls his eyes. “Sure, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s eyebrows raise to his hairline, nose scrunching up.

“The fuck gave you have the right to talk, shitnerd?" His thumb hooks through the handle of his mug. His voice lowers, quiet between them. "You still haven’t told me shit about what happened with you and your mom,” he says, his thoughts meandering. Crossing another threshold that Izuku won't be able to follow.

Izuku's smile is apologetic. "I'm sorry, I'll elaborate soon. It's just a lot to take in."

Katsuki doesn't appreciate how this sounds, but he doubts that Izuku will respond if he continues growling and yelling.

A whiff of spearmint cologne reaches him, as cool and fresh as water in wintertime.

"... Is that my cologne?"

Izuku freezes. Instead of answering, he lifts his cup and drinks the tea.

The blush is easily noticeable, painting his youthful face a rosy pink.

"Um. Maybe?"

Katsuki snorts. "Fucking moocher."

"I'm sorry! I was so curious and it was the only one in the bathroom!"

"Yeah? Well that doesn't mean you steal mine! Stupid nerd."

Izuku hums under his breath, scratching his cheek and turning pointedly away from Katsuki's glare.

Silence develops, an awkward weight linking their unspoken words together.

"I wanted to talk about it after we met with the detectives. You know, in case they asked about that," says Izuku. He leans forward, crossing his arms on the table and pressing his nose into his arm. Katsuki watches him, the heat of his mug sweltering and dampening his hand. "I don't know, Kacchan. It's all a bit… more than crazy, really. Part of me is optimistic, and not worried at all, and another part of me is just, kind of struggling to believe everything. And all of this is so much bigger than we thought, and so much more insane and blown up than we expected, and I'm not sure how I'm supposed to handle this? Um. I don't know if that makes any sense, but, um, I'll explain in better detail later when I'm not being weird and… rambling."

Katsuki groans and adjusts his seat, his left knee bumping Izuku's.

"Just tell me when you're not stuck in a scrambled mess, Deku."

Izuku turns, finally facing him directly. His smile is contagious, spread wide across his face. Dimples pop amongst a sea of freckles.

"Thanks, Kacchan. I promise I'll tell you, when all of this calms down."

Katsuki's stomach flips. His heart stutters.

Swallowing audibly and ignoring the voices in his head that scream for him to grab Izuku's bottom lip between his teeth, he turns back forward and scowls.

Fuck.

"... Whatever."

Izuku bites the inside of his cheek to prevent his smile from growing.

He giggles with each tiny mannerism Katsuki reveals during this close moment of proximity between them in the bistro. Each frustrated grunt and dismissive comment leads to a bitter remark from his friend, and it never fails to make Izuku's insides squirm with comfort and a sense of freedom he hadn't come to know for a long time.

His thumbs brush over the stress ball in his pocket, hidden from Katsuki's inquiring view.

He swallows back the bile in his throat, hoping that his stemming anxieties aren't as obvious as he believes them to be.

His mother's words echo like ghosts.

The gun was Mom's. The gun was Mom's.

His father, on top of that, was once a *rival* to the Bakugous, intent on removing them from their position and somehow grooming Izuku to take over when he was older… the idea was so ludicrous, so farfetched.

Yet, with each passing second, Izuku could not deny the unfathomable honestly pouring from his mother's trembling frame. She would never lie to him, and her tears were the most truthful thing about her.

It was impossible for him to imagine that she would ever bother to construct lies around her answers, or even attempt to dissuade Izuku from his assumptions.

"Deku, you're muttering."

"Ah! R-Really? Am I? How weird!" Izuku splutters, ignoring the urge to slap himself in the face.

He turns even further away from Katsuki, who blinks owlishly at him and leans in closer, his hot breath trailing over his neck. Teeth nipping, skimming along his ear.

He's doing this on purpose, oh my God.

Izuku presses his side to the window, his throat bobbing.

"K-Kacchan, stop—"

"No. The hell is wrong with you? You're acting like I'm trying to set you on fire."

Despite this, he's grinning.

Izuku snorts.

“No, it’s not like that, and you *know* it." Izuku sighs and pushes Katsuki away from him, fingers splayed out over the other’s broad, toned chest. “Just, bear with me, until the detectives come and—”

He stops, mouth half-opened with another complaint threatening to spill over, as he notices that he and Katsuki are not alone anymore at all in their booth.

Yagi Toshinori addresses them with a firm dip of his head, an amused smile crossing like a sickle along his jaw. He sets down his drink, wisps of steam swirling about the rim of the cup.

His narrow features and striking ice-blue eyes are even more unsettling now, despite the clear air of kindness and understanding dwelling within.

Izuku’s arms shoot up, smacking Katsuki in the jaw.

“Shit, fuck, *Deku, you fucking idiot*—”

Izuku ignores him.

“M-Mr. Toshinori! I’m so sorry! We were just—I was—Kacchan wasn’t—”

Yagi holds up his hands, a chuckle reverberating in his wiry throat.

“That’s quite alright, my boy. No worries or offense taken. Your mothers informed my partner and I about you both. Your personal matters won’t be a hindrance with the questions I would like to run by you this afternoon.” He coughs into his fist, the gesture releasing a wave of calm though Izuku as he grips the edge of the table with iron force.

Katsuki growls, rubbing his jaw and scowling petulantly—challengingly—at the detective.

He props his elbow on the table and fixates a withering stare onto the much older gentleman, a sneer curling back his lips.

“Why the fuck did you even want to do this, old geezer?”

Izuku buries his face into his hands. “*Kacchan*.”

“No, it’s quite alright.” Yagi waves his arm, shrugging off his coat and pulling out a notebook and pen. He clicks it, and begins to and calmly scribble in the margins. “Is it alright if I take notes during this interview? It’s part of my conduct as a reporter and detective.”

Izuku blinks, a small smile overtaking his lips.

“Y-Yeah, you can. I… I know about that rule. I’m studying to be a journalist myself.”

The words feel so foreign on his tongue, as if he hadn’t considered his own dreams for a long while. Since encountering the Bakugous and having his interests waylaid by insane crossroads, Izuku hadn’t bothered sitting down on his lonesome to think extensively about

the paper. The *Yuuei Herald* would surely be suffering without his presence, and most likely Uraraka's if she was removing herself from the project without him there.

"Ah, your mother mentioned something like that." Yagi hums, a sparkle of amusement clear on his angled features. "That's impressive, for someone so young to be that motivated. Inko had told me quite a bit about your ambitions. Really, those are important goals to have, particularly with the state Augustana is in today." He coughs. "Now, let's go over some of the core details of what happened. If, of course, you're comfortable to share."

Katsuki rolls his eyes. "Whatever. It's not like you don't fucking know what happened in that warehouse. Wouldn't bigshot detectives or some shit already be knee-deep in that business?" His raises an eyebrow. "Why would you need to know *our* sides to a story you already know about?"

Izuku licks his lips at this thought, glancing back and forth between Katsuki and Yagi. Tension threads through the air, though it immediately dissipates once the detective chuckles and marks a bullet point on his notepad. It's a much smaller booklet in comparison to Izuku's, he notes, even though his own documents are crowded with arguably useless information.

"We want to know because we weren't actually there, experiencing it for ourselves. We know that some important details must have been discussed for you both to have been targeted by Shigaraki Tomura. He's a face we've been trying to weed out for quite some time."

Yagi props his elbows on the table, intertwining his fingers.

"Augustana has been an unsafe place for years, now, with certain rules being broken by local and expanded squadrons, and we believe that it stems all the way back to the roots of how it all began. Even before heroes were forced into retirement."

Yagi's eyes darken, his lips pressing into a thin line, though it vanishes almost as quickly as it appears.

Izuku's mouth turns dry.

Unconsciously, he flinches, his knee bouncing beneath the table.

He suppresses the urge to panic or to confess, wondering if his father's information was meant to be kept hidden with he and his mother, or if he was supposed to talk about it now.

Even so, his recollection of his father was a muddled disarray of images and fleeting thoughts he could no longer reach out to.

"Now, there is something I would like to discuss with you both."

Izuku tenses, his right hand clenching the booth by his outer thigh.

He feels Katsuki tense up beside him, as frozen as a beanpole.

They both watch as the detective unfurls a plastic bag from his strapped case, unzipping the contents and removing the outlined shape of an object Izuku recognizes as soon as it clatters

on the table.

“That’s—”

“Yes. The gun from the warehouse. I presume that you used it to defend yourself while escaping.”

Yagi unfolds the cloth further, splaying it a neat square on the tabletop. Customers send them odd glances, though no no one says a word.

A lump settles in Izuku's throat.

He recalls the strange way his hands engulfed the trigger and fumbled around the barrel as his instincts somehow, someway, called for him to unleash the bullet and strike Zeke in the knee.

Katsuki raises an eyebrow. “How the fuck do you even have that?”

“I had it still on me when we left the warehouse,” says Izuku, his eyes latched onto the gun. His right hand slides over and squeezes Katsuki’s knee, earning a sharpened stare from the blond. “Our moms must’ve talked to them about it. Is that right?” He looks up to the detective, sighing shakily. “That was, submitted as evidence of some kind?”

“Well, yes. That’s certainly one way to put it.” Yagi clears his throat. “We understand that you shot this firearm. Correct, young Izuku?” The boy in question only nods, unsure of he should even attempt to lie given the circumstances. “Have you ever used a gun before?”

Izuku bites his lip.

“Hey, hey, hey!” Katsuki growls and leans forward. “What the fuck does that have to do with anything? Deku helped us escape with that gun! You trying to call him a suspect?”

Izuku holds his breath and quickly reaches over, grasping Katsuki’s elbow from under the table.

His companion growls and refuses to look at him, though he settles back in his seat.

Yagi chuckles. “No, that’s not what I was saying at all. It’s just, knowledgeable to both my partner and I that young Izuku had never used a gun before. We confirmed this with his mother. On top of that, she notified me before arriving that there were some incriminating details she’d revealed to you, my boy.”

Izuku pales.

“I…”

I don’t know.

“Deku doesn’t have to say shit,” says Katsuki, bitter and venomous.

“No, Kacchan, it’s fine.” Izuku struggles to smile, the gesture so wobbly and misshapen that it contorts his features into a mask of awkwardness. “I’ve never, ever touched a gun before I held that one, aside from the one that I…” He hesitates. “The one I found in my mom’s apartment. It… she’d made a big deal about not touching weapons at all, but especially guns, growing up. And, I mean, I met with her this morning and she told me that there are more things going on and I didn’t know about any of it, and she asked me if I experienced anything strange after touching the gun, and…”

His brow furrows, lips pursing in the middle of his thought. His heart stutters, a conflicting series of possibilities running through his brain. He picks them out one by one, as if assembling the bullet points for a potential news article, and feels his fingers twitch at the sensation. He ignores the strange, wide-eyed look Katsuki sends him, quickly dissolving into his mind as he searches and explores.

“She told me about the gun, after the both of you talked this morning,” says Yagi. Izuku glances at him, gulping. “There is nothing for you to worry about, when it comes to that. So, you’ve handled that gun, and the gun you used to escape the warehouse where you and young Katsuki were kept.” He glowered down at his notepad, adding an additional sentence. “And your mother. What did she say about the gun?”

Katsuki’s right fist clenches on the table. His left hand slithers over Izuku’s, which still firmly rests on his knee.

His calloused palm sliding over the top of Izuku’s hand causes him to release a breath he didn’t know he was holding, sweat streaking his skin and framing the outlines of Katsuki’s knuckles.

“If Deku knew shit, he would tell you, asshole,” says Katsuki.

Yagi’s lips twitch.

“Ah. You’re a lot like your mother, it seems.”

Katsuki snorts, and grips harder around Izuku’s hand.

“Perhaps either of you could tell me, then, what Shigaraki Tomura questioned the both of you about in the warehouse, and what led to the both of you escaping.”

Izuku shakes his head. “He mentioned my father. Hisashi Midoriya.”

Yagi pauses, his eyebrows lifting. “Yes. We… had suspected as much. I’m assuming Inko enlightened you on your father’s history?”

Izuku’s teeth grit. “She—yes. She did.”

Why do you know? How come she told you first and not me?

“Your father was a prominent adversary to the squadrons. He was… quite vocal, about his desire for heroes to retire and to leave control to the government and the new policies that had taken place in Augustana.” Yagi runs one hand through his streaky golden hair. “I

shouldn't be telling you boys all of this, truly, but since you've become so involved, it's fair that you know the extent of what Hisashi Midoriya had done."

Katsuki bristles. "Wait, Hisashi Midoriya?" He snaps his head towards Izuku. "Your old man? He's the one responsible for—"

"I don't know, Kacchan," says Izuku, rubbing his left temple. "All of this is so crazy, and, I don't know who and what to trust anymore. Not with what Shigaraki said."

"And that's quite alright." Yagi coughs into his fist. "He has been missing, from Augustana, for quite some time now. Your father made some rather intense changes on his own accord while working with the Bakugous in their golden days."

He flicks his head towards Katsuki, who looks away.

"He was drawn to power, but not to the heroic dream."

The heroic dream…

Izuku's tongue turns drier than sand. He remembers those flickering articles stacked on his mother's desk years prior, slowly coming to an understanding that heroes were officially retiring and forced to slip under the radar. The coined idea for paradise, for a utopian world without crime and heroes reigning supreme and indebted to the community was coined as the *heroic dream*.

He'd written several pieces covering that subject in the school paper, as well as through his internships with other news junctures. The reception was almost always negative or too skeptical to accept his evidence or quotes he'd scoured from other news clippings and old, taped interviews.

Discussing the heroic dream seems almost impossible now, with the districts squirming with a corrupted tolling system that sapped the public dry and forced families out of their homes unless illegal promises were made.

"Lay off the fucking questions, *detective*," Katsuki snaps. "Clearly you already know too much and Deku doesn't have to answer your shit."

Izuku glances at him, eyes sharp as stone. "Kacchan, I can speak for myself—"

"Ah, no, that's quite alright." Yagi dips his head. "We will talk again, young Izuku. I will speak with you both separately when the investigation gets further under way, and we locate Shigaraki Tomura through the corrupted canals that make up Augustana—"

"Cut to the chase." Katsuki snorts. "You saying that the Bakugous don't have as much control on these districts anymore? In keeping things regular?" He shakes his head. "You act like you know everything that happens, but that's not the case. Bakugous don't half-ass *shit*."

He clicks his tongue.

"So why interrogate us about two fucking guns?"

Yagi pauses at this, slowly turning his attention from Katsuki to Izuku.

“Well.” He clears his throat. “The gun young Izuku discovered in his mother’s apartment was taken for examination after Inko informed us of the event that transpired. We knew it was important, judging from her desperation. She hadn’t known at the time that Izuku had touched the gun in her apartment. That being said,” he takes a brief sip of his tea, “the reason we took in the one she offered to us after we returned you both to the Bakugou household, is that those two guns are the same.”

Izuku frowns. “I mean… a lot of guns are the same, though—”

“Ah, yes. This is true. But, that specific revolver you used was from the same cartridge of selected, number-branded guns transported through Augustana around the time heroes were forced into retirement.” He eyes them both warily, blue eyes glinting like steel. “Inko Midoriya was keeping a gun in her own home that should not exist outside of Shigaraki’s possession.”

Izuku’s stomach flips.

What?

He registers each word slowly, his brain unable to process each onslaught of new information going through his ears and winding back out in torrential rhythm.

A steady rise of fire burns in his bloodstream. Shaking, he removes his hand from Katsuki’s knee to grip the underside of the booth.

His teeth grind to the gum, slow and even. The only option he feels is necessary is to stare the detective straight in the eye, each question he wishes to say stuffed to the back of his mind in favor of a phrase he knows he should ask before anything else.

“You’re saying that my father could have conspired with Shigaraki.”

Katsuki reels back to the chair, silent.

Yagi nods. “I’m afraid so, young Izuku. While our suspicions are not confirmed, and your mother herself is conflicted on the subject, the evidence does point in that direction. Among other things that we need to go over with the further we dive into this investigation.”

He coughs into his fist, this one far harsher than the last.

“Ah, sorry about that. As a side note, Izuku, you will be cleared to go back to classes at your high school with permission from my agency. Discussion of your kidnapping will not be made prevalent or spotlighted in order to secure your and young Katsuki’s privacy.”

Izuku dips his head hollowly.

“Sure.”

Izuku’s hands seek the warmth in his jacket pockets, curls wildly caught in the winds the further he moves along the sidewalk with Katsuki Bakugou walking in equal strides.

Strangers walk by them in blurred colors, conversation adrift like the humming of flies.

His breathing shakily travels through his chest and windpipe, scorching his lungs. His teeth sink into his tongue, and move alongside his inner lip, seeking pressure. Somewhere to inflict his worrisome thoughts.

If he’d brought his notebook, his habits would be far easier to quell.

“The fuck’s wrong with you?”

Izuku blinks out of his stupor.

“Sorry, Kacchan."

He avoids looking in Katsuki’s direction, the other teen standing just a couple inches taller than him, scarf wrapped in bundles around his neck and his ears turning pink under the blustering cold. His glare is focused and stony, riddled with anger and frustration that Izuku knows he’s caused.

"I'm not mad at you, you fucking idiot."

Izuku hesitates, embarrassment fluttering in his stomach.

"I..." He cards one hand through his hair. "I'm sorry, Kacchan. I don't know, what's coming over me right now."

Katsuki reels in a long, exhausted breath, his nostrils flaring.

Izuku glances at him with a cocked eyebrow, his fingers fumbling awkwardly in his pockets. With a firm pinch on the bridge of his nose, Katsuki whirls on his feet, heels firmly planted on the sidewalk, and stares at him.

“I just, fuck—Deku, you apologize on reflex. You didn’t do shit to me. How are you going to be stronger, make a statement in this city, *and* kick ass if you wallow in your own self-pity?” He rolls his jaw, bones cracking under stress. Izuku's mouth opens to reply, but he stops at Katsuki raising a hand, conflicted. “Fuck off with that. It’s pathetic. And you’re not… *that*, or whatever you’re telling yourself right now. It’s pissing me off.”

Izuku’s flushes. His pupils bounce around like a game of table tennis, his attention focused on the streets spread out before them and the long lines of people spilling out to the tram

entryways. His eyes glaze over and travel up to the long, stationary locomotive that winds through the entirety of Augustana like a snake. Timestamps are presented broadly on the electric screens, like billboard advertisements.

“Um—we have, I think an hour left, before we have to be off the streets.”

He rubs the back of his neck. The wind ruffles through his jacket, slinking a trail of goosebumps over his flesh.

He feels Katsuki studying him, assessing him. He should be more intimidating, but it's difficult for Izuku to take him seriously with the other boy keeping himself warm in his puffy winter coat, long fluffy scarf, and woolen mittens.

“... Right. Obviously."

"I'm just saying that we can't, you know, stay out here for too long." Izuku nibbles on his lip, reaching instinctively for the stress ball in his pants pocket.

Katsuki grumbles something inaudible, yet keeps pacing at his side.

The last thing Izuku wants to do is mull over Yagi Toshinori’s words and consider the horrible realization that his father could have been grooming him, of all people, for something far darker and more sinister than he could have ever imagined.

Outside, he breathes in the same cold air as the rest of Augustana’s populace, and addresses the details of smiling faces and oblivious children who board the train and pay their respective tolls for the evening. None of them would know about what he and Katsuki witnessed, what they were both subjected to, and the dangers they would inevitably become a part of soon.

“Hey.”

Izuku jerks his head over, and blinks at the sudden close proximity between him and Katsuki. As if flipping a switch, his heart leaps into his throat.

Thump.

Thump.

Thump.

Katsuki tilts his head, his scowl firm, eyes searching and deconstructing him as if attempting to piece together a complicated puzzle.

Izuku fidgets, splutters and turns away. He attempts to quicken his pace, unused to the attention.

A flinch shocks throughout his body when Katsuki nudges him.

“Don’t pass out on me, Deku. I’m not dragging your ass to the hospital.”

Izuku rolls his eyes, his smirk faint. His heart slows,

“Jerk.”

Thank you, Kacchan.

Katsuki turns away, yet the ghost of a crooked smile lingers. Izuku catches it just as his profile angles away, made of all strong lines and contouring patterns. He bites his lip, and locks onto his fidgeting hands, glancing over to Katsuki’s own position with his mitten-covered fingers seeking shelter in his jacket pockets.

“What, you want to hold my hand, shitty Deku?” Katsuki sneers, his grin cocky, alight with temptation.

Izuku rolls his eyes and looks away, hands brimming with sweat despite the bitter cold.

“If I wanted to, I would have.”

Katsuki's eyebrows raise to his hairline, lips twitching as a toothy grin takes over and he closes in on Izuku’s space.

He leans down and growls beside his ear, his chin once again finding the crook of his neck and resting comfortably in place.

Izuku squeaks, wriggling.

“We’re in public, Kacc—”

Katsuki’s teeth waste no time to find his earlobe, a nip that lasts less than a second that instantly succeeds in causing Izuku to splutter.

He breaks away from him, only for Katsuki to reach around, his arm crushing his waist to his chest. He straightens, almost bumping his nose to Katsuki’s cheek.

“You still owe me a fucking explanation for all this shit, Deku,” growls Katsuki. “Something tells me you’re a little weak in the knees at the moment, ya damn nerd,” he finishes lowly.

His purr is vindictive and cruel, igniting Izuku’s senses into wildfire.

Izuku’s heart stabilizes against his chest, running in rhythm with his frantic mind, and aside from the dangerous concerns flooding his conscious, he locks onto the way Katsuki’s arm around him begins to lower. He considers smirking back, falling into this game. Perhaps, he will be able to think of a way to reduce Katsuki to a flustered mess as well, to somehow thank him for giving them a moment of clarity and distraction from the terrifying truths they will need to face.

Izuku is not prepared, however, for Katsuki’s hand to find his rear and give it a harsh, long squeeze.

“*Kacchan*!” Izuku rips himself away and glowers, his words a jumbled mess.

He waves his arms frantically, gesturing to every person walking by them.

“We are in *public*! What are you even thinking—”

“What's got your panties in a twist, shitty Deku?” Katsuki shrugs nonchalantly. “Fuck it. I’m the only one who can do that. Might as well let every other motherfucker know who it belongs to.”

Izuku rolls his eyes, slapping his hand over his face.

“I *highly doubt* every stranger is staring at my ass, Kacchan.”

“You’d be fucking surprised, Deku,” says Katsuki, grumbling.

Then, bristling, Katsuki proceeds to scream, his veins bulging in his forehead at a completely random stranger walking by their awkward junction at the edge of the sidewalk.

“Yeah, I’m looking at you, you bastard! Keep your eyes to yourself!”

Izuku sighs. “Oh my God, Kacchan. That is so *unnecessary*."

“It’s always fucking necessary! Fuck you!”

“Mmhm. Also, my ass belongs to me, first and foremost. I don’t remember signing a contract for you to just grab it like that. Especially in public!" He crosses his arms and huffs, cheeks puffed out and red.

Katsuki glowers. “Oh, I get it, now. So, you’d just let *anyone* touch it? And look at it? What kind of logic is that, shitty Deku? You got an explanation that'll convince me otherwise?"

He flicks Izuku in the forehead.

Izuku bites his tongue to prevent himself from both slapping him in the chest, and breaking out into hysterics.

“I don’t think I ever once insinuated that," he says, "to be fair."

“Well what if it was *my ass*, huh? Would you be so peachy keen about that?" Katsuki snorts and bumps shoulders with him, his question sharp and snappy in the air. "If some jerk-ass bitch decided to have at it, I’d fucking expect *you* to be pissed off.”

“Oh, that’s definitely true,” says Izuku, with absolutely no pause.

Katsuki temporarily halts in his tirade, his skin blossoming into an adorable pink that sends Izuku’s soul fluttering.

“I mean, logically, it would make sense. You have, honestly, probably the most amazing ass I’ve ever seen. I’m kind of jealous. How many times do you have to do deadlifts or squats in the gym to get that kind of shape? Also, it feels amazing, and I couldn’t think straight this morning because you were wearing jeans. Kacchan and jeans are the closest I’ve ever come

to spontaneous combustion." Katsuki's jaw is slacked, open wide enough to let insects fly through, and it's enough to make Izuku burst out into giggles.

“F-Fuck you, Deku! H-How the fuck can you even—"

"I mean, you did ask me." Izuku chuckles as Katsuki fumes. "Aw, are you embarrassed, Kacchan?"

"I'm going to kill you, fucking nerd!"

Izuku laughs, and quickly avoids Katsuki diving for him.

Your threats are meaningless at this point, Kacchan.

Katsuki trips over his own words, his entire face flushed a deep crimson and his angry screams bolting off in each and every direction. He yells streams of profanities that only make Izuku’s giggling and chuckling continue, as the freckled boy soon walks in equal strides with the embarrassed Bakugou heir after Katsuki manages to regain his composure.

Still fuming and bristling from head to toe like a porcupine, but nonetheless reduced to silence.

"You're so cute, Kacchan."

"Shut the fuck up."

Izuku hums in thought, their arms brushing.

Without warning, he slaps Katsuki in the rear, and *bolts*.

As he'd predicted, Katsuki relinquishes control on his Quirk. Explosions are unleashed into the streets, sparks bouncing off his palms and completely disarming the public.

"I'm going to fucking murder you, you idiot Deku!"

Despite the fact that his threats seem all the more real this time, Izuku sacrifices ten minutes to calm Katsuki down and lead him in the opposite direction from the crowd of panicking people, hoping inwardly that they can somehow grab the next seat on the train before the tolling hour commences.

"You know," says Izuku, patting Katsuki's arm, "you could try to control your Quirk better."

“Your fucking fault,” snaps Katsuki, plopping himself down on a bench next to the sidewalk. Izuku chuckles, and joins him, nothing but bashful grins and shining optimism.

Katsuki's glare is *murderous.*

“Okay, yeah, a little, but you started it.” He laughs as Katsuki folds his arms across his chest and slumps in his seat, jaw tight and clenched. “I mean, even with all of this crazy nonsense,

and my dad being a big part of this, probably, I know that you were just trying to take both of our minds off things—”

Katsuki grabs the collar of his shirt.

"Eh? K-Kacchan?"

Then, Izuku is pulled into the kiss so quickly that his mouth opens on instinct, tempted to ask a question before his voice is muffled by the entrance of the blond’s tongue into his mouth.

His eyes flutter, body relaxing into the embrace. Katsuki leans further, almost crawling over him, his presence a looming shadow that threatens to engulf him whole. His soft lips graze and teeth nip along Izuku's mouth, his movements voracious. Impatient.

Izuku reaches up and cups Katsuki’s jaw, angling his mouth and slipping his tongue inside. Pleasure shoots down his spine as Katsuki growls into the kiss and continues moving over to him, his body weight pushing him further back to the bench and his right hand landing on the left of Izuku’s outer thigh.

Katsuki’s teeth snatch onto his bottom lip and *pulls*.

Izuku shudders at the touch, a defiant tremor shaking his gut as his hands tremble from around Katsuki’s face. He feels Katsuki smirk against his mouth, those sharp teeth prodding and searching as always.

Then, Izuku is unable to breathe once more as Katsuki recaptures his lips, his moans long and strained and territorial.

Izuku pulls away, breathless, panting as if he’s running an Olympic marathon. He gazes into Katsuki’s smug expression, those dark red irises hardened into glass.

Katsuki’s smirk falls, slightly, as Izuku brushes a thumb along his jaw.

His throat bobs, pupils dilated, curious. His tongue swipes over his bottom lip.

Katsuki's breath is low and hasty, his eyes flickering across Izuku's features in a fascinated pattern.

"Deku, I—"

“*Oh*.”

The intrusive voice shocks the both of them.

Instantly, Katsuki pulls away, though his body remains close to Izuku, his warmth temporarily detached and his lips swollen red. Izuku’s heated, flushed face immediately blanches as he recognizes the crown of red-and-white hair and two inquisitive—and currently surprised—heterochromatic eyes.

“T-Todoroki?” Izuku squeaks.

Todoroki opens his mouth to say something, yet decides against it. He's dressed in a windbreaker jacket and jogging pants, a fresh sheen of sweat noticeable over his smooth, flawless skin. He's carrying a small plastic bag of groceries in one hand.

He blinks once, then twice, and switches between both Katsuki and Izuku as if he's stumbled across the most horrifying discovery he could have ever thought possible.

Izuku can already feel Katsuki's murderous scowl and dreads what it could possibly look like when directed towards someone he knows the other male already hates with every fiber of his being.

Todoroki clicks his tongue.

"This… explains a lot."

Metamorphose

Chapter Summary

He knows his father has placed him in a predicament that neither he or his mother deserve, and Inko's worries for him are now rooted into something far deeper and out of their control.

Izuku bunches his hands together. His knee bobs up and down.

Whatever will come heading their way, they need to be ready.

Chapter Notes

Oh, man.

This chapter was a bitch to write. It's also the longest chapter I think I've ever written for something on this site. I loved writing it, so... gosh. Yeah. Also, we're now over 100,000 words!

Also, you guys. THANK YOU. So. Much. For your incredibly kind comments, for being so wonderfully dedicated to this story, and for being so supportive in this journey. Spread the KatsuDeku love! I don't even know what to say with every chapter where I get responses like this.

Thank you so much. I hope you enjoy the next chapter to Before Midnight!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The taste of Izuku's mouth still sizzles and burns on Katsuki's lips when he directs his attention to Todoroki, standing in front of the bench with his sweat-slicked hair and a plastic bag dangling off his side.

Katsuki huffs and furiously wipes his mouth, leaping up from his seat and charging forward —

"W-Wait! Kacchan!"

Katsuki stiffens, turning to glare over his shoulder towards Izuku, who has hastily grabbed the end of his sleeve.

Izuku frowns and locks onto him, slowly pulling him back against his seat on the bench, as if to subdue the steadily rising fire in the other teen's chest.

"Are you *shitting* me—"

Todoroki clears his throat, his eyes flicking awkwardly off to the side.

Katsuki and Izuku glance up and focus on him, one sneering with curled lips and the other scratching the back of his head in utter embarrassment.

"Ah, well. I don't think any of us expected this. I apologize for… interrupting." He turns on his heel, hesitant. "Though, the tolls will be starting soon, in Illenova. I would suggest you both head onto the train soon, without getting caught up in another escapade." He rubs his neck. "I… have nothing else, to say, I suppose."

Katsuki growls and rips his sleeve out of Izuku's hand. He stomps forward and jabs his finger into Todoroki's chest, the other boy glancing up at him with a furrowed brow.

"*Don't* fucking tell me, or Deku, what the hell to do. We go where we fucking please, Half N' Half." He tilts his head high, a growl breaching his lips. "Stay out of our way, and don't bother with us, you pretentious fuck."

Todoroki's lips twitch. His left eyebrow crooks.

"I forget how charming you are outside of one-sided arguments over the phone." He turns away from Katsuki, a subtle glimmer brimming in his heterochromatic gaze. "As much of an influence you and I have in Sommartyn, the rules still apply. Unfortunately. Maybe I would extend benefits to you if you weren't so conceited and full of yourself."

Katsuki's teeth gnash together. Sparks pop in his palms, threatening to spill over and reach an entirely new critical point that may or may not be under his control. He ignores the steady breathing from Izuku behind him, the other boy glancing between him and Todoroki as if expecting a cataclysmic fight to break out on the sidewalk.

"I don't need your bitch-ass *benefits*," he says, low and damaging. His body shifts ever so slightly, a cocky assuredness clouding his posture.

"Hm. Your history would claim you to be a liar," Todoroki smoothly replies.

Veins bulge in Katsuki's neck.

His muscles coil, tight and outraged.

Far too many restrictions are placed on him in this very moment, knowing well of the rules in each district and the amount of disgust he'll be facing directly with both authorities and Izuku himself. He would rather bend the rules to his will and force Shouto Todoroki to abide by his demands, given the stretch of arguments, threats, and secret investigations that placed them both on opposite ends of the spectrum.

Though, he supposes that he can't blame Izuku for this assumption.

“How about we all head there, then?” Izuku asks, his smile too broad and too welcoming.

Though, his lips are strained and his hands are clasped together in a desperate attempt at peace-making.

Katsuki whips his head towards the other teen and glares, lips set in a firm line with each sheepish grin Izuku gives in return.

“Where were you heading, Todoroki? I always forget that you’re from Sommartyn, too.”

Todoroki clears his throat, scratching his ear with his other hand.

“Ah, well. I had a meeting with my father and… clients, around an hour ago. I was heading home, actually, but if you would like a pass back to Isabori—”

“Oh, no, um, that’s alright.” Izuku straightens, a blush coloring his cheeks.

What the hell?

Katsuki’s glare finds Todoroki’s calm, yet slightly pink, features as he addresses Izuku in a way that makes Katsuki feel strangely out of place.

“I’m sure Bakugou will have no trouble retracing his steps back to Sommartyn, but with the controversy that occurred in Isabori, it might be safest for you to find refuge somewhere else.” Todoroki briefly admonishes Katsuki with a glare, as if suspecting an explosive answer in return, though he turns back to Izuku before he can properly gauge a reaction. “I would assume that you would have talked to Mr. Aizawa or someone else at the school board to excuse you. Others in the class are concerned about where you’ve been.”

“Oh, um.” Izuku swallows. “I’ve been calling some of them… but, I’m not exactly friends with our entire class. I called Uraraka and I’ve been texting her, but, oh no, does that mean people think…? Do people think I’m dead? Or, wait, are the others okay? You’ve seen all of the others, right? Mina, Tsuyu, Eijirou? Are they alright?” He pales. "Oh, wait, no, that wouldn't make sense at all if people thought I were dead. That would be awful... and it wouldn't be made clear like I wasn't, right? Oh gosh, I'm losing track of even my own friends. I'm such a terrible person..."

Katsuki’s frown deepens. The anxiety spiking from Izuku’s body unsettles him greatly, which, in itself, is unfamiliar enough to discomfort him.

"Hey, Deku, calm the fuck down," he says, with hardly any bite. He pats Izuku on the back, and his friend exhales shakily to glance around him, skin red and flushed.

Todoroki watches them, silent.

Katsuki snarls, and remains close to Izuku’s side, a brace between the person he knows he would protect and coerce with ease against someone he would much rather consider a stranger.

“They are all back at the high school,” Todoroki says, quickly. “I know that you work for the school newspaper.”

Izuku scratches the back of his head.

“I’ve been writing some drafts and have been talking to Uraraka about them. There are some article ideas I need to run by her first before we move forward with anything.”

Katsuki’s brows raise to his hairline. He holds back an aggravated sneer at the fact that Izuku had never mentioned this once to him. He’d staked a firm foothold in the pool of possibilities that Izuku had granted him in terms of their brief, yet relatively terse, conversations. He was aware that Izuku was a blooming writer, and according to both of their mothers—and his reputation—he was talented.

While the young Bakugou was unable to believe that words alone could benefit society or even make the great changes that a Quirkless individual like Izuku dreamed, the depth to his ideas and responsibilities were certainly there. Strong, undeniable and *real*.

“Quit pestering him, Icy Hot.” Katsuki growls and brings his hand up in a curled fist beneath Todoroki’s nose. The other teen barely acknowledges this, his nose scrunching up in distaste at the scarred knuckles positioned several inches from him. “Deku doesn’t owe you *shit*. He’ll tell you when he fucking wants to.” He smirks dangerously and tilts his head. “Eh? Got nothing to say for once?”

Todoroki’s jaw tightens.

“I believe the only one instigating a fight of any kind is you, Bakugou.” He backs away slightly, sighing. “Really. Communicating with brute force will get you nowhere.”

Katsuki snorts.

“Fuck. *You*.”

“I’m starting to lose my patience dealing with you, Bakugou—”

“Oh, like I give two shits about your bullshit *public persona*,” Katsuki retorts. “We both know the shit you pull when no one’s looking. If Deku weren’t here, you’d be bringing out all those fancy ass flames and icicles like the fucking candy cane poser you are.”

His pupils dilate, his curled lips receding even further, his shoulders vibrating with the insatiable need to punch the smug aura right off of Todoroki’s face.

Todoroki takes one bold step forward, his mouth opening to reply, when Izuku abruptly comes over to his side and grasps his forearm.

Katsuki’s chest bursts with twitches, as if a colony of fire ants were beginning to crawl and slip under his flesh. He huffs and breaks off the two of them, attempting to keep his attention away from the fact that Izuku’s hand is gripping like iron around Todoroki’s arm and not *his*
—

“You both need to stop, but you look like you’re going to crack first, Todoroki.” Izuku’s gaze is firm, his voice thick with warning. “Please don’t do this, either of you.” He releases Todoroki, who glances at him in an apologetic manner, and within seconds those big green eyes turn to lock on Katsuki once more.

Immediately, his disposition softens, his freckles a smattering of stars on flushed skin as he smiles, warm and tender and reserved solely for Katsuki.

Katsuki straightens. Swallows.

That *look*.

Fuck.

He pushes down a feverish growl, snatches Izuku’s wrist and yanks him away from Todoroki, the both of them strung alongside each other as he marches down the sidewalk.

A sneer curls his lips, his steps heavy and reprimanding.

His heart is racing, beating recklessly.

Anger pulses fiercely and loudly in his head, throbbing and aching and painful.

“Kacchan, ah—wait, *stop*.” Izuku huffs, pulling his arm away. “What’s gotten into you? I’m not sure what kind of history you have with Todoroki, and—actually it would be great if you could, I don’t know, *explain* some of that to me—but was that *really* necessary?”

Katsuki runs one hand through his hair.

"Yes, it fucking was," he snaps.

Izuku recoils, hurt flashing across his face.

"What's your problem today? And with him, of all people?"

Katsuki's fists clench tightly at his sides. He puffs up his chest, though Izuku stubbornly glares at him in return. The fire and electricity in his gaze locks onto him and holds him down, as if throttling him in chains.

"You don't know anything about him, Deku! Just because you go to the same fucking school doesn't mean you know what I know! Why the hell do you think we can't get along, huh?" Izuku seems to consider this, though he seems less than impressed. If anything, the irritation thickening the space between them only grows.

"He's a good person. I get it, though, that I don't know him the way you do. There's clearly history there." Izuku sighs, exasperated. "But don't yell at me like it's my fault."

Katsuki gawks, blinking rapidly.

"I'm—fuck, Deku, I'm not yelling at you like it's your fault, you idiot!"

"Oh yeah? Then what do you call," Izuku gestures at their feet, and waves his arm around him in a near-windmill motion, "*this*? You're always yelling at me for something, like I somehow have an inkling of an idea on what's going on. But Kacchan, you have to understand that nothing that's happened is all what I expected! I'm just in the dark as you are."

Izuku is inches away from his face, close enough for Katsuki to spot the noticeable crinkles in the corners of his deep green eyes.

After several long, agonizing moments, Katsuki sucks in a breath, and steps away.

Hundreds of yards from where they stand, timestamps flicker on the tram railway. The sight sends a flickering beneath Katsuki's skin.

His hands fidget awkwardly over his pants, sweaty palms brushing over the fabric.

He clicks his tongue and surveys the crowd growing thicker ahead of them—a stuttering sea of wind-whipped coats and scarves.

He regards Izuku strongly, a dozen questions and demands burning on his tongue and desperate to be released like the cracked end of a whip.

He wants to force the answers out of Izuku, but knows that it would only degrade what little progress they've made as… whatever they are, to absolutely nothing once more.

"I'll—fuck, I'll explain on the damn train, alright?" He snorts. "Nosy piece of shit, you know that? You don't owe that bastard anything."

Izuku watches him, and the glare itself sears and breaches Katsuki's defenses in a way that renders him angrier than before.

He huffs into the cold winds, his breath leaving his parted lips in a cloud.

He understands Izuku's hesitance, but the irritation burning in his veins is open and raw, riding directly off the wave of encountering Shouto Todoroki only hours after being forced into a threatening phone call.

"I doubt, despite your history, that Todoroki is coming from a bad place." Izuku hums, muttering into his hand and inhaling a fresh gulp of air. "I don't want to fight with you about this, Kacchan. The deeper we get into this, though, the more answers I'm going to need from you. I have nothing more to hide other than what I have yet to find out. And, it's only been a couple weeks, but with everything that's happened—I mean, don't you think I deserve some answers from *you*?"

Katsuki sharply turns his head, fists clenching.

"You fucking saying I owe *you* answers, Deku? Are you fucking shitting me?" He barks out a harsh laugh. "Oh, that's *rich*. I don't owe you shit, Deku. I never have, and I never will, understand? People like that Icy Hot motherfucker are worth avoiding because they antagonize *me* and *my family*. And *you*—," he jabs a finger into Izuku's chest, his face

looming close, “are under *my* protection. If I’m keeping information from you, it’s for your own good.”

He draws his finger back, but only just slightly as his eyes take in every inch of Izuku’s body freezing in place.

Katsuki’s insides somersault, a sudden question brewing in his mind’s eye as the obvious repercussions to what he’s just said slap him in the face.

Izuku draws in another breath, his hands balling into fists at his sides. He jerks his head away from Katsuki, his glare intensifying, as if he's struggling somehow accept what he’s just heard.

“Good to know you don’t consider us equals.”

Katsuki’s jaw slacks.

Rage bubbles up in his chest.

He stalks forward, right as Izuku paces ahead and moves away from him, his back stiff and his neck strained. Katsuki twitches with each second that Izuku refuses to take in glancing over to him—he expects more from this, especially if the other teen is going to be this unforgiving and brash. He suspected that Izuku would succumb to his claims and ultimately understand, given that he’s been admirable of the Bakugous before.

“Hey, Deku! Where do you think you’re—”

Izuku ignores him, and leaves him behind in the scuffle of the growing crowd.

Katsuki splutters. He lifts his head higher and surveys the taller adults and small children weaving through their legs and arms. He snorts, and allows sparks to pop in his palms, quickly shoving his way through and ignoring the shocked squeaks and angry curses thrown in his direction.

“You’re causing public panic, Kacchan,” says Izuku, not even looking over his shoulder as he selects the correct number of change in his pocket to place in the toll collector—a tall, languid piece of machinery that creaks with each button Izuku presses.

It chortles like a broken instrument, and prints out a familiar bronze ticket for him to swipe from the mouth.

Katsuki huffs and grabs the other’s wrist. Izuku glares back at him, expectant.

“The fuck is your problem?” He snaps. “You just marched ahead like some crazy—”

“Hm, not really what I was hoping you'd say. You’re holding up the line.” Izuku gestures with a flick of his head towards the angry bustling people in the back.

Katsuki rolls his eyes and glares at his companion, who calmly pulls his wrist back and ignores the way he blinks at the action.

“I’m serious. I was *this* close to leaving you behind. But that wouldn’t matter, right? Since you’re so *tough* and don’t need someone like *me* to drag you in the mud.”

Katsuki stills.

The words slice through his bones like icicles.

He readies himself, anger rising hot and fast through his neck as his tongue curls back to reinforce a scream. Though, instead of releasing it, he shuts his mouth tight and glares the other way, refusing to allow his need to profanely vent into the air to give away the impression that Izuku’s simple statement affected him.

“Just because he’s the opposite of you doesn’t mean he’s any weaker.”

His mother’s words echo in his mind, rattling his insides.

He snorts and averts his eyes from looking too far into the dangerous depths of Izuku’s gaze. Those green irises could hold him for a frighteningly long time, and if the stares ever broke it would mostly be because Izuku bothered to blink or draw his attention to something else that had nothing to do with Katsuki.

Izuku shakes his head, and pushes through the iron grating that separates the clamoring guests from the opening doors to the train.

Katsuki punches the appropriate numbers in the toll collector, and follows him.

Tuesday. 2:02 PM.

The train cart reeks of mildew and expired deodorant.

Izuku’s nose wrinkles several steps onto the locomotive, his tongue tracing with the experimental taste of metal and smoke drifting in the vicinity. He closes in and scouts an open spot, shouldering past a cluster of taller strangers and muttering his apologies. He refrains from glancing over his shoulder to see if Katsuki has spotted him finding another spot, and silently wills himself to remain patient and cautious.

His blood still simmers with contempt and anger.

He's such an asshole.

Though, perhaps, Katsuki's reaction shouldn't have surprised him.

He’d known since encountering Katsuki Bakugou for the first time that the other teen was a walking time bomb of rage and egotism, among other aspects of his personality that Izuku

found more intriguing than anything.

Though, to hear those words leave Katsuki's lips, to register them in the open air, made his skin crawl with laces of poison.

He bypasses a little girl with large, skeptical eyes and a pair of pigtails, to place himself in a seat beside the window.

Frost tints the glass, his own breath forming warm rings on his side of the barrier between the inside and outside world. He rubs his hands together, friction steady and welcoming between his palms and fingers.

A piece of him wishes to peel his phone from his jacket pocket and check for notifications, or even make a phone call to someone at the high school operating the newspaper in his absence —anything, to distract him from the incessant worries pounding the back of his skull.

"Your muttering is like a fucking Deku beacon, you know."

Izuku blinks and turns, right as he spots Katsuki shuffling in the tight spot next to him.

Despite his apparent need to remain close at his side, the Bakugou heir's skin is tinted just the slightest shade of red, his lips rosy and flushed from their kiss.

Izuku's insides flutter with simultaneous frustration and curiosity, his lips still burning from the feel of the other's mouth over his own less than twenty minutes before. He hates this effect that Katsuki has on him, this grip on his senses and drive that both distracts and fuels him.

"Only for people who bother to find the source," quips Izuku, a faint grin curling his lips. "That's an interesting apology, by the way. I don't think I'm familiar with the type."

He strokes his chin, chuckling into his hands as he envisions the murderous scowl Katsuki must be granting him this very moment. He draws circles onto the window next to him, nose scrunching up against the growing cold on the train.

Katsuki roughly shoves Izuku.

"Dumbass." He licks his lips, dark reddish brown eyes scorching holes into the seats in front of them. "So, I'm going to ask you a few things, but only once, so pay attention."

"I'm not answering. Sorry." Izuku shrugs.

Katsuki balks. "What?!"

"I *said*, I'm not answering. Apparently neither of us owe each other any explanation whatsoever. According to *you*, at least." Izuku tilts his head to the side, biting the inside of his cheek to prevent a mocking smile from overtaking his mouth. "Seriously, though, Kacchan, what's gotten into you? You're usually pretty tense, but…" he chuckles as Katsuki's eye twitches. "N-Not that that's a bad thing, necessarily! I understand the pressure

you have, being a Bakugou and everything.” He ponders, muttering under his breath and flicking his eyes around the train. “But, with Todoroki…”

Katsuki stills his jaw, leaning back into the booth.

“Half N’ Half doesn’t know when to shut his mouth,” he grumbles, trailing off as if to piece together what he wants to vocalize.

He adjusts his seat, resting his right ankle on his left knee and turning his profile to scan the premises.

His eyes narrow every so often, as if spotting something interesting but not enough for him to bring it to Izuku’s attention.

His left arm weaves and rests behind Izuku’s head, causing the other teen to stiffen and turn pink.

He laughs nervously and scratches his cheek, somehow still not accustomed to the close proximity of the infuriating teen beside him. Katsuki’s heat flows from his body in tidal waves, the arm caging behind his head and the hand resting too casually beside Izuku’s shoulder instantly making his chest explode into butterflies.

No, no, you’re supposed to be mad at him!

“You’re the pathetic fanboy,” Katsuki huffs. “I doubt you don’t know who the former pro hero Endeavor is.”

Izuku blinks, staring at Katsuki as if he’s grown another head.

“Of course I do!” He waves his arms, frantic and suddenly becoming lost in the numerous images flashing in his mind’s eye. “He’s one of the most respected heroes of the last thirty years! Even, even in All Might’s best era!”

He nods his head furiously, making vigorous hand motions in the air and drawing several shapes in front of him, as if to map out what he envisions through each passing second.

“He was responsible for teaming up with Kamui Woods and even stationing his own agency to prevent the outbreak in Two-Thousand Two! And, of course, no one can forget his contribution to the riots in Two-Thousand Seven, and his pretty frequent and controversial opinions on the status of heroes in society…” he hums, rubbing his chin in thought. “Oh! And, he’s always been a rival to All Might, both in the court system, in heroic excursions *and* in the storylines on the television show that premiered when we were kids—”

Katsuki’s hand slaps over his mouth. Izuku flushes beet-red, momentarily pulled back from his pit of ramblings and memories to fixate his stare onto Katsuki’s amused smirk.

“Damn nerd.” He snorts. “I didn’t ask for a fucking book, Deku. Just whether or not you knew who he was.” He shrugs, taking his hand back. “The bastard is Shouto Todoroki’s father.”

Izuku's brain short-circuits.

"... What."

Katsuki snorts. "Yeah. That pretentious fucktard—"

"Wait, Kacchan, this means…" Izuku buries his face into his hands, gobsmacked. "I've been going to school with the son of retired Pro Hero Endeavor and didn't even know it? Oh my gosh—I, I have to ask for his autograph! I have to call him, or, or even ask Todoroki if he can introduce me. Kacchan, what is he like in person—"

"Shut up, Deku!" Katsuki snarls, grabbing Izuku's shoulder with his other hand. Izuku pouts, an action that prompts Katsuki to lower his eyes and flick back up for a handful of seconds.

He adjusts his seat, scratching his ear.

"Fuck. Just, shut the hell up. I shouldn't even be sharing this shit. Calm the fuck down or I'm not sharing jack about this with you!" He jams one finger into Izuku's chest.

Izuku calms the steady excitement building in his body, and smiles at Katsuki.

"Okay. I'll be good." He obediently places his hands on his lap, his expression tender and patient, like a puppy waiting for the treat of the century.

Katsuki blinks, his eyes widening for a split second before he curses, withdraws his finger and rubs his jaw. His cheeks turn an even darker hue, his brow furrowing in the middle and his glare becoming less and less intimidating the longer Izuku assesses him.

"Too bright…" he grumbles.

Izuku frowns. "Kacchan?"

"Anyway!" Katsuki jolts back up, clearing his throat. "Yeah. That prick is Todoroki's old man. I'm not giving you that entire fucker's backstory, but long story short, his family hates mine. We both operate our own establishments in Sommartyn, and those pieces of shit have been slandering our name and claiming us to be villains and pariahs for years. I met Todoroki years ago in a meeting with our parents."

Izuku tilts his head, pondering. "Why would they spread lies about you like that?"

He's never believed Shouto Todoroki to be a person who would blindly accept reasons for disliking another person, though perhaps his loyalties were far deeper than what he'd assumed.

"They're convinced we're Russian villains or spies or some shit." He raises an eyebrow towards Izuku. "I thought you were spying for him, since you went to the same high school and I didn't trust you." He pinches Izuku's cheek. "Should've known better. You're about as intimidating as a fucking mouse."

"*Kacchan*," groans Izuku, smacking his hand away. "Not the point."

“Whatever.” Katsuki snorts. “He called me this morning."

The statement registers slower than it should.

"W-What? Really? Why?" Izuku's frown deepens. "Why would he even... oh wait, I guess it would make sense for you to have his number, and vice versa. But still."

"He was hounding me about you." Katsuki rolls his eyes. "Acted like I was keeping you hostage or something."

Izuku shrugs. "Well, to be fair, you *did* threaten me the first night we met, and *after* that, actually... but, I mean, you didn't hold me hostage or anything. So he would be wrong about that." He grins at the memory. "I just thought you were really interesting, and so handsome." Katsuki stiffens at this, though his smirk seems satisfied. "Even after knocking you off the train, giving you a concussion..." He bites his lip.

"Yeah, you crazy fucker. Tackling me out of nowhere like a man possessed. Jesus Christ."

"You were taunting me!" Izuku laughs, swatting his arm. "Seriously. I was tired of you being an asshole. I wasn't *trying* to give you a concussion!"

Katsuki hums at this, licking his lips. "So. What, did you and Icy Hot...?"

Izuku's laugh shuts off. Confused, he fixates on Katsuki as the train rumbles and moves, strangers bumping shoulders and shoving one another to leave.

"Did we...?"

Katsuki's entire face turns a deep scarlet. He grits his teeth and glares at the window on the other side of the train, refusing to meet Izuku's inquiring gaze.

"Did you... ugh, Deku, did you two fucking *date* or something?”

The words roll easily off his tongue, though the way he finally turns to side-glare at Izuku as if he’d insulted his explosive Quirk makes the other boy hold up his hands.

“No, no, um—hah, no way.”

He blushes fiercely and whips his head away from Katsuki’s unconvinced, aggravated look.

“I haven’t been interested in anyone at my high school. You’re the first person I’ve ever kissed, and…” he pauses, embarrassment and awareness prickling up his spine. He considers avoiding this topic altogether, though he knows that once the train stops, Katsuki won’t let him leave this booth until he gives him the answers he wants. “I mean, I used to think he was attractive, sure, but a lot of people did. Nothing romantic behind that. We’re not even really friends. He’s always been a bit standoffish and keeps to himself, but I’ve never been anything but nice to him. And, he's always been nice to me, so."

He looks at Katsuki, leaning comfortably back against the booth.

“Why’d you ask?” He says, quieter now, as if the world around them have closed in to just the two of them.

He watches Katsuki’s expression, the other teen focused and contemplative, searching his features as if attempting to weed out the potential lies.

"Does it matter?"

Izuku ponders. "Well, I mean, a little bit..."

He knows that Katsuki’s insecurities lie far deeper than he’d originally expected, and the intense possessiveness that follows Katsuki’s actions with him in public say enough for him to conclude that the explosive teen may need assurance.

"It doesn't. You didn't date, so it doesn't matter."

"What if we did?" Izuku grins despite himself. "Don't tell me you're..."

Then, Katsuki whips his head to stare at him, shoulders tight and fingers gripping around his elbows.

"*Don't tell me you're*... what, Deku?" he growls, mimicking Izuku's voice mockingly. "You going to finish that sentence? Go on. I dare you."

Izuku considers this, mouth opening with a decisive *pop*.

"You're jealous for no reason, you know." He grins. Katsuki's eyes widen. "Really, Kacchan."

He shudders, just slightly, as he feels Katsuki’s fingers experimentally trace the exposed nape of his neck.

Izuku’s eyelashes flutter, a spread of goosebumps dancing over his skin. He watches Katsuki’s expression, still unchanged, even as those same digits trail up and tenderly—*affectionately*—weave through his curls.

He feels the heat of Katsuki’s palm rest and lift, and he watches, suppressing a giggle, as Katsuki’s gaze and eyebrows turn sharp.

“K-Kacchan?”

Katsuki says nothing.

His eyes are glazed over, questions and theories burning in those intense auburn eyes.

The way he shifts in his seat, the way his tongue swipes over his bottom lip, and the way his fingers suddenly drop from Izuku’s hair to trace teasingly over his neck, render Izuku breathless.

Katsuki’s lips crook into a smirk.

“So *easy*,” he says, as if hypnotized with each shuddering breath and stilted motion Izuku makes in response to his caresses. Then, he leans in and growls along Izuku’s ear, the action completely unwarranted and yet, Izuku’s heart thumps loud and harsh against his chest. “You’re so shameless, Deku. So *easy* for me. Not that Icy Hot bastard. *Me*.”

That tone.

He’s never spoken like this to Izuku before.

Izuku’s mouth parts, his words left ghosting on his tongue.

“I—um.”

He swallows.

It takes every ounce of willpower and control Izuku has to push himself further away from Katsuki and tenderly, slowly, reach behind him to find those searching fingers and intertwine their hands together. His smile is sheepish, almost apologetic, yet he gestures with a flick of his head to the people surrounding them, as if to indicate that, indeed, they are still in a public place.

Katsuki, rather than explode into a tantrum, huffs, rolls his eyes and squeezes Izuku’s hand. He withdraws his arm and remains in the position on his seat, folding his own fingers together and leaning his head back to focus on the ceiling.

“Gonna sleep. Wake me up when we get there, shitty Deku.”

Izuku shakes his head, his smile nothing but fond as Katsuki closes his eyes and allows his facial features to smooth out into cut angles and plains. He leans back as well, and pulls out his phone to send a quick text to Uraraka.

To: Uraraka

- *Hey, I know we haven’t talked in a couple days. I’ll be in tomorrow so we can go over things for the paper! I have an idea on what we can write about next. Remember that profile piece I mentioned? Yeah, I think I can get us a good source for it, if you’re still okay with that idea.*

He closes his phone, and sighs.

He scoots closer to Katsuki, the blond’s nose scrunching up at the intrusive presence, and then instantly relaxing as Izuku pats his knee, to assure him.

He watches Katsuki’s features soften once more, a scowl firmly in place despite the loosening spot in-between his eyebrows.

Hopefully, Katsuki will be willing to comply with what he has planned.

If anything, Izuku knows that applying a truthful story for the Bakugous in the local paper, or even in publications willing to accept his voice and work, will help propel Katsuki's family to a spotlight that deserves them.

The underlying corruption within Augustana sings through the streets and derails the pedestrians on the train.

To him, it's always traveled in patterns.

He watches children and adults alike communicate in silence, strangers who would never know of their impending destinies. He sees the miniscule moments that make up relationships between the old and the young, the thoughtless and the mindless, the gifted and the prodigious, and many other combinations that form the basis of their city and the world beyond.

Shigaraki Tomura, from what Izuku has gathered in his obsessive notes, research, and jotting down in his own notebooks in the late hours in the Bakugou household, is a person who will be following their every step from then on.

He knows his father has placed him in a predicament that neither he or his mother deserve, and Inko's worries for him are now rooted into something far deeper and out of their control.

Izuku bunches his hands together. His knee bobs up and down.

Whatever will come heading their way, they need to be ready.

"Kacchan, I'm kind of still in school—"

"Yeah, I don't really give a fuck."

Izuku snorts, hiding his smirk as he drops his backpack to the ground and bids a small wave towards his fellow students flocking to their lockers in the hallway. He keeps his phone pressed to his shoulder, fingers coasting through his unzipped bag and pulling out numerous folders, binders and other stacks of strung-together homework that he's painstakingly finished over the course of several clustered days.

"Well, I have to work on the paper in about ten minutes. So, I won't be back in Sommartyn for awhile…" He hesitates, his hand fumbling on the sleek black phone balanced between his phone and his shoulder. He scowls at his locker, frowning at the lacking presence of several

textbooks he believed he'd left inside before his kidnapping. "Anyway, did you even listen to me this morning when I asked you for that favor?"

"What favor?"

Izuku scoffs. "Kacchan. The paper. Can you come? I want to interview you for a profile piece. It took me forever to convince Uraraka to let this happen, and she's already been through enough, so it's kind of a miracle that she's willing to go through with this at all." He pauses, assessing the aggressive blond's response over the line. He grins to himself at the clear mumbling he recognizes through the sparking connection.

"Round Face? Why the fuck do you take orders from her? I've read your shit. You can write far better than that bimbo."

Izuku flushes and glances around him, hoping Katsuki's blatant insults and colorful language hadn't escaped into the open.

He smiles bashfully at several other students from a separate class walk by, their stares lasting only milliseconds before they resume walking to their respective classrooms.

"Kacchan, she's my best friend. You can't call her names like that." He frowns. "Seriously."

"Whatever, Deku! I don't have to fucking like her if I don't want to!"

"Well, yeah, I know that." Izuku shrugs. "Anyway. Back to the paper. Can you come? I know it's a lot to ask, but, this could be really good for you and your family! And, it would be worth it to get the word out there, that you're not going to stay silent even with what happened to us. I don't even have to talk about anything you don't want to."

"Dunno, Deku. Sounds like a waste of time."

Izuku groans. "Kacchan. Please?" He ponders. "You should do it. I can't—I won't force you. But, this could be a major opportunity to get things on the right track! And…" He looks around him, slowly closes his locker, and speaks quietly into his phone. "Shigaraki might even be looking out for it. We could maybe help the detectives put another stop to this if we have the public understanding that you're not this villainous person that everyone thinks."

He bides his time, rocking on the balls of his feet, as the clock ticks on the wall above the lockers. Students pass by in blurred colors, their voices nothing but jumbled white noise in Izuku's eardrums.

"What do I get in return?"

Izuku stiffens. He sighs, turning around and leaning with his back to the lockers. He cards one hand through his curls, and cycles through the options of possible rewards someone like Katsuki Bakugou would want. He's aware of the Bakugous' imminent wealth, and the access they have to public amenities that most wouldn't have access to unless they had special connections in Augustana.

He knows that Katsuki likes certain books and video games and even has a special—*private, aggressive, adorable*—love for a series of novels about a young boy with a tragic destiny who goes to a magical boarding school for witches and wizards. Though, from the last time he dared ask Mitsuki Bakugou about Katsuki's apparent secret affection for those books, she'd laughed too long and hard for him to understand the extent of why the question in itself was so funny.

Katsuki Bakugou and gifts seem almost possible when thinking of them together.

Izuku bites his lip. "Um. Well, what do you want?"

He waits, and smiles at Uraraka Ochako making her way over towards him. Her presence is altogether lighthearted and tender, a feather in a bustling storm, especially after the events that separated them last. His kidnapping and Uraraka's paranoid belief that she'd never see him again were quickly shoved into the same dark pit that Izuku never wished to reopen.

"Izuku!" She stops in front of him, doe-brown eyes shining. "Ah, what are you doing on the phone? Come on, we have so much to talk about on top of the paper!"

Izuku chuckles awkwardly and gestures to his phone.

Uraraka smirks in understanding, and punches his arm before bouncing off. He watches her go, knowing that he will have to follow her footsteps and unlock the door to the room they've reserve for the news committee.

Katsuki's voice finally returns, sounding far too smug and comfortable for Izuku's liking.

"I can think of a few things."

A chill races down Izuku's spine, directly to his curling toes. He keeps his head low, racing with his backpack loose over his shoulders to the newsroom.

"O-Oh, yeah?" He asks, pulling at his collar. "Um, I guess, maybe, something to do with… food? Yeah! Um, I could take you somewhere, or, we could just, I don't know. Do something. Is that what you want? Or, I could leave you alone or, even—"

"Christ, Deku! I'm not planning your fucking murder, stupid nerd."

Izuku rolls his eyes. "Alright, well, I'm about to head into the office to get things situated for the next paper issue. Uraraka and I haven't met about this in person since before the… incident." He scratches his neck, sighing. "So, you'll be coming, though?"

"Whatever, nerd. I'll be there."

For once, Katsuki is the first to hang up on their call.

Izuku stares at his phone, perplexed.

"Izuku, I could use some help in here, you know."

Izuku lifts his head, and grins at Uraraka, who opens the door wider and gestures towards the interior of the place where they've spent countless nights staying late nights, editing and writing until their brains would teeter on the edge of barely functioning.

"I'm sorry that I've left all of this to you these last few days." Izuku sighs. "I mean, with all that happened… I know that we talked, but, are you okay?" He watches her, frowning. "I'm sorry, Uraraka, about what happened to all of us, and to have you and the others caught up in that—"

"Izuku." Uraraka shakes her head, her thin, delicate hands sweeping her hair into a messy bun atop her head. She studies him, long lashes fluttering in silent amusement and concern. "You shouldn't be the one apologizing for everything. Sure, it was… crazy, but you just… vanished." She bites her bottom lip, tucking one stray hair behind her ear. "Anyway, we can talk about that inside. Is your victim here for the cross-examination?" She winks, folding her arms under her chest and casually leaning next to the doorframe.

Izuku chuckles dryly. "He'll be here soon. I was just on the phone with him."

"Yeah. Can't wait for his charming self to make an entrance." Uraraka rolls her eyes. "We should clean up before we start drafting anything. Let's get this under way."

It takes less than thirty minutes for Izuku and Uraraka to clean and rearrange the insides of the place, at least with the assistance of Uraraka's Quirk.

The way she meticulously rearranges documents and moves old folders into storage boxes with her anti-gravitational touch makes Izuku laugh. He nearly stumbles over with the mounds of folders crushed to his chest, broken pens and pencils awkwardly shoved beneath his armpits and a stack of papers clenched between his teeth.

Uraraka uncaps her water bottle and drinks, smiling towards Izuku as they sit beside one another on the floor. Their backs are pressed to the wall, an open bag of chocolate raisin candies shared between them.

They chuckle and laugh into the private emptiness of the office, this very place sending memories and familiar smells alike into Izuku's senses. He recalls the tender hours late into the night, listening to Uraraka spouting off ideas, his own pencil tight in his teeth as they bounce ideas off of one another, their words instilled in scrapped papers and in abandoned computer documents.

"Okay, but, no one was able to help me with this. It's kind of sad, Izuku." Uraraka giggles. "Tsuyu tried, bless her heart, but there's just too much that only you know about. I couldn't just, erase the ideas and drafts we talked about beforehand. I even kept that one note page I had about your dumb profile piece."

Izuku snorts. "It's not dumb. It's just…" He chuckles. "Oh my god. Never mind."

"What?" Uraraka pokes him. "What were you about to say?"

“I—oh man, he would kill me if I said this.” He slaps his hand over his mouth, his giggles muffled under his skin and threatening to burst. “I just—it would be… such an *explosive* piece, you know?” He continues laughing as Uraraka rolls her eyes and smacks his shoulder. He stares at her with an amused twitch to his lips. “Okay, well, maybe that really was too much."

Uraraka smirks. “Whatever, dork.” She sighs, resting her hands in her lap.

Izuku holds back the many questions he wants to ask her, especially about the shadows bruising her eyelids and the scratches marring her cheeks. She’s received treatment in the hospital and scheduled appointments with a private therapist, as all the other victims in the incident from Yuuei High were required to do, yet, Izuku can’t contain his bottled worry.

“Don’t worry about me, Izuku.” Uraraka winks at him, the gesture fleeting and too kind. He smiles in return. “Hey, we should—”

The door to the place is suddenly kicked wide open.

“Leave me the fuck alone—hah? No, I’m not a student at your shitty school! Keep your fucking opinions to yourself! No, *you* shut the fuck up!”

Uraraka blinks. “... Guessing that’s him.”

Izuku is far too mortified and embarrassed to respond.

Especially as the grouchy, furious blond teenager stomps into the vicinity, his hands shoved into his pockets, while using only one leg to take the edge of the door and slam it back shut. His heel presses to the glass, a snarl marring his lips and his eye twitching.

“Fuckers.” He snorts, and scans the area until his eyes rest on Izuku and Uraraka. He scans them up and down. “The hell are you two useless nerds doing on the floor?”

“Gosh, you’re just as charming as I remember!” Uraraka chirps.

“Fuck you, Round Face!”

Uraraka flips him off.

Katsuki returns the gesture.

Izuku stutters and stands up, brushing down his pants. “Kacchan, thank you for—”

He blinks, taking in the other’s appearance with a small snort in the back of his throat.

He’s not sure what could have transpired for Katsuki to appear like this, but it’s certainly not what he expected, since the blond often places a rather meticulous amount of effort into his outfits through each and every day.

Katsuki looks as if he’s run through an obstacle course of ash, smoke, grime and dust. Izuku has never seen Katsuki wear a hoodie before, but the threadbare material is colored a bright,

shocking orange, his bruised features slathered in dirt and splotches of the same substance peppering his outfit. His worn sneakers are surprisingly clean in comparison, though the angry glow in Katsuki's red eyes are offset with the amusing amount of dirt and dust caked in his hair.

"Kacchan, what…" Izuku tilts his head, fascinated. "What *happened* to you?"

"Shut the fuck up, shitty Deku!" Katsuki snaps, aggressively trudging forward, grabbing Izuku by his arm and yanking him to his feet. He jabs a finger into his chest, his teeth bare and growls rising heavy and menacing in his broad chest. "Don't. Ask. Me. Dumb. Questions. Get it?"

Uraraka whistles. "Wow. What a mean boyfriend."

Izuku's frustrated reply to Katsuki fades in an instant.

He gawks, burying his face into his hands and avoiding Uraraka's knowing stare. His skin flushes with heat, and he spots Katsuki spluttering and turning redder than a summer tomato. Katsuki screeches and proceeds to stomp around the place, hands clenching and unclenching and muscles tight from refusing to unleash his Quirk.

"Fuck you! We're not fucking boyfriends!"

"U-Uraraka—"

"Oh. My mistake, then."

Though, Izuku knows by the twinkle in Uraraka's eye, that she is anything but apologetic.

"How long is this going to take?" Katsuki drawls, sitting with his legs crossed on the swiveling chair a few feet away from Izuku.

His elbow is balanced on his knee, chin resting in the palm of his hand while he surveys the unkempt, sprawling surroundings of the newspaper office.

Despite his messy attire and the rather angry way he'd entered the area, Izuku can't find it in himself to remain frustrated or even insulted at how Katsuki made himself present.

He had agreed to a favor he'd asked of him, and that alone was worth the clicking of his pen and the opened notebook positioned on his lap.

He smiles welcomingly towards Katsuki, who raises an eyebrow in return and fixates his glare on the notebook.

“Not too long.”

Izuku shrugs off his blazer, propping the jacket around his own chair and turning back towards his companion. The blond watches him, slowly, as if attempting to root out the questions Izuku is going to ask him, and immediately Izuku wonders if Katsuki suspects of the statements he has ready in his repertoire.

“I’m just going to ask about your basic story, and you have the freedom to completely reject my questions or even offer your own answers. Starting now, this is on the record, which means I can legally use anything you say in the paper.” Izuku smiles. “But, no pressure. I won’t force you to talk about anything you don’t want to. It’s up to you on what kinds of questions you want to answer, and how you want to answer them.”

“Whatever.” Katsuki shrugs. “Don’t give a shit.”

Izuku grins, thankful. “Alright, Kacchan. I’ll start with something simple.” He clears his throat, clicks the end of his pen, and begins scribbling into his notepad. “What brought you to Augustana in the first place?”

Time passes in a series of long, scattered questions and quickly taken answers.

Izuku listens to each word that falls from Katsuki’s lips, the answers bordering between complete disinterest or mild fascination.

He watches the way Katsuki’s eyes light up when asked about his childhood, about his admiration for heroes before their impending retirement, or even his favorite home-cooked dish. Some of these answers remain drabbled in the margins of Izuku’s notes, some underlined to remind him for later as he collects feedback that both entrance and marvel him.

Izuku rubs his eyes, blinking away the dryness seeping below his eyelids.

He sets down his notes and stretches his arms above his head, his spine popping in response. He rolls his neck, and rubs the sore spot developing in the nape. Leaning backward, he spares a wave after Uraraka, who eyes the both of them earnestly.

“I’m heading out. You should both head back before the train’s hours go on lockdown.” Uraraka dips her head. “Okay? Would be pretty bad for you to have to stay the night here.”

Izuku groans. “Uraraka, that was only…” He scrunches his nose. “… Four times!”

Katsuki rubs his jaw, quirking one eyebrow at Izuku.

“The fuck? You did *what*?”

“Oh, he didn’t tell you?” Uraraka taps her chin in mock-thought. “Well, since he’s such a workaholic, there’s definitely been times with me walking in here in the early morning to find Izuku in that chair, right over there, slumped over and drooling all over the keyboard.”

Izuku groans. “*Uraraka.*"

“He asked.” Uraraka winks. “But, seriously, take care of yourself! And you,” she points towards Katsuki, “you should make sure he gets home.”

Katsuki, to Izuku’s surprise, only clicks his tongue and folds his arms over his chest.

“Have a nice night, Uraraka,” says Izuku, waving after his friend as she leaves.

The door clanks gently behind her, and Izuku turns in his swiveling chair to reach his keyboard.

He can feel Katsuki’s glare burrowing into his profile.

He runs one hand through his hair, and opens up a new document. He taps his finger on the mouse and scans old notes that pop up on the glowing blue screen, foot tapping on the ground with barely contained patience. The only pencil that hasn't been chewed to bits between his teeth is lodged behind his ear.

The silence grows rather uncomfortable with Katsuki’s presence lingering a few feet away.

Izuku finally turns, and stops at the way Katsuki is looking at him.

The other teen’s eyebrows are pursed in the middle, his jaw set and pupils sliding over his frame.

“What are you staring at?” Izuku squirms in his seat, uncomfortable.

Katsuki calmly pulls his chair over towards him, switching his attention from the notes on the desk to the glaring screen.

Izuku straightens in understanding.

“Ah, I’m just—jotting things down before I compile it into a proper article.”

After a long quiet moment, Katsuki breaks it.

“You’ll kill yourself, operating like this.”

Izuku frowns, gesturing for the other to continue.

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “The fuck do you think I’m talking about? You interview me, get all your notes down, then try to write the article in one sitting? The hell is wrong with you?” His scowl deepens, though the line between concern and annoyance seems to blur in his alternating expressions. “You treat everything like a deadline, then you’ll never move forward. You’ll just, stay in the same place and never get your actual message across. No use even trying to pursue what the hell you want to do with your fucking life if you’re just a zombie.”

Izuku tilts his head, thoughtful.

“I…” He pauses. “I see your point, I think, but—”

“But *what*, Deku?” Katsuki’s glare deepens. “Also, if you’re going to slave your ass off on this article or whatever, you better make me look fucking awesome.” He folds his arms across his chest. “Stubborn nerd.”

Izuku scoffs. “I’m not the only stubborn one here, Kacchan.” He scratches the back of his head, typing out a quick first sentence opener for his article. “Are Spicy Pops really your favorite candy?” He grins at Katsuki, who glares sharply in return.

“Get bent. Spicy Pops are the shit.”

Izuku laughs, free and unafraid, and the tiredness easily dissipates.

“Okay, okay. Spicy Pops are the shit, as you say.”

He shakes his head and drags his fingers over the keys, pressing his thumb to his lips as he browses through the notes he’s thrown onto his book. He hesitates, however, his left hand fumbling for his pen out of habit. He feels Katsuki studying him, reading him.

“So. Um. About what Uraraka said…”

He tests the waters, unsure of whether or not he should address this topic while the both of them are alone, exhausted, and straddled on the edge of concerning revelations that concern them and their roles in Augustana. He knows that he and Katsuki have been placed in circumstances out of their control, thrust into a world bridged between dark and light that propose ideas and results that he would have never dreamt of being possible without meeting Katsuki.

“She’s just, you know, like that.” Izuku bites his bottom lip, his palms sweating. Nervousness tingles under his skin like static. “I know that—um. We’re not… I don’t know, what we are… exactly. But, I'm just letting you know that you don’t have to worry about what she said. I didn’t tell her anything. She just likes to tease me, and—”

“Deku.”

Izuku pauses, turning to Katsuki with barely marked flinching.

Katsuki is facing the ceiling, his arms crossed behind his head for support and one leg folded over the other. His lips are firm and his eyes glazed over, clearly lost in thought.

“Shut up and work on your article.”

Izuku nods. “R-Right.”

The hours pass by steadily. Occasionally, Katsuki will begin pacing the room around him, refusing to leave the premises and head back to Sommartyn while Izuku remained at his seat, typing furiously away and scouring over his notes for emphasis.

Izuku groans, rubbing his temples. A headache begins to stir, his words contorting and shifting in patterns.

He leans back in his chair, scratching his cheek and obsessively glancing over his notes and what he has prepared for the article he needs to make active within the next few weeks.

The sooner he has the piece out and alive in the world, the better the possibilities.

Izuku nearly falls out of his chair in surprise at Katsuki's presence looming behind him, an angled chin finding a comfortable resting place on his shoulder.

He relaxes, though his upper back and neck are still store from hunching over and writing for hours on end. As if sensing his discomfort, Katsuki lifts his chin and stands behind him.

The fabric of Katsuki's hoodie brushes the back of his neck.

"Kacchan?" He blinks and looks up, only to see Katsuki staring down at him.

"Lean forward," he says.

Izuku frowns. "What?"

"Just do it, you damn nerd," mumbles Katsuki. He rolls his eyes and waits for Izuku to cautiously, unsurely, lean forward and prop his elbows on his knees. "Ugh, not all the way to your lap, dipshit. Here. Gotta do fucking everything…" He places his hands on Izuku's shoulders and quickly, yet gently, pulls him back, just a few inches away from the chair's spine.

Izuku bristles at the touch, of feeling Katsuki's digits form such a strong grip on him.

"Um…"

"Jesus, have you never taken a fucking break in your life?" Katsuki's thumbs then dive between the tightly wound muscles in Izuku's upper back, and Izuku lets out a soft breath of surprise at the jolting sensation in his bones. "Deku, *relax*," says Katsuki, and then, Izuku holds back a long, pleased moan as a geyser of heat blossoms and spreads through his body.

Katsuki remains silent, knowingly placing his hands as stabilizing forces on Izuku's back, his thumbs pressing deeply into the tightest spots and allowing his other hand to coast and press tender heat through his skin and further soften selected spots.

Izuku's eyes flutter at the sensations. He unconsciously leans backward into Katsuki's gentle, calming touch, relishing the feel of the other's calloused hands over the fabric of his shirt, searching and prodding and repairing the pulled and tight muscles. He's unaware of how loud his pleased groans and moans are, or how he occasionally, breathily whispers Katsuki's name into the open.

"Fuck," mutters Katsuki, an audible swallow heard behind Izuku, "Your back is so tight. Jesus." He grumbles something else, barely heard and noticeable. "You've got some pretty gnarly knots in there. Going deeper."

Izuku's hands fumble in his lap, his mind drifting between pleased, daydreaming slumber and passing out completely.

Katsuki's attentive, strong and healing touch warms his muscles, making him smile to himself in thanks that he's been given this opportunity and this sacred moment between the two of them.

Then, Katsuki's hands recede.

Izuku blinks awake, sighing contentedly as he leans back in his chair. He smiles up towards Katsuki, a blissful, thankful wisp of breath leaving his lips.

Katsuki focuses on him, thoughtful and lost in his own world, as Izuku reaches one hand up and tenderly traces his hand under Katsuki's strong, smooth jaw.

"Thank you, Kacchan," he says.

Katsuki, rather than scoff or smack his hand away, as Izuku partially expects, does something that shocks the green-eyed boy enough to pull him out of his stupor.

Katsuki turns his head, his eyes never leaving Izuku's, and brushes—*nuzzles*—further into Izuku's touch. His glare is hard as glass, challenging and, somehow, soft. Welcoming.

Izuku draws his hand back.

His heart skips.

Katsuki pulls his chair behind Izuku's, sits down, and firmly hooks his chin over the other's shoulder. He rests his face there, scowling towards the screen. Silent.

Izuku shifts at the motion, and tries to ignore the steady thumping of his own heart against his ribcage.

Katsuki's arms reach over the armrests of the chair—the structure itself far thinner and ganglier than the bulk Katsuki is sitting on. His right hand finds Izuku's sleeve, tracing experimentally, slowly, as if unsure of whether he has the right to do so. Izuku holds his breath, unsure of the silence, or the reasoning behind Katsuki's focus on his computer screen or his close proximity.

He feels guarded. Shielded. Protected.

Oh.

He bites his lip to prevent a gentle smile from overtaking his lips.

He wants to ask him why he feels the need to be this way, to be this much of a monitor. And then, he considers the repercussions to doing so, that poking the wolf will cause angry growls and a possible moment of the aggressive teenager leaving his side and storming out the door.

He doesn't want that.

“The sooner you finish, the sooner we can bail,” Katsuki whispers. “Don’t be lazy. I can tell you’re already almost done.”

Izuku blushes.

“R-Right! I mean, yeah. Of course.”

Katsuki smirks, his profile far too distracting beside Izuku’s face.

“Weren’t you the one just lecturing me about this, though? Pulling all-nighters for articles?” Izuku chuckles. “You’re sending me mixed messages, Kacchan.”

Katsuki huffs at this, a ghost of a chuckle.

“You still owe me, Deku.”

Izuku has barely typed one extra word in his document before he squeaks at both of Katsuki’s hands suggestively trailing up his arms.

Katsuki's smirk is arrogant and crooked, pressing teasingly into his neck.

Uh. Okay. This is. Mm-hm. Yep. The exact, complete, irrevocable opposite. Of. Ah. Of making me productive.

Izuku's hand trembles on the spacebar, his thoughts running directly into a wall as the blond’s lips coast over his neck, teeth brushing. Nipping at his flushed skin.

“K-Kacchan, what are you…?”

He freezes, heat pooling in his groin as Katsuki’s right hand drops from his arm, slides over his wrist, his palms, his fingers, until finally resting on his inner thigh.

Izuku licks his lips, trembling.

“Um. I can’t. Focus. At all? You know, this is a little counterproductive. I don’t, know what’s happening—”

Katsuki’s hand—*so strong, laced over with scars, with the crossroads of his past and present, riddled with callouses and hot to the touch*—traces up Izuku’s thigh and brushes over his crotch.

Izuku’s eyes blow wide. He doesn’t need to turn to see Katsuki’s expression, wondering if the other teen is even slightly ashamed of doing this.

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki’s lips press to his throat.

“This okay?” He growls, husky and dangerous, trailing his mouth up Izuku’s neck and *sucking*.

Izuku’s entire body *melts*.

“Y-Yeah, but, Kacchan, the article—”

“Take another break.”

“But, I need to—”

“Finish it tomorrow.”

“But, you wanted me to finish it—”

“Mm." Katsuki's breath leaves goosebumps on bare skin, those lips kissing up Izuku's neck until teeth nibble on his earlobe. "Will take too long.”

Izuku’s heart nearly explodes out of his chest.

He hesitates, wondering if this is even acceptable, to be taking these gestures from Katsuki while on school property and feeling the other teen touch him like this with hardly any shame.

“*Deku*,” Katsuki hisses, and his hand brushes dangerously close to Izuku's crotch. “You just gonna sit there, nerd?” He nips his ear, chuckling and dark and *possessive*. “Gonna sit there for me, be *good* for me—”

Izuku spins in his chair, and quickly grabs Katsuki’s collar. He doesn’t think, doesn’t even question Katsuki’s smug face as he crashes their mouths together in a violent, wet, and *terrible* kiss.

Katsuki stands up from his chair and pulls him flush to his chest. He angles Izuku's mouth, tongue sliding over his in a sensual tango.

Katsuki pushes Izuku against the desk.

"Ah, Kacchan," grunts Izuku.

Katsuki's growl is hot and feverish. Izuku reciprocates, instinct causing his legs to wrap around the other's waist and keep him there, their groins slotting together in near perfect synchrony.

He moans as Katsuki snarls and buries his face into Izuku’s shoulder, crushing Izuku even closer to him.

"Kacchan, you can, um." He tilts his head back, hands shaking and unbuttoning the top few slots in his shirt. Katsuki noses around his mouth, teeth trailing from his jaw to his collarbone. "*Y-yeah, right there*."

Katsuki huffs out a laugh, licking his lips.

He growls, and sucks another bruise into Izuku's clavicle, his hips *rolling* onto his.

Electric heat zips through his bones and quivers his entire body from head to toe.

It takes only seconds. A heartbeat or two, until Izuku is drawn fully into Katsuki's warmth, his powerful grip around his body, the relentless crushing of his hips onto his and the way his own fingernails ferociously bury into Katsuki's bare back beneath his hoodie.

He draws in the musk of earth and sweet moss from Katsuki's frame, the bruises and splotches of dust hardly forming a barrier between the incredible security and pleasure racing through Izuku's body.

"*K-Katsuki*," he says, and almost instantly regrets it when Katsuki freezes. Then, the blond lifts his head, his smirk positively dangerous in its lacy curve and the baring of his canines.

"*Fuck*, yes," he growls. "Again," he breathes, pupils blacking out the wine reds of his irises. "*Deku*," he adds, his right hand gripping the collar of Izuku's button-up and daringly flicking off several more buttons.

It's an order.

Izuku holds his breath, and plays with the drawstrings of Katsuki's hoodie, his legs trembling from around Katsuki's sturdy, taller frame.

He pulls him closer.

He shakes with want, with *need*, and the insatiable hunger stirring in his chest calls for more and more of Katsuki Bakugou.

"Make me," he says.

Katsuki's eyes *flash*.

And then Katsuki ruts against him, their clothes tight, thick, a far too rumpled barrier between them, though Izuku feels and accepts each movement and responds with what he can give.

The pressure is unbearable, the heat throttling his insides and curving his mind towards pleasure.

His nails dig into Katsuki's back, the other teen's name leaving him in perfectly timed gasps with each aggressive roll of Katsuki's languid, flexible hips.

Then, Izuku's mind shocks to the forefront as Katsuki's fingers reach down for his jeans—

"W-Wait, ah—oh, um—Kacchan, *wait*."

Katsuki slows to a stop, blinking towards Izuku with an impatient furrow in his brow.

Izuku maintains his balance on the desk with his elbows, exhaustion creeping into his body. Tenderly, he lowers his right hand onto Katsuki's mindless fingers.

Katsuki tenses and draws back, his jaw set.

“I—fuck.” He pulls back, hesitant. “I didn’t—I—”

“It’s okay.” Izuku quickly pecks Katsuki’s nose. “Just, not here. I don’t know if… either of us are ready for that, yet.”

A part of him definitely wants to take that leap, but the thought of entering those waters so soon terrifies him.

Katsuki’s skin is red as a rose, his tongue swiping over his lips. He eyes Izuku carefully, and slowly drifts away from the desk. His mouth quirks into a smirk, and he ruffles Izuku’s sweaty curls.

“Even if we didn’t do *that*,” he says, “I fucking wrecked you, nerd.”

Izuku blushes and swats his hand away. “Whatever, Kacchan.” He grins bashfully. “It’s because of you, though, that I won’t be able to finish this article tonight.”

Katsuki snorts, grabbing Izuku’s cheek and pulling it.

“Whatever, shitty Deku. Not like I care. Worth it.”

Izuku keeps his head low to prevent his fiery blush from drawing a few more teasing words from Katsuki.

Yeah.

He bites the inside of his cheek to prevent a giddy smile.

Worth it.

The night air is crisp and cool, a trail of misting winter through the shadowed streets of Augustana.

Katsuki is glued to Izuku’s side, the taller of the two having placed extra layers over his frame and assisting Izuku in gathering the appropriate supplies to edit his paper at the Bakugou household.

They walk towards the train station in silence.

Izuku's heart still steadily beats in distorted rhythm in his chest, his thoughts meandering and wandering back towards the explosive pleasure he'd experienced only minutes prior, relishing the opportunity to have Katsuki leaning over him, grunting, *grinding* onto him, marking him with bruises, kissing his hot skin—

I have issues.

He rolls his eyes, muttering.

He hadn't expected the night to turn out like this at all.

He knew he wasn't going to finish his article in one fell swoop, not after his lengthy interview with Katsuki and his unwillingness to go back through and edit in the same few hours. He was determined to complete the article in the next few days and send it off to various publishers who would accept more opinion-based articles and so forth. He knows that it will turn out polished and stable enough for all of Augustana to see in due time, and to have Katsuki's permission in doing so warms him.

He bites his bottom lip, slowly glancing over to his companion.

Katsuki's profile is swathed in starlight, his stature rather calm and composed for once, despite the focused glimmer in his eyes that are surely directed towards threats who could pop out of the dark.

Izuku's hands tighten around the boxes of supplies in his arms.

He steadies his shaking breath, wondering, in the deepest core of his heart, if his impending doubts and theories on his more-than-physical attraction to Katsuki could be lengthening.

He wants to know so much more about Katsuki Bakugou, far past the image of the person who'd strolled arrogantly onto the train on the first night they met.

Just two hours before the tolling hours were over—before the impending arrival of midnight, Izuku had crossed into the path of the most volatile and dangerous person he'd ever encountered at the time.

And, tonight, he had been willing to sacrifice several defenses for the other teen to show him a level of intimacy that neither of them had experienced yet.

Maybe…

He hesitates, swallowing.

Katsuki stops in his tracks, noticing that Izuku has fallen a few steps behind him.

"The hell is up with you, Deku?" He mutters, not unkindly.

Nerves attack Izuku's senses. His heart rams deafeningly in his ears.

“I—Kacchan, um.” He closes his eyes, and braces himself. “I think—um, so, I’ve been thinking.” He hesitates, absolutely furious at the clearly growing blush racing up his neck. “I just, think, that maybe, there’s something I have to tell you, and, maybe… maybe what Uraraka said, didn’t really bother me?”

Katsuki blinks owlishly. “Okay?"

Izuku's entire body vibrates with nerves. With the fears of what could go wrong, of what could attack him if he is making the worst possible choice.

Breathe. Breathe. It's just Kacchan.

"I'm saying..." Izuku's grip tightens around the box in his hands. "I think I'm feeling things. New things? I don't know how to describe them, but something really is there, and it's growing the more I see you and spend time with you. It's, um... it's not exactly a feeling I understand yet. But, I think I owe it to you to be honest, since, you're being more honest with me, and..."

The more he rambles, the more Katsuki's blank expression morphs into one of understanding.

His eyebrows raise to his hairline.

"Wait, Deku—”

“Kacchan, I—,” Izuku hesitates.

“Deku, you’re going to have another panic attack—”

“I *like you*, Kacchan!”

Izuku stops, trembling from head to toe, and finally lifts his gaze to lock onto Katsuki’s.

The weight of the world feels balanced on his shoulders, his courage quickly building and evaporating at the same time as he draws in Katsuki’s wide gaze.

His hope plummets.

Katsuki remains frozen, his eyes as wide as saucers.

Izuku’s hands shake around the box.

“Kacchan…?”

Chapter End Notes

HAHAHAHA.

I know. I am evil.

Also, easily, my favorite chapter so far. :D Despite its flaws.

What'd you think? I would love to hear your thoughts! (Including angry screams, I'm sure. It fuels me. Muahahaha.)

But yeah this chapter was difficult to write so feedback would be appreciated! What did you like? What DIDN'T you like? I would love to know! Thank you so much for reading as usual and I hope you enjoyed this chapter!

Sockdolager

Chapter Summary

He recalls the dreaded weight slamming into his body from multiple angles, the taste of blood on his tongue and gums as he'd watched Izuku being forced into vicious torture against his will—

Not again.

Katsuki's fists clench.

Not on my fucking watch.

Chapter Notes

Ah, I'm so sorry for the late update to this chapter, and all my fics in general. This will be the last update to any fic for a few weeks. I knew I couldn't leave you guys hanging on that cliffhanger, so I thought I should resolve it before I continue with this insanely busy month ahead of me.

You see, wonderful people, I'm participating in NaNoWriMo this year. Nothing flashy, or really that public of an announcement, but my goal is 100,000 - 120,000 words, which I know I can do since I pulled off a crazy 50,000 words in six days at one point in college... running on fumes and desperation.

But this means my fanfics will have to be put on hold. I wrote 5,000 words for my story today, and then wrote this chapter in one sitting to hopefully please you guys... again I'm so sorry for the wait.

Thank you so much, to each and every one of you, for being so incredibly amazing and wonderful and dedicated with this huge story. I could not be more grateful. Every comment brightens my entire week. Really. It means the world and so much more. I'm sorry that this update a little shorter, but hopefully... HOPEFULLY, it's okay.

Thank you so much, and I hope you enjoy!

Wednesday. 3:04 PM.

“Christ, Deku, I’m not planning your fucking murder, stupid nerd,” drawls Katsuki.

Izuku’s voice breaks into spluttering nonsense over the phone—a spur of static in his ears.

He pinches and rubs his thumb and index finger together, scanning the vicinity of the train cart with little acknowledgement towards the incoming and departing silhouettes of strangers.

“Alright, well, I’m about to head into the office to get things situated for the next paper issue. Uraraka and I haven’t met about this in person since before the… incident.”

Katsuki hums noncommittally, picking at his cuticles with his teeth. He looks up and around him on the train, over the dim greenish lights and old leather cushions.

“So, you’ll be coming though?”

Obviously, Katsuki thinks.

He catches the glare of an older woman, her gaze steady and dark; he sneers and turns back to the windows showing the passing profile of each district. Sommartyn quickly melds into a brief glimpse of Illenova and Redmond as they pass, the buildings bearing just the slightest difference in stature

Izuku’s request for him to leave his studies and do a favor like this for the other boy should have riled him up with anger. But, instead, he finds that he would rather see what rewards he could receive from an act like this, and what would become of the potential article that Izuku has been talking about nonstop since the day they somewhat decided to put aside their differences.

The train screeches to a halt. He squints up at the familiar numbers and letters spelling the district name above the handlebars.

Katsuki snorts.

A delay? Are you shitting me?

He rolls his eyes and slumps back against his seat, absentmindedly toying with the strings of his old, faded orange hoodie. He balances the phone between his cheek and shoulder, listening to Izuku mumbling incoherently on the other end of the line while the current influx of people departs from the train.

He opens his mouth to reply to Izuku, then stops.

His jaw clenches tight, hand bunching around his knee and grasping at the fabric of his jeans.

The two familiar members of the Isabori squadron make themselves comfortable on the opposite side of the cart, draped over in leather jackets and boasting their green-numbered watches.

Katsuki's hand grips the phone even tighter—his third one in less than two weeks—a snarl bubbling up in the back of his throat as he takes in the two men.

One of the squadron members glances up, and locks onto him with a cruel lilt to his smirk.

Katsuki returns the glare tenfold, lifting his chin a little higher.

"Whatever, nerd," he says with a slight pause, watching the other two men fixate on him quietly. "I'll be there."

He hangs up, resting his hands between his parted knees.

His back is rigid with tension.

He won't be arriving at the high school for another twenty minutes or so with this delay, and while the profiles of these two intrusive individuals are hidden behind cloth mocks, he knows he's seen them before.

"No puppy with you today, Bakugou?"

An alarm signal rips like lightning through Katsuki.

He inhales, and turns to glare harshly at the air vents on the other side of the cart. His fingers burrow into his palms, sweat slicking and threatening to crackle into sparks.

He can't activate his Quirk on the train, but he knows that these fools would be smart not to provoke him in a public area with few options for escape.

"Fuck off," he says.

"Oh, touchy." One squadron member laughs under his breath and gestures to the train's closed, sliding doors. "You seem a bit eager to get somewhere. What's a Bakugou even doing around this late at night, heading to Illenova of all places? Don't you live in Sommartyn?"

"None of your business." He clicks his tongue. "You should all be in hot water, anyway. With that shit you tried to pull with that freakish hand-faced bastard." He scowls and lifts himself from his seat. He palms around the iron support beams, and glares frigidly towards the other two men. For a brief moment, he wonders if he's met them before. "So why are you pestering me tonight? I'm too fucking tired to deal with this bullshit."

The two squadron members exchange a look, before turning back to Katsuki.

"What the rest of the squadron does isn't always linked to the rest of us. Besides," the first man adds with a shrug, "Shigaraki Tomura doesn't really relay all of that info with us. Even with those from Isabori. But, the shit that Zeke mentioned… you're lucky that he's alright with just a minor wound in the knee."

Katsuki snickers, remembering the sight of Izuku setting off a well-timed bullet at the motherfucker's knees with a satisfied chuckle.

He wishes he could replay the event for these other two to see, and make it even clearer that despite his Quirkless nature, the curly-topped teen was not a person they would want to mess with.

“Oh, I’ve seen that kid before. The one with the big green eyes,” the second squadron member says, smirking behind his cloth. “He’s cute, if you’re into that. You fucking him, Bakugou? Is that why he’s such a loyal dog, trailing after you wherever you go?”

Katsuki snarls. His grip tightens around the support beam.

“If you have one *lick* of a brain in that puny skull of yours, you’ll can it.” He watches as the doors to the train slide open, revealing the cold, brisk evening that trailed after the high school where he was meant to meet Izuku. “As much as I’d love to stay and chat with a couple braindead morons,” Katsuki chides, “I have somewhere to be.”

He steps just barely outside the threshold, when the first squadron member reaches out and snatches his elbow.

Katsuki blinks, and side-eyes the bastard with a twisted scowl marring his lips. He’s not prepared for the moment where the stranger leans in, his smirk detectable even past the cloth and the strange glimpse of bandages wrapped around his cheeks.

His voice is low, coupled with an air of taunting aggression, as it ghosts over Katsuki’s earlobe.

“Tell Freckles I said hi,” he says, before shoving him out of the door and cackling at the sight of him stumbling over his own shoes.

Rage bubbles up in Katsuki’s chest.

He turns, and roars, slamming his flaming fists into the iron grating beneath the moving train.

He clenches his fists, frustrated at the missed opportunity, and the familiarity of that patrolman's voice setting like poison in his ears. He huffs and rakes his hands through his hair, the faint smell of smoke and decaying rubber breaking his concentration.

Motherfucker!

He rams his foot into a trash can by the stairwell, grimacing at the shock of pain that ripples through his muscles and bones. He resists setting off explosions in his midst, glaring with a heaving chest at the train that refuses to circle around and present those despicable people as his most preferred dummies for target practice.

“Twisted fuckers,” he growls. A woman turning the corner of the sidewalk stares at him, and he barks. “Mind your own business!”

She squeaks and dashes off, her heels clicking on the cement.

Katsuki exhales, his breath puffing into a cloud in the freezing air.

He sets his jaw tightly and starts to walk, rolling his neck and allowing the bones to crack to relieve the tension in his body. The anger still resides under his skin like flickering embers, threatening to bloom into something dangerous and stormy if he allowed it.

It's fine, he tells himself, breathing through his nose, *it's all fine.*

... What?

Katsuki stares, unblinking, towards Izuku Midoriya, who returns the look tenfold with a gaze so glassy and green that it sends Katsuki's heart into overdrive.

Sparks snap in his palms, dancing on the edge of blissful combustion, while he finds himself unable to glance away from how attractive Izuku looks beneath the glare of the streetlights and the fading wash of the stars.

Izuku's rumpled clothes and wind-tossed curls are dark and heavy in the wind. Freckles dark and red with blush. His confused, slack jaw showing more than just a glint of teeth Katsuki had stroked with his own tongue less than twenty minutes prior. Lips red and swollen from his bites, his kisses—from the relentless eagerness Katsuki had felt shrivel up his insides while he pinned Izuku down in the privacy of the newspaper workroom.

Katsuki's tongue dries up.

I like you, Kacchan!

Was that possible?

His entire body erupts into flames.

He shakes his head, raking his hand through his blond tufts and hissing under his breath.

He can hear Izuku babbling nonsensically into the air, anger and frustration lacing his every word.

He's caught between reassuring Izuku and reacting to the first reckless statement with feelings he can hardly pinpoint in his own mind.

"You—," he breaks into a laugh, staring at Izuku as if he's grown another head. "You're shitting me. No, you're… you're fucking with me, right? There's no way. You *can't.*"

His heart stutters in the confines of his ribcage. It races faster and faster, pounding in his ears.

He wishes he could rewind time, and go back to the intimate moment where he could wrap himself around Izuku and promise him safety, promise him protection with the warmth and caging of his body. He wants to return to those moments, where Izuku thanked him wordlessly and never allowed such a frightening declaration to break into the open.

“Wha—*what*?”

Izuku inhales, and drops the box of supplies in his hand. His hands ball into fists at his sides, his neck straining and chin wobbling with barely constrained emotion.

“How could you—how *dare you*, Kacchan?!” He slaps one hand over his chest, his voice rising higher and higher at Katsuki’s dumbfounded, unreadable expression. “How could you think that I would say something like that and not mean it? What kind of a person do you think I am?”

Katsuki shakes his head. He’s caught between laughing in disbelief and screaming.

“This, whatever this is,” he starts, bitter and cold, “none of this is *labeled*. What part of this made it seem that way? We’re already roped in all this shit together and making it harder than hell for ourselves, Deku! You think I wanted to get this deep? To get involved in all of this so fast?”

Izuku’s glare hardens into ice. “No, you don’t get to just… throw all of this away—”

“Isn’t that what *you’re* doing?” Katsuki snaps back.

His patience burns and shrivels to hardly anything at all, leaving behind pinpricks of flames under his skin.

He stomps closer to Izuku, and barely restrains from shoving the other boy back a few paces to instill some level of control in this situation.

“You think I wanted to put us both in danger? You think I took this risk in fucking around and staying connected in my own damn house without wondering if this would happen? You *can’t* fucking like me, shitface!”

Izuku rolls his eyes, flinging his hands in the air. “Oh, just great, it’s bad that I probably *like you* because it’s not what *you* wanted! Is that it?”

He furiously wipes at his nose.

Katsuki’s eyebrows raise to his hairline, just now detecting the fresh sheen of tears glossing over Izuku's eyes. He panics, and steps backward, even as Izuku’s stare regards him with nothing but hurt and anger.

“*You* kissed *me*, Kacchan,” says Izuku, carding one hand through his curls. “You *started* this whole thing. The fact that you obviously don’t return my feelings hurts enough, but for you to think that I was expecting something different at all without even asking me…” he trails off, expectant. Lost. “That’s worse. Much worse.”

Katsuki wants to swallow a bomb.

“You don’t have feelings for me.” He glowers. “Don’t kid yourself.”

“*Wow*, asshole, I don’t remember giving you the permission, or the *ability*, to read my mind,” deadpans Izuku. He rolls his eyes. “I can’t believe this. I was practically having a heart attack before telling you anything and *this* is how you take it…”

"Well how the fuck was I supposed to react?"

"Not like this!" Izuku shakes his head wildly. "Not like..." He bites his lip, shoulders trembling like a leaf. "Not like you're disgusted by it, like it didn't even cross your mind. That doesn't even make any sense..." He snaps his head back to Katsuki, puffing up his chest. "If you didn't want anything like this, you shouldn't have kissed me."

Anger rolls off of him and attacks Katsuki before he even finds another chance to speak, to somehow retaliate and regain a foothold in this.

"I didn't," Katsuki pauses. For once, the words he wants to say become jumbled. Broken. "You can't assume how I feel, or think I'm going to take this a certain way, you fucking idiot!"

“Serioiusly, Kacchan? You think that's all this is about?” Izuku sighs, exasperated. “You know what? *Fuck you*.”

He leans down, grabs the box, and hoists it up to his chest. He bypasses a dumbstruck Katsuki Bakugou, refusing to even glance over his shoulder and see if the other is following him.

“I’m heading back, with or without you. The least you could do is respect how I feel instead of acting like I asked you to marry me or something.”

Katsuki blinks and rushes after him, snatching the sleeve of Izuku’s blazer. The other boy loses his balance and drops the box. Newspaper documents and folders spill out onto the curb.

“Hey!” Izuku drags one hand down his face. “What are you—”

“You think you can get away with that?” Katsuki hisses, tugging Izuku closer to him despite the other teen’s protests.

Izuku rips himself out of the other’s grip, but doesn’t move to grab the box or leave a second time.

Katsuki shoves his hands into his pockets, an unfamiliar, tingling heat crawling up his neck.

“I can see that you’re… crying and shit. Despite what I may feel, or how you feel, apparently, I don’t want to be the cause of that.”

He swallows and quickly looks away from Izuku’s frown, those soft lips twisted in suspicion.

“Just, ugh, hold on for a few fucking moments. You didn’t even give me a few seconds to process before you went crazy! Do you know how fucking dangerous this place is at night?”

Anyone could show up.

Anyone could track down Izuku Midoriya simply because he was constantly linked to Katsuki’s side. Anyone could turn up on his doorstep, or even in front of his school, with the evidence backing up his claims being linked to him as a person who was on friendly terms with the Bakugous. Anyone could take Izuku out of the temporary comfort zone where he and his mother were carefully placed, all because of the risks Katsuki had already instigated in kissing Izuku after their escape.

It makes Katsuki wonder just how many people working for Shigaraki Tomura now knew exactly who Izuku was, and how dangerous it would be to have him stick to his side each and every day if they were not afraid to place them both in public danger.

He recalls the dreaded weight slamming into his body from multiple angles, the taste of blood on his tongue and gums as he’d watched Izuku being forced into vicious torture against his will—

Not again.

Katsuki’s fists clench.

Not on my fucking watch.

Izuku brushes down his blazer, his cheeks tinted pink from his building anger and a wave of exhaustion.

The wind is calm and tender, brushing over their shoulders and combing through their hair.

Katsuki feels the awkwardness of their current situation more than the weather’s tingle, even as the biting cold skates over the enraged bind of his fingers.

“Okay.” Izuku dips his head, defeated. He waves blankly at the air. “I… overreacted. You’re right.” He grumbles. “But I meant what I said.”

He searches Katsuki’s expression, tilting his head to the side. His eyelashes flutter in the breeze, a tender, unsure frown lacing his lips.

“You know that I trust you, right?”

“Obviously,” says Katsuki, though his hesitant glare says otherwise. He rubs the back of his neck, glaring into the line of bushes framing the buildings in the dark.

“We wouldn’t have made it this far if I didn’t, or… or if you didn’t,” says Izuku. He chuckles slightly, barely carrying the weight of sunny cheerfulness that Katsuki had begrudgingly become used to. “Is it really that impossible for you to believe that I like you? That I might have a crush on you? After all this, in such a short span of time?” Izuku crosses his arms. “I didn’t think you would say yes, Kacchan, but—I mean, do you really feel nothing at all? I

don’t really understand what you want from me, or this, or whatever this is, if that idea repulses you so much. If we have to stop doing… things, then, I’ll—,” he hesitates, “I’ll understand. If that’s what you want—”

Katsuki grabs his shoulders and shakes him.

“No, fuck, that’s—,” he hesitates, releasing Izuku quickly as if the brief contact burned him. Izuku blinks innocently. “No, Deku. That’s not what I want. I mean…” he groans, pulling at his hair. “Why are you so… why are *you* the difficult, stupid one? Almost everything about you pisses me the fuck off, and it’s been that way since you gave me a concussion on the goddamn night we first met!” He purses his lips, jabbing a finger into Izuku’s chest. “You’re stupid, you hear me, shitty nerd? With your—shit, the dumbass, bright smiles and, whatever. It’s like… you’re like a fairy.”

Izuku’s irritated expression quickly morphs into one of confusion, and then, upright amusement.

“... What did you just call—”

“No, wait, shit, that's not what I meant!” Katsuki splutters. “Fuck you! I can tell you’re laughing! Stop!”

He steps backward, his sweat already transforming into tentative sparks in his hands.

He could easily singe Izuku’s hair or clothes and stop his mocking giggles, but the thought of physically harming him in any way causes his stomach to twist into knots.

“You radiate like the fucking sun. It’s distracting, and annoying as hell. Also you don’t know how to take care of yourself. You want to be a full-time journalist and make a difference about heroes? Well, newsflash, shitty nerd, you’ll die of malnourishment and dehydration before you even get the chance to get into fucking college with how you operate!”

He scratches his cheek.

The words, the emotional buildup, tumbles out of his lips in a torrential storm, thrashing into the open like the cracking of a whip.

He’s not entirely sure of what he’s saying, with the impulsive way his statements skitter into the open air like insects.

He hopes that Izuku can’t see the flickering blush coloring his cheeks, or hear the embarrassing squeaks that separate one statement from another.

I can’t believe this.

“And don’t even get me fucking started on your All-Might obsession. It’s weird as hell. I don’t know how you can memorize every single episode of his damn television show like some walking Wikipedia article. Shit’s practically supernatural.”

He shudders, refusing to glance Izuku's way in expectant fear of what the other teen could be thinking. He already knows these are dangerous waters he's treading, especially in the wake of Izuku's rather blatant and open-ended confession.

Then, he flinches at the tender, familiar feel of Izuku's thumb running under his jaw.

He slowly turns his head, and glances over the amused, yet touched, flicker of emotions washing over Izuku's features.

His lips curve into an elated smile, so soft and tender even beneath the waning starlight.

Crickets whistle in the shadows, louder than even the roaring of Katsuki's blood in his ears and the angry, reckless beating of his heart.

"I hate your freckles, too," says Katsuki, low and distracted. "Like… sparkles and shit, all over your face. It's weird. And too many of them. Can't really count them all in one sitting."

His gaze flies from one telling dot on Izuku's face to another, and holds back a pleased smirk at the snort that erupts from Izuku's chest.

The other teen rubs at his eyes, raising a bemused eyebrow at Katsuki. For a reason he can't explain,

Katsuki wishes that Izuku's hand remained under his jaw for just a little longer, at least enough for him to press his lips to a knuckle. A silent apology that he knows he can give. Maybe.

"So, you don't *like* me," says Izuku, his smile fond and sensitive. The healthy blush blossoming on his cheeks causes Katsuki's chest to flare. "But, you count my freckles?" He grins teasingly and places his hands in his pockets, rocking back and forth on his heels. "And you like kissing me, and apparently giving me massages, and comparing me to the sun—"

"Okay, okay! Jesus Christ." Katsuki groans and rubs his temples. "Quit saying that shit. It's embarrassing as hell."

"It's just the two of us, Kacchan," says Izuku, shrugging.

But his smile won't falter. It lingers, like a remnant of a dream, and Katsuki loathes how much it draws his attention, how much it makes him want to crumble to his knees and kiss Izuku senseless.

When did he turn into such a godforsaken sap?

"Anything we say here, doesn't have to be repeated to anyone else. If it's privacy you want, I can give you that. I won't make you do anything you don't want to do. It's why I'll understand if you don't like me back."

Izuku looks down at the calloused finger pressed to his lips. He looks up questioningly at Katsuki, who assesses him with a glare that has already softened with a weight of something

new. His scowl morphs into the smallest, fondest smile, barely curving the corners of his mouth.

“This is new for me.” Katsuki snorts. “So let me talk. You always babble too much anyway.”

Izuku frowns, yet nods nonetheless.

“Fuck. Okay.” Katsuki inhales, and groans with the strained, exhaustive release. “You’re kind of… my first friend. At least, since I was a kid. I don’t exactly get to meet anyone outside of being homeschooled and learning how to be a Bakugou. I knew some Russian punks back in kindergarten and whatever, but that never mattered.”

He locks onto Izuku.

“That shit with that hand-faced fucker… even that’s new to what I’m used to dealing with. The fact that he knows your dad, and that he might come after *you* again, doesn’t sit well with me.” He scoffs at his own wording, mumbling under his breath. “I saw Nero on the train even coming here, with another Isabori squadron member.” Izuku tenses, but says nothing to this. Katsuki growls. “I didn’t know it was him until I left the train.”

He rolls his jaw, a malicious, devious smirk spreading apart his mouth.

His palms burst with sparks, desperate to catch the flames of his rising anger, of his insatiable desire to enact revenge, and—to his flagrant understanding and acceptance—to protect Izuku Midoriya.

“He’s not getting away next time,” he mutters darkly. “Don’t know how he got fucking healed that quickly, or what he and the others are planning, but there’s no way he didn’t know I was on that train. They’re tracking us, Deku, with each and every move we make. The fact that they know that we fool around, and all that shit, is just ammunition for them.”

Izuku frowns, already bouncing with energy. “I can handle myself, Kacchan. Don't you think that we've already come pretty far with that—”

“*Don’t.*” Katsuki holds up a hand warningly, his brow furrowed. “I’m not done yet, Deku. This shit is important.” He waits until Izuku accepts this with a stubborn pout. “You’re not fucking weak. I get it. We just need a few more months training you, and getting you used to combat moves that even those fuckers won’t know about, before we can even get further into this. Understand?”

“You’re still going to train me?” Izuku brightens. “When can we start? I know that we kind of took a pause back then, but we were starting to do some really interesting things—”

“*Deku*."

Izuku smiles sheepishly.

“Point is,” Katsuki continues, “they can target you and track you just as easily as me. You’re involved, now, and there’s only so much that my parents and I—hell, even what Half N’ Half

is offering… none of that will be enough. Pro heroes are in hiding, Deku; they can't just come out and save you. And, you're Quirkless."

Izuku winces.

"You'll get stronger and faster." Katsuki nods. "So don't worry about that. You work hard, and I'll teach." He studies Izuku carefully. "If they know where I am and what routes you take, what's stopping them from finding you again when I'm not there? From Nero tracking you down himself and—"

"Kacchan."

Katsuki blinks, and looks down at Izuku tenderly taking his hands and clasping them together. His touch is comforting and warm, even in the blistering cold that dances around them.

Katsuki flushes at the proximity, and even more so when Izuku nods his head with a determined smile.

"Whatever happens, we'll figure it out. You just need to trust me, like I have with you."

Katsuki bites his tongue.

"You're an idiot," he drawls, though his smirk remains as he ruffles Izuku's curls. "You going to be a drama queen again and run off, or let me walk you to the train?"

Izuku bats his hand away. Despite this, he's grinning.

"I doubt I would've made it far," says Izuku. Then, hesitantly, he reaches over, and intertwines his fingers with Katsuki's. The blond watches the motion carefully, and squeezes his hand in return, tugging Izuku closer to his side as the blushing, green-eyed boy gathers the box into his free arm.

They walk in silence, shoulders bumping and sleeves brushing under the cold.

This is different, Katsuki thinks, keeping his jaw tightly set even as he flicks one eye over to Izuku on occasion.

The boy's hand is sweating in his grasp, and the occasional mutter that escapes Izuku's lips is impossible not to notice as they walk side by side to the train ready to depart from their current district.

They return to Sommartyn with ease.

Sleep weighs down Katsuki's eyelids, his grunts of exhaustion only matched with Izuku's mumbling complaints as he gathers the newspaper supplies and levels them on the living room table.

The kitchen is dark and wafting tenderly with the leftover scents of evening cooking.

Izuku smiles at the food sitting untouched on the granite counter. Two simple sandwiches are wrapped in white paper packaging, toothpicks stuck in the middle and joined with two separate cups of pickles and jalapeño peppers. He giggles at the kind gesture from their parents, and gestures over for Katsuki to glance his way.

Katsuki has his back turned to him, rifling through the shelves in the opened refrigerator with a determined scowl on his features. He glares harshly into the plastic space, and sneers at the lack of available ingredients he was most likely going to use for some late-night dish or soup. Izuku hadn't been ignorant to the occasional quip from Katsuki when they passed the closed grocery store on the way to the train, verbally remarking that he needed to make curry sometime.

"Kacchan, there's food right here," he says, unwrapping one of the sandwiches and taking a firm bite out of his meal. He grins happily and bounces on his feet, even as the familiar twinge of mustard and tomato flourishes on his tongue. He sucks on his fingers, and turns to say something else to Katsuki, and stops.

Katsuki is watching him, pupils blown wide, blowing carefully through his nostrils as he eyes Izuku's hands.

Blinking questioningly, Izuku removes his index finger from his mouth with an audible *pop*.

A shudder reverberates through Katsuki.

"Kacchan? Are you okay?" Izuku asks.

His question seems to snap something into place for the other boy.

Katsuki flushes red instantly and slams the refrigerator closed, his shoulders and back going rigid.

"Peachy."

Huh.

Izuku shrugs.

"Okay, if you say so."

He takes several more bites of his sandwich before carefully wrapping it back up in the paper packaging. He smiles at Katsuki and politely makes his way over to the fridge, popping open

the door and setting his leftovers inside. He catches Katsuki's dazed, yet confused expression, if the furrow in his brow was anything to indicate such a conclusion.

Izuku shivers under Katsuki's unwavering stare.

"Um—I'm going to—shower. If that's okay."

Katsuki shuts the refrigerator door, and Izuku squeaks at the sudden action. He turns to Katsuki, frowning at the way the other male is leaning against the wall with his arms crossed, his head tilted to the side and eyes running up and down his body.

"Parents are asleep," he says.

Izuku shrugs. "Well, yeah. It's late."

Katsuki rolls his eyes. "Come to my room when you're done, Deku."

He leaves without a word, slow and relaxed in his movements even after he disappears around the corner of the kitchen.

Izuku's heart leaps. He rubs his hands together, wondering if the fresh bloom of sweat overtaking his skin was solely because of his tiredness, his annoyingly unhinged attraction to Katsuki Bakugou, or a tumultuous combination of both.

The thought lingers long in Izuku's mind after he steps out of the shower, running a towel through his curls and staring at his reflection. He frowns and rubs at the red and purple patches glowing on his freckled skin. Some of them are fresher, newer, from his own fingernails as well as Katsuki during their more... energetic moments together.

Maybe he does like me?

He sighs, rubbing his hands up and down his face.

He should be concerned with more important matters, like finishing his profile article for the paper and making more connections between Shigaraki and his father. He wants to fulfill his dream of becoming a journalist sooner than later, and with the tension looming in the horizon and Katsuki's doubts becoming all the more prevalent, there are far too many things that need to occur for him to find some method of peace once more.

He slips on a faded, gray All-Might T-shirt and a pair of dark black sweats. He fumbles with the drawstrings, groaning at the fact that one side is far longer than the other and will make it nearly impossible for him to adjust the length and width if he wants. For now, he will have to be fine with the way it nearly sags on his hips.

He bundles up the towel in his hands and cautiously opens the door, tip-toeing on the carpet as to not make any noise.

Then, his heart jolts in his chest as he spots Katsuki's open bedroom door.

Come to my room when you're done, Deku.

Izuku shudders.

Nerves tingle under his skin like a fresh dash of lightning. He wonders if Katsuki wants to talk, or if he wants to instigate… other things.

They've mostly only kissed, and recently rutted hips like dogs in heat in his very own school. The thought alone makes Izuku blush in shame, though he doubts that Katsuki will feel the same way.

On the train ride back, Katsuki was completely silent.

He never said another word after they held hands on their walk, and the memory alone makes an unsure, hesitant smile overtake Izuku's mouth. He wants to ask more prodding questions, to explore the possibilities of what Katsuki might actually feel for him.

He certainly seemed, in that one moment, that he cared more than the both of them believed to be true.

Cautiously, Izuku walks the length of the hallway, and steps into the dark, expectant space of Katsuki's bedroom.

He glances around him at the neat arrangement of books on the shelves, and the stack of textbooks ordered directly to their home for his homeschooling sessions nestled in the nooks and crannies. Superhero figurines remain polished and pristine on the topmost shelf, and Izuku's eyes glisten as he recognizes some of them from the cartoon that they both watched while growing up.

He squeaks as the door is closed behind him, and Katsuki is suddenly inches away from his body.

His powerful arms are barricading him against the door, hands on both sides of his face. Liquid heat stirs in Izuku's gut and travels dangerously low.

He swallows, daring to look up into the smoldering, unreadable expression lingering in Katsuki's eyes.

"Um—"

"You took too long," Katsuki says with a tiny smirk. "Still mad at me, Deku?"

Izuku frowns. "I should be," he deadpans.

Katsuki considers this. "Hm." He trails one hand down Izuku's jaw, the touch leaving sparks in its wake.

Izuku licks his lips, biting back a moan.

"B-But even if I was, still mad, I would probably use another method to annoy you. And most likely not be passive-aggressive about it." Katsuki only seems doubtful at this claim. "Hey,

give me some credit there. I didn’t leave you behind after you blatantly rejected my confession.” He shrugs. “I deserve more than a medal for that, you know.”

It’s a game he’s willing to play. The first move in a chess match.

The slow, wicked smirk that cuts across Katsuki’s face is, however, not what Izuku expects.

“Sure, sure,” Katsuki growls and pushes his knee between Izuku’s legs.

Izuku yelps. Katsuki breathes over his neck and gradually lowers his hands to rest on Izuku’s hips.

“You piss me off,” Katsuki starts, his voice rumbling with a deep growl—a purr, that shakes Izuku to the core. “Drives me *crazy*,” he adds, and without further warning, pulls him into a kiss.

Izuku shivers, gasping against his mouth. His body betrays him, begging for Katsuki to return as soon as he pushes him away.

“Kacchan, what are you—”

“Don’t do apologies,” says Katsuki, his lips brushing over Izuku's parted mouth. “Let me show you.”

His nose runs up Izuku's cheek, to his temple, and buries deep into his hair.

Izuku flushes, paralyzed under this intense influx of heat, of strange, euphoric newness.

Katsuki’s hand lifts from Izuku’s hip to travel underneath his shirt.

“This okay?” Katsuki asks, nibbling on Izuku’s earlobe.

Izuku’s brain is halfway melting at the mere feel of Katsuki’s teeth on his skin, but he nods regardless.

He trusts him, and he wants him to believe this.

Katsuki Bakugou is not Nero Edmure.

“I want to feel you, Kacchan,” says Izuku, breathless, “that’s part of why I—ah, um, why I know... know that I like you,” he stutters out.

He barely suppresses a moan as Katsuki bites and sucks, his probing hand reaching up his abdominals and coasting over his skin in experimental, needy motions.

Katsuki growls. “Stupid,” he mutters.

“No,” Izuku counters, "think you're the dumb one, here."

Katsuki captures his mouth in another kiss.

This one is different.

Izuku's not sure how, but it is, and it's everything he didn't know he needed.

Katsuki *attacks* Izuku's mouth with no restraint, his tongue and teeth clashing against his and seeking dominance immediately. Izuku wraps his arms around Katsuki's neck and pulls him down, and holds back a moan at the feel of Katsuki's smirking lips against his. He pushes forward, pressing their bodies flush together.

Katsuki growls, and suddenly, Izuku finds his back on Katsuki's bed.

Katsuki cages him against the blankets and pulls him into another embrace, this one even fiercer than the last. Izuku reciprocates with burning, energetic movements, sucking on Katsuki's tongue and exploring the confines of the other's hot, wet mouth.

Katsuki grinds his hips down onto him, their sweats forming little to no barriers between their mutually growing erections.

Izuku's arms and legs shake with vibrations. He pants, staring up into Katsuki's eyes.

The other boy swallows, gazing down at Izuku with something new. Something undeterred.

It's a look that's predatory, caring, protective. *Hungry*.

I really like you, Izuku wants to say.

He wants to taste the words on his tongue without Katsuki looking over to him in guilt in his inability to reciprocate the same feelings.

I really like you, Kacchan. It's okay that you don't.

Katsuki buries his face into Izuku's neck, breathing deeply.

Izuku takes this moment to grab the hem of the other teen's shirt, lifting it up to just barely glimpse the teasing flash of chiseled abdominals.

Katsuki smirks into Izuku's neck and nips him before he leans back and yanks his shirt over his head. Before Izuku can truly take him in, Katsuki dives back down, his powerful legs straddling Izuku beneath him.

Izuku's hands run over Katsuki's back, marking him. Diving deeply into his skin and carving lines into flawless, fair flesh. He grins victoriously at the shudders that quake Katsuki's body, even as Katsuki bites into his skin and bucks his hips onto him.

"Kacchan," whispers Izuku, biting his lip, "I want to try something. Do you—do you trust me?"

Katsuki huffs, yet says nothing as he gnaws on Izuku's neck.

Izuku hesitates, nerves fluttering, then reaches for the waistband of Katsuki's sweats.

Katsuki doesn't notice until Izuku's palm drifts over the noticeable bulge, fingers scraping around the cloth before slipping underneath and drifting over the thin fabric of his boxers.

Katsuki's entire body goes still.

He grunts and trembles with each teasing, experimental movement Izuku makes, his hand forming an angled caress over Katsuki's erection.

"Please, Katsuki," Izuku says, a faint smile dressing his lips. "Let me make you feel good."

Katsuki glares down at him, brow knitted in awe and a twisted form of pleasure.

His teeth are gritting, his lips twisted into a malformed frown.

His back arches with each stroke, with each tender press of Izuku's hand around his length.

He bucks into the touch, and snarls harshly into the open hair, his hands bunching up the fabric of his blankets and sheets.

"Fuck, Deku—*Izuku*—"

Izuku's eyes bolt wide at this. A gleeful smile blooms on his face, so vivid and bright that he knows Katsuki will be embarrassed to see it.

He doesn't care, though, as he daringly slides his hand over the waistband of Katsuki's boxers, using his other hand to lower the other's sweats down halfway to expose the dark red fabric.

He holds his breath—frightened, afraid, *anxious*—as he takes Katsuki's warm cock in his hand.

Katsuki's entire body stills and shakes, as if his balance will break with a mere touch or two. His throat strains, a gasp leaving his clenched teeth and curling lips as he swiftly moves into Izuku's touch.

Izuku goes slowly at first, looking up to read Katsuki's reactions as the blond growls, grunts, and pushes. His arms are quaking, beams of support sure to collapse if Izuku plays this correctly.

"Fuck, *fuck*," Katsuki all but *whimpers*, "Ah... damn, Izuku—"

Izuku's rendered completely breathless when his name leaves Katsuki for a second time.

He pumps faster, mesmerized, *enthralled* with each motion he makes, with each teasing rise and fall of the speed in which he worships Katsuki.

"Does that feel good, Kacchan?" Izuku asks, shy and embarrassed beyond belief despite the actions taking place. Katsuki snarls and opens his eyes wide, blinking abruptly with whatever collision of sensations he must be feeling. "I like you. I really mean it." He bites his lip. "I trust you. I want you—"

“Stop. Fucking. *Talking*.” Katsuki then grabs Izuku’s wrist, pulling it off of him. He's shaking, but the smirk he wears is dangerous.

Izuku is not prepared for this, not at all.

Katsuki crashes his mouth onto Izuku’s, licking up every squeak, every protest that could possibly interrupt them further.

He ravages Izuku’s mouth, biting and sucking on his lips, releasing annoyed grunts at the cloth holding him back from the rest of his body. He roughly, clumsily, takes the cotton shirt and yanks it up over Izuku’s head, ignoring the squawk of protest that flies from Izuku as a result.

He rests his chin right above Izuku’s navel, his smirk a dangerous curve of malice and lust on his handsome features. He licks his teeth, watching as Izuku swallows at the motion.

“K-Kacchan?”

“Think you can get away with that, Deku?”

Katsuki growls, purring over the sweats hanging off Izuku’s hips. His hands run up Izuku’s outer thighs, which are propped up and caging Katsuki’s head. His back arches up towards the ceiling as he moves, feline and mischievous.

Katsuki grasps the hem of Izuku’s sweatpants, and pulls them down over his thighs.

His eyes never leave Izuku’s, holding onto every whimper that escapes him, every impending thought—

Katsuki’s fingers grasp Izuku’s outer thighs, the touch on bare skin setting Izuku’s body alive with goosebumps. He jostles, breathless, as Katsuki pulls down his boxers with his teeth.

Oh my God.

“Eyes on me, Izuku,” says Katsuki. He licks his lips, purring. “You want this? Want me to take it?”

Izuku gulps. “K-Kacchan—”

Katsuki bites into his thigh.

Izuku squeaks. “Y-yes, you can. I trust you, K-Katsuki.”

“Good,” purrs Katsuki.

Then, he takes Izuku’s length into his mouth, pressing his face as close as possible to the most intimate areas of his body, and Izuku is *gone*.

Circumspect

Chapter Summary

It’s a snapshot of Izuku, alone on the train heading towards his high school.

He’s reading one of his notebooks, the item splayed open on his lap while he rubs his chin in thought. It’s at an angle where the person taking the photograph was less than ten feet away on ground level.

Chapter Notes

Thank you so much, everyone.

I'm dying. So fucking tired. Haha. Here's an update for you all. I hope you like it.

Peace

Izuku’s eyes snap open.

His entire body trembles, slick with a fresh layer of sweat. His heart is pounding, thumping underneath a cage of protective bone and flesh. A wave of relief crashes through him as he recognizes the white expanse of Katsuki’s bedroom ceiling. He bites his lip, slowly moving his hand over his mouth to suppress the startled sob rising in the back of his throat.

This dream was one of the worst.

It always ends similarly, with the door to a room he doesn’t recognize swinging open, a tall masculine shape looming in the doorway, his mother screaming in the background for Izuku to run, run, *run*—

His lungs constrict. His heart pounds faster. Blood roars in his ears.

He grips harder around his mouth, a strangled hiccup breaking between his lips and gritted teeth. Tears gather in the corner of his eyes. He breathes shakily, and hopes, with each tense fiber of his being, that he doesn’t disturb the person lying next to him.

Then, a toned arm lopes around his waist, slapping on the other side of the bed in a stretch of dead weight.

Izuku holds his breath, his panic dissolving, as he draws in the quiet, content look on Katsuki Bakugou's face.

His shuddering body gives way to the trembling in the bed, and then, his companion's eyes flutter open, a petulant pinch furrowing the middle of his brow. His nose scrunches up, a tired sigh rumbling deep in his chest—the vibration drifts through his arm and into Izuku's skin.

"Why're you 'wake…?" Katsuki grumbles. "It's early, nerd…"

Izuku shakes his head.

His wobbling smile, despite being hardly present at all, curves along his mouth like a line of imbalanced string.

"... Deku?"

Izuku freezes.

No, no, this is my problem—shit, no, I should've just stayed quiet. I didn't want to wake you, I'm sorry!

But none of the apologies break into the open.

In a sudden snap of reflexes, Katsuki's drowsiness dissipates, his beaming red eyes cracked wide open and searching Izuku. The wide set of his shoulders shifts from under the covers, and then, he's hovering over Izuku, his gaze far too intense for this early in the morning.

The sun has barely risen past the glare of the window.

"I-I'm sorry," Izuku hiccups. The pressure behind his eyelids becomes unbearable, and his vision of Katsuki, who's narrow jaw is twisted into a concerned frown, blurs behind a fresh sheen of water. "N-None of this was s-supposed to happen—I, I didn't want to wake you… t-these happens sometimes, and it's too much. I'll go, I'm sorry—"

Tender, calloused fingers rest in Izuku's curls. It's a firm grip, but not painful. A warning in the present, stabilizing Izuku through the leaps in his stomach and the unbearable palpitations in his heart.

"Deku. Breathe." Katsuki's gaze is firm, a silent command.

Izuku shakes underneath Katsuki, the thin fabric of his pajama shirt turning looser and wetter with sweat.

"I'm going to count, Deku. You got that?"

Izuku shakes his head, and Katsuki raises another hand, tenderly stroking his jaw with the backs of his knuckles. The action renders Izuku somewhat shocked, his sweaty hands instinctively holding onto both the bed and grasping Katsuki's bicep.

Katsuki's stare hasn't broken. It's an intense and unwavering glare, one that anchors Izuku.

“From one to ten.” Katsuki dips his head. “You’re going to have to breathe, shitnerd. Focus on me. No one’s here to hurt you.” His fingers coast through Izuku’s hair, until both of his palms are resting on his face, thumbs brushing wistfully over his cheekbones.

Focus on me.

Izuku’s insides feel as if they’re trembling worse than a city swept in a hurricane, but he complies with a nod.

Katsuki’s jaw tightens, but he begins counting. Izuku stares up into the other teen’s features, memorizing and counting each detail that slowly lulls him back from the deep pitfall of his nightmare.

Focus on Kacchan. Focus on Kacchan.

The fine slope of his jaw. The broad, rounded structure to his shoulders. The strong column of his throat. Bruised pink lips pursed and firm. A jagged scar cutting through his left, pale eyebrow. The wild tufts of matted ash-blond hair, often framed as pale as porcelain in the glare of the sun and moon. The deep, running pools of auburn in his irises.

“… Eight.” Katsuki’s smile is snarky. Fond.

Izuku exhales. The newfound tremble in his chest is pushed to the side, but the slight rumbling of his heart in his ears, and the recognition of Katsuki’s touch on his skin makes his insides quiver.

He holds back a pleased, weak chuckle, the temptation to somehow embarrass Katsuki falling behind his first need.

Before Katsuki can react, Izuku pecks him on the lips.

Katsuki blinks. His entire face flushes.

“Stupid nerd,” he mumbles.

Despite his words, there’s hardly any bite, and the lingering stare that follows Izuku as he lies back down, smooth and pliant on the covers, rides on the wave of fascination in place of aggression.

“I’m sorry, Kacchan,” Izuku whispers.

Katsuki twitches, and pinches his cheek.

“Ah! Ow! Kacchan—”

“The fuck are you apologizing for, asswipe?!” Katsuki snaps.

“That’s mean, Kacchan—”

“Shut the hell up!”

Then, he clicks his tongue, releases Izuku with a huff, and rolls back on his side of the bed.

Unfortunately, he's pulled almost the entire length of his covers with him, and Izuku is left with a bare chill running over his knees and boxers. He squirms in the pajama shirt, and frowns at the distinct memory from the previous night.

He groans, burying his face into his hands.

"I can't believe we did that…"

"Eh?" Katsuki pokes his head out from beneath the covers, scowling. "You're making it sound like you got laid or something, fuckmunch."

Izuku looks over at him, and hides an ugly snort.

"K-Kacchan—"

"The fuck you laughing about? I'll kill you!" Katsuki growls. His blush has become all the more pronounced, riding on the tide of anger and embarrassment that Izuku can feel in their proximity.

Katsuki doesn't seem to notice how ridiculous and accidentally adorable he looks, though Izuku will surely remember this for months to come. His friend is tightly bundled in his blankets, wrapped up to his nose in a coil of white and simple black and blue patterns from the comforter. His unruly hair sticks out in a pronounced flurry, his hidden mouth and angry red eyes only adding to the unexpected appeal of the image.

"You're—you look like a Pomeranian, wrapped in a fluffy cocoon…" Izuku breaks out into laughter. He snorts, giggles, and struggles to hold in his reactions to Katsuki's ridiculous appearance. "I-I can't take you seriously when you're like that!"

Katsuki rips himself out of his blankets.

Despite what Izuku expects, anger is only one of a multitude of broiling emotions shadowing Katsuki's face. His glare is only accented with the aggravated tic in his right eyebrow, the equal twitch in his lip, and the menacing toothy sneer that shakes with the rest of his body.

"Oh yeah?" he growls, halfway out of his blanket prison. "Can't take me seriously, *Deku*?"

Oh.

Izuku blinks.

So this is how I'm going to die.

He moves to jump off the bed, but Katsuki is quicker.

"Wait—no, Kacchan, you're a really badass Pomeranian! I swear! I take it back! Ah, *oof*—"

He squeals, laughing, kicking and flailing his arms as he tries to push the other boy off of him.

Katsuki grins and buries his mouth into Izuku's neck, arms pulling and caging around him in a maneuver to keep him in place. Izuku retaliates with slapping his hand over Katsuki's jaw and pushing him back, but Katsuki growls and reaches under Izuku's shirt.

His fingers drift over his stomach.

Izuku squeaks.

"Fucking knew it," growls Katsuki. His smirk is teasing, merciless, and nothing short of competitive. "*Die*, Deku!"

Izuku's squeals erupt into raucous laughter, practically shaking the bed with each plunge Katsuki takes with his hands. Skittish bundles of delightful, and persistent, nerves rise to the surface as the tickling continues, and for a moment—just one, glass-clear moment—Izuku feels his spirits relax.

It takes a few extra seconds for Izuku to realize, with a slight jolt to his concentration, that Katsuki's body is shaking as well. He halts, wondering if he'd somehow done something wrong, but his fears are instantly abated at the sight of a genuine, *breathtaking* smile—erupting with mischievous laughter, lighting up his eyes.

Katsuki pauses, his handsome face open and loose.

"Oi, what the fuck? Suddenly not ticklish anymore?"

Izuku leans up, wraps his arms around Katsuki's neck, and pulls him down.

His lips crash against Katsuki's, a smile breaking out between the contact with a barely muffled giggle rising in his chest. He grins further as Katsuki splutters and snorts, only for the blond to relax his heavy weight on top of him, his annoyed grunt betraying the easy way he returns Izuku's kiss.

Izuku teasingly slips his tongue into the other's mouth, and the rushed fervor of the previous night comes flashing in his mind's eye.

Katsuki, positioned between his legs, the crown of spiked blond hair bobbing up and down as he took in his cock—pulsing, raw, wet and hot—and smirking at him as if he'd won the devil's lottery. The way he'd wiped his mouth and licked his teeth, taunting, like a wolf cornering its prey. He remembers feeling up Katsuki's abdominals, the chiseled round of his shoulders, the powerful slope of his back and the generous curve to his rear, all flexing and moving as they rutted hips, whispering and panting each other's names into their mouths.

The way Katsuki had looked at him last night felt different.

Raw. Something wonderful. Something new.

Izuku wants to see more.

Katsuki deepens the kiss, earning a moan from Izuku.

He melts into the coasting of Katsuki's tongue in the walls of his mouth, scarred hands sliding under his shirt and resting on his back. Katsuki then pulls him up, their bodies flush together, and when they flop back down onto the bed, he smoothly rolls down his hips—

"K-Kacchan, ah, *Katsu*—"

The bedroom door slams open.

"Hey you little brat, when the fuck did you—oh, Izuku?"

"*Izuku*?"

In the wake of the door slamming open, Katsuki had sprung from Izuku like a startled cat.

He sits up, straight as a board, still shirtless and, Izuku realizes with horror, littered with deep, purpling hickeys from the previous night.

Izuku is resting on his forearms, mortification coloring his face an entirely new shade of red.

And there, at the doorway, are both of their mothers.

Mitsuki and Inko blink, slowly, shifting back and forth between Izuku and Katsuki. Katsuki's mother is the first to break the silence, her eyebrows risen to her hairline and her wicked, amused smile far too devilish for Izuku's liking.

"Well, this explains why we couldn't find Izuku in his bedroom."

Inko has gone incredibly pale.

Izuku can feel her disbelieving stare, drifting over his rumpled clothes, including the ever-present tent in his boxers, and the embarrassingly noticeable trail of hickeys exposed on his collarbone.

He personally loves them, but he'd planned on shielding them from his poor mother.

Izuku waves his arms. "I-I can explain—"

"Holy shit, old hag, you ever heard of *knocking*?!" Katsuki yells, finally standing up from his bed and pointing accusingly at his mother. "You're so fucking embarrassing!"

Mitsuki clicks her tongue. "Jesus, brat, poor Izuku looks like he's been mauled by a lion." She snorts, slapping her knee. "Oh, this is *rich*. Come on, Inko, we can discuss punishing them or whatever, later, but we have to tell Masaru."

"What the hell, shitty mother?" Katsuki screeches, dangerously close to the level of a squeak.

Izuku swallows. He hangs his head in shame at the devastated, and graciously accepting, look in his mother's eyes. Inko glances over him, her face unreadable.

“… Mitsuki, I really think we should speak to them sooner than later,” Inko whispers, still locked onto Izuku as if she can hardly stand the thought of looking over to the boy who had, most definitely, been the subject of Katsuki's hormonal fantasies for quite some time.

“Heh.” Mitsuki laughs. “Whatever. Brat, go take a shower. You look like shit. Izuku, honey, sweetie, little ball of sunshine my bratty son doesn’t deserve—”

“Jesus Christ, *you fucking hag*—”

“Y-Yes?” Izuku says, sheepishly rubbing his neck and glancing everywhere in the room except for the two women at the door and the boy he’d confessed to the previous day.

“We would love it if you helped us make breakfast.” Mitsuki’s grin is nothing short of taunting, but underneath it, Izuku reads something akin to mirth. “So change out of… oh, you’re even wearing his shirt. Well ain’t that adorable.” She glares at Katsuki. “I swear, you spoiled brat, you go sneaking around again under my own roof, you're getting a smack."

Izuku’s hands grip his knees. He can feel Katsuki’s building anger and frustration, and the impending embarrassment that they both certainly share.

Hesitantly, he nods. “R-Right, Mrs. Bakugou! Of course!”

“Good, good.” Mitsuki pats Inko on the back, as if Izuku’s mother has completely gone into shock. “Come along, Inko. Looks like we’re going to be talking about quite a bit down the road.”

Expectantly, the door remains pushed open as Mitsuki and Inko take their leave.

“Um…” Izuku blushes. “Sorry…”

“Shut up,” says Katsuki, exasperated. “Was both of us. I told you to come in here last night, anyway. Should’ve known the stupid old hag would come up here at some random-ass time.”

He rubs his temples, and turns to glance over Izuku’s frame, slow and tantalizingly drawing up his legs, resting on his crotch, and then on his chest and shoulders. He snorts.

“You really are wearing my shirt. When the hell did you do even put it on?”

Izuku smiles shyly. “Uh, well, when you fell asleep, it was just lying there, and I got cold during the night, and I like wearing your shirts… they’re just a little bit bigger than me, so…” he sighs, rolling his eyes. “Sorry. I don’t, really have a good reason. I mean, I can give it back to you—”

“No. Don't."

Izuku blinks, looking up to see that Katsuki has come closer, leaning down to his height. The other teen smirks, ruffling Izuku’s messy curls.

“Hmph. Well, it looks way better than any of the usual shit.” He chuckles, dry and lax. “Stupid nerdy clothes for a stupid nerd.”

Izuku huffs. “Whatever, Kacchan.” He grins. “Does this mean you like it when I wear your clothes?”

Katsuki wastes no time in swooping in and kissing Izuku on the mouth, aggressively sliding in his tongue for only a few seconds before pulling back.

“They’re mine, aren’t they?” he whispers, his voice huskier. Darker.

A shiver bolts down Izuku’s spine.

“Y-Yeah…”

Katsuki’s arrogant smile is the last image imprinted in Izuku’s brain, before he grabs some clothes off his bedroom floor, and leaves.

“Ah, you almost got it, sweetie,” says Mitsuki, her fondness lingering in her voice like fairy dust.

Beside her, Izuku has his sleeves rolled to his elbows, frowning as he looks over the mess of cottage cheese on the granite counter.

Katsuki sits on one of the chairs by the island attached to to the kitchen space, his arms folded.

He raises an eyebrow and glares at Izuku’s somewhat amateurish movements in the kitchen. His long-sleeved, black shirt hugs closely to his muscular form, and within minutes of walking into the kitchen he knew that he could have used this as a reason alone to drag Izuku away from everyone and kiss him in private.

“Sorry, ah—oh no.” Izuku slaps his forehead, groaning. “I’m sorry…”

Mitsuki laughs. “No, you’re fine! Just a little mess is all. Hey, brat!” Katsuki lazily glares at her. “When this is done, you help Izuku clean up! It’s the least you both can do for getting up to way too mature things in the late hours of the night—”

“Fucking shut up!” Katsuki snaps. His cheeks flush warm and red. “Jesus, you’re never going to let this go! For the last time, we didn’t have sex!”

He conveniently leaves out the details of giving Izuku a mind-numbing blowjob—especially since Inko is calmly sipping tea in the corner of the room, striking up idle chatter with his father—but, his case still stands.

“Sure, sure.” Mitsuki rolls her eyes.

Izuku mumbles under his breath, examining the directions and ingredients with a determined, yet unsure slump to his posture. His apron is completely covered in flour, freckled cheeks spattered with leftover batter and bits and pieces of salt.

“Nerd, you’re adding way too much flour,” mutters Katsuki.

Mitsuki smacks his hand with a spoon.

“Forgive my shitty son. He’s always been a backseat chef.”

“Oh, no, um, it’s fine! It’s always fine!” says Izuku, tripping over his words.

“You give him way too much credit, sunshine,” says Mitsuki. She clears her throat. “Breakfast will be ready soon!” she calls, as if Inko and Masaru were not a staggering twenty feet away from her meandering in the kitchen. “We’re making *syrniki*, Masaru, darling, your favorite!”

“Saps,” grumbles Katsuki.

He hops off his chair and strides into the living room, rubbing his slightly sore hand on his jeans.

His palm brushes his pocket, where the vibration from his temporary phone buzzes through the fabric. Frowning, he pulls out the device, checks the number, and scowls.

The fuck is this?

It’s another number he doesn’t recognize.

He glares at the strange contacts fleeting on his touchscreen with bated interest. He spares one look in the kitchen, at Izuku’s nervous chuckles and his mother’s patient mannerisms as she gives him instructions. A hum buzzes in his throat, a series of questions prodding his brain with one glance over his phone.

Then, as the call ends, the number returns, flashing a gray text message on his screen.

Katsuki blinks.

[**From: Unknown Number**]

- *Hey, Bakugou. Have a present for you~*

Katsuki’s hand clenches around his phone.

He quickly marches his way to the front door of his house, rips it open, and walks briskly into the cold outside.

The wind is bitter and soft, coasting over the dip in his collar and spreading goosebumps on his wrists. He steadies his breathing, running one hand through his spikes, as he calmly opens his phone to read the message.

His heart drops to his toes.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *Mm, wonder how many freckles he has… bet you know, though, right?*

Below the message is a blurred picture of Katsuki through his bedroom window, his naked back flexed towards the ceiling and mouth trailing down a shirtless Izuku's stomach. It's a moment frozen in time from the previous night, of where Katsuki's teeth hung on the waistband of Izuku's boxers.

Whoever this was had seen this through his own window.

Katsuki's entire body erupts into static fire. His right fist clench while his left struggles to not break the phone in his hands. His stomach coils and heart leaps at the thought of this sick stalker eyeing the both of them through his own window, so dangerously close to hurting them. Killing them, even, if they were caught off-guard and not able to react in time.

Another image pops up.

It takes every ounce of willpower within Katsuki not to explode his phone into pieces.

It's a snapshot of Izuku, alone on the train heading towards his high school.

He's reading one of his notebooks, the item splayed open on his lap while he rubs his chin in thought. It's at an angle where the person taking the photograph was less than ten feet away on ground level.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *Ya know, I'd seen him in passing before he clung to you like mucus. Was always a cute motherfucker. But then, you got all tangled up in it, Bakugou, and I guess he's not safe anymore, either…*

“Fuck you…” Katsuki’s breathing turns labored, ragged. “*Fuck you*…”

He wants to destroy his phone, but a piece of him also wants to read every piece of evidence that this fool will be willing to send him. Maybe he can trace the number after it’s over, or even inform his parents of an apparent stalker with clear connections to the underground workings in Augustana. He knows that they are aware of the growing corruption, but with his and Izuku’s recent kidnapping, the ammunition could potentially be all theirs, or entirely against them.

Another image. And then another.

Before Katsuki can gather his angry thoughts into one place, his phone is erupting with photos of Izuku Midoriya walking down Isabori, turning the corner of the street to stop in a convenience store in Illenova, popping into interviews with retired pro heroes and other authority figures kept out of the spotlight… some of them even feature Izuku long before he met Katsuki, waving goodbye to his mother and leaving their joint apartment complex to break into a sprint for the train.

The number of images this anonymous sender has is more than alarming. It sickens Katsuki to his core, twists him apart in the inside and fuels the growing rage inside him. He simultaneously wants to destroy a dozen buildings and pull Izuku close to him in a crushing embrace, to know for sure that the Izuku in his house is safe and away from prying eyes.

I need to tell him.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *You know, it’s because of you that I know his name. And, no wonder, honestly. None of us thought the little whore could be the spawn of Hisashi Midoriya.*

Katsuki’s teeth grit.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *Makes sense. Daddy Midoriya is hot as fuck.*

Katsuki pushes aside his frustrations for that spare detail.

Izuku's father is alive, then.

Was he still running the suspenseful routes in Augustana? Was he still watching over the city, his ex-wife and his son?

Katsuki's hand trembles. His nostrils flare with contained, furious breaths.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *You know, I don't mean Freckles any harm. I mean, a bit pissed that he tried to rip off my tongue, but you know… all is forgiven.*

Of course.

Nero—

Katsuki holds back a scream.

"Fuck you, fuck you, *fuck you*," he whispers harshly.

He feels watched, as if many potential eyes could be watching him, could be stationed somewhere, someway outside of his family home and observing his every word and step.

[**Unknown Number**]

- *Heh, at this point, you would be smart to hand him over. Having Hisashi's son would do us wonders, and maybe even do good for your widely hated family.*

Katsuki is unable to finish the entire text. He calls the number, and presses it up to his ears. He's trembling from head to toe, jaw clenched, teeth grinding, a furious pulsing in his forehead that barely resembles the mounting rage and protectiveness he feels surging in his blood.

"Surprised you called, Bakugou. Missed me?"

Katsuki holds back a growl.

“Listen, *Nero*,” he breathes, pouring each and every emotion into his voice, into the words he wants to permanently imprint into this bastard’s mind. “You’re not going anywhere *near* Izuku Midoriya. If you do—if you even *consider* following him or anything remotely related to him—I will find you myself, and *destroy* you.”

A sickening, menacing smirk overtakes his lips. He loses himself to the morbid fantasy, to the twisted idea of letting loose his explosions and watching Nero fall prey to his devastating onslaught with nowhere else to turn.

“Your fucked up gang buddies won’t even recognize you. I’ll tear you limb from limb, rip your tongue out of your fucking throat all over again, and burn you piece by piece, until you’re *begging* for it to stop. Izuku is under *my* protection. *Mine*. You touch him, you touch me. You *look* at him, you’re looking at *me*. You even so much as *think* of following him again, I’ll know.”

A pause sounds on the other line. A rumble of static bursts in his ears. Despite this, Katsuki knows Nero is still there, processing like the coward he is.

“One thing you should keep in mind, *motherfucker*,” says Katsuki, “Bakugous don’t make empty threats.”

And with that, he hangs up.

The world around him swallows his angry screams.

Izuku’s reaction was far too calm on seeing the images and the texts.

If anything, Katsuki felt as if he was bottling up and exploding with emotional reactions meant for the both of them combined, rather than just for Katsuki himself. Izuku had gently ushered him into the guest bedroom, and allowed him to explain the reasoning behind his dramatic leave earlier that morning.

Izuku pauses as the final words spill out of Katsuki, a contemplative expression lacing his features. He folds his hands together in his lap.

“What do you think they’re planning?”

Katsuki stares into the carpet.

Izuku's question falls on his ears, a blur of white noise through the flurry of images and texts he'd seen, the threats he'd witnessed.

It sickens him to think that Nero is still following Izuku, and that he's been so close, hanging about like a shadow when they consistently believe they're several steps ahead.

"Kacchan?" Izuku frowns, tilting his head to the side.

He's sitting at his temporary desk, the final draft of his newspaper article popped up on his screen. The finishing touches have already been made, with additional notes in the margin of his folders and spiral books, but the concern he wears is enough for Katsuki to avoid making eye contact.

"Don't know," he finally mutters. "They'll expect all of us to know. He wouldn't be so blatant if it was a trap of some kind. Those bastards want you, now, though." His jaw clenches. "Your dad is alive and well, probably pulling some strings where we can't see." He snorts. "This is all fucked up, all of it."

Izuku rubs his chin in thought. "There's still the matter of the gun." He snaps his fingers. "That's it, Kacchan! The gun! We need to ask the detectives again about the gun. My mom has one of the copies, the one I touched back in our apartment, and the only other ones were with Shigaraki and his minions a few years ago. It's evidence enough that my dad was somehow working with them at the time, but for what reason?"

Katsuki sits up, watching as Izuku launches into a tirade of his own deductive reasoning. It's amusing, and endearing, to see Izuku become swallowed up in this new light, as if piecing together puzzles and assembling one fragment to another is what his brain is built for.

Despite the seriousness of their situation, Izuku's green eyes are bright and shimmering.

"Money. Power." Katsuki shrugs. "The usual cliché reasons that villains and corrupted people go for. Why else would those fuckers take so many risks?" He rests his chin in his hand, brow furrowing. "Wait…" He blinks. "Deku, your dream. You said this morning, that you've had them multiple times…" he trails off, dragging one hand down his face. "Listen, you little shit, this will be the *one time* I want you to explain something in way too much fucking detail. Get it?"

Izuku slightly huffs at that. "You're kidding me, right—"

"Okay, whatever! Maybe it won't be the last! Just bear with me!" Katsuki raises his hands in the air. "Explain your dream. This one that you've been having for, apparently, fucking forever."

Izuku opens his mouth, and then closes it. He leans forward in his chair, cheeks puffed out as he mulls over his thoughts. Strangely enough, the look of him so focused and puckering his lips as he thinks is far too distracting for Katsuki.

He looks away, blushing and coughing into his fist.

“Hurry up, shitty Deku,” he grumbles.

“Okay, okay!”

Izuku frowns.

“I mean, it always starts off dark. Really dark. I’m in a room, and I have to be around five or six years old. I can hear my mom shouting on the other side of the door, and there’s always this… moment where I look at my legs and realize they’re broken. Even though it’s a dream, it’s like I can remember every painful thing on my body.” He bites his lip. “I hear my mother yelling, and sometimes the other voice is blurred, but it sounds masculine. I used to think that this was just my subconscious presenting some image of what I thought my father was like. But, I don’t know.”

Katsuki remains silent, and steadies himself lest Izuku becomes overwhelmed with recalling these grating details.

“But, I mean, there are a couple times where she says his name. Hisashi.” Izuku shrugs. “I never questioned that. I knew that it’s always been his name. She’s never hid that particular detail from me.” He furrows his brow in thought. “But, there are other times, too, where I wonder why Mom wouldn’t tell me some things. When we met to talk about him and what he did years ago… she said something a little strange.”

Katsuki blinks. “Spit it out, nerd.”

Every piece of information we can get is important.

Izuku swallows, and nods. “When I told her about the gun, my mom had asked me… if I’d experienced anything strange. Like, if I was going through some changes or something that even I didn’t know about. She was so tense when she asked, too. I thought she was going to break the mug in her hands.” He frowns at the memory. “Kacchan, what if—I mean, I only had one dream before I touched that gun, I think… but it became so constant after that. What if—maybe these aren’t *just* dreams.”

Izuku mumbles under his breath, as if verbally counting off the arguments against his possible conclusions. Katsuki sneers, aggravation seeping deep into his muscles and threatening to cause his Quirk to burst into life.

“… You bringing some supernatural mumbo jumbo into this, Deku?” Katsuki says.

“No! Well, maybe a little bit, but, we live in a world with Quirks, Kacchan! Who knows what’s possible. I mean, I hardly remember anything about my dad before he left us. There could be a reason I’m having this dream constantly, and it could be linked to my mom, or the gun in our apartment… Hisashi’s gun.”

Katsuki dips his head, shutting his eyes tight. He pinches the bridge of his nose and slowly counts to ten, allowing his lungs to recede in their expansive weight.

“You sound fucking nuts,” says Katsuki.

“I *know*.” Izuku rolls his eyes. “Just, bear with me, here. And one thing at a time. Right now, my main goal is to get this paper up and running to put a healthier light on your family, and maybe we’ll even see some good come from this.” He nods his head, his determined smile bright and true. “Nothing will slip through those cracks, at least.”

Katsuki folds his arms. He knows Izuku is correct about this one, and it’s too early to assume that his theory could be incorrect. The thought of Izuku’s dreams actually being memories, or even visions, of some kind, seem far too abnormal to be true.

One thing at a time.

He supposes this is true. Regardless, the thought of letting Izuku ever leave their house alone sends a terrible shiver up his spine. He neglects to think about the possible backlash against those thoughts, the repercussions potentially even deadlier than what he images could take place.

“We could ask Todoroki…”

Katsuki snaps out of his thoughts. He glares harshly at Izuku, who beams at him with a sheepish, detestably adorable grin.

“*No*. Icy Hot can suck my dick.”

“Oh, well, I didn’t propose that. I don’t think he’d want to, either,” says Izuku. The playful glint in his eyes is enough to keep him just a shy inch away from Katsuki’s wrath. He holds up his hands in surrender, as if he can read the intent in Katsuki’s posture. “Just listen, though! He has a lot of influence in Augustana, too. And, even though he can’t stand you, and vice versa, he cares about the city and its residents.” He scratches his cheek. “And apparently me, too.”

Katsuki barks out a harsh laugh. “Yeah, big fucking surprise.”

Izuku blinks. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Oh, gee, I don’t know, Deku. You talk about the asshole like he’s some… like he’s a fucking notch or two below All-Might! Sure, whatever, he goes to your high school and he’s always *so cool*,” he drawls, “but screw that shit! Half N’ Half can’t stand my guts. And the feeling is fucking mutual. Doesn’t matter how much he fawns over you.”

Izuku flushes, and glares. “Kacchan, wait, he doesn’t *fawn over me*. We've talked about this. Never dated or anything. He’s just worried out of obligation—”

“Oh yeah?” Katsuki snorts. “Every time he gets on my case, it’s about *you*. Seriously, do you have history with him? I know you said you didn’t, but Jesus, he definitely acts like some clingy ex-boyfriend. Tough shit for him.”

Izuku pauses, considering. “I’ll ask him to stop, then. I’m not sure why he’s so… adamant. He knows that I trust you. He definitely knows that I like you.”

Katsuki blinks. “How?”

“… Kacchan.” Izuku chuckles, though it’s a dry sound. “You’re joking, right?”

Katsuki reels, slightly unsettled by the steely glint in Izuku’s eyes. The other boy is shifting in his chair, as if contemplating between standing up and remaining in his seat.

The glare of his article on the computer screen serves as a distracting beacon over his shoulder, carrying the carefully woven truths and exposed secrets that Katsuki allowed to be told.

He stiffens, and returns Izuku’s glare tenfold.

“Is it really… that weird, for you to believe that? For me to like you? Maybe for you to like me too?” Izuku sighs, running one hand through his hair. “Look, I know we talked yesterday, and I understand where you’re coming from completely, but I want to know why you seem so skittish about it. Like you don’t really believe me.”

The dejected look that washes over Izuku in a cloud steals the breath from Katsuki’s lungs.

He clenches his fists, and pushes against the temptation to yell, or scream, or taunt the other boy into a tirade that neither of them want to experience. His heart flips beneath his ribcage, carrying the weights of his uncertainty, of his unwillingness to accept the responsibilities that both he and Izuku have been given.

“And why would you care if Todoroki did—if he *did* like me, anyway?”

Izuku tilts his head, the aggressive lilt to his brow and the frustrated pout to his lips making him far less intimidating than he believes. Katsuki stands his ground, despite the incessant anger pummeling away in his core at thinking of the son of Enji Todoroki.

“I mean, you don’t consider *us* boyfriends. So why would it matter?”

Katsuki balks. “You—Deku, what the fuck? Obviously it would piss me off—”

“You said yourself that you don’t like me like that, Kacchan!” Izuku says, his hands balling into fists. He pushes himself up from his chair, wiping under his nose. “I’m willing to go at whatever pace you want to go, and maybe I’m even okay that you can kiss me and touch me like that while still… not returning how I feel, but why *this*?” He stares, confusion evident and bright. “Why all this—this *jealousy*?”

The word snaps something inside Katsuki.

The steel cable wrapped around his thoughts break in half, and Izuku releases a grunt as Katsuki grabs the collar of his shirt with one hand, using the other to firmly cup his jaw. The action could be painful, if not for the faint restraint that lies in Katsuki’s tense, agitated muscles.

“I’m *not* jealous, Deku,” Katsuki says with a growl.

Izuku swallows. His eye shine with competitiveness, with a tentative shade of understanding and confusion mixed into one.

“I don’t think you know that you are,” he says. He reaches up, and wraps his hand around the wrist holding onto his collar. “But you should decide what you want from me.”

He sighs, and peels himself out of Katsuki’s unwavering grip.

The other teen eyes him warily.

“I do like you,” he says.

Izuku freezes.

Katsuki groans, rubbing his jaw.

“I know that I like you in some… weird, way, or something.”

He coughs into his fist.

“Is that what it fucking takes? To be your fucking boyfriend or whatever?” He pushes his hands into his pockets, his skin prickling beneath Izuku’s wide-eyed gaze and breathtaking, slowly spreading smile. “And if that Half N’ Half fucker comes around again I’ll just shove my tongue down your throat and tell him to fuck off.”

Izuku tackles him, arms winding around his neck, and kisses him.

Katsuki stumbles backward, and braces himself as the contact deepens.

The growl that rumbles in Katsuki’s throat is nothing short of feral, even as he backs up to the wall. Izuku then leaps up, and Katsuki hooks his knees around his waist. Smirking, biceps bulging with rippling cords of muscle, Katsuki turns and pins Izuku to the wall, slotting their groins together in a messy array of friction.

“*Fuck*,” Katsuki whispers, licking his lips. Izuku grins down at him, his shyness momentarily replaced with a dark huskiness that seems so unfamiliar, yet entirely welcome, on him. Heat pools low in Katsuki’s stomach, his mouth salivating.

He swallows, and eyes the strong, slender column of Izuku’s neck. His throat pulses in a stretch of milky white skin and a dusting of freckles.

The bruises Katsuki had left the night before linger beneath the unbuttoned collar of Izuku’s shirt, but he sees several more spots waiting for him to mark—places where he can take ownership and allow others to see and memorize and *know*.

“I want you to do it,” says Izuku sternly.

Katsuki’s pupils block out the reds of his irises.

He growls, leaning up and nibbling on Izuku's ear. Izuku clenches his legs tighter around Katsuki's waist, fingers digging into his back.

"Want me to bite you, Deku?" Katsuki smirks against his skin.

At Izuku's trembling response, he chuckles darkly and licks a long, languid stripe from Izuku's jawbone to his temple.

"Gonna do it, Deku. Gonna mark you up. *All mine*."

"Katsuki," Izuku breathes.

Katsuki growls and grinds into him.

He knows they have only a few minutes left alone, but those thoughts for the rest of the day become swarmed behind the liquefying scent of Izuku. He wants to keep this moment together and pretend that they're in their own world, free of the possible prying eyes searching their every movement, of the impending dangers waiting in their midst.

Izuku kisses him back with each clothed thrust, his entire being aching, *needing*.

"W-We should stop," Izuku says, quickly gasping afterwards.

His left hand grips harder on Katsuki's shoulder, sinking into the fabric of his shirt.

"Ah, yeah, right there—"

"Make up your mind, Deku," Katsuki snarls.

"Katsuki! You little brat, we can hear you from downstairs!"

Katsuki nearly drops Izuku, who squeaks in protest, and the two teens stare at each other blankly before Katsuki is, expectantly, the first to break it.

He storms out of the guest bedroom, ripping open the door and stomping to what Izuku can only assume to be the top of the stairwell.

"*Mind your own fucking business, old hag*!"

"Well then quit canoodling like rabbits up there and come down here! The detectives will be here soon for a consultation!"

"I don't give a rat's ass about those shitty detectives!"

"Get down here now, you shitty little brat!"

Izuku groans.

He wonders, privately, if he'll be able to have a single moment alone long enough with Katsuki to ever move further than this.

Turnabout

Chapter Summary

> “Deku?”
>
> Izuku swallows, and shakes his head. He glances around him, at the laughing, smiling strangers bounding towards the square in Redmond District, and the undeniable concern washed over his companions’ features.
>
> “S-Sorry,” he says, breathless. Panicked. “I… thought I saw someone I knew. It’s no big deal.”

Chapter Notes

> Welp. First off. Sorry for the delay. Real life, lack of inspiration, all those things... thank you so much for the support, guys. There's still quite a lot left to happen in this story, so it's got a bit of a ways. I actually have an estimate on the number of chapters it will have. Between 25 and 30, for sure, which is insane.
>
> Thank you so much. Also... this chapter takes place three months ahead. Hooray for holidays.
>
> Also, happy holiday season everyone! :) Thank you for your support and reading this for so long! I know that the chapters uploads have been pretty sporadic and delayed recently, so I appreciate the patience more than anything. You're all wonderful.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

... Three Months Later ...

Monday. 5:41 PM.

Izuku rubs his gloved hands together, momentarily marveling in the friction, as the decorative strings of lights in the train continuously blink in gold and bright red patterns.

He’s always loved Christmas.

Other than the turn of autumn into wintertime casting a faint, cold glow onto the city of Augustana—and the familiar sightings of children and adults alike swaddled in layers of comfortable sweaters and rainbow mittens—the unquenchable joy that filters through each and every smile around Izuku warms up his soul better than anything else.

And this would be the first time he’ll be able to spend the holiday with those outside of his own family. The idea of celebrating Christmas with the Bakugous seemed unlikely to him, especially with the prospect of temporarily moving in with them, though he had entertained the thought to be less likely than Katsuki being the first to initiate a kiss.

So he supposed that he gained a few points in that spectrum.

His smile is unrestrained, stretching wide enough to expose the dimpled markings in his cheeks, and his wave is undeterred over the crowded seats of people as the doors to the locomotive slide open, and the familiar silhouette of Katsuki Bakugou steps onto the cool metal floors.

“Kacchan!” he calls, far too loud for the pedestrians glaring at him from all sides.

He grins only wider when Katsuki swivels around and locks onto him, his eye-roll concealing only slight bitterness and affection, even underneath the scarf layering over his mouth and muffling his growls. The leather jacket over his broad shoulders and enormous headphones around his neck remind Izuku of the first night he met Katsuki, awash with constant fascination and unwitting curiosity.

“Too loud, nerd,” he grumbles as he walks over to his side. Deep shadows purple his eyelids.

Izuku frowns, his excitement dissipating in favor of concern.

“Kacchan, you look so tired. Are you—”

“What, and you don’t?” Katsuki scoffs, pulling down his scarf and leaning his head back against the cushioned seats. The train rumbles and wails on its usual path, their destination not too far at all from the district where Izuku had offered to meet. “This better be good, Deku.”

Izuku grins, reaching over and quickly taking Katsuki’s left hand in his. Katsuki stiffens for only a few moments, his flinching a noticeable spark in a dark room, and relaxes as Izuku’s thumb brushes over his palm. He remains quiet, his expression calculated and cruel to onlookers, but soft and exhausted to Izuku.

“It will be,” he says, squeezing Katsuki’s hand. “I promise.”

Thank you for coming out with me.

It had taken him a few days to convince Katsuki to come with him to the lighting of the Christmas tree in Redmond District. Several other classmates would be there, including Uraraka, and he was more than delighted at the idea of actually turning away from the

impending mysteries swallowing them whole and enjoying an evening alone with his friends instead.

He was adamant on convincing his boyfriend—a term which had grown from secretive and awkward to loudly proclaimed and defined within a few weeks—to go to the event with him.

The fact that Katsuki did eventually agree to an event that Izuku knew he would otherwise never attend on his own volition, makes something warm and gentle flutter up inside his chest. As if his heart sprouted butterfly wings and immediately attempted to fly.

The train ceases to a halt, the familiar voice calling for passengers to depart booming through the carts. Izuku and Katsuki gradually rise from their seats and step off, with Izuku bouncing on the balls of his feet and the blond refusing to release him for even one second.

“Ah, Kacchan! The lights!” He coos and grins brightly, pointing to each and every tree, bush, store and apartment complex strung about in colorful lights. They blink like stars in the night sky, fading and whispering in warmth and delight. “They’re so pretty! Come on, we have to get closer to the tree before it gets too crowded!”

Katsuki stares at him blankly, but only nods when Izuku squeezes his hand and pulls him behind him.

“It’s too fucking cold,” he grumbles out, his breath puffing white and cloudy.

“I know, but, at least you’re not alone in that,” Izuku says with a small smile. Katsuki rolls his eyes, but squeezes his hand in return, apparently satisfied.

Izuku hums, falling into a calmer step beside his companion on the sidewalk. Frost fringes several glass windows of closed restaurants and department stores. Crisp green bushes and wiry potted plants are dressed in twinkling sparkles, garlands and lights, festive and bright and altogether perfect for the one holiday Izuku looks forward to every year.

“Does your family ever celebrate Christmas?” Izuku asks.

Katsuki snorts.

“Used to.” He shrugs. “It’s all a bunch of bullshit, anyway. We’re not religious, and it’s not like we talk to anyone outside of our household.”

He gestures with a brief flick of his elbow to the lights, the trees, and the happy, smiling faces of children and adults alike as they scramble towards the one destination in Redmond worthy of reaching on this night.

“None of that,” he says, unusually stiff, “is something I’m… used to seeing. Lot of the people here don’t give a shit about my family, and it used to be so bad that even if someone mentioned the name *Bakugou*, people would boycott events.”

Izuku stops, blinking in the rising cold. He looks over Katsuki’s unreadable, blank features. A dark, angry twist claws through his chest, yanking out the piece of his heart that would do absolutely anything for the boy beside him, including his family.

“Things will change,” he whispers.

When the paper accepts my story, your name will be cleared. No one will fear you ever again. No one should fear you. They should trust you.

Katsuki scoffs at this declaration, though he bumps shoulders with Izuku regardless. His smirk is a jagged cut across his jaw, smooth and pliant and always handsome.

“Well, tonight you don’t have to worry about that,” Izuku says, nodding determinedly. “Tonight we’re going to have fun! Because it’s Christmas Eve, and this is a special event for *every* resident in Augustana. And trust me, Kacchan,” he leans up and pecks the other boy on the cheek, earning a frustrated glare and spluttering noise from Katsuki, “even you will be impressed by the lights!”

Katsuki recovers quickly from his embarrassment, his smirk dangerous and familiar. He yanks Izuku’s knitted beanie down over his forehead, and smacks him in the rear.

“We’ll see about that, shitnerd,” he says, cackling.

“K-Kacchan! There are children present!”

“Sure, sure. Whatever.”

Izuku pulls back his beanie, and gasps as warm, tender lips meet his own. His lashes flutter, a small smile spreading across his mouth. He reaches up and traces fingers over the scattering of hairs on the back of Katsuki’s neck, right below the beanie his mother had knitted in a matching set for the both of them.

Izuku breaks the kiss and lightly taps Katsuki’s chest.

“We can make out later,” he says, giggling, despite Katsuki’s protesting growl. “For now, I want to show you things, and have a fun night. For just a little while.”

Katsuki’s snarky grin only grows wider, but he nods regardless.

“Fine, whatever.” His eyes never leave Izuku’s, a taunting, his tongue slowly swiping over his lips. Izuku blinks, blood rushing through his body and humming hotly under his skin. “But after this, you’re not getting away, shitty Deku,” he whispers, wrapping an arm around Izuku’s shoulders and pulling him close to him.

There’s a secret softness to Katsuki’s voice. It makes Izuku wonder just how long he’s been waiting for this, too.

“There you are!”

Katsuki straightens, but does not release his hold on Izuku.

“Uraraka?” Izuku cranes his neck, struggling to glance over Katsuki’s protective arm. “Ah, I’m so glad you were able to make it!”

“Obviously,” says Uraraka, smiling and bounding up to them. “Wouldn’t miss it for the world. We haven’t even gone to the tree lighting since you first moved here!”

“Ah, right,” Izuku says, laughing, “I forgot about that…”

Uraraka looks adorable, he muses, as he glances over her outfit. The pink sweater, black tights and frilled skirt are nicely paired with the simple red gloves, matching scarf and hat. As usual, even outside of their self-proclaimed “journalism office of mysteries,” she always appears put-together and attractive.

She grins and waves, and shares a content nod of her head with Katsuki. “Bakugou.”

Katsuki scowls petulantly, his grip unconsciously tightening around Izuku.

“Round Face.”

Izuku elbows him in the stomach.

“Ow! What the fuck—”

“It’s *Christmas Eve*, Kacchan,” says Izuku, grumbling, “can’t you at least be nice to her for one of the two greatest nights of the year?”

“Oh, don’t worry, Izuku, I can handle him.” Uraraka shrugs and strolls up to their side, wrapping her hands behind her back. “He’s all talk and no bite.”

“Fuck you!” Katsuki snaps, though even with the anger simmering in his dark brownish red eyes, there’s nothing resembling malice dwelling in those depths. “Whatever, I’m only here ‘cause of stupid Deku and his stupid lame-ass obsession with this dumb holiday!”

“You’re totally whipped,” says Uraraka.

“*Hah*? Say that again, Chipmunk Cheeks—”

“*Okay*,” says Izuku, pulling himself out from under Katsuki’s shoulders and waving his arms plaintively at the both of them. “Let’s just go have fun, with no fighting. You know, for once.” He grins bashfully at Uraraka. “I know that it’s only been a few months of knowing him, but—”

Then, he stops, blinking at the adjusting shadows and lights.

A dark figure drifts from the alley of one building to the growing crowd spilling from the sidewalk. It shifts and slides through the myriad of people in a distracting pattern.

He blinks, and the shape is gone.

A dark, cold chill rips through his body. For a single moment, the breath is stolen from his lungs, as if sucker-punched in the stomach. His vision blurs as his heartbeat thrums in loud, steady rhythm, barely loud enough to let him know that he’s still awake—

“Deku?”

Izuku swallows, and shakes his head. He glances around him, at the laughing, smiling strangers bounding towards the square in Redmond District, and the undeniable concern washed over his companions’ features.

“S-Sorry,” he says, breathless. Panicked. “I… thought I saw someone I knew. It’s no big deal.”

He wrings his hands together and carefully avoids Katsuki’s narrowing glare. “Let’s go! We’ll be pushed to the back before the tree’s even lit up!”

Uraraka studies him, frowning. “Izuku…”

“Really, it’s all fine.” He tugs at his scarf, blowing hot hair into his mittens. Uraraka spares a brief glance at Katsuki, who never wavers from glaring harshly into Izuku’s profile.

He turns back around, pulls back his beanie, and begins to walk. His short laugh is not even convincing enough for himself.

“Come on, we can’t lag behind on Christmas Eve! There’s still much more happening!”

Katsuki comes over to him in seconds, leaning in so close he can feel his breath sliding over his earlobe.

“Cut the bullshit, Deku. You look like All Might’s ghost came out and scared you shitless.”

Izuku’s throat bobs with apprehension. Both Katsuki and Uraraka were the boldest people he knew, and it would take the entire night to convince them that nothing was wrong.

“Who did you see?”

Izuku shakes his head. “It’s not important, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s frown deepens, the strain noticeable in his taut neck.

“Deku—”

Uraraka quickly broke in-between them, smiling too widely and innocently for Izuku’s liking. Though, at the moment, he was thankful for her intrusion.

“Hey, you two! Let’s just get closer and we can talk about this later, huh? It already looks like the show’s starting!”

Katsuki scoffed, about to retort, when Izuku gawks and points excitedly towards where the crowd of people have finally stopped around a circular peddle in the square. The rusted red and gray tiles all lead to a giant tree, taller than most buildings in Isabori alone, decorated with fine ornaments, glass lights, and sparkling garlands.

Katsuki opens his mouth to speak, but with one glance over Izuku's open, happy face, he shuts his jaw tight and looks away.

Uraraka grins knowingly, hooking her arm through their elbows and pulling them both forward. Katsuki protests for only a few seconds before begrudgingly falling into silence, though a small, gleeful part inside Izuku knows that it's mostly due to the fact that she's separated them.

Izuku leans over and smiles against Uraraka's cheek, her giggles infectious and sweet in the evening darkness. He allows himself to breathe in this welcome space, surrounded by decorated, planted trees in the district and the excited scattering of the locals. Even the timestamps and toll collectors have stopped patrolling for these special two days—one of many occurrences that Izuku wishes could continue to be practiced for the remainder of the year.

"Move over, Round Face."

Uraraka smirks, tapping her chin innocently and skipping ahead. She blends in easily with the large group of people in front of them.

Katsuki comes close to Izuku, arms brushing.

"I'll tell you afterwards," he says, a loose promise in the wind.

Katsuki clicks his tongue, keeping his attention forward and scaling the tree.

"The fuck's so special about this?"

Izuku grins, and slides his hand below his boyfriend's puffy sleeve to intertwine their fingers. Katsuki easily melds into the contact, the smallest twitch noticeable in the corners of his mouth.

"You'll see," says Izuku.

"You guys better not be snogging when it starts!" Uraraka says, calling over her shoulder with an exaggerated cock to her hip.

Izuku flushes red. "U-Uraraka—"

Katsuki quickly pulls Izuku into a kiss, his right hand cradling his chin. The contact, as if it's the first one they've ever shared, sends a bolt of electricity down Izuku's spine. When Katsuki releases, his smirk is far too smug, and only grows wider at noticing the shorter teen's embarrassment.

"Stupid Deku," he mutters.

"Dumb Kacchan," Izuku whispers back, his smile sweet and soft.

He looks up, catching the faintest glare of Katsuki's profile right as the buildings and planted, smaller trees around them begin to blink in synchronized practice, lights flickering and

building to something incredible about to happen.

Katsuki raises an eyebrow at Izuku's words, yet, much to the other teen's surprise, only stares and remains completely quiet.

Izuku's heart flutters in confusion and wonderment when Katsuki looks away to stare at the unlit tree, his hand tightening around his.

"… Kacchan—"

Then, a collected series of gasps rise from the opportune silence. Bitter, yet comforting winds sweep onto bare faces and shiver through the tender dusk. A fresh sheen of stars blink overhead against an inky black sky, each one twinkling like a spare set of Christmas lights.

The giant tree in the center erupts into beauty, and Izuku's joyous laughter is one of many that careens in the lively area.

Thousands of lights and decorative ornaments burst into life, like firecrackers on the Fourth of July. They glisten and sharply contrast to the grays and browns of the district, emitting pale yellow, green, purple, gold and even silver and red waves onto the gathering onlookers. Puffy jackets and knitted hats bob in excited jittering.

It reminds Izuku of many times he would beg his mother to join him in this very district for the yearly Christmas Tree lighting in Redmond. For the few events stationed in Augustana, it was one that many other residents flocked to the train for, especially when the tolls were apprehended and the regulations were dropped entirely.

The lights grow brighter as the seconds pass. He watches as Uraraka claps her hands, her smile undoubtedly gleeful with each second she turns and waves for them to join her. Izuku grins bashfully in return and gestures with a flick of his head to Katsuki, who still remains stagnant and stiff, as if unsure of what to do.

Uraraka winks knowingly and turns back around, a bounce in her heels.

Izuku scratches the back of his head, and shuffles in his shoes.

Katsuki had come to this event with him with no interest whatsoever, and it was one of very few opportunities they had outside of their shared home to avoid being chaperoned. Their parents watched over them like hawks, and his mother especially was not comfortable with the possibility of stumbling across them again while they were half-naked and kissing.

Despite his current mortification and shame at the memory, the startling shadow he'd glimpsed only minutes before returns to his vision.

He huffs out a breath, his grip unconsciously tightening around Katsuki's hand.

The shadow disappears once more, slinking further into the crowd.

What…?

He wonders if he'll see it again, traipsing by the lights in a cloud of false merriment and wonder. Would any of these strangers notice? Would any of them follow the trailing, malformed darkness like he was?

He knew it had to be a person, a figure crouched in secrets and avoiding him at all costs.

Someone was following them.

"You're muttering, Deku," says Katsuki, still not looking at him but squeezing his hand. "What's up with you? You've been antsy all night. It's just a fucking tree."

Izuku wipes his forehead. He almost snorts at the sweat sprouting under his hairline.

"Right. Yeah. Of course." He hesitates.

Guilt festers inside him. He wishes he could rewind time and erase ever looking away from Uraraka and Katsuki for that one second, just for the chance of not glimpsing some paranoid shadow in the dark.

Then, a flash resonates in the night.

It would have gone completely unnoticed if not for Katsuki breaking his concentrated, frozen state to wild and growling.

Before Izuku can react, the blond is already running off, angrily pushing his way through the crowd to follow the fleeing stranger.

"Wait! Kacchan—"

Uraraka whips around, barely catching Katsuki's figure disappearing into the bustle. Several men and women turn their heads. An eruption of confused, suspicious murmurs rattles into the night, flowing evenly in the bitter winds.

"What just happened?" Uraraka asks, coming over to Izuku's side and quickly grabbing his elbow to stabilize him.

Izuku slowly shakes his head. "I…" He bites his lip. "I have no idea. Come on, we have to find him."

Uraraka watches him closely, eyes narrowed, but nods.

“You better stop running, you twisted *fucker*!” Katsuki howls, yanking off his gloves allowing his palms to burst into ready, tumultuous flames.

His blood simmers with venom, anger and frustration riding on the oncoming wave of adrenaline constricting and pulling at his muscles.

His lips are drawn back in a menacing snarl, teeth flashing. Deadly.

“You’re not fucking getting away from me!”

Not this time.

The man in the jacket less than ten yards ahead of him increases his pace, arms flailing in wild patterns and camera hung formerly loosely around his neck. He has not glanced backward once to face Katsuki directly, leaving his identity hidden.

Then, Katsuki blasts off the ground, using a series of explosions to catapult him to the other side of the man. He lands on his feet, shoes scraping onto cracked concrete and chest heaving. He stands up quickly, a maniacal grin curving his lips.

“What, you *scared* now, hm? But you’re totally fine stalking us, taking pictures of *Midoriya Izuku* like some pathetic *creep*.” He spits out a wad of saliva onto the building beside him. The bricks look darker under the waning nightfall.

The stranger hesitates, bristling from head to toe. Then, he reaches up, and yanks back his hood, the scarf muffling his mouth and dark shades quickly removed to reveal the face of one person Katsuki definitely did not want to see this night, or any night.

“Meant no harm this time, Bakugou,” says Zeke, his long silver hair tumbling over his shoulders. Dark purple bruises underline his jaw and frame his cheekbone, the evidence of his fellow lackeys, Katsuki would presume. “Tolls are cut off, like expected. Was just taking some shots for the rest of the patrol when things get a little less festive, ya know?”

Katsuki snarls, cracking his knuckles. “You have *ten fucking seconds* to explain why you were following me and *my boyfriend* like some stalker, you bastard!” He steps closer, the tinier explosions in his hands sparking with life through each passing second. “So start yapping that ugly ass mouth of yours.”

Zeke snorts, affronted.

“This camera doesn’t hold just pictures of you and your boyfriend, Bakugou—”

“*Time’s up*.”

In seconds, the camera crashes to the ground, and Katsuki’s hand is pinning Zeke to the wall by his throat.

He squirms in his grasp, hands flailing.

“I know about your shitty Quirk and what you pulled a couple months back,” says Katsuki, low enough to rumble through gravel, a jagged smirk overtaking his lips “I also know that it requires a lot more than just skin contact to activate it. So I’m gonna play dirty, you piece of shit. How does that sound?”

He snarls, reaches into his pocket, and pulls out his phone, dangling the device in front of his captive.

“You see this? I have *dozens* of fucking pictures that *you* and your pathetic *partners* have sent to me through different phone numbers, and all of them point to Nero. I’ve warned all of you for a good long *fucking while*, now, that if I caught you pulling that shit, there’s no more waiting.”

He pockets his phone and uncurls his fingers, his right hand gripping harder around Zeke’s throat. The muscles in his right arm bulge under his jacket sleeve, carrying the strength and rising frustrations he’d bottled for months, the concern of Izuku’s safety reaching far past the borders he’d originally lain down.

“So talk, *Zeke*. I’m tired of this bullshit, and the longer you’re breathing, the more danger you’ve roused in not only this city, but around Deku.” He snorts, eyes flashing with false mirth. “That doesn’t seem smart, does it? Threatening my boyfriend with physical harm? With something as disgusting as *rape*?” He spitefully bites on the last word, growling and hissing into Zeke’s strained, pale features. “If you or that *Buzzcut Fuckface* ever talk about Izuku again, there’s more where this came from.”

He slams his fist into the wall, the explosion detonating and rattling brick and concrete. Shards split off and bounce over their faces, clipping splinters on Zeke’s broken nose and cheek.

“Pretty good speech, Bakugou,” says Zeke, coughing in his hold.

He squirms, but stops with each warning snarl from Katsuki and each tentative spark in his available hand. One twitch could very well end his life, and Katsuki is, at first, inwardly delighted at seeing such fear cross the mask of someone he despises.

“But, you ever think—ow, *fuck*—that, it’s not… ah, shit! S-Stop, uh… that’s it not just *us*?”

Katsuki’s jaw snaps shut. His teeth slowly grind and roll over his gums.

“*Explain*.”

Zeke splutters and coughs. “S-Shit, man—”

Katsuki tilts his head, and slams another punch into the wall. He is seconds away from salivating and growling with the mounting fire inside him, stomach coiling and heart lurching against his chest on sparked adrenaline and impatience. He wants to break Zeke’s face in numerous angles and listen to the crunching of his bones, and even then it would not be enough to account for the fury he’d contained for these last several months.

Then, a startling, whooshing barrage of heat assaults Katsuki's senses. He jerks away, releasing Zeke in only a hairsbreadth of a second, bounding and leaping away from the wall to skid through the alley. He tastes smoke in the air, singing the collar of his jacket. He yanks off the material and tosses it to the ground, cold air tossing back sweat and burns.

"Hey! What the fuck, fucking cowards—"

He stands up, body completely still, as he recognizes the feel of a hand barely wrapped around his throat. The gloved material encasing these fingers are unlike anything he knows, trailing in a chainmail-like pattern and disappearing into a long, ruffled black sleeve. The forearms are exposed, rippling with cords of slender, toned muscle, and the simple, silk material disappears underneath a deep black waistcoat.

If he moves, the gloved hand wrapped around him will emit the same sparks he'd tasted only seconds before. Swallowing, Katsuki glimpses Zeke collapsed on the ground, fumbling with his crushed camera, and turning within moments to flash a smug smirk in his direction.

His fists clench, anger rising like steam.

"You're much more gullible than your father, but, being your mother's son, I should have expected you to react this way."

Katsuki's blood runs cold. He squares his jaw, and daringly lifts his head to finally meet the eyes of his captor.

The expensive clothes form a bit of a mocking, unfitting cloak over the tall, poised figure of a man in his early forties. A strong column for a neck, the distinct tracing of freckles caressing high cheekbones, a rather welcoming yet teasing grin cutting across his handsome face, thick and wild auburn-black curls sweeping past his ears in a messy flourish above the nape of his neck.

His eyes are large, green, narrowed and dangerous.

For a moment, Katsuki believes he's glimpsing the near-mirror reflection of Midoriya Izuku.

"You're always so dramatic, Hisashi," says Zeke, brushing down his coat lapels. "But, guess you deserve some points for making that bitch shut up."

The man in question tilts his head, dark gaze running from Katsuki's hair to his toes. Beneath this inquiring stare, Katsuki feels the unbridled intelligence and calculated insistence that was so absent from Shigaraki, so devoid and detached from the likes of anyone else operating the underground in Augustana.

This man was a living legend, a dark urban myth in the underworld.

"To think my Quirkless son would worm his way into your family," says the shadowed man, lips curled in amusement and fascination with each second that passes.

It seems so eerily familiar, so uncomfortably tangible, that imagining Izuku writing an article with a similar, calculated expression makes Katsuki's stomach tumble.

“Zeke,” says the man, as smooth as silk and honey, “go back to the base. Tell Shigaraki that he’ll just have to be a bit more patient for these further developments.”

He crouches down on one knee, thick eyebrows curved towards the middle as he drinks in Katsuki’s statuesque, completely frozen demeanor.

Katsuki grits his teeth. If he bides his time, perhaps he can blast his way out of Hisashi’s vicinity and skirt along the walls. The rocket power will be enough for him to maybe coast over the corner of these two buildings wedging them in the middle. If he collects his patience well enough, he can form his own diversion and escape right underneath this criminal’s nose —

“I can see the wheels turning in your head.” Hisashi closes his mouth, humming lowly in thought. His free hand raises to grip his chin, another smirk ghosting over his mouth and revealing the fine pearls of his teeth. “Hm. What does my son call you?” He props his elbow on his knee, resting his chin in his hand as he stares directly into Katsuki’s unwavering glare. “Ah, right, *Kacchan*. What an unthreatening title for the supposed Bakugou heir.”

Katsuki snarls, palms sparking.

“*Fuck off*,” he bites out.

You don’t have a right to call him your son, fucker!

Zeke takes several steps forward, opening his mouth, but Hisashi is laughing before he can say another word. Katsuki freezes, holding his tongue with little restraint he has left as the much older, more experienced man cackles into the dark night.

“Ah! How adorable,” he coos. The sound twists something dark and uncertain Katsuki’s gut. He wriggles in the man’s grasp, unsure of the growing heat sprouting and wrapping around his throat. “You remind me of your mother. I wonder how she’s doing, as beautiful as she is. Was always a bit of an obstacle, though. I can see why my son would be… *amused* by you.”

Katsuki’s eyes flash.

“*Don’t* talk about him! What the fuck do you even want?”

“Hm.” Hisashi tilts his head. “Zeke. What did I tell you to do by now?”

The man in question turns stiff as a board.

“I—was going to—”

“You’d best leave. Would be unwise to keep Shigaraki waiting.”

Zeke immediately turns, and sprints out of the alley before he can be asked again.

Hisashi sighs, a long, mockingly slow breath. He swivels his head and addresses Katsuki with a mask of complete exasperation, as if they have been acquaintances for many years.

“Shigaraki never hires the smartest to operate underneath him.” He clicks his tongue. “Oh. I would also recommend holding back that flashy Quirk of yours. I’m sure you’ve heard the rumors of my own abilities as well.” His smirk reappears, a phantom smile that chills Katsuki to the bone. And with it, trails of smoke coast over his tongue and wade into the air, followed by a tentative spray of embers.

Of course, Katsuki thinks, grumbling. He’s heard of the rumors circulating around the legendary Hisashi Midoriya’s Quirk, especially from the detectives after his kidnapping. They had both insisted that fire-breathing was the best possible deduction of his Quirk, and Inko herself had attested to this fact with hardly any secrets left for her to devoid.

But with the heat circulating through this strange, powerful, oddly beautiful criminal’s body, Katsuki senses the intense power wafting through his muscles and blood. He knows that Hisashi is much more capable than releasing fire through his loose, smirking mouth.

“You’re a smart one,” he says, grinning. “I believe we have much to discuss, young Bakugou. Besides, I don’t think I’ve ever given any sort of blessing for you to… fraternize, with my Quirkless, *worthless* son.”

Katsuki snarls, low and dangerous. He strains in Hisashi’s grip, risking the inevitable burns already scorching into his flesh. He’s never been able to pinpoint the exact reasons why direct insults towards Izuku have driven him more haywire than anything, but the fact that this man, Izuku’s own biological father, would reduce him to such a state infuriates him to a point he knows he cannot return from.

“Oh.” Hisashi blinks, the same fascinated open to his features alighting in the dark brighter than any Christmas tree. “I see, now.”

Katsuki’s frown dissipates, softening his impending growls. He suppresses his confusion at Hisashi’s words, at reading the way the disgusting man’s smirk morphs into one of knowing, as if he’s come across a discovery that only he knows about.

He needs to be patient, and hope that Izuku and Uraraka do not follow him here.

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck!

No.

Izuku had undoubtedly followed him.

If that was true, then—

“Kacchan…?”

No! No! No! No! No!

Hundreds of alarming signals blare in Katsuki’s mind. He braces himself, throat straining to the breaking point within Hisashi’s powerful, ever-heating grip. He catches the glimpse of Izuku’s silhouette even in the cloak of nightfall, panting as if he’d run a marathon. Bright green eyes alive with worry, with desperation to find *him*.

And he had led him directly to Hisashi.

Fuck! No! No, no, you stupid fuck—

"*Deku—*"

"Oh, that's enough out of you." Hisashi's grip tightens on Katsuki, and within seconds he lifts the teen off the ground and tosses him to the nearby building.

He watches, apparently satisfied, as a deafening shattering of bones collapses through the shocked silence.

"*Kacchan*!"

Izuku, no, you stupid idiot, just run—

Katsuki chokes out, desperate.

He needs to grab Izuku's attention, to warn him to flee before he realizes what he's just stumbled across.

He barely catches the immense flames hurled in his direction in time.

He slams his hands onto the rubble underneath him and blasts off several yards, landing sloppily on his sneakers. He braces himself to the wall, not daring to glance over towards Hisashi, or even Izuku's undoubtedly worried expression.

"Deku, get *out of here*! You stupid shit!"

He expects another series of flames. He expects Izuku to argue with him as he usually would, always hell-bent on sacrificing his safety for him, his mother, his friends. He expects to be thrown into a verbal battle with someone he'd never believed he could care so much about in the short amount of time he'd known him. He expects another attack from Hisashi, but none of these occurrences arrive.

He turns, and drinks in the shocked, blank look swallowing up Izuku's freckled face. Beside him, Uraraka watches the entire scene transpire with confusion and uncertainty coloring her frown.

"Ah, you're a bit late, Izuku, but it's better now than never, I suppose."

Hisashi's voice slips into the cold, black air like water through a trough. It slips and slides into Katsuki's consciousness and alerts him to the consequences of what will transpire if Izuku doesn't wrap his head around the situation and run as fast as possible.

"*Run, Deku*!"

Hisashi rolls his neck and cracks his knuckles.

“You cower in fear like your mother,” he drawls out, that same insufferable smile returning, as if beckoning for the intruding teenagers to make the first move. “This is a boy you love, isn’t he? Are you really going to just stand there, and watch me bat him around?” He shrugs. “Hm. No matter. Would be best if you came with me, Izuku. We have much to talk about.”

Katsuki’s own cracked bones and pulled muscles are not enough to stop him from immediately jumping off the pile of rubble and dashing towards him.

Izuku will not be taken.

You’re not taking him away. You’re not taking him away.

He won’t let him.

He quickly dodges the first strike of spiraling fire, snarling and hissing to hold back the pained grunts from the blood welling through cuts and wounds on his body.

He stands, guarded, a barricading force in front of Izuku and Uraraka, a menacing growl slipping through clenched teeth. He bares his hands, eyes wild, twitching, a menacing storm building in his very soul and grasping ahold of what little control he has left.

“*You get near him*,” he growls out, halfway between a scoff and a laugh as he spits out a wad of saliva and blood onto the cracked cement, “*I’ll fucking kill you.”*

Hisashi’s features turn blank. Annoyed.

“Ah, this was to be expected, I suppose…” He sighs. “That’s fine, then. I wasn’t planning on bringing just my son along, anyhow.”

Katsuki barely has enough time to register what’s happened, when a heavy weight slams into his gut and the back of his skull.

Within seconds, his world becomes swallowed in darkness, with Izuku screaming his name.

Chapter End Notes

THANK YOU SO MUCH FOR READING.

Would ya look at that. Hehe. Papa Midoriya here for the WILD RIDE UP AHEAD WOOOOOO.

Would love to hear your thoughts, dear readers. Also, if you're curious about my first multichapter canon BakuDeku fic, check out my new work, *synthesis*. Would love to see you all there. :)

Thank you so much for reading. It means the world.

Will see you guys next in... most likely either *Alexithymia* for its conclusion, or the next chapter of *synthesis*!

Ultimatum

Chapter Summary

Katsuki rigidly glances away. The heavy weight returns to his gut, thick and molded like a bundle of steel cables.

Inko Midoriya's son is taken, *gone*, because of *him*.

Chapter Notes

HOLY COW GUYS. I can't believe I actually wrote this today. It's also 12:30 AM and I have work tomorrow so this was a dumb decision but when I started I couldn't stop, so... 7,000 words later we have the next chapter!

Things are really rolling.

Did I mention you guys are amazing? Because you are. Thank you. I can't express how thankful I am each chapter. It means the world to see all these new comments, kudos, bookmarks, ALL OF IT. Thank you! It fuels me and motivates me beyond anything else. I'm so glad people are still enjoying this story and are liking the turns it keeps taking. Believe me, there's more to come.

I really hope you enjoy this chapter. It's also my new favorite! So that's a thing.

Also I kind of love (read: really love) writing this rendition of Hisashi. I hope you enjoy reading him as much as I do writing him.

ENJOY YOU WONDERFUL PEOPLE.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The smell of burning plastic and rubber is what lulls Katsuki back into the world.

He blinks—once, twice, ten times—with his mind slowly following suit. His lashes flutter, an understanding dawning on him from the first stretch of square ceiling tiles spread out in his line of sight. He turns his head, and grimaces at the straining ache that shocks from his shoulders to his tailbone, sensitive and wrought tightly together like binding ropes.

What happened?

He groans, racking his mind for any indication of what occurred.

It was Christmas—wasn't it?

He and Izuku were supposed to meet in Redmond District for the annual tree lighting. They were supposed to be there alone with only Uraraka for company, despite his initial protests. They were supposed to be there until past midnight, shaking in the cold and grinning despite it all. He was supposed to be holding Izuku's hand while attempting not to blast it off with nitroglycerin sweat. He was supposed to wait until the very end and tell Izuku that—

Wait.

His heart thumps. One name, emboldened and caught in a throng of lightning, slashes apart his fading concentration and takes hold of his stomach.

Hisashi.

The soft, baby blue sheets draped over him knock about an alarming series of signals. He grimaces, worn fingers delving into a firm, white mattress. His lungs feel tight, a sudden barrage of confusion and toxic pain swelling up his insides and threatening to choke him.

A tall, looming figure, masculine and exuding nothing but mischief and power. Wide shoulders, a criminal grin looped into a dimpled cheek. A familiar splash of dark, sun-browned freckles. A childish shape to an otherwise dark and deceitful glare, riddled with intelligence that sparkled like butterflies. He had waded into the festive night with a Quirk unleashing smoke and embers, voice as smooth as silk and viper's poison.

"You're much more gullible than your father, but, being your mother's son, I should have expected you to react this way."

Katsuki's teeth grit. Fury builds inside him in a geyser, bubbling and frothing in untamed heat.

"I believe we have much to discuss, young Bakugou. Besides, I don't think I've ever given any sort of blessing for you to… fraternize, with my Quirkless, worthless *son."*

Katsuki's chest heaves. The sound of plastic tugging on metal directs his attention to the bandages on his arms and healing pads pressed to his skin. He jolts, sweat exploding across his skin. He bites his tongue and glances around him. Shocked. *Panicked*.

He recognizes this room.

"… Bakugou?"

Katsuki jerks up. It's not the voice he wants to hear.

Ochako Uraraka regards him with a blank, defeated look. She's sitting on the lone stool next to his bed, grasping at the hem of her skirt and worrying her bottom lip under her teeth. Her features have paled into snow-white, dark brown eyes puffy and swollen with unshed tears.

Katsuki glances away from her and over her shoulders. The walls are colorless, white, and lonely. The door to the room is shut ominously closed, presumably locked, and not one

attendant is in sight. He expects a doctor or a handful of nurses to buzz haphazardly through the doorway and badger him about the reasons he could be here.

Uraraka reaches out, and grabs his wrist.

He jolts, flaring and holding back a snarl and a stream of curses. His heart is still racing deafeningly in his ears, blood raring alongside it.

One question blares, unfocused and *loud*.

“You can’t leave the bed, yet, Bakugou—”

“Where’s Deku?” Katsuki asks.

His voice shatters the remaining silence. He watches, his insides knotting and dropping to his toes as Uraraka pulls her hand back, shuts her eyes tight, and glares off into the opposite wall. She bunches her hands around her sleeves, chest heaving in an erratic pattern.

“*Uraraka*,” he grits out. Bile rises in his throat. “*Where is he*?”

Uraraka opens her mouth to reply, when the door blasts open.

His mother storms through, her eyes wild and hair in complete disarray. Her eyes are swollen, redder than Uraraka’s, underlined with purple bruises. She stares, and marches over to Katsuki’s bed, her arms strained at her sides and open jacket flaring around her in a billowing curtain. Katsuki doesn’t even shift over, shock and anger pulsing though him at an unfathomable rate, when she grasps the iron bar so tightly her knuckles turn white.

“Katsuki,” she breathes, “what do you remember?”

Katsuki clamps his jaw shut, his mouth running dry.

“Where’s Deku?” he asks, barely a whisper. His hands tightly wind up the blanket fabric in his hands, heat simmering through his palms. He glares up at his mother, never breaking contact with her as his voice rises, like the mounting red bar in a thermometer. “*Where* is *Deku*?”

Mitsuki pales. Uraraka stares up at her, pleading, stern and strong and yet too frightened to hide the one emotion that overpowers the others.

Katsuki’s entire body feels caved in with lead. He remembers spotting Izuku at the end of the alleyway, his own bones snapping from being tossed into a brick wall. He remembers the scorching heat wrapped around his throat, Hisashi’s face and voice—so oddly familiar to the Izuku he knows—slithering into his eardrums, coaxing him to reveal secrets. He remembers hearing Izuku scream for him, desperate and, damn him, *scared*.

Fuck.

It’s his fault.

He steels his jaw, grinding his teeth to the gum.

No. No. No, no, no, no, no, no—

“Katsuki,” says Mitsuki, her hand paused in the air, as if prepared for this reaction. Uraraka steps off her stool, and Mitsuki turns to her quickly. “Get the nurse, or—*anyone*. Right now. His father and Inko are still in the waiting room.”

Uraraka holds her breath, but nods, and dashes off without another word.

Katsuki tears off the blanket and nearly screams at the unbearable pain scoring through his muscles. He shuts his eyes tight, nostrils flaring.

“Deku’s gone,” he whispers, lost in a ferocious daze as if hypnotized. “I have to get him back —”

Mitsuki grasps his shoulders and holds him against the bed. He struggles, incoherent, glaring murderous daggers into the doorway as if Hisashi is on the other side. He thinks of the bastard’s snarky smile, his taunting words, his powerful fire-breathing Quirk. A serpent riding on flames and casting them as easily as a wizard.

“*Katsuki*,” says Mitsuki, pushing him even as he shoves forward and growls, his strength slowly returning. She bites her lip, panic seeping low and deep into her gut. Katsuki feels her apprehension, her guilt and her worry, because she *knows* and how *dare* she keep him back while he tries to leave to find his Izuku—

His Izuku. His Deku.

“Katsuki, look at me—baby, please,” she breathes, holding him down as best she can.

He holds back only in fear of hurting her, of lashing out and burning his own mother. He glares and pushes against her, screaming as another jolt of pain zips through his bones. He feels his mother’s harsh breathing, her tough façade crumbling.

He slumps, the hospital gown airy and dragging on his form. He snarls and attempts to stand up, his vision blurring.

“Katsuki, quit being a brat,” Mitsuki says, harsh and grated. “You are going to be *useless* in getting him back unless you rest—”

“No! Stupid old hag, *fuck you*! Fuck all of you!”

Then, the door opens once more. Katsuki grimaces as sturdy, heavy arms loop under his shoulders. He recognizes these uniforms, these masked blue and white faces holding him under constraints and gently, yet firmly, guiding him back to his bed. He screams, an earsplitting noise that renders his mother trembling despite the way she holds herself as tall and proud as a statue.

“Fucking let go!” he snaps. “I’m getting Deku you fucking assholes! That bastard has him!” He stares, panicked and screeching at the top of his lungs, angry and *hurt*. “I’ll fucking kill

you! I'll kill all of you! Fuck off! You stupid bastards!"

He was foolish to chase after Zeke. It was a trap, meant completely for him, and he'd led Izuku directly into Hisashi's hands. He'd listened to Hisashi's taunts and fell, and now he continues falling, hoping for something to change and wishing he could rewind and understand the gravity of his actions.

What was he doing to him now?

"Tell Freckles I said hi."

Katsuki sucks in a long breath, eyes blowing wide with teeming flames.

Zeke. Shigaraki. Hisashi. *Nero.*

Their subordinates, their corrupted groups patrolling the premises of Augustana… all of it ties into them, and the apparent father of Izuku Midoriya is now delivering his son into their bonds.

Izuku could be interrogated. Tortured.

"I have to get him," he whispers, a growl rolling over hot coals. "*Let me **go***."

"We're working on finding him, brat!" Mitsuki yells, already reaching her limits. She's standing, tense and desperate, though if it weren't for Masaru's sudden presence beside her, his hand wrapped around her and holding her close, she would be tempted to fall. "But nothing is ever going to get done if *you don't get better*! Quit harassing the doctors and get back in the *fucking bed* before I do it myself!"

Katsuki snaps his head over towards her.

Their gazes lock.

The conflicting emotions swallowing up Katsuki whole spills into his every stare, every crinkle of his devastating snarl, every sharp tint to his eyes, every twitch of his fingers, and every bead of sweat rolling down his back. From looking into his mother's eyes, he knows she feels the same thing, from the top of her frazzled hair, to the lack of sleep dressing her flawless features in a messy scowl.

"Katsuki," says Masaru, unusually stern, "listen to your mother. Racing off to find Izuku's kidnappers won't solve anything, especially when we know that we're outnumbered. And you going alone will only lead to you being taken, or worse, *killed*."

Katsuki snaps his jaw shut, staring defiantly at his father as he yanks his arms out of the nurses' grasp. He snarls at them, bristling from head to toe like a perturbed cat. He spins on his heel, and points accusingly at is parents, watching as they both return the sentiment with nothing but molten steel and raging fire.

"So you're just gonna stand there?! Deku could be fucking—"

He doesn't even want to consider the possibilities.

Tortured? Raped? *Killed*?

Would Hisashi be aiming to hurt Izuku, or use him as leverage for contact?

“We’re working on getting a team together to find him,” says Mitsuki. “We’ve been a part of this scene far longer than you, brat. We know the stakes. We *know* not to take this seriously. But you’re *fucked in the head* if you think I’m going to let *my* only son throw himself into danger with no allies or methods to help him.” She sets her jaw tight, and glances away.

Katsuki’s fists clench.

“You’re injured,” says Masaru, rubbing back and forth on Mitsuki’s shoulder. His wife lowers her head into one hand, pinching the bridge of her nose and breathing shakily. “Believe me, son, we’re not taking this lightly. We can’t afford to. Hisashi has made his first public appearance since we were still active…”

He blinks at the collected group of nurses who awkwardly huddle by the beds, exchanging cautious looks in wariness of the rumor-clouded family.

“… in certain work areas,” he finishes, swallowing.

“I don’t care,” says Katsuki. “I don’t *fucking care*. Deku’s out there, and those twisted fuckers could be doing *anything* to him! The guy’s *Quirkless*!”

He usually refrains from spitting out the word as if it’s acid on his tongue. The amount of fights in the past month alone with Izuku while training in the gym was high enough for him to reconsider stating the fact. Izuku’s undeniable insecurities related to him being Quirkless became all the more apparent leading up to Christmas, and it strikes Katsuki now as the only time he can consider it a life-threatening problem.

Izuku is out of his sight, out of his *reach*.

“We know,” says Mitsuki. She bites her lip, her shoulders shaking. “There’s nothing we can do at this moment, but we’re getting things underway.” She shoots an icy glare at the nurses. “All of this is confidential, is that clear?” She doesn’t even wait for a response before she clicks her tongue and glances back at Katsuki, who snarls. “You need to understand why we’re putting down these limits for you. Izuku is captured, but we’re aiming to get in contact with Hisashi soon.”

Katsuki slowly shakes his head.

“The longer we wait…”

His entire body coils up like a spring.

He needs to punch something.

Masaru looks between his wife and son, a furrow in his brow. He opens his mouth to speak, but Katsuki is already stomping away from the both of them, yanking open the door, and disappearing through the gaping mouth of the doorway.

The hallway is littered with nondescript landscape paintings and a handful of empty benches. Katsuki curls his hands into fists, knee bobbing up and down. He glares harshly into the wall, every ache in his muscles and every strain in his shoulders, specifically, adding another jolt to his mind. His eyebrows and nose are scrunched up, a hidden frown stilled to a tight line through a constant myriad of concentrated thoughts.

He's barely aware of the shape that slips onto the bench beside him. His eyes burn from staring unblinkingly for so long.

The clock hanging above one of the magazine shelves ticks louder each second.

"He was going to take all of us."

Katsuki stiffens. His fingernails press tightly into his palms, scoring crescent moons.

His throat is dry. His gums are numb. His mind is racking up a thousand scenarios where he could somehow demolish and *destroy* each and every person who have haunted him for years as a Bakugou, and who have now taken one person he never believed he could care about away from him.

He doesn't wish to speak to anyone.

The girl beside him knows this, but she continues talking nonetheless, as if the dark aura wafting from his body is not nearly enough to push her away.

"You were unconscious, I think, but…" she hesitates, shaking. Breathing. "Izuku, he—god, he screamed, and I—I've known Izuku for a long time. We've been best friends for years. And I've never… I've *never* seen him like that. He was holding you like… like you were *dead*."

Katsuki sucks in a long breath. He doesn't turn to glance at Uraraka, and he doesn't need to in order to feel her body trembling like a leaf caught in a storm next to him.

"He was so angry. I… I was completely frozen. I didn't know what to do and it was… it's a moment of weakness that cost us Izuku."

Shut up.

Katsuki's teeth grit.

Shut the fuck up.

"I know that you don't want to hear me talk, or listen to me. And believe me, I would rather talk to a cactus than talk to you," she says with a rather striking bluntness.

Katsuki, despite her words, somewhat relaxes at this statement.

"But," she begins, tucking a strand of hair behind her ear, "there's a lot more to this than I understand. Izuku mentioned you were part of a big business, and I've heard a lot of nasty things about your family." Katsuki snorts at this. "People talk. It's a big city. Still, I know that you're not what I thought you were. I think you're incredibly rude, pigheaded, and Izuku is *way* too good for you, but," she pauses, "I know that Izuku loves you."

Something inside Katsuki flips a hundred times.

He jerks up, momentarily baffled and blinking rapidly as if he'd just plucked himself out of a daydream. He glances at Uraraka, watching as the girl brushes away a fresh sheen of tears.

His fists clench around his knees.

"Does he?" he whispers, unsure.

It's a question between them circulated for many days and nights, some spent in close proximity to a boy with eyes too bright and a soul too hopeful. It still takes minutes each time for Katsuki to read the sparkle in Izuku's mannerisms as admiration and respect, rather than derogatory.

It still renders him speechless to listen to how quickly his heart beats when he spots Izuku doing something as mundane as brushing his teeth, wearing a stupid All Might sweatshirt and looking at him as if caught with a hand in the cookie jar. They still stumbled awkwardly in intimate moments out of the earshot of their mothers, craving each other's touch with the lack of privacy.

When Izuku held his hand under the cold winds, their arms brushing, Katsuki had considered these moments. Had pondered over the unspoken words shared between them amongst the apologetic kisses and hesitant words of affirmation. Had kissed Izuku with the hopes of saying something more, lost in a sea of confidence and sureness that Izuku would surely return the favor.

It was a moment wasted, leading to a person he knows he wants to protect with every piece of himself, being stolen right from underneath him like sand in an hourglass.

"He's over the moon for you," says Uraraka, chuckling dryly. "I don't understand *why*, per say, but he is. And to your credit, the way you defended him in front of his crazy father… that was nothing short of heroic. So I'm sorry for not expecting that of you and judging you."

She shrugs, and her face is far too defeated and colorless for someone so normally jovial and vibrant. “You two are so dumb, though. I keep wondering who’s going to say it first.”

Katsuki cards one hand through his hair.

“Mind your own business, Round Face,” he grumbles.

“That’s more like it!” she chirps, lightly shoving him. He scowls, yet says nothing. Uraraka folds her hands in her lap, legs swinging. “We’re going to get him back.”

“Obviously,” growls Katsuki. “Stupid Deku…”

Fucking nerd…

When he sees Izuku again, it will take every ounce of him to not slap the idiot across the face and demand why he would even dare trade himself for the two of them. He’d known that Izuku was unbelievably selfless to a fault, and far too polite to strangers and enemies alike to actually present himself as a stable and strong offender.

“*Do* you love him?”

Katsuki snaps his head and glares with nothing but ice and contempt in his gaze.

Uraraka only tilts her head, unaffected. “You’re not scared to tell him, are you?”

“Shut the fuck up!” Katsuki snaps. “This isn’t the problem here! Deku is—”

“Captured,” says Uraraka, completely composed despite Katsuki yelling quite loudly in the middle of the hospital, “and probably being interrogated as we speak.”

“You don’t get it,” says Katsuki, desperately fighting the growing concern and loathing building in his chest. He wishes he could claw out his own heart and stomp on it to stop him from being so distracted from the mission at hand. “Those fuckers are deplorable. When they had Deku and I, we barely got out of there alive. And Deku…” he clenches his teeth, heat boiling and sparking into life in his hands. “This one fucker wouldn’t *stop* touching him. Taunting him and *threatening him*, like he was… I was…” he blinks, recalling the events as clearly as if they happened yesterday. “I was going to kill him. Deku stopped me. It gave us the few extra minutes to escape.”

He shouldn’t be telling her this. He shouldn’t be exposing the secret of what happened, of Izuku being molested and almost subjected to a much worse fate if they had not escaped.

He’d made Katsuki promise to keep the entire ordeal a secret and leave the other details as facts. His reasoning as to why, Katsuki wasn’t sure, but he knew it affected Izuku’s mother and the drastic measures she would possibly work towards to avenge her child.

He wouldn’t blame her.

He sneaks a glance at Uraraka, and watches as the shock on her features slowly evaporate into a red flush—pure, unadulterated *anger*.

He immediately thinks she should wear this look more often.

“They… they did *what*?”

“You don’t need the fucking details, Round Face.” Katsuki rubs his jaw, gaze becoming lost and dark. “Just know that it was fucked up.”

“Did—oh, god, no, *did,* don’t tell me they, or *he*—”

Katsuki straightens and uses every ounce of control he has to not yank on her collar to shut her up from her own rambling.

“You really think I’d let some bitch-ass Quirk hold me back long enough to let Deku go through that?” he says, layered over in a tone so low and gravelly he doesn’t even recognize it. “Deku’s no weakling, either. He chomped on that fucker’s tongue and made him bleed like the bastard pig he is. But it’s not enough.”

Should’ve killed him then, a voice whispers to him, *should’ve killed him when you had the chance. Otherwise Deku would be safe and sound.*

Uraraka slowly softens, but her eyes are wild. Fiery.

“His own father wouldn’t let them go through with that, would they…?”

“I don’t want to wait long enough to fucking find out,” says Katsuki, losing his patience. “There’s no point in talking about this bullshit, anymore! We need to go out and find him *now*.” He shakes his head. “Those bastards are planning something big. They have to be. There’s no other reason why they would bother having Hisashi called back to them. They want Deku for something, not just as a hostage. If he were just collateral, there’d be stakes.”

Uraraka opens her mouth to speak, but she is cut off when another door opens, and Katsuki completely stiffens as solid as a statue.

Inko Midoriya drags herself into the hallway. Her slippers slide on the tiles, hair messily swept up in a ponytail. Her cheeks are rosy and flushed, stained in dry tears and fingernail scratches. She turns, and stares at the two teens sitting on the bench with a visible swallow rolling in her throat.

“Katsuki. Uraraka.” She dips her head.

Uraraka stands up and rushes over to her, embracing Izuku’s mother in a gentle hug. Inko stands there, hesitant at first, but she returns the gesture, slowly running her hand through Uraraka’s soft brown hair.

Katsuki rigidly glances away. The heavy weight returns to his gut, thick and molded like a bundle of steel cables.

Inko Midoriya’s son is taken, *gone*, because of *him*.

Fuck...

“Katsuki.”

He jerks his head up, completely landlocked in silence. He stands up from the bench, an absolute mess in his wrinkled clothes and rapidly clenching and unclenching fists. He watches as Uraraka pulls back from Inko, the older woman smiling thankfully before turning her attention solely on him.

The look behind her misty eyes is unreadable. It chills him to the bone.

“We should talk alone,” she says, voice hoarse and scratched.

Katsuki only nods in response, the weight in his chest plummeting to his toes.

His wrists burn. If he twists them a certain way over the armrests of the chair, the chafing cuts and bruises burrow deeper and deeper—a scorching coastline over his flesh.

These ropes are pulled taught, far too tight, he thinks, for someone who doesn’t even have a Quirk. He bites his lip, the flesh littered with bruises to match the ones speckling the area around his mouth. He lolls his head back, his green-and-black flannel shirt in disarray and covered in cement fragments and dust from the brief skirmish in Redmond District.

When he’d awoken from consciousness, he hadn’t expected a location like this to greet him.

It seems like a lawyer’s office, or the main room in the center of a library.

He’s strapped to a dark mahogany chair in front of a freshly waxed desk, with another chair on the opposite side. A large window exposes the workings of the ocean outside, rain spattering the glass. To his left, numerous shelves are lined with the spines of many books, old and new, some fiction and nonfiction, and others riddled with colored sticky notes sticking between pages.

Kacchan…

He holds his breath, willing himself not to tremble. He knows that Hisashi kept his word, that his begging had convinced him to only take him instead.

He remembers Katsuki being tossed like a rag doll to one end of the alley, bricks and stone tumbling around him and surely breaking bones. Katsuki was livid, riding on the fire of his Bakugou blood and shielding him, *protecting him*, with the force of a person he’s grown close to over the last several months.

And Uraraka…

Please let them be safe. Please let them be safe.

He gulps down his concerns. There's nothing he can do right now, tied to a chair in a silent, small office space. It smells faintly of lemony mildew and cologne.

The sound of a door opening and closing leads to his heart leaping into near-cardiac arrest.

"Ah, of course, they go a little bit overboard with the restraints. So sorry about that."

Izuku's teeth grind.

He pictures his father's face, pinpoints the exact details that struck him the moment he saw him in the alleyway, and wonders how his mother could have fallen for someone so dynamically twisted and malicious. He'd barely hesitated in attacking Katsuki and nearly killing him, and that was enough to propel Izuku's desperation to trade himself for his and Uraraka's safety.

Hisashi slowly, tauntingly, strolls up to the desk. His bare hands are interwoven behind his back, his form of dress oddly casual in comparison to what he donned in on Christmas night —a crewneck cream sweater, black jeans, and scuffed loafers. His broad shoulders and calloused fingers are worn to the seam, exposing scars and cuts that echo many conflicts.

When Izuku dares to look up, Hisashi is already cracking open a book with a pencil held in his teeth.

His eyes are large, narrow and dark. A deep jade in color. A studded earring is pierced into his left ear. Faded freckles, far lighter than Izuku's, dust his nose and cheeks. His features are hardened and mature, a truly grown man, with one main differentiation between him and his son boiling down to how Hisashi's curly locks are lashed through with auburn streaks, rather than green.

Hisashi's grin is a jagged slope cut across his face. Izuku stiffens at the gleaming look, even as his father chews on the end of the pencil, sits down in his chair with one leg loped over the other, and snaps the book shut with an audible *clap*.

"So, Izuku," he starts, setting down the volume and leaning forward over his desk. "We have quite a lot to talk about, don't we? I have to say, it's been a long time since I've seen you. How many years now? Eleven? Twelve?" He hums in mock-thought. "Interesting how time flies when your life is taken from you."

Izuku slowly shakes his head.

"You're insane," he says, drawing in each and every detail of his man. Unbelieving. "You're not… you *can't* be—"

"Ah, the *no you can't possibly be my father* spiel? You should table that, young blood. Not a worthy ramble to tackle." He chuckles, his own laughter shaking his strong shoulders. "There's a lot that your mother refrained from telling you, I'm sure." He raises an eyebrow,

something akin to fondness flashing in his eyes. Izuku hates the look on this man. “How is she doing? I imagine still lying through her teeth about me, of course.”

“Don't talk about her,” growls Izuku. He doesn’t recognize his own voice, or the darkness underlying his own words. He subconsciously tugs on his bonds, huffing through his nose. “Don’t *ever* talk about Mom. You don’t—you don’t have a *right*.”

Hisashi’s brows raise to his hairline, one side of his mouth curling in amusement.

“Is that so.” He nods and leans back in his seat, far too casual. Too sleek. “I don’t have a right. Damn. You really do sound like that Bakugou brat.”

“*No*,” says Izuku, an instinctive response that leaves him before he can stop it. Hisashi regards him blankly, unimpressed, but he presses further anyway. “Kacchan is a much better person than you *ever* were, and ever will be. He and his family are good people. The Bakugous are much better than you and what you have planned for Augustana.” He bites his tongue. “Don’t *ever* talk about Kacchan like he’s—like he’s…”

Worthless. Powerless. Useless.

“On the contrary to what you’re probably thinking, my son,” says Hisashi, waving his arm, “I actually find your *adorable* little boyfriend to have quite the potential.” His grin incites something violent and undisturbed within Izuku, like a snake waiting to strike. “He reminds me quite a bit of Mitsuki. Strong woman. Beautiful. Never as much as your mother, of course, but damn, Masaru and I were the luckiest dons.”

Izuku settles into his chair. He needs to listen, regardless of the conflicting anger and frustrations coiling up inside him. The desire to flee is pushed aside for the opportunity he can use to listen to whatever information Hisashi will give him.

“Anyway, I’m getting a little off-topic.” Hisashi chuckles. “Ah, memories. Seeing you and that boy traipse about the city, acting all high and mighty in his self-proclaimed vigilante ideals… none of that really works, you know, son.” He shrugs halfheartedly. “I’m afraid to inform you of this, but,” he pauses, locking onto Izuku, “you’ve been wasting your time.”

Each word he speaks seems tailored together through oil and sugar.

Izuku’s glare hardens.

“You’re wasting your time trying to convince me,” he says. With a shaking breath, he puffs out his chest in a meager attempt to be somewhat standing in this conversation. “What do you want from me?”

Hisashi clicks his tongue, eyes sparkling with mirth, and maybe even amusement.

“I’m sure you know the answer to that, boy.” He shrugs. “You’re intelligent, despite you lacking the needed skills in becoming someone truly great.” He weaves his fingers together. “There’s a certain potential you have that is different from your *Kacchan*’s, if this makes any sense to you.” He only chuckles at Izuku’s enraged stare. “You are Quirkless and pathetically

weak, yes. I'm frankly embarrassed to see a son of mine stretched thin by his mother's babying."

Izuku refuses to wince at the harsh words. He steels what's left of his control, hoping that he can listen as best as he can to what valuable details Hisashi will let slip at some point.

"However," says Hisashi, "I have not given up hope in what little potential you have. Trust me, my son, you'll find that what I have planned for this city will impress you far more than what your mother or the Bakugous could offer." He tilts his head, just slightly, but it strikes Izuku as nothing more than feigned innocence. "You wouldn't want something to happen to your mother, would you? Or that pretty young girl you like so much? Or, of course, the little Bakugou *prince*?"

Izuku's blood simmers at the thought, at the mere concept of his mother, Uraraka, or Katsuki being placed in more danger than they already have. He wants to scream and throw every book in the room, and demand why his father would dare allow himself to be the sole source of corruption in Augustana, and threaten his former wife and son.

Stop, he tells himself, willing the silence over him, *none of those matter right now.*

"Just tell me what you want, then," says Izuku, controlling his breath to remain even and composed. He needs to, for all of their sakes. "There's no point in beating around the bush. You already know what I do. You've been following me, Mom, and even Kacchan for so long that you must know all that there is to me." He glares, dark and unforgiving. "So what are you even planning?"

Hisashi blinks. A second or two passes, until he breaks his calm mask and bursts into uproarious laughter, a single tear leaking out of the corner of his right eye.

Izuku straightens. Despite the incredulous laughter, he knows this isn't a good sign.

"Ah, of course," says Hisashi, chuckling, "you're so much like Inko. Brings back memories." He stares at Izuku pointedly. "Your heart is too soft to really understand the lengths of what Shigaraki and his goons will go through to achieve what they want. It's taken years of practice to undermine heroes and push them into retirement, and allow our control to take place in Augustana."

He pulls open a drawer in his desk, and flicks out a cigarette and a box of matches.

Izuku blinks as Hisashi removes an extra one and calmly leans across his desk, waving the cigarette stick in front of his nose.

"Your mom never liked it when I smoked in the house," he drawls, low and hazy. "Should take on a rebellious side once in a while and puff one with your old man."

Izuku turns his head. "No, I—"

Hisashi's strong hand grapples his chin and forces him to look forward. Then, the cigarette is promptly jammed in-between his teeth, despite his resisting. When Izuku continues shaking

his head, opening his mouth to get rid of the stick, Hisashi jams the entire thing into his mouth.

“Then chew on it,” says Hisashi.

Izuku chokes, coughing and spitting out the pieces of the ground cigarette stick onto the carpet. He winces as Hisashi roughly jerks his head to the side. The indents on his cheeks will surely well into bruises, and if this is only from the man touching him, he knows what’s to come if he continues resisting.

“Hm.” Hisashi watches him, lighting his own cigarette and allowing the stick to dangle between his lips. “Lot of work to do, I guess. Oh well. Should’ve expected it. Will take a lot of time erasing what your mother has instilled into you.”

Izuku yanks on his bonds, a sizzling retort boiling on the tip of his tongue, when the door to the office opens. He stiffens, and leans back in his chair, listening keenly as he recognizes the shuffle of hard boots on the carpet.

Hisashi raises an eyebrow. “This better be good, Nero.”

Izuku’s heart flips. His hands ball into fists, a nervous sweat breaking out onto the nape of his neck. Complete and utter panic seizes hold of him, and the flickering images of what transpired the last time he saw the mentioned teen sends a jolt of fear and ice-cold hesitation through him. He needs to remain calm, even now.

Kacchan wouldn’t let this get to him, he thinks, biting his tongue. *He wouldn’t let this bother him. Focus. Listen to Hisashi. Get every detail you can. You’re a journalist, aren’t you?*

“My apologies, Sir,” says Nero. Izuku swallows, picturing the teen dipping his head in acknowledgement. “I was informed by Shigaraki to come and check on you, and see the progress of your mission…” he trails off.

Izuku can feel his stare burning into him.

He catches Hisashi glancing from where Izuku assumes Nero is standing to him. A suspicious frown dresses his lips. Slowly, he leans across his desk and folds his hands together, knuckles rubbing over raw spots and his green irises growing cold as steel.

“Well, clearly, you’ve seen I’ve already completed my own mission. No thanks to you, or to Zeke, for that matter. Tell Shigaraki to fire that useless imbecile.” He rolls his eyes. “Complete fool who almost failed in gathering intel on the Bakugous. Was an easy mission for him. Should have taken a minute or two and nothing more.”

“… Right. Of course, Sir.”

Hisashi slowly tilts his head to the side.

“You seem distracted, Nero,” he says, jovial and compliant, as if they have been friends for years. “Have you met my son?” He gestures to Izuku with a smile that crinkles the corners of his eyes, as if attempting to mirror the image of what he believes a proud father would look

like. “Growing into a handsome young lad, if I do say so myself. For all his misgivings, he’s taken after the better genes in the family.”

Izuku’s stomach churns. He feels Nero’s presence coming closer. Sweat cascades under his shirt and stains his back. He refrains from swallowing even as he feels Nero’s body heat, and *hears* his clinking boots on the carpet, echo in the room.

“I’m afraid we haven’t been acquainted.”

Izuku blinks, his brow furrowing. He dares not look up to glance over Nero’s profile, to see if the man is being genuine or if he and Hisashi are playing a game. But when he reads the look of pure amusement and nothing else on his father’s features, he knows that something unspoken has lingered here.

Nero being here is a complete coincidence, and he didn’t know that Izuku would be present.

“I believe we’ve talked quite a bit for tonight,” says Hisashi. He crosses his arms behind his head, but does not seem fazed in the slightest. “Nero, since you’re here, make yourself a little useful and show my Quirkless son to his room. You know the one.”

“Of course, Sir.”

Izuku pales. He watches, nibbling on his bottom lip, as Nero carefully unbinds the ropes around his wrists. His actions are mechanical and purely driven by command, avoiding all contact with Izuku’s own skin. He holds back an annoyed grunt as Nero presses a knife to his wrist, a warning. He rolls his eyes, sends one last glare towards Hisashi, and obliges.

Each step feels heavy with the knife pressed to his back. His hands are tightly clenched at his sides.

The door closes behind them. Izuku is greeted with a long, rustic hallway decorated in tapered paintings, casual stands with flower vases, and a dark red carpet stretching from one end to another. Each door leads to a room that he imagines resembles Hisashi’s office, golden numbers imprinted on the outside.

Ten long, monotonous and heart-stopping minutes pass, with Izuku being led with a knife to his back up two flights of stairs, until he finds his back slammed into the wall with his escort’s hand wrapped tightly around his throat. He grits his teeth, gasping as the blade follows suit, the edge threateningly close to his cheek.

Nero is inches away from his face, but the look boiling in his brown eyes can only be deduced as—

Panic.

“Did you fucking tell him?” Nero growls, pulling Izuku away from the wall before slamming him back against it. Izuku winces, but shuts his lips and teeth tight. Nero’s nostrils flare. “Did you say something to him? Because if you did, oh, *Freckles*,” he whispers, “your ass is getting *skinned*. You peep a word to your pops about what happened, you’ll *regret it*.”

Despite his words, and how built and intimidating this squadron leader looks from a distance, he is shaking.

Izuku records these minute movements carefully as Nero grumbles and curses.

“Get off me,” Izuku grunts.

Nero gawks at this, a disbelieving laugh spilling out of his open mouth.

“You fuckin’ with me, Freckles?” He shakes his head, never breaking eye contact. “I’m not joking around, here. No more playing nice.”

He pauses, slowly drawing up and down Izuku’s frame, a certain spark dancing in his eyes. Izuku goes completely still under this stare, hoping that his panic isn’t noticeable with how harshly he grips Nero’s arm.

“Listen,” Nero mutters, seemingly lost in thought, “if you *ever* yap that stupid mouth of yours to your pops, I’m *dead*, got it? Whole shit blows out of proportion. Shigaraki and all of Augustana crumbles because two sides fucked up.” He squeezes around Izuku’s neck, a sadistic grin curling his lips. “You wouldn’t want that, would you, *Bakugou bitch*?”

Izuku strains in his grip, his hands tightening around Nero’s arm. Still, he glares defiantly into the other man’s eyes, and musters what he can into his longest breath.

“*Fuck you*.”

Nero snorts, almost laughing. “Oh, you some *tough guy* now? That’s cute.”

Izuku winces, as he is flipped over, his chest slammed into the wall.

He feels Nero close in on him, the knife pressed once more to his back. Panic seizes his chest and his thoughts become a jumbled mess. Tears threaten to break, but he remembers—

He won’t do anything. He won’t attack you. He can’t. It’ll anger Hisashi.

Still, he loathes how close Nero is, how he hovers a few inches taller than him, exuding so much obvious power and control in something he wants to completely break down when he can.

“Not gonna lie, though…” Nero mutters, a rough growl that sends goose bumps and a frightened sweat across Izuku’s skin. “Kinda turns me on, you know? You fighting back, getting all snippy…” he huffs. “Wonder what Bakugou would think if he saw us right now…”

Rage bursts inside Izuku at the mention of Katsuki’s name, but it is quickly submerged beneath the wave of panic at realizing the situation he’s placed in. He grimaces as Nero’s knife presses further into his back while the other traces over the slightly exposed skin above Izuku’s hip, where his shirt had gone untucked.

The touch shocks Izuku. His hands are white against the wall.

Then, Nero leans in, his whisper a ghosting caress on Izuku's earlobe.

Izuku's entire body *trembles*.

Stop, stop, stop, stop, stop—

"You ever rat me out, you'll *pay*, Freckles. Understand?"

And then, he backs off.

An overwhelming wave of relief, fear, and anger assaults Izuku at once. He is roughly pulled from the wall and shoved down the hallway. He turns to shout, to say anything, but is abruptly stopped at the gun Nero is pointing at him. The other teen is glaring, stiff as a board, and clearly as impatient and paranoid as Izuku had expected.

"Keep walking. Room's a few doors down. Don't try anything stupid."

Izuku glares, but holds his tongue. Exhaling shakily, he turns on his heel, and begins to walk.

He slowly reaches to place a hand over his heart. He breathes slowly, in and out, to calm the incessant rhythm of his panicked heartbeat.

It's okay. He stares straight ahead, his strides even. *You have an upper hand.*

He never expected he would have an advantage while under Hisashi's capture, and under the hands of Nero Edmure no less. But he does, and whether Nero realizes it or not, the idiot has just given him a possible first step to an escape plan.

He will just need to bide his time until then.

Chapter End Notes

Izuku's too smart for his own good.

What'd you guys think? Would love to hear your thoughts! Thank you so much for taking the time to read and support this story for almost twenty chapters now! Thank you, thank you, thank you, thank you, THANK YOU.

You're all amazing. Bless your souls.

Until next time!

Jeopardize

Chapter Summary

> “Hisashi clearly doesn’t care what I do during the day, given that he’s had me holed up in here with no rhyme or reason!” he snaps, holding back a thousand words he wants, no, *needs* to vent. “And you? You’re a sick pervert with nothing better to do than think about sex and threaten me this way and that, and I’m done with it. So leave me the *fuck* alone.”

Chapter Notes

> First written thing with new computer and new writing app. Scrivener is awesome, and this chapter is a little short but it is MUY IMPORTANTE.
>
> Thank you so much, everyone, for the support and love you've sent to me and to this story. It's my fic baby. :) I hope you enjoy this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“We need to figure out a plan,” says Uraraka, her hand resting on piles and piles of cluttered documents set aside on her desk. Pencils rattle under her tapping fingers. “Before things get worse, and we lose more and more traces of Izuku.”

Katsuki shoves the door to the newspaper office closed, his shoes caked in mud and dust. A backpack is slung over his shoulder, the zipper pulled down and revealing several strapped folders and paper clipped printings poking out of the mouth.

His hands tighten around the strap, jaw tensing.

“Obviously,” he mumbles.

He saunters over to her desk. The room seems smaller and far too quiet without Izuku, and the thought makes Katsuki’s teeth grind.

Instead of the missing boy’s usual musk—somehow a cross between pencil shavings and spring grass—Katsuki smells mildew and polished wood. He wonders, if Izuku wished to remain a journalist for the rest of his life, if he would bother clinging to this smell and wearing it proudly, a cloak similar to the writers he admired alongside retired professional heroes.

He exhales, a shaky drum beat sounding in his chest.

Focus.

When Uraraka had requested for him to meet her at Yuuei High School's newspaper office, he didn't even question her. The first conversation that brewed between them out of a mutual understanding, a phantom thread woven through with one thought in mind: *rescue Izuku. Save Izuku. Reach out to Izuku. Get connected to Izuku. Don't let him get hurt. Don't let him die.*

A tempered explosion riddles his hands. He rolls his jaw, nails scraping flesh, and flicks his head over to Uraraka in a small semblance of greeting as the silence in the room penetrates what he wishes to say.

"Can you…" Uraraka bites her lip, brow furrowed, "can you bring that over here? We can look over everything together, for a sign, or even a clue."

Right.

Katsuki shoves his hands into his jacket pockets and cocks his head towards Uraraka, who immediately looks from the top of his wild hair to the supplies he'd dropped onto the ground.

Her eyes are shining, swollen with tears. Red marks underline her cheekbones, rubbed raw from her own hands.

He tenses, counts backwards from ten, and breathes sharply through his nose.

"You look like shit," he says, throat hoarse and ashen.

"The mark of a dedicated journalist," says Uraraka dryly, snatching one of the envelopes sticking out of his backpack and tearing off the binding string. "We don't have to talk much. And before you ask, this is confidential. The school board is freaking out over Izuku being gone, but all of that is protected somehow, at least, that's what Ms. Midoriya said."

Katsuki pulls over a swivel chair, and plops down.

"Whatever."

He avoids Uraraka's pensive frown and pulls out his own set of folders. Licking his tongue, he flips through various pages until he stops on a familiar binding of pamphlets and old photographs, the sepia-toned figures in the foreground glimmering in a ghostly light.

"All of this is from my parents," he says, nose scrunched up. "Those fuckers think they know everything about my family, but they know jack shit about how many resources we actually have. We work alone, but our connections?" He snorts. "It all runs too deep for them to track. Even that piece of shit Hisashi wouldn't be able to track all of this." He reaches over, and points at several emboldened statements scrubbed under highlighters, whiteout, and colored sharpies. "All of that is marked for a reason, Round Face. Don't miss those details."

With that, he leans back in his own chair, and palms through his own collection of gathered notes. He rubs his chin every so often in calculated thought, nothing but

Uraraka slowly tilts her head, a soft smile waning a curve onto her lips. She looks away once Katsuki lifts to glare inquiringly, a giggle brushing up her throat. Soft and sweet, and irrevocably designed to prickle the hairs on Katsuki's neck.

"The fuck you laughing about?" he mumbles.

She hums, though it's a shackled sound—weighed down with emotions and memories Katsuki cannot see.

"You're just full of surprises, you know."

Katsuki quirks an eyebrow.

She stares, and sighs with a quick *snap* of one of her workbooks.

"Just, everything with you and Izuku," she says, her smile weak. Tender. "You haven't even yelled once since walking into the room." She shrugs. "It's just a thought. Nothing to get worked up over, you know."

Katsuki rolls his eyes, and swivels away from her to face the opposite wall.

"Wow. How mature."

"Fuck off and focus, Round Face."

They work in companionable silence. The occasional click of a touchscreen device or a computer keyboard shatters the quiet, but Katsuki is too preoccupied with glancing over his notes and printed out newspaper clippings to pay attention to them all. The several taglines printed under the *Yuuei Herald* indicate that there have always been something dark lingering in the channels operating Augustana, yet none of them ever directly pinpoint the Bakugous.

"Katsuki."

Katsuki straightens, and barely turns to look over his shoulder at the near-quivering desperation in Uraraka's voice. He doesn't want to console her, and he knows that he doesn't need to—she's proven herself in more ways than one, a pillar of strength that Izuku regarded as stronger and more resilient than he'd ever been. Katsuki's bias on the matter only wavered after he awoke in the hospital bed, panicked and sick in his heart and mind, with only the watery—*fiery, stone-cold*—eyes of Uraraka Ochako directing him towards something stable. Something physical to hold onto.

He would be grateful to her now, when they needed to work together. Needed to make things work, to retrieve Izuku and establish a force that firmly exposed the inner workings of Augustana without slandering his name, or anyone else's.

"Did you hear me?"

“Yeah,” he says, blinking out of his thoughts. “What do you want?”

Rustling. The sound of tennis shoes scuffling on hard floors.

“Do you think they’re… do you think he’s okay?”

Every muscle in Katsuki’s back tightens like strips of coiled leather.

He’d expected this question. This uncertain phrase, tempered in a veil of fear and concern. A very real fear, that he wishes he didn’t feel so intensely, so physically, as if his combined guilt and bloodlust turned into one vice grip around his heart and lungs.

He’d asked himself the same thing many times from the moment he’d woken after Hisashi’s attack and Izuku’s kidnapping. The feel of the blanket rustling under his hands, of his Quirk singing the blankets and singing the uniforms of the nurses and doctors restraining him without folly, had driven a firmer stake into his chest.

He’d wondered, when he was going to have to ask himself about Izuku’s safety even in this moment, when he had the chance to prove that he could handle the responsibility of a Bakugou vigilante at sixteen years of age. If his mistakes could be redeemed, and if Izuku—the freckled idiot, whom he hates to miss this much—would be willing to forgive him.

Izuku being taken from them, from *him*, is his fault, and his alone.

He slowly rises from his seat. His head throbs with another ache, teeth already grinding the gums down to a point where they would turn numb and bleed.

Uraraka is already standing, and he hopes that she doesn’t notice she is not the only one with eyes swollen pink and red, strung taught with the heaviness over the last few days of enduring the loss of Izuku Midoriya.

He clears his throat, awkward.

“Put down your pen, Round Face,” he says. “We’re going for a walk.”

Uraraka blinks, her eyebrows raising to her hairline. “Eh? But, no, we have so much left that we have to get done—”

“I’m not asking,” he grunts, rolling his eyes. “Jesus, no wonder Deku likes you. You’re both fucking workaholics driving yourselves to the ground.” He flicks his head to the door. “Get moving. Don’t have all day for this shit.”

Uraraka watches him cautiously, like a child observing a creature of the wild. Then, she shoulders on her coat, slips on her mittens and beanie, and gestures for him to lead the way.

“I’m surprised your parents let you meet me this late, with all that’s happened,” whispers Uraraka. She shuffles in her tennis shoes, hair loose and frazzled as the streetlamps cast a faint glow over her rosy cheeks and smooth doll eyes.

Katsuki half-shrugs, staring straight ahead on the silent, empty streets. Crickets chirp in the distance, the sounds swallowed up in the trimming of birdsong and the rustling of their own footsteps on cemented pavement. Each step feels heavy and limbered, bearing an unseen force that he wishes he could explode with his Quirk without the excessive pandering and the disillusioned thought that Izuku will appear around the corner of any building. Safe.

“They knew I was just seeing you, and heading straight to the high school.” He kicks a pebble away from their path, scowl setting firm and strong on his lips. “Not really a danger unless Deku’s involved…”

Uraraka fidgets nervously.

“If you have something to say, just say it!” he barks, snarling. “Jesus fuck.”

“Don’t be such a grouchy bastard,” says Uraraka, higher and sharper. Affronted. Katsuki quickens his pace, but he knows it would be foolish to think that she wouldn’t dare try to race after him and demand further answers. “I’m worried too, you know! Izuku is my best friend! I would do anything for him, and he’s trapped somewhere and neither of us have any leads, and…” she sniffs, wiping furiously at her nose. “None of this is ever fair. Why did *he* have to be taken?”

Katsuki scoffs, a bitter laugh puffing out into the cold wind.

“Like I would know,” he says. “We’re getting him back, so it won’t fucking matter.”

Deku…

Izuku is most likely locked away, kept hidden from the public eye, his name evaporating quickly in the streets of Augustana. The patrolmen won’t let the local residents talk about him, won’t let them speak openly about him in fear of having him recognized in a wider state. Those who are rightfully concerned about an innocent boy, a young journalist with dreams bigger than even his pathetic red sneakers, will be silenced on first sight.

Katsuki’s blood boils.

Nothing will stop him from killing every last bastard keeping Izuku away from them. He won’t stop himself from unleashing every last inch of firepower from his Quirk, as he thrashes whatever hall or yard or garden or wherever Izuku is being kept, in hopes of finding him and freeing him and holding him close so that he won’t be let out of his sight again—

“Whoa.”

Katsuki whips around, palms sparking and teeth gnashing.

Uraraka backs away, hesitant and defensive, though her gaze is soft. Pitying.

He hates it.

“Don’t fucking look at me like that,” he snaps, before abruptly turning back around and stalking ahead.

He never asked for her to start caring about him. Izuku needed her friendship, but he never desired it, and he wants nothing to do with the genuine lilt to her laugh and the kind flutter in her furious smiles when she talks about rescuing her best friend of several years.

“You look like you’re going to murder someone,” Uraraka whispers, shaking her head. “Listen, I know how you feel. Trust me. I want nothing more than to make them all…” she nibbles on her lip, “they better not hurt him again. They *can’t*. But Bakugou, we’re never going to take a step forward with this unless you trust me. I *have* to trust you because Izuku loves you and—”

“Stop saying that!” barks Katsuki, throat taut and tongue lashing with venom.

Uraraka pauses, watching him steadily, as if she’s dissecting each breath he takes.

She’s too observational, not unlike Izuku, but far less caring as to how it affects him. If anything, it reminds him more of his mother and father, and how they constantly break him down and piece him back together, placing their hopes and expectations and dreams onto him as if he can carry them until the end of time.

“Stop saying what?”

“That he—that he fucking *loves* me, alright?” He jerks away, fighting the growing blush spreading up his neck. He wipes his sweaty palms on his jeans, willing his Quirk to submit. “You don’t know that, so quit saying it. If he did, he would tell me.” He huffs through flared nostrils and glares viciously toward her, hoping his words sear deep enough to pepper her bones. “And if he did, it wouldn’t be any of *your business*.”

Uraraka whistles, slowly shaking her head without breaking eye contact.

“Wow. You’re a real charmer.” She sighs. “Bakugou, you don’t need to feel threatened by…” she gestures around her in broken circles, “me. Or, my friendship with Izuku.” Her cheeks and ears burn a bright pink, but she says nothing about it, even as she calmly steadies her pace and looks up contemplatively to the stars. “He’s always meant more to me than a friend.”

Katsuki’s glare lessens, but the competitive fire broiling in his gut tempts him to spur the conversation further, to question her on her standing with Izuku. Though, if Izuku knew about this, he would be more than disappointed with his lack of trust in Uraraka, despite the reluctant amount of respect he’s gained for the girl in a few short days.

“Also, I’ve done literally nothing wrong, so quit being an asshole.” She rolls her eyes. “Izuku is way too nice to you, and I swear, you’d think that you were a pro hero or even All Might

himself!" She giggles, crossing her arms behind her head as a fond grin graces her lips. "He… he has nothing but admiration and respect for you, Bakugou, and anyone can see that from a mile away. I don't really know what love is, if I were being honest, but I know from what I've seen, that whatever Izuku has for you, it has to be something really good."

When she smiles, it's basked in a new shimmer, something star-touched and understanding.

Katsuki swallows.

She reminds him of his mother, and it terrifies him more than it comforts him.

"… Sorry," he mumbles.

Uraraka stares at him, her face scrubbed blank.

"… What?"

"I said I'm sorry!" Katsuki snaps. "Take a picture, hah? it will last longer, Chipmunk Cheeks!"

Uraraka snorts behind her hand, her smile hidden behind the barrier she's formed with her mittens.

"You know that phrase is for when people stare too long, not for when they're listening to something unbelievable and totally not part of a hallucination," she says playfully.

Katsuki splutters and jerks away, ferociously rubbing his scalp and yelling harshly into the night. Though, for once, it's not submerged in the doubts and anger from the last few days, but a mild, charming anger he will gladly indulge in with Izuku's most beloved friend.

"You know," says Uraraka, smirking far too coyly for Katsuki's liking, "you *are* kind of cute when you get all embarrassed. But more like, the kind of cute when a Pomeranian barks too much and gets scared off by the first thing it sees." She shrugs. "Then again, it's pretty unfair that someone with a face and body like *that* has such an awful personality."

Katsuki grabs her beanie, yanks it off, and holds it threateningly beside his twitching face with one hand open and ready to ignite the poorly knitted yarn.

"No! Not my beanie!" Uraraka says, though she is still giggling, "anything but the beanie!"

"Then shut the fuck up!" A sadistic grin settles on Katsuki's mouth. "Or sparks are gonna *fly*."

"Wow, you are such a sadist," says Uraraka, but she swipes it away from him without a problem. "Okay, Mr. Explosion Man, we should probably head back before it gets too dark."

Katsuki grunts, rolling his eyes, but he nods in silent agreement.

"Sure."

He runs one hand through his hair, breathing shallowly. Harshly.

Just a little longer, Deku. We're going to bust our asses to get you back. Hold on.

"You trying to starve yourself to death, Freckles?"

Izuku ignores the prying question, and calmly slips a bookmark into the novel—*Emma* by Jane Austen, unfortunately, even though his love for literature never directed him towards any particular fondness for her work—that Hisashi had *kindly* left on his nightstand.

His rather immaculate meal remains untouched on a silver tray at his bedside, barely illuminated by the flower-printed lampshade. Salmon cutlets and mixed greens stir idly, like wilting plants on the plate arrangement.

He finally turns his head, raising one eyebrow towards the condescending presence of Nero Edmure, his self-proclaimed "watch dog" positioned at his doorway with a keyring twirling around his finger. He is watching him, golden-flecked irises scaling Izuku from head to toe as his own form of greeting that leaves Izuku's spine tingling and his toes curling with anger.

Quit looking at me like that.

"Think being around you will make me suffocate before any food kills me," Izuku says, bluntly.

Nero blinks, and barks out a laugh. It's a grating, horrible sound, and Izuku can't resist comparing it to Katsuki's.

It was always tasking, and incredibly rewarding, managing to break down Katsuki's defenses enough through actions or a minor conversation to earn a loud belly laugh in return, a sound so oddly musical and richly tossed in gravel and smoke. It's a sound he loves, that he misses, and it's so far out of his reach that his chest *aches*.

"You've got some tongue, there," says Nero, leering. "But I guess I already knew that."

Izuku stiffens. "What is your *problem* with me?" He bunches his hands on the blankets beneath him, his muscles strung tight with exhaustion and his eyes heavy from a lack of sleep. "Do you get off on walking by my room and harassing me like this?"

"Harassing?" Nero clicks his tongue. "Come on, Freckles. You know you like it."

"Leave me alone." Izuku's teeth grind. "Get *out*."

“Nah, sorry. Your pops has me stationed here for a shift, to watch over you and make sure you don’t try to escape through the window or something.” He shrugs. “Shame. Should’ve brought cards. Your old man is never a fan of cards, which is too bad, since no one minds being in his presence for too long.” He grins, halfway shrugging. “Makes sense why his son would look like you, except you're… skinnier. Weaker. Smaller.” His eyes flash, dangerous and taunting. “Easy to *snatch up*.”

Izuku’s skin prickles with lightning. His fists clench at his sides, his lungs constricting with the growing snap to his temper and the few restrictions he has left that will allow him to properly deck the idiot squadron leader across the jaw.

“Hisashi *clearly* doesn’t care what I do during the day, given that he’s had me holed up in here with no rhyme or reason!” he snaps, holding back a thousand words he wants, no, *needs* to vent. “And you? You’re a *sick pervert* with nothing better to do than think about sex and threaten me this way and that, and I’m done with it. So leave me the *fuck* alone.”

Nero tilts his head, twisting and flipping the gun on his belt in casual circles. He reaches behind him, and turns the lock on Izuku’s door.

“Wanna run that by me again?” he asks, a daring smirk cutting across his features. It’s a hungry stare, one that’s devoid of any playfulness, but completely written in malice and a sick, twisted lust.

He won’t hurt you. He can’t.

Izuku steels himself, and stands up from the bed.

Nero raises an eyebrow at this.

“Hm? Growing some balls after all, Quirkless?” he mutters.

“Don’t call me that.” Izuku’s stare hardens, licked through with embers and iron. “Don’t even talk to me.”

“Can’t do that, baby.”

The word flies off Nero’s tongue before Izuku can decipher it, far too relaxed and not at all like the intimidated man who’d led Izuku by gunpoint to this room in the first place. That was four days ago, and yet, it feels as if too much time has passed, and something unspoken has been crafted without Izuku’s knowing.

“Don’t call me that,” whispers Izuku, bile rising up in his throat. "Don't call me that, *ever*."

“Huh? *Baby*?” Nero chuckles, curious. “Really. That bothers you, Freckles? Calling you baby?” He snorts, and flips the gun out of his belt and twirls it in his hand. Izuku watches him, stiff and unsure, defenseless. “I can call you whatever the fuck I want. You have no power here. You’re lucky you’ve got Hisashi’s protection, otherwise…” He latches onto Izuku, pinning him down like an eagle swooping onto its prey. “Well.” He shrugs. “You know.”

Izuku's heart jumps into overdrive. Anxious.

"If you touch me, I'll do more than bite off your tongue," he says.

Nero snorts. "Don't doubt it. You know, it's a shame, really, that you're so caught up in Bakugou and all of his bullshit—"

"*Shut up*!"

Nero startles, clamping his jaw shut and glaring.

"The fuck?"

"Don't *ever* talk about Kacchan!" Izuku growls, seething. "Talk to me, or about me, fine! I don't care. But don't you *dare* talk about Katsuki like that. Like you even *know* him."

He's not yours!

Anger burrows deep inside him and surges to the surface, latching onto anything that will quell the rising fury he wants to unleash. He wishes he could set Nero on fire, or throw him into a wall, or do anything that would command him to stop talking to him as if they're acquainted, friends, or, God help him—*lovers*.

"… Huh." Nero shakes his head. "Damn. Real shame, kid. Real fucking shame." He watches Izuku closely, considering. "Wonder what you'll be like when Hisashi's done with you. You've got this… fire, that my squadron would've been real lucky to have." He laughs, bone-dry and chilling. "Shigaraki wouldn't let me back then, you know. When I offered you a free toll into Illenova. You should've taken it, Freckles. Things would've been a lot easier if you played nice, and just let me strike up a friendship. An alliance, even."

He takes a step forward, and Izuku immediately takes one backward.

"Oh, your reflexes are fast. That's good."

"Don't come any closer. I'll tell him."

Thump. Thump. Thump.

Izuku swallows. He needs to remain calm.

Don't panic. Stay strong. Stare him down. He can't touch you. He can't touch you—

"Hm. Maybe." Nero grins, and calmly enters his space, far too close.

He is several inches taller than Izuku, a looming frame that he knows won't actually touch him. Still, to feel him hover over him, to recognize the malicious intent in those burning gold eyes, to feel his hot breath trail over his neck and enflame a stream of goosebumps on his skin—

It's overwhelming. It freezes him in place. Suffocates him.

Nero's calloused thumb takes a curled strand, and calmly tucks it behind his ear. Izuku flinches, breathing harshly through his nose and staring in every direction aside from Nero's inquiring gaze, latching onto a potted plant propped on a spare dresser.

"I could take good care of you, you know," Nero says, soft and comforting, like a lullaby. Izuku briefly wonders if he's done this before, if he's enticed younger teens into his trust with a voice like this, with words that promise a sweet poison in a corrupted city. "Could train you, show you the ropes here, what it takes to be a squadron leader. What it means to be on the *winning* side."

Izuku's stomach lurches. His jaw clenches.

"Could teach you so much," he whispers, teeth ghosting over Izuku's earlobe.

"*Stop*."

Hit him! Punch him! Do something!

But his body is completely frozen. Petrified.

Izuku falls back onto the bed, his spine straight and hands desperately clenching the blankets and sheets. Nero remains standing, but his hands are now positioned next to his hips, his gaze far too taunting and *knowing*, lingering with secrets that Izuku must know, that he *must* pull out of his mouth if he wants to survive his imprisonment in this room.

"You've got potential." Nero grins, a salacious sickle curve.

"I'll tell him."

It's a pathetic whisper that betrays the fiery storm of his thoughts and emotions. A cloud drenches him whole, an electric storm zapping his muscles and soul and suppressing his actions behind a barrier that he can't feel himself breaching.

"Oh, but Freckles," says Nero, that cocky glint returning, "your pops doesn't care."

Izuku's eyes widen. Realization settles in his stomach.

But then, he spots something catch the light on Nero's belt. A smooth and metallic object.

Quick. Quick. Quick.

"You're lying," says Izuku.

Nero blinks, and pushes back slightly.

"You're fucking with me, right?" He snorts. "You think I'd make this shit up?"

"If you were, you would've tried by now." Izuku leans upward, scooting back from the other teen's entrapping body. "You didn't hesitate when you kidnapped me. You threatened to rape me, right then and there, in front of Katsuki." He wills himself to remain calm through those

memories, and hopes the panic rising in his blood doesn't visibly shake him. "You wouldn't risk that at this point. Hisashi wouldn't change his mind about something like this that you yourself called severe just a few days ago."

Nero snorts, though he doesn't recede. Instead, he lowers himself onto the blankets, elbows and forearms propped on the blankets, his gaze steady and focused. Watching him.

"You're a smart fucker," he grumbles. "I'm impressed."

"Then you're easily impressed." Izuku's palms begin to sweat. "If you don't leave, I'll tell him about that night."

Nero stiffens, but only slightly. It's a subdued reaction, one that doesn't give Izuku enough leeway for his expectations, but he takes it in as something useful nonetheless.

"Kiss me," he says, "and I'll give my shift to Zeke for the next few days."

Izuku's laugh is bitter and hollow when he glares and mutters: "*No*. Over my dead body."

"If you don't," says Nero, far too blasé, "I'll find Bakugou and your girly friend, and kill them. No one will miss their nosy mugs."

Izuku pales.

Uraraka and Kacchan…?

No. He has to be bluffing, Izuku reasons. How could he know—

"We've been tracking 'em." Nero smirks. "You mumble a lot, you know." He taps his finger on his temple, a gesture that unsettles Izuku more than it bemuses him. "You forget we operate all underground channels in Augustana. Your boyfriend and that cute girl won't make it far in Illenova without treading past *my* territory."

No…

And, Uraraka and Katsuki would definitely already be trying to find him. Trying to decrypt the mystery surrounding why Izuku was being contained in the first place. His patience had already worn thin after a few days of being kept in this locked room with people like Nero Edmure watching his every movement and monitoring him like a mouse trapped in a labyrinth.

"So what's it gonna be, Freckles?"

Izuku eyes the technical instrument strapped to Nero's belt, and then back to the squadron leader as he dares to inch closer on the bed, but at a safe enough distance for an impending conversation to take place. An uneasy sickness grows and twists into knots inside Izuku, deep and prodding, like claws strapped in sponges.

"I…"

He holds his breath, and exhales.

One step at a time.

He mentally nods, reaffirming his private thoughts, the many details he'd run over with the absence of these people watching him constantly.

Kacchan and Uraraka will be safe if you do this. One step at a time. One step at a time.

"Fine," he mutters, though the word itself feels like a spike of betrayal surging deep into his gut.

I'm so sorry, Kacchan.

Nero's eyes widen, his grin turning feral and predatory.

"*Perfect*," he purrs, and then he's on top of Izuku, his lips and teeth slamming onto his.

Izuku refuses the instinct to bite, grimacing at the uncomfortable invasion of the other's tongue into his mouth. He straightens his back and grunts at the impact of the other teen's weight, all muscle and reckless aggression, riddled with a pathetic desperation that Izuku spitefully mocks as he's locked in a cage he wants to escape.

Nero's hands are *everywhere*, pinching and pulling and grabbing around his legs.

It's disgusting, and vile, but it's just this once.

Then, Nero's mouth pops off of him and dives onto his neck.

"What are you—"

Izuku gasps, his eyes ripe with *fury* and pain as Nero's teeth sink into his flesh and easily puncture into a blooming purple bruise. He knows the spot is bleeding, and he hates himself even more for letting this happen.

With Nero's head ducked into his clavicle, however, Izuku spots his target.

One step at a time.

"Damn, Freckles," whispers Nero, out of breath and *moaning* in a way that makes Izuku shiver in revulsion. "Gotta mark you up—"

No!

Izuku slams his knee into Nero's ribs, effectively shutting him up.

"You got your kiss!" Izuku snaps, and promptly rams his other knee into Nero's stomach. "Now get the *fuck* off me!"

He watches in blind, angry satisfaction, as the other teen stumbles backward, although his appeased smirk completely boils down the moment of victory Izuku was feeling.

Nero watches him, slowly, tauntingly, as he saunters off the bed, wiping his mouth.

“A deal’s a deal,” he says, voice hoarse and drunk with lust. He stares at the bite mark on Izuku’s shoulder, clear and viciously imprinted, as if a dog had chosen to maul him. Blood drips down the bare flesh and disappears into his collared button-up. “Gonna be hard leaving you here when you’re so…” he licks his lips, “*pretty*. But, I’m a man of my word.”

Izuku glances away, ashamed.

Kacchan…

Katsuki would be furious if he knew what just happened.

One step at a time, he tells himself.

“Get out,” he whispers.

“Sure, sure.” Nero brushes him off. He clips on his gun, grabs the key to Izuku’s bedroom, and opens the door with a few inches of light spilling into the room. “By the way, Papa Midoriya wanted you to show up for breakfast or something tomorrow. Gonna show you some special behind the scenes nonsense. Zeke will escort you.” He grins and shrugs on his long rain jacket, a shadow surely readying himself for an evening patrol in Illenova. “Try not to dream of me, Freckles.”

When he disappears, a sob bobs up in Izuku’s throat, like a buoy in the middle of an ocean.

“Don’t cry, Izuku,” he mutters, choked on his own anger, on his own frustration. “You had to do it,” he adds, though the voice inside him insists he could have done it some other way. “They’ll—he’ll understand.”

The doubt lingers. A festering, slithering snake striking venom into his mind’s eye.

He doesn’t want to think of how Katsuki will feel, when he finds out that the bite marks newly engraved into his skin against his will do not belong to him.

He could have bought more time for Katsuki and Uraraka if he’d distracted Nero more.

Though, carefully, with Nero finally gone, Izuku calmly reaches under his shirt, and pulls out the metallic object he’d plucked from the other teen’s belt.

He wipes the growing tears from his eyes and looks over the device, a small smile forming on his lips.

“Bingo,” he mutters, flipping open the cell phone and cautiously glancing over the intricate numbers and paneled design. “What kind of phone is this…?” He rubs his temple, glaring into the screen and counting off the many names of the Illenova squadron that form a complete list. He looks over the numbers and the odd symbols associated with them, and groans. “It doesn’t have an antenna… but it looks more than fifteen years old… were these specifically designed for the Augustana squadrons?”

It would make sense, he supposes, if the expectations for the local squadrons relied solely on mutual communication. The numbers are formatted in patterns rather than in order, with certain symbols pertaining to the Illenova District in particular.

Cautiously, Izuku presses a button.

“Strange,” he grumbles. “I can send a message through here…”

Then, his eyes brighten with an idea. A surge of hope sweeps through him in a tidal wave.

“I can do this,” he says, and quickly, he leaps off his bed to clamber at the nightstand, pulling out a spare pen and piece of notepad paper sandwiched between the Jane Austen novel’s pages. “Okay, okay. Draw it out. Piece it together. Figure out the patterns.”

He will need to contact someone before Nero realizes the device on his belt is missing.

He can’t dial a fully functioning phone number, but he can create a pattern that spells out a number. Maybe, just maybe, it will work.

He presses several buttons and sketches out the patterns onto the piece of paper. He scrunches nose and bites his lip in concentration, hoping that certain combinations that create certain numbers aren’t lost in the scattered fray. Carefully, he sets down the piece of paper with the combinations listed out, with several symbols and dots indicating the numbers 1 through 9.

Shaking, Izuku presses in a combination, and holds the device up to his ear. His heart is racing, a jackhammering force under the protective bones of his ribcage.

Then, the line picks up.

“Whoever this is, don’t you dare fucking call this number again—”

“Kacchan!” Izuku says, delighted and feeling lighter than air for the first time since seeing him.

Recognizing the other’s voice welcomes a sense of relief far greater than anything he’d felt before.

A heavy rustling noise and a loud *thump* bounces off the other end, followed by a heavy string of curses and a desperate fumbling to grasp ahold of what Izuku imagines is Katsuki’s phone.

“Izuku?”

Izuku’s heart flutters at hearing his name.

“Kacchan, yes—I—it’s me, oh my god, I’m so glad you’re okay—is Uraraka okay too? Oh man, I—Kacchan, *Katsuki*, I’m so happy to hear your voice—”

“Fuck. Fuck, Izuku…”

Izuku wonders if Katsuki had fallen asleep while working. Hair rumpled and eyes heavy with exhaustion, that stubborn scowl twisting up his lips and his features handsomely and with little restraint.

He wants to see him. Touch him. Kiss him.

His hand shakes around the makeshift phone pressed to his ear. He wipes at his nose, tears of relief streaking his cheeks and blurring his vision of the lampshade on his nightstand.

"*Izuku. Deku. Thank fuck! Are you—are you alright? Where the fuck are you? Where did those fucking bastards take you?"*

He sounds tired, angry, and relieved all at once.

"I'm okay." Izuku gulps, sighing to steady himself. "I don't… I don't know how much time I have. I took this off of Nero—"

"What?!"

"—and he was just here, and he's going to notice it's gone soon so I have to tell you all of this quickly—," Izuku halts, dragging one hand down his face. "I don't have much time, Kacchan. I'm already working a plan to escape, so don't worry about that!"

"Did he—Deku, did he touch you? Is he hurting you?"

Nothing but fury and fire envelops Katsuki's voice, like molten lava in Izuku's soul. It's an infectious feeling, one that motivates him even more to escape this place and prove that he can handle himself without being a burden to the Bakugou vigilantes.

Izuku worries his bottom lip, hesitating.

Don't tell him. Not now. It won't help.

"I… he can't touch me, because it will anger Hisashi," he says. "Kacchan, I don't know where I am, but it might be somewhere in Illenova, since Nero and Zeke are here so often. I haven't seen the other squadrons and I'm not even sure if they're working for Hisashi. This isn't even really a phone that I'm calling you on, it's… I'm not sure what it is. But, you have to find a way to get into contact with Shigaraki or Hisashi without them knowing it's from you!"

"We're working on it, Deku. Round Face is aiming for the kill."

Izuku's heart warms at this.

"Is she okay? Are you both safe?"

"She's fine."

Izuku bites his tongue. "Kacchan, I want you to make sure that you're all safe, and that—"

“Don’t fucking worry about us, Deku! I’m gonna get you out of there, and I’m going to murder those fucking sons of bitches for taking you away.”

Izuku chuckles at this, solemn and detached.

“I miss you,” he whispers.

There’s a pause on the other end. Izuku’s chest tightens with worry.

“Kacchan? Was that—I’m sorry, was that too much—”

“Fuck.”

It’s the first time Katsuki has sounded so close to being broken.

“Katsuki…” Izuku tilts his head, picturing the other’s face, sullen and angry and frustrated. “It’s okay. It will be okay. And you’re okay. I’m so, so happy you’re safe.”

“… Izuku, I need to—”

Izuku jolts up to his feet as the door to his bedroom swings open, landing an audible crack on the wall.

“Trace these coordinates if you can, Kacchan,” says Izuku hastily, trembling from head to toe.

Nero stands there, steam practically rising from his sweating form. He looks as if he’s run a marathon, his ferocious glare and bared teeth focused entirely on Izuku.

“Think you have something of mine,” Nero growls coldly, cracking like marble. “Wasn’t a very smart thing to do, you fucking *whore*.”

He pulls out a baton slung against his belt, the item sparking with blue electric bolts.

“No—wait, no, fuck, Deku, don’t hang up—”

Izuku braces himself, and quickly shuts the device shut, blocking off Katsuki’s voice.

I’m sorry, Kacchan.

He stares at Nero, and swallows.

“Do your worst.”

Chapter End Notes

... SO THAT'S A THING.

Got a lot of psychological stuff going on.

Believe it or not, Nero is actually heavily based off of someone I knew in real life. Scary stuff, huh?

Thanks so much again and thank you for commenting!

Camouflage

Chapter Summary

> “Mitsuki.” Yagi’s voice is a blade of ice in the warm quiet. “May I talk with your son alone?”

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all so much for your continued support! I knew the last chapter ruffled a lot of feathers, and it was SUPPOSED TO. So I'm glad it did! Hopefully you enjoy some of these newer developments coming up! I love how vocal you all are about how much you hate Nero. It's great. Also, you're all amazing. Did I already say that? Because you are.
>
> Thank you so much. Thank you. Thank you. THANK YOU.
>
> Here's the next chapter. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“So, you’re saying that he didn’t call you from a phone?”

Before Katsuki can scream out another demand—his throat scratched from hours of harsh, desperate yelling into phone calls and thrashing about in his own home—his mother bolts up from the chair, and slams one hand on the desk.

On the other side, Yagi Toshinori coughs into his fist, frosty blue eyes drifting back and forth between Mitsuki and Katsuki—a mother and son pair that none would ever want to trifle with.

Katsuki’s chest puffs out, his hands impossibly tight around the arm rests of his chair.

“Katsuki was able to record exactly what Izuku was saying over the line,” says Mitsuki. “Shouldn’t that be fucking enough, Yagi? You and Tsukauchi have been at this for how long, now?”

She runs one hand through her hair, glaring harshly into the wide windowpane cracked open on the wall. Outside, songbirds gently chortle in the distance, as if attempting to calm her and the firecracker rage building slowly up inside Katsuki.

Yagi interweaves his fingers, settling his hands on his desk with a tightly set jaw.

“We have been extending our search into Illenova, but we have less…” he gestures vaguely in the air, “resources, when Augustana’s government is not on our side. Tsukauchi is a certified detective, but if we were discovered for conspiring against the inner workings running Augustana, then we could very well be put on trial. On top of your entire family, Mrs. Bakugou, being placed on the execution block as well.”

Mitsuki’s nose scrunches. She huffs, brushing her hands down her pencil skirt.

Katsuki’s glare is sharp as daggers, unforgiving towards the one man he had hoped to understand their current ordeal, to take an extra step further into rescuing Izuku.

“Then you’re a fucking coward,” he bites out. “What good are you, if you can’t even save *one* kid? One *fucking* teenager?” He spits onto the table, lifting his head high—cocky, shielding. He feels detached without Izuku at his side, reprimanding him for his disrespect like an endearing leech, though he despairs over the thought when it occurs. “We don’t need detectives like you! You’re just wannabe posers trying to live off like heroes! Like vigilantes! Well Pro Heroes are fucking gone and Izuku could be getting hurt the longer we talk about this!”

Mitsuki smacks him in the back of the head.

He refuses to look up at her, to let her know of the anguish swimming behind his eyes. He grits his teeth, scoffs, and pushes himself out of the chair. Yagi’s stare burns into him, prickling the hairs on the back of his neck.

“He’s worried,” says Mitsuki. An apology. An excuse.

The silence that follows is thick enough to bind into ropes.

Katsuki’s fingers find shelter in his pockets, clammy and threatening to combust into his Quirk in any moment. He stares out, listening to the slight bustle of the cars rumbling below. The stench of asphalt and cigarettes wafts through his nose, an inescapable perfume of the Redmond District.

“Mitsuki.” Yagi’s voice is a blade of ice in the warm quiet. “May I talk with your son alone?”

Mitsuki’s hesitation is palpable. He doesn’t need to hear the clacking of her heels as she turns to him, watching him, reading him as if he was still five years old. Still attempting to escape the metal bunker in their hideout in Russia, desperate to form an established leadership with the children in their small, cornered neighborhood. He doesn’t need to turn, to recognize the natural protectiveness contort the beauty of her face, from the fire in her eyes to the softness of her smile.

“Yes,” she finally says. “Inko is waiting for me, anyway.”

Katsuki almost snorts.

She’d mentioned Izuku’s mother on purpose.

The door closes, inviting another bout of silence.

“Young Katsuki, there is clearly a lot on your mind. Please, sit.”

Fuck you.

Was Izuku alright? Was he being attacked? Tortured?

His heart jumps into a steady crackle of lightning. He flinches, and almost shouts when Yagi’s hand rests on his shoulder.

There’s nothing left in him to fight the need to stare at their faded reflections in the window glass. His tongue is dry, hardly capable of tasting how dehydrated and exhausted he is. He hadn’t been able to sleep after Izuku successfully contacted him, and cut off right when he was placed in more danger—

“Breathe.”

Katsuki shrugs off his hand, stiff.

“You don’t—don’t *patronize* me.”

He growls, a warning, and refuses to turn and acknowledge the clear pity and understanding dwelling in those bright blue eyes. He wishes he wouldn’t feel the instinctual need to tilt his head, to show some form of action that indicated he was listening.

He had no interest in being around this skinny older man when he seemed hardly helpful in the slightest.

“You care strongly for him, despite the short amount of time you’ve known each other.”

Yagi laughs, and it carries sweetly, almost hollowly. A ghost of a song once held in better times, and for reasons Katsuki can’t explain it elicits a fresh trail of goosebumps to pop on his collarbone.

“Doesn’t matter how long,” grumbles Katsuki.

Not like I expected to fall for the shitty nerd so fast.

Or at all, he adds, quietly.

Yagi hums in thought, a perceptible sound riddled in many hidden answers. “There is something I do need to talk to you and your family about, however. But, we will go over those details later, when we’re all present. And Inko will want to be around for those developments as well.” He rubs his hands together, grinning cheerily towards Katsuki as he raises an eyebrow in return. “Do you enjoy coffee or tea, young Bakugou? I have many to choose from.”

Katsuki blinks. He focuses on a cobwebbed corner in the room, sandwiched between two bookshelves, before nodding awkwardly.

“Uh. Sure.”

He's ushered back to the chair propped in front of Yagi's desk, not without protesting at least once or twice. The cushioned seat settles under his weight, and before long he allows his gaze to flit about the room, and he wonders if there's a particular reason Yagi asked for his mother to leave.

His brow furrows, cautious.

Yagi hums a tune under his breath, hunched over an electronic teakettle by the window with two plain white mugs. His movements are bony, all weathered skin and muscle strapped tightly over bone. Katsuki wonders how a man like this could have ever succeeded in the police force, or grabbed a somewhat secretive position as an assistant to the former chief of police.

"Any preferences?" Yagi asks, pouring himself freshly brewed coffee. The smell wafts in the air and wrinkles Katsuki's nose—he's never truthfully enjoyed coffee.

"… Earl Grey," he grumbles.

"Ah, good choice," says Yagi, his smile and eyes equally soft. For a moment, it reminds Katsuki of Izuku, and his chest clutches in reflex. "I will have that ready for you shortly, before we dive into more important matters."

Katsuki mumbles his thanks once Yagi hands him the warm mug. The warmth seeps into his palms, calming what left he has of his unkempt, rattled nerves. Meandering thoughts stir like the very leaves in his cup, spurring images of Uraraka watching him, laughing with him, and claiming with utter sincerity that Izuku could be *in love*—

A heavy *clank* on the desk draws Katsuki's musings to an abrupt halt. He stiffens his back before he could elicit another embarrassing reaction in front of this seasoned, older man, but he pauses at the sincere, cautious glimmer in Yagi's wintry eyes.

The object placed on his desk, is Inko Midoriya's gun.

"… Why'd you bring it back?" Katsuki asks, raising an eyebrow.

Yagi interweaves his fingers on the desk.

"We had to be sure that this was, indeed, the same model, clip size, and even type before speaking with you and young Izuku about it. Inko was less inclined to answer the more specific questions, but those have been brought to light as of Izuku's disappearance."

"He didn't *disappear*," says Katsuki, clamping his teeth shut. His grip tightens around his mug. "He was *kidnapped*."

Yagi's gaze settles. "Indeed. Nevertheless, what happened remains the same. Tsukauchi and I have worked extensively in the background to be sure that the connections between the Midoriyas and Shigaraki's squadrons made logical sense. I have already spoken with your parents and Inko about the matter, and after ruling out several possible reasons Hisashi could have taken Izuku, we have deduced a few options. However, there is…" He pauses, rubbing

his chin. “There are some grueling matters, associated with this particular gun, Inko, and Izuku.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “We already knew this, old man. Deku asked his mom about it and got the answers he expected. It’s not her gun, but Hisashi’s. And we already pieced together that Hisashi and that many-hands bitch are working together, so why the fuck are we retreading the same thing?”

Yagi slowly nods. “You have many good points, young Bakugou. However, I’m talking about the reasoning behind Inko possessing the gun in the first place, and why Hisashi didn’t simply take it with him when he presumably left to join an alliance with Shigaraki Tomura and his squadrons.”

Izuku’s bright face pops into Katsuki’s mind. A memory, splashed in the foreground of a cold afternoon, walking with their hands in their coat pockets and sharing glares and chuckles at the people passing by them in blurs of color and thick layers. The trees were pale as death, muted greens and browns that swayed the further they walked.

“I’m not sure if we’re going to be able to find too much about Hisashi, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s fingers curl. He holds his breath.

“Maybe he’s not actually after anything. What if we made a mistake? What if he’s not actually here, doing all of these terrible things? Maybe it is all a coincidence and Mom is just confused—“

His chest puffs out, anger and resentment boiling under his skin.

“When we were kidnapped,” Katsuki says, “they flipped out when they realized Deku was a Midoriya. They acted scared, like they slipped up on something huge, and not even Deku had any idea what that was about.”

He snorts, lips curling in amusement and pride at the memory—one of many moments where he considered how quickly his hostility towards Izuku turned into admiration. To respect.

“He was distracting them, keeping their attention on him with these impulsive lies. It almost fucking worked.” He shrugs. “But it didn’t, in the end. We escaped, but we both knew that something was up. When Deku told me about the gun, and that his mom was the one responsible for owning it in the first place, we knew it had to do with his pops in some way.”

Yagi watches him, even as he pauses. As if waiting for the rest of the story to play out.

“What else?”

Katsuki blinks, frowning pointedly.

Yagi considers this, and opens his mouth once, before closing, and finally choosing to follow through with his words.

“Did young Izuku talk to you about anything else? Did he express any…” He waves his arm in a brief circular motion, as if flicking away gnats. “Additional concerns?”

What the hell are you trying to…?

Then, Katsuki’s eyes widen. His stare matches Yagi’s, and the connection is palpable, like electricity winding in the air and drawing their thoughts together in a striking collaboration. He considers the question, and wonders if Izuku had ever attempted to piece these particular thoughts together outside of their brief conversations about it in the past several months.

“Nightmares,” he says, gaze lost and unfocused. He rubs his chin in thought and glares into the carpet. “He mentioned… having a lot of fucked up nightmares, and they usually were about the same thing. Shit.” He grabs a fistful of his hair, teeth grinding. “Shit! He—yeah, they were always… he was always young, around six or seven.”

He stands up from the chair and walks in abrupt, contorted patterns in the space of Yagi’s office. His hands are sweating profusely, nervous sparks ticking off his flesh and threatening to ignore the threads of old carpet and books propped on the shelves.

“Deku always heard his voice. And, it was always the same thing.” A crooked grin overtakes his mouth, sharp and glinting like knives. “He heard his parents arguing when he was stuck in a room, and—his legs were always frozen, broken even. The dream never changed, and I told that idiot that it couldn’t just be a coincidence… the subconscious is more complex than that, and affects more than the neural receptors that connect regular dreams to fucking life experiences.”

He whirls on his heel, and one final theory lingers on his tongue. He watches, as a satisfied—and if Katsuki is reading this correctly, *impressed*—smile growing on Yagi Toshinori’s lips.

“It’s a memory,” says Katsuki, his gaze shifting from Yagi to the object placed on his table.

Now, it glows with a significance Katsuki had never expected, calling toward him with a dozen more questions and the unseen possibilities threading one scenario to another.

“Deku’s memory…” He pauses, and locks onto Yagi. The detective remains statuesque, stirring sugar into his coffee in a jarring blanket of silence. “His memory—no fucking way. It can’t be.”

He drags one hand down his jaw, his glare sharpening onto the gun and a series of goosebumps quickly spreading over his flesh.

“They’re connected. Somehow, that gun and Deku’s memory are fucking *connected*. That’s why it only happened consistently after he touched the gun. Then that means his mother…”

Yagi dips his head, an affirmative gesture that altogether enrages and inspires Katsuki.

Katsuki holds his breath.

Neither of them spoke. Yet, Katsuki knew that their unsaid conclusion was mutual.

Inko Midoriya knew.

Pain explodes under Izuku's shoulder. With a small, controlled wheeze, he tightens the loose rags around his shoulder. Dried blood crusts around the exposed cuts slipping between the bandages, distracting him from the inevitable numbness that has spread through his entire right side. He leans his head back against the wall, and grits his teeth.

He supposes he's lucky, to have only an injured arm and leg, and a handful of fractured ribs. He hadn't expected the blunt weight of the baton to hurt as much when it collided with his back, but Nero was stronger—he was always stronger—and it was easy for him to overpower him, if only for a few torturous minutes.

Despite his wounds, aching bones, and the swelling around his jaw and left eye, Izuku was relieved that Nero hadn't attempted to assault him. He was blinded behind a veil of animalistic rage that seemed far out of the realm of human control, and in those final few minutes his restraint led to nothing more than spitting blood onto Izuku's screaming face. He was pinned beneath him, his lungs twisting ferociously into knots and his heart threatening to explode out of his chest, with fear and adrenaline and everything in-between, and not once had he conceded to giving up.

Nero knew he couldn't have him entirely.

The frustration was there, in every slap of the baton on his body, in every vicious insult hurled towards him, degrading him to a *whore*, a *cunt,* a *spineless Bakugou bitch—*

"Ah, you look better than I believed you would."

Izuku flinches, swallowing the rising bile in his throat. The faded light, distilled and artificial, filters through the crack in the door even after the tall, familiar masculine figure saunters in.

How Hisashi Midoriya can walk with such unbridled confidence and sensuality rattles Izuku.

He hates this about him, and hates even more that a small, indecipherable part of him wishes he could emulate that in some way.

"Oh, come now, my son," says Hisashi, gradually taking a seat at the end of the bed. Izuku turns his head further away, and glares at the windowsill, jaw tight. "You can't expect things to go your way simply because we're of the same blood! Such an idea would be laughable!" He chuckles. "Nero took reasonable measures in securing a rather important device from you, I heard. One would think he'd be worthy of a promotion, considering his success."

Izuku bites his tongue.

“What do you want?”

Hisashi hums quietly. Nothing but mock-interest.

“You’re tougher than I anticipated you’d be, Izuku,” he says.

Izuku blinks, and turns his head cautiously to acknowledge the shadowed turn in his father’s irises. Hisashi’s profile is waned by the flickering light in the hallway and the shadows enveloping his bedroom. He doesn’t seem real—more like a phantom plucked from an old storybook. One meant to both entice and terrify children.

“You really don’t like answering questions,” Izuku mutters. “Mom used to say that about you.”

Hisashi’s posture stiffens. A heartbeat passes, and he’s normal once again, that vicious and charming smirk curving the corner of his lips into a grin. An unreadable expression that pulls on Izuku’s heartstrings in a poisonous, defiled way.

“Did she, now?” Hisashi nods complacently. “Despite her cowardice when dealing with you, that woman was persistent in pointing out my flaws. My wrongdoings. I quite miss her for that.” He shrugs. “How is your mother? Doing fairly well now I’m sure, with her son taken right beneath her nose. Even with her precious Bakugous at her side, her *favorite*,” he soaks the last word in a spiteful venom, “still winds up… gone.”

Izuku bristles. His lips purse, hands bunching in the sheets pressed around his crossed knees.

The self-consciousness he feels creep along his body shouldn’t be there, especially around Hisashi Midoriya of all people. He shouldn’t care, that he’s dressed in little more than a loose white T-shirt left in the wardrobe, and sweatpants that seem far older than even the decor of the building itself.

He was lucky, that he was able to change his clothes without Nero being in a lucid enough state of mind to demand to remain and watch him, like a crow refusing to depart from an endlessly sprouting field of golden corn.

It’s almost a distracting enough thought to waver him from the momentary blaze of hatred that swallowed up Hisashi’s gaze. It was only for a few seconds, but it was there. Blaming him, pinning him down to his own bed with a reckless force that betrayed his balanced posture.

“You seem troubled, my son,” he mutters, cocking one thick eyebrow, “maybe I should have your watchdog return for a complimentary visit, to see if you’re holding up well after your —”

“You’re jealous.”

Hisashi snaps his jaw shut. He tilts his head like that of a confused dog.

“About Mom.” Izuku licks his lips, hesitating. “You hate me, for a lot of reasons. I can tell. But you’re jealous of how much she loved me.” His brow furrows, the pieces fumbling together in his mind’s eye, like a puzzle he’s forgotten how to solve. “You didn’t want me around. You never…” He almost splutters out a laugh, dry and forced, at the idea, but it seems too logical to toss away. “Sure, I’m Quirkless and useless, as you said. I already knew that. You should pick fresher insults, since those are basically compliments by now.”

Satisfaction swells up his insides once Hisashi’s brows lift to his hairline. The shock is just visible enough to color him a lighter shade.

“That’s it, isn’t it? That’s the final reason why you can’t stand me. Why you want Mom to hurt.” The lump in Izuku’s throat refuses to settle, one built of nervousness and the incessant need to draw some sort of reaction out of his father. “Because she chose me over you.”

Izuku’s blood roars loudly in his ears. He wonders if he’s made a mistake, with the way Hisashi’s petulant smile falters, turning into something relentless and cruel. He recognizes this look from times long gone, from before he could truly recall the magnitude of what his father had done to him and his mother, but in the present, he reads the disbelief and bemusement on Hisashi’s handsome face easier than crayon drawings on paper.

“… My, aren’t you the clever one,” whispers Hisashi, hiding his smirk behind one hand.

The distance between them seems smaller and smaller with each tense second that passes, and Izuku knows that if Hisashi wanted to, he could easily snap his neck, burn the body, and be done with him in a matter of minutes.

“Hm. Should’ve expected as much.” He shakes his head. “You’ve only confirmed my reasons for bothering to keep you around, my son. I will make you useful, even without natural gifts. Your mother—my wife, our *Inko*… she will learn to enjoy the reformed version of you. The version of you destined for much better things outside the world of those *Bakugous*.”

Izuku’s hands clench around the blankets. The grip is painful, and shatters the weakened stature of his own knuckles, but he persists. Nothing inside him warrants his glare to shift from his father, or the cocky aura he exudes that’s far different from that of Katsuki Bakugou.

“I must say.” Hisashi tilts his head in the opposite direction, seemingly curious. “Nero has taken quite the liking to you. You could learn from him, and his maintaining stature over the squadron in Illenova. They are often consistently successful, far more than the one in Isabori.” He rolls his eyes. “Shigaraki has always been a bit of a fool, choosing to hire Zeke alongside Nero in these… more petulant scenarios.”

Izuku’s stomach drops to his toes. His heart jumps.

“Although, you two seem to have… history.”

Think fast. Think fast.

“We met a couple times.” He gulps. “Kacchan—Katsuki. Um. Katsuki Bakugou and I were on the train heading to Illenova. We met him there.”

Hisashi chuckles. “Oh, come now.” His stare hardens into steel. “You really think I don’t know what that vile horn dog intends to take from you?” He shakes his head. “Izuku, Izuku. You must learn to… embrace, this appeal. Learn how to use that to your advantage. You’ve inherited decent looks from both your mother and I.”

He leans across the length of the bed, and pats Izuku’s covered knee. Still, the touch burns him.

“If you were smarter, you’d have been able to wrap that fool around your finger by now. But alas, you are too nice. Too sheltered by Inko.” He stands up from the bed, and brushes down his collared shirt. With a final straightening of his own tie, his back turned to Izuku, he walks over to the door—even then, his voice carries. “I would expect you to know how to push away fools like Nero when all they want is sex and a few good words in for their inflated egos.”

What?

Izuku bites down on his tongue, harder.

Don’t lose it. Don’t yell. He could bring Nero back.

Hisashi’s dry chuckle washes out Izuku’s thoughts, paralyzing him.

“I do wonder, if the young Bakugou knew of how willing you were to suck another boy’s cock, would he be disgusted with you? Or, drawn to you more? To know how *easy* it is?” He shrugs. “Something to think about if you plan to be an intimidating leader. You will become stronger and capable of making a statement, but with your too-soft heart, despicable lechers far worse than Nero—ones who would attempt to fuck you and kill you without question—will have no problem breaking down your defenses in a heartbeat.”

Izuku clamps his mouth shut, hoping the boiling fire in his veins prevents him from saying too much. He wants to strangle his father and watch the life drawn from those insufferable, deep green eyes.

“I didn’t…” He almost chokes, and blinks.

Tears are running down his face.

“Ah.” Hisashi rolls his eyes. “What a crybaby.”

“You’re *sick*,” says Izuku, his voice shaking with each breath. “I never—he was the one who —”

“Fight back next time. Prove yourself.” Hisashi’s smile is tainted and raw. “I wouldn’t find fault in you mangling him up a bit.”

Izuku’s brow furrows.

“He’s not going to touch me.”

“Good.”

And with that, Hisashi leaves.

Izuku, for the fourth night in a row, is unable to sleep.

“Are you sure that we should—”

“Yes I’m *fucking sure*, Round Face!”

Katsuki rubs his temples and slumps in front of the polished doorstep. He refuses to glance up over the monogrammed door or the perfectly assembled window boxes, each one sprouting with lovely spring blossoms. Beside him, Uraraka nuzzles her face further into her scarf, her backpack stiff on her shoulders. He adjusts his own posture and glares ferociously up ahead of him, chest puffing out, before taking several giant steps, and slamming his fist on the door.

“Open up, asshole! I know you’re in there! We’re talking! Right fucking now!”

Uraraka groans.

“Bakugou.”

“Shut up!” He steps back several paces, his hands shoved into his pockets with an impatient scowl thrown across his lips. “This is something that isn’t even negotiable, Chipmunk Cheeks. None of this can be tampered with anymore.” He turns to her, assessing the size of her backpack with careful interest. “Do you have everything in there?”

“Yeah.” She runs her hand over the left strap, frowning. “But, Bakugou, there’s a reason that the school board didn’t let the article go through. It was about you, and… we couldn’t really, publish anything concerning a controversial topic like that in a light that the majority of the school boar didn’t agree with. Izuku and I fought them on it, but it’s not their fault.”

Katsuki huffs. “That article was *the shit*.”

Uraraka blinks. Slowly.

“Did you just…” She pauses. “Compliment Izuku’s writing—“

“We’re getting that fucking article published! This plan will work. Got it?” He stubbornly straightens and glares heatedly into the tall white columns that support the elaborate estate positioned in front of them. It seems too polished dan pristine, even for a house that can’t be

much larger than his own. “And this is the only option we have. And trust me, this was on the *last* of my list of options that I wanted to go to.”

But it wasn’t about him, or his family, or Uraraka.

It was about Augustana. About rescuing Izuku.

The door cracks open, a hesitant gesture strung together through a security link chain.

Katsuki’s expression hardens into brittle stone. Beside him, Uraraka shivers under his aura, as if she can sense the undeniable tenseness lingering in the air.

“… I must be dreaming.”

“You gonna let us in or what?” Katsuki snaps, though his growl is restrained. Just slightly.

The door widens.

Shouto Todoroki glances between the two of them with one perfectly arched eyebrow. He’s dressed in athletic shorts and a casual sweatshirt, white and red hair ruffled under the first brush of the cold changing winds. His lips are firmed in a hard line, yet despite the inevitable hatred sparking between him and Katsuki, there’s an equal understanding shared in their silent eye contact.

“Hi, Todoroki,” says Uraraka, waving meekly.

Todoroki blinks. “Oh. Ochako.” He clears his throat. “Hello. I didn’t…” He switches back and forth once more, his nose scrunching up in what Katsuki assumes to be both distaste and confusion. “When did you two become friends?”

Before Uraraka can reply, Katsuki takes another aggressive step forward, inches away from Todoroki’s unchanging face.

“Not important.” He lifts his head high, growl deep and threatening. “Let us inside.”

Todoroki’s aggravated sigh is followed with a tilt of his head towards Uraraka.

“Would you like to come in?”

She nods, and smiles shyly.

“Sorry about… him. Izuku has weird taste in men.”

“Oi! What the fuck—”

“Oh, believe me. I know.”

“Who even *asked you*, Icy Hot bastard?”

Uraraka sips on her tea, and absorbs her surroundings with her best attempts at not letting her jaw fall in shock.

“Your house is… um…” she blinks at Todoroki, who hands her a cookie. She takes it, her thankful smile earning a kindly one in return. “It’s beautiful, Todoroki. I knew you were wealthy, but actually being in your place is something new entirely.”

“I’m glad you approve,” he says. “Although, my mother’s tastes have somewhat washed out over the years due to my father’s overaggressive need to have the wallpaper a certain color.” He gestures to the pale beige dressing the many, many walls that form the artistic structure to the mansion. “The carpets have thankfully retained their color, though.”

Katsuki pipes up from his seat beside Uraraka, extremely tempted to chuck his steaming hot cup of tea directly at Todoroki’s face.

This is for Deku.

He inhales. Exhales.

You can handle this fucker for fifteen minutes for Deku.

“Just… can you—” Katsuki grunts and waves his arms, frustrated, “can you fucking help us or not, you cheapskate bastard? The longer we wait for an answer from you and this article remains unpublished, the longer Deku has to wait for us to find him!”

Todoroki assesses him with a glare hotter than melting iron.

“Believe it or not, *Bakugou*,” he says, strongly, “my father, as questionable as he is in these investigations, has already begun looking into Izuku’s disappearance.” He dips his head, surveying the calm ripples in his tea. “We know that it has to be connected to the squadrons, and it’s a definite planned attack, but the other details have been kept from me.”

Katsuki leans forward, his frown challenging and daring to tear him apart.

“We already *know* who fucking took him. We’re on a lead as to *why,* also.” He sneers. “We don’t need help in *that* department. You think I’d bother even ringing your doorbell if that were the case? Round Face and I are here because we need *this article* to get published.”

He bobs his head to Uraraka, who rolls her eyes at his theatrics before unzipping her backpack and pulling out an assorted, paper-clipped bundle of documents. Even from this awkward angle, Katsuki recognizes Izuku’s hasty red scrawl in the margins.

Todoroki glances over Uraraka's presented documents, a questioning look furrowing the middle of his forehead. His stare flickers back and forth between Uraraka and Katsuki, a hesitation settling in his words that seems as palpable as the very sofa where he's chosen to sit.

"This is…" He pauses, rifling through each scuffed piece of paper with heavy interest. "This seems like a rough draft of something huge. Where were you trying to publish this? And what does this have to do with Izuku? And his disappearance?" He sets down the papers and glares pointedly at Katsuki. "Clearly, you know something I don't. If you want my help, I need the details. All of them."

"Oh, fuck off," drawls Katsuki.

"What he *means* to say is that of course we'll let you in on what's going on." Uraraka heaves a sigh, and ignores Katsuki's steaming glare when she clasps her hands together in preparation. "Izuku has been kidnapped by Hisashi Midoriya, his biological father and Inko's ex-husband. We don't know about the reasons as to why, yet, but it was a few months after Izuku and I proposed this article to be approved and published to our school paper, only for it to be turned down for classified reasons." She nibbles on her bottom lip, her energy receding. "We don't… know, where Izuku is, but he contacted Katsuki successfully through a phone-like device that he took from one of the squadron members guarding him there."

Todoroki mulls over this, the silence thick as tar.

"… You believe this article about the Bakugous will help?" He raises the pile of papers as if to prove his point. "The public don't like his family." Katsuki snorts. "It's obvious to anyone who even hears the name *Bakugou*. His parents are detested, as is he. Of course our school board didn't accept this for publication." He sighs. "Look, there's not much I can do about that—"

"Oh, no, Half N' Half," Katsuki says in a dry, dangerous laugh. "Oh, no, we're not going back to the school board to publish this article. We need your influence to publish it to the *Augustana Times*."

Todoroki blinks.

"I…" He pauses, considering. "It's possible. I won't deny that." His stare sharpens. "But why would this help in finding Izuku?"

"This article points out details that direct the squadrons' involvement in a possible scandal that no one in Augustana knows about." Katsuki stands up from the couch and approaches Todoroki's side, plopping down on the cushions and reaching over to skim his fingers over the highlighted sentences. "Here, there, and others on these other pages I'll show you… all of them have hints showing Shigaraki Tomura's involvement behind the scenes."

Todoroki leans back, his frown stiff and unsure.

"How do you know?"

Katsuki bristles.

“They kidnapped us.”

Todoroki does not even twitch a muscle. He leafs through the pages, his frown growing deeper and deeper, his face shifting to a paler hue.

“This is… if you’re right…” He stares questioningly at both Katsuki and Uraraka, who watch him expectantly. “If Izuku was correct, if what you’re saying is true, then this could potentially bring them out of the shadows to clear their name. This could put Augustana’s central government on its head. This is all incriminating evidence for a corrupted regime.”

Katsuki scoffs, his head high and arms folded behind his head. He kicks his legs up on the coffee table, expression morphed into something unreadable and too soft for Todoroki or Uraraka to truly recognize.

“We already know about all that, Icy Hot,” he says.

“My father has a lot of influence in Augustana,” says Todoroki. “This might be important enough to grab his attention, and push him in the right direction, but I can’t promise anything —”

“That’s not good enough!” Katsuki snaps, slamming his hand on the coffee table.

Uraraka jumps from the couch, her voice cracking.

“Bakugou—”

“You have to fucking promise!” Katsuki barks, throat taut and veins popping in his forehead. Fury and desperation rushes in a hot fervor under his skin. “Deku—Izuku, he’s,” he growls and whips his head around, refusing to meet the shocked, blank stares cast in his direction. They wash over him like a cloud of curious flies, poking and prodding for admissions he doesn’t want to give. “You have to promise, because this is our best shot right fucking now to get the word out, and to put those disgusting snakes in the open before I fucking lose it and go find them myself. Izuku is *not* going to suffer because one lousy bastard wimps out from *his daddy issues*.”

In a flash, Todoroki is out of his seat, a threatening simmer of both frost and heat swallowing him up in a cloud. Katsuki does not shift, not even an inch, as the other teen prepares to strike him, to do something to push him back from the pedestal where he’s stepped on.

“Both of you need to stop your pissing contest and pay attention to what matters here!”

Katsuki is the first to snap his glare over to Uraraka, insults burning on his tongue. But at the sight of her face, puckered red with anger and worry, he relents. Dissolves, like salts tumbling into a bathtub.

“We’ll get this plan underway and see what happens.”

She nods her head, determined, and her bright trademark smile returns, something that had always stricken Izuku as unstoppable. He hadn't believed him when his boyfriend rambled adoringly about his best friend, but seeing her now makes Katsuki reconsider.

"You should both stay." Todoroki clears his throat, awkwardly stepping back from Katsuki and dipping his head apologetically towards Uraraka. Katsuki almost slaps himself in disbelief at the undeniable rosy blush that spreads up Todoroki's neck and spreads into his cheeks. "It will be easier to have this presented to my father without it being pure speculation. He takes some of my suggestions for bettering Augustana as flights of fancy."

Uraraka's eyes soften, her gentler smile echoing a thousand *thank yous*.

"… Well, fuck." Katsuki rolls his eyes. "Half N' Half."

"What now, Bakugou?" Todoroki grumbles, snapping out of his embarrassed state.

"Deku will thank you for me," he says, quick and awkward. He shuts his mouth and grumbles under his breath. "He thanks people and apologizes too fucking much for one person, anyway."

Todoroki tilts his head, as if unable to picture the two of them being a couple even now, months after the revelation of finding them in an embrace in Sommartyn. Frankly, Katsuki was still incredibly smug over the fact that Todoroki seemed painstakingly constipated at the image of him shoving his tongue down *his Izuku's* throat.

Izuku's reprimanding glares and insisted advice for him to stop being petty only makes this current moment all the more invigorating.

"We'll find him." Todoroki nods, and Katsuki's trail of thought breaks.

Katsuki isn't sure about the strange, uncomfortable knot in his chest at the searing looks that both Todoroki and Uraraka send his way. As if they're both aware of a secret that he doesn't know himself.

"Catching up on some reading?"

Izuku barely lifts a finger, barely twitches a muscle, barely moves his lips to acknowledge the presence slinking into his bedroom. Calmly, he turns another page, gaze flicking over the last few sentences of the fifth chapter in *Around the World in 80 Days*, before closing the book.

He holds his breath to suppress the natural flinch bustling under his clothes, as a warm pair of hands descends onto his shoulders.

The touch sears an uncomfortable, snaking warmth, and the added pressure joined into the wounds in his right bicep make his tongue curl.

“Tense, Freckles?” Nero purrs beside his ear, cautiously kneading his calloused knuckles, palms and hands into Izuku’s back. For once, his touch isn’t planning to invade his personal space, but the dark chuckle that leaves him sends Izuku’s pulse into an exhausted overdrive, a response to flee or punch if he can do so. “See you put on Papa Midoriya’s outfit for you. Looks good. Solid.” He rests his chin on top of Izuku’s curly head, his chest pressing to the back of his neck. “You feeling *better* today, hm?”

It’s a taunt. Salt rubbed literally—and figuratively—in the wounds created by way of Nero’s own hands and weapon.

Breathe. Slow and steady. He’s trying to push you.

Even then, he can feel Nero’s expectant stare, the weight of his presence behind him as he releases his touch and backs away.

Izuku’s pinstriped shirt is already wrinkled from the many times he’d chewed on the collar, and the slacks hug his legs like a second skin, though the new, alien clothes provide little to no barrier against even the slightest touch from Nero. Strangely enough, through the words of many squadron members patrolling the premises, he appears like an exact reflection of his father. He’s not sure if he intimidates or… draws Nero in more, with this impending revelation.

“Thought he wanted to go over something for…” Izuku trails off, keeping his voice as distant and dry as possible, “dinner? Or, whatever the suggested.” He turns in his chair, watching Nero as the teen slumps, clearly bored and momentarily disinterested in him.

“Sent me to come get you. Make sure you’re all…” He hums. “Prepared, I guess. So you feeling prepared for what your pops has to offer, Freckles?” He clicks his tongue at the end.

Izuku stands up from the chair, rolls down his sleeves, and locks onto Nero steadily. Fire boils in his eyes, foretelling a courage that snakes through the air and renders Nero, for once, completely speechless.

“Take me to him, then.”

Nero blinks, one eye at a time. He tilts his head, arrogant smirk fading in favor of a fascinated glimmer, gold-flecked stare alight.

“Yeah. Will do, Freckles.” He dips his head, almost mocking, but Izuku can barely stifle the rising pleasure at seeing Nero back away and address him in such a manner. “Follow me.”

And he does.

The walk down the usual pattern of hallways to the top floor of the building is, for once, led without hostility. Izuku keeps his pace, desperate to smother the thrumming of anxiety in his gut at the definite cautious stare Nero is burrowing into his back from behind. He can

imagine the baton from days before, how much it hurt to feel it descend onto him, and he wonders if he can maneuver himself once more, to grab that device, and call Katsuki again—

No. No.

It would be too reckless. He needs to be patient.

Kacchan…

His fists clench.

"That door over there," says Nero, speaking for the first time since leaving Izuku's bedroom, "that's where Hisashi is. He asked me to, you know, keep my distance for this one."

Izuku turns halfway, jaw tight. Eyes sharp.

"Anything else you need to say?" he asks, leveled as a tile of concrete. He watches Nero shift composure once more, a slight air of shock and pleased surprise overflow him.

Then, Nero dips his head for the second time this afternoon, turns, and leaves.

Izuku's chest deflates. He runs one sweaty hand through his curls, holding back the urge to mumble out the stream of babbling nonsense that clouded his mind during the entire duration of that grueling walk.

The door opens.

"Ah, good. You're on time."

Hisashi's presence is oddly stable, his powerful body pushing out the door. The buttons to his vest and the green pinstripes match the ones attuned to Izuku's own outfit, and he almost swallows audibly at the fact that side by side, they may look too similar. Much too similar. Similar enough for his mother to vomit if she ever dared see them right now.

"Uh—right." Izuku avoids Hisashi's stare. His heart skitters and leaps, confused on a derailing pattern. "I… what, exactly, are we doing up here?"

Hisashi chuckles, though it's anything but a sound of amusement.

"Well, come see for yourself."

Izuku follows him. His jaw drops open as the door closes in a heavy *whoosh* after his previous step. A gust of wind flies through his hair, ruffling the fine cotton of his shirt. He blinks against the blinding sun overhead and the stretch of bright blue sky, and it almost—*almost*—delights him to inhale his first intake of fresh air in nearly two weeks.

Hisashi's hands are pressed over his hips. His jacket billows behind him in a wave, his arms free and untucked of the dangling sleeves.

"So, Izuku."

He jerks up, stiff as a board. A hundred possible scenarios and questions blare through his mind, demanding his attention. Fingernails crease his palms, seeking shelter. His nose scrunches up, a definite foul odor racing through his nostrils—smoke. Factories and leaking faucets are scattered around them, whirls of black clouds spiraling up and painting the sky.

Then, Izuku's eyes land on the object in Hisashi's hand. It deflects the ray of sunlight, carefully poised and balanced in his palm. His thumbs brush over the trigger, the sleek golden stripe running from the handle to the tip reminding Izuku exactly of its purpose, of his own hands automatically finding a purpose with a similar weapon.

Except this one is much larger. Much more defined. Different.

The wheels in his head turn and the obvious answer startles him. Nearly knocks him off his feet. His purpose on the rooftop, the subtle smile Hisashi is sending this way, the clear expectations rolling off of him in waves.

"W-Why do you—"

"Never seen a rifle before, son?" He gestures with a flick of his head to the railings barring the edge of the roof. "Come here."

Izuku pales.

"No. I won't."

Hisashi hums, lazily rolling his head.

"Ah, don't make this so difficult, young blood."

"N-No, you're going to ask me to—"

"You don't know what I'm going to ask of you yet, my son." Hisashi whirls the rifle to position it over his shoulder, casually turning on his heel and striding to the other edge of the roof. "The door is locked on the other side, by the way," he calls. "And if you refuse, I'm sure one of Shigaraki's men would be fine taking a little trip to where your boyfriend lives —"

"*No*!" Izuku barks, and halts.

He needs to stay calm.

Stay calm. Stay calm. Stay calm.

His heart refuses to listen. It's audible in its pounding, a broken jackhammer under his ribs. Stomach twisted up and lurching. Lungs constricted in a python's grip.

"No?" Hisashi snorts, bursting into laughter. "Ah, you're getting even more fiery by the day! However, it's the wrong kind." He watches Izuku, locked onto him like the laser point end of the gun he holds carefully in his left hand. "Come here, Izuku."

“No, I…”

Remember Kacchan. Mom. Uraraka. The Bakugous. Todoroki. Kacchan. Kacchan. Kacchan —

Would they be killed if he refused? How many resources on his own body did Hisashi have? What games was he going to continue playing with him being forced into his vicinity multiple times a day, on random hours of the week? Being shoved out of his bed for torturous weight sessions, being shoved onto wrestling mats and punched and kicked, fighting and screaming as threats were tossed left and right about his friends, his mother, his *Katsuki—*

“There’s nowhere for you to run, Izuku.” Hisashi’s tone is gentle, layered like the many scales trailing a serpent’s back. “We’ll have some father-son bonding time. Have to make up for all those years I’ve been gone, yeah?”

No. You can’t make me do it. You can’t make me do this. You can’t make me like you—

“You have thirty seconds.” Hisashi’s frown returns, stabilized and dangerous. A mask of a true, experienced killer. “Walk over here now, or Katsuki Bakugou will be the first to be tortured, and the last to die.”

Izuku’s teeth grind to the gum. Blood soaks his tongue. He grimaces, suppressing every ferocious, protective urge inside him to a standstill as he stares into his father’s incriminating green eyes. Eyes that his mother once loved. That he surely once admired. *Adored*.

“Target practice isn’t so bad once you, you know.” Hisashi angles the gun carefully over the edge of the railing, smile slick with polish. “Get a good, loud target.”

Izuku holds his breath.

He needs to find a way out of this. Now.

“Izuku?” Hisashi straightens, eyebrow risen. “Your practice dummies aren’t going to shoot themselves, young blood. Better them than us.”

Better them than us.

Izuku swallows, considers, and uses every inch of his body to carefully nod.

“Okay.”

Hisashi’s grin is nothing short of satisfied, sweeping across his features in a tidal wave.

The door to the rooftop slams open. Izuku jumps out of his skin, turns, and stares.

It’s a goon Izuku doesn’t recognize, a squadron member. The same ticking green clock watch is strapped to his wrist, his clothes torn in several places, tattoos rippling up his shoulders and smothering his sideburns. He resembles Nero for a few quick seconds, until Izuku recognizes the glare in his eyes to be far more human.

“It’s Shigaraki, sir,” he says, panting. “He—it’s an emergency—”

He’s silenced with a crimson mark square in the middle of his forehead. His jaw trembles, confused, glassy eyes watering in a brief moment of clarity, until the body crashes onto the ground like a sack of potatoes.

Izuku claps a hand over his mouth and drops to his knees. Every inch of him *trembles*.

Oh my god, oh my god, oh my god, oh my god—

“Such a shame,” says Hisashi, calmly sauntering past him with the rifle perched over his shoulder and a gleaming pistol hanging from his right. Smoke drifts from the mouth of the smaller gun. “Was going to enjoy seeing you fuck up a few useless lives down there, but I guess we’ll have to postpone your target practice.”

Izuku stares mindlessly into the ground. Sound blurs around him in a blanket of white noise.

He doesn’t register the moment Hisashi grabs the back of his collar and yanks him to his feet. A fist punches him across the jaw, and pain explodes in his mouth. He gasps, nearly falling over with the impact. He touches his lips and winces at the shock of blood and swelling already forming.

Hisashi says nothing once he grabs his wrist and shoves him first into the hallway, his feet knocking against and tripping over the corpse bleeding senselessly over the rooftop.

No, wait, he’s dead, what was his name, why are we leaving his body here, where are we going, no, he’s dead, you killed him, oh my god, oh my god—

“Get yourself cleaned up,” his father whispers, stone-cold. “You’re coming with me.”

Chapter End Notes

EH? EHHHHHH?

Thank you so much for continuing to read and support this very plot-heavy story that needs a ton of editing like HOLY MOLY it's a fucking mess, especially in the earlier chapters but it WILL BE DONE. Thank you, all. So much. Thank you.

Malaise

Chapter Summary

> Izuku blanches. “You… you don’t want to help Augustana.” He swallows. “You just want to watch it burn.”

Chapter Notes

> Thank you, as always, for keeping up with this story. You're all wonderful. I'm sick, so, have some more time on my hands, even though I'm a little delirious.
>
> hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Oh—Mitsuki! Katsuki. I didn’t realize you would be back so early.”

Katsuki barely lifts his head to acknowledge the new silhouette at the door.

The sound of shoes being kicked off and placed gently beside the doorframe registers as familiar and comforting. Or, at least, it would be, if not for the spike of tension that swallows up the room as soon as Katsuki's mother, across from him, perks up.

“Inko.” Her smile is sweet, yet strained. Perhaps she’s also tired of the constant secrets, even between them.

Katsuki can see the many years of anguish and worry in his own mother’s frowns, like peeling back creases in manila paper.

“Thought you had another appointment after meeting with the detectives. Katsuki had a visit with Enji’s son before stopping by, so, we wanted to wait for you," says Mitsuki.

Katsuki adjusts his seat on the couch cushion, thumbs brushing over his phone.

The glass is covered in faded fingertip blemishes, signs of his constant swiping and checking to see if that mysterious number would ever call back. The reflexive desire to assign a contact name to it faded after several days, usually backed with Uraraka’s constant chattering. She’d begged him not to think about it too much, to lose sleep over it.

If she was not allowed to suffer because of Izuku’s disappearance, neither was he.

As much as he detested the logic behind her words, he agreed.

His attention wavers only slightly, when the revelation from his last appointment with Yagi Toshinori slithers into his mind and plays back and forth in a glamorous highlight reel.

"The gun and Izuku's memories are fucking connected!"

And perhaps, when Izuku had suggested the possibility himself, he should have listened. Should have considered the undeniable logic behind claims that seemed too outlandish to be possible. Should have turned off the argumentative chorus in his own head to become open, and listen, to what Izuku was desperately trying to explain to him.

He should have.

Stop.

Exhale. Breathe.

Let a shallow breath in, one at a time.

Fucking stop.

He licks his lips.

He's not wrong about this. He *can't* be.

Inko Midoriya slinks around the corner of the couch, hair disheveled and swept up in a ponytail. Her long trench coat is heavy with rainwater. She shrugs it off her shoulders and drapes it over the chair in the adjacent kitchen island, her movements too slow, too rehearsed in the presence of familiar company.

"You were out talking to the detectives, right?" Mitsuki asks, leaning back against the sofa.

She's watching her friend with a certain scrutiny, sharp like twin daggers. Still, despite her edgy skin, she would shed it in an instant if her suspicions about Inko were proven even minutely wrong.

"Yes. I was." Inko swallows, and turns to face them. Deep green eyes wide. Wet. "I know that you spoke with Detective Toshinori as well, didn't you? The both of you?" She shakes her head. "They haven't had any luck finding Izuku."

Mitsuki hums at this. "Were there any other leads? About Hisashi?"

"No, they…" Inko bites her lip. "I'm afraid that the gun they recovered won't be enough to link any clues together. My Izuku wouldn't even know how to handle a gun like that. And while the gun is mine, I have no reason to believe that Hisashi would be willing to even keep another copy of the same gun, or have it anywhere near him. I… I don't know where Yagi is going with his theories. It all just seems a little too outlandish, even for our experiences, Mitsuki."

Katsuki's hands tighten.

"Why are you lying?"

The moment it slips out, Mitsuki whips her head around, and *glares*.

Inko's entire body freezes, like a cat caught scratching the curtains. Mechanically, she continues slipping out of her jacket, a purse in her lips.

The air-conditioned room feels thick and tense with unsaid secrets.

"I'm not." Inko swallows. "Katsuki," she begins with an airy chuckle, though her mousy twitches are telling enough, "what's the meaning of this?"

Katsuki's fists tighten around his knees.

"Katsuki." Mitsuki's voice carries a warning, a detonation ready to explode.

Katsuki keeps his gaze focused on Inko Midoriya, the woman whom he believed would never be able to hurt a fly, nonetheless be somehow skilled in carrying firearms or conspiring with his own parents in their glory days.

She's Deku's mom. Deku's mom. Don't blow up. Don't fucking blow up—

But he wants to.

Wants to scream and make her admit to the secrets that everyone else knows she has. Wants to pry open her mind and barge through the doors on lockdown inside her mind, and yank open those hidden rooms and discover those many clues and links they've all needed for so long. Wants to make her admit one little trail after another that will guarantee an arrival of something stronger than the lack of resources they currently have.

"Deku's nightmares are connected to the gun." He watches Inko, notes the distinct shuffle in her feet and the lift in her eyebrows; a brief flash of panic lost to those who aren't as observant. "I didn't want to believe it when we talked about it a few months ago... a long time before he was kidnapped. I didn't want to fucking buy into all that supernatural shit."

He stands up from the couch, keeping his distance, yet squarely eyeing Inko with electricity and fire holding their stances together.

"Katsuki, this isn't a time for an interrogation. What the hell are you thinking?"

"Shut up, old hag!" Katsuki snaps. "You know just as well as I do that she's hiding something!"

"It's fine, Mitsuki."

Katsuki pivots on his heel, blinking at the clear language drifting between the two mothers.

Something ripples in the air, soundless to him, but nonetheless definitive.

“It was a mistake.”

One could have heard a needle hit the ground with the quiet that followed Inko’s words.

It swallows up the room in a tidal wave, echoing the many suspicions and unwanted answers Katsuki had both been craving and resenting.

Katsuki opens his mouth, unbelieving. He watches the mask of anger distorting his mother’s features crumble in a heartbeat, leaving nothing but defeat and acceptance. He recoils, as if struck in the chest by both of them, unable to process the undeniable secret that bound their promises together.

He reads the understanding on Mitsuki’s face, the way her mouth stills into a line. Processing.

Inko tucks a strand of hair behind her ear. Green eyes fogged and glassy, like windows dappled with rainwater in a cold morning.

“It’s not a coincidence,” she continues, biting her lip. “But Izuku… my baby…” she sniffles, wiping at her nose, face flushing. “There’s nothing I could’ve done at the time to make his father change his mind. Hisashi was determined to train him to become this… monster, and there was no way I could let that happen. There was nothing I could do but go to the resources I had to make sure that he was alright. I had to take certain measures to be sure that my only son would be free of that… what *Hisashi* was trying to do.”

“Inko, you don’t have to—”

“No, your son is right, Mitsuki.” Into shakes her head. “There’s no point, in keeping this a secret, any longer. And Izuku…” She holds her breath, trembling. “He deserves to know, as well.”

Katsuki whips his head towards his mother, throat tight. Teeth grinding.

“And Hisashi…” Inko pauses, thinking. “He wouldn’t know about this. I made sure at the time that he didn’t.”

“Quit dancing around it!” Katsuki barks, veins pulsing in his forehead. His temper was already rising, having reached its near-limit when Inko walked through the front door. “Why the fuck are Deku’s memories and the gun connected? How is that even possible?”

He used a gun in our escape like he’s been trained to do it. Like he somehow knew.

“I promise I will explain, to you and the detectives. I suspect that Toshinori already knows a great deal about it.” Inko rifles through her purse, pulling out a small flip-phone that buzzes and glows blue every few seconds. She opens it, and presses it to her ear. “It will all make sense in due time, Katsuki. I promise that you will know soon enough. And Izuku, too.”

She seems like a different person. An Inko Midoriya bred for distinguished conversation, for trades made in secret and in the dark bowels of a corrupted city. A person armed with many strategies for protecting her family and friends alike, while the other side glistens like a ray of endless sunshine, even in the most inopportune moments.

It makes Katsuki's skin prickle. He's not sure which side he needs to trust more.

Mitsuki's glare sharpens.

"Inko, if you try to contact him now, Hisashi could find out the truth soon enough and put you *and* your son in danger. Is that really what you want?"

Inko, for once, ignores her. The phone still rings as she rests it between her cheek and shoulder, her body stiff and her voice liquefied into a tender humming pattern.

Katsuki frowns, irritation swelling through his stomach and clawing at the inner workings of his chest.

"Who the fuck could you be calling that's more important than Deku?" he barks, and bites back a screech at the feel of his mother grasping the nape of his neck.

He growls, glaring icily toward the ground as her grip hardens, fingertips pressing warningly into the sides of his throat. It's a gesture she only enacts when he's at his most aggressive, in points in his younger years where throwing plates at his own father or kicking down doors in the house were his most reasonable methods of venting.

"Hello." Inko sighs, watching Katsuki carefully. "Yes, it's me. Inko Midoriya? I've been to your clinic before." She giggles, a soft and forlorn sound, reserved for someone familiar. "Yes, I'm calling for Doctor Abrams. Is he there?"

Katsuki wills himself to remain still. He refuses to turn and look at his mother's expression. He imagines it's a cross between disappointed and exasperated.

The door opens, heavier shoes stepping onto the floors.

"Welcome back, Masaru," says Mitsuki, softer.

"Hello, Mitsuki… oh."

Katsuki turns just slightly to meet his father's confused stare. Masaru locks onto them, and then drifts towards Inko, who smiles sheepishly and waves in his direction as if nothing transpired minutes before he walked through the front door.

"Am I…" Masaru stops, slipping out of his jacket. A wisp of cold air follows his steps as the door shuts behind him. "Am I interrupting something?"

"Oh, no. You're fine." Mitsuki dips her head, sighing. "Inko's contacting an old friend."

Katsuki holds back a scoff. His palms begin to spark, tempted to ignite.

"Yes. Yes, that Doctor Abrams…" Inko's voice snaps the three Bakugous to attention. "I would love it if I could speak with him. I'm in the company of his other old clients as well. Oh? Mitsuki and Masaru Bakugou." She nibbles on her bottom lip, hesitating, before chuckling. "No, no, that won't be necessary. My son isn't present, at the moment. He… he's

just not here. No need to worry about that. No, I'm not asking for a service. I'm just asking to be in contact with him again. He's a friend."

Mitsuki rolls her eyes, releases Katsuki, and stomps over to Inko. She holds out her hand, hip popped and arm crooked over her waist.

"Give it here."

Inko sighs, and drops her phone in Mitsuki's hand. Without breaking eye contact, the Bakugou woman holds the device up to her own ear, and growls.

"Listen here, whoever you are. Don't give us any trouble. This is Mitsuki Bakugou speaking. Connect us to Doctor Philip Abrams immediately and have him contact us as soon as fucking possible. Do you understand me?"

Silence.

Katsuki exchanges an unsure glance with his father, who sighs and pinches the bridge of his nose.

"Good. Glad that you can actually follow through with your one job." Mitsuki huffs, snaps the phone shut, and places it back in Inko's outstretched hand. "I hope you know what you're doing."

Inko searches her face, shaking her head. "Of course I don't know what I'm doing. I never do." She wipes her nose, holding back a series of sniffles. Katsuki steels himself, watching her closely, as if she'll spontaneously combust or draw out a gun from behind her back. "But this is what's going to help us find Izuku. I have a feeling that it will help. And it's one of few things that happened in my marriage to Hisashi that he will have no knowledge of."

Katsuki crosses his arms, dropping back onto the couch with an aggravated sneer curling his lips.

"So." Masaru claps his hands together. "We're paying a visit to Philip's, eh?"

Katsuki groans and buries his face into his hands. His father, even when he's feared for his whip-smart intelligence and dangerous knowledge behind he and his wife's Quirks, never fails to embarrass him in his own home.

"Been, what, ten years?" Mitsuki glances at Inko. "Or more?"

Inko nods, defeated. "Around that time."

"So who the fuck is he, then?" Katsuki grumbles.

Mitsuki looks over to him. "He's a special kind of underground doctor. Not necessarily a black market kind, but he's worked with your father, Inko and I quite a bit in the past. He has a special Quirk that helps in trauma recovery in most patients."

Trauma recovery?

Katsuki frowns. “What the fuck is his Quirk, then?”

He doesn’t expect to receive an answer, not when his parents share another glance. Another look that promises nothing but secrecy to him.

But it is Inko who breaks the quiet, who bothers to finally meet Katsuki’s searching stare. It’s in this look that Katsuki sees the overwhelming concern of a mother and former protector of the city who values her only family more than the air she breathes, and he supposes he feels the same.

“You deserve to know now, before you come with us to see him, Katsuki.” Her smile is soft and tender. “His Quirk is incredibly valuable but not meant for overuse.”

Katsuki’s nose scrunches. A silent gesture for her to continue.

She twiddles her thumbs, but the next words send a shock straight down Katsuki’s spine.

“Doctor Abrams’ Quirk ties specific items from one’s past to certain memories that remind them of those moments. His services require one link, to tie to another link, in order for the patient in question to find relief of certain trauma, and even skills that they would have known. It’s very powerful, but it does have his limits. How those limits are reached, though… I’m unsure of those. But…”

Katsuki’s heart thumps, louder than the clacking of his own teeth.

“His Quirk, Katsuki,” whispers Inko, scared and desperate, “is memory repression.”

Soap suds run in rivulets down Izuku’s back. Scalding water flattens his hair to his skull, the wild curls barely tamable even under the intense pressure. With shaking hands, he turns off the shower handle, inhales, and grabs the one remaining dry towel in the bathroom. Steam fogs up the windows, sheltering his naked form. With careful, minute movements, he forces the dryness away on his skin, moving over new cuts, bruises and scars that weren’t there weeks prior to this.

The outfit left for him on the countertop is freshly laundered and ironed. The smell of pre-applied cologne hangs off the trim, deep moss-green collar. The accompanying black jeans are newly purchased from his own father’s wallet, leading to an entire getup that Izuku knows is purely for self-indulgent purposes that he wants to part of.

And yet, his choice matters little to none.

He slips on the shirt, fingers trembling still, heart racing, as he slips each button through their partnered holes. He leaves the top two undone, retaining some sense of himself in an overly pristine piece of clothing. With his legs still clammy with shower smog and water droplets, he shimmies into the new pair of pants. The material clings to his every muscle, an illusion of the mild strength he grew to maintain over the brief period of time Katsuki trained with him.

He hiccups, and forces his tears down his throat. It turns into bile.

A knock on the bathroom door jerks him awake. He holds a ferocious growl on his tongue, so reminiscent of Katsuki that he wonders if he misses him more than he originally thought. The concept almost makes him laugh. Almost.

“You almost done in there, Freckles? Your old man’s losing his patience.”

Izuku rolls his eyes, rubbing the towel haphazardly through his curls. He glares at the reflection starting to appear in the wide mirror above the granite countertops. The smell of cucumber and lemon body soap filters through his nose and slightly quells the rising panic in his heart.

He can’t erase the image of the dead man on the rooftop, his blood filling the cracks riddled into the stone. He can’t push back the nonchalance on Hisashi’s grin as he stepped over the body, the maniacal glint in his eye when he struck him across the face.

Izuku touches the large bruise swelling under his jaw.

He was given thirty minutes to shower and change, to be presentable for Shigaraki Tomura. It’s almost laughable, to think of standing beside Hisashi, or beneath him, in the presence of a gangly, villainous spectator who wished he could be on the same level as his father.

Izuku turns the doorknob, and steps out, purposefully avoiding Nero’s staring. He should be accustomed to it by now, but he isn’t, and the rippling anger that spirals through his bones under that weighted, hungry gaze makes his insides squirm.

“Do you really have nothing better to do than stare at me?” Izuku asks, barely closed off from a snarl. “Just lead the way.”

Nero shrugs, his smirk infuriatingly simple, as he nods, and begins to lead Izuku out of his bedroom.

By the time they arrive at the bottom of the old hotel, Izuku is sweating too much to focus properly. His heart palpitates thunderously under his ribs, desperate and fumbling. He wipes his clammy hands down his pants.

The lobby to the complex is wide, empty, and covered in numerous old paintings, coffee stands, and threadbare furniture. Velveteen red and purple carpet stretches from one side to the next, decorated with the occasional flower vase on a coffee table. Several guards, some Izuku recognizes from past Isabori patrols, are stalking back and forth with guns and other weapons strapped to their belts. Their clockwork watches loudly portray the time in green numbers.

Izuku stiffens as Nero wraps an arm around his shoulders.

“Shigaraki will be impressed, you know,” he mutters. “Gonna be fired up for what Hisashi has planned for you. Soon enough, he’ll be asking for regular tea with your pretty face.” His light touch turns into a deeper grip around Izuku’s shoulder, tense, yet not painful. “But even if he’s my boss, don’t think I’d like sharing you all that much…”

Izuku shoves him away from him, his glare steady and ice-cold.

Nero chuckles, shaking his head.

“One day you’ll be begging for it.”

Not on your life.

A long, black limousine pulls in front of the building. The glass doors slide open automatically, beckoning for Izuku and Nero to step through. With one last acknowledging nod towards several other guards and members of security, Izuku hesitantly steps past the threshold and avoids the curious onlooking glares.

He scans the vehicle, unbelieving.

None of this seems real. The glamor, the people, the weapons, Nero... his father, undoubtedly hidden behind the tinted windows in the back seat.

Nero strides past Izuku, grabbing the door and pulling it open. Inside, Izuku glimpses a stretch of fine carpet, an unopened bottle of champagne, and crystal glasses lining the sill. He swallows, unsure, even as Nero mockingly bows and watches him like a starving hawk.

“Don’t want to keep your pops waiting.”

Izuku glares, but reluctantly complies. He slips through the door, and is abruptly cornered into the one spare seat in the stretch of the limousine’s interior. He shuffles on the cushions, glancing around him warily at the claustrophobic, overly elegant atmosphere.

And on the seat perpendicular to him, Hisashi Midoriya downs a glass, ice clinking together in the cup. He licks his lips, and turns towards him with a smirk far too proud for someone abruptly shooting the life out of strangers for no reason and finding pleasure in punching their children across the face.

“You managed to get here five minutes before your time was up. Good.”

Izuku looks away, swallowing. He maintains what little nerve he has left when the sound of the door closing, and Nero slipping into the spot beside him fills up the limousine.

“Go on, driver. To Shigaraki’s headquarters.”

Izuku bristles, unable to grasp the fact that Nero’s thigh is chafing against his.

Hisashi watches them closely, as if challenging Izuku's silence. His little reaction to Nero being far more forward than he was in this near two-week span of time contained together.

"Why?"

Izuku nearly chokes. How foolish, to speak now when the car has barely begun to move.

Hisashi tilts his head. "Speak up, my son. You'll have to be more specific." He pulls a cigarette out from his pocket, taking one glance at the opposing mirror as he lights the end.

Smoke drifts in a sensuous circle in the air. It does little to distract Izuku from the rummaging in his mind.

"You killed him." An uncomfortable lurch crawls through Izuku's chest, begging him to vomit out his worries, those startling images of a a bullet striking a man square in the forehead, and watching as he collapsed onto the rooftop, his own blood running fresh and scarlet on the concrete. "He… you had no rhyme or reason. You just, took out your gun, and —"

"Ah. Right." Hisashi shrugs. "Was a minor loss, I'm sure. Squadron members are disposable."

Nero shifts at Izuku's side.

"While the message delivered was… apparently, important, he was interrupting." He glances over Izuku, assessing him from head to toe. "You look presentable, at least. Glad the outfit works on you. Although your cologne choice is left to be desired."

Izuku watches him, almost gawking.

"I didn't…"

Nero, once again, stiffens and squirms.

"Have something to say?" Hisashi asks, teetering on the edge of a challenge. A dangerous invitation to something Izuku does not wish to tread.

He needs to continue biding his time.

Izuku bites his tongue, rage building like a firestorm.

"No."

Hisashi quirks a grin. "Good."

The drive is too long, even if the actual length is indecipherable to Izuku. Buildings whisk by in barely any semblance of color, hard to distinguish with the shadows sweltering the windows. It's as if the world outside the hotel where he's being held captive, and the very car where he's been forced to sit, is overwhelmed in a cloak of darkness and ambiguity.

Halfway through the drive, Hisashi pulls out a pair of noise-cancelling headphones, and slips them over his ears. He closes his eyes, a contented sigh falling through parted lips.

Izuku watches him. He's close, and somewhat vulnerable…

If only he could use a weapon, and take those spare seconds to slice something across his throat.

The thought terrifies him.

"Let me guess." Nero's voice is quiet, tempered in a sort of hesitation that surprises even Izuku, after knowing him for this long. "Fantasizing about killing him?"

Izuku turns away from him, glaring out the window.

"Aw, come on. Don't be mad—"

"Don't talk to me."

A shock shakes him to the bone.

He grimaces, refusing to meet Nero's undoubtedly amused face, as those fingers creep along his thigh, inching enough to form a possessive brand over his leg.

"You know I'll protect you around Shigaraki, right?" Nero whispers.

If Izuku had known him any differently, or in another time where he was more foolish and naive, he would have taken that sound to be somewhat genuine.

"Since, well, he'll know you belong to us. To *me*."

Something inside Izuku *snaps*.

In a flash, Izuku has Nero's wrist in his grip. Clutching as hard as he can. Willing every ounce of what little strength he can muster into this one hold, and watching as an evident look of shock, rage and unsureness color Nero's leather-tan skin pale with shock.

"I'm *not* yours."

His voice grates like steel, unlike anything he's ever sounded like.

It holds Nero prisoner for just a few moments, long enough for him to slowly, cautiously, nod towards Izuku, despite the malicious grin that curls his lips. Amusement sparkles like fireworks in his eyes.

Izuku releases his hand, and looks away, his heart ramming mercilessly against his chest.

Nero hums contemplatively at his side. Every now and then, he taps a few coded signatures into his phone-like device.

Hisashi pulls off his headphones, eyeing the both of them carefully.

“We’re here. Get ready.”

Izuku is forced to look to the ground when he’s pushed into the building. The smell of mildew and leather assaults his nostrils, forcing him to step back several paces until Nero’s gun at his back shoves him forward once more. He grits his teeth, but obliges, following Hisashi’s footsteps in the dark halls.

Hisashi scoffs as they arrive in front of one particular door, and at first glance, this place resembles far more of a jail penitentiary than the polished hotel where Hisashi had taken residence.

“I don’t think I require a password for entering, now do I?” Hisashi asks, his voice booming loud and echoing in the chambered corridor.

Seconds pass, some muted with the occasional, anxious shuffle in Izuku’s shoes. Then, Hisashi clears his throat, and casually raises his leg, and kicks the handle off the door. He heaves a sigh, and shoves open the entryway, gesturing for Nero and Izuku to follow him.

“Mustn’t keep me waiting when you send a messenger for me. He won’t be coming back, by the way.”

Izuku slowly, daringly, slides his glare over to where he suspects Shigaraki to be, and gulps.

The skeletal man seems hardly different than he was before, those several months ago where and Katsuki were subjected to his plans. His gangly form seems even slimmer, hugged under a long-sleeved, simple black shirt and jeans that sag low on his hips. His knobby fingers are paused on a computer desktop, photographs hanging on an assembly line above his head in weaving patterns. Izuku holds back a gasp at several where he and Katsuki are the centerpiece.

Some are far too intimate to be captured on these photographs. Of Katsuki holding Izuku’s hand on the train. Of Izuku leaning over his shoulder and catching him in a kiss. Of those few moments where they were able to shed their clothes and lie in comfort with each other without their parents knowing. Of several moments where they were meant to hold those seconds together in private, between the two of them and them alone.

Were they ever not under a camera of some kind?

How long had they been watched?

What else had these people seen?

Izuku flushes, embarrassment, shame and anger rising hotly inside him. A geyser ready to burst.

Shigaraki sighs, aggravated. He taps several more keys, before clicking on the computer mouse. The look he sends towards Hisashi, through the protective encasing of the strange scarred hand over his face, is enough to send anyone else shivering under such intensity.

“You make a dramatic entrance as usual, Hisashi.” Shigaraki sweeps his gaze over both Izuku and Nero, tilting his head. “Ah. Nero. Good to see that you’re still alive, at least. I don’t take kindly, Hisashi, to you continuously offing off my squadron members the moment they spill your pretentious coffee over your own rug.”

Hisashi laughs, raising one hand. “Guilty as charged, I’m afraid. Nero has proven himself useful enough to remain a good guard dog for my rather reluctant son.” He places one hand on Izuku’s head, ruffling his curls. “A rather handsome young lad, is he not, Shigaraki?”

Shigaraki locks onto Izuku. His stare chills him to the bone, and infuriates him all the same.

“… Quite.”

Izuku bites his bottom lip, scowling.

“Is there a particular reason you brought him here when it was highly unnecessary, Hisashi?”

“Oh, I disagree about that.” Hisashi puffs on his cigarette, placing it confidently between his teeth. As if slapped across the face, Shigaraki is unable to meet his gaze. “If what I’m assuming about this meeting is correct, it has nearly everything it do with my son, does it not?”

Izuku jerks up at this.

What?

Shigaraki folds his arms across his chest. He studies them quietly, before staring at Nero.

“Leave, Edmure.”

Izuku blinks, noticing that Nero has not moved an inch. The squadron leader is braced perfectly still, as if operating entirely on command. He looks over towards Hisashi, one eyebrow risen, as if asking for silent permission.

Shigaraki noticeably bristles.

“You may leave, Nero,” says Hisashi, nodding his head. “Don’t worry. No harm will come to my son.”

Nero’s grin is slick and satisfied. With a nod, he turns on his heel, and leaves. The door slams shut behind him, a weighted sound that violently throttles the room.

Izuku's fists clench. He can barely hold back the disgust from scrunching up his features.

Don't talk about us like that. Like we're more than what we are.

It's almost as if Hisashi is attempting to erase the image of Katsuki Bakugou from his life, one moment at a time. And Nero has apparently become a chess piece he wants to maneuver through his every day lifestyle, like dangling an image in front of him he wants him to accept with ulterior motives.

Shigaraki clears his throat.

"You both may sit, then. I guess."

Izuku jolts under Hisashi's touch on his shoulder. He breathes quietly, and matches his strides to the two chairs propped in front of Shigaraki's desk. The surface is layered in polish and cobwebs, bobbleheads positioned in the corners and a stack of documents and photographs lying dormant.

"No need to hinder the details, Shigaraki," Hisashi says, smooth as glass. "You can deliver whatever information you want at your own heed."

Shigaraki watches him, clearly frustrated with the way his hands tremble over the keyboard.

Izuku frowns.

The blood between his father and Shigaraki must be far more tainted than he originally expected.

"You shouldn't be so calm about this, Hisashi." Shigaraki's frame buzzes with barely hidden anger. "The news that came up—what those fucking detectives have brought into the open… what that pathetic former hero has done to our reputation, it will only continue growing!"

He refrains from slamming his hands on the table, and Izuku wonders if Hisashi's glare is powerful enough to even subdue someone of this caliber.

"You're overreacting." Hisashi puffs out a trail of smoke, a frown taking over his lips.

"Did you even *read it*?" Shigaraki growls. "Did you even take a glance at it, Hisashi? Do you have any idea how damaging this could be, how it could potentially ruin our reputation?" He grabs the computer monitor, and whips it around to show the downloaded screenshot of fine newspaper print that Izuku would only recognize from his own private files.

Alarm bells ring off in his mind.

And for a moment, hope rises high and mighty under his skin.

Hisashi squints. "This is a profile piece about Katsuki Bakugou." He watches Shigaraki, shrugging. "This is exactly what it appears. And you think the public will bother listening to this? Even if it's published in the *Augustana Times*?"

Izuku holds back a squeak. He looks over the numbers, under the date of the publication, and the photograph of Katsuki Bakugou's profile inlined with the columns of text. He recognizes certain phrases he'd underlined months before, in a time where Uraraka helped him pour over his notes and decipher which informational line needed to be there, and needed to be present for the school board to accept them.

The rejection made him hesitant to even consider pitching it to someone else. Made him rethink the idea of having it in the first place.

Who published it to the *Times*? Who had the power to do something like that?

He wished he could cheer and have the opportunity to be proud about his article, something he'd slaved over for months, was published successfully to the most widespread paper in Augustana. It was a small step towards his bigger dreams, to allowing him an opportunity to reach past the borders of this corrupted city and latch onto something new.

Izuku bites the inside of his cheek to prevent a proud smile.

He knows the information in that article, and he knows what incriminating pieces of secrets are lodged between the lines. He knows what lies in one of the most solidly constructed articles he's ever written, and if Shigaraki's reaction has anything to show for it, the targets of the article have taken recognition.

"No one will pay attention to it," says Hisashi, sighing. "You're wasting my time with this, Shigaraki. Although I do believe you wouldn't call me here just to bitch about an unimportant article that my son spent too much time on." He rolls his eyes. "It's basically a pedestal for him to vent his misguided affections for his boyfriend. Puppy love. Nothing more than that."

Izuku clenches his fists around his thighs, desperately holding back every urge to attack his father right then and there.

"You're not taking this seriously *enough,* you fool!" Shigaraki snaps. "This shouldn't even be published in the first place! The paper is one of few things we don't have control over!" He shakes his head. "You're delusional if you think that we will be able to go through with our plans with this hanging over us."

"Hm. I disagree." Hisashi crushes his cigarette between his thumbs, smoke billowing between his lips, though this is borne solely from his Quirk. "And I would watch it with the name calling, Shigaraki." He pauses, lifting his legs up and setting them at the corner of his ally's desk. "No matter what occurs as a potential wrench in our plans, there will be no concern. This is little more than a flea to swat off our backs."

Shigaraki leans back in his chair, quietly fuming.

"Although I do wonder who could have published this." Hisashi glances at Izuku, a glint in his antifreeze eyes. "You have something you wish to say, my son?"

Izuku slowly shakes his head. "I didn't publish this."

“Impossible.” Shigaraki snorts. “No need for you to lie about this sort of thing, you brat.”

“I’m here, aren’t I?” Izuku counters, bristling. “I don’t have access to any kind of technology! And I still don’t, not while being held captive here. No phone, no computer, nothing.” He straightens up, his glare intensifying. “And the date on the PDF you have there signifies that this was published yesterday by an anonymous source. Believe me, if I wanted to publish this on my own accord, my name would be *all over it*.”

Shigaraki tilts his head, unable to truly break eye contact with Izuku.

Hisashi chuckles, a dry sound that raises the hairs on the back of Izuku’s neck.

“He has a point, Shigaraki.” He shrugs. “No need for him to lie about this sort of thing. And if he did have the technological resources to accomplish this task, he would have used it to contact the police, or some other person to help him escape.” He ponders, tapping his chin with a finger. “However, this does not rule out other potential suspects. The Bakugous, for one.”

Blood drains from Izuku's face.

No. No. No. No, Kacchan, no—

“Would that seem still a little outlandish, Izuku?” Hisashi leans back, watching him with a stare sharper than knives. “To have your boyfriend publish this for you?” He laughs, shaking his head. “Ah, young love! Times where your significant other would risk everything to save the one who holds your heart. Wonder if Inko would slap me if she heard me say such a thing today.”

Shigaraki snorts. “Obviously it would have to be the young Bakugou.” He interweaves his fingers, elbows balanced on his desk. “Unfortunately, it would be a risky move, to kill him now. My squadrons have reported fluctuating activity in Sommartyn, which means Enji Todoroki himself is establishing a firmer hold in that area. The last time he was this active was when the Bakugous were adamantly attempting to uproot us from the inside-out... though I suppose you would remember that, Hisashi.” He hums, knee bobbing up and down and vibrating the ground. “There is a plot happening here…”

Hisashi seems to consider this, twirling another cigarette stick clutched between his thumbs. Smoke swirls out of his open mouth, his Quirk ready to ignite.

“Indeed." He presses the stick to his lips, pondering. "Although this risk was well-known before I brought my son back to my side.”

Izuku chews on the inside of his lip. Blood wells under his teeth.

His heart jumps once both men lock onto him, expectant.

“You’re going to be doing quite a number of tasks for us, young Izuku.” Hisashi leans into his chair space, a phantom smirk curving his mouth into a blade. “After all, you probably miss your Bakugou prince, do you not?”

Izuku's heart drops to his toes. Immediately, he clenches his fists, and glares back.

"I'm not going to help you hurt him. Never." His gaze splits between Hisashi and Shigaraki. "You'll have to kill me first."

Shigaraki splutters, and Hisashi barks out a laugh.

"Hah! What fire. Although a tad misplaced." He rolls his eyes. "Do not worry, my son. We still need him for a few things. However, you can extend the deadline for his death if you follow through with these plans. After all," he pauses, allowing the tension to sink in, "you have no idea what we have in store for this city. Not yet, at least. But you will."

Izuku blanches. "You… you don't want to help Augustana." He swallows. "You just want to watch it burn."

The smile that follows is charming in its weight, though Izuku knows better than to trust a look so simple and elegant.

"And burn it shall." Hisashi turns towards Shigaraki, nodding. "I believe our time is done here, Shigaraki. Perhaps I will take my leave. Or, better yet…" he strokes his chin in thought. "Izuku, I will be leaving you in Nero's care for the afternoon. Be good while I discuss some important matters with our ally, here."

Izuku grits his teeth. "Fuck you."

"I would assume you'd want to hear about this. Since it involves your *Kacchan*."

And then, whatever self-control Izuku had instilled himself in this last terrifying week, breaks in an instant.

He leaps up from his chair, prepared to reach, grab onto something, *anything*, that would allow him to watch the life drain from his father's face. Hisashi backs away in seconds, and strong arms are wrapped underneath Izuku's arms and pulling him flush against another chest. He screams, kicking, punching blindly at the air.

With Shigaraki standing up and Hisashi watching him closely, Izuku knows that the person restraining him is Nero.

"Don't you *dare* touch him! I'll kill you if you even think of looking at him! You're laughing now but I *will* do it! Somehow, I will! Don't you dare ever, *ever touch him*!" Izuku fumbles, desperate, exhausted, scared. "You can't make me do anything to hurt him. You *won't*."

Hisashi's chest puffs out, a wary mask crawling over his features.

"Hm. Perhaps you will be harder to convince than I suspected. And, ah, good instincts, Nero." He dips his head. "I'm embarrassed to admit that his outburst had caught me off-guard. Not that a little burn or two wouldn't do this bratty son of mine some good."

Nero's grip only tightens. He's wordless.

Izuku stops, panting, his body tense with fury. With a protectiveness that he didn't know he possessed.

It snakes through him and takes control with ease, his vision swarmed with Katsuki, with him being attacked. Hurt. *Killed*.

I can't let that happen.

"Come on, Freckles." Nero breathes next to his ear, a grunt leaving him as Izuku rams an elbow into his stomach. He growls and rams one closed fist onto Izuku's chest, effectively knocking the breath out of him. "Gotta leave the adults to talk. Be good, now."

Izuku wants to rip him apart.

"Be careful not to damage him any further as you take him out, Nero," says Hisashi, brushing off the encounter as if no more than a fly on his jacket. "He's still sporting that nasty bruise from earlier."

The door closes in front of Izuku, and nothing but absolute hopelessness consumes him from the inside-out. He clenches his teeth, and glares spitefully into the concrete floors as Nero's hands slide down his arms and latch cuffs around his wrists.

Sweat rolls down his neck.

"You already cracking?" Nero asks, a curious hum flitting through his throat. "Might be a problem. Your pops may seem patient, but if you defy him too much? Jesus." Izuku can picture him shaking his head, that same, nasty smile never fading. Always lingering. "You wouldn't last more than a minute or two. No offense."

Izuku's forehead is then pressed to the wall, a hand on his constrained wrists. Dust and grime gathers on his skin.

He can only imagine how many spiders and ants have crawled on this very surface.

"Why are you working for them?"

Nero's hand loosens, only slightly, on his wrists, before tightening as the question sinks in.

"... You curious?"

"No." Izuku sighs, a shaky sound that he immediately resents. "I don't think I've hated anyone more than you, actually. If you're really asking for honesty." His blunt answer scrapes through the walls, and only earns a dry chuckle from Nero. "But it makes no sense to me. Shigaraki kills your squadron partners, your friends, like they're nothing. As does Hisashi."

A pause follows, a thick and uncomfortable presence.

"Careful. One might think you're starting to care about me." Izuku rolls his eyes, but doesn't question this as Nero's grip tightens. A silent threat. "Hm. When it comes to our squadrons, be band together, but we also split apart when needed. We follow the orders given to us, and

we're paid well to listen. It's been that way for awhile, since I became a leader in Illenova's patrol."

Izuku stares down at his shoelaces. Dried bloodstains mar the worn, sneaker material.

"That makes hardly any sense, still, for you to be such a blind follower."

"Hm." Nero cracks his jaw. "Even though we all work in groups under Shigaraki and Hisashi, we operate independently. Why do you think I'm always the only one Hisashi keeps close? He rotates bodyguards and personal security all the time. Shigaraki lends them to him when he requests it, but lately..." Izuku can picture him grinning, a foolish gesture meant for people of equal intelligence. "Lately, your pops has been pulling people over to his regime. Shigaraki is losing that power he once had, y'know. Makes things a little more interesting."

Izuku listens, quiet, as the words sink in. It would make sense, he believes, for Shigaraki to be resentful of Hisashi for earning the favored attention of his most loyal followers.

"Besides." Nero pauses, a hesitance that strings apart Izuku's nerves. "You're Hisashi's son. And why would I *ever* want to be kept far away from that, hm?"

The disgust that builds up in Izuku's chest is forcefully pressed down, a deafening alarm signal blaring in his mind.

“It’s weird.” Nero clicks his tongue. “Normally, people we track and monitor break under pressure by this point. But you…” He huffs. “You’re different. Stronger. Guess we like that about you, maybe.”

Izuku squeezes his eyes shut.

He wants to see his mother’s face, and feel her arms around him. He wants to listen to Katsuki’s laugh, or feel his lips on his skin. Anything other than being pinned to a wall under the force of a person who regards him little more than by his appearance, and the unintentional strokes to his ego.

Wait, Izuku.

He still has some resources. Some figments left of a plan that will be too early to act on.

And yet…

The people on the other side of this door are speaking about the future of Augustana. Was it an attack? Something that Izuku must know? Something that he can somehow relay to Katsuki before he’s discovered?

He considers the options, knuckles grating against one another in the cuffs.

He lets out a slow breath, hesitating, before gradually turning around to flash a look towards Nero.

“Can you listen to what’s happening inside?”

Nero snorts, raising an eyebrow. “You nuts, Freckles? You think I’m going to relay that to you? Not a chance.” He shakes his head.

Izuku considers this, hoping that Nero is watching him.

“Would you let me?”

Nero stiffens, his grip on his neck somewhat loosening. Testing the waters.

He hears Nero swallow, a shudder reverberating through his entire body.

“You would, wouldn’t you?” It takes every ounce of self-control within Izuku to not let his words shake. He steels his body against the wall, hesitating, and yet, keeping himself smooth. Careful. “You’d let me. Because you want to please me.”

Nero’s gaze slides over to him. A side-eyed look full of suspicion.

“You’re delusional.”

“Am I?” Izuku grits his teeth, turning around just slightly in Nero’s powerful grip. He’s half-turned towards him, wrists still linked behind his back. “You’re obsessed with me. You took this position for Hisashi to be close to me, right? You just said that yourself, less than a minute ago.” Nero whips his head away, a bob in his throat. “You don’t want me out of your sight. You’re jealous of Katsuki. You want me, but you can't have me completely, lest you want to risk Hisashi shooting you square in the head like your poor friend on the rooftop.”

It had taken less than a second for Hisashi to turn on a squadron member and point a rifle at his forehead.

Somehow, Izuku believes Nero's status in comparison to that unfortunate squadron member to be identical.

After a terse minute, Nero snorts. “You’re playing a dangerous game, Freckles.”

“If I kiss you,” says Izuku, as slow and cautiously as he can, “will you let me listen?”

Nero’s jaw unhinges for a second, his tongue swiping over his bottom lip. His nostrils flare, his body tense yet riddled with apprehension.

His gaze searches the door, considering the options lain before him, and Izuku wonders if he’s spoken too far, if he’s already wasted his chance.

“It’ll be our secret.” Nero’s hold on him is loose enough for Izuku to inch closer to him, still distant, but now facing him directly with his cuffed wrists pressed to the wall. “Between me and you. Hisashi won’t know. Shigaraki won’t know. Something we’ll have, just the two of us.” He bites his bottom lip, knowing that the endgame will be worth it. “I’ll give you what you want, if you give me what I want. And that way, you won’t get in trouble with Hisashi —”

Nero then turns to him, grabs his neck and shoves him into the wall hard enough to have the back of his head knocking on the concrete.

He grunts, and maintains the glare between him and his captor, knowing that he's reached some level of interest in the older male.

"You're trying to trick me." Despite his words, Nero is close, flush against him, licking his lips as he locks onto Izuku's mouth. "Trying to drive me crazy, huh? Bat those pretty eyelashes and think you'll get what you want? I know the game you're playing, baby."

Izuku flinches, just slightly as Nero's other hand grazes his cheek, a tender brush of his thumb along his bruise.

"But you'll do it. Won't you, Nero?"

Nero sucks in a breath, pupils blown wide and fascinated. Hypnotized.

Izuku grins despite his weaker position against the wall.

"I can't attack you while like this. My wrists are bound. And you and Hisashi are watching me twenty-four-seven. So how would I be able to use this to my advantage?" He gasps as Nero's grip hardens around his throat. "I…" he coughs. "Aren't you curious?"

Nero snorts, eyes drawing him up and down.

"… Hm." He loosens his grip around Izuku, considering. "If you're lying, or you back out, you'll pay for it. Understand?" He grins. "Okay, Freckles. I'll let you listen in. But when I'm in your room tomorrow night, I'll get that kiss, and more. How does that sound?"

Izuku hesitates, his eyes narrowing.

By tomorrow night, hopefully, he will be gone before Nero could ever make those advances.

"I meant what I said." He nods. "Your end of the bargain first, and then I'll pay you back."

Nero's smirk grows.

"Alright, then. Glad we've reached an impasse, Freckles." He gestures with a flick of his head toward the door. "I record all meetings with Shigaraki and Hisashi. All squadron members do to keep info and intel close to them, and away from prying eyes. Security measures." He raises another hidden device from his utility belt, clicking on the button. "You get fifteen minutes with the recorder under supervision."

Izuku bites his lip.

"Okay. Yeah."

Stay calm. Stay calm. It's better than nothing.

Nero holds up the device to Izuku's ear, and presses the button.

He breathes as shallowly as possible, while the words slip in a buzzed context through the grating of the device. His own heartbeat thumps loudly in his ears.

And then, one particular statement threads through the thick air, one that even prompts Nero to lift his head and watch Izuku for his reaction, as if he regretted his decision to betray his boss.

"Well then, perhaps you should be more careful about your planning, Shigaraki… we won't be able to make this follow through with destroying the train if not enough people are on board… too many witnesses will be held accountable if the explosions aren't made correctly… we'll have to get my son to convince the young Bakugou to arrive at…"

Izuku's eyes widen, the static blurring into nothing.

The train? Not enough people? Explosions? Bakugou…?

His entire body quivers. Panic holds him under a frosty embrace.

He avoids Nero's cautious stare, his suspicions suddenly rising.

He needs to act soon. Sooner than he thought.

Kacchan, Izuku refrains from showing how scared he is, how desperate he is to escape at this very moment. *You're in danger. The whole city is in danger.*

He needs to find him as soon as possible.

The door opens.

Hisashi glances between Nero and Izuku, lifting an eyebrow.

"Hm. I must say, you both look like you've seen a ghost." He turns to Izuku, clasping his hands together. "We have any things to go over, my son. And one of them will gladly assure your spirits." He pulls out his phone, dangling the device tauntingly beside his ear. "I'm sure you've missed speaking with your precious Kacchan, have you not?"

Izuku swallows.

He can tell, from this one look alone, that Hisashi knew he'd heard.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much again for reading. Things are revving up for some pretty big turnouts!

Hope you liked this chapter. Leave a comment if you'd be so kind. So thankful for all of you reading, leaving kudos, bookmarking, all of it. Thank you thank you thank you

thank you thank you.

Until next time.

Abstruse

Chapter Summary

> *“I’ll… I’ll be seeing you soon, Kacchan. Katsuki. Come to the station in Illenova at exactly ten minutes before midnight. Make sure no one sees you. And come alone.”*

Chapter Notes

> To everyone who's read, bookmarked, commented and left kudos on this story so far... thank you.
>
> Hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The news bulletin flashed across Katsuki Bakugou’s computer screen as soon as he clicked on the link. He licked his lips, glancing over the familiar headline, the picture of his profile smirking in snarky pride and indifference on the grayish white plaster. The numbers were continuing to grow, popping up in cloudy balloons on various social media channels, the hundreds of curious readers suddenly sprouting and expanding to thousands within Augustana alone.

“Looks like your idea is taking off.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Not sure if it’s going to work, but it’s the only way Deku’s kidnapping is going to have an inkling of exposure in this fucked up city.” He swivels around in his chair, watching his father, Masaru Bakugou, observe him with a glimmer in his dark eyes. “The hell do you want, old man? I’m busy here.” He tilts his head. “Since you and the hag won’t let me come to your fucking weird-ass date night.”

Masaru closes the door to his bedroom. When he approaches Katsuki’s chair and places a hand on his shoulder, the gesture is immediately easy to differentiate from the coarse way Mitsuki often snatches the nape of his neck. Masaru calms the fires in the Bakugou household, while his wife and son stir the inevitable hurricane that entangles each and every person who walks through their front doors.

Despite this attribute, which Katsuki has often seen as a remarkable gift in its own right, he wishes his father didn’t choose to use this natural way about him to quell his personal issues. The battling inconsistencies, the worries, the doubts, the anger and the growing ammunition for hatred stacks like blocks onto each other, forming a tower that Katsuki wishes to keep to

himself, and talk about only when he needs to scream and unleash his Quirk into a secluded, private place.

But with his father, his chest feels pulled open, layer by layer, his heart left to be bled dry.

“It’s not a date night. We’re visiting an old friend.” Masaru pats him on the back, his smile tender. Soft. “I understand why you’re frustrated, firecracker, but there’s a lot more at stake here than even you realize. Izuku was placed under a lot of stress at a young age by his father, and it’s because of Doctor Abrams that many of those occurrences have been… improved, in some ways.”

Katsuki shrugs off his hand, scowling into the carpet.

“Aren’t you always preaching about how our memories shape us or some shit?” He raises an eyebrow, and turns to his father. Masaru returns the look, silently probing him to continue. “You know, just… ugh. Fuck it. You always say that our failures and our victories make us who we are. Whatever. That just sounds like corny bullshit you’d seen in an All Might cartoon. But isn’t that what you’re going against right now?”

Masaru sighs, stroking his stubbled chin. “I wasn’t as adamant about asking for Philip’s help back then, when Izuku was just a boy. I’d seen him only once or twice, and knew that he was Inko’s son. I hardly recognized him at first, when I saw him here, in our own house, for the first time in over a decade.” He chuckles, shaking his head. “At the time, I was the only one against the idea. But Inko believed it would be good, for her son to forget what his father had done to him.”

Katsuki’s teeth grit. The fact that Inko went to such lengths only tells him that Hisashi would have had to make Izuku go through some terrible, unspeakable things. Even if the idea itself seems ludicrous, it would perhaps explain some of her overly cautionary approach to how she even speaks to Izuku in a normal, everyday conversation.

She views him as too fragile to understand the weight of his past. Breakable.

“He’s stronger than she thinks.”

Masaru recoils, blinking down at him.

Katsuki clears his throat and swivels back to his computer screen, face warm and pink.

“Deku’s gonna be pissed, when we get him back.” He chews on his bottom lip, anger searing into every bite, every nervous twitch in his body. “If he’s not already.”

Wherever he is.

“… You care for him a lot, don’t you, son?”

A heartbeat passes.

“Obviously.” Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Don’t make a big deal out of it. Jesus. Mom almost bawled her eyes out when I told her we were fucking dating like two and a half months ago.

Or however long it was. So why should any of this be a surprise?"

Another online advertisement pops up in his search. He groans, and clicks out of it quickly to shuffle through the social media posts about the article. Some comments are worth salvaging, with several conspiracy theorists contributing to the conversation about Katsuki's family.

"Enji Todoroki published this, y'know."

Masaru's content humming takes an abrupt pause.

Katsuki inwardly punches himself in the face.

"… Does your mother know?"

"No. I didn't plan on telling her. She'd flip the fuck out." Katsuki cards one hand through his hair, leaning back to stare up at his poster-clad ceiling. All Might's blindingly white smile catches his meandering attention. "Shouto bothered to listen to what I had to say, I guess. He actually convinced his batshit crazy old geezer that this was worth publishing in the *Times*."

Masaru snorts, an awkward sound that Katsuki hasn't heard since his childhood.

"Yes. Well." He hesitates, patting Katsuki's shoulder over the chair. "She would definitely not be that excited to know that you went to the Todorokis for help."

"Was better than sitting around and doing fucking nothing," Katsuki spits. "All of this is fucking pointless if we don't get Deku back, though. He's probably shitting himself seeing his article pop up in the newspaper or whatever, if they're letting him see it…" he grins slightly at the thought. "Those fuckers have something big planned though. Don't they?"

Masaru clicks his tongue. "That's the assumption. This kidnapping was planned. Hisashi was never one for subtlety, at least when he worked with us. But when it comes to who he is now, apparently his strategies go back and forth between being a master of subterfuge and louder than a Bakugou cannonball."

Katsuki tilts his head back further to meet his father's expectant gaze.

"What about his wife?"

Masaru shrugs, arms folded over his broad chest. "Well. Inko… even with us, has always been a woman of her own secrets. I'll be honest with you, Katsuki, I'm not sure if visiting Doctor Abrams and talking to him will do much good. It seems hardly likely."

"No shit." Katsuki sits back up, and clicks through another link. "This article's being shared by a ton of fucking people, though. Jesus. This many people read the news? Even in this shithole of a city?" His nose scrunches up as he passes over several similar article titles, though very few have anything actively to do with the squadrons in question. "Guess when someone's missing, especially a young kid, it becomes a bigger deal…"

Masaru says nothing to this. Though Katsuki can imagine he's nodding his head in silent agreement.

Katsuki's cell phone buzzes in his pocket.

"Please don't destroy this one," Masaru says with a brief chuckle.

"Fuck you," Katsuki mutters, though he tugs the device closer to him and squints at the screen.

His heart backflips.

"Shit!" He bolts out of his chair, frantic, eyes nearly bulging out of his skull. "Dad! Get the hag! And Deku's mom! Shit, fuck, I *know who's number this is*!"

He nearly trips over himself bolting out of his bedroom, dashing down the hallway and careening down the stairwell from the second floor. He barges into the kitchen, where Mitsuki and Inko are huddled around the island counter with two cups of coffee in their hands. Both women look exhausted, eyelids drooping and purple and hair a scattered mess, but he can't bring himself to care.

"You guys!" Katsuki points, every hair on his neck standing straight up. "We have to put this on fucking speaker and record it! Quickly! They're going to fucking hang up soon—"

"Katsuki," Mitsuki starts, straightening, her eyelashes fluttering, "what are you going on about now—"

"I mean it, hag!" Katsuki nearly trembles, desperation clinging to his every word. "You have to fucking just take my word for it and help me record this! It's *them*."

Inko's eyes flash in understanding, and within seconds, she is leaping from her seat at the counter and rushing through to the other room. Mitsuki watches her son expectantly, eyes narrowing down at the continuously buzzing and violently ringing phone in his hands.

"Are you sure?"

"I'm never not fucking sure, Mom." Katsuki inhales. "I have to answer them before they fucking vanish. I know who it is."

Relief settles into his stomach, but only slightly, when the dialers continue calling him back. He waits, setting the phone in the middle of the coffee table in the dining room while Inko arrives with a large, strangely clunky mechanical device with outward speaker phones. She connects the cables to his phone, pressing a rainbow of patterned buttons until small, voiceless signals ring into the house.

Mitsuki and Masaru watch the spectacle closely.

"It will start recording when you answer," says Inko, locking onto him. "They're calling again."

Katsuki licks his lips, and nods.

As soon as the same number returns, he presses the external button.

Silence engulfs the living room. Wind rustles outside the windows, enough to rattle the bricks and polished wood that makes up the Bakugou household.

Katsuki furiously wipes under his nose, knee bobbing up and down.

The static quiet finally erupts into a jumbled series of noises. Voices whisper and mutter in the background, with the sound of an object being pulled, lifted, and slammed onto a heavier surface snapping through the area.

Mitsuki's brow furrows in suspicion.

"... K-Kacchan?"

The look of combined horror and relief on Inko's face is almost heartbreaking.

Katsuki glares at her warningly once she opens her mouth. He dips his head, and turns back to his opened cell phone, every instinct to scream and ask Izuku as many questions as possible being shoved to the side.

"Deku?" He licks his lips. "Can you… can you hear me?"

"Yeah. Yeah, I can hear you, Kacchan. Are you… are you alone?"

Katsuki hesitates for only one second before he quickly says: "Yes."

The adults in the room eye him warily, unsure.

"Where are you? Do you know what district they're keeping you in? Those sons of bitches —"

"I don't have very long, Kacchan. I have instructions to give you."

Katsuki's intertwined hands blanche white. His chest heaves with a frustrated breath.

"… Deku, who's telling you to say these things?"

"I can't tell you that, Kacchan. I can only tell you what they've given me to tell you. Even then, none of us have a lot of time left. Not here, not in Augustana."

"What the hell does that mean?" Katsuki straightens.

"I'll… I'll be seeing you soon, Kacchan. Katsuki. Come to the station in Illenova at exactly ten minutes before midnight. Make sure no one sees you. And come alone."

Mitsuki's fists are balled at her sides, her entire body ruffled like an angry bird's feathers.

Katsuki glares at her to push her into silence, an act that would normally end with him being shoved into his bedroom with the door locked.

"Why Illenova? Why that station?"

“I’m not allowed to answer your questions, Kacchan. If you follow these instructions, you won’t…”

There’s a pause, a silent step in an otherwise bloated atmosphere. Katsuki’s heart jumps, concern etching into his body at the mere thought that someone was most likely putting a gun next to Izuku’s head.

“If you follow these instructions, you won’t find me delivered to your doorstep in a body bag.”

Inko claps a hand over her mouth, shaking.

Katsuki’s hands grip fiercely around his knees. The fabric crumples under his grip, and he wonders, if he lets himself loose now, if anything will be able to prevent the gnarly anger creeping up his body.

“Deku,” he growls, “who the fuck is with you right now? Can you tell me that?”

“… Kacchan, I can’t… I can’t. They’ll hurt you if I don’t listen—”

“Whoever’s with Deku right now, quit being a fucking coward and put yourself on the phone!” Katsuki stands up from the couch, bellowing at the top of his lungs. Sparks lick at his hands, threatening to burst out into plumes and destroy everything around him. “Man the fuck up and quit making him say these fucking things! I’ll go to the station at the time you requested, whatever, but tell me yourself, instead of making Deku spout this bullshit!”

Another bout of uncomfortable, thick silence follows. Katsuki steadies his breathing, jaw open in near-animalistic pants. He locks onto his cell phone as if trying to detonate the object with his staring, but when the sound returns, it’s not Izuku on the other side.

“Goodness, you’re very much the spitfire I believed you would be.”

Mitsuki, Inko and Masaru whip their heads around, listening in absolute disbelief at the familiarity behind such a voice.

Katsuki remembers how it sounded in person, poisoning him behind a veil of smoke and flames.

“Though, you are a bit foolish to make these demands while your significant other is clearly on the less-than-favorable side. Perhaps you would like to reword your statement for the sake of his life?”

“Fuck you.” Katsuki furiously wipes at his nose. “Fuck you. *Fuck you*. Did you hear that, you crazy, fucked up old geezer? I’ll fuck you over and blow you the fuck up if you even lay one fucking finger on Izuku Midoriya!” It takes every ounce of restraint inside of him to not explode his own cell phone. “Do you fucking understand me? I don’t care if I have to come alone to your stupid rendezvous. What the hell do you even want? Power? You want to get rid of my *family*? Well news flash, you presumptuous asshole, none of that is going to change how you and that hand-faced fucker operate in the city! The Bakugous don’t go down

without a fight, and the Midoriyas are under our protection. And Izuku, he's under *mine.* You fuck with him, you fuck with me. And you do *not* want to fuck with me."

The words leave him naturally, an echo he's rehearsed in the deepest embrace of his dreams. Those nights without Izuku to talk his ear off, to annoy him incessantly, to kiss him and reassure him in his own way, had made him restless with need. With a desire and bloodlust that was unfamiliar even to him.

His mother and father watch him as if they've never seen anything like him before. He's not sure if it's a good or bad interpretation of his actions, but he's willing to sacrifice their current image of him if it means he's able to protect Izuku in some way, shape or form.

"Hm. Such a waste. You would have been valuable, if you had joined the Illenova squadron all those years ago. Nero mentioned you so favorably at one point, when you first moved here. Although, he's not too keen on having you take away my son, young Bakugou. Consider it a trade of arms, and after all… Izuku is my son. I plan to make him into someone extraordinary, but only if you follow these instructions. I do not mind killing this Quirkless brat if need be."

Katsuki's jaw clenches, tight as a brick wall.

"I'll be there, motherfucker. If even a fucking hair is out of place on his head, I'll kill you."

An uproarious laugh breaks through the speaker phones.

"Well, I suppose we'll see to it, won't we? I'll trust you to keep your word, young Bakugou. For all the flaws you and your parents have, none of you have ever been known to be… dishonest."

A shiver races down Katsuki's spine.

"Nothing to say for once? Interesting. If I had known putting my own flesh and blood in danger would do this to you and render you so defenseless, young Bakugou, I would have done it ages ago. Make sure to tell my lovely wife that I'm keeping him in good hands. I'm sure she misses him."

Katsuki's gaze briefly flicks to Inko, who is staring blankly at the transmitting device, lips twisted into the most frozen expression he has ever seen dawn on her face.

"… Hm. Tough crowd. Well, you've made your case, young Bakugou. Be sure to be there at the correct time. A minute late and my son may find himself in a more difficult position."

"Don't fucking touch him," growls Katsuki, "I said I'll be there."

"Ah, there he is!" A chuckle breaks through the static barrier. *"I'm sure he is looking forward to seeing you, young Bakugou. Remember to be there in Illenova, ten minutes before midnight. Do not be late."*

The connection breaks, leading to nothing but total quiet.

“… Katsuki Bakugou, you are not, by any means, going to that station alone.”

Mitsuki’s voice drips like icicles, her gaze unwavering. Powerful and weak, a simultaneous blazing firestorm and defeated avalanche.

Katsuki glares at his mother, throat hoarse and dry.

“And what do you think we should do then, huh? Play another fucking gamble and risk Deku getting a bullet to the fucking head? Yeah, I didn’t think so.”

“We can’t lose you too,” says Inko, halfway lost in her own world.

Katsuki ignores her. “Whatever. I’m going, and you can’t stop me. If he wanted to kill me he would’ve done it when he kidnapped Deku.”

“Not necessarily.” Masaru clears his throat and steps forward, placing a hand on his wife’s shoulder. “There’s a lot about this that we still don’t know. Clearly, Izuku was being held against his will and forced to give those instructions. The option we have at the moment is to follow through with Hisashi’s request.”

Mitsuki stares at her husband, mouth agape.

“Masaru, you… no, no, no, you both sound absolutely crazy!” She’s a second away from breaking into hysterics. Katsuki takes one step back, watching her carefully. “There’s no way I’m losing my son to that monster. There’s without a doubt in my mind that he knew we were listening. He could suspect us to play a trick against him, anyway. And what the hell does he even want?”

“He wants control over Augustana.” Inko rises from her seat, eyebrows furrowed in contemplation. The seriousness stabilizing her voice strikes Katsuki as unnerving. “He wants to use Shigaraki Tomura to plant his roots deeper into the city, and spread without a powerful vigilante influence affecting him. He knows that he’s still too far from taking absolute control. Augustana would be the first step in many to achieve a wider unground holding on the entire country.”

Katsuki scoffs. “That’s fucking ridiculous. Seriously? It wouldn’t be that easy.”

Inko turns to him, sighing. “I know my husband, and I know his ambitions. Regardless of how outlandish his dreams are, he will do whatever he can to achieve them. Even if it involves taking our son and trying to turn him into something that he isn’t.”

“I’m not losing my son.” Mitsuki’s arms tighten around her middle, her face going pale. Anger twists up her pretty face into an expression Katsuki hates seeing on her. “We’ll get Izuku back, but they’re not taking Katsuki too. I’m not going to let that happen. That bastard has toyed with us for years, Inko, and it’s time we lay it back down to him.”

Katsuki looks away, boring deep into the box that now contains a recorded exchange between them, the enemy, and Izuku Midoriya.

“… Deku’s got a plan of some kind.” He strokes his jaw. “There’s no way he doesn’t.”

“Sure, he thinks a lot. Theorizes more than the average kid does, but what does that have to do with anything, hm?” Mitsuki glares squarely at him, a mother tiger’s ferocity hidden in that stare. “There’s nothing that benefits us in you going there alone, and actually listening to him.”

“Deku’s not going to be alone when he arrives at the station. Hisashi won’t be there, but someone else will. If they don’t try to kill me then they’ll try to kill Deku.” He bites his lip. “They won’t know that I’ll have backup. But it can’t be any of you guys.”

Inko’s eyes widen at this. “Your parents, or me, or any of us, Katsuki, would be better than no one—”

“Wrong.” Katsuki crosses his arms. “That would be what he expects. He doesn’t know about some of the new relationships we’ve forged.” He grins toothily, nodding. “Yeah, that’s fucking it!” He stands up, swiping his cell phone and voraciously tapping out a number.

“Katsuki, what are you doing?” Mitsuki asks, rubbing her forehead.

“Getting someone to watch my back. And that Hisashi fucker won’t expect a thing.”

And with that, Katsuki presses the dial, and holds it up to his ear.

“Your plan won’t work, you know.”

Izuku’s whisper threads through the quiet expanse of Hisashi’s office. He squirms in his restraints, wrists bound to the arm rests of his chair and ankles shoved into the same gel cuffs Nero had restrained Katsuki with when the two of them were kidnapped.

The late afternoon sun spills a welcome ray of light into the office. Book spines glisten in cobwebs and a fresh layer of dust.

Hisashi has his back to Izuku, his right hand preoccupied with twirling a cigarette.

“Seems to me, that you were attempting to swindle my followers, my son.” He flashes a grin over his shoulder, curved in a menacing shape. “Perhaps, you would be wise to reconsider whatever plea you’d bargained with Nero. As much as I enjoy his services with you, you’re only digging your grave a little deeper with attempting to lead him astray from his duties.”

Izuku swallows, tongue thick and dry.

“We never made a bargain.” He shrugs, avoiding Hisashi’s expectant stare. His heart slows and speeds up in patterns, a devastating throttle under his ribs. “He only believes that we did. I thought you’d be impressed with how easily I can tug him around, giving what you told me a few nights ago in my own bedroom. After he struck me with a baton.”

Hisashi quirks an eyebrow. “Hm. Color me a little surprised, then.” He chuckles. “Again, you waste your potential on such trivial, fickle things. Attempting to become a widely publicized writer, a journalist who wishes to bring back heroes from the dark world where they’ve been pushed…” He shakes his head. “There’s much more to this entire game than you could ever imagine, my son. You’re only in the beginning stages. The prelude for something great to come.”

Izuku licks his lips. Sweat laces the skin on the nape of his neck.

“So why aim to destroy Augustana, then?”

Though, he supposes that he already knows the answer.

Hisashi puffs out a ring of smoke through his lips. Flames lick around his mouth.

“I’m not destroying Augustana. Or even considering it.”

“But you want to sacrifice lives to prove a point?” Anger rises in Izuku like a steaming pipeline. “Isn’t that the exact opposite of what you keep claiming to do? Isn’t that what you shouldn’t be doing? Putting the people you want to control in imminent danger? If they find out who you are, and what you’ve been planning, they won’t want to follow you!”

Hisashi scoffs, the action left with little volume to spare.

“You’re much too emotional for this line of work, I’m afraid.” He crushes the cigarette stick between his thumbs. “Although, your intelligence is surely your greatest weapon. Your naivety, however, keeps you in the dark.”

A frown pulls at Izuku’s lips. The implication is not lost in his father’s words.

“These lives are necessary to take for the sake of a new beginning.” Hisashi turns to him, the look in his eyes glossy with mischief, with dreams held in glamour. “Perhaps you would care to think about that a little more, when you think about the necessities taken to rebuild. In order to start anew, previous distractions must be eliminated for the sake of the greater good. For the sake of a new beginning. And of course, none of that is achievable if the loyalties within one city are divided. Some consider the squadrons to be useless. Others consider them to be controlling. Some believe that they are far better than a normal police force or even superheroes parading the streets.”

Izuku mulls over this, lost in the image of the Bakugous in a time where they would have been heralded as the city’s protectors. Requested to relocate from Russia to instill some form of normalcy in a place quickly diving into corruption. Very few questioned those methods, those beliefs behind the Bakugous pulling strings in the shadows. Though no one had considered the positive results of their decisions, of their sacrifices.

“There can’t be two kings.”

Hisashi’s hand pauses in raising to his mouth with another stick. The paper material ruffles under his fingertips, and he slowly, agonizingly so, turns towards Izuku with both brows risen to his hairline. The gobsmacked expression seems so out of place on a man who deems himself incapable of stepping out of line in any way.

Izuku nods, locking onto his father’s gaze.

“You’re going to kill him, aren’t you? Shigaraki.” He considers this, rolling over the possibilities. “It would make sense, honestly. To think that you have him under your control, after knowing him for so long. I know that you and Mom worked with him in the past, or at least that you did. I was being kept a secret in the background, apparently, so I wouldn’t be able to recognize any of these things in an obvious way. But I guess it’s kind of glaring evidence when actually thinking through it, isn’t it?” He shakes his head. “You’re so willing to throw away any possible challenger that you give up your family, and your old allies to achieve it. I suppose that is the opposite of what a hero would do, if your goal really is to go against the normal status of a pro hero.”

His eyes glint, mischievous and bright.

“Unless, you have something else planned for that. Planned for me. I think, if you really had everything going your way, you’d have Mom stay with you, and you’d get rid of me as fast as possible—”

“You’d best be quiet before I tell Nero to pay you a *visit*.”

He spits the words through gritted teeth, sharp and fleeting. Unnerved.

Izuku shrugs, glancing about the office with a marked sort of interest.

“Hm. Think he’s starting to like me more than you, Dad.”

Hisashi straightens at this, a vein pulsing in his forehead. His silhouette falters slightly in front of the tinted window glass.

“You’re wasting your time with the Bakugous.” Izuku grins slightly, his eyes crinkling in the corners. “Maybe it’s me that you should worry about.”

The silence that follows is deafening.

Izuku’s lungs feel tight and heavy, as if he’d swallowed a bucket full of iron and lead.

Hisashi jams his unused cigarette into the ashtray on his desk. Smoke billows in a whimsical cloud, though none of it is comparable to the definitive stream flowing through his flaring nostrils. The anger that rests in his dark jade eyes, that color his pale features a darker rosy hue, ignite a new sense of confidence within Izuku.

“Perhaps I should.”

Hisashi does not even need to buzz any of his guards in to let them know that he wants Izuku gone.

Play your cards right. Play your cards right.

For once, Izuku doesn't believe he's completely foolish to consider that maybe he doesn't actually have any cards to play. But right now, standing beneath a dark, starless black sky, he reconsiders that idea and follows it into another realm of thinking.

Smoke floods the emptied streets of Illenova. It's eerily quiet, and beside the resting, giant automatic structure of the train. Within minutes, the giant machine will rumble to life, piloted with no one in the front, meant to pick up weary people only hours after its first testing circle winding throughout the loops of Augustana. An iron fence is positioned around the hotel building where Izuku has been kept prisoner, several guns pointing through windows, ready to shoot if need be.

"None of this is necessary," he whispers.

Only one person is accompanying him on ground level. He refuses to admonish the dark, quiet silhouette leaning casually against one of the supportive pillars to the building. The utility belt glistens in its gold and copper lining, the familiar patrolling watch bright and luminescent with glowing green numbers. They tick closer and closer to midnight, and the air grows colder still.

"You sure have been complaining a lot lately, Freckles," says Nero, pulling out a cigarette and chewing on the end.

Izuku turns away, swallowing the lump in his throat.

With how roughly Nero's hands are trembling around each and every movement he makes, Izuku knows that his father had spoken to him. Not once did Nero attempt to grope him, or whisper in his ear, or press himself up to his back when leading him from his bedroom to the outside destination. All the while, Izuku was forced to keep staring ahead, the blindfold removed to only allow him viewing of the train resting at his side, stationary and unresponsive.

"Hate that blond fucker," says Nero, his foot tapping impatiently on the cement ground.

Izuku grits his teeth.

He's not your biggest fan either.

None of this makes sense to him.

"Why did Hisashi even set up that call with Kacchan and his family?" He watches Nero expectantly, wondering if the other male will bother to even acknowledge him when he's practically shaking in his boots. "I don't have anything to trade, and he doesn't… so why have him meet by the train? Why does any of this matter? There's no point in killing the Bakugous, or trying to."

Would he attempt to capture Katsuki as well?

Part of him was delighted at the thought of finally seeing Katsuki again, of reassuring him that he was safe. But another part of him knew, inevitably, that none of this would amount to the conclusion that he believed possible…

To leave this area unscathed, and return to the Bakugou household.

"All you have to do is stand there and look pretty."

Izuku glares at Nero's profile, his wrists chafing in the Quirk-enhanced cuffs.

"Not going to relay any of this to me?"

"What, you gonna offer to suck my cock for it?" Nero peers over his shoulder, his glare sharp and offended. "Almost worked the other day, Freckles. Would've let you, you know. Didn't know that your papa would think I was scheming with ya and threaten to burn my dick off."

Izuku shrugs. "Not my fault."

"Hm." Nero's smirk is barely noticeable behind a puff of his cigarette. "Wish I could just kill him. That prissy Bakugou prince…"

Izuku holds back a rumbling growl threatening to burst out at the comment. He shoves his heels further into the soil, hoping that he can control his emotions until he sees Katsuki.

"Speak of the devil."

Izuku then jolts up, nearly tripping over his own shoes. He gasps as Nero reaches out and snatches his forearm, holding onto him with a vice grip. He swallows, and looks forward into the darkness, squinting as he does, to make out the familiar, unmistakable shape of Katsuki Bakugou.

He's alone, walking towards them with his hands concealed in the pockets of his jeans. Old, rugged sneakers, the outline of a black shirt detected through the open zipper of his brown leather jacket. A beanie, one of the matching ones Inko had made for both Katsuki and Izuku, is pressed tightly over his wild blond hair and forming a protective cover over his ears. He saunters towards them, lips set in a firm scowl, and to watch him make his way over with not even a weapon or one person attached to his side makes Izuku's heart leap.

Nero hums under his breath.

“Interesting. Fucker didn’t bring anyone with ‘em…” He takes out the same phone-like device that Izuku had hacked only once, and flips it open. He speaks into it as if using a walkie-talkie. “Hey. Yeah, Edmure here. Hold your fire for now. Keep an eye out, though. Looks like the dog prince came alone.”

He is the first one to take a step. Izuku is tugged alongside him.

He needs to remain stone-faced, despite the tug on his heartstrings.

To see Katsuki, even now, both of them exhausted and stressed beyond belief, lifts his spirits.

Izuku opens his mouth to speak, to say something, anything—

“Deku.”

Katsuki says his name stiffly, but the undertone of relief is undoubtedly there.

Izuku hesitates, and nods, holding back a smile. He can see that Katsuki is doing the same, clenching onto every muscle that will allow him to remain impassive in front of Nero.

Nero’s grip tightens possessively around Izuku’s arm.

The action prompts Katsuki to break away from Izuku, stare at Nero’s hand, and then back up towards the Illenova squadron leader with a sneer curling back his lips.

The fire in his dark maroon eyes is nothing less than *deadly*.

“Talk, Nero. What the fuck did you want from me?”

Nero snorts. “Well, I want you dead.”

Izuku squirms at this, tempted to speak, but stops at the threatening squeeze around him. Nero chuckles darkly, shaking his head.

“Fortunately for you, Bakugou that would be a bit counterproductive to what my bosses both want. I don’t get to call the shots from the higher-ups, you know? Big bummer.” He grins crookedly, an expression that seems ghostly in the dark of nightfall. “Be nice, and neither of you will get hurt, understand?”

Katsuki’s glare sharpens, his nostrils flaring.

“I’d appreciate it,” he begins, teeth glinting, “if you took your *fucking hands* off of my boyfriend.”

Izuku’s eyes widen at the tone of voice.

He’s never seen Katsuki this close to the edge.

Nero’s hand pauses on his utility belt, inching towards his baton.

“Oh. I see. So that’s how you want to play it?” His grin only widens, as if envisioning slapping Katsuki across the face with the deadly force of his weapon. “That wasn’t part of what I told you, Bakugou. Pretty damn sure I wasn’t finished talking before you started making demands. Not very smart of you, eh?”

“I don’t fucking care.” Katsuki takes one step forward, standing a solid four inches shorter than Nero, but his stance strong and countering, nonetheless. The energy that surrounds him, that consumes him, is electric. Reckless. “Hands. *Off*.”

“Kacchan.” Izuku bites his lip, watching as Katsuki’s hands pull out of his pockets, sparks threateningly spurring in his grasp. He needs to soothe him, to pull him back from whatever spell he’s put himself under. “Kacchan, it’s okay.”

They need to be patient. He needs to be patient.

“You should listen to him.” Nero tilts his head. “You ready to be nice now and stop making demands of the person who’s got Hisashi Midoriya’s son under keeps? Who’s got him close to a gun, to a baton and, oh, you know… death?” He yanks on Izuku’s arm for emphasis, refusing to break eye contact with the absolutely furious, barely controlled glare that Katsuki is sending his way. “Would be terrible, really, if something were to happen to that pretty face while we’re negotiating like adults. Wouldn’t you agree, Bakugou?”

Izuku grits his teeth, fury pulsing through his body.

“Listen to him, Kacchan. Please.”

For your sake. Please, don’t get yourself killed. Not now. Trust me. Look at me and trust me.

Katsuki glares at him, sharp and dangerous, though Izuku remains steadfast. He silently nods, hoping that the message is clear, that Katsuki can trust him enough to do this.

Wordlessly, Katsuki takes a hesitant step back, hatred and anger rolling off of him like the waves of a storm-trodden ocean. He raises an eyebrow as a gesture for Nero to continue.

“Hmph.” Nero rolls his eyes. “Good. You see this train over here?” He flicks his head to the giant, unmoving locomotive beside them, protected behind iron railings and locked gates. “We’re going to board this metal motherfucker. You following so far?”

Katsuki’s glare is telling enough.

“… Right.” He smirks. “You’ll be going on there, and we’ll be following you shortly after. More instructions will be given inside. Glad to know that we’re on the same page.”

He ruffles Izuku’s curls, his grin malicious and taunting.

“Freckles here will just be quiet while we talk. Glad he could join us for this man to man conversation. Think we can both agree that we have one thing in common, right?” He reaches over and takes hold of Izuku’s chin, the teen stiffening and immediately attempting to pull out of it. “Though I think he likes kissing me more. ”

Katsuki's entire body freezes. The murderous look in his eyes promises death, and for once, Izuku finds himself truly terrified.

"Kacchan—"

But Katsuki ignores him. "You going to spout bullshit all night or…?"

Nero huffs at this, straightening and pulling Izuku next to him.

"Yeah, yeah. Get on the train, fucker. There's a lot to discuss."

Izuku can feel Katsuki's glare boring into the grip Nero has on him. Guilt seeps into him at the memory, of allowing Nero to kiss him where he was afraid he wouldn't be able to reach the one method of communication possible to reach Katsuki.

Nero unlocks the gates and leads them both onto the train. His grip is easily bruising, even over the material of his sleeve, as the doors to the train open, and they are ushered inside.

"Opposite side of the cart, Bakugou," says Nero, goading Izuku to sit beside him. He leans back against the window as Katsuki glares at him quickly before, reluctantly, abiding by his command. "Good, good. Look how *obedient* you are with Freckles at my side." He chuckles. "Damn. Alright. So you see this giant train, here, Bakugou?"

Katsuki's knuckles are white, hands gripping around each other. His throat is bulging, veins popping.

He's barely containing himself.

Izuku closes his eyes, breathing.

Patient. Patient. Patient.

"Yeah. I fucking see it." Katsuki snorts. "So what's the point then? It's not even active right now."

"Oh, but it will be soon." Nero smirks, crossing his legs. His arm lopes behind Izuku's head, hand resting on his shoulder and squeezing the area threateningly.

It isn't until Izuku barely shifts an inch when he notices the glare of a blade hidden in Nero's sleeve.

The action itself is enough to make Katsuki *bristle*.

"You know that, Bakugou. Our patrols used to overlap. Except yours was illegal and mine was approved by the government. So, with this in mind, think of what we would need you for."

Katsuki eyes him, rolling his jaw. Clenching his teeth.

“Come on, don’t leave me hanging.” Nero shrugs one shoulder. “Think about it. The Bakugous… well, we all need that kind of reminder in the city that you and your family are just, not to be trusted, you know? With that bullshit article you posted online, people are starting to question the squadrons. Questioning our validity in Augustana.”

“I wrote it, not him,” says Izuku.

It’s an instinctive reflex, one that earns a look from Katsuki that’s cloaked in concern.

The blade flicks out from Nero’s sleeve and grazes his throat.

He freezes. Sweat bursts out onto his skin.

Nero leans in to whisper against his ear.

“Don’t talk, Freckles. The adults are speaking.” He turns back to Katsuki, seemingly satisfied with the barely controlled anger radiating off of the shorter teen. “Even if he did write it, you put it into the world, Bakugou. So tell me, what would I ask of you to do?”

Katsuki’s back is tense.

“You want Augustana to see us as worse than you. They already do, you fucking idiot.”

“Ah, hold on there.” Nero nods. “This is true. The public don’t like you. But here, on this train… everyone, all kinds of civilians, pass through here and hope that they’ll be able to make it work, to school, all of that good stuff without any harm. We squadrons keep the trains safe from crime, from assaults and terrorist attacks. Everything suspected to occur in a large metropolis like Augustana.”

The wheels begin to turn in Izuku’s head.

He pales, mouth opening.

“No, no, you can’t—,” he gasps, silenced with the point of the blade pressing into his pulse.

Katsuki stands up, fists balled at his sides and his lips twisted in a disgusted, distressed frown.

“Oh, Freckles figured it out.” Nero grins. “He’s so smart, isn’t he, Bakugou?”

“Kacchan,” says Izuku, desperate, “don’t—don’t listen to him. You can’t do what he says—”

“Shut up, Deku!” Katsuki snaps, desperation hanging onto every word.

Izuku shakes his head, tears welling in his eyes. His hands are trembling, barely holding onto what confidence he had left.

“Smart.” Nero licks his lips. “It’s really simple, Bakugou. We’ll just be waiting here on this very train until the routes open up for the day. We’ll even give you all the instructions, and then…” He gestures around him vaguely with a wave of his arm. “Boom.”

Realization dawns on Katsuki's face. HIs throat bobs with a swallow.

"You…" He looks away, ripping off his beanie and carding one hand through his hair. "You're fucking *sick*…"

"All those sacrifices will be worth it, Bakugou." Nero laughs softly. "Besides, it'll be much easier for you. You don't even have to do more than let loose your Quirk in this tram. Let the sparks fly, let the bodies fall, and we'll even get a good, fat picture of you to post all over the city. Then everyone will know who started the biggest massacre in Augustana history."

Horror seeps into Izuku's gut.

"But if you refuse, well."

Izuku wriggles, attempting to break free when Nero grasps him and pulls him closer to him. He buries his nose into his curls, the blade tracing down his arm and the point still close to the buttons trailing up his collared shirt.

"Even as a hostage you smell so damn good, Freckles," he purrs. "You refuse, Bakugou, and we'll both have to suffer the loss of this sweet face."

"*Let him go*," growls Katsuki, his voice ashen and strained. Held back by chains of his own command, like the desperate charge of a tiger.

"Hm. I think not."

"Kacchan—Katsuki, I'm not worth all of those people." Izuku shakes his head, his fists clenching and unclenching. "Katsuki. I'm serious. Look at me, you can't let this happen! You can't let all of these people die, but you can't trade my life for theirs, either!"

"How noble of you," mutters Nero.

Katsuki stares at Nero, a conflict brewing in his shifting eyes.

Then, Izuku keeps his head held high, and Katsuki meets his gaze.

For one moment. One fleeting, indescribable moment, Izuku can read him clearly.

I have a plan.

And so, Izuku closes his mouth, and chooses to trust.

"Fine, you sick bastard." Katsuki nods. "I'll do it."

Chapter End Notes

And it will only get crazier from here...

As always, thank you so much for reading, everyone! Let me know what you think in the comments. Does anyone have predictions on what I have planned for these two? Hmmmmmm?

Stay tuned. :)

Sabotage

Chapter Summary

Forgiveness was not even a blip on his radar. Not until he met Izuku Midoriya.

Chapter Notes

WARNING: Pretty gory stuff. Lots of action. All that jazz.

Actual Note: Thank you, first off. Everyone, you keep me going. You make things easier. I'm lucky to post this on my lunch at work because man I don't have time as I usually do. Thank you for your thoughts.

Please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Friday. 4:15 AM.

Katsuki knows he’s not a patient person.

From the moment he was born, he was volatile, screaming at the top of his lungs in the arms of his own mother. Never begging, but demanding. He was entitled to react a certain way given his surroundings, and any change in what his underdeveloped mind had perceived to be out of place was meant to be straightened or corrected, or else he would lose whatever temperament he kept bottled up inside.

Perhaps it’s not patience that riddles every breath he intakes at watching Izuku shift across the length of the train. Perhaps it’s not anything related to patience at all, given the unbridled anger and fury that rises high and sweltering—a pipeline seconds away from bursting. The bloodlust that courses through him, that distracts him from his own plan, makes every image of tearing Nero’s head off his shoulders and exploding his corpse all the more vivid.

Izuku is watching him, doubtful. Hopeful. A walking contradiction. The blade pressed to his pulse taunts Katsuki, lulls him into a growling timbre.

Get your greasy hands off of him, motherfucker.

It's a message sent wordlessly through every glare. He knows Nero receives it, given the overly satisfied smirk and the growing shine in his dark.eyes.

Sweat cascades down his back, staining his shirt and jacket, and the glare in his eye shows confidence he admittedly does not currently have.

The one lifeline to his scheme is linked under his collar. A simple wire, taped to his chest, hidden from plain view. With Nero's eyes either locked onto him or Izuku, he doubts that the thin black trail will be detectable anytime soon.

"I'm glad we get to have a couple hours of just, man to man bonding. Y'know?" Nero laughs lightly, crossing one leg over the other and allowing the hand on Izuku's shoulder to drop, sliding down his arm. Izuku tenses up. He leans in, and Izuku looks away, his Adam's apple bobbing with apprehension. "So good that we see eye to eye, right? What do you think, Freckles? After all this is over we can go back…"

Katsuki's eyes flash.

Nero presses his lips to Izuku's temple, his grin slick and malicious.

"Remember what we talked about, hm? I can have you transferred to my squadron, get you all nice and ready for a reformed Augustana, keep you protected…"

He shoots a glance at Katsuki, who remains stone-faced despite the war zone brewing in his throbbing head. The hand snaking over Izuku's thigh is more than a taunt—it's a claim, a competitive attack against Katsuki.

"Stop," says Izuku.

Nero ignores him.

"C'mon, you like this. Be good for me. I'll take care of you. Make you *mine*—"

Something terrifying, protective and possessive spirals up inside Katsuki and motions him to stand up. He doesn't realize he's moving until Izuku desperately shifts in his seat and stares up silently at Katsuki, those green eyes swollen with fear but not for himself—for him, for Katsuki Bakugou and no one else, and it's because of that look that Katsuki releases a long, strained breath.

He turns on his feet, and punches a window. Cracks splinter under his knuckles. Pain wells under the flesh and bone.

"Kacchan—"

"You're fucking dead as soon as this is over, Edmure."

Nero's face is washed blank, unimpressed, but Katsuki refuses to relent. The fury that dives through his muscles and fuels his clenched fists beg to hit something, to break something.

“Yeah, yeah, you’ve said that before—”

“No.” Katsuki seethes, a wry, crooked smile slicing across his mouth.

His eyes are dark with unconfined, animalistic fury.

“You don’t get it. When my reputation’s soiled, it won’t matter what I do. If I’m going to kill anyone in my lifetime, it’s gonna be you, motherfucker. I’ll follow through with this sick plan of yours, but it was your mistake involving Izuku.” He leans over, brow pinched in the middle, mouth partially opened to allow a fume of air to fall through. “You understanding me?”

“Leave him alone, Nero,” whispers Izuku, barely audible but certainly there.

Nero hums, as if considering this.

“Of course you’ll defend him…” he mumbles. “I can do whatever I please, Bakugou. If it weren’t for me, who knows what would’ve happened to our favorite baby face here. I protected him, kept him under guard, made sure he was fed and kept in a nice, spacious bedroom.” He clicks his tongue. “Besides, he’s mine. I fucked him first.”

“No, that’s a lie,” says Izuku, moving to stand. Anger rolls off him like steam. He winces at the press of the blade into his ribs, and glances up at Katsuki, those green eyes wild with a rising flame. “Kacchan—Katsuki, that never happened. *Never*. I never wanted anything he did to me—”

Nero silences him with pressing the blade up to his neck, forcefully tipping his head back.

Before Katsuki can lunge forward and break Nero’s jaw, the train rumbles.

Nero picks up the phone hybrid device from his belt and brings up to his mouth, his gaze never once leaving Katsuki.

“No, wait, no,” says Izuku, shocked pale, shaking, “this—this isn’t possible. Why is the train —why is the train *moving*?”

“Starts in the early hours today. Five o’clock and things move right on schedule.” Nero clicks the button on the device and clears his throat. “Hey. Edmure here. Yeah. Train’s starting to deploy. Things are right on schedule. Keep the fleets on higher ground and put a sharp eye on the train.”

The wire under Katsuki’s shirt feels heavy. He hopes this information travels.

“So where’s your coward of a boss?”

Nero blinks at this. “Care to repeat that?”

Katsuki’s nose scrunches up. Energy crackles in the air.

“Hisashi. Bit of a bitch move to hide behind his dumbass guard dog.”

Nero's chest puffs out.

"You have no right to call me a guard dog, you piece of—"

A blurring, distorted noise flies through the train. Katsuki braces himself against one of the iron support beams. His heart steadies under his chest, anger surging through his blood.

Static rumbles through the cart. Vibrations sputter under Katsuki's shoes. He steadies his balance, even as the metal screeches and grinds, and the sound of steam and oil-powered machinery rolls and leaps in distorted patterns.

His palms spark, filling with anxious sweat, though the detonations are forced to a halt when he wipes them on his jeans.

"Huh." Nero's lips curl.

The speakers crackle like thunder.

"Good morning, Augustana residents and tourists. This is Cori, your trusted guide through our signature cycle from our designated hub in Illenova. Please be amicable to boarders, keep watch over your belongings, and watch your step. Security protocol is installed for safe travels and our tolling system remains the second-best ranked in the country. So, make yourself comfortable, smile, and welcome to Augustana."

Katsuki squints up at the speakers as the voice fades out.

The grinding ceases, and the train rattles and launches into a silk-smooth pace.

The endless column of squeaking, yet polished iron and metallic fibre tiles and leather cushions are empty. Within minutes, this entire train will be flooded with incoming strangers, all nameless faces attached to their own schedules. Mothers and daughters rushing to school and work. Fathers and sons doing the same, crossing paths with others of the same kind, of the same dress—every shadow with their own story, and none of them understanding the weight of what these minute, daily interactions will lead to.

Katsuki's mother and father never deemed themselves to be heroes. They watched over the city while working underneath it, refusing to let certain ties fall loose like shoelace strings. Masaru walked about as if always prepared with an olive branch hidden in his pocket, while Mitsuki was adept and skilled in more than twelve varieties of firearm. They were a force to be reckoned with, yet it never occurred to Katsuki what it meant to feel like a true guardian.

He never listened when his mother lectured him about being a Bakugou. He'd never considered the attachments to his name until he'd sauntered into the districts themselves, sneering and unimpressed with the vast amount of stench and spineless patrolmen littering the streets.

Katsuki blinks out of his reverie. He lifts his head, back aching. He shuts his eyes tightly, breath leaving in controlled flares though his nose.

He glances upward, and catches Izuku's stare.

Despite all that's happened, with the knife still trailing down Izuku's clothes like a rolling barbwire, he smiles.

Lips spread and wobbly, green eyes shining. Hopeful. Determined.

There's strength in his gaze, in his entire being. Behind the awkward clothes and constant mumbling, Izuku's doubts and worries never overrode his resolve. For the few months they had known each other, Izuku had pushed him. Inspired him. Took his hand, and pulled him through a veil of uncertainty and new expectations—new dreams, new possibilities—by insisting that he was going to be one of the best reporters of the new generation.

Since the beginning, he reflected his beliefs.

Izuku, as if sensing his thoughts, tilts his head. It's a brief gesture, but it speaks loudly to Katsuki, lassoing him in a place of brief comfort that he knows will be diminished in a matter of moments.

"Won't be long, now," Nero mutters.

"Shut up," says Katsuki.

He wipes his nose in his sleeve, discretely brushing over the button hidden underneath the leather material. He looks up, and catches Izuku's wandering eye. The other boy's brow is carefully furrowed, a level of caution clouding over him in a silent wave. Thumbs rubbing together in quiet friction, lips pursed, chapped, and painted with cuts and a sliver of a bruise.

The length from his side of the cart to Izuku feels wider and wider with each second that passes. As if the metal is folding up and over itself, rippling in a storming gray ocean. His knuckles are plastered white with tension as the noise of the train dissolves into white noise, and then a new blanket of silence.

Twenty minutes later, the train slows to a halt.

The doors slide open, and a handful of people step onto the train. All older, possibly in their late forties or early fifties, wiping sleep from their eyes and carrying coffee thermoses in gloved hands. A blast of cold air washes through, and few of them pay any mind to the three young men positioned in the far end of the rear cart.

"You know, Bakugou," says Nero, humming, "I almost thought you'd try to throw some backup plan at us. You really came on your own, huh?" He grins and leans forward. "May not have been the best decision on your part. Love seeing this... heh. You're on your own, being an obedient little dog."

Izuku visibly reddens at this, his anger a dangerous button to press.

Katsuki almost grins.

"But, on the other hand, I've got all sorts of people watching the train. Guns pointed. Scanners ready. If you brought anyone without telling, well, we'll find them. Who'd you convince to come with you, huh? Your parents? Freckles' precious mother?" He ruffles

Izuku's hair, and the boy ducks out of his reach, but is pulled back into his space less than a second after. "So many options—"

"Yeah. You got me all figured out." Katsuki rolls his eyes.

Nero cocks his head, studying him quietly. The expression on his olive face is unreadable, though when he stands up, roughly tugging Izuku along with him, Katsuki bolts from his seat on reflex.

"Ah, ah," says Nero, eyes blown wide, "not another step. Just watch."

Katsuki grits his teeth, but reluctantly stays beside the bench. Izuku's hands are balled and pressing over the fabric of his pants, seeking some sort of anchor. Some type of leverage.

"Right here," says Nero, planting this foot firmly on the middle tile that separates one cart from the next. It's a slick, smooth surface of solid steel and rumbling cables underneath, made to be the perfect walkway from one cart to the next. "You'll be standing right here when the time comes. Just let your Quirk go. The rest of it will be handled."

Alarm bells ring off in Katsuki's head. He stills, locking onto the walkway, and carefully scanning the parameters of where he would potentially be aiming his Quirk. Through the long line of moving carts, he detects certain spaces that are smoother, flatter than others. Other walkways for the elderly and children, waiting for another step.

No fucking way.

He presses his hand over his chest, carefully brushing over the wire.

"So, what, you think my Quirk has an endless range, dumbass?" He suppresses a grin as Nero whips around and glares. "Despite how amazing my Quirk is, it doesn't have its limitations. You expect me to just set them off like flamethrowers from here? Would be impossible, unless I had enhancers of some kind. Maybe something cylindrical to fire off like a cannon." He dips his head, considering. "But here? Nah. None of that would ever work. So maybe be fucking clearer with your instructions."

Nero snorts. "You're trying to trick me—"

"You want me to follow through with this plan or not?"

Their eyes clash. Fire and steel. A rockslide and a thunderstorm.

"Don't get smart with me." Nero kicks the ground. "We've enhanced the train. Get it? That's all you need to know. This vantage point will make it easier for your Quirk." He looks over his shoulder, to where several more passengers have stepped onto the train, some exchanging silent greetings amidst the warm, coffee and smoke-filled air. "You got anymore questions, I'll just have Freckles answer for me."

"Fuck you."

Izuku's jaw is clenched tight, face pale. But he's watching Katsuki, as if attempting to decipher what he's planning.

Discretely, Katsuki tilts his head back, glaring mockingly towards Nero but deftly sliding his hand over his collar in a feigned attempt at rubbing his neck. His fingers barely flick out the wire before he quickly adjusts his collar and shoves his hands into his pockets, breaking eye contact.

Before he glances away, however, he catches Izuku's mouth parting in awe.

Despite the situation, he grins.

Before long, the tram fills wall to wall with people. Many different faces pop out with color amidst scarves, heavy coats, puffy jackets and a gloves rubbing together for spare warmth. Exhaust pipes ground outside the windows. A drizzle of rain slathered the glass.

It was nearing five o'clock. Tolling hours were not ready to commence just yet.

Nero removes the communicating device from his belt and presses the button.

"Yeah, Edmure here." He pauses, groaning. "Yes, asshole. Obviously the train is moving. Keep the others ready when we cycle through the districts… yeah, we're about to stop in Redmond, now."

Redmond District…

Katsuki's lips curl.

The exact place where Izuku was kidnapped six weeks ago.

The train rumbles and slows to another stop. Katsuki grips his wire, hoping that the information travels. Sweat slicks his palms, a steady stream of sparks dashing through his veins, prickling underneath his skin and simmering on his flesh like back burner fumes.

"And where exactly am I supposed to be, then?"

Izuku's sudden question surprises Katsuki, though despite the restrictions placed on him with Nero's hold on Izuku, he will not hesitate in striking Nero if he steps out of line again.

"Just at my side, Freckles." Nero pats his shoulder, watching Katsuki carefully. "Since Bakugou is being so good," he drawls, grinning at Katsuki's vicious glare, "think we'll have some time to ourselves after this. That what you want?"

Izuku turns away, furious. He tenses as Nero's fingers weave through his hair, the touch mockingly feather-light, dangerously close to a threat.

Katsuki's breathing quickens.

Focus. Focus. Focus. Remember the plan. Remember the plan.

“Thought so…” Nero nods his head towards Katsuki. “Five minutes.” He points to the platform. “Make sure you get yourself coordinated, alright?”

He then turns, and smiles at a few questioning onlookers in the second cart over. “Good morning,” he croons in a surprisingly soft voice. Several of the strangers smile in return, and look over to his timestamp watch for confirmation. He chuckles and waves politely, and the gesture is so oddly fitting that Katsuki finds himself shocked and angered.

As if flipping on a switch, Nero is able to transform and don a cloak of superiority and trust.

The thought sickens him.

“You’re *disgusting*,” says Izuku, nearly bristling with anger.

“Quiet,” says Nero, “I’m in a good mood.”

Katsuki presses his hand over his shirt, and feels along the wire for the button. His heart steadies, slows, and jumps again as he feels a familiar shiver. A voice, buzzing through, a command crawling inside a tunnel of brief connection he shares with a handful of people he is able to trust that aren’t related to the Bakugous.

He knows this pattern.

He closes his eyes.

They know where we are. Remember the plan.

He stares out, into the unaware throng of people.

People who have slandered him, held him on a pedestal of distrust and defamation. People who have turned to his family without hesitation and have spat on his shoes, have disregarded him at his own home in Sommartyn. People who he wanted to protect, because it was a role he obtained at a young age—at an age where his parents smiled down at him and told him to remain courageous and strong. And, ultimately, forgiving.

Forgiveness was not even a blip on his radar. Not until he met Izuku Midoriya.

“Kacchan,” says Izuku. “You—please, you don’t have to do this. Don’t worry about me. I’ll —I’ll be fine, I can get out of this okay.”

There’s an exaggerated lilt to his voice, telling of an underlying confidence.

Katsuki hides a smirk.

Smart motherfucker.

He wishes he could kiss him.

“Ah, he’s made up his mind, Freckles.” Nero nearly purrs through his sentence. “Will do anything for that face of yours.” He pinches his cheek, the grip harsh enough to make Izuku

stumble. “Makes sense. Would be such a shame—”

“Tell me where to stand,” says Katsuki, edging closer and closer to a growl. “Quit fucking around.”

Nero taps his foot on the same tile.

Katsuki takes a bold step forward, and waits there. His hands sweat in his pockets, brimming with energy. He imagines fire and gasoline, and pictures the thousands of people somehow caught up in a violent whirlwind. He knows it won’t happen, if his allies are watching his back like they claimed, then they should be moving soon.

He presses the wire under his shirt.

“Fine. Stepping onto the tile now, I guess,” he says a little loudly, rubbing over the wire and pressing a hidden button. “So what, you just want me to activate my Quirk—”

“The fuck you playing at?” Nero snaps. “Don’t talk about your Quirk fucking out loud, you moron. Just follow my instructions. Isn’t that hard.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, but nods. He pulls his hands out of his jeans, fingers flexing, knuckles cracking.

He stares out into the other similar tiles, the barely noticeable folds in the floor. He wonders what’s hidden under those spaces, what wires are connecting to potentially extend the effects of his Quirk—

Realization slaps him in the face with the weight of a cinderblock.

He stares at Nero, insulted. Outraged.

Then, without warning, he grabs his communicator, rips the cable out from underneath his shirt, and screams into it.

“Todoroki! The train is littered with bombs! Don’t let loose your fire side! Get moving *now*!”

Nero’s face is washed blank, and he blinks dumbly.

Time seems to slow.

Katsuki grabs the iron support beam and crouches low to the ground, bracing himself as the train jolts, shifts, and rickets off the rails in moments. People scream and stumble over themselves, grappling desperately onto the walls and each other. Children bellow at the top of their lungs, and Katsuki can hear crying. Sobbing. Can see tears sliding down many faces of people he’s never talked to, whom he’s never bothered to know until now.

Nero stumbles, grabbing onto the bench for support. For just a few seconds, he doesn’t have Izuku in his hold.

Izuku grabs the knife, turns around, and slams it onto Nero's hand.

He screams.

"You fucking—fucking *whor*e—"

Katsuki's heart is close to exploding out of his chest. He looks around, and watches Izuku brace himself beside the wall, watching Nero like a hawk as the teen struggles to move with his own hidden knife skewered through the back of his hand and through his palm. Izuku then reaches outward and swipes the communication device from his belt, bringing it up to his mouth.

"Don't shoot," says Izuku, shaking, "we have Nero Edmure here on standby. Do not shoot the train, under any circumstances!"

Nero rips the knife out, and the murderous anger that flashes through his eyes is unmistakable.

Katsuki curses.

He can't use is Quirk.

The entire train has been turned into a death trap.

"Deku—"

"Go, Kacchan!" Izuku nods his head and backs away. "Get those people out of here! I can handle him!"

No you fucking can't!

Nero's bloodied hand clenches into a fist. He pulls out his baton, the length electrifying with sparks.

"Trust me," says Izuku, not breaking eye contact with Nero. The smile on his face is telling enough: there will be no changing his mind, and Katsuki can't rescue these people and save him at once. "*Go*!"

Katsuki feels as if the air has been sucked from his lungs.

He needs to tell him—

No. Trust him. Move quickly. Get back, help him.

Katsuki turns, and bolts through the train.

"Everyone!" He shouts at the top of his lungs, standing on top of the bench and nearly ripping his own throat apart with the ever-increasing volume. "This train has been sabotaged! You have to walk in an orderly line and get out the emergency exit at the end of the train! Get off into Redmond and don't ask any questions!"

The look of absolute fear that swallows up the entire crowd ignites Katsuki's anger.

"Just get moving!"

"The door—the door's stuck!" one older gentleman shouts. His spectacles are nearly falling off his nose. "It must be sealed from the inside—"

"Well try *harder*!" Katsuki shouts. Sweat builds under his shirt, running down his back.

So many people could die if they step somewhere out of tune. If something ignites one of the many bombs placed on this cart.

Todoroki had successfully stopped the train, as they had planned. But the engines will start up again soon, and the ice surely holding down the first few carts will be broken through within minutes. They have a limited time span, and with the myriad of other tasks that his own parents are completing in this very moment to buy them time, he knows that too many decisions rest on his shoulders.

Fuck.

His knees are shaking.

Keep your shit together!

"Head to the emergency exit near the front!"

Several heads turn up towards him, questioning even now in the middle of a moment where all of them would have fallen over dead.

"You're going to have to trust me! Augustana's patrolmen are against you!" He points down through the opened channel of carts, to the very end where a slew of exits will greet them. "So get moving and get off this train before it starts moving again! If you don't, this entire tram will blow up, and none of us will be able to stop it! You really want to stick around and see what happens?"

His words settle into a crackle. Men and women alike start to rush, dashing and stepping over each other's shoes to reach the doors first.

"Let everyone move quickly! Don't step over each other and fuck everything up!"

He watches them carefully. Many heads bob up and down, different silhouettes running and pushing against each other and, thankfully, attempting to obey his instructions.

Deku. Deku's alone. Fuck, fuck—

He needs to return to Izuku.

And then, the train jostles. A barrage of noise assaults their surroundings, from screeching glass to grinding gears to the sound of thick ice snapping in half like toothpicks rattle the

entire train. Katsuki's balance fumbles, and he falls forward to grab onto another bench, one foot on the ground and the other white-knuckled on the glass of a window.

Panic bursts into the area, leading to a chorus of shouts and frightened screams.

"Everyone stay calm!" He stands up tall, blinking. He lifts up the wire, and presses one of the communicator buttons. "Hey, Todoroki, why the fuck is the train moving again?"

"We're trying, Bakugou."

"Well try harder!" Katsuki shakes his head. "You need to stall for more time."

"The doors are barred from the outside as well. This was planned."

Katsuki bites his lip.

"Can you reach the front of the train?"

"... There's a dip between Redmond and Sommartyn—"

"Can you cross that border?" Katsuki's hand is shaking. He pushes through the crowd, shouting for them to stand aside. He needs to return to Izuku, though his movements are haphazard with each leap and stumble. "You're going to have to. If the front of the train is moving in Sommartyn, you have to get there to stop those wheels. If you don't, then that Nero fucker will let the bombs loose."

"I will do what I can."

"Good."

"Bakugou, we will save these people."

Katsuki snorts. "Obviously. Now get moving. And if you stop the train, get on here and help me find the bombs!"

He drops the wire and pumps his arms. The train jolts, and he slides off his shoes. He slips, his back cracking against a locked door. The metal rams into his spine and skitters pain down to his toes. A harsh grimace flies through his chest and knocks out air.

"Fuck," he gasps.

He scrambles to his feet and shifts to move. His heart is a reckless battering ram in his ribs, and the dread that hangs in his gut belongs to the image of Izuku losing to Nero, dying by his hand. The life choked out of him, that same blade struck through his chest, across his neck, or pinning him down while he was shot to death—

Don't die.

Blood roars in his ears.

If you die I'll fucking kill you, Izuku!

He's about to meet the walkway to the second to last cart where Izuku and Nero are barred, when a blast of fire spirals past his shoulders and shockwaves him back. He loses his balance for a fraction of a second, before slamming his fists into the ground and gasping as his own added attack forces him to remain upright, knuckles near-broken.

He whirls around, and stops.

Hisashi Midoriya grins at him, a phantom from another night. Those haunting green eyes are bright with hidden rage, with a lick of energy that aims to tear Katsuki apart from the inside-out.

His bare arms are entrapped in cords of flame. His mouth opens and closes, smoke billowing out and threateningly caressing the air in tentacle-like wisps.

The massive hole in the ceiling is telling enough for how he somehow barged into the tram.

"And where do you think you're going?" His voice drips with sin and barely contained anger. "You really do love interfering with my plans, don't you, young Bakugou?"

Gooseflesh streams along Katsuki's arms. He gulps, stands up, and holds out his palms. He turns his body, as if in a boxing match, careful with watching Hisashi's calculated, feline movements. The other man is tall and slender and nearly serpentine in the way he moves, the way he speaks—it brings back memories of Katsuki being thrown into the wall, fire nearly engulfing his entire body.

"You're gonna lose," he says, a shard of ice in the train.

"I'm afraid this won't be a fair fight. After all, fire is able to move rather carefully with my Quirk. Your explosions are too dangerous to use in this space." Hisashi clicks his tongue. "I was impressed, that you were able to deduce where the bombs were so quickly. And to use Enji's own son as your ally…" He shakes his head, chuckling. "Color me surprised. But even that trick won't work for you."

Katsuki snorts. "Cut the fancy garbage. You gonna fight me or not? Because I'm not leaving until you're fucking dead, crazy fucker."

"I let him do it," says Hisashi. His head tilts slightly, like that of a curious tomcat. "Nero."

Katsuki bristles.

"*Shut up*." His voice clips, barely above a whisper, harsher than gunfire. "Shut the fuck up —"

"I let him have his way with my son." Hisashi's grin grows wider. Crooked and silky-smooth. "Izuku never did listen to my advice to use that to his advantage. I would've expected more. Perhaps him being Quirkless has been a bit too much of a setback, don't you think? Not being able to defend yourself, when a person preys after you so openly and without conscience—"

Katsuki blindly rushes forward, fists swinging, and barely misses Hisashi's rebounding kick. He jumps back, panting, his glare sharpening into glass.

"Stop fucking around!"

You're lying. You're fucking lying!

"Then fight like the Bakugou you claim to be. Like your mother and father." Hisashi laughs, a cheerful, destructive sound. "I would hate to see all of these innocent people die without reason. Other than to set an important example, of course."

Katsuki steadies himself, pausing. For a moment, the train rolls beneath him, the echoes of his own footsteps and Hisashi's words running through his mind.

"Then don't fight me in here, where the bombs will set off."

"… Maybe you're not as smart as I believed you were." Hisashi's lips quirk. "But do enlighten me. I find this fascinating."

Katsuki's nostrils flare. He has very few options, and he won't be able to return to Izuku with Hisashi standing here, with him only yards and yards away from killing both Hisashi's successor and Katsuki himself.

"You wanna fight fair?" Katsuki snorts. "Then let's fight fair. I can't use my Quirk in here. You already said that."

"True…" Hisashi frowns, and then, his eyes widen in realization. "I see."

Katsuki jumps onto the bench, leaps up, and grabs the rim of the circle where Hisashi came through. With a burst of strength, he hoists himself over the edge, and staggers to his feet as the train moves in a rumbling, broken pace that was once careening at higher speeds. The air rushes coldly through his jacket and over his bare skin.

The moon and stars are luminous. The city of Augustana is cloaked in morning darkness, with dawn barely slipping over the more distant rooftops. Lightposts flash in broken patterns. They remind him of better times, where he held Izuku's hand in a cold, gentle night under a Christmas tree. Where he smiled, and for just a few minutes, they didn't have to worry.

For a moment, he can breathe.

Katsuki turns around, his muscles tightening as he balances on the back of the train. He watches as Hisashi appears within moments, the man locking eyes with him and moving to stand tall, shoulders squared and mouth parted.

"You're reckless, yes," he says, grinning, "but you have a lot of guts. Get ready, young Bakugou. I will not show any mercy."

Katsuki barks out a laugh. He extends his hand, and curls his finger once toward him, smirk ever-changing and wide as sparks bloom over his palms.

Energy crackles through him; a buzzing firestorm of bliss and vivid release.

“Bring it on, motherfucker.”

Friday. 5:25 AM.

The moment Katsuki turns to run, Izuku is barely able to dodge from Nero’s swiping hands. He lunges backward, scrambling, uncertain with the baton landing where he once stood.

“*You fucking little bitch*,” breathes Nero, lost in a blind, animalistic fury. “You’re not getting away. Not this time. I won’t let you.”

Izuku shakes his head, hand splayed out on the wall. He watches the baton carefully as it twirls in Nero’s hand, and glances over to the blade scattered on the ground. He needs to reach it, but with Nero forming a blockade between him and the blade, he knows he won’t be able to.

Nero’s blood drips ominously on the metal floor.

“Then come get me,” he says, spitting onto the ground, “*coward*.”

Nero lunges for him, slamming his baton onto the ground. Sparks explode on impact, a reminder. A threat. Izuku runs and stumbles, reaching for the blade, right where Nero’s shoe slams onto his wrist. He gasps as a ripple of pain shoots through his muscles. His fingers splay out, and the knife is taken from his reach. He can hear Nero chuckling, grinding down his boot onto his wrist. Bones crack under the pressure.

Nero’s mouth is by his ear, and Izuku’s heart is in his throat.

“You look so good beneath me, Freckles.” His knee jams into Izuku’s back. “Much better than Bakugou ever did.”

Izuku’s mind blanks.

Kacchan.

Nero and Katsuki…?

A memory, one that seems so far gone, chases after him and beckons him to listen.

Their encounter with Nero for the first time. Katsuki warning him to stay away. Nero talking to him with so much familiarity, as if their acquaintanceship stemmed between them, and without the influence of the other Bakugous. The fact that they had each other’s phone numbers. Threatening voicemails and text messages. Katsuki mentioning talking to each

patrol when first moving there, testing the waters. The dreading realization that whenever Nero would approach Izuku, Katsuki's name still lingered on his tongue.

"... Lucky for you, this a private session. Doesn't matter when or where I use my Quirk, old friend."

"Answer the questions, Bakugou, or I'll fuck him right now and make you watch."

"I bet Bakugou has you go down real hard on him..."

"Wonder what Bakugou would think if he saw us right now..."

"Hate that blond fucker."

"Wish I could just kill him. That prissy Bakugou prince..."

His heart rushes, stops, and kicks into overdrive.

Every muscle coils, and with strength he didn't know he had, he twists his torso, shoving Nero's leg aside, and rams his knee up into Nero's crotch. He gasps, though it's not before Izuku grabs the baton in slams it into Nero's temple. The patrolman grunts, momentarily falling off of Izuku while the smaller boy crawls out from beneath him, grabs at the blade, and shoves it into Nero's arm.

What did you do to him?

He wants to scream every accusation, every question burning in his throat like a layer of bile.

He never asked. He'd never considered Nero targeting Katsuki. Not once.

And yet…

"Fucking cunt."

Nero grabs Izuku's wrist and pulls the blade out. He pins him down with his body weight, snarling beside his ear. His legs straddle Izuku, and the teen screams behind Nero's hand beneath him. He wriggles, struggling, desperately reaching for the blade, and panic seeps into his heart as Nero's other hand reaches under his shirt and towards his belt.

The body pressed flush against him, the knees pressed on either side of his hips, and the rapid tearing of his clothes blare louder than any signal in Izuku's body.

"You're mine, Midoriya," Nero snarls, sinking his teeth into Izuku's shoulder, "now quit squirming and be good for me, Freckles—"

No!

Izuku bites Nero's hand, clamping down as hard as possible. His teeth skewer through flesh, chipping on bone, and Nero howls, ripping his and out of his mouth and allowing Izuku a

chance to slam his head back and ram into his jaw. Nero gasps, winded. Izuku scrambles out and grabs the knife.

He turns around, and *aims*.

The knife jams into Nero's eye, right as the man is already hovering over him for the third time, ready to trap him. He screams, blood gushing out into the tiles. Within moments he's trembling and flailing onto his back, howling brokenly at the top of his lungs.

Izuku grabs the baton, shaking, and stands. He looms over Nero's body, and the rage that rushes through his body fuels a fire he never knew he had.

"F-Fuck, no, no, no, don't, y-you fucking cunt—"

Snap.

The baton rams down onto Nero's chest, and he jerks at the impact. His body convulses, blood frothing in bubbles through his lips. He reaches out aimlessly, struggling to see as Izuku bounds around him and strikes again. Electricity zaps through his body and causes him to jolt, even as the blade remains lodged in his head and drawing out shriek after shriek.

You tried to hurt Katsuki.

The thought of this disgusting man targeting a boy he adores makes Izuku's blood boil. He keeps moving, his mind warped in another realm of reality. Nothing seems real—the train, the echoing snap of metal on bone, Nero's pained yells dissolving into defeated whimpers, and then to nothing at all—none of it.

Eventually, Izuku's grip around the baton loosens. Sweat cakes him from head to toe. He blinks through his reverie, and locks onto the body.

Nero's face is completely caved inwards, his head lifelessly tweaked to the side. His left arm is broken and twisted in an inhuman angle, blood pooling beneath his body. His eye continues gushing, from a dramatic fountain to the slow, telltale trickle of a new death.

Izuku turns, and vomits onto the floor. His hands are quaking around his knees. Tears slide down his face, a devastated, horrified groan building up inside his body and threatening to overtake him completely.

Nero's dead.

He wipes his mouth with his sleeve. Each move is shaking like a leaf under a raging summer wind. His heart slows and rocks back and forth in a seesaw. His lungs feel heavy, wrapped in steel. When he turns to the door, he wants to see someone, anyone—Katsuki, Katsuki Bakugou—step through that entryway and lead him out.

He glances at the body. His fingers twitch.

I...

He killed him.

… oh my god…

He slumps back, though the panic he expects changes into a sense of overwhelming blankness. He can still feel Nero's fingers burrowing into his hips, his breath ghosting through his ears, the sound of his fingers tearing apart his clothes and reaching for his belt. He remembers every touch, every threat, and to think of Katsuki, once in a blue moon, being subjected to something even remotely similar makes him feel only a little bit justified.

"Midoriya."

Izuku jolts, flinching at the slightest touch. He blinks, and locks onto the shocked, concerned features of Shouto Todoroki. The boy's hand is inches away from his shoulder, his mouth settled into a stern frown. He flicks his gaze briefly to Nero's corpse, and back towards Izuku.

"Can you stand?"

Izuku swallows.

"Todoroki, I…" He bites his lip. "Thank you."

The boy's frown deepens. He sighs.

"Don't thank me yet. The train has already started moving. We have to get you somewhere safe—"

"Wait, what?" Izuku straightens. "You were the one who stopped the train just now? Oh…" He remembers Katsuki screaming into the hidden wire. "Wait, where is Kacchan? Have you seen him?"

Todoroki wordlessly reaches out his hand. Izuku takes it, and stands up. Despite the growing sickness in his stomach, he knows this isn't over.

"He's fighting your father on top of the train. I've managed to slow down the gears with enough ice and frost to keep the rear carts and two of the first two railcars stationary. Many people are trying to evacuate and I need your help in doing that."

Izuku stares at him.

"Kacchan—he's on top of the train? Fighting my *father*?"

Oh, no, Kacchan, no—

"Midoriya—"

"Todoroki, he's going to get himself killed." Izuku shakes his head. "Help take me to him. Please. Show me where he is. I'll help you evacuate those people but we need to find him and make sure that he's not alone—"

Todoroki places a hand on his shoulder. Izuku locks eyes with him, steady and furious.

“Okay.” He hesitates, and nods. “I understand. Let’s go.”

Izuku smiles, though the gesture is weak.

As soon as they burst through the back door, the thought of Nero’s words and his corpse lingering in the rear cart remains instilled in Izuku’s memory.

Hold on, Kacchan.

He quickens his pace.

Just hold on.

Chapter End Notes

FUN FACT: That scene with Katsuki fighting Hisashi Midoriya on the top of a train was actually the very first random scene I thought of before even coming up with the concept for the fic. So basically that one scene in this chapter is the one I thought of first, and everything else? Just kind of came together. Funny how that works.

And. Hm. I wonder how many of you suspected Nero's history with Katsuki.

But, is he worth trusting?

You will see...

Next chapter is a doozy, guys. This is also the hardest one I've written so far. It was so difficult, especially that last scene. Writing any sexual scene is very difficult for me but this in particular was hard for obvious reasons.

So thank you for your patience. Until next time.

Pandemonium

Chapter Summary

> Nothing will prevent him from putting each and every ounce of strength he has into this encounter; the longer this battle takes, the more time he has to keep the train in motion and the inhabitants safe.

Chapter Notes

> Have I mentioned how amazing you all are? I read and cherish every single comment with my life. It means so much to know that all of you are still reading and even enjoying it with all the twists and turns that's happening so quickly...
>
> Thank you. So much.
>
> Onto the next chapter. You're all wonderful, and I owe you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Friday. 5:37 AM.

“So, do you plan to gawk at me from over there? Or are you going to finally make a move?’

Hisashi’s grin is taunting under a full moon and thousands of stars.

Katsuki’s blood boils, an invigorated grin breaking out onto his lips as he drives his heels into the steel of the train cart. Wind rushes through his clothes and ruffles his sleeves and collar—nothing can obstruct their confrontation.

Nothing will prevent him from putting each and every ounce of strength he has into this encounter; the longer this battle takes, the more time he has to keep the train in motion and the inhabitants safe.

“You sure like to talk for a little *bitch*,” growls Katsuki.

He aims his igniting hands on the floor, and a flurry of explosions propels him off the metal. He flies off the tiles and skates around Hisashi, right as his opponent whips around and slams his knee into his gut. Gasping, Katsuki launches his left fist to Hisashi’s shoulder, sparks clipping the cotton and causing the older man to duck out and weave away from the surprise attack.

Hisashi somersaults, sits upright, and lashes out with a flame-encrusted hand. His palm lands on the spot where Katsuki jumps, the teen rolling to the side and ramming his fingers into the metal. Small explosions skitter off his fingertips and carve holes into the metal, anchoring him.

He pants, heart racing.

“Fuck,” he gasps, reeling back and angling his entire body in a defensive stance.

Hisashi wipes a smudge of grease from his jaw. The jade glint in his eyes are fierce, highlighted with bloodlust and a trace of starlight.

“You’re fast,” he says, huffing out a breath, “quicker than expected. I must say, your parents never did have such impressive reflexes. Perhaps I’ve been underestimating you.”

Katsuki blinks, and Hisashi is gone.

The smell of burning sulfur and smoke assaults his nose, and a blistering grip is wrapped around his neck.

He gasps, writhing in the painful sensation of embers being released and scorching his flesh. Panicked, he sinks his teeth into Hisashi’s fingers and rips himself out of his grab, tumbling over the tiles and forcing another series of sparks to allow him to form another series of finger-shaped holes in the metal material.

The heavy stench of his own burning flesh makes his stomach twist into knots. He chokes, ramming his own fist into his stomach. He spits out bile and saliva, desperate to prevent the potential poison from entering his bloodstream.

“F-Fuck! What did you—”

“You’re lucky to only have obtained a few second-degree burns, and not even with a full grip around your neck, young Bakugou.” Hisashi chuckles. “I would have taken you to be aware of such a strategy. Did you never learn about basic dodging, of all things?”

Katsuki growls and snaps his teeth. “Come fight me like a man, fucker!”

“Such a spoiled brat…” Hisashi sighs wistfully. “Very well.”

Katsuki's eyes bulge, nearly popping out of his skull.

Don't stop moving.

He leaps back, his shoes scraping the train. Wheels slide threateningly on the railings, chipping through the temporary barrier of slow-melting ice and forcefully burned platings to hold the first few carts together. He glances over the edge to the iron support beams and platforms, and gulps in air as the burns continuously lick and grow on his skin.

Hisashi's chest heaves, his stomach sinking in.

With the wild, manic look in his eye, Katsuki reads the attack before it happens.

A massive plume of flame shoots from Hisashi's mouth, lightning-fast and crackling. Katsuki rolls, blasting off his feet with a quick burst from his Quirk. He whips his body halfway, Hisashi's other palm landing right beside him. A harsh, crunching pain zips through his spine.

Hisashi is hovering over him, an exposed palm burning with fire. Katsuki brings his hands together and slaps them on Hisashi's legs, but before he can ignite the explosion, the older man leaps off of him and bounds several yards away.

Sharp pain rips through Katsuki's ribcage.

Shit—!

He hobbles, but just barely, and forces himself into standing once more. He brings up his hands into fists and angles his body for the umpteenth time on the top of the train. The noise of a blaring horn and screeching metal on rails is not enough to distract him from the searing burns on his clavicle and throat, and the stuttering pulse of broken bones underneath his skin.

He pants, glaring across the length of two train carts to watch Hisashi. The man is relaxed, regaining his breath and wiping sweat from his forehead. He looks ethereal, prepared for any minor, quick movement that Katsuki could throw.

His Quirk is versatile and quick, while Hisashi's is suited for longer and shorter ranges. The way Hisashi watches him, slick and composed and undeniably stone-cold,

What's his weakness?

Katsuki's knees shake.

Ignore it. Ignore it. Fucking ignore it!

"Again," shouts Hisashi, laughing, "you're very quick! Stupid, but quick!"

Katsuki grunts. Blood swells up along his punctured lip and drips from the burns on his collarbone to the dip in his shirt.

The train makes a sharp turn. The taller buildings and broader, polished streets of Sommartyn greet them—a snapshot of simpler times, where onlookers watch their trusted transportation curve in a loop and struggle to recognize the occurring chaos.

In a matter of hours, whatever happens on this train will be broadcasted and imprinted into thousands of residents who believed they were safe.

Katsuki wobbles and leans down, only slightly, to drive his nails through the holes he'd formed minutes earlier. He scans the perimeter, silently counting each way he can create another hook to prevent him from flying off the train. It costs him at least two seconds to drill sparks through his fingers alone to create those holes, and more time Is needed to dodge the expected attacks.

Hisashi has possibly already deduced the pattern he's creating, and is now biding his time.

"You're stalling," calls Hisashi. Coils of flame and smoke slip past his open mouth, his laugh frozen and dangerous.

Katsuki huffs and rips off one hand. "Don't underestimate me, you piece of shit!"

Ripping both of his hands off the metal, he launches off one tile to the other, slipping and sliding as the wind rushes and the train swerves to the left and right. Hisashi watches him closely, arms taut. Katsuki tilts his head downward and flicks his thumbs against his middle fingers. The small extra push to the blast shoves him a second faster under Hisashi's radar, landing him right beside him. Clenching his teeth, Katsuki pivots his heel behind Hisashi's leg, and slams his open-faced palm into the older man's back.

Hisashi is there for a second, and within moments he's skirted around Katsuki.

Katsuki gasps, a dreadful weight slamming into his chest and stomach. He gapes down at the metal surface, saliva and blood frothing between his lips. Black spots blur his vision, and the smell of burning clothes and a hiss of pain from Hisashi reminds him that he landed one successful shot.

He smirks, just briefly, as another weight rams into his spine.

Every bone and muscle screams. The weight on his back shoves further, a steely boot grinding into the dip between his shoulder blades. He wriggles, and brings out his palms and slams them on the ground to propel him off—

Only for another boot to ram into his wrist and crack the bone.

"Look at you," Hisashi mutters, his voice thrumming in Katsuki's skull, "acting so high and *mighty*."

The foot pinning down Katsuki's wrist presses down further, brutal and unforgiving—yet Katsuki forces every noise to remain subdued. The train blitzes by, the noise of wheels on steel hardly enough to keep him lifted above the murky ocean of his mind.

The boot pauses, sliding almost tauntingly over his sleeve until it presses feather-light over the bone and skin.

Katsuki's eyes blow wide.

"*Disgusting*."

Katsuki wrenches his body to the side, raising his other hand—

—As Hisashi's boot *crushes* his wrist.

Friday. 5:25 AM.

The train jostles to an abrupt halt. Wheels screech. Doors slide open and closed in frantic, broken rhythm. Icicle spears chip away increasingly under the fighting pressure of the railings.

Izuku's knees are weak. His chest feels numb.

Around him, the voices of many strangers blur together in a cacophony of disjointed color and noise. The static buzzes in his ear, instantaneous; a taunting melody that lulls him continuously into a stupor. With each step he takes, each intake of breath that flies through him, his heart falls throusgh and struggles to catch the coattails of every unspoken word and vision.

Todoroki yells every few seconds, directing Augustana residents—men, women, children—off to the sides. His face comforts some of them, the occasional nod and smile of gratitude meeting him with little restriction. His chest heaves and his arms pump, desperation hanging over him in a heavy cloud.

"The ice," Izuku starts, staring out of one of the windows. The earsplitting grinding of the railings hits another block of ice, spurring off its movement. "How many… how long do we have?"

He blinks through the haze. He tells himself to focus on the burning, bright yellow and red paint of the walls. The occasional, desperate muttering from a stranger. The shuffling of his own shoes.

Todoroki slows, following Izuku's eye.

“I had plenty of time to move through Illenova and Redmond. But once we pass through Sommartyn, we won’t have any resistance from the ice. I tried…” He hesitates, “I tried holding it off as best I could for the time being. But I had to get on the train when I knew that it wouldn’t hold back in Illenova for much longer. And Bakugou was desperate to take a head start.”

Izuku nods. “It makes sense.” His focused on the jarred tiles separating the carts, and the pattern of linked squares, railings and pipes that interweave the train into one giant corridor. “Kacchan mentioned bombs… when Nero was holding me hostage, he mentioned that Kacchan’s Quirk would set off a few more explosions if he stood in one particular spot.”

Todoroki considers this. “When he was yelling through the wire, he mentioned that. The bombs.” He glares out the window, focusing on the columns of shaving ice being pushed and ground under the train’s desperate wheels. “I’m not sure how long this will last…”

Izuku turns to look over the patterned squares and the patterns that had struck him earlier that morning. Katsuki had been told to stand in one particular spot to release his Quirk, and those spots had to be scattered throughout the entire length of the train. Were they heat detectors? Conductors? Were these a special type of bomb that only reacted to certain temperatures or Quirk effects?

“Midoriya.”

Izuku clamps his jaw shut, thankful for the inevitable mumbling.

“We have to check the pathway tiles that separate the carts.” Todoroki raises an eyebrow, and Izuku’s smile only grows as he considers his options. “Think about it, Todoroki—the bombs have to be hidden in plain sight, and reactive only to certain temperatures or fluctuations. That’s why Kacchan told you to hold back your fire side while onboard.”

“So then maybe cooler temperatures would hold off the bombs from reacting…” Todoroki swivels around the tight space, locking onto several dark corners and empty seats. “And you think they’re all set up underneath the pathways that link the train together?”

Izuku’s brow furrows, stroking his chin as he scours his surroundings. Several strangers watch the two of them curiously, though Izuku only grins if he catches their eye. If he allows any semblance of his musings with Todoroki to affect these people, then nothing will be able to prevent the wave of panic that would ultimately consume the entire operation.

“Kacchan’s strong, but he won’t be able to defeat my father. Not on his own.”

“This was out of what was originally planned,” says Todoroki. “My father didn’t believe what I had told him, and was ultimately against the prospect since it involved the Bakugous. But, those detectives that you befriended offered to help us.”

Izuku’s eyes widen.

The detectives!

“And our parents?” He holds his breath, dread seeping into his muscles at the thought of something happening to either the Bakugou parents or his mother. “Are they…?”

“They told us they would be going behind the scenes. But none of us expected Hisashi to be here.” Todoroki locks onto Izuku, a tentative glimmer of impressment shining in those depths. “They’re investigating Shigaraki’s location back in Illenova.” His lips quirk. “If they hadn’t, I guarantee you that many more patrolmen would have followed me onto the train.”

The thought alone makes Izuku pause. He thinks of Detective Yagi Toshinori, a man of waif-like features and an air of obscurity. Despite these, he appears kind and empathetic, as if he understands Izuku’s plights with each hour that passes in this dark, tangled city.

Was he protecting his mother? Were they all searching for more clues? How was it possible for them to stay on their own path while Izuku, Todoroki and Katsuki fought out of their reach?

“They’ll be alright, then,” he whispers, an uncomfortable rise of bile traveling up his throat. “But Shigaraki… he’s more equipped than they think. They would have to get someone else’s help if they wanted to take anything down.”

Todoroki pauses. “Midoriya, you’re already injured pretty badly. And—I wouldn’t recommend you follow me any further. I will need your help in securing every person and making sure they all leave the train unscathed.”

Izuku glares at him, a defensive recoil winding up his muscles. The feel of Nero’s baton in his hands and the sight of his corpse flashes in his mind’s eye.

“Midoriya?”

“I…” Izuku shakes his head. “I’m fine. I want to help. I can do more than that. I’m not weak.”

“I didn’t say you were,” says Todoroki, searching him. “Either way, I have a good idea on where Bakugou is located, and which cart he’s on.”

The thought of Katsuki being hurt—burned, broken, battered—makes Izuku’s insides lurch.

“We need to find him,” he says, hollowly. “Please, Todoroki—we have to move *now*.”

Todoroki opens his mouth to respond, but his voice chokes into a grunt as the train rumbles and slams into an abrupt halt. The carts are splayed in a curved angle, and the force of the shift causes Izuku to stumble and grab onto a support beam. The pipes screech, wheels pausing and clunking in a broken song.

An earsplitting scream sounds above them.

Izuku’s heart drops.

Kacchan.

Todoroki pales. “That was—”

“Kacchan. That was Kacchan.” Izuku holds his breath, his pulse loud and refusing to remain steady under his skin. Each heartbeat echoes in thunderclaps. “I have to go find him.”

Todoroki grabs his elbow. Izuku whips his head around and glares, his chest heaving in desperate pants.

“Midoriya, you won’t be able to stop him,” Todoroki mutters, harsh and grating like iron between them. “You have to understand that if we go too far of what we had originally planned, Bakugou could be placed in even more danger.”

Izuku rips his arm out of Todoroki’s grasp, the humming in his ears blaring.

“I’m going to help him.” He shudders, flicking his attention to the folds of metal separating them from the tumble of wires, gears and oil-slicked machinery underneath. “Todoroki, how controllable is the ice side of your Quirk?”

Todoroki blinks, his frown deepening. “I… I have more control over that side of my Quirk. It wouldn’t be hard to manipulate the width or length of it, if that’s what you’re asking.”

Then maybe…

Izuku brightens, determination and a newfound surge of confidence rushing through him. Katsuki wouldn’t allow these concerns to hold him behind from his goals. And with the sensation of Nero’s blood lingering on his clothes and flesh, Izuku knows he needs to change his intentions. This entire train, with every struggling resident, needs to be stopped entirely.

“It will take too long to find all of the bombs and pull them out, if we actually do find them…” Izuku dips his head as the words tumble through his lips, until his eyebrows shoot to his hairline. He rushes to Todoroki, grabbing his shoulders and shaking him. “Todoroki! That’s it! We need to keep the entire train completely stationary, right? And the bombs will ignite if we allow the metal to be too hot or for the engine to burst. So now, we have to use your Quirk to set the pipes and wiring to a cold enough temperature that will halt the bombs entirely! And if the bombs are put in a cold enough state to be inactive, judging by what Nero was saying earlier…”

Todoroki stiffens, realization washing his face blank.

“Then the surrounding machinery will force the train to stop.”

“From the inside-out,” says Izuku, finishing with a broad smile as he backs away.

Despite this discovery, he’s trembling from head to toe. Every inch of his body is sensitive, as if the hushed whispers dispersing around them and the rumble of the train under their feet pull him continuously back into the present. His balled hands shake, vibrating with the thought of helping these people, of stopping the train, of somehow forcing the heat-sensitive bombs to a permanent stasis—

Kacchan needs him.

“I’ll inform the others,” says Todoroki. Izuku turns to him, startled. “I know that you need to find Bakugou. Hisashi won’t be able to predict that you would make it there.”

Izuku’s smile his weak, but his heart is leaping with adrenaline.

“I’m going to help him.” He hesitates. “Hisashi won’t succeed, Todoroki.”

His friend says nothing, and grins. The confirmation of their discussed plan falls in the silent space, and Izuku holds onto it with desperation as he turns, and bolts through the gathered crowd. He pushes, shoves, and gently reprimands adults and children alike—and the sight of their faces, of their doubts and lingering pain, resonates powerfully inside him.

As a child, he’d sought to change the interpretation of pro heroes. He’d wanted to bring back a fallen dream for not only the city of Augustana, but the country; maybe even the world. He’d written countless experimental pieces, commentary segments on websites, and integrated his own thoughts into whatever journalistic manner he could muster. He’d never imagined to find heroes in the undercurrents of this place he knows as his home. The humble buildings, scattered districts, and large populace have struck him as overall indecisive, and unable to grasp the inevitability of needing someone heroic to watch over them.

Katsuki Bakugou had never sought such an image.

Nero Edmure, and those who supported him, and followed the rules of Shigaraki Tomura and Hisashi Midoriya, were the ones these people knew to be honorable and true. Not once had they considered a Bakugou to care more about them or consider their misfortunes while they remained trapped in the scheme of their own heroes’ making.

Augustana needs the Bakugous. They need you, Kacchan.

The racing of his heart turns sporadic. A dance hidden in the confines of organ, blood and bone.

I need you.

Almost instantly, the temperature grows from warm and tight to cold and measured.

“What’s happening?” an older woman hidden in the scuffle asks, terrified. She’s thin like a beanpole and clutching her jacket, a thick red scarf wrapped loosely around her heavy neck. “Why is the train getting colder? Oh, no, no, no, this can’t be happening. Where are the squadrons? Why aren’t they helping us?”

Izuku hesitates, only for a second, but he can’t answer her. He needs to keep running, and find the source of Katsuki’s one noted scream.

Todoroki can handle it. Don’t stop. Don’t stop. Find Kacchan. Find Kacchan—

A massive *thud* reverberates through the train. The sound of something heavy being slammed, repeatedly, onto the metallic ceiling. Thick, bulbous dents form outlandish shapes in the hallowed metal. Yellow paint peels and flakes, nothing but faint wisps in the condensed atmosphere.

Izuku glances up, following the trailing noises, every hair rising on the back of his neck.

Could that be them?

He looks forward, and gasps at the sight of a massive hole torn into the ceiling. A heavy gust of wind flies through, whipping the collar of his shirt. Trembling, with a new burst of energy, Izuku scrambles forward and desperately climbs the emptied seat cushions, eyeing the mangled rim of the impromptu escape with a form of focus he never knew he possessed.

He leaps far enough to grasp the edge of the hole. Huffing, he hoists himself up, and ducks instantly as a blast of ferocious air rushes by him and whips through his curls. The moon and stars are near-blinding, the sight of the train struggling to move from its spot making his entire body turn stiff and invulnerable. With a tight clench of his muscles, he reaches over the edge, desperately clawing at the metal. The surface slides under his hands, his own blood—and Nero's—printing the sleek tiles.

Another gigantic slam, one that ricochets through the night like a vicious slap, directs Izuku's attention around. His body swivels, and his balance is thrown off its position, when he locks onto Katsuki's body sprawled on the ground, Hisasihi's hand wrapped around his neck.

Katsuki's right hand is limp at his side, twisted in a horrific angle. His left hand is grasping Hisashi's pinning forearm, desperate and igniting whatever sparks he's able to inflict. He's staring up at Hisashi, a choked, gurgling noise flying through him as Hisashi lifts him by his neck and rams him back into the ground, causing another shudder to vibrate through the cart and quake Izuku's bones.

The sound that rips through Izuku's lungs and crackles into life is anything but human.

"*Kacchan*!"

The train swerves. Izuku gasps and and springs to his feet, nearly slipping off his own shoes. When he finally turns back up, he meets the eyes of his father.

Dark green, yet illuminated like blistering comets.

"You're a bit late," he says. "Oh, did you hear him?"

Katsuki's response is a harsh grunt, a desperate whisper that Hisashi silences with another slam into the train.

Izuku needs to hear him speak, to know he's alright. That he's still breathing.

"Stop!"

Izuku falls forward, seeking the finger-shaped indents in the metal that form the perfect hooks for his fingers. His body and mind blazing with fury, Izuku meets Hisashi's eyes again, intent on dismantling him as soon as he reaches their vantage point.

"Get your hands of off him! Kacchan has nothing to do with this!"

Hisashi scoffs. “I beg to differ. It’s because of scum like him that Augustana is stuck in such a primeval state. It’s a shame just how gone you are, Izuku.” And then, with startling strength, he takes Katsuki by the neck, and lifts him up. Katsuki chokes, struggling to move, and spitting droplets of blood onto the metal. The look that crosses Hisashi’s face is positively manic.

“No, *stop*!” Rage and worry courses through Izuku’s veins. He watches Katsuki’s every twitching muscle, the definitive slashing of his clothes and he wonders just how horribly bruised and broken his body is.

“Very well.”

Izuku blanches. He’s forced to remain still, completely swallowed up in the envelopment of time slowing to a standstill. His father turns away from him, strolling to the edge of the train and dangling out Katsuki’s barely conscious body over the edge.

Izuku reaches forward on instinct, and wobbles as the train stumbles through another hunk of ice.

Keep going Todoroki! Please!

“I should just drop you,” Hisashi says, loud enough for Izuku to hear over the grating railings and rushing of smoke and wind. “Get rid of the Bakugou prince that’s been grating pretty strongly on my nerves. That was a bit of a trick you did earlier, I must admit.”

He chuckles, and in this moment Izuku is able to pinpoint the singed and viciously burned clothes draped over Hisashi’s figure. Torn patches of sinew and burned flesh, revealing brutal pink and red slashes on his own skin.

“What do you want from me?”

It’s desperate, a move that he’s not sure will work. For a moment, he imagines he’s strapped to the chair in Shigaraki Tomura’s warehouse, being manhandled against his will while accusations of being a spy were hurled towards Katsuki Bakugou. He’d never been more afraid, but for a few moments, just a few, he had their attention. Zeke, Nero, and Shigaraki himself had listened to every word he said, and it was because fo those spare moments he was able to allow them a chance to escape.

Buy time. Buy time.

But for what?

Hisashi clicks his tongue, a sound that laughably echoes far louder than the blaring metal and wind.

“Suppose it would be a waste of time.”

Izuku braces himself, and a slight tremor of relief vibrates through him when Hisashi carelessly tosses Katsuki to the ground, along with the dreadful rage that ignites his senses. Izuku tenses up, and dashes to Katsuki’s body. The other teen struggles, blanching as he

attempts to balance on one side and reach up with his available, unbroken hand already sparking to life.

“Y-you stupid, twisted *motherfucker*!” Katsuki spits, each word hoarse and gravelly. Izuku comes behind him, holding him, right as Katsuki slumps backward. He’s heavy and pliant in his hands, and the warmth of Katsuki’s bleeding, bruised, injured body against Izuku’s comforts him and horrifies him.

“Kacchan…” Izuku chews on his lip harshly. “Kacchan, Katsuki, don’t…”

He traces every bruise, every blemish and broken blood vessel. Anger rides on heavy waves within him, seeking a sense of release. Katsuki’s dark eyes are narrowed and fierce in the dark, but exhausted and bruised purple and green.

Katsuki’s haze seems to dissipate once his gaze flicks to Izuku. Instantly, the tense, exhausted lull in his body lifts. For a moment, his jaw goes from tense with gritting teeth to relaxed and washed in disbelief. Izuku smiles weakly, choking back the inevitable worries that cloud his senses.

“Deku, you’re,” he coughs, growling and shaking his head, “fuck…”

“Kacchan, don’t, please,” Izuku whispers, soft. “You’re… oh my god, you’re bleeding…” He swallows and exhales shakily.

Katsuki’s pale hair is slathered in his own blood. Burn marks are lacerated around his neck.

“I didn’t exactly put him there to create a touching reunion.” Hisashi’s voice looms, a rising threat in the cusp of Izuku’s vantage point.

Izuku bristles, protectiveness and the reckless need to defend cloaking him. He holds Katsuki close to him, his arms a brace around the struggling body. Katsuki breathes, harsh and angry in Izuku’s ear, infuriated and impatient.

“Get—what the hell are you doing? Get the hell out of here, Deku—”

“Kacchan, you need to shut up, okay?” Izuku bites out, harsh and yet, riddled with the need to protect him. He wants nothing more than to shield Katsuki from his father, to wipe away every bruise and cut and gnarly burn engraved into his skin like the tattoo of an ambush that should have never happened.

Katsuki chuckles dryly, his breath warm smelling of sulfur and smoke.

“Stubborn nerd…”

Izuku’s heart glows at his words, and shatters at the sound.

You’re so strong, Kacchan.

“He won’t last long, I’m afraid,” says Hisashi, watching them. His gaze is unfocused and transfixed on something else, like a hawk focused on a piece of scurrying prey that is only

being considered as a primary target. “My Quirk allows the temperature of each fire spout to instill a lingering sensation after it hits the target. I’m afraid that his windpipe will become clogged with smoke from my fire before he’ll be able to get back up again…”

“Shut up!” Izuku whips around, his body shaking yet his grip tightening around Katsuki. The other teen slumps forward, eyes fluttering and struggling to latch onto any thread of consciousness.

“And what are you going to do about it, my son?” Hisashi scoffs. “You have nothing on your side. You’re completely inept in skill, mind, and spirit.” He tilts his head. “Your attempts at manipulation have only landed you in a situation where this disgusting poser of a *vigilante*,” he growls out the last word, “finds himself ready to die.”

“Don’t talk about Kacchan!” Izuku’s glare is defiant and bold, and Hisashi steps closer to them in response. Izuku, however, refuses to move, not with Katsuki in his embrace and the train rumbling to another abrupt halt.

Wait…

Excitement and relief rushes through Izuku.

He bites his lip, and knows he needs to bide his time.

You’re amazing, Todoroki.

Izuku holds his breath in an attempt to calm himself. He hopes he’s correct.

The way the entire locomotive pauses this time is different. The train stutters, like a cell phone buzzing with a new message. Steam and smoke billow into the winds, joint columns rising up and blotting out the stars and moon. Rumbling machinery cranks and splutters underneath the grasp of the growing cold atmosphere, and even the metal beneath Izuku and Katsuki sprouts with a frosty touch.

Hisashi pauses in his movements, the look of perplexity crossing him the first sign of weakness Izuku has spotted in weeks.

“What…?” His eyes bulge, and his voice huffs out in an impatient twist of fury. “Impossible…”

“Where are your allies, Hisashi?”

Hisashi’s nostrils flare. He turns on his heel, every muscle taut and coiled in preparation to fight. Smoke and embers crackle through the air, winding through his parting lips. The natural flush to his neck and the exposed flesh of his muscular arms are enough to intimidate any minor enemy—yet Izuku is not going to allow this to intimidate him. Not now.

Not when victory, somehow, feels so close, and yet so far away.

“Did they leave you behind?” Izuku’s voice rises, clipped through the bitter air. “I imagine they would… you’re the coward here, hiding behind a scheme to kill so many innocent

people just to prove a sick, disgusting point. You're the one who's posing to be something he's not. You claim to be strong and the one to protect and preserve what you believe to be true in Augustana, but you've done anything but that!"

Katsuki stirs, his uninjured hand trembling on Izuku's shoulder. His fingers delve into the cloth, warning him.

It's okay, Kacchan.

A symphony of collective noise breaks out through the train. Doors slide open. The sound of countless footsteps breaking out onto gravel, and the welcoming chatter of people ripple like static.

Hisashi looks away from them, and out into the dark-washed scope of Redmond District. Many people stop to stare at the frozen train. Fingers pointing, whispers carrying in secretive currents. Each face stands out like a broken stream of lights, scattered in a sea of many names and identities that blur together under the waning dark sky.

"How…" Hisashi turns to Izuku, eyes narrowing. "What did you do…?"

Izuku shrugs. "I have no idea." His smile is stable and curved generously. "But unlike you, I have people watching me and trying to help. If I didn't know any better I'd say Shigaraki bailed on you."

Hisashi's glare shifts from cold to steady and unsure. His lashes flutter, the rigidness in his posture lessening. With the train now at a complete standstill, the wind is lighter—a faint touch in the bluish morning. He stares out into the crowd of confused onlookers, his profile swathed in waning shadows and the lightest traces of an early rising sun.

"Then I suppose," he says, rolling his neck to let off an audible crack, "that I have no choice, my son." He turns, pivoting on his heel. His nostrils open up, lips parting once more to allow smoke and dangerous embers to burrow and burn in the back of his throat. His pupils dilate, threatening to black out the human green of his irises. "I can't let you live."

Izuku moves, barely a muscle, but it is not him, but Katsuki who breaks the silence.

He barely registers it, from the moment Hisashi starts to run towards them, to the moment he recognizes Katsuki holding the wire from under his shirt close to his mouth. In less than a second, he shifts from being nearly unconscious in Izuku's arms to sitting upright, struggling and wheezing into the electrical wire, his voice hoarse and soaked in confidence.

"*Do it.*"

Hisashi pauses, having caught the motion. Realization dawns on him, twisting his fierce battle-ready expression into a frown of disbelief. Before he can dodge, however, his body violently jerks to the left. His silhouette collapses, a lifeless, broken figure of an icon slumped on the metal back of the train. Large, nearly identical green eyes wide, blank, and drained of any sign of life.

Blood slips from underneath Hisashi's body. Deep, red, and unforgivably real.

Izuku's jaw hangs open.

"Thanks," breathes Katsuki.

Izuku jerks his head to the left. Through one of many tall buildings in Redmond District, with a window propped open, Izuku catches the glint of a rifle, and a familiar head of long green hair.

… Mom…?

Caught in a whirlwind of shock, Izuku's grip around the other teen slumps, for only a moment, until he recognizes the faintest curve of a smirk on Katsuki's lips. With a squeak, he steadies his fallback, and his face—his heart, his entire being—melts.

An unsung joy rips through him, and he holds Katsuki close to his chest, tears quickly streaming down his face.

It will be okay.

He holds his breath, trembling.

It will be okay…

… Three Days Later …

Katsuki dreams of Izuku.

The pain that tore him from the inside out, the harsh burning hands that grappled him, slammed him into metal, ground the bones in his wrist into dust… it stings. A thunderous pattern of sensations that refuses to leave him in peace, even with each disparaging moment he loses himself to consciousness. When Izuku found him, he'd screamed inside for him to flee. He needed to distract Hisashi long enough to keep him in the line of sight, to allow the emergency trick of the plan to unfold.

It had all been incredibly risky. If he wasn't conscious, Hisashi would have killed both him and Izuku without a second thought.

But Izuku—Deku, his *Deku*—had held onto him as if he was the last safe point keeping him together. Izuku's stupid, ridiculous smile in every inch of danger, even with his own father stalking towards them with his throat and arms coiled up in flames, made him want to believe that his plan was going to work. He had hoped, through each second of his pride being soiled and drowning him in pain and growing wounds, that his parents had succeeded in tracing Shigaraki Tomura.

Were they successful? Did they find him?

Deku…

He dreams of Izuku.

Traces the memory of being held close to him, inhaling the horrifying musk of smoke, coppery blood and the stench of a person other than him—*Nero, fucking bastard, disgusting villain, Nero Nero Nero*—cloaking Izuku's clothes in a fragrant mist. He'd breathed in those scents, and somehow found comfort with one half of his mind still present in the world, and the other seeking the comforting darkness of unconsciousness.

He dreams…

It's comforting, seeing Izuku smile at him, bloody and bruised beyond what he'd liked to see. The strength and unshakable confidence within him on top of the train.

You stupid bastard… you have to get out of here…

But he couldn't speak. And a selfish, tiny part of him wished he could keep Izuku there, and forget the destruction around them.

The pattern is the same. He remembers speaking into the wire, hoping that Izuku's mother was prepared, that the path was cleared for her to take that final shot.

She had insisted to take it. To watch her husband fall.

Katsuki was more than willing to let her do it. He supposed, during that moment, there was one thing they could agree on: protecting Izuku Midoriya, and their hatred for Hisashi.

He wishes his dreams still consisted of Izuku, and only Izuku. The backdrop of danger and blood that now shrouds their every action and spoken word will linger in the backs of their minds for however many years, but he refuses to let this chain him down.

With an angry, deliberate instance of stubbornness, Katsuki stirs, and opens his eyes.

The black canvas from behind his eyelids snaps in half like a scissor cutting through paper. Cracks in a dotted, familiar cream ceiling. Off-white walls hanging with decorative pictures. An older television set propped on moving wheels in the corner of the room, beside flickering plastic blinds and a window locked tight and firm. Sunshine filters through the open spaces, painting the end of the bed, and the turquoise blankets, a brighter hue.

His entire body, while in far less pain than when the attack had happened, still aches. His right forearm throbs, stabs of pain searing like knives under his skin. His teeth grind on instinct, a shuddering breath heaving through his bandaged chest. Cotton and temperature-sensitive pads are strung all around his body, wrapping him in a near-cocoon.

“Katsuki?”

He groans, shutting his eyes.

He needs to compose himself before he opens them once more and stares at the rosy pink face of his mother. Her hair tousled, blouse ruffled and skirt misshapenly crossed with one leg loped over the other. Her lipstick and mascara are smudged in various places, and the look of exhaustion that hangs under he eyelids should have made him feel guilty.

“Jesus…” She shakes her head, pressing her hand to her forehead. A trail of tears flicker on her eyelashes. “You really gave me a scare, you brat.”

Katsuki snorts. “Dumb hag. Ya think these fucking wounds are enough to,” he coughs, groaning, “take me down? Fuck that.”

Mitsuki rolls her eyes. “Guess your injuries aren’t as bad as they thought, if you’re doing this well.”

Katsuki considers this.

“… ‘Kay, I’m ready to leave. So fucking let me leave.”

“Yeah, no, that’s not how it works.” Mitsuki chuckles. “Hisashi’s dead, by the way. The plan worked. Things are… a bit hectic right now in the city. But you don’t have to worry about that. Let your parents take care of all that political garble.” She presses her lips tightly, considering. “What you did… was not what your father and I preferred. We told you to let us handle the train, and have Inko placed somewhere different—”

“It worked, didn’t it?” Katsuki glares at the blank television screen. “He’s dead.”

“You didn’t let me finish.”

He grumbles something inaudible, but says nothing.

“Despite what happened, and you completely disregarding what we asked of you and going out there *alone* to face him…with Enji Todoroki’s son as your only backup, of all things, I’m proud of you.”

Katsuki’s frown deepens. He raises an eyebrow, turning his head to send his mother a questioning glance.

She grins. “You were thinking about someone else.” She props her chin on the palm of her hand. “Granted, you’re grounded for pretty much… forever, actually, and that’s being lenient. So don’t be an ass about it.” She brushes off his annoyed glare. “And because you acted recklessly, Izuku is alive.”

Katsuki's eyes widen. He tries to sit up, and angrily barks at the bandages and monitors attached to him.

"The fuck is this?! I have to get to Deku—"

"Oh my god, quiet down!" Mitsuki crosses her arms, but only after flicking Katsuki's nose. "He's fine. His wounds weren't nearly as serious. But…" She trails off. "He'd looked like he'd seen a lot of ghosts. Being kidnapped by his own father and put through all that… well, I doubt any of it went well. Inko is doing her best, but there's only so much she can do."

Her words are heavy on Katsuki's heart.

"He told us." She pauses, searching for the correct words. "About what Hisashi had done. And that one lackey, Nero Edmure."

Katsuki's healthy hand grips the blanket. The muscles in his body tighten up.

"… Can feel your bloodlust from here, brat," she mumbles, but not unkindly. The glossy look in her eyes is nothing short of fond. "He sounded familiar. Suspiciously familiar." She locks onto him, her look demanding and questioning all at once. The concern on her features is enough to remind Katsuki that she wishes for him to be as safe as Izuku.

Nero Edmure was never an uncomplicated presence in his life.

"Izuku managed to kill him in self-defense," she continues, still watching Katsuki carefully. "Katsuki, baby… did you know Nero—"

"I don't want to talk about him," growls Katsuki. "I want to see Deku."

Take me to him. Let him see me. Fuck. Please.

Mitsuki tilts her head, soft and understanding.

"He'll be here soon. I phoned Inko about an hour ago. They're probably in the waiting room."

If Katsuki even bothered to care anymore, he would have been horribly embarrassed at the immediate happiness and joy that rushed through him at the idea of seeing Izuku again.

Mitsuki brushes his hair back, one hand on her hip.

"You look more and more like Masaru when you're all heroic and battered up." She grins at his frustrated glare. "I'll give you some privacy when Izuku gets here. Guess you've earned that much, haven't you, brat?" She winks, and Katsuki sends her a warning growl before huffing and turning away from her. "Just saying that you probably shouldn't have a super rigorous victory make-out session as soon as he gets in here—"

"Shut the fuck up, hag!" Katsuki snaps, his face alarmingly red. "I-It's—it's none of your fucking business!"

“Touchy, touchy.” Mitsuki laughs, but her smile is genuine before she picks herself up, and leaves.

Katsuki lies in his bed, annoyance and impatience bristling under his skin.

Where the fuck is he?

If Shouto Todoroki was expecting some equal praise from Izuku for his admittedly amazing work on the mission instead of visiting his boyfriend in the hospital, Katsuki would have some words to say.

But when the door opens, the frustration and mask of annoyance he expects to wear dissipates in a matter of seconds.

Izuku Midoriya smiles at him, blinding. Relieved.

His freckled cheeks are glowing pink, hair an absolute mess, but healthy and lush. Eyes bright, happy, overjoyed. The bright orange sweater he’s wearing seems strangely familiar, with the Russian translation of All-Might’s name imprinted on the fabric, until Katsuki realizes quickly that it’s his own sweatshirt. The bruises and bandaged cut on Izuku’s chin are not enough to distract Katsuki from the unadulterated happiness that radiates from the other teen.

Izuku's presence, while gentle and comforting, is heavy. Those deep forest eyes brim with ghosts and sights Katsuki wishes to see, only to allow him the opportunity to *destroy* them.

Still, that same gaze, one that both drove Katsuki insane with anger and confusion and made him weak, were so... emotional, soft and *full*.

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki swallows, his heart close to exploding out of his chest.

“‘Bout time you got here, Deku.”

Izuku rushes over to him, and he pauses. Hesitates, scanning his body from head to toe in the bed. Katsuki rolls his eyes, lips twitching with fondness.

“I don’t—I mean, I really don’t want to hurt you. Or make you bruise, or… or make your injuries worse. Ah, Kacchan, you were unconscious for two days! I kept calling in and asking if I could come in here but it wasn’t really allowed even though I asked to come here with your parents. But, that didn’t actually work either, but I swear that I tried my best to come in here…”

God, this fucking nerd…

“Deku.”

Izuku blinks. Katsuki’s left hand traces under his chin, a delicate touch that distracts him and causes a thick, gentle blush to overtake his neck and swim up to his cheekbones.

“C’mere,” Katsuki mumbles.

Izuku grins, and obeys.

Katsuki opens his mouth at the near instant Izuku’s lips touch his. He pulls him closer, the desire to hold Izuku nearer, beside him, never pulled from him again, rising higher and higher in each second that passes. He licks the roof of Izuku’s mouth, and the shudder that passes through the other teen’s body makes Katsuki smirk into the kiss.

Eventually, Izuku pulls away. He smiles bashfully, lashes fluttering.

Katsuki gulps, hypnotized.

“Said,” he grumbles, “come *here.”*

Izuku frowns, perplexed. “But, I am here, Kacchan. Didn’t you want me to kiss you?”

“Oh for the love of,” Katsuki growls and shoves his own body over several inches. He pats the open spot aggressively, ears burning pink. Izuku stares at him blankly, arms crossed and one eyebrow risen, as if challenging him on his serious he is. Scoffing, Katsuki slams his hand down on the ruffled sheets and blankets. “Just, sit the fuck down! God. Stubborn nerd…”

Izuku breaks his facade, and laughs.

Katsuki wants to punch himself at how quickly he realizes it’s his favorite sound in the world.

Izuku peers over his shoulder, as if to see if the nurse or doctor would open the door and find them. And with that, he slips down beside Katsuki, adjusting the covers and blankets to fold over the two of them. He carefully slides up Katsuki’s chest, and lopes his arm around the other teen’s tapered waist. Izuku’s curls ruffle Katsuki’s nose, smelling of fresh cut grass and mint.

They lay there, absorbed in the comforting silence. Katsuki reaches up, absentmindedly stroking Izuku’s hair, and then sliding down to rub at his back in gentle circles. The weight of what happened only two days ago, and everything beyond that, lies heavy and waiting for them outside this very room.

To have Izuku this close, and to be able to kiss him and feel the fabric of his own sweatshirt draped over the form of the other boy, reminds him of how lucky they are.

“There’s…” Izuku sighs, mumbling. He rests his head on Katsuki’s chest, hand playing with the bandages and occasionally rubbing circles in Katsuki’s toned, covered stomach. “There’s a lot that’s happened in the city, while you were out. I wanted to talk to you about it, and about what happened—”

“Not now.” Katsuki pauses, glancing down at Izuku, who blinks up at him. “Later.”

Izuku frowns at this, but nods in understanding. His weight is warm and pliant, draped over Katsuki in a welcome layer of comfort and safety.

“Thank you, Kacchan,” he mutters.

Katsuki frowns, pausing once again. He rests his fingers in Izuku’s hair.

“For what?”

Izuku rises from under the covers, watching him curiously. Katsuki’s brow furrows in speculation, his attempts to read Izuku for naught as the other teen takes the hand in his own, lowers it to his mouth, and presses a series of kisses to his knuckles.

Katsuki flushes, mesmerized. His lips part, a keen interest bubbling to the surface despite his grievous injuries.

“What’s…” he swallows and whispers breathily, “gotten into you, nerd?”

Izuku’s grin is curved teasingly. He leans in, kissing Katsuki’s lips sweetly and gently. It’s too short though for Katsuki’s liking, as he leans forward to capture Izuku’s mouth again. He nearly hiccups in surprise at the feel of Izuku’s lips trailing along his chin, down his neck, and pressing tenderly and wistfully along his collarbone.

It’s a light touch, yet it burns so brightly under Katsuki’s skin. He groans, forcing a moan back into his throat as Izuku’s lips ghost over his new scars, a menacing reminder of Hisashi’s first attempt to kill him.

“You believed in me, and saved me.”

Katsuki’s eyes flutter open, his breath hitching.

“Y-Yeah, ‘cause I’m great, so what?” A shudder rushes down his spine. Izuku’s mouth finds its way back to his neck, the tender patch of unblemished skin apparently becoming a sight for the other boy. He feels Izuku’s tongue first, and then his mouth sucking a bruise onto his skin. “A-Ah, Deku, the hell—fuck, that’s good…”

Izuku pulls back, and kisses him on the nose.

Katsuki blinks, and Izuku laughs before he lowers and snuggles into his chest.

“I don’t want to mess with your injuries,” he mutters, “but I’m so glad you’re okay, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s frown smooths into something blank. Unsure.

“Yeah, well, takes more than that to take me down.”

I didn’t fucking protect you…

Izuku shouldn’t be thanking him.

Katsuki doesn't want to think about what could have happened to Izuku. What could have transpired within the walls of that horrific building in Illenova, or in someplace else where Izuku was always kept under watch. What did his father tell him? What did those monsters instill into his mind? Was Shigaraki Tomura still an existing threat?

And Nero…

Katsuki growls before he can stop it, the need to protect, to shield Izuku once again setting his mind ablaze. He shifts in the bed, grumbling under his breath.

Izuku notices this, and sits up to watch him carefully.

"Kacchan? What's wrong? Did I hurt you? I was trying not to mess with your bandages—"

Katsuki flicks his nose.

"Shut up." He glares at the pointed, unimpressed look Izuku sends him. The bruises under his eyelids and framing his jawline grab his attention. "Don't worry about it. Or I'll kill you."

"… Sure you will." Izuku shrugs, and considers this. "… We'll… talk though, right?"

Katsuki pulls him close, and roughly shoves the two of them under the blankets. Izuku squeaks at the sudden action, and mumbles his concerns about Katsuki's wounds. His question sits in Katsuki's stomach, in a dangerous tango with the rest of his thoughts and scattering memories.

It isn't long before Izuku falls asleep, completely lax on his chest. He snores, and drools at one point. It's almost as if Izuku hasn't slept at all in the time where he was gone from Katsuki's world.

Augustana will be forever changed from what happened.

Katsuki snorts. Even from this awkward angle, he uses his left hand, still healthy and rough with callouses, to card through Izuku's hair. The other teen's breathing is soothing and solemn against his chest, and it takes every ounce of Katsuki's patience and ferocious glares to force every nurse to look away when they come across them. He will destroy anyone who attempts to pull Izuku away from him, especially now.

He won't let him go now.

Not when he finally has him back.

Katsuki's heart stutters. His hands pause, jaw clenching and loosening as a bolt of uncertainty rips through him.

Uraraka Ochako's words blare through his mind, an unforgiving reminder.

"I think you're incredibly rude, pigheaded, and Izuku is way *too good for you, but…"*

Katsuki shuts his eyes tightly, tensing up.

“I know that Izuku loves you.”

“Fuck…” Katsuki breathes in, wishing he could scream and not wake Izuku from his much-needed rest.

Staring up at the ceiling, he listens. Thinks, and the words rushing through him are louder than the tentative rustling of his own blankets and Izuku stirring in his slumber.

Would it be dangerous to tell him…?

Katsuki almost scoffs at the thought. He refuses to be a coward now.

Soon.

He rolls the thought like a bowling ball. If his mother ever knew about this, she would laugh, maybe even mock him for days on end, no matter the outcome.

He never expected to be the one to fall first.

Chapter End Notes

Ah, gosh, that last scene was a joy to write after so much chaos...

Thank you so much again, everyone, for sticking with this story for so long. It would mean the world to hear more of your kind words and just thoughts in general. This is an exhausting fic to write and I plan to end it as best I can, and your comments and feedback make me thrilled and overjoyed each time. It helps me grow and develop, and really inspires.

Thank you, thank you, thank you, THANK YOU.

Next chapter is super soft and covers a lot of what we didn't see while Katsuki was resting in the hospital. Woot.

This fic is coming to a close so soon, folks... can't believe it.

Until next time!

Conciliation

Chapter Summary

> “Like what you see?”
>
> Izuku closes his mouth. “I… you’re just very…”
>
> *You’re gorgeous. Just, all of you. Every part of you. To me.*
>
> All at once, inexplicably, Izuku becomes aware of how lucky he is.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you so much everyone for your support. This chapter is one of my favorites. This fic is coming to a close soon and that hardly feels real at all. Gosh.
>
> Thank you all again. Hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

> “Do you think anyone’s going to remember your article a month from now?”
>
> Izuku sets down his tea, the taste of mint and green leaves fresh on his tongue.
>
> “Mm. I dunno,” he replies, his smile soft and genuine. The lack of tension in his shoulders beckons him to rest
>
> Across from him, Uraraka remains skeptical, shifting in her seat and glaring out the bistro window to the construction workers barring off the train.
>
> The rails are splintered in thousands of square spots of shrapnel and twisting gears. Pipes had become dislodged and twined into vicious knots, mostly owed to the deft speed and reckless blasts of ice Todoroki had inflicted. Passersby occasionally stop to point and snap a photograph or two, though none of them bother to stay behind and ask one of the construction workers about the process.

"… It'll take awhile," says Uraraka, propping her chin in her hand. "I'm a little surprised that Enji Todoroki was so… open, about what happened. Denouncing his previous claims about the Bakugous like that? I never thought I'd see *that* happen." She laughs under her breath, a whimsical smile washing over. "Shouto is… he's good, though."

Izuku hums, fiddling with his cup.

"And Kacchan had you stay behind," he adds, watching Uraraka's eyebrows lift. "He told me."

"Of course he did." Uraraka rolls her eyes. "I begged that asshole to let me be a part of the plan. But, he already had Todoroki positioned to freeze up the train carts when the time came, but he's only one person, so he thought about letting me go. My parents, though…" she nibbles on her bottom lip, contemplative. "They made me stay behind. I wanted to go there and find you, Izuku."

She whispers the last words so softly, so tenderly, that Izuku can barely hear them. But he feels them all the same.

"I'm so thankful for you!" he blurts.

Uraraka's eyes bolt wide, and she unleashes a flurry of giggles. The sound relaxes Izuku, and he chuckles awkwardly with the previous anxieties buzzing to a numb minimum.

It had been too long, he muses, to spend time with Uraraka without impending danger looming over their heads. He was more grateful for the fact that she was kept safe, and that the Bakugous were able to watch her and use her help without placing her directly in the line of fire.

Hisashi's threats, each word dripping with malleable poison, still haunts him. Hisses in his ear when he tosses in his bed at night, bringing forth the dreadful, bloodied pictures of Uraraka and Katsuki broken and battered beyond belief.

He's gone now. Things are changing.

He draws in a deep breath, and exhales.

Somehow, the smell of drying cement, burning asphalt and fresh-baked bread rolls from within the bistro quell the tempering thunder drum of his thoughts.

"So." Uraraka's grin is cat-slick and playful. "You look nicer today than normal. Instead of the usual homeless journalist aesthetic."

Izuku snorts, blushing and smiling appreciatively at the compliment. The black jeans and the red and black flannel shirt smell clean and new—a gift from his mother from many months back. They were garments he never paid attention to in his closet, and they always seemed too inappropriate for spending many hours and nights at the high school.

And today, he has a reason to wear them.

“Don’t tell me.” Uraraka slaps a hand on her chest, sniffling. “My Izuku is growing up!”

Izuku splutters. “U-Uraraka! This is a completely normal thing!”

“But you look adorable. And kind of hot.” Uraraka’s laughter only grows at Izuku’s confused expression—a cross between being mortified, embarrassed, flustered, and flattered. “Bakugou will be *all over you*.”

Izuku looks away, blushing.

“Y-Yeah, well, you know. He—he deserves better on a date than just, ah, old ratty jackets and dumb shoes and jeans that are way too big on me…” he trails off into a series of mumbles. “And I mean, it’s not like I’m hoping he stares at me a lot! But I guess it would only be fair since I stare at him too much. I don’t even know how many times both of our moms have commented on it. And, ah, we can’t even get a single time to ourselves when under his roof, so it’s a little awkward—”

“Hey, earth to Izuku.”

Izuku stops, groaning. “Sorry…”

“It’s okay.” Uraraka nods, her eyes soft and full. “I’m happy for you.”

Izuku smiles bashfully, unsure of how to handle the genuine sincerity that Uraraka always presents. It’s startling to him, how loyal and unabashedly brave she’s been throughout this entire ordeal, and how easily she’d slipped back into his life only hours after he was rescued. Wrapping her tightly in his arms and allowing her to both scream and angrily cry at him for his safety filled him with joy and relief.

She was alive. Breathing. Energetic. Completely, thankfully, *safe*.

“So, you didn’t even tell me where you were going.”

“Hm?” Izuku blinks at her. The question sinks in. “Oh! Um… just, somewhere. Nothing too exciting. I know we’re going to go on a walk for a bit before we do whatever.”

Uraraka seems unconvinced, but she shrugs nonetheless.

“If you say so.”

Izuku squirms, his fingers flexing around his cup and seeking purchase. Something solid to hold onto that isn’t the table side, the old stress ball he used to carry with him constantly. Katsuki’s hand. His mother’s arms around him.

It isn’t long before the two of them gather their materials, sharing a chuckle and giggle along the way, and leave the bistro. As soon as the glass doors close behind them, Izuku stops, a rapid blush crawling up his neck and spreading to his cheeks.

Katsuki is leaning casually stretched out on a bench, thumbing through his phone and unaware of their presence yet. His blond hair is lighter, golden by the sun and tempting Izuku

to touch. His jeans, sneakers and unbuttoned shirt over a black tank top shouldn't be as breathtaking to Izuku as they are, but he knows it's due to it being Katsuki Bakugou that the effect leaves his knees weak and words lost.

Despite Katsuki's usual confident strut, his right arm is balanced in a sling, protective bandages wrapped all the way up to the knuckle.

Uraraka slaps his shoulders and darts off.

"Have fun with your *date*!"

Izuku groans, but shakes his head fondly at her gesture.

Katsuki looks up, his smile all the more menacing and teasing. Even with a noticeable tracing of bruises on his jawline and cheek, he's always handsome. Always arrogant and brash.

"Hi, Kacchan." Izuku's grip tightens on his backpack strap. A loose, unsettling feeling swells up in his stomach, like a cage of butterflies being released and spilling into his ribcage. "You're… I thought that I was going to meet you back at your house?"

Katsuki strolls over toward him, hands in his pockets. He moves with dreadful slowness, sizing Izuku from the bottom of his shoes to the top of his curly hair, and the action is enough to cause Izuku's heart to leap in anticipation. A skitter of goosebumps pebbles his arms under Katsuki's stare, putting his buzzing thoughts to a halt. The secretive, cocky smirk Katsuki wears when he locks eyes with Izuku once more is enough to make him *beam.*

"Said I'd find you whenever the fuck I wanted, nerd," he says, voice pulling Izuku closer, spellbinding him. "Got tired of waiting."

Izuku snorts. "You're ridiculous."

Katsuki shoves Izuku's shoulder.

"Fuck off."

"Make me." Izuku squeaks when Katsuki grabs the hood of his sweater jacket and yanks it over his head. "Kacchan, I can't see! The world is so dark!"

"Fucking drama queen. Shouldn't have opened your dumb mouth."

Izuku tears himself out of his hold and raises an eyebrow.

"*I'm* the drama queen? Not in this relationship."

"Hah?" Katsuki snorts. "Whatever, fucking—just lead the way, Deku. Don't have the patience to deal with your shit."

Izuku bites the inside of his cheek to prevent an amused smile from breaking out. Despite Katsuki's words, he's staring into the sidewalk and kicking pebbles as they make their way through Sommartyn, ears burning pink and face flushed and pretty.

“You okay?”

Katsuki jerks up and glares at him.

“The fuck? Obviously. Why wouldn’t I be? Shitty nerd…”

“No, I…” Izuku ponders this over. “I just wanted to ask. I’m sorry.” He sighs, shoulders slumping.

Izuku’s sweaty hands find their ways into his pockets, ruffling the hem of his flannel. A thousand questions burn in the back of his throat, though he doesn’t want to relinquish Katsuki’s first few days out of the hospital by placing him in another uncomfortable position. Their discussions over the recent adjustments being made in Augustana’s government will haunt them for days to come, and yet…

“Hey.”

Izuku nearly jumps in surprise at the firm hand resting on his shoulder. He pauses, and glances at Katsuki.

He is holding his left hand out to him, face impossibly red.

“Are you just going to stand there and gawk like an idiot?” he barks.

Izuku bursts into a fit of giggles, and gradually takes Katsuki’s hand. He interlaces their fingers, and hums with a small bounce in his step at the satisfied squeeze Katsuki gives him in return. The feel of his scarred, nitroglycerin-smooth palm in his grasp delights Izuku’s spirits.

Of the many things they still need to discuss, Izuku is glad for the few hours they have to themselves, and the new obstacles they have agreed to tackle together.

“Saw your article being featured again. The old hag was turning up the volume on her usual informercials and you came up in an ad.”

Izuku nearly trips over his shoes, coughing.

“W-What? Really?”

“Yes. Really.” Katsuki rolls his eyes, but his grin is fond. “Dumbass.”

Izuku’s chest flutters with warmth. He tightens his hand around Katsuki’s, and leans in to kiss him on the cheek. Katsuki pauses for a moment, pulling away to glare for only a second before leaning in and capturing his mouth in a searing, fond kiss.

Izuku pulls back. The sight of Katsuki’s lashes fluttering, his cheeks rose-pink and lips slightly flushed, makes something inside him lift and soar. He nudges the other boy and gradually slides closer to him as they continue their walk. The clouds seem softer, and the sky seems bluer—though Izuku refrains from trying to pinpoint the reasons together for once as he enjoys the companionable gentleness Katsuki is willing to show him.

Eventually, they stop in front of a tall, nondescript building with humble wooden pillars supporting the front porch, a painted white fence squaring off a patch of fresh-cut grass, and a humble trail of stone steps leading to the front open gate. The mailbox greeting Katsuki and Izuku is positioned next to a hummingbird feeder, a bright red sugar liquid filled to the very top.

Izuku scans the establishment briefly, a nervous tingle spreading up his back.

“Don’t chicken out, nerd,” says Katsuki, firmer now. Reading him even without bothering to ask.

Izuku exhales, tentative.

“Not chickening out,” he mutters, eyes flickering to the photogenic image in front of them that seems like it was ripped directly from a magazine publication. “It just looks like, you know…”

“A murder house.”

“Yeah—wait, what?” Izuku snorts. “Kacchan, no. I’m just, a little nervous. That’s all. I don’t even know what this guy is going to be like. And after everything that my mom told me, and about the gun, and…” he trails off, heart starting to thunder under his bones, segueing him. “What is he going to say? I mean, I’ve seen a lot of therapists before. Doctors in general. Psychotherapists. Social workers. People I had to talk to when adjusting to living here for the first time. A lot of it is still so hazy, even after everything that you and Mom explained… and that the detectives uncovered—”

Katsuki squeezes his hand, cutting Izuku off.

“I’m not just dropping your ass off here by yourself, shitty nerd.” Katsuki’s gaze is intense and unwavering, pinning Izuku down with ease. “You’re tough. You can handle it. It’s just a fucking doctor. And if he says stuff that bothers you I’ll kill him.”

Izuku laughs, even as Katsuki takes a few bold steps forward to the front of the building.

“Please don’t maim anyone on my behalf.”

“Didn’t say nothin’, shitty nerd.”

“Sure, Kacchan.”

Izuku approaches the front door, brushing down his shirt. A golden plaque stares directly back at him from above the doorbell, inscribed in black, bold letters with the name *Dr. Philip Abrams*.

The phantom memory of Inko’s fingers carding through his hair, tea being pushed into his hands, and a sweet voice asking him to understand something entirely new gives him pause.

“This will be good for you, Izuku. Doctor Abrams is going to help you. More than… more than any of us could. Your father can’t stop you from remembering what happened. And I

can't be the one to tell you."

Her eyes had shone with fresh tears. Since the moment she was the one to kill Hisashi Midoriya, she had grown more distant. Cautious. The air that drifted around her tightened Izuku's advances and questions and shoved them into an invisible box.

The last week in the Bakugou household felt relieved of tension and yet, sprinkled with apprehension and doubts.

"Set up an appointment with him. He'll know what to do."

Izuku gulps.

Just one appointment.

One will be fine.

Just one.

Okay, Izuku. You can do this.

He raises his fist to knock—

And the door swings open.

"Ah!" Izuku squeaks and jumps back, stumbling into Katsuki, who steadies him with one arm. "Ah, oh no, I'm so sorry Kacchan—"

"Oh, you're here a little early!"

The warm, comforting voice distracts both teenagers. Standing there at the doorway is a man in his late forties, dark brown hair balding near the hairline. To Izuku's flagrant surprise, he seems rather ordinary, from the gray short-sleeved shirt to the friendly crinkle around his brown eyes.

Izuku nods apologetically and clasps his hands together, flustered.

"M-My name is Izuku Midoriya, sir!"

"Deku, stop *bowing*," grumbles Katsuki, now standing far away from him with a twitch in his eyebrow.

"Right!" Izuku bolts straight back up, rubbing the back of his neck. "You're… um, Doctor Abrams, right? My mom has told me a lot about you. I just, wanted to make an appointment and, oh," he quickly walks over to Katsuki and takes his hand. "This is my boyfriend, Kacch —Katsuki Bakugou! He's, um, just here for moral support!"

He ignores the fact that Katsuki is staring at him with saucer-wide eyes and a dropped jaw.

The man at the door, however, only shakes his head, laughing.

“Ah, yeah, you’re definitely the same Izuku I remember… Inko’s kid, for sure.” He crosses his arms. “No need to be so nervous, Izuku. Come inside. I have tea and coffee. And, Katsuki, was it?” At his question Katsuki raises his head, puffs up, and nods. “You’re free to stay here and wait until the appointment is over, if you’d like. We have a seating area.”

Izuku nibbles on his bottom lip, a handful of his concerns dissipating.

He seems… nice, enough.

“Deku, you look like a fish.”

Izuku clamps his jaw shut and chuckles awkwardly. He glares at Katsuki for only a second, before the other teen takes his hand, and leads him up to the door. Face and neck flushed red in mortification, Izuku watches as Katsuki stands boldly in front of Dr. Abrams, chin jutting outward and dark eyes glazed over with edge.

“He’s nervous, and a total dipshit. I’m not leaving him here. So show us inside.”

Izuku buries his face into one hand, grumbling apologies.

Dr. Abrams, however, seems only amused at this.

“Of course. Come on in, the both of you. There’s a lot that all three of us need to discuss, as well. But, for now, we’ll focus on your appointment you set up for today, alright Izuku?”

The inside of the office smells like mildew and decaying people.

At least, this is what Katsuki registers the moment he begrudgingly lets go of Izuku’s hand, sends a warning glare to the doctor in question, and plops down on one of the hideously green velvet benches just outside the door. Potted plants and a single cactus greet him in the narrow crawlspace of a hallway, offset only by several paintings of seemingly minuscule and unimportant things—a Dalmatian puppy sitting in a field of grass; a woman walking in the rain with a red umbrella; a pair of hands holding up a single rainbow stone.

None of these are distracting enough for Katsuki to direct his attention to while Izuku remains to be questioned out of his line of sight. It grates his nerves, makes his knees bob up and down in a bundle of urges he wishes he could control. This building, and even the doctor himself, vaguely remind Katsuki of various teachers he’d been told to speak to as a child for anger management.

Stupid posh fuckers. He glares at the doorknob, as if attempting to will it open.

He exhales, and leans back against the wall. The cast on his arm is red under his sleeve with a rash. He should have known that wearing it for only a few days would both help his mangled wrist and push his temper to another limit.

When Izuku stepped out of the bistro with Uraraka, he was drawn immediately to the dark circles underneath his eyes. A promise of past nightmares, of encounters they both shared and hadn't all at once. He wonders if Izuku has been able to sleep at all, given with his strange distance underneath the roof of the Bakugou household. Whenever he instigated a chance to talk, Izuku would smile and insist that it wasn't worth discussing.

Fucking liar, Katsuki muses bitterly.

It was this morning, when he caught the end of a conversation between Mitsuki and Masaru, that made him pause in his tracks and reserve himself quietly to the edge of the staircase.

"Izuku won't be charged with any felonious accusations after what happened to Nero Edmure," Mitsuki had said, her voice strained and frayed, as if pulled directly out of her chest. *"But that poor boy… he still won't talk to us. Not Inko. Not even Katsuki. So what are we supposed to do about that? Philip can help with all of that hullabaloo with the gun and maybe get some personal shit straightened out, but if Izuku had to kill someone in self-defense…"*

Katsuki's teeth grind at the memory.

Izuku had looked so haunted, tears streaming down his face when held him close to his side on top of the moving train. He could barely drink in their surroundings or make sense of the way Izuku looked over him, green eyes alight with fear, with guilt and a dozen separate emotions that intermingled in a dangerous tidal wave.

Deku…

How could he have been so reckless?

So fucking stupid.

It was a miracle that Inko was able to pinpoint Hisashi so perfectly.

If he had missed even one step, or had fallen unconscious under Hisashi's attacks moments before the time was right, none of their efforts would have mattered. The people trapped inside the train would have eventually fallen victim to a devastating series of bombs, and the train would have been blown to discarded pieces of scrap metal, blood, flesh and bone.

They all would have perished.

Hisashi. Todoroki. Himself. *Izuku*.

Katsuki briefly wonders if this is one of the many reasons his mother loves alcohol so much. The stress riding the shoulders of just one vigilante in a massive city like Augustana must be

unbearable.

“… We’ll… talk though, right?”

Katsuki closes his eyes, leaning his head back and relaxing his body from the neck down.

The sound of a fan whirring above his head lulls him into a calmed stupor. He can rest here, while Izuku babbles whatever nonsense is needed to the doctor, and maybe that Quirk his mother mentioned will come into play for them to discuss. The matters of the gun and the secrets of the Midoriya family that Katsuki wants to pry out of Inko’s own head are still tangible threads in the air—stories he needs to unveil to put everyone at peace.

He snorts at the thought.

He doubts he’ll ever have a fully peaceful mindset, much to his parents’ chagrin.

Before long, he’s pulled out of his dreamy state with a gentle touch weaving through his hair. He grumbles, nose twitching slightly as his body starts to wake up. He immediately directs his attention to the boy now seated beside him, smile tender and too-big eyes so disgustingly fond it makes Katsuki’s stomach backflip.

“Hey, Kacchan.” Izuku tilts his head. “Are you tired?”

“Shut up,” says Katsuki, yawning. “You good to go?”

Izuku pauses for a moment, hand resting in Katsuki’s hair. The action sets off an alarm bell in Katsuki’s mind, but before he can ask Izuku is already nodding his head and grinning with a false air of stability and confidence.

“Yeah. Let’s go.”

Katsuki sits up, watching him carefully. Izuku bristles under his stare.

“Something’s up.”

“Huh? No, I…” Izuku scratches his cheek. “Can we, talk about this another time? I’m…” his expression morphs into one of almost total blankness, a wary searching look overtaking him. “Just thinking of a lot of things. I promise I’ll tell you later.”

Katsuki’s eyes narrow. “Fine.”

Izuku giggles slightly, shaking his head. “You’re so cute, Kacchan.”

“Look who’s talking.”

The response is enough to make Izuku splutter and blush, and Katsuki feels completely dignified to smirk victoriously in the entirety of their walk back home.

“How did it go, Izuku?”

The numb echoes thrumming in Izuku’s skull rush to a stop.

He blinks out of his daydreaming spell and grins at his mother, who seems all the more preoccupied with her bookkeeping supplies spread out on the coffee table in the Bakugous’ living room. Beside her, Masaru is assembling a myriad of files and documents into colorful folders.

“It went well,” he says.

He avoids his mother’s concerned, and somewhat hopeful, smile. The need to clench his fists and kick over something in the vicinity fades in an instant, if only to be replaced by a cold, unsettling wash of fear and confusion rushing over his head and heart.

He can talk to her later.

If it comes to that…

Katsuki closes the door behind them, and scoffs.

“Shitty nerd was shaking like a leaf the whole time.”

“Was not!” Izuku gawks. “I could’ve been way worse!”

“It was pathetic.”

“You’re so mean, Kacchan.”

“It’s your fault you make it so damn easy, Deku!”

“Oi!” Mitsuki saunters her way into the room with a box full of folders and documents in her arms. She seems particularly refreshed and energetic, even in a pair of sweatpants and a blouse that in no way matches the rest of her outfit. “You two, quit noisily flirting and leave the adults to their work.” She winks at Izuku, who blushes and looks away. “Could use some help cleaning around the house later, you know. So bother us in about an hour or two!”

“Whatever, hag!” Katsuki growls and grabs Izuku’s hand. He pulls him over toward the staircase. “None of you nosy fuckers talk to us for the rest of the day!”

“Kacchan?” Izuku frowns as he is, rather aggressively, pulled up the steps and down the hallway by means of Katsuki’s only slightly better left hand.

Katsuki waits until they are out of earshot. He turns, wraps his hand around the small of Izuku's back, and pulls him into a kiss.

And instantly, Izuku melts.

Katsuki grunts and presses him closer to the wall, careful with his injured arm yet gentle with the slide of his lips and tongue. He coaxes Izuku's mouth to open, angling his head and pressing deeper into the embrace. Izuku moans and kisses him back, hands reaching up and snaking around Katsuki's neck. A gasp escapes him at the gentle press of Katsuki's body against his, his lips drifting from his mouth to his neck.

Izuku's eyes flutter. His hands tremble around Katsuki, seeking purchase in his strong neck and the back of his head, but finding none.

"K-Kacchan, why are you—"

Katsuki bites him.

Izuku squeaks, and claps a hand over his mouth. Katsuki snorts out a laugh, his shoulders shaking.

"Jerk," he whispers. Katsuki nips him again, earning a rough smack against his hip. "Kacchan, you know I can't—"

"Stay quiet?" Katsuki licks the new, swelling bruise on Izuku's collarbone, grinning satisfactorily at the unbuttoned top of Izuku's flannel shirt. "I know. It's fucking hot." Izuku's eyes nearly bulge out of their sockets, but he has no reply. Katsuki then backs off, and Izuku's glare and resulting pout only earns a broader smirk from the other teen. "You know you just look like an angry puppy when you're mad at me, right?"

Izuku huffs. "I can be intimidating."

"Nah," Katsuki drolls with a click of his tongue. He then pinches Izuku's cheek and pulls it, cackling at the other boy's waving arms and frustrated growl. "You're a little shit."

Izuku smacks his hand away, rolling his eyes. "You're lucky you're an injured man."

"Oh really."

"Yeah. Can't hurt a guy in a cast."

Katsuki hums in thought, eyes flicking to Izuku's lips and then back up.

Izuku, against his will, blushes furiously. As if this the first time Katsuki has flirted with him. As if not once has Katsuki ever dragged him away just to kiss him breathless in a private corner. As if Katsuki has never looked at him like he's wanted to both hold him close and devour him.

"Hey." Katsuki flicks Izuku's forehead. "Wipe that shitty look off your face. You look depressed as fuck."

Izuku sniffs, blinking at the sudden tears framing his eyelids. He wipes them away with his sleeve, avoiding Katsuki's narrowed stare.

"Sorry, Kacchan. It's—it's nothing."

Katsuki takes his hand, and continues pulling him down the hallway.

"You know, I can just walk. You don't have to drag me." Izuku chuckles at Katsuki's irritated snort and a quick squeezing of his hand.

For now, Katsuki's incessant hovering is needed.

He doesn't want to think about what he's learned, and how small and strangely claustrophobic that little room felt. The doctor's questions probing something out of him, a careful series of images flashing through his mind in a broken carousel. His breathing had turned erratic and vanished entirely in separate patterns.

Katsuki closes the door behind him to his bedroom.

"Deku."

Izuku turns to apologize to Katsuki, and immediately his words die on his tongue.

Katsuki, rather miraculously, considering his small cast, has removed his jacket and shirt with ease. The shocking, cut lines to his pectorals and abdominals are unfairly prominent. The round contour to his shoulders and dimples buried in his lower back draw Izuku's eye long after Katsuki slips out of the final sleeve and tosses it in the laundry basket.

He's so absorbed into drinking in every detail of Katsuki's physique that he doesn't notice the arrogant smirk being flashed in his direction.

"Like what you see?"

Izuku closes his mouth. "I… you're just very…"

You're gorgeous. Just, all of you. Every part of you. To me.

All at once, inexplicably, Izuku becomes aware of how lucky he is.

He doesn't fight against being coaxed to the bed. He surrenders to the way Katsuki splays himself out on the covers, propping aside his cast and gesturing grumpily to the empty space beside him. Izuku lies down, the soft covers providing comfort he didn't know he needed. Fresh detergent and the lingering smell of Katsuki's body soap encompass Izuku, and he smiles secretively even after Katsuki presses his nose into the back of his neck. One sweatpant-clad leg is suddenly thrown over Izuku's, tangling up their limbs in a loose hold.

"Are you just not wearing a shirt to spite me?"

He can feel Katsuki's grin against his neck. Then, the gentle press of kisses traveling up the skin, scattering goosebumps.

“You’re wearing too many clothes,” he mutters, his voice a gravelly rumble that sends Izuku’s heart racing.

“Yeah, well…” he pauses.

The memory of Nero Edmure, a phantom that haunts his every dream, smile slick and dangerous and *consuming*, rattles through him. He remembers every second, every moment of the taller, stronger, older man pinning him down to the bed and forcing him to concede to kissing, to groping, to the inevitable smacks across his face and the slapping of a baton on his bones—

He draws in a sharp breath, a panicked skip in his lungs constricting him.

“Deku?”

“I—I have to go.” Izuku moves up to leave. Katsuki reaches out and grabs his forearm, but the grip itself is anything but forceful. “Kacchan,” he mutters, his voice crumbling. “I can’t —”

“Deku, wait.” Katsuki leans up, hair already a frazzled mess. He takes Izuku’s chin and cautiously turns him to lock their gazes together. “Just fucking *talk* to me.”

Izuku flinches, and Katsuki releases him.

“You didn’t,” he starts, and before he can take anything back, he feels Katsuki’s eyes on him. Burning into his shirt, attempting to root out his secrets and, for once, allowing him to speak. “You didn’t see, what happened… I still have scars, ones that he gave me, and I can’t get rid of them. When he touched me, I couldn’t… I couldn’t do anything because he threatened *you* and, and…” he raises his hands to cover his mouth, muffled sniffles and a sudden influx of sobs threatening to break out.

He can feel Katsuki’s body tense up, a dangerous, warning growl slipping into the air. His emotions slip and whiplash in the air, enough to both terrify and enthrall Izuku, though he refuses to indulge in this or even look at his boyfriend when these thoughts and memories continue to bind him.

He stares at the ground, finding a target in the white carpet, and hoping that he doesn’t have to face Katsuki’s surely furious expression. What will he think, when he knows the extent of what Nero had done to him?

“He told me he’d make me his,” he whispers, almost laughing at the mere thought of it. “He just—I’ve never met someone so entitled in my entire life. He would not stay away from me, and Kacchan, I promise that I *tried*. I never let him do it voluntarily. I punched him and hit him, and when he kissed me I bit him and told him to stay away from me…” His voice drips with anguish, with guilt, and the sickening twist in his stomach only grows as he feels the weight in the bed shift.

Is Katsuki leaving? Is he angry? Hurt?

Izuku shudders, his tears quaking through his entire body in an earthquake.

“I’m so sorry.”

His self-control crumbles into ash. He listens for some sign of Katsuki yelling, of him being angry, but all that he’s met with is the undeniable beat of *silence*.

He hates it.

“I mean it. I’m…” he chokes into a sob, a painful throbbing pulsing in his temples. “I’m so sorry, Kacchan. I understand if you’re mad, or if you want to cut this off, or—whatever it is, I’ll—I’ll understand. I—I swear I never wanted any of it, and I pushed him away! I snapped and attacked him back because he said…” he pauses, the previous, black anger he’d felt sweltering in smoky fumes inside him only a week before suddenly returning. “Kacchan—”

The bed creaks.

He stops, terrified of watching Katsuki brush by him and leave, but is instead met with an arm encircling him and crushing him to a recognizable, compact chest. His back presses against Katsuki, molding to the familiar lines and patterns of his body. Katsuki’s heart thumps and rattles against his back, racing and tumultuous and *outraged*.

Izuku hiccups, swallowing back the many questions brewing in his mind’s eye.

“Kacchan…?”

Katsuki’s silence is a startling shock to his system.

Aren’t you mad?

Shouldn’t he be disgusted? Infuriated?

The grip around him tightens, however. Katsuki’s cast-bound arm lopes around him as well, lighter, yet caging him in a protective embrace all the same. Izuku’s body racks with confusion, delight, and an overwhelming sense of knowing he doesn’t deserve this from Katsuki.

“Kacchan, aren’t you mad—”

The threatening growl that rises through Katsuki’s body in a dangerous vibration quiets Izuku.

Izuku, realizing he is hardly able to move a muscle under Katsuki’s impressive cage, relents. He leans his head back onto Katsuki’s shoulder, which seems to please the other teen enough for him to turn and press his nose into Izuku’s temple. His grip, however, does not loosen in the slightest, only pulling Izuku back further onto the bed. Katsuki’s legs fold up and slide around Izuku, slotting Izuku in the middle of Katsuki’s legs and pulling him further flush against him.

Normally such a position would render him stuttering and breathless, but the way Katsuki holds him only echoes the opposite: tenderness. Gentle affection. An aggressive, underlying anger that radiates like gasoline in a factory.

Izuku's throat is dry.

"I…" he pauses. "I didn't mean to kill him—"

"Tell me what he did."

Izuku pauses, confusion rippling through him.

"What do you mean?"

He was already doing that, wasn't he?

"I need to know." Katsuki's voice is here and not—a channel of misplaced anger and near-animalistic rage, pointed at something that no longer exists.

Izuku hesitates. "Kacchan, I know you're mad at me, but—"

"I'm not," Katsuki starts, almost threatening, "mad at you, Izuku."

Izuku lets his words sink in.

"Why the fuck would I be mad at *you*?"

Izuku, for once, does not have a reply to this. He stares at Katsuki's door, uncertain of the arms around him and the sudden press of the other teen's nose into his curly hair.

"I have marks on me. Some… some scars. I couldn't stop him. He bit me," Katsuki goes completely still, "on my neck, and my chest, and…"

He rolls his bottom lip under his teeth, one particular memory flashing through him, warning him. Pulling him back from a stupor where Nero, despite not taking everything he could, made sure he would reach whatever inch of him possible.

"I—I tried to stop him, Kacchan. But, he—he got to my back, and my hips, and he got to my thigh before I stopped him and locked him out of the room Hisashi had ready for me…" he swallows back a shuddering sob, and does not recognize Katsuki's tightening arms and the disquieting way he glares into the wall. "He never did rape me… not—not fully… a lot of it is foggy, though… I don't know if..."

"He drugged you."

Izuku frowns, puzzled at the possibility, but nods.

He's too exhausted to argue.

“Wait…” Izuku leans forward, peeling himself off of Katsuki’s chest to turn around and look him in the eye. Katsuki is unreadable, from the fierce scrunch in his brow to the upturned sneer in his bottom lip. “How did… how would you know?”

Katsuki’s gaze breaks away from Izuku for only a second before returning.

“He did the same to me.”

Izuku’s entire body flips from sullen numbness to fire-surged blood and muscle. He turns back through the memory of Nero pinning him down, legs clamped around his hips, hands reaching for his buckle, and that venom-slick, sugar-sweet voice confessing having Katsuki *underneath him—*

“Kacchan.” Izuku’s face twists up with fury, a protectiveness he knows he only possesses around Katsuki.

He can’t imagine Katsuki being placed in that situation, or becoming so vulnerable that he would allow someone like Nero to try and take advantage of him, but the idea of it alone is enough to send Izuku from one mood to another.

“I got away.” Katsuki snorts, but his arrogant words fall short under a tone of concealed worry and concern that holds Izuku close and safe. “I should’ve told you when I warned you to stay away from him. That fucker shouldn’t have been allowed to patrol in the first place.” He rolls through his memories, but does not let his grip slide from around Izuku. “He tried buttering me up to join his fucking squadron. Caught him checking me out all the time.”

Izuku watches him carefully, reading the way Katsuki’s expression shifts from angry, to complacent, to disgusted.

“Hey. Was my shit to deal with. I reported him after he drugged me and copped a feel in one of his fucking get-togethers with those other shitty Illenova patrolmen. Fucker couldn’t get far enough before he was called on a scouting mission. And his squadron?” He glares into the opposite wall, throat bobbing. “They didn’t do a damn thing.”

Izuku leans in, running his hand through Katsuki’s hair.

“He got pissed that I had him suspended.”

Izuku’s fists bunch in the blankets.

“… I’m sorry, Kacchan—”

“Deku, no.” Katsuki jabs a finger in Izuku’s chest, nostrils flaring. “That was *my* shit to deal with. Not yours. Get it? I want to tear that fucker apart for targeting you and doing all of that while I couldn’t do fucking *anything*. Fuck him. Fuck him, and fuck what he did to you, and fuck him for using you as a *hostage.*” Sparks light up in his palm, pulling a gasp from Izuku. Startled, Katsuki draws his hand back. “… Sorry.”

Izuku tilts his head, sympathetic. Open.

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s bare chest is heaving with anger that builds and builds with each second that passes. His posture is tightly wound, fingers seeking anchor in the comforter of his own bed. He lives and breathes through smoke and fire and power, and it rides on an electric path that involves the both of them. Something intertwined, that Izuku wishes he and Katsuki never had to share.

Katsuki never deserved Nero’s advances.

“And you *did*?”

Izuku shuts his mouth, flushing. He didn’t realize he’d thought that aloud.

Katsuki is staring at him, and he looks *furious*.

“Take it back.”

“What?” Izuku blinks. “What do you—”

“Fucking take it back. I know what you’re thinking.” Katsuki snorts, and pinches Izuku’s cheek. “You better fucking tell your own head to shut the fuck up, Deku, because I’ll knock whatever you’re not telling yourself right now!”

Izuku groans, but laughs.

For the first time in awhile, he feels a little bit free.

At Katsuki’s questioning look, Izuku kisses him.

It’s soft and slow, at first. Izuku holds Katsuki’s face in his hands, and smiles when the other opens his mouth wider to accept it. He adjusts his position, sitting straighter from in-between the space in Katsuki’s legs. He pulls away, grinning down at Katsuki, who leans slowly backward onto the bed while Izuku moves to straddle his waist. He runs his hand from Katsuki’s chest to his stomach, eyes wide in fascination at the fluttering skin and muscle rolling under his touch.

“You’re so handsome, Kacchan.”

It’s so soft it barely slips between his lips, but it’s there, and it makes Katsuki glance up at him with red eyes burning with intensity and awe. Izuku flushes under the look, but his smile turns shy as he leans down and presses a kiss to Katsuki’s collarbone. Katsuki’s fingers weave through his curls, as if to placate him, to push him into the space beside him, but Izuku relents.

He trails his lips from Katsuki’s neck, to trailing downward, and mouthing in various spots on the other boy’s chest. He can feel that heart that beats for both of them, crackling in a hazy firestorm under his ribcage.

“Izuku.” Katsuki sounds aggravated and breathless. “You don’t,” his breath hitches as Izuku sucks a fresh bruise into a spot on his stomach, releasing crackling embers under his skin. “Shit, how do you do this…?”

Izuku appears controlled, but he’s terrified. Every trace of his fingers over Katsuki’s skin, every word that is shared between them, turns into a ghostly reminder of what had happened, and what’s to come. He’s awed at the beauty before him, at Katsuki’s willingness to be coaxed into lying on his own bed, his one good hand resting in Izuku’s hair while he trusts him, wholeheartedly, to continue.

“Izuku, wait.”

Izuku kisses the teasing flash of Katsuki’s hip, and looks up.

Katsuki’s face is flushed red to the tips of his ears. He seems caught between saying something, and allowing Izuku to move downward, to go past the exposed hem of his boxers and—

“Come back up here.”

Izuku frowns. “Is something wrong?”

“No, idiot. Just…” Katsuki’s eyes flick away. “Whatever. Come up here.”

The sudden flash of awkwardness is adorable enough for Izuku to reconsider. He hums thoughtfully and slinks back up to Katsuki, kissing his jaw before spilling off his stomach and lying at his side. He tucks into Katsuki’s warmth, marveling at the pronounced ribs and rippling trails of sinew, flesh and bone that easily fold under his fingers.

“Are you okay?” he asks.

Katsuki’s arm reaches behind Izuku, rubbing circles into his back.

It reminds Izuku of a few days ago, finding Katsuki beaten and bruised in his hospital bed, and being pulled into the empty spot beside him with barely a word of protest.

“Stop asking dumb questions!” Katsuki barks. “Idiot…”

“You’re acting…” Izuku huffs. “So weird, Kacchan. It’s cute, though.”

“Shut up. This is like, the only fucking thing I have a hard time with.”

That… gives Izuku pause.

He leans up on his elbows, watching Katsuki closely. From what he can tell, Katsuki hadn’t meant to any of that either. He’s glaring up at the ceiling, eyes wide and shocked, and another new blush spreading from his neck to the crown of his hair.

“Kacchan?” Izuku slightly giggles, his previous anxieties curbing into nothing. “Are you… okay?”

“Nothing!” Katsuki barks, and jerks his head away. “You look stupid.”

“Sure.” Izuku chuckles, his grin spreading so far wide it begins to ache. “Kacchan, you can tell me. Please?”

“No.”

“So you *do* have something you want to tell me.”

Katsuki whips his head back, glares at him, and roughly shoves Izuku’s head into his armpit.

Izuku *squeals.*

“No! Ah! No, Kacchan, I yield! I yield!”

“Yeah? Soak it all in, stupid nerd!” Katsuki growls. “Bet you’re gonna stop laughing at me now, huh?”

“I give!” Izuku pulls up for air, gasping. He wrinkles his nose in disgust. “You’re an asshole.”

“Hmph.” Katsuki seems satisfied with Izuku’s brief moment of misery, but he does not allow Izuku to leave the space on the bed.

They settle into a comfortable silence. A habit that has become newly developed over the last several days, but most definitely welcome.

Izuku runs his hand down Katsuki’s stomach, marveling at the natural warmth that exudes from him. His flushed skin and the way Katsuki relaxes under his touch almost makes him believe this is an acceptable deflection from what happened earlier.

“I…” Katsuki groans. “Look, Deku.”

Izuku blinks, and watches as Katsuki lifts himself from the bed. The powerful muscles in his back shift and roll as he does so, and Izuku chastises himself for the rather inappropriate moment to start staring and, once again, admiring his significant other’s body.

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki says nothing, his eye-rolling the only signal Izuku needs to sit back up again. Katsuki shifts back, allowing space for Izuku to adjust and place himself comfortably between Katsuki’s parted legs. A tender warmth reaches up inside his chest and wrap around his heart.

“Kacchan?” Izuku tilts his head, searching.

Katsuki straightens, his face contorting from a confused, unsure mask to something that’s far more human and understandable. He nibbles on his bottom lip, and at Izuku’s concerned grin, reaches over, and takes both of Izuku’s hands in his.

Izuku’s heart immediately leaps, stopping him short of breath.

Katsuki looks down, his grip painful on Izuku's hands.

He silently hopes that Katsuki's Quirk won't lead to two very untimely explosions.

"I… fuck." Katsuki groans under his breath. "Fucking old man said this'd be easier…"

"Eh?" Izuku frowns. "Kacchan, you're starting to worry me."

"I have something important to tell you!" Katsuki says, loudly, sharply, though instead of appearing bold and vindictive, it comes off as a choking squawk. Izuku's eyes bulge, both endeared by Katsuki's current efforts and somewhat worried. "Listen, I've been meaning to —hey, fucker, just, stop laughing at me! Christ."

"I'm sorry! I'm not trying to." Izuku nods. "Okay. Please, talk."

Katsuki hesitates. "I… okay." He stares down at Izuku's hands. "We haven't really… known each other that long, or whatever. You know. Usual shit. People, kind of hating each other. Becoming… friends, or something like that. Or something. And, kissing eventually and fooling around. And you like my face and I like your face, I guess. And, smile, and shit. You look really good in that shirt, and I hate your stupid fucking sneakers but for some reason I don't them as much as normal. You've got a nice ass, too. Ah, wait. Fuck. That's irrelevant."

Izuku can't stop the adoring smile from spreading across his face. His stomach is backflipping, heart speeding into a delighted rhythm.

"And I freaked out, when you told me you liked me. I didn't know how to handle it, and it was shitty. Your friend, eh, Round Face…" he rolls his eyes. "I dunno. She just spouted shit and I thought about all of it. And…" he pauses, nose scrunching up like a confused rabbit's. "I thought about it all more when you were gone."

Izuku's thumb strokes Katsuki's palm, a quiet reassurance.

"I have no idea how this fucking happened, because frankly you're a huge nerd and a total loser." Katsuki snorts, but his grin is altogether fond. He finally lifts his head to look Izuku in the eye, and his confidence recedes under a blush and a bobbing of his Adam's apple. "I knew that, I would do what I could to fucking protect you. It was the first time I wanted to, I dunno, take someone's place and destroy everything for them."

"Kacchan…" Izuku whispers, touched.

"I dunno, shit." Katsuki hesitates, eyes flicking off to the side briefly before going back. "I dunno, maybe I fucking love you or something. Fuck."

He says it so quickly that Izuku barely catches it. The words fall into place, one by one, and Izuku's entire body turns deep red. His jaw hangs open in disbelief.

"You…" he blinks owlishly. "Huh?"

"You're not deaf!" Katsuki huffs, ripping his hands out of Izuku's and scratching his cheek. As he does so, however, a small explosive energy cloud bursts in his palm, surprising both of

them and drawing a giggle out of Izuku. “Fuck!”

“Kacchan, you love me?”

“I—I didn’t say that.”

“… Yes you did. Just now.” Izuku tilts his head.

“Fuck you. Did not,” Katsuki deadpans.

“… Okay. So, theoretically, if you did.” Izuku grins despite himself, relief and joy crashing over him. “It’d be good. I feel the same way.”

Katsuki freezes at this. Then, cautiously, he side-eyes Izuku, one eyebrow lifted in suspicion as if this entire conversation is a well-concealed conspiracy.

“I’m serious.” Izuku chuckles. “Katsuki.” He traces his hand under the other boy’s jaw, marveling at the way Katsuki softens and, still guarded, watches him skeptically. “I love you, too. I have for awhile. I just… wasn’t sure if you would feel the same way.”

Katsuki grabs his wrist, halting his movements.

“Kacchan?”

“You love me?” He swallows, not meeting his gaze. “Really?”

“Yes.” Izuku shifts on the bed, effectively closing the distance between them. “And you love me, too, right?”

Katsuki holds his gaze this time, though the look in his eyes has shifted. The hesitation simmers into something genuine and indescribable, with a flicker of desire and hunger that Izuku relishes.

“Then let me prove it to you.”

Katsuki straightens, and in a flash Izuku is flipped, pulled underneath him. He squeaks at the quick movement, staring up in awe at the other boy, drinking up every inch of golden skin, every inch of a person he can now open his heart completely to, and drowns in it all.

“Can you support yourself with one good wrist, Kacchan?” Izuku teases.

Katsuki huffs, and descends. “You’re gonna find out.”

Izuku laughs, and meets him halfway.

Chapter End Notes

Would love to know your thoughts. This chapter was sooo hard to write, but so satisfying to finish. Been waiting to write those moments since chapter four. So, it's been a long, patient ride for me too, haha.

Thank you again, for your support. The comments. The kudos. The bookmarks. Just clicking on this story at ALL. Thank you so much. There is not one moment where I am unthankful. It means the world, and so much more. I hope you're enjoying this fic as it's coming to its close.

Would love to know your thoughts. Please let me know what you thought in the comments below. As usual, thank you for reading, and taking the time to read this fic.

Unity

Chapter Summary

> “I do.” Izuku nods, his heart racing, a thunderclap in his ribcage. “I want to. With you, Kacchan. Katsuki. Please.” He squeezes his arm. “Only with you.”

Chapter Notes

> I don't have enough words to express my gratitude.
>
> One more chapter after this one, folks. We're almost done.
>
> Thank you. From the bottom of my heart. I love you all.
>
> ... also this is my first real attempt at writing explicit sex.
>
> ...
>
> ...
>
> ...
>
> You've been asking for it. Get ready for feels.

… Four Months Later …

The purple box grabs his attention only moments before his mother calls for his name.

Katsuki’s lips curl back, a thoughtful sneer that leaves him dragging his eyes along every aisle in the tiny convenience store. The image of a familiar medieval mascot watching him on the front of the box makes his fists curl tighter and tighter, as if taunting him for only the handful of reasons that relate to one aspect of being in a relationship that terrifies him.

“Oi, brat! Get a move on!” Mitsuki calls, her purse swinging at her side. Plastic bags dangle from her arms, overstuffed with what Katsuki knows are useless trinkets at best. “Do you seriously want to lag behind all day or are you gonna start walking anytime soon? Jesus. Your father’s got his book club this evening and I promised we’d be back to watch his show before that!”

Katsuki glares at the purple box, and rolls his eyes.

“Whatever, hag! I’ll catch up!”

His mother shakes her head, muttering something under her breath and leaving the tiny establishment with a dramatic *clang*.

Katsuki wipes his sweaty hands on his joggers. He’s already exhausted from his morning run, and he’d promised Izuku that he would spar with him in Sommartyn’s gym later, but just looking over these wares on his lonesome causes his lungs to constrict and thump. His chest feels tight, the phantom memory of wandering from one bedroom to another and tossing Izuku’s belongings into multiple cardboard boxes makes his blood simmer.

He hates the idea of Izuku and Inko moving into another apartment. Away from them.

“It’s fine, Kacchan,” Izuku had insisted numerous times. *“There aren’t any patrolmen anymore. We don’t have any overly suspicious gang members watching us.”*

He’d said it wistfully, as if Katsuki was meant to take it as a joke. But it didn’t feel that way. Not with their overlapping therapy sessions and Izuku’s mysterious appointments with the Quirk-certified therapist Dr. Philip Abrams, who was apparently more gifted in solving memory repression and amnesiac patients than engaging in normal routines.

The gangly teenager manning the cash register pops a wad of bubblegum and watches Katsuki closely, as if caught between marveling why or how he could exist. Or still be there.

“Hey, kid, are you going to buy something or what?”

Katsuki twitches. He grabs the box, glares frigidly at the door, and marches over the register with a confidence and apprehension that both puffs out and strangles his chest. He latches onto the boy with his glare riding in toe, his finger jabbing the purple box with remarkable restraint.

“Just ring this up, gum-fuck.”

He leaves the convenience store with a considerable weight added to his left side. The bag feels heavy, carrying implications that he would rather burn alive than let his parents see. He knows that, regardless, they will figure out what it is within seconds of entering the front door to his home. A home that will only consist of him, his father, and his mother, and not the two Midoriyas who’d taken shelter in their home so easily almost a year ago.

He hopes his parents, or Inko, in particular, won’t bother to ask him why he needed to buy a travel-sized box of condoms.

The apartment itself is almost twice as large as the one where Inko and Izuku had stayed before. Though from what Katsuki can hardly remember, since he'd only seen it in passing and never stepped inside to greet it until Zeke rendered Izuku unconscious. Those moments were considerably too stressful to harbor any additional observations.

In just a few months, Augustana has faced numerous changes. Though this was one Katsuki wasn't willing to accept yet.

He drinks in his surroundings, contemplative.

Fuck.

What was the best way to ask your boyfriend to have sex for the first time without pressuring them?

"Goddammit," he grits out, dragging one hand down his face. "Fucking… manners and shit. Deku won't like that, fuck. He'll freak out."

Take a goddamn chill pill, Katsuki! Jesus. You're not in a rush.

Izuku is living somewhere else now, safe.

The living room space and kitchen spaces are identifiably separate, leaving more breathing room for guests and extra family members. Or even a pet, if Izuku was so inclined to buy a dog. Or a cat.

Katsuki's nose wrinkles at the smell of fresh mint and lemon. He locks onto the bottle of cleaning spray left on the kitchen island, all smooth blue granite and marble. Paper towels and packaged gifts wait in clusters in the corners, beside the new toaster oven Masaru and Mitsuki had aggressively fought to purchase for Inko, despite the Midoriyas already having a clearly functioning oven.

He sets down his backpack, welcoming the coolness of the place. The silence is comforting, after months of listening to and watching news headlines flash in bulletins each morning. The names of the patrols falling like flies, the government insisting on taking a stand to regulate the appropriate usage of law enforcement and Quirks. It would still take many steps for any heroes to receive recognition for what they deserved, though Shouto Todoroki had received numerous accolades and notified callouts from his work in stopping Hisashi's plan from being completed.

He straightens, the sound of a door opening and a running shower grabbing his attention.

He smirks at the prospect of Izuku being here, naked.

Casually, he leans against the counter and inspects his cuticles. The black tank top draped over him accentuates every muscle and gives way to the strong cords in his neck and broad shoulders. He wants Izuku to stumble over himself, and look. He wants him to see, and be rendered just as foolish and tongue-tied as he sometimes is when it's just the two of them.

"Kacchan?"

He looks up, and grins.

"Nerd."

Izuku flushes, hair a tousled curly mess, his smile wobbly and awkward. He's haphazardly dressed in an All Might-branded T-shirt and sweatpants. Both articles of clothing seem older than even his red sneakers.

"Mom is—ah, still at your place, I think. Getting the rest of everything. I just wanted to shower here first and maybe start unpacking while she was off doing that. You know. Haha. Making things a little easier…" he trails off, and rubs the back of his neck. Pupils flick about wildly, latching onto anything other than Katsuki's cruel smile. "Kacchan, I thought you were coming later tonight. Weren't we all going to have dinner together or something? Oh wait, no, damn, that's tomorrow… so wait, what was happening tonight? Ah, just hold on a second, I still have to make sure my collectibles are ready to be put on my new shelf—"

Katsuki walks over to him, wraps an arm around his waist, and pulls him into a kiss. Izuku melts almost instantly, weaving his arms around Katsuki's neck and deepening the embrace, but only for a moment. He pulls back, lips already swollen.

"Felt like coming, dumbass," says Katsuki, "so why the fuck're you mumbling?"

Izuku rolls his eyes. "You know why."

Katsuki raises an eyebrow. "No, what the hell are you talking about?"

Izuku tilts his head, squinting. "I had another appointment today. You know. With Doctor Abrams." He pauses, staring at the ceiling, and then back at Katsuki. "He's helping me with… recovering what was lost. Even with his own Quirk, it's difficult for him to pull everything back after it was submerged for so long. And the nightmares, they're getting better with the more I remember, but it's also more difficult because of what's happening with Shigaraki."

Katsuki ponders this over. "Saw something on the news. He vanished from his headquarters?"

"Presumably fled the country." Izuku nods. "I don't… know if that's true. Where would he even go? How would he be able to flee anywhere without someone knowing? After Hisashi's death, the train was at a complete standstill and people still haven't stopped talking about it." He huffs, the determination in his green eyes sharp like lightning. "It's not—I don't

understand how people can just be brushing all of that aside. Everything that you and Todoroki did, and… and our parents, everything they accomplished, that's all being shoved aside and you're not getting any credit for it."

Katsuki snorts. "Fuck 'em. Don't care."

"You care, Kacchan," says Izuku, shaking his head and carefully peeling out of his arms. Katsuki watches his back appreciatively as he jogs through the living room to a tower of stacked moving boxes. "And it's okay to care. At least when my article was shown it's helped a little bit, but you were part of why that plan worked all those months ago, and now you're not getting called out. It's stupid, and I wish I could change it, and—"

Katsuki quickly comes up behind him, arms around his middle and nose buried in the crook of his neck. Izuku pauses, his stammering lodged in his chest and bobbing up his throat.

"Oi, Deku." He snorts at the other teen's grimace. "Doesn't fucking matter. It's over."

At one point, he would have cared. Immensely, even. But there are aspects of him that have changed since the first night he met Izuku Midoriya on that very same train in less-than-traditional circumstances. Gaining a concussion and a frustrated lack of understanding of his own city led to an unpredictable series of events, but none of it left him aching to grow and develop as much as the words Izuku shared with him.

"… You're different today."

Katsuki backs away and glares. "I'll fucking kill you."

Izuku laughs. "You are, though!"

"Fuck you. Am not." He rolls his eyes, attempting desperately to remain calm while his heart races at an unfathomable speed. He wonders if he'll spontaneously combust if he stares at Izuku too long. "Show me what to unpack."

Izuku's teasing expression dissolves. "Oh—are you sure, Kacchan? There's still a lot I need to do—"

"Yes. I'm fucking sure. I'm your fucking boyfriend or whatever, right?" His glare intensifies, skin heating up, as Izuku's gaze turns soft. "So just—show me where to put everything! Goddamn, you're so fucking slow."

The process is simple, albeit tiring.

Hours pass, though Katsuki doesn't feel the weight of time sliding through his arms and legs even after the number of unpacked belongings catch up to him. He's careful when navigating through Izuku's new room, eyeing the strange occasional crack in the drywall and the clean, pristine white carpet with bated interest. The mattress is set up, blankets and sheets folded in a corner. Bookshelves are already set up neatly and endearingly by the closest window, containing what Katsuki knows to be hundreds of personal documents Izuku had written himself, and glass cases containing superhero memorabilia and other nonsensical items.

It’s a space that feels strangely empty, if not…

Katsuki swallows.

He stares at the mattress, and the panicked thoughts from before slam back into him.

He’s imagined it many times, how he would ask Izuku, how long it would take to feel like a decent person with taking that next step. Buying the condoms was both impulsive and a planned maneuver he’d wanted to act out for months, even when still bound in a cast. There were too many nights, kept in that space with Izuku, where his thoughts wandered to more traitorous images, and he was unable to sleep without sweating and singing his bedsheets and pillows.

“Hello—oh! Katsuki?”

Katsuki nearly jackknifes straight back up after glaring at Izuku’s bed for nearly five minutes. His face flushes, the instinctive growl folding back behind his tongue. He nods his head at Inko, who pushes open the door with a small smile on her lips. She seems healthier, skin rosy and glassy green eyes more vibrant than they had even months before.

It was hard to believe that she was also a sharpshooting killer.

Hours after she’d shot her own husband on the top of the train, her smile betrayed any sense of regret that possibly lingered there. Guilt and shame swirled in hidden patterns, traceable through the wrinkles around her eyes and the shadows following her steps.

Between then and now, seeing her was still eerie.

Not ever gonna fucking get used to this…

“Ms. Midoriya,” he grunts, dipping his head.

Inko blinks. “There’s no need for the formalities, Katsuki. I’m just surprised you’re here so… early in the pre-production stages. You know?” She glances around Izuku’s room, lips curled. “He’s so excited about moving into a better place and having a room to himself again. Not that he didn’t love living with you and your wonderful family, Katsuki.”

“Obviously.” Katsuki shifts, hands shoved into his pockets. He avoids looking at Izuku’s mother, hoping that each second she remains standing at the doorway leads closer to her realizing he doesn’t want to have any kind of conversation right now.

Especially after daydreaming—once again—about having sex with her son.

Izuku’s voice echoes through the apartment.

“Hey, Mom! Do you need help putting away the groceries?”

Inko smiles at Katsuki, and peeks her head out of the door. He frowns, anxiety prickling under his skin. Why was she being so exclusive?

“You can get a head start, Izu. I’ll be there in a few minutes. I wanted to show Katsuki around the place a little bit before we set him to work, too!”

The sound of pans clattering to the ground and Izuku’s surprised squeak earns a small chuckle from Katsuki.

“Izu?”

“I-I’m good! Sorry! Got it!”

Inko sighs to herself, shaking her head. “That kid…”

“… Yeah.” Katsuki clamps his jaw shut. Inko glances at him, her expression unreadable. It almost terrifies him, even with the darkness to Izuku’s near-empty room and the strange feeling that Inko is able to pluck out his darkest secrets.

“So, Katsuki,” she says, her tone shifting to one of solemn acceptance, “I did see something by the doorway that I don’t remember picking up at the store. Was wondering if you could maybe go over some of the details with me, outside of Izuku’s earshot, of course.”

She holds up the purple box of condoms, barely concealed in a plastic bag.

Katsuki’s stomach flips.

Oh, fuck.

Inko closes the door behind her.

Shit.

Inko Midoriya quite possibly replaced her husband as the most unsettling person he’s ever met.

“Relax, Katsuki.” Inko’s face softens. She sets the box on one of the unopened moving boxes, her dainty little hands somehow smooth and yet, capable of wielding a multitude of firearms. “I’m not here to intimidate you or threaten you. I think we can bypass some fo the semantics, given that the question about what your intentions are with my son would seem a little redundant.”

Despite her words, an underlying threat is strung up in her words. The air seems thick and cautious, and the look Inko sends him reminds him of a mother tigress protecting her cub.

“So.” She clasps her hands together. Katsuki swallows. “How long?”

For a second, Katsuki feels relief flood through him. He glares at the door, half-expecting Izuku to poke his head inside and walk in at an inopportune time—an area where he seemed proficiently skilled.

“We haven’t.”

Yet.

“Hm.” Inko’s eyes run up and down his frame, her brow pinching in the middle. She mirrors her son with the thoughtful mumbles that soon tumble out of her mouth, matching the unspoken thoughts he’s sure she would rather say aloud. “And your reason for bringing an entire travel-sized box of *extra protection* condoms into my house?”

Katsuki holds her gaze, his confidence slithering away like sand.

“It was… an impulse buy.” He shrugs. “I haven’t—we haven’t talked about it yet.”

He wants to evacuate this conversation immediately.

“So you *weren’t* planning to seduce my Izuku in our new apartment?”

Katsuki goes completely still. The image of Izuku stepping out of the bathroom in his ridiculous old clothes, rumpled curly hair and bashful smile strikes him like a battering ram.

Hell yes.

Inko seems to read the subconscious smirk growing on his face.

“Katsuki?”

“I wasn’t.” He pauses, quickly regaining some foothold in the moment. “We never talked about it. With… the therapy and, all that… there’s been a lot for him. I didn’t want to pressure him.” He scratches his cheek, his reasons starting to build up in a tower of resolve. “I wouldn’t do that to him. And he wouldn’t fu—he wouldn’t want that.”

He holds Inko’s gaze, willing himself to stand tall.

Don’t fuck it up.

He was planning to talk to Izuku about this no matter what his mother said, but to have her blessing…

He remembers the way Izuku looked at him, how he held his face in his hands when he told him he loved him back. He was ridiculous and stupidly adorable, constantly reassuring him and building up what he wanted to be true. When he laughed or smiled or cried, he was honest and open with him. He’d allowed Katsuki to push boundaries before, to lay his hands over his skin and trace the scars he loathed under his fingers.

Many fears were instilled into Izuku’s body against his will. Katsuki wanted to remove that apprehension, one by one. He wanted to replace those thoughts and dark dreams with his face, to keep Izuku in a way that stemmed far past his territorial and even overtly possessive tendencies.

His casual jealousy never reached close enough to incite the amount of anger he’d felt at Izuku confessing what Nero had done to him.

His own mother knew almost immediately, as soon as Izuku was rescued and Katsuki admitted into the hospital. He remembers the way she looked at him, her face swollen and strangely imperfect.

"That boy… no one should go through that, but I can't imagine what he must be feeling."

Katsuki never knew what to say.

He still feels the warmth of her fingers sheltering his on the coffee table in their living room, his anxiously twitching limbs enough of a warning for her to follow through.

"Sex should never be used as a weapon, Katsuki. I've raised you well enough to remember that."

The memory fades, a shallow pool of thought he doesn't want to revisit in the moment. Not with Inko still latching onto him with so much uncertainty and nervousness crinkling her features.

They hold one another's stares, searching and asking silent questions in the safety of Izuku's bedroom. Then, Inko's disposition slumps, her shoulders lowering just slightly. She purses her lips thoughtfully, eyes running back and forth from Katsuki to the condoms positioned too close to her frame and the suspiciously closed door.

Now would be a great fucking time for you to show up, nerd.

"He's growing up so fast." She nods. "You'll stay for dinner, won't you?"

Katsuki blinks, and nods.

"Good." Inko grabs the knob and twists it, only to pause. "We've only been out of your house for less than a week, and he still never tires of talking about you." Katsuki's chest flutters, but he pushes it down in favor for the way Inko lights up. "My Izuku loves you dearly, Katsuki. Treat him well, won't you?"

She doesn't wait for an answer.

The door closes behind her. He exhales, and draws his fingers through his hair, breathing through flared nostrils.

"… Holy fucking shit."

Izuku scoops a spoonful of rice into his mouth, the taste of spiced vegetables and port cutlets sizzling on his tongue. He smiles broadly at his mother, who seems more than a little distracted as she grabs their plates and pans to place in the sink.

The television they have is old and shouldn't be operating as well as it is now, with the occasional flicker in a blue screen and the choppiness of rehearsed sitcom actors. DVD cases lie sprawled over the carpet, and the lack of any furniture to support them while they eat their food on the floor only makes it seem less real. Like a vision plucked from a dream he never expected to have, not when his life used to be consumed with the smoky, suffocating atmosphere of their old district.

"I'll put the dishes away," says Inko, grinning down at the two of them. "Make sure you clean up after yourselves and put whatever's left by the sink, alright?"

"Of course. Thank you, Mom," says Izuku.

"Oh, I almost forgot." Inko smiles at them both, practically twinkling. "I wanted to tell you that I was going out to run a few more errands. Would you both mind holding down the fort for me?"

Izuku frowns, tilting his head. "Are you sure, Mom? Do you want help with anything—"

"It's quite alright. I'll be needing your help probably when I get back, of course, but not until then." Inko studies them, a knowing glint in her eye. "Katsuki, you'll make sure things are alright here, yes?"

Izuku tries not to point out Katsuki's change in demeanor and the rapid blush rising in his cheeks.

He chooses not to question it.

"Good, good." She clasps her hands together. "Well, I'll be off in a few, then."

Katsuki clears his throat and murmurs his thanks, though he seems far more apprehensive. Izuku leans back, and relaxes under the weight of Katsuki's shoulder, his other hand sliding around his back and propping on the outer side of his right hip.

His knee brushes Katsuki's. Even after months of holding hands, kissing, and exploring boundaries they'd never deemed possible at one point, the sensation is electric. Sparks flitting through his tensing muscles, bringing about dreams he was ashamed of at one point.

It's almost enough to push each session he has with Dr. Abrams out of his mind.

"Hey, nerd," says Katsuki, flicking his ear. "Something up?"

Izuku shakes his head, distracted. "No. Sorry."

Katsuki's glare intensifies.

“Really!” Izuku grins nervously. “Kacchan, it’s fine. It’s been a long but really good day, right?”

“… Right.” Katsuki rolls his eyes, but doesn’t move away from Izuku.

Katsuki knows more details about his therapy sessions than his mother does. The continuously frequent communication briefings with the detectives—Yagi Toshinori, in particular—still grates his nerves and makes him twitch. His hands seek purchase in the carpet, imagining being folded around the very gun that his mother and father once wielded; an item that was connected directly to his memories.

The many nightmares, the memory, of holding the weapon in his hands still taints his everyday actions. He feels the prickling sensations return with each recollection. The stroke of his father’s hands over his shoulders, skimming over metal and directing him to no direct target in particular. His mother, watching in the background, thinner than a pencil and easier to shake than a brittle tree.

“Do you want…” Izuku huffs out a laugh, turning to smile at Katsuki. “Do you want to watch a movie?”

Katsuki frowns. “The fuck? Didn’t we just watch, like, two fucking hours of your mom’s sitcoms?”

“No, no, I mean…” Izuku shrugs, suddenly bashful. He looks away and stares at the wall, hoping that the sudden racing of his heart won’t block out what he wants to say. “You know. Um.” He briefly glances over his shoulder. Inko is humming lowly to herself, distracted with each clink and clank of a dish being washed and stored from one side of the sink to the other. “In my room?”

Katsuki stiffens behind him. The heavy rumble of his diaphragm rolls into a standstill.

He leans over and locks eyes with Katsuki, concerned.

“We don’t have to, Kacchan,” he says, “I just wanted to… offer, since, you know—”

“Yeah.” Katsuki snorts. “Let’s go.”

Izuku grins, a flutter in his chest.

Katsuki remains quiet, shoulders hunched and neck tense. Izuku’s not sure why he would be acting this way, since he seemed so relaxed and content when walking into the apartment only hours ago.

Maybe he’s tired.

He watches his mother, reading her slinking from the kitchen to the front door with her purse and keys, before he releases a relieved sigh.

Having her watch the two of them constantly was already draining.

Once he closes the door to his new bedroom, he looks to the open blinds over his window, transfixed. His eyes flicker over the carefully placed, still-packaged action figures and limited edition cards he'd gathered over the years.

"… I still have to figure out where to put my collectibles."

Katsuki snorts, arms folded. "You're a shitnerd."

"Okay, you call me that all the time, but you loved the show too." Izuku raises an eyebrow and makes his way over to the tower of moving boxes he hasn't been able to touch yet. The labels seem older than they are, faded marker betraying the lack of familiarity in this much larger, more comfortable place. "Pretty sure that's what we agreed on."

"We didn't agree on shit," says Katsuki, who seems particularly focused on a poster of All Might from their shared childhood cartoon. "Don't make up things."

Izuku slinks up behind him, resting his chin on his shoulder. He wraps his arms around Katsuki's waist, welcoming the warmth and hard plane of his abdomen through the thin cloth of his top.

"You sure?" He grins at the threatening growl rumbling in Katsuki's chest, a vibration that comforts him and pushes him to tease. "I dunno, Kacchan. Pretty sure how that all happened was you were trying to impress me with how you fought Zeke, but I happened to bring up a certain cartoon that we both really loved—"

Katsuki turns around, too quick for Izuku to catch him. He yelps, suddenly caught and pressed flush to Katsuki, unable to contain the grin spreading wide and adoring across his face.

Katsuki's eyes are wild and competitive. There's amusement there, hot coals settling in flames.

"Who said I was tryin' to impress you?" he asks, leaning closer.

"Hm, you were kind of obvious," says Izuku.

Katsuki's mouth brushes over his, and Izuku ducks out of his arms, almost skipping to the other end of his bedroom to pick up his laptop off the ground. He whirls around, and breaks into a laugh at the surprised—and incredibly angry—expression on Katsuki's face. Cheeks enflamed and hands empty from where they had held him.

"You're such a little shit."

"You love me anyway." Izuku grins and turns around before he can drink in the apprehensive look that washes Katsuki's face blank.

He hops onto his bed, opening up his computer and quickly browsing through a myriad of files he'd forgotten to close from earlier. Many articles were still half-finished and littered in highlighted pointers. He would have to run through them all with Uraraka later, at least

before Monday. Too many competitive college fairs were coming up, and none of that would be—

The laptop lid is slapped shut.

Izuku jerks back, glancing up to Katsuki's cruel smile, his face only inches from his.

"Uh." Izuku laughs. "Can I get a ten second head-start?"

"You *wish*."

The computer is nearly thrown off the bed with how quickly Katsuki wrangles him into a defensive position. Legs and arms clamped around his body, hands wringing up Izuku's wrists and yanking them behind his back. He squeals with each quick retaliation, annoyed at how easily Katsuki manages to twist him into a pretzel and tickle him mercilessly when any spots open up.

"A—okay! Ah! Okay, okay, I give!" Izuku laughs, his entire body flustered. Katsuki's hands pause, fingers tracing over the cloth in his shirt. With his chuckles slowly simmering to a standstill, he takes in their position, glancing up to drink in Katsuki's expression. "Kacchan…?"

Katsuki, for just a few seconds, is lulled in a distracted state. His lips are pursed and thoughtful, eyebrows furrowed as if contemplating something heavy, something unseen. The way the light filters through the window's blinds makes him almost look ethereal—pale, smooth skin touched gray and blue. The day is grayer, warm and heavy, gliding over the normal gold and bronze that turns the sun's rays a certain color.

Yet on Katsuki, it seems surreal, like it shouldn't exist. But it does.

Izuku's mouth opens, momentarily awestruck. He catches Katsuki's glare, the other teen hovering above him, his gaze unreadable.

It holds an intensity that Izuku has sensed only a handful of times before. The first time they kissed, thankful to be alive, thankful to find some sort of anchor in a world they realized was far more mangled and corrupt than what they originally believed. The night Katsuki held him close, expelling his truths and past mistakes, confessing his love for him.

Katsuki strides like a man infused with gunpowder and ash, always living off the adrenaline and reveling in the aftershocks. He screams profanities in different ways, his voice changing when addressing his mother as opposed to his enemies. On the first night they met, Izuku saw someone who would never shed any layer, who would never take those chances with him. He was intrigued, and accidentally stepped forward, only to plunge into a world that left their paths interwoven.

"You're amazing."

Katsuki turns beet-red, the seriousness soon replaced with anger.

Adorable.

Izuku's cheeks hurt with how widely he's smiling.

The quiet in the room is palpable, weaving tenderly and softening around the both fo them. He wants to feel Katsuki's lips on his, maybe trace his fingers over that smooth skin, maybe share a laugh or two over how stupid they had been and how ridiculous they were always going to be.

Things were changing, and too quickly.

"… It's not," Katsuki croaks out, throat bobbing, "not fucking fair."

Izuku blinks, drawn out of his haze. "What do you mean? What's not fair?"

"*You*." Katsuki's hand slides up and tenderly takes Izuku's chin, thumb brushing his jawbone. "Everything about you. Fucking stupid, nerdy, and unfair."

He kisses him.

It's so sudden that Izuku barely catches it, but he's there all the same. He settles, hands wandering up Katsuki's powerful arms, testing the goosebump-riddled skin. The sudden quiet leaks into his senses, the realization of the weight pressed over him on the bedsheets keeping his mind awake.

He expects Katsuki to pull away, to tease him, and fall into something else. The patterns that Izuku is accustomed to make him think that Katsuki will release him, say a few words that pretend to be angry but hold too much affection for the statements to truly mean anything. The anger that lies in Katsuki's voice when he holds Izuku close only tell him how much he wishes to not be apart from him.

But Katsuki's teeth find Izuku's lower lip. Testing.

Izuku jolts at the sensation that springs up his back. He tenses, only to soften as Katsuki's tongue slides back in, his movements smooth and containing, but unsure. The hesitation that rides each movement makes Izuku's body melt and fall into an uncertain state.

"*Deku*," Katsuki whispers, breath warm and sultry against his neck.

"Kacchan."

Katsuki's mouth presses to his neck, sucks, and pops up in rhythm. He trails down, crackling with energy and soft as a feather. Izuku trembles, caught in the slowness, the tenderness that envelops Katsuki as if he's touching him for the first time.

"Katsuki…"

He wants to ask him a question. But what?

Katsuki leans up and kisses him again, more insistent. His weight presses closer, a strong presence hanging over him. Bare shoulders highlighted in sunlit stripes. Izuku returns it,

leaning up on his forearms, finding balance with his back against the wall as he snakes his other hand up to Katsuki's neck, gripping those fine blond hairs.

Katsuki opens his mouth wider, pressing even closer. He's never been this close.

Izuku can hear—*feel*, every heartbeat. Every pulse.

Thump.

"Izuku."

Thump.

Katsuki turns his head, and angles deeper.

"K-Katsuki," he says, with barely a chance to speak.

Katsuki growls, his movements growing ravenous, uncontrolled.

Izuku reciprocates, both arms now reaching up to encircle Katsuki's neck, fingers lowering to find purchase in the powerful muscles of his back. They move quickly, bodies pressing closer and the rhythm picking up. Izuku doesn't notice when Katsuki pulls him—yanks him, back underneath, his knees flying out.

Katsuki's hands wander down to the hem of Izuku's shirt, and for the first time, he doesn't ask permission as he *pulls*.

Izuku is breathless, caught off-guard.

"*Off*," grunts Katsuki, his teeth gnashing by Izuku's ear, a warning.

Izuku nods vigorously, grabbing his old, ratty shirt and quickly wriggling out of it. He tosses the bundled cloth to the darkened corner of the room. Katsuki leans up and does the same, and each roll of his muscles flexing as he quickens each movement and stumbles to act smoothly makes Izuku's heart skip and skip and *skip*.

Izuku doesn't wait. He gazes up into Katsuki's eyes, wrapping his arms around his neck to pull him down to his level. He kisses him, earnestly, a fire kindling deep in his core.

Katsuki touches him freely now, as if a dam is broken. Hands wandering over his arms, behind his back, trailing dangerously low to the curve of his rear.

This is different.

Izuku's hand, newly calloused, runs down Katsuki's pectorals. He feels the scars, the patches of smooth skin and the expanse of hard-earned muscle. Katsuki's stomach heaves in, sensitive, pebbled in gooseflesh. Izuku smiles, soft and powerful.

Katsuki nips his ear.

“Quit it,” he rumbles, voice raking Izuku’s eardrum like gravel and asphalt.

“Sorry,” Izuku breathes out. “Can’t help myself.”

“Hm…” Katsuki pulls back, and for a moment, it’s back to the first time they were like this.

The first night they kissed, the first time he let anyone see him like this. Partially exposed, spirits bared, fears kept locked away in a safe he never wanted to crack open. His nightmares chasing his heels like sprinting stallions. Both nervous and impulsive, always moving forward and struggling not to look back. Katsuki’s threats dissolving into meaningless phrases. Izuku’s worries escalating and transforming into words of affection.

“Do you want to do this?”

Izuku frowns, confused. Katsuki is staring at him with that same unreadable intensity, that look that hypnotizes him and brings him down to an entirely new world, chains clamped around his every thought and sense.

“Do… do what?” Izuku hopes he hasn’t said the wrong thing. Katsuki only blushes.

“I…” he shakes his head, grumbling, the wry grin only telling of how exasperated and amused he must be. Izuku holds himself back from laughing at how endearing he thinks the action is, especially with being easily held under Katsuki’s mercy. “Do you want to— dammit, Izuku, I’m asking if you want to have sex.”

Oh.

Izuku flares up. Suddenly, Katsuki’s hands on him feel much heavier.

Have sex?

He stares up at Katsuki. Thinks of the countless times he’d wondered what it would be like, to completely surrender himself to someone with his body, mind and soul. The idea seemed too romantic, a thought instilled into him from a mother who wanted more than what her husband gave her. He never considered it being possible, aside from the times he’d given Katsuki relief and Katsuki had done the same for him.

“Fuck.”

Katsuki’s expression shifts from determined to anguished in seconds. Disheartened. *Embarrassed*.

No, please, don’t look like that—

Izuku grabs his forearm, steadying him.

Katsuki locks onto him, unsure.

“I do.” Izuku nods, his heart racing, a thunderclap in his ribcage. “I want to. With you, Kacchan. Katsuki. Please.” He squeezes his arm. “Only with you.”

Katsuki's dark eyes seem to glow.

"Deku, I'm not going to force you—"

"No, Kacchan, I want this." Izuku turns his head to kiss Katsuki's wrist, eyes never leaving him. "I trust you. Always have."

The visible shudder that ripples down Katsuki's frame and opens his mouth renders Izuku still.

Katsuki's pupils flicker about, running quickly from the hem of Izuku's pants, to his lips, and finally back to his eyes.

"Okay." He breathes through his nose, though the excitement is obvious. "Okay. Fuck."

Izuku splutters and laughs as Katsuki almost leaps off the bed, scrambling in the dark canvas of his room. His silhouette is enticing and amusing, the pronounced bones of his ribs and distracting, ample size to his biceps and pectorals distracting Izuku as he moves about. He huffs like a wolverine, frustrated and pulling at his hair, until he comes across something that gives Izuku pause.

He returns to the bed, the condom dangling in his teeth.

Katsuki positions himself above him, ripping open the wrapper.

Izuku swallows, transfixed with the sudden hunger that enraptures Katsuki. He's seen him like this several times, but they've never gone further than only reaching the cusp of wanting to become one.

Is that what this is…?

He's not sure. But he wants to know.

Katsuki pauses, and snarls.

"Fuck, *shit*, I'm such an idiot—"

"Kacchan?" Izuku stills. "What's wrong?"

"Fucking…" He groans. "Lube. I remembered to buy fucking condoms, *of course*, but I don't have—"

"Oh, I have some, in that box over there."

Katsuki's gobsmacked, betrayed expression makes Izuku burst into laughter.

"You little *shit*."

"Why are you so upset? Isn't this a good thing?" Izuku shrinks back into the covers as Katsuki's frustrated scowl bores into him. "Kacchan, it's not like…" he turns his head away,

embarrassment prickling under his skin. “It’s not like… I haven’t thought of this before… why else would I have lube in my bedroom?”

Katsuki stares, and then, slowly, his lips spread wide and crooked. Eyelids half-lowered and curious.

“Thought about me, Deku?”

Izuku snorts. “Who else would I think about, Kacchan?”

In an instant, Katsuki’s glare returns, mercilessly cold.

“Don’t even fucking joke about that.”

The dark, territorial edge to his voice sends a static bolt down Izuku back. Warmth settles between his legs, molten hot and liquefying.

Focus.

“Whoa, hey.” Izuku takes Katsuki’s hand and presses kisses to his knuckles. “It’s only ever been you, Kacchan. I wouldn’t do that. Would never dream of thinking of this with anyone else.”

“Hmph.” Katsuki reaches over him, his irritated mumbles only confirming that Izuku’s attempts at placating him failed. He sits back up with the small jar in hand, skimming the lid and looking over the label fo the object in awe.

Izuku gulps.

“Do you…” He hesitates. “Do you know how to…?”

“‘Course I’m fucking prepared, Deku.” Katsuki uncaps the lid.

Izuku looks away, his nerves springing to life. And still, the sight of Katsuki being so ready for this, so unabashedly prepared and eager to have him, makes him believe that it will be okay.

Katsuki’s eyes run up and down his frame. Dreadfully slow.

Izuku blushes.

“The fuck you waiting for?”

“Oh. Right.”

Izuku’s hands shake, fingers pushing down his sweatpants as quickly as possible. He can feel Katsuki watching him, the stare sending his body erupting in a burning wave.

The garment slips off of him. He throws it off the bed, staring up at the ceiling and looking anywhere else except for the boy he loves. Cold air wafts across his skin, scattering sparks

and goosebumps alike.

Katsuki's hands rest on his thighs. He squeaks.

"K-Kacchan, why—"

"You're shaking, nerd."

Izuku huffs. "I'm nervous. Aren't—aren't you? I'm…"

He doesn't have the courage to look at Katsuki's expression. Not now. Not when those strong, calloused hands, scarred and running deep with history, trace his legs and skim over the countless freckles splashed on fair, flushed skin. Tingling burns are left in his wake, running possessive trails down the lengths of his thighs until those same fingers wrap around his ankles.

Izuku gasps, instinctively reaching for anchor as Katsuki lifts his legs, testing. Izuku nods, as if reading Katsuki's mind, understanding the silent question. It's overwhelming, being this exposed, to feel the hot skin of Katsuki's waistline brushing in-between his legs.

He can feel his cock swelling up, already aching.

"*You're fucking perfect.*"

Izuku's hands tremble, one still anchored to Katsuki's bicep, but the words delight him in ways he doesn't understand. His chest feels warm and full, and still, so very nervous.

He listens to the sound of Katsuki slicking up his cock with lube. Izuku's free hand grips the bedsheets, desperate for support. He's terrified, tears threatening to burst.

Katsuki's body slides across him, their lengths brushing.

He gasps out, a burst of sensations sprawling up inside him. It's brief and agonizing, and totally foreign. His legs shake, excitement and adrenaline rushing through his body. His hands reach up and grasp onto Katsuki's back as the other boy hisses, rolling his hips experimentally. Izuku draws his bottom lip under his teeth, Katsuki's head pulled down to his ear.

Teeth sink into his neck.

Izuku moans, his back arching.

Everything feels new. As if every bone and muscle recoiled and extended for the first time under Katsuki's touch, the bare glide of his skin on his.

"I've got you," he growls out, a husk that shakes Izuku to his core. "Stay with me." He licks his lips. "Gonna—gonna make you feel so good. Make you mine."

Izuku's eyes snap open, pleasure racing between his legs. He rolls up his hips, shocking Katsuki to stiffen up and gasp out at the burst of friction.

“Show me,” he says, voice skipping like stones on a lake, “please. Please. Kacchan.”

Katsuki no longer wastes another word.

He’s a beautiful sight, crawling back and adjusting his position between Izuku’s legs, his fingers crooking and running slick with lube. Izuku watches him this time, absorbed in the idea of what’s to come, of the image of Katsuki pumping himself into him. One digit at a time, rocking him to his knees until he’s broken apart and the words are forced out of his lungs.

I want this.

Katsuki watches him, a devilish grin overtaking his lips. The crinkle around his eyes are all-knowing.

Izuku nods his consent.

Katsuki presses a finger in, then two. Izuku gasps, arching, eyes squeezing shut from the influx of pain, fear and pleasure that rocks him down to the bare bone. Katsuki shifts side to side, kissing along his thighs, sucking dark marks into the bare expanse of flesh.

Izuku almost laughs.

Even now, Katsuki wants him to know.

Mine, mine, mine.

He loves it. He craves it.

You’re mine, too. And, and I'm yours... I want it. I want that. I want you.

Katsuki’s third finger nearly shocks Izuku to tears. He mindlessly rolls his hips, seeking friction. His cock is aching, ready to be touched. He’s caught, helpless in this mind-bending pleasure that shakes him down. He wants to see Katsuki’s face, but the sensations push him to tip his head back, to feel as if he’s being forced to look away and take it all at once.

“K-Katsuki,” he moans out, legs trembling.

“Izuku, *god*, look at you…” Katsuki sounds hypnotized. “Taking me in like this already… so good. You’re so—fuck. You’re so fucking hot.”

Izuku's heart leaps.

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki crooks his fingers.

Izuku dissolves.

“Ah—Katsuki, more. Please. I can’t—just do it already, won’t you?”

I want you. Please. Make me yours.

Katsuki huffs out a dry chuckle, a confident sound that rings like music in Izuku's ears.

"Didn't think you'd be so demanding."

Katsuki grabs the underside of his thighs, and guides legs up over his shoulders. Izuku bends, wincing at the removal of Katsuki's fingers. He glances up, transfixed in the way Katsuki gazes at him, now so close, their chests brushing, hips gliding and cocks grinding in a burst of friction. Katsuki's open mouth, flushed cheeks, lashes fluttering and teeth gritting in concentration. He groans, hands bracing down beside Izuku as he angles himself.

Izuku smiles at him, wobbly.

Katsuki rolls his hips, a jerk that sends Izuku nearly screaming.

He grasps at Katsuki's back, racking with sobs. Pain and pleasure races through him at the first thrust, the feel of Katsuki's cock inside him so shocking and boundless.

"Fuck." Katsuki grits his teeth, harsh, but he doesn't release Izuku. He holds himself around him, bracketing, a cage of protection. "You're so—," he hisses, "so *tight*."

"Kacchan," Izuku gasps out.

Katsuki rocks his hips, considering. His nose brushes Izuku's collarbone, the motion of the muscles rolling in his back alluringly predatory.

Katsuki pulls out, just slightly, and rams back in.

"Izuku," he growls, his motions turning more fluid. More sensible.

The wet slap of their hips grinding and their painting, open-mouthed kisses leave them hungry and ravenous for more. The mattress squeaks under them, their voices louder and muffled under the desperate, brief moment of privacy allowed in this new home. Katsuki thrusts recklessly, endless, and growls into Izuku's ear, nibbling, biting, making sweet promises in the privacy of his half-empty room. The dark welcomes them, light filtering just barely, a drift between afternoon and evening.

Izuku's mouth opens, soundless.

He's close.

It's too much. *It's too much*.

Katsuki kisses him, open-mouthed and reckless, like a starved animal. Izuku's back arches, whimpering at the steady motions of Katsuki's cock sliding in and out of him in wet glides.

"Katsuki, Katsuki, *Katsuki*—"

"Fuck, Deku, Izuku, I'm not gonna last—"

Izuku clenches his teeth, fingers burying into Katsuki's shoulder blades. His thighs clamp tightly from around his hips, their bodies slick with sweat.

"I wanna be *yours*, Katsuki, please, ah, *don't stop*—"

Katsuki snarls, a dangerous sound. His hand finds Izuku's cock, pumping him voraciously, desperate to get him to the same level.

"This—all of you," he gasps out with each thrust, somehow growing faster. Izuku breaks into sobs and holds back a wail, biting his lip. "All of you—just for *me*."

"Just you," Izuku whispers, broken apart, "just you. Only you."

"I'm yours, too," Katsuki moans, pausing for just a moment to whisper directly into his ear, "Izuku."

Even in the middle of this moment, Izuku wants to cry.

I love you. Katsuki. I love you so much.

"Fuck, Izuku," Katsuki moans, panting, "gonna come."

Izuku gasps, an overwhelming tremor shooting through him.

He rolls his hips, chasing pleasure in Katsuki's grasp, relishing the feel of the other's body and the harsh words he growls into the open air. He keens, back bowing in an arc, hands struggling to remain focused and legs quickly growing weak and shaken as he comes.

Katsuki follows suit, thrusting one last time. He pants next to Izuku's ear, his body growing still as rock, and then boneless. Exhausted.

They both lie there, consumed in the other's quiet.

Katsuki slowly, carefully, pulls out of him. Izuku winces, clenching his teeth, and holding back a moan at the loss of contact. His eyes flutter open, catching Katsuki's profile, his silhouette unfairly gorgeous and naked against his own doorway as he throws the condom in the trash can.

He hopes his mother hasn't come back, yet.

He rolls on his side, and whimpers at the feel of Katsuki around him, arms snaking over his ribs. Feather-light kisses pressing down his neck, a smirk hidden there, curving so softly and secretly. Just for him. Only for him.

"Izuku." Katsuki kisses his temple. Izuku turns his head and smiles weakly. "You okay?"

It seems impossible, to think back to almost a year ago. Meeting a stranger on the long winding train in a dangerous district, in a city corrupt and running in tormented rivers right under their noses. He never imagined anything coming to fruition from that, from understanding the weight of knowing the volatile, angry teen. He would have never known

how gentle and protective Katsuki could be, how understanding and brave he was in the middle of anger.

He was incredibly imperfect in every way. All harsh angles and fierce lines, screams and private declarations rolled into a maelstrom of a human being.

And still, Izuku loved him.

He reaches over and intertwines their fingers.

Katsuki rests his chin on his shoulder, eyes narrowed and searching him like that of a concerned feline.

It makes him think, and he wishes it didn't.

Sometimes he wondered how long this would last. How long he would remain in Augustana, when both of them were meant to grow. Where would they be, months from now? *Years* from now?

The thought terrifies him. Wraps thorns and claws around his lungs.

“... Yeah.”

Yet, Izuku smiles, feeling full. Warm. Safe. Choosing to, with the weight of their future dangling in a thread.

Izuku presses his forehead to Katsuki's, a secret smile shared.

“Better than okay.”

Devotion

Chapter Summary

Finale.

Chapter Notes

This is it. I can't believe it, but it's here.

I will respond to every reviewer after this chapter. Thank you for being with me on this journey. I'm exhausted, and sad to see this story end, but also relieved that it managed to tie together. Thank you. Thank you. Thank you.

Please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Monday. 11:15 AM.

“It’s my understanding that this will be our last session, Izuku.”

Dr. Abrams’ kind, elderly voice is a balm on Izuku’s unconscious wounds. He sits beside him in the little garden set outside his office, the chrysanthemums and bluebells barely a distraction under the warm summer heat. He’s dressed in loose cotton and jeans today, a pressuring insistence from a mother he adores and respects, and sometimes, even fears.

The gun in Izuku’s hands turn this way and that, trembling with old memories. Fragments and pieces of his past left shoved under a carpet he couldn’t see, probing him in his nightmares only when he came into contact with it again. He shudders.

The first several weeks of recollecting those harsh, violent images—drenched in deep red and dark blue, the faces and bodies of people torn like strips of paper, the all-around walls of his innermost thoughts colored gunmetal gray—leaves him short of breath and thought.

“It needs to be,” he says, carefully nodding. “You can… you can let go of it, now. I think… I think I don’t need to use this to remember, anymore.”

Dr. Abrams smiles wanly. “That would make sense, considering even the effects of my Quirk, as powerful as it is, can be diminished and allow the user perfect clarity after a few months through extensive interaction with the object used. You’ve done well, Izuku. I’m sure Inko would be glad to hear about your progress.”

Izuku rubs at his eyes, exhausted.

“I’m not sure if she would,” he says.

A hummingbird flits low to the garden, wings flapping blindly and tiny black eyes focused on the nectar left out on top of the white fence. Izuku grins, despite the unsureness resting in his stomach.

“This was… I needed this, though.” He leans back against the bench, caught between staring at his therapist and up at the clear blue sky. “I almost didn’t want to believe it, that a Quirk of all things could somehow bind memories. And all of this, well, none of it really made sense to me. None of it seemed real or possible. And to find out everything behind a father I didn’t know existed…” his fingers curl into themselves, nails clipping skin. “It’s all a little too much, sometimes.”

Walking through the front doors of a therapist’s office rattles anyone’s nerves. This, Izuku understands, despite the desire to argue for the case of his own memories haunting him, growing richer and more detailed with each day.

Uraraka hardly understood whenever the topic becomes apparent in conversation, usually in the middle of their planning for college fairs and presenting their newspaper articles to higher conglomerates. She always spoke to him wistfully, with sympathy and harmony, two attributes he’s always associated with her. The way she holds his hand and guides him through his troubles and offers advice found in places of wisdom far beyond her years helped unwind the tension in Izuku’s gut, though only slightly.

And Katsuki…

He smiles behind his hand, a youthful warmth rising from his toes to his ears.

“You’re doing it again,” says Dr. Abrams, with a knowing grin.

“Huh?” Izuku snaps out of his daydreaming, bashfully scratching his cheek. “I—what do you mean? I wasn’t—I’m sorry, I was zoning out again. Probably muttering, right? Ah. I’m sorry. That happens sometimes and I really hate it when I do it during our sessions. I swear it’s completely unintentional and not at all meant to segue from this—”

“Relax, Izuku.” Dr. Abrams shakes his head, a chuckle permeating the comfortable air. “Young love is bold, and bright. You should hold onto it before you’re put into scenarios that won’t be completely under your control.” His smile is weathered by age and wisdom, though Izuku wonders how many of those wrinkles are borne of past demons as well. “I have a good feeling about that boy, even though he’s a bit…”

Izuku laughs, unable to stop his blush. “He can be a bit much. Kind of loud. And angry. But he’s,” he smiles softly, “he’s amazing.”

Dr. Abrams nods, fingers interwoven. “Has he been a great help with you recovering from the events over the last few months?”

Izuku’s phone buzzes in his pocket. He grins.

Speak of the devil.

“Yes,” he says, a gentle murmur in the peaceful summer day, “he really has.”

Tuesday. 8:20 AM.

“Why, the fuck,” groans Katsuki, tying the knot of his apron in the small of his back, “do we have to make two fucking cakes? Doesn’t Icy Hot already have a trust fund of his own or some shit? He could waltz into a bakery and buy them all out for his pretentious taste buds.”

Izuku resists rolling his eyes. “Kacchan, it’s for his dad’s commemoration announcement. Becoming governor is a huge deal! So it’s good to make as much as possible for Todoroki too.”

“Whatever,” says Katsuki, “one cake is enough. Fucking moochers…”

“You like baking, though,” says Izuku, grinning cheekily. “And think of it this way; you get to have me as your assistant!” Katsuki snorts, unimpressed, though wisely choosing to stay quiet instead of insulting him for his apparent lack of ability in the kitchen.

Izuku shakes his head and turns back to his bowl, stirring sugar into the next batch of flour.

He glances up, pauses, and grins with an idea. He stops stirring, and with sudden determination, grabs a handful of flour from Katsuki’s bowl and flicks it at his nose. Katsuki sends him a sharp glare, and without breaking eye contact, grabs the tub of frosting and hurls

a dollop at Izuku's face. Izuku squeaks, ducking with only seconds to spare, before popping back up and breaking into laughter.

Izuku scrambles and turns to fling more flour, only for Katsuki to grab his wrists and wring them behind his back. He giggles, back pressed to the counter and hands brought back down to his front, both clenched in one of Katsuki's powerful grip. Katsuki's livid expression morphs into a teasing grin, smirk curved and dangerous.

"Kacchan," Izuku mutters, tilting his head, "are you *distracted*?"

"Hm." Katsuki's pupils flicker about, from the frosting smudged on Izuku's cheek to his flirtatious grin. His left hand slides down Izuku's back and cups his rear, pressing him closer against him. "Wonder who's fault that is," he breathes, a husky growl that sends shivers down Izuku's spine.

"Couldn't help it," Izuku says, a giggle bubbling up, infectious and colorful. He sidles off to the side, peeling his trapped wrists out of Katsuki's grasp and removing his other hand off his jeans. "I could always leave—"

Katsuki kisses him. Izuku grins in delight, wrapping his arms around his neck and returning it fully, lips and tongue clashing in an eager mess. Blood rushes through him, heart beating wildly under his chest—giddiness and excitement twirling and flourishing throughout his body. Katsuki grabs his waist and hoists him up onto the counter, drawing out a squeak.

"Kacchan—"

"Calm down," says Katsuki, lost in a lustful haze, "got you, 'kay?"

"Okay," says Izuku, and pulls Katsuki back into a kiss. Katsuki moans at the attention, hands everywhere on Izuku's body, smoothing down his arms, shoulders, thighs, and greedily carving lines through the fabric of his shirt.

Katsuki then is abruptly pulled from Izuku's arms, into the merciless, angry gasp of Mitsuki Bakugou.

"What the fuck—"

Mitsuki smacks him in the back of the head.

"Unbelievable! Katsuki Bakugou, how dare you canoodle with your boyfriend on Inko's brand new kitchen counter? What kind of fucking voyeur are you?" She continues slapping him, harmless little bats that send Katsuki screeching and swinging his fists, despite behind held back and a little off his toes by the collar of his shirt.

Izuku is frozen, mortified and unbearably flustered.

"M-Mrs. Bakugou—"

"And *you*!"

Izuku squeaks, and blinks down at his swatted hand. He blinks at Mitsuki, who huffs and releases Katsuki, her hands placed on her hips.

“You should know better! I trust you to keep my bratty son in line but the two of you are just as hormonally imbalanced as the next goddamn teenager. Ugh, can’t get a break from this, even now. Masaru! Are you coming anytime soon? We’ve got to get a move on with this!”

Izuku’s head spins. He glances at his boyfriend, then Mitsuki. Once her words register, however, Izuku finds it in himself to somewhat calm the incessant storm rising in his heart.

He turns his attention over to the door, where Masaru strolls inside with several gift baskets under his arm.

“Did you even get the cake ready? This stupid event is in less than three hours!”

“Yes, crazy old hag! I already made the first fucking cake!” Katsuki rolls his eyes, rubbing down his sore neck and coming back over to Izuku’s side. They share a sideways glance, careful to avoid Mitsuki’s furious stare.

“Well, get to finishing it, then.” Mitsuki brushes down her blouse. “God, need to get out of here and just get this whole event over with…”

“Ah, dear, need you take a few deep breaths, alright?” Masaru says, finishing tying the bow on the first gift basket. “Besides, we still have plenty of time before even Inko is ready with the rest of the food. It will all turn out fine.”

“Your mom seems to hate this event even more than you do,” says Izuku, still seated on the counter and whispering to Katsuki. Katsuki snorts, leaning further back against the tiles and folding his arms. “It won’t… take too long to finish the next cake, right?”

“Don’t worry about it, Deku.” Katsuki shrugs. “Not a big deal.”

Izuku kisses his temple, grinning at Katsuki’s surprised growl and apparent blush.

“Okay.”

Tuesday. 1:01 PM.

The Todoroki mansion was, to Izuku’s lack of surprise, immaculate in every way.

Tall pillars holding up thick-paneled windows and decorative statues lining the sills. The glimmer of diamond chandeliers hanging from the ceiling, with elaborate tables draped in clean white cloth stretched out on multiple sides of the room. Men and women alike dressed in gowns and sharply cut suits, the clatter of wine glasses and champagne flutes drawing lingering eyes to wary targets.

Izuku gulps, fingers playing with his collar. He's dressed in a dark green collared shirt with a long black tie, rumpled and horribly assembled from his hasty exit from his apartment. His hair is wrung through with coconut-scented spray, and the smell causes his nose to wrinkle up in uncertainty. He refuses the urge to touch his hair, shifting back and forth in his slacks and already dreading the bruises and blisters that will form due to these new loafers—

"You're mumbling, nerd." Katsuki sidles up beside him, and Izuku's mouth dries up.

"Kacchan." He swallows, eyes nearly popping out of his skull. The tray of cupcakes in his arms trembles in his grip. "You look *amazing*."

Katsuki smirks, puffing out his chest. He does look incredible, with the bright silver-blue shirt that brings out the sharp auburn color in his eyes, the buttons opened near the top and leaving a clear view of his angled collarbones. His slacks and shoes match Izuku perfectly, the fabric of his pants hugging every curve and muscle. Their coordination was mostly due to their mothers hounding them in the middle of the shopping center and struggling to decide on what combination they wanted for their sons.

Sons who happened to be dating, and—in the privacy of Izuku and Katsuki's conversation—in love.

"Obviously," says Katsuki. He looks Izuku up and down slowly, a satisfied curve of a grin resting in the corner of his mouth. Izuku shifts under his stare, fingers twitching. "Come on," Katsuki says, turning to scowl through the dreadful throng of fancily dressed and eagerly chattering people, "let's get this over with."

Izuku nods, and blinks down at Katsuki quickly interlacing their fingers.

His heart stutters and picks up.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

"W-We, um," Izuku rolls his eyes at his own stammering, "we should find Todoroki."

"Gotta set the food somewhere first." Katsuki glares at the long, stretched table. "Fuck. What the hell. Who eats this many sweets? Does that bastard even eat sugary things?"

"Kacchan, you probably shouldn't call him a bastard at his own party."

"It's not his party. It's his old man's. I can say whatever the fuck I want."

Izuku looks back toward the door.

"Where do you think our parents are?"

Katsuki shrugs. “Dunno.”

"Weren't they behind us?"

"No, they left after we did."

Izuku almost asks another question, but then brightens, coming over to an empty space on the table and setting down the tray of cupcakes. He pulls back the plastic wrapping and bundles it in his hands, the aroma of vanilla and cinnamon spices spiraling into the air. The purple frosting, cinnamon-chocolate base and flamethrower-shaped sugar decals accent the treats perfectly.

“Fucking best treats on this whole shitty table,” says Katsuki.

“Of course they are.” Izuku turns to smile at him. “They’re wonderful, Kacchan. Do you have the other cake?”

“Does it look like I do?” Katsuki folds out his empty pockets. “Your mom’s got it.”

“Oh.”

Katsuki glances past Izuku’s shoulder, and gives a stiff nod. Izuku tilts his head questioningly.

“Hi, Midoriya.”

Izuku whips around, and beams at Todoroki, who grins tinily in return and nods his head. Izuku pulls him into a broad hug, laughing at the way Todoroki’s arms hover around him, unsure of where to place his hands. Then, he swallows, setting for placing one hand on Izuku’s back and patting the area reassuringly.

“Watch your hands, Half N’ Half,” Katsuki drolls, popping a spiced cherry into his mouth.

Izuku pulls back, assessing his friend from head to toe.

“You look great, Todoroki!”

“Ah, well,” Todoroki flushes slightly, swallowing. “Thank you. You do, as well.” He dips his head in Katsuki’s direction. “Bakugou. It’s good to see you.”

“Sure,” says Katsuki, stiff as an iron pole.

Izuku rolls his eyes. “Kacchan, you guys took down a train and helped restore order back to Augustana together. The least you could do is say a proper hello.”

“*Hah*?” Katsuki glares at him and flicks his middle finger. “Fuck you, Deku. I do whatever the hell I want.”

“So charming.” Todoroki shrugs. “It’s no problem to me, Midoriya. It’s good to see you both here.”

“Congratulations, by the way.” Izuku can hardly contain the admiration bubbling up in his chest, the need to hug Todoroki again and bounce back and forth in appreciation nearly claiming him. “That’s so amazing about your father! If anyone can handle being Augustana’s first governor in… well, decades, it would be him.”

Todoroki smiles softly at this. “Yes, well, he’s a bit… of a traditionalist with certain things. He’s more experienced with politics and handling massive change. I think it might be a good start.” He shrugs, and reaches over to grab a small plastic cub of juice from the table. “We haven’t been on the best terms.”

Izuku blinks, a sinking weight in the pit of his stomach.

“Oh… I’m—I’m sorry to hear that.”

“Don’t be.” Todoroki stares into his cup, one hand hanging off the pocket of his dark gray slacks. “It’s a work in progress. I learn as much as I can while sitting in his shadow, and take the opportunities when given. It’s good that Yuuei is willing to take some of his accommodations, and with the change in patrolling hours and the shifts taking place, it’ll get better in a few months or so.” He smirks behind a sip of his drink. “And don’t even get me started on the train…”

“It’ll be repaired soon.” Izuku nods vigorously.

Katsuki slinks up behind him and drapes an arm over his shoulder, his gaze menacing and hard as steel.

“You two losers done?”

Todoroki snorts. “You’re a bit paranoid.”

Katsuki straightens, teeth bared. “Say that again, Candy Cane.”

“Not sure if I need to.”

Izuku rests one hand on Katsuki’s fingers, which have grown tighter around his shoulder.

“Kacchan.”

Katsuki tilts his chin high, and drops that same hand down to Izuku’s waist, pulling him closer. Izuku flushes, the embarrassment stemming even higher at the way Todoroki’s eyebrows rise.

“We made one fucking cake, vanilla and buttercream. The cupcakes are cinnamon with fucking decorative sugar decals because Bakugous don’t half-ass shit. That good enough for you, you piece of fool’s gold shit?”

Todoroki blinks.

Izuku stares at Katsuki as if he’s grown another head.

“Catch you never.”

Izuku frowns, nearly tripping over himself at Katsuki pushing him through the crowd. He squeaks and apologizes to multiple people, stepping on the tailings of gowns and suits alike. His heart rapidly squirms under his ribs, calling attention to the straightforward gait to Katsuki’s stride.

“Kacchan, where are we going?”

“You’ll see.”

The mansion truly is enormous, Izuku muses, the further he is guided through the long, winding hallway that juts out from the main room. The chandeliers fade into fine portraits hung up on the walls, some showcasing the Todoroki family—men and women with long and short red, flaming hair, and one in particular with a beautiful silver-haired woman—and other ancient figurines that Izuku hopes to be allies.

He’s shocked out of his observations when he’s pinned against the wall, Katsuki’s hands on his collar and his lips slammed onto his. The surprise recedes only seconds later, with Izuku splayed against the wall and unsure of Katsuki’s mouth on his, completely at mercy to his aggressive movements.

Katsuki pulls away, lips swollen red. Izuku swallows.

“K-Kacchan…? What was—what was that for?”

Katsuki presses himself flush against Izuku’s body, both hands greedily reaching down to find his rear and squeezing him through his slacks. Izuku groans, head tilting back against the wall, a shiver racing down his spine.

“*Want you*,” he growls, teeth latching onto Izuku’s earlobe. “Can’t keep me away, not when you’re dressed like *that*.”

Izuku, through his sudden flaring of lust, huffs out a laugh. “Y-You’re doing this because of my *clothes*?”

Katsuki mouths at his neck, lips tracing up his throat and teeth tugging on his bottom lip. He releases him with a *pop*, pupils blown wide and gaze volcanic with *hunger*.

“Obviously.”

An explosion of heat sweeps down and curls in Izuku’s groin.

Oh.

“Come on, *Izuku*.” Katsuki’s grin is a devilish curve, releasing him and placing one hand on the side of Izuku’s head. He looks positively dangerous, his knee brushing in-between Izuku’s legs, his chest so close, eyes searching him for his secrets, and Izuku is already swimming in anticipation. “Let’s ditch.”

Izuku opens and closes his mouth, skin hot to the touch.

“You’re…” He gulps. “Are you asking to…?”

Katsuki smirks with malicious intent. “Asshole’s got a pretty spacious bathroom.”

The words make Izuku throb with anticipation. Sweat beads in his palms, his very coherent thought suddenly running to a halt. He glances over Katsuki’s positioned arm, to the still-gathering group honoring the former professional hero’s announcement, and he wonders if their parents have arrived yet…

It was a terrible idea. Awful. Completely unbecoming.

But Katsuki, well…

Izuku wants to kick himself in the shins to stop him from tackling Katsuki in this very moment because this boy renders him weaker than a windswept tumbleweed.

His green eyes flash, allowing his eyes to travel from Katsuki’s shoes, to the enticing open triangle of his shirt, to the blazing dark eyes he loves so dearly.

“Alright, Kacchan,” he says, grinning, “show me.”

Katsuki brightens, smile stretched wide, toothy and gleeful.

“Oh, hell yeah.”

Tuesday. 1:23 PM.

“Ah—K-Kacchan—”

“Don’t be so loud, nerd,” growls Katsuki, his hips slamming into him in a rhythmic, ruthless pace. “You like it like this, huh, Deku?” He bites his bottom lip, his pants rushing out, hot fumes fogging up the glass window behind Izuku. “So easy for me.”

His teeth are by Izuku’s ear, their shirts disheveled beyond measure and slacks pulled down to their ankles. It had taken two steps into the bathroom suite before Katsuki lost his patience

and ripped the buttons and tie off of Izuku, charging in with full crimson energy and the scarring desire to mark and claim and *fuck.*

The sensation is fierce and fiery hot, scorching Izuku from the inside out and making him gasp out in a shockwave of pleasure.

Katsuki moans at the sound, hands pulling Izuku even closer to him, legs splayed out around his waist and ankles trembling. “Want them all to hear, yeah? Want them to know how loud you really are? Goody two-shoes, shacking it with a *Bakugou*. Fuck.”

He thrusts hard enough for Izuku to lose his balance, his hands splaying out and desperately slapping against the wall. It vibrates under the impact. He gapes, open-mouthed toward the ceiling with each ram of Katsuki’s body against his.

“Katsuki, ah, that’s amazing, you’re *amazing*, please, harder, *more*—”

“Fuck, love it when you talk,” he grunts, “drives me wild, Izuku.” Katsuki sinks his teeth into his shoulder, sucking dark bruises into his shoulder. He licks his lips, wanting to pepper that freckled flesh with constant reminders that he was there, that Izuku is his. The thought alone pushes him into a tangled greed, wishing he could ask for more than he already has. “Gonna make you scream my name, Deku, make everyone *know*.”

“Yes, Katsuki, yes, always. Always yours.”

Katsuki almost comes at the broken honesty in Izuku’s voice, the way he shakes around him and yet clenches with every ounce of his strength.

His grip is fierce around the backs of Izuku’s thighs, sure to leave handprints. Marks he wants to see in a shower together, where the skin is left bare for him to witness and he’s allowed to finger Izuku until he winds apart and comes with his name on his lips.

In only a couple of months since their first time, sex has grown as a new form of communication between them. One he relishes and craves, and sometimes, unable to stop. Not when Izuku dresses like he’s worth a million dollars, laughing and burning brighter than a summertime peach and pulling Shouto Todoroki into a hug, of all fucking people. Not when he looks at him shyly, as if torn between touching him and kissing him, only to be pulled into his desires when Katsuki becomes the first to initiate. It’s a secret span of language that controls Katsuki’s urges and, dare he ever say it aloud, love, for this boy, and everything that cradles him.

The thought prickles Katsuki’s nerves. He grits his teeth, and slams hard enough into Izuku to make him shake, stutter, and moan. He smirks into his shoulder, adrenaline coursing through him, sweat and musk building in a heated temperature that he doesn’t wish to smother down.

Izuku, even through his body shaking and being jerked back and forth from Katsuki’s weight, reaches and paws at his rumpled shirt. He leans up, kissing him, stealing the hungry words from Katsuki’s mouth before anything can escape that rattles the moment. Katsuki rolls his shoulders back, his hands sliding from Izuku’s thighs to his waist. He pulls him off the

counter, turns around, and rams him into the wall. The impact shakes the decorative painting parallel to them.

Izuku laughs, legs wrapped around Katsuki's waist and eyes glowing green with untamed light.

"Animal," he teases, his toothy smile brighter than pearls.

"Yeah?" Katsuki growls, and rocks his hips in another rhythm. Slower, but mightier. He's not going to last long doing this, but it will be worth it; he knows it will. "Behave, *Deku*."

Katsuki supports him with a strain in his biceps, muscles bulging to support the both of them against the wall. A deep, petty part of him hopes Todoroki—that fucking asshole, always scoping Izuku from head to toe as if he has some *chance*—hears. Hears, and memorizes the sound of Izuku screaming Katsuki's name and moaning as if it's the first and last time they will have sex.

"Close, Katsuki," Izuku whimpers, mouth open and hands fiercely anchored into Katsuki's back. Katsuki loves the pressure of his nails, the patterns Izuku rakes down him through any barrier. "Close, ah, come on, get me there—"

"I've got you, Deku," he moves impossibly close, slamming his mouth onto Izuku's and absorbing his pleasured noises, their bodies slick with sweat under their remaining layers. He locks eyes with Izuku, reading the intensity in there, the dazed look that shakes Katsuki to the bone and transforms his mind into a whirlpool. "I've got you, always."

"I love you," Izuku gasps, his entire body clenching on Katsuki's cock, his voice rising to a trembling squeak with Katsuki's hand around his own length, pumping him, pushing him over the edge. "Love you, ah, *Katsuki*."

"Fucking, Izuku—" Katsuki growls, slamming into him one last time, thighs quivering from the effort. He lowers them, near-collapsing to the fine polished tiles. Izuku peels off of him, both exhausted and leaning back against the wall, their naked legs stretched out and motionless.

The lightbulbs blink above them, made of diamonds and fine rose gold. Porcelain and marble blink back at them. Katsuki's eyes flutter shut, lips slightly parting and curving into a smile. Pure bliss flows through him, a familiar surge of delight and understanding that takes hold of him in the aftermath of having Izuku, and Izuku having him in return.

Izuku's hand slides over, intertwining their fingers.

Katsuki, eyes still closed, snickers.

"Sap."

"Say it back, Kacchan," Izuku says, a hopeful cheer in his tone. His voice is hoarse, scratched through with pleasure and tiredness. Katsuki wishes he could deny how addicted he is to the sound.

“Dunno what you’re talking about.”

Izuku kicks him.

“Ow.”

“That didn’t hurt.” Izuku giggles, drunk off sex, or maybe even Katsuki himself. Sometimes he’s not sure what the difference is, at least when he has Izuku brought down to this state. “We just… wow, we actually fucked in Shouto Todoroki’s master bathroom.”

“We sure did.” Katsuki smirks. Then, his brow pinches in the middle, eyes opening and slowly turning to drink in Izuku’s profile. “… Did you just say *fuck*?”

“Mm, I’ve said it before.” Izuku turns to face him, his face still flushed, freckles smeared in the glow of the crystal lightbulbs over their heads. “Usually during sex, but, you know. It can happen afterwards. The afterglow. Or whatever it’s called. Post-orgasm?”

Katsuki places his hand over Izuku’s face.

“Kacchan?” he mutters behind his hand, swatting at him.

“Exhausted. Jesus.” Katsuki groans. “We have to clean up before someone finds us here.”

“Oh… oh no, Kacchan. What if they *heard*?” Izuku bolts up, scrambling to fix his slacks and trying to find the buttons Katsuki recklessly yanked off with his own hands within seconds of wandering into the room.

Katsuki scopes out Izuku’s bare backside for a brief moment before his boyfriend readjusts and shimmies into his pants, fumbling and frantic.

“They probably did,” he clicks his tongue, “since you’re a screamer.”

“Not now, Kacchan!” Izuku glares at him over his shoulder, and flushes. “S-Stop staring and at least get dressed! Oh no, I can’t believe we just did this. I’m the worst person alive. No, wait, scratch that. I’m the worst *friend ever*. Todoroki would be so mortified if he ever found out. Ah, and we were supposed to come and celebrate Todoroki and his father’s commencement—”

“We’re still technically here, nerd. Chill the fuck out.” Katsuki stands up, pulling up his pants as well and tucking his sweaty shirt underneath and past the belt. “This won’t be hard to clean up.”

“I feel gross.” Izuku sighs, shoulders slumping. “And… sore. Already. Ouch.”

“*That didn’t hurt*,” Katsuki mocks, imitating Izuku’s higher pitch. He grins at the ferocious glare Izuku sends his way, which, with the frustrated frown and blushing cheeks, looks anything but threatening.

“Kacchan, be serious.”

“Oh, we were serious.”

“Be *actually* serious.” Izuku crosses his arms. “We’re lucky that no one found us here… how did you even know that it was going to be available? Or that it even *existed*?”

Katsuki shrugs, adjusting his collar. “When Round Face and I came here to meet with him about your article, I found it. Was pissed off at how nice it was and wanted to fuck it all up. Breaking a soap dispenser didn’t really work, though.”

Izuku’s eyebrows raise. “You… you didn’t actually break his soap dispensers, did you?”

“One.” Katsuki’s lips twitch. “Fucker obviously had a spare.”

“*Kacchan*.” Izuku shakes his head, though his smile is small and fond. “You’re terrible.”

Katsuki grins, eyeing Izuku up and down shamelessly.

“Yep.”

Tuesday. 3:15 PM.

The announcement leads to an uproarious applause on the live telecast.

The television blares with an explosion of color. The familiar sight of Enji Todoroki’s powerful figure stepping up onto the podium in front of Augustana’s City Hall sparks a wave of celebration in the remaining small crowd watching the announcement in the Midoriya residence.

Of course the Midoriyas would insist on having a small afterparty in their tiny establishment, though with the rushed momentum of Katsuki’s time together with Izuku in Todoroki’s mansion—much to the knowing chagrin of their mothers—he can hardly find a reason to complain. He’s unable to breach the anticipated joy sweeping across the small gathering of guests, most of whom from MItsuki and Inko’s connections, and none of them striking Katsuki as familiar faces.

Enji’s presence exudes strength and fortitude even through the small television screen. His Quirk is momentarily receded, licking flames held back to expose the natural red color to his hair and beard. Frosty blue eyes scan the growing crowd outside the City Hall.

“We will be making a change in Augustana, together,” he says. His voice booms effortlessly, carrying in a sonic wave over the assembled onslaught of people. “The events over the last few months have created a reasonable shift of concern from our government. The patrolling and tolling systems will be redacted indefinitely, citing a complete change for not only the residents of Sommartyn District, but for our friends in Illenova, Redmond and Isabori.”

Another rise of applause claps like thunder.

“He’s really doing it,” says Izuku, eyes bright and wide with awe. “I can’t believe it. Todoroki… he must have somehow convinced him to go through with it.”

“Was a fucked up system anyway, flawed to the bone.” Katsuki nods. “Not too surprising.”

Enji holds up his hand, effectively silencing the excited chatter. He looms like a heavy shadow, fire and brimstone curling around his presence in a thick cloak.

“There have been recent elements of the incident that destroyed the transportation system that makes Augustana a notable place to visit.” He flips through a stack of documents set in front of him on the podium, his angled expression impossible to read. “My son, Shouto Todoroki, enacted a victorious and potentially reckless plan that led to all two hundred and fifty-one passengers on the train to be rescued indefinitely. He acted with great precision, fortitude, intelligence, and a notable call to action that brings pride to the Todoroki name.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. He wouldn’t deny Todoroki’s incredible qualities. If heroes were still permitted to act publicly, he was almost positive that Todoroki would be a mighty presence to combat, even if the thought alone grates him in a painful way.

Izuku has gone silent, focused on the telecast with unbridled optimism. He’s nearly shaking, hand gripping Katsuki’s tightly, squeezing him in reassurance.

“However,” says Enji, with a heavy air of confusion drifting about him, “there were actions taken that my son has brought to my attention that were not originally aired in the tabloids. It is due to the actions of one Katsuki Bakugou—”

Katsuki’s eyes bolt wide. His mother drops her wineglass.

“—and the incredible sharpshooting precision of Inko Midoriya, the courageous actions of Izuku Midoriya, and the overall plan constructed to take down the corrupt rebelling Illenova squadron that led to the defeat of Hisashi Midoriya. This man has been removed from Augustana indefinitely due to the heroic display of talent from these individuals, and far more. In future newspaper coverage, I will make sure that my son’s name is included with the acknowledgement that he was working alongside people who do not deserve to be slandered any longer. The Bakugous have become our allies, and were important staples in reversing the corruption underlying our streets.”

Katsuki’s blood roars in his ears. He processes each word, the gasps of shock and mild understanding that flow through the crowd around the City Hall, and the dropped jaws of their surrounding parents igniting a sensation of electric fire and smoke through his veins.

“Holy shit,” whispers Mitsuki.

Katsuki swallows, and echoes his mother’s statement by the thousandfold.

“To close on this matter,” continues Enji, “it should be noted that the victim of this entire scheme, Izuku Midoriya, had attempted to bring positive attention to the Bakugous by way of his exceptionally written article submitted to me anonymously. I was unaware that a high school student, and the victim of a kidnapping and ransom deal, no less, was able to aid underground officials in uncovering the roots of Hisashi’s heinous plans. Much appreciation should be given to the Midoriyas who are, as of today, in no way related to the despicable villainous actions brought out by Hisashi.” He stands tall, head high. “I will see to it personally that Izuku Midoriya is offered compensation for his incredible efforts, and that the Bakugous will be admitted into a higher status as their vigilantism spreads in the protective plan behind Augustana.”

He closes his speech soon after, though none of it matters to Katsuki. He is barely able to process the reality of what’s just happened, and what just came out of Enji Todoroki’s mouth.

“Oh my god…” Izuku whispers, awestruck. “That… he just…”

“… We fucked in his master bathroom. Holy shit.”

Izuku snorts, bursting into laughter. He pulls Katsuki in, hands cupping his face, and lips smashing onto his for a breathtaking kiss that draws a gasp out of Katsuki’s mouth. He smiles into it, wrapping his arms around Katsuki’s neck and pressing his forehead against his. His touch is warm and stable, carrying him through it all.

When Izuku holds him like this, he remembers too little and too much all at once. Their incredible first escape from becoming potential hostages, their separation under the weight of Izuku’s own father attempting to tear them apart, the destruction of Augustana’s tram system, and waking up in the hospital with the disintegrating hope that Izuku somehow never made it out alive.

“… Are you crying?”

“S-Shut up,” Izuku mutters, stepping back to wipe at his eyes. “Kacchan, this is so—ah, so amazing. W-we were just, publicly—my article—you were—it’s too much. I can’t believe this. What an honor this is. Why didn’t we go to the City Hall to see his speech live?”

Katsuki shakes his head. “Nerd.”

“We’ve been dating for almost eight months and that’s still your response to almost every single time I cry. It’s getting a little old, Kacchan.” Izuku giggles despite his words, close to hiccuping and entering another round of tears. “We’re so lucky. I’m so…” He finds Katsuki’s gaze, smile small and yet, so genuine and kind, so prepared and ready to send Katsuki’s heart stuttering. “I love you.”

Katsuki blushes, and turns away. His sweaty hand grips Izuku’s tighter.

“Yeah,” he whispers, still watching the television in disbelief, “you too.”

Tuesday. 7:00 PM.

Hours pass.

The sound of people laughing and chattering in the small, cramped space of Inko Midoriya’s apartment levels out the knotting in Katsuki’s chest. Tentative jazz music rumbles through the little area, borne from the lone speaker propped by the doorway and shifting between artists that belt impressive notes and transform into saxophone masters. The non-alcoholic beverages lined up on the counters clink with ice cubes and carbonation, though none of them entice Katsuki’s taste buds the way he wishes.

“Any reason you’re sulking in the corner?”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. “Got nothing better to do than bother me, Round Face?”

Uraraka giggles, a whimsical glint in her doe-brown eyes. She’s dressed in a flared leather skirt and a red silk turtleneck, an odd combination in this hot summer weather, though Katsuki would be lying to himself if he didn’t think she looked decent. Her hair is swept up in a bobby-pinned fray of braids and curls, her face dusted in a light layer of makeup.

“It’s good being here with everything going right for once, you know?” She sips from her glass, the bubbles momentarily distracting Katsuki. “I just didn’t expect to see you here all alone. Not when ‘Zuku is over there, socializing.”

“None of your business.” He pauses. “Needed some breathing room.”

Katsuki shrugs one shoulder, though the lie is slightly bitter on his tongue. He locks onto Izuku, who is laughing and talking loudly with other guests to the small gathering that his mother specifically planned for after Mr. Todoroki’s fanciful event. He’s practically shining from all angles, absorbed in the light atmosphere, in the promise of something great to come, and the relaxation seemed impossible or Katsuki to approach without crossing a border.

“You belong in that group, even if you don’t think so,” says Uraraka.

Katsuki twitches, ears burning pink. “Shut up.”

“I know that’s what you were thinking. You’re not nearly as hard to read as you think you are.” She chuckles behind her glass, eyelashes fluttering. “You’re a softie.”

“Shut. Up.” He grabs a nearby glass and tilts his head back, forcing the sparking beverage down his throat in heavy gulps. The carbonation is a little flat, and hardly rests after he’s finished. “Don’t need your bullshit opinions. Doesn’t mean shit to me.”

“Aw, you like me, Bakugou.” She bumps him with her hip. “You know you do.”

“Leave before I rip your tongue out.”

“Charming. But you won’t.” She winks. “I’m Izuku’s best friend.”

Katsuki crosses his arms. “Means jack shit.”

“Sure it does.”

Despite Katsuki’s expectations, Uraraka remains at his side. She jokes and laughs while he simpers in total silence, the music and lively chatter drowning out his conflicting thoughts. Every now and then his hands slip back into his pockets and return to folding over his chest, seeking anchor in the middle of this small, albeit claustrophobic, gathering.

“I know that you don’t go to Yuuei, and clearly your parents aren’t a couple of gangster lords that most of us thought before we even got to know you. And wow, that speech just now from Governor Todoroki sure cleared a lot for you,” Uraraka says with a light laugh, “but… it does make me wonder. What do you do? Are you homeschooled?”

Katsuki frowns, the bridge of his nose wrinkling in suspicion. “Why does it matter?”

“Just curious.” She tilts her head. “I’m a journalist. Investigating, asking questions, exploring new ideas and identities… it’s part of the job description.” She grins. “I’m sure you understand, given you’re dating the most shameless nerd in Augustana.”

Katsuki bites the inside of his cheek.

“Touché.” He considers her question, mulling over the details of his youth. “Been homeschooled since I could learn how to talk. We’re from Russia, and the education system is a little different from where we’re from. Our accents have changed a little and we’ve blended in with what Augustana has to offer, but enrolling me in a public or private institution didn’t seem like the right choice to make.”

As if sensing his stare, Izuku turns in the middle of his conversation with his mother to smile at him. It would seem so innocent and ever-blinding, if it wasn’t so close to the Izuku that fights and bends under his will until both are brought to a breaking point.

He nods his head, and Izuku tilts his head, as if to ask a silent question of concern.

Katsuki waves his arm. Izuku frowns, but carries on nonetheless.

“That would make sense.” Uraraka taps her chin, thoughtful. “But what are you going to do now?”

Katsuki finally turns to acknowledge her, eyes narrowed. “The fuck’re you talking about?”

“What do you think?” Uraraka stirs a spoon into her glass, the ice quickly melting. “Izuku wants to be the best journalist around. He wants to bring heroes back into the spotlight. We’re going to be participating in college fairs soon.”

She gestures to Izuku, who is attempting to twirl his mother in the middle of their living room, the haunted look in his eyes from two months ago fading in an instant. This, Katsuki is glad for, even when Uraraka’s words truly sink in.

“I don’t…” He clamps his jaw shut, fingers curling into his palms. Nervousness wrings out his confidence, drilling him with questions he never considered asking. “We haven’t talked about it.”

“… You might want to.” Uraraka hesitates, guilt evident in her tone. Katsuki can’t afford to look at her, not when his frustration seems aimless. “He’s been thinking about it a lot. I know that he’s not planning on staying in Augustana. I…” she trails off, nibbling on her bottom lip. “Bakugou—Katsuki, I’m sorry. I didn’t… I thought you already talked about it with him. Please don’t be angry at him. He’s just been tossing around ideas—”

“I don’t care.” Katsuki watches Izuku, teeth gritting. “Doesn’t matter.”

Don’t get angry. Don’t get angry.

Was Izuku planning on talking to him about it anytime soon?

Of course he fucking was.

But the doubts remain.

Thursday. 3:15 PM.

The smell of lavender and lemongrass soaks the clean living room, a fragrant mist that comforts and assures anyone who passes through. Izuku wipes his sweaty forehead, placing his hands on his hips and removing the protective rubber gloves soon after. His fingers are dry and pruned from handling cleaning spray the entire morning.

“Any progress in the living room, Izuku?”

“Just finished with the coffee table, Mom!” Izuku shouts back, sighing in relief. It was exhausting, cleaning after an entire group of people he’d never met in his life, combined with a very small handful of people he treasured far more than his own ambitions.

Sleep was almost impossible with the announcement from the newly appointed governor ringing in his skull. He'd wanted to speak to Katsuki more about it, to ask his opinion on being named directly in the middle of his commencement speech.

But towards the end of the night, Katsuki had grown quieter. More distant.

I'll call him soon.

"Oh, that reminds me." Inko peers around the corner of the adjacent kitchen, an apron tied around her waist and her own bottle of cleaning spray held tightly in her left hand. "Izuku, Katsuki called to ask if he could come over today. I'm sure you already know that, but I'd thought I'd let you know in case it was something you forgot."

Izuku blinks, a sinking weight crawling in his stomach. Katsuki usually texted him or called him first before showing up at their apartment, or even instigating a time to talk or spend time together.

"Ah, yeah, of course." He shrugs. "He didn't tell me anything, though. Did he say why?"

Inko tilts her head. "Well I would assume it's so he can see you. There are a lot of changes happening lately, you know."

"Yeah…" Izuku scratches his neck.

Why didn't he call me first…?

"Izu?"

"Ah, sorry." He smiles softly. "It's all okay, Mom. I'm just tired."

His response doesn't relax his mother, but she nods nonetheless. She carries on with her cleaning, not even bothering to ask him about his progress with the rest of the apartment after the cramped arrangement of guests the previous night.

Izuku stirs in his worries until he's able to gather time to himself. He changes into jeans and a bright orange T-shirt, opting for something without his favorite hero's cartoon face imprinted on the front. He scans his room, still unfamiliar with the larger space and his innumerable amount of posters not yet plastered over the surface of each wall.

With a shaking hand, he pulls out his phone, and dials Katsuki's number, pressing it up to his ear.

Izuku sits on his bed, legs crossed.

"I'm kind of busy, Deku."

Izuku blinks at his tone.

"I just… wanted to check in."

“Figures.”

The clear bark in Katsuki’s voice grates Izuku’s patience like iron nails.

“I… are you coming over today? My mom just mentioned that.”

“Yeah?”

Izuku bites his lip. “Kacchan, what’s going on? You sound… off.”

“Nothing’s off.” Katsuki sighs over the line. The sound of shuffling papers and something soft rumbles through, and Katsuki’s voice returns, somewhat hoarser. *“Just need to talk to you about something. Can’t do it over the phone. Didn’t want to call you and ask ‘cause it’d freak you out.”* There’s a pause. Izuku’s heart backflips. *“Like you’re doing right now.”*

“But something is clearly wrong.” Izuku’s hand grips tighter around his phone. He struggles to keep his voice at a normal pitch. “You sound upset. And I know it has to do with me. You could’ve called me and let me know you were coming instead of having my mom tell me indirectly.”

“Didn’t know she’d tell you.”

Izuku refrains from snapping. It’s strange for Katsuki to be this short with him, as if attempting to lead him to another conversation that neither of them want to have, but must.

“Katsuki.” Izuku sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. “Can you just tell me what’s wrong?”

“I already said we’re not talking about it over the phone, dumbass.”

“Well if you were more insistent on what it was about then I wouldn’t be as concerned.” Izuku rolls his eyes. “You can’t… be so indirect with me. It feels like you know something that I don’t. I’m not… Kacchan, I’m not sure what I did wrong.”

“I’m not mad at you, Deku.”

Izuku’s frown deepens. “That doesn’t seem to be the case…”

“Well then take my fucking word for it. I’ll see you in an hour.”

Katsuki hangs up.

Izuku stares at his ceiling, frustrated tears speckling his lashes.

Thursday. 4:32 PM.

The clock ticking on the wall is almost enough to lure Izuku out of his distracted state of mind. His hands are sweating, fingers tightly interwoven, and teeth urgently sinking into the flesh of his bottom lip. He hates waiting, and he hates not knowing the reasons for causing someone harm to some capacity even more.

The knock on the door startles him from his position at the kitchen counter. He swallows, despising the apprehension and anxious nerves that take over his arms and legs. With careful strides, he makes his way over to the doorknob, glancing over his shoulder once, and releases a sigh of relief at knowing he's alone.

Cautiously, he opens the door.

Katsuki is leaning against the railing, arms folded. He's dressed in a pair of joggers and a black tank top, exposing the sculpted lines to his physique that distracts Izuku far easier than it should. His eyes are closed, mouth set in a slim line, and nose scrunched up in perceived concentration.

"Hi, Kacchan."

Katsuki blinks open, and turns to face him. His pupils flicker about, drinking in Izuku's appearance, his carefully blank face, and the unspoken tension winding through the air.

"Hey."

Izuku scratches his cheek. "Would you… would you like to come inside?"

Katsuki sits up straighter, hands in his pockets. "Let's go on a walk."

Izuku hesitates. The purple shadows bruising Katsuki's eyelids are telling enough. Had he been losing sleep over whatever was bothering him? Was it because of something Izuku said or did, even though Katsuki insisted he wasn't angry with him?

"Okay."

Izuku closes the door carefully. The breeze wafts through his hair, a comfortable gust in this warm summer afternoon. He motions for Katsuki to continue, who obliges with a dip of his head and a quick jog down the steps.

They soon walk side by side, both keeping their hands to themselves.

Izuku hates every moment of this strange tension. The frustration returns from before, and he carefully breathes to prevent any tears from breaking out, from consuming any coherent word he could say instead. He doesn't want to appear weak or incapable of having whatever conversation they are about to have in front of Katsuki.

He blinks, perplexed, at Katsuki suddenly reaching out and taking his hand in his. His scowl is fierce, eyes hard as glass, but his grip tightens around him considerably.

“Fucking pisses me off when you do that,” he mutters, staring straight ahead down the clear sidewalk. “Just wanted to talk to you about something. I’m not mad. Just thinking.”

Izuku slightly relaxes at this. He returns the gesture, thumb stroking the inside of Katsuki’s palm.

The walk is slightly more comfortable, if quiet. They make their way through the slowly reforming territories in Sommartyn, sauntering by coffee shops, boutiques, bistros and parlors. The air is ripe with joy from the surrounding citizens, carrying the positive weight of change that stemmed originally from Enji Todoroki’s speech.

They stop at a small, humble park with a smattering of cherry blossoms and a single bench available to them. Katsuki lets Izuku take the first seat, and pats his hand in a small gesture of surprising reassurance before leaning forward and clasping his hands together. His throat is taut, jaw notably clenching through tight muscles and lips.

Izuku tentatively pets Katsuki’s hair, the strands soft under his fingers. Katsuki closes his eyes, shoulders lessening in tension. Izuku smiles gently at this, scratching his scalp and watching as the other boy leans further into his hand, seeking him. Feeling him.

“Damn, that’s good,” he grumbles.

Izuku retracts his hand, lowering to squeeze his bicep.

“Be honest, Kacchan.” He sighs. “Are you really okay?”

“Yes.” Katsuki stiffens. “Don’t worry about it.”

“Okay.” Izuku contemplates in a moment of quiet, staring out into the empty streets and the flutter of blossom petals drifting in the wind. “So, tell me what’s wrong.”

Katsuki balances his chin on his clenched hands.

“When were you going to tell me you were leaving Augustana?”

Izuku halts, blinking dumbly. His hand freezes, and slowly lifts off of Katsuki’s arm.

“Kacchan, I don’t… I don’t know what you’re—”

“Colleges, right?” Katsuki’s gaze narrows, veins popping in his forehead. “When you graduate. You want to fucking be a journalist or whatever, don’t you? So when were you going to tell me you were leaving? Or at least fucking talk about it with me.”

“Kacchan, I’m not leaving.” Izuku shakes his head, confused. “I never… I never even told anyone this. I mean, yes, I’m going to attend a couple college fairs with Uraraka for scholarship opportunities, but that doesn’t necessarily mean I’m going anywhere—”

“But you want to.” Katsuki finally leans back, and looks at Izuku. Searching him.

“I don’t know,” Izuku says. “Kacchan, I really don’t. When I graduate, I’ll be going wherever the best offer is. I want to pursue journalism as a career. You’ve known this for a long time. We’ve talked about that. I’ve… I’ve never been secretive about wanting to pursue this.”

“I… shit, I know that.” Katsuki rakes his hands through his hair, nostrils flaring. “I don’t want to be one of those shitty-ass controlling boyfriends. I want to, I dunno, support you and shit. It wouldn’t be fair to make you stay in the city. And hell, you’re fucking good at what you do. Any posh-faced university would be fucking lucky to have you.”

Izuku’s chest tightens unbearably, the pure honesty in Katsuki’s words slamming into him with a weight he no longer understood.

It sends his spirits soaring.

“Katsuki.” He tilts his head, tentatively reaching over to place his hand over Katsuki’s knee. “If I was going anywhere, I would tell you.” He sighs. “Besides, it’s not for awhile. I still have to graduate and that’s another year away. And whatever you choose to do might change by then. We’re just… we’re in this, no matter what, right?”

Katsuki mulls over this, digesting his words. Izuku can see it in the reflexive twitching to his facial features and the way his knuckles rub against each other in nervous habit.

“I would never make a decision like this without talking to you about it first.”

Katsuki’s eyes flicker to him, and then back to the ground, skeptical.

“Whatever happens, happens.” He strokes Katsuki’s back in gentle circles, kneading the muscle and tissue to earn a few groans from the other teen. “Where I go matters to me, yeah. My dreams are important, and I want to become a journalist successful enough to bring back the positive light in superheroes. It will happen if I keep working hard. And all of that is up there on my list, and as much as I love them…” he grins, eyes soft and glowing, “there’s nothing in my world that means more to me than you.”

He turns his head, just slightly, to gauge Katsuki’s reaction, but holds back a squeak instead as he’s pulled into a kiss. It’s so feather-light and gentle that it doesn’t seem real.

Katsuki pulls back, his gaze intense.

“You better fucking not drop me anytime soon, Deku. I won’t let you.” He jabs him in the jest with his finger, glaring. “Understand, dips hit?”

Izuku chuckles, shaking his head fondly. “Wouldn’t dream of it, Kacchan.”

Their gentle kissing in the middle of a public park soon transitions into a heated make-out session that almost has Katsuki draped over Izuku in a protective vice. It takes only minutes into it, where Izuku is close to asking Katsuki to take them somewhere more private, when an old woman snaps her cane on the bench and drives them away with threats on diminishing their future chances for sex.

Thursday. 5:45 PM.

“Crazy old bat.”

“That was hilarious.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, but follows Izuku through the front door of his apartment. “Whatever.”

Izuku turns around and grabs Katsuki’s collar, kicking the door closed behind them and kissing him slowly, sweetly, with every ounce of patience he has. Katsuki’s tongue slips through, licks the roof of his mouth and drags over his teeth, his strong hands stroking his back and lowering to rest on his hips.

“Deku,” he growls, a warning. “Doubt your mom’s not here.”

Izuku laughs, grinning cheekily but nodding nonetheless. “Yeah, just wanted to do that really quick.”

He leads Katsuki through their small kitchen space, and almost curves into the living room, when he spots the silhouette of his mother sitting at the coffee table.

And another familiar guest.

“Oh! Izuku!” Inko smiles at the two of them. “And Katsuki too. How wonderful.”

Yagi Toshinori grins at them both, raising his teacup.

“M-Mr. Toshinori?” Izuku squeaks, blushing.

“The fuck?” Katsuki barks, not so eloquently.

“It’s good to see you both again, young heroes.” Yagi dips his head, his movements calculated and formal, even now in the comforting space of Inko’s apartment. “That was quite an incredible feat you accomplished several months back. Enough to earn our new governor’s attention, I’m sure.”

“Yes, ah, thank you.” Izuku swallows. “What brings you here today?”

Inko claps her hands together. “Mr. Toshinori just wanted to visit us to talk and catch up. Mitsuki and I have known him for a very long time. Connections run deep with the Bakugou

family, and at the time your father and I knew Yagi well enough to be acquainted."

"It's always good to reconnect," says Yagi. "Although there is something I would like to speak to you about, Izuku. When you have the time."

Huh?

Izuku isn't able to hide his confusion with the apprehensive look his mother sends his way. Katsuki glances at him incredulously, though not borne out of suspicion.

"But, that can wait for another day." Yagi chuckles, and smiles at Inko. "It was a pleasure seeing you without a terrible case bringing our paths together again, Inko."

"The pleasure was all mine." She pats his bony hand, the action prompting Izuku to watch the two of them with uncertainty. He turns to Katsuki, who shrugs, apparently also lost in the void of unwelcome questions that plagues the remainder of the room. "Please travel safely. Augustana will miss your sharp eye."

"You flatter me." Yagi straightens and pulls back on his coat, his slender frame somehow echoing strength that neither Izuku or Katsuki can see. "It was good to see all three of you again. Oh, and young Katsuki," he dips his head respectfully in said boy's direction, "congratulations. I'm aware that your family has been given a great political honor in the name of the city. That's sure to look impressive for future endeavors."

Katsuki scratches the back of his neck. "Thanks."

Yagi swerves around the couch, carefully sidestepping Izuku and Katsuki's placement in the middle of the brief path from the kitchen to the living room. Both boys crane their necks, unable to hide their curiosity as their eyes lock onto Yagi's back, the older gentleman pausing to search his pockets. He laughs, turning to smile blindingly at Izuku, and whips out a white card.

"We will call soon, Izuku."

Izuku blinks, and takes the card. The embossed, bold letters spell out the detective's full name, occupation, phone number and email. Katsuki peers over his shoulder, a suspicious sneer curling his lip.

"Thank you, sir," he whispers, entranced. "It's… it's an honor." He bows halfway, only for Katsuki to grab the back of his shirt and yank him back to standing straight. "S-Sorry. It's a nervous habit. But, really, thank you! This is… this is an incredible honor."

"It's only my contact information, my boy." Yagi's smile is infectious. "Be good for the remainder of your school years, won't you, boys?"

"Sure."

"Y-Yes!"

"Good, good." Yagi turns on his heel, and within moments, he's striding out the threshold.

“Have a wonderful trip, Yagi!” Inko calls, grinning from ear to ear.

The moment doesn’t seem real at all until the door closes behind the detective, a thick gust of air slipping through and tossing Izuku’s slightly sweaty curls away from his forehead.

“The fuck was that all about?”

Izuku stares down at the business card, thumb brushing over the letters and numbers.

“… I’m not sure.”

Friday. 12:35 AM.

Dusk rests over the horizon, eclipsing even the tallest buildings in a tender gold-rift halo. Lavender, indigo and rust-orange seep like blood into the receding colors, a wash of stars spreading across the night sky in a promise for the impending twilight. The breeze is without hindrance, carrying the sweet scents of summer flowers and fresh grass.

Lying on a blanket spread out in the same empty park, Izuku spots another constellation, and curls his hand tighter around Katsuki’s.

“Don’t tell me you found another one,” he grumbles.

“Of course I did,” he says, laughing, “it’s the Little Dipper! No one really talks about that one. Makes me a little sad. The Big Dipper gets all the credit for being the most impressive one. But I guess that would make sense if you think about people who study constellations for a living. Oh, did I ever tell you about that Kacchan? About—”

“Deku.”

“Sorry.”

Katsuki only hums in response.

“It’s really beautiful out.” Izuku sighs. “So nice in the summertime.” He turns on his side, unable to hide the glee at seeing Katsuki so relaxed and composed under the starlight. He’s dressed in jeans and a white short-sleeved shirt, his left arm resting on his chest as he breathes somberly under the stars. “Thank you for taking us out here, Kacchan.”

“Tsk. It’s whatever.” Katsuki rolls his eyes, but his blush is unmistakable. “Since it’s… our anniversary, and shit.”

Izuku brings his hand up to his mouth, peppering kisses along his knuckles.

“It means a lot to me.”

“Whatever.”

It was surprising, at first, for Katsuki to show up at Izuku’s apartment and, with no explanation whatsoever, take his hand and drag him through Sommartyn in the middle of the night until they walked past a familiar bench, and splayed out a blanket over the unoccupied lawn. It was on a curved hillside, daisies and rosebushes apparent in gorgeously trimmed patterns, though the flowers meant nothing to Izuku when his heart was beating wildly only in reaction to how much Katsuki was doing for him.

Izuku scoots closer to Katsuki, and pecks him on the lips.

“You asking for something, nerd?” Katsuki glares up at him, squinting.

“Mm. No.” Izuku smirks mischievously, his hand running down Katsuki’s ribs, never breaking eye contact. His fingers move to run tenderly over Katsuki’s toned stomach, the heated skin more than comforting to touch, to feel. “Isn’t it weird that you thought I was a spy just a few months ago?” He chuckles. “Kind of crazy if you think about it. You hated me. And for a few days I was so terrified of you, and so confused with how you were dragging me everywhere. This angry blond boy, trying to be a super intimidating vigilante…”

Katsuki thinks for a moments, and grins. “You’re still a little shit.”

Izuku huffs. “You were so threatening, and you yelled a lot more. I can’t believe I was ever scared by a softie like you.” He squeaks, Katsuki suddenly looming above him, that smirk curving dangerously and filled with playfulness. “Kacchan, wait—before you kill me, can I repent for my sins?”

“Hm, I dunno, Deku. Been awful patient with you all day.” He leans down, capturing his lips in a searing, heated, *perfect* kiss. He licks Izuku’s lips, teeth a hairsbreadth away.

“You know I mean it though, right?”

Katsuki pauses, lips teasing his Adam’s apple.

“Hm…?”

“That I love you.”

Katsuki pauses. He sits up, balancing his forearms in a bracket around Izuku’s head. He stares down at him, his handsome face narrowed and shielded in slender shadows and moonlight.

Izuku is unable to stop his hand from reaching up and caressing Katsuki's cheekbone, thumb sliding over soft skin and barely tracing the upside of his burn scars. Even with them, Katsuki is handsome, *beautiful*, a walking cataclysm of immense care and emotional outbursts.

"I love the way you protect the people you care about," he whispers, as if in a trance. "I love how you're so thoughtful with me, how you always ask before we have sex. I love how passionate you are, how dedicated you are to your dreams. You're so brave, and reckless, and angry, but it makes up who you are. All of the bad and the good balance each other out. Your Quirk is obviously amazing too, but you…" he trails off, swallowing, overwhelmed. "I just want you to know—"

Katsuki kisses him, though it's brief. Izuku whimpers when he releases him, but stops under the calloused fingers stroking his cheek.

"Katsuki?"

"You're stuck with me, you know," he says, ever so determined and territorial. "I'm the one who lucked out, you idiot."

Izuku swallows.

He can trust him. He can love him.

He's not sure if there will ever be a time where either of them will want to break apart. With the next few years coming towards them, nothing will be easy. Nothing will be simple. But with Katsuki here, and the unspoken promises brewing in the crisp night air, Izuku has choices to make, and a person to fall back on.

With his heart in his throat and mouth wobbling, Izuku smiles, and nods.

We're fine.

He laughs at Katsuki grinning and dragging his hands down his sides, searching and prodding for more. Always more.

We'll be fine for a long time.

"Now, since that's over and done with." Katsuki smirks dangerously. "Where were we?"

Friday. 6:15 AM.

VOICE MAILBOX - IZUKU MIDORIYA

“Hey, it’s Izuku! Leave a message and I’ll do my best to call you back!”

ONE NEW MESSAGE

“Izuku, my boy. Hello. This is Yagi Toshinori. I took some liberties and decided to call you first, since your mother was kind enough to pay me that courtesy. When you get the chance, I would love to talk to you. I have a… proposition, for you. Your ears only. Please, I would love to hear from you. And congratulations again. Your future is looking bright.”

Chapter End Notes

It would mean the world to me to hear your last thoughts, my friends. Thank you once again for being on this journey with me. It's been a wild and unpredictable ride.

With love,

Taylor

End Notes

Um, so, I have an extremely unimpressive and random Tumblr now... let's talk. :D

https://driftingglass.tumblr.com/

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!